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SHELF 007 • SOVEREIGN KNOWLEDGE BASTION

BOOK 06 • MASTER CONSOLIDATED CODEX

GENERAL AWARENESS, BANKING REGULATION & CONTEMPORARY POLICY

The Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike Codex (January–September 2026)

Statutory Banking Acts • RBI Master Directions & Basel III Norms • Macroeconomic Base-Year Series • 2026 Chronological Policy Dossiers (Jan–Sept) • IBPS Mains 35+ Marks High-Yield Compendium • Computer Aptitude & Digital Financial Systems


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MASTER STATIC BANKING, REGULATORY ACTS & PRUDENTIAL NORMS CORE

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified Statutory Foundations, RBI Mandates & Banking Governance

Complete High-Yield Reference Matrix: Codes, Acts, HQs, Basel Ratios, Limits & Constitutional Schedules

0. MASTER STATIC BANKING & REGULATORY FOUNDATIONS

[STA-001] **Financial Message Codes, Identifiers & Standard Formats (UTR, IFSC, MICR, LEI, SWIFT)**

- **RTGS UTR (Unique Transaction Reference):** Exactly **22 alphanumeric characters**; canonically structured under RBI RTGS System Regulations as: **4-character Bank IFSC (`XXXX`)** + **1-character System code (`R` for RTGS)** + **1-character Channel identifier (`C` for customer payment, `I` for inter-bank, `P` for participant)** + **8-digit Date (`YYYYMMDD`)** + **8-digit unique sequential running number (`nnnnnnnn`)** (Decomposition: 4 + 1 + 1 + 8 + 8 = 22 characters).
- **NEFT UTR (Unique Transaction Reference):** Exactly **16 alphanumeric characters**; generated uniquely for interbank batch electronic clearing.
- **IFSC (Indian Financial System Code):** Exactly **11 alphanumeric characters** used in NEFT, RTGS, and IMPS; First 4 characters = Bank identity; **5th character is permanently fixed as '0' (zero)** reserved for future expansion; Last 6 characters = Branch identity (alphanumeric).
- **MICR (Magnetic Ink Character Recognition):** Exactly **9 numeric digits** printed at the bottom of cheques using magnetic ink; First 3 digits = **City Code** (matches first 3 digits of postal PIN code); Middle 3 digits = **Bank Code**; Last 3 digits = **Branch Code**.
- **LEI (Legal Entity Identifier):** Exactly **20 alphanumeric characters** based on ISO 17442; globally unique identifier for legal entities participating in financial transactions; mandatory in India across two distinct regulatory regimes:
  1. *Non-Individual Borrowers (RBI Circular RBI/2021-22/162)*: Mandatory for all non-individual entities with aggregate credit exposure ≥ **₹5 Crore** from Scheduled Commercial Banks, AIFIs, and NBFCs (fully phased in by April 30, 2025; entities without LEI are barred from renewal or enhancement of credit facilities).
  2. *Cross-Border Financial Transactions (FEMA Directions)*: Mandatory for single cross-border transactions ≥ **₹50 Crore** in RTGS/NEFT for capital or current account transactions.
- **SWIFT / BIC (Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication): 8 or 11 alphanumeric characters** based on ISO 9362 (4 letters = Bank code; 2 letters = Country code; 2 characters = Location code; 3 optional characters = Branch code); SWIFT international headquarters located in **La Hulpe, Belgium**.
- **National Registry & Scheme Codes Matrix:**
  - **PRAN (Permanent Retirement Account Number - PFRDA): 12 digits**.
  - **UAN (Universal Account Number - EPFO): 12 digits**.
  - **EPF Establishment Identification Code: 22 alphanumeric characters**.
  - **PAN (Permanent Account Number - CBDT): 10 alphanumeric characters**; 4th character denotes entity status (**'P' = Individual/Person**, 'C' = Company, 'F' = Firm, 'H' = HUF, 'A' = AOP, 'T' = Trust, 'B' = BOI, 'J' = Artificial Juridical Person).
  - **GSTIN (Goods and Services Tax Identification Number): 15 alphanumeric characters**; First 2 digits = State Code (e.g., 07 for Delhi, 27 for Maharashtra); Next 10 digits = PAN of the entity.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The RTGS vs NEFT Trap: RTGS UTR has **22 characters**; NEFT UTR has **16 characters** (examiners frequently swap these two numbers).
- RTGS UTR Structural Anatomy: **4 IFSC + 1 System (R) + 1 Channel (C) + 8 Date (YYYYMMDD) + 8 Sequence = 22** (Notice: 8-digit sequence number, NOT 9-digit; 6th character is the Channel identifier).
- LEI Dual-Threshold Trap: Non-individual borrower credit exposure threshold is **≥ ₹5 Crore** (phased in by April 2025). The **₹50 Crore** threshold applies strictly to cross-border remittances under FEMA.
- The IFSC 5th Character: The 5th character is always numeric **0 (zero)**, NEVER the letter 'O'.
- The MICR Sequence Trap: MICR 9-digit sequence is **City → Bank → Branch** (Examiners often trick candidates with Bank → City → Branch).
- Target MCQ: 'How many alphanumeric characters are there in an RTGS UTR number, and what is its sequence length?' → **22 characters total (with an 8-digit running sequence number)**.

[STA-002] **Evolution of Modern Indian Banking: SBI Genesis, Nationalisation & Statutory Acts**

- **Presidency Banks to State Bank of India:**
  - Bank of Calcutta (founded 1806, renamed Bank of Bengal 1809), Bank of Bombay (1840), and Bank of Madras (1843) were amalgamated on **January 27, 1921** to create the **Imperial Bank of India**.
  - Under the statutory recommendations of the **All India Rural Credit Survey Committee (chaired by A.D. Gorwala)**, Parliament enacted the **State Bank of India Act, 1955**.
  - On **July 1, 1955**, the Imperial Bank of India was formally converted into the **State Bank of India (SBI)** (RBI originally subscribed to 60% equity; Government of India acquired RBI stake in 2007).
- **The Two Epochs of Bank Nationalisation:**
  - **First Wave (19 July 1969):** 14 major commercial banks with aggregate public deposits **≥ ₹50 Crore** nationalised under Banking Companies (Acquisition and Transfer of Undertakings) Act, 1970 (passed during Indira Gandhi premiership).
  - **Second Wave (15 April 1980):** 6 commercial banks with aggregate public deposits **≥ ₹200 Crore** nationalised.
- **Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934 Statutory Pillars:**
  - **Section 17:** Defines legitimate business transactions RBI may conduct.
  - **Section 22:** Confers exclusive authority to issue bank notes in India (except ₹1 currency notes and metallic coins issued by Ministry of Finance).
  - **Section 24:** Establishes maximum denomination bank note RBI can issue (up to **₹10,000**); Coinage Act 2011 authorizes coins up to **₹1,000**.
  - **Section 42(1):** Mandates every Scheduled Commercial Bank to maintain **Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)** as a percentage of Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL) with RBI (RBI (Amendment) Act 2006 removed earlier statutory 3% floor and 20% ceiling).
  - **Sections 45-ZB to 45-ZG:** Codifies composition, appointment, voting, and quorum rules of the 6-member **Monetary Policy Committee (MPC)**.
- **Banking Regulation Act, 1949 Core Anchor Sections:**
  - **Section 5(b):** Statutory definition of 'Banking' (accepting for the purpose of lending or investment of deposits of money from the public, repayable on demand or otherwise).
  - **Section 22:** Mandatory licensing requirement from RBI to conduct banking business in India.
  - **Section 24:** Statutory mandate requiring banks to maintain **Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR)** as unencumbered liquid assets against NDTL (ceiling capped at **40%**; current operational rate is 18.00%).
  - **Section 35A:** Comprehensive statutory power empowering RBI to issue binding executive directions to all banks in public interest or to prevent banking affairs from being conducted prejudicial to depositors.
  - **Section 49A:** Restricts acceptance of deposits withdrawable by cheque to licensed banks only.
- **Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881 Core Anchor Sections:**
  - **Section 4:** Defines **Promissory Note** (unconditional undertaking in writing signed by maker to pay certain sum of money).
  - **Section 5:** Defines **Bill of Exchange** (unconditional order in writing directing person to pay).

- **Section 6:** Defines **Cheque** (bill of exchange drawn on a specified banker, payable always on demand; includes truncated electronic image of cheque).
- **Section 138:** Codifies criminal offense and penalties for **Dishonour of Cheque for insufficiency of funds** (penal sanction: imprisonment up to 2 years, or fine up to twice the face value of the cheque, or both).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Legislative Origin: CRR is governed by **Section 42 of RBI Act 1934**; SLR is governed by **Section 24 of Banking Regulation Act 1949** (critical distractor pair in banking exams).
- SBI Foundation Date: **July 1, 1955** under SBI Act 1955 based on the **A.D. Gorwala Committee** (All India Rural Credit Survey).
- Target MCQ: 'In which year was the Imperial Bank of India converted into State Bank of India?' → **1955**.

[STA-003] **Institutional Headquarters, Global Foreign Banks & Multilateral Bodies**

- **Indian Financial & Statutory Bodies Headquarters Matrix:**
  - **Mumbai:** Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), NABARD, EXIM Bank of India, State Bank of India (SBI), National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), Indian Banks' Association (IBA).
  - **Hyderabad: Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI)** and **Insurance Information Bureau of India (IIB)** (established in 2009 by IRDAI as the single statutory data repository for Indian insurance).
  - **New Delhi:** Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA), National Housing Bank (NHB), Competition Commission of India (CCI), Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI).
  - **Lucknow: Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI)**.
  - **Kolkata:** UCO Bank, Bandhan Bank, Tea Board of India.
  - **Chennai:** Indian Bank, Indian Overseas Bank.
  - **Bengaluru:** Canara Bank.
  - **Vadodara / Mumbai:** Bank of Baroda (Registered Head Office in Vadodara, Corporate Centre in Mumbai).
- **Foreign Banks Operating in India (Origin & Global Headquarters):**
  - **Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (SMBC): Tokyo, Japan** (converted to Wholly Owned Subsidiary / WOS in India).
  - **Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group (MUFG)** / **Mizuho Bank: Tokyo, Japan**.
  - **DBS Bank India: Singapore** (pioneer foreign lender converting to Wholly Owned Subsidiary mode in India).
  - **BNP Paribas: Paris, France** (major European corporate and institutional lender).
  - **Société Générale: Paris, France**.
  - **Deutsche Bank: Frankfurt, Germany**.
  - **HSBC (Hongkong and Shanghai Banking Corp)** / **Barclays** / **Standard Chartered: London, United Kingdom**.
  - **Citibank** / **JPMorgan Chase** / **Bank of America: United States** (New York / Charlotte).
- **Multilateral Financial Institutions:**
  - **World Bank Group (IBRD / IDA / IFC / MIGA): Washington D.C., USA** (President: Ajay Banga; Executive Director representing Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Sri Lanka: **Neelkanth Mishra**, who succeeded Parameswaran Iyer in 2026).
  - **International Monetary Fund (IMF): Washington D.C., USA** (Managing Director: **Kristalina Georgieva**; First Deputy MD: **Dan Katz**, who succeeded Gita Gopinath; Deputy MDs: Bo Li, Kenji Okamura, Nigel Clarke).
  - **Asian Development Bank (ADB): Mandaluyong / Manila, Philippines** (President: **Masato Kanda**, who assumed office 24 February 2025 succeeding Masatsugu Asakawa, re-elected September 2026 for a 5-year term).
  - **New Development Bank (NDB / BRICS Bank): Shanghai, China** (President: Dilma Rousseff).
  - **Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB): Beijing, China** (President: Jin Liqun).
  - **Bank for International Settlements (BIS): Basel, Switzerland** (known as the central bank of central banks).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Headquarters Traps: IRDAI and IIB are in **Hyderabad** (not Mumbai or Delhi); SIDBI is in **Lucknow** (not Mumbai).
- Foreign Bank Origin: SMBC, Mizuho, MUFG = **Japan**; DBS = **Singapore**; BNP Paribas = **Paris, France**.
- Target MCQ: 'Where is the headquarters of Insurance Information Bureau of India (IIB) located?' → **Hyderabad**.

[STA-004] **Basel III Regulatory Architecture, Balance Sheet Ratios & Delinquency Timeline**

- **Basel III Regulatory Capital Framework:**
  - Developed by the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision (BCBS) headquartered at BIS in Basel, Switzerland, in response to the 2008 Lehman Brothers liquidity collapse.
  - **Minimum Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1): 5.5%** for Indian banks (vs 4.5% Basel international accord).
  - **Capital Conservation Buffer (CCB): 2.5%** in the form of CET1 capital.
  - **Minimum Tier 1 Capital: 7.0%**.
  - **Minimum Total Capital Adequacy Ratio (CRAR): 9.0%** under Basel rules, but **RBI mandates 11.5%** for Indian commercial banks (9.0% base + 2.5% CCB).
- **Short-Term & Long-Term Liquidity Metrics under Basel III:**
  - **Liquidity Coverage Ratio (LCR):** Conceived under Basel III; mandates banks to hold an unencumbered stock of High-Quality Liquid Assets (HQLA) equal to at least **100%** of total net cash outflows anticipated over a **30-day severe stress period** ($LCR = \text{Stock of HQLA} / \text{Total net cash outflows over 30 days} \ge 100\%$).
  - **Net Stable Funding Ratio (NSFR):** Complementary structural metric requiring banks to fund long-term assets with stable liabilities over a **1-year horizon** ($NSFR = \text{Available Stable Funding} / \text{Required Stable Funding} \ge 100\%$).
  - **Leverage Ratio:** Pure non-risk-weighted balance sheet constraint (Tier 1 Capital / Total Exposure); RBI prescribes minimum **4.0% for Domestic Systemically Important Banks (D-SIBs)** and **3.5% for other banks**.
- **Asset Classification & Delinquency Ladder (RBI Master Directions):**
  - **Standard Asset:** Generating normal income with principal and interest serviced on time.
  - **Special Mention Accounts (SMA) Triggers:**
    - **SMA-0:** Principal or interest overdue between **1 to 30 days**.
    - **SMA-1:** Principal or interest overdue between **31 to 60 days**.
    - **SMA-2:** Principal or interest overdue between **61 to 90 days**.
  - **Non-Performing Asset (NPA):** Ceases to generate income; principal or interest remains overdue for **more than 90 days** (for agricultural loans: 2 crop seasons for short-duration crops, 1 crop season for long-duration crops).
  - **Substandard Asset:** Remained in NPA classification for a period **≤ 12 months** (provisioning: 15% for secured, 25% for unsecured advances).
  - **Doubtful Asset:** Remained in substandard category for **exceeding 12 months**; three provision slabs on secured portion:
    - **D1 (Up to 1 year):** 25% provision.
    - **D2 (1 to 3 years):** 40% provision.
    - **D3 (Exceeding 3 years):** 100% provision.
    - *Unsecured portion of doubtful advances is always provisioned at 100%.*
  - **Loss Asset:** Identified by bank, internal/external auditors, or RBI inspection as completely uncollectible; 100% written off or 100% provisioned immediately.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- LCR Horizon Trap: LCR is strictly for **30 calendar days** of stress (do NOT pick 90 days or 1 year); NSFR is for **1 year**.
- SMA Classification Sequence: SMA-0 (1-30 days), SMA-1 (31-60 days), SMA-2 (61-90 days). Beyond 90 days is **Substandard NPA**.
- Target MCQ: 'Under which global regulatory framework was the Liquidity Coverage Ratio (LCR) introduced?' → **Basel III Framework**.

[STA-005] **Operational Banking Limits, Consumer Redressal & Deposit Insurance**

- **ATM Free Cash Withdrawal Norms (RBI Master Directions):**
  - **Own Bank ATMs:** Minimum **5 free transactions per month** (inclusive of both financial cash withdrawals and non-financial services like balance inquiry).
  - **Other Bank ATMs in 6 Designated Metros:** Minimum **3 free transactions per month** (Metros: Mumbai, New Delhi, Chennai, Kolkata, Bengaluru, Hyderabad).
  - **Other Bank ATMs in Non-Metro Centers:** Minimum **5 free transactions per month**.
  - **Permissible Interchange Fees Capped by RBI:** Maximum **₹17 per financial transaction** and **₹6 per non-financial transaction**.
  - **Failed ATM Transaction Compensation (T+5 Rule):** If an account is debited but cash is not dispensed, bank must reverse the funds within **T+5 calendar days**; delay beyond T+5 days attracts statutory penalty of **₹100 per day** payable directly to the customer without requiring a complaint.
- **Reserve Bank Integrated Ombudsman Architecture & Versioned Regimes:**
  - Unifies 3 predecessor schemes (Banking Ombudsman 2006, NBFC Ombudsman 2018, Digital Transactions Ombudsman 2019) into 'One Nation One Ombudsman'; **RB-IOS 2026 Coverage Categories:** Commercial Banks, Regional Rural Banks, State Co-operative Banks, Central Co-operative Banks, Scheduled Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks, Non-Scheduled Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks with deposits of ₹50 crore and above, qualifying NBFCs subject to the RB-IOS 2026 exclusions and ₹100 crore/customer-interface or deposit-taking conditions, Non-bank Prepaid Payment Instrument Issuers, and Credit Information Companies.
  - **Temporal Version Control & Compensation Slabs:**
    1. *RB-IOS 2021 (Operative November 12, 2021 to June 30, 2026)*: Maximum compensation for direct financial loss: **₹20 Lakh**; additional compensation for mental agony, harassment, loss of time: **₹1 Lakh** (Max composite award: ₹21 Lakh).
    2. *RB-IOS 2026 (Effective July 1, 2026 onward)*: Maximum compensation for direct financial loss enhanced to **₹30 Lakh**; additional compensation for mental agony/harassment enhanced to **₹3 Lakh** (Max composite award: ₹33 Lakh).
  - **Pre-requisite & Filing Deadline:** After first approaching the Regulated Entity, complaint may be filed before the RBI Ombudsman within **90 days from expiry of the applicable response timeline or the date of the last communication, whichever is later**.
  - **Appellate Authority:** Executive Director in-charge of Consumer Education and Protection Department (CEPD) at RBI. Appeal is available **only against an Award** of the RBI Ombudsman. The complainant may appeal within **30 days of receiving the Award, subject to the applicable extension provision**.
- **Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC) Act, 1961:**
  - Wholly owned subsidiary of RBI; insures bank deposits across Commercial Banks, RRBs, Local Area Banks, and Co-operative Banks.
  - **Coverage Slabs:** Insures each depositor up to a maximum of **₹5 Lakh** (principal + interest) across all deposit accounts held in the same right and capacity in each bank.
  - **Mandatory 90-Day Payout Timeline (DICGC Amendment Act 2021):** If a bank is placed under all-inclusive directions or moratorium by RBI, depositors must receive insured funds up to ₹5L within **90 days** (Bank submits depositor list within 45 days; DICGC verifies claims within 30 days of receipt; payment is made within the subsequent 15 days; overall statutory limit = 90 days; statutory breakdown: 45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Ombudsman Regime & Temporal Slabs Trap:
  - *2021 Scheme Baseline (pre-July 2026)*: **₹20 Lakh** (direct loss) + **₹1 Lakh** (mental agony).
  - *2026 Scheme Baseline (from 1 July 2026)*: **₹30 Lakh** (direct loss) + **₹3 Lakh** (mental agony).

RB-IOS Filing Deadline: After first approaching the Regulated Entity, complaint may be filed before the RBI Ombudsman within **90 days from expiry of the applicable response timeline or the date of the last communication, whichever is later**.

RB-IOS Appeal Right: Appeal is available **strictly against an Award** of the RBI Ombudsman (appeal does not lie against rejection); within **30 days of receiving the Award**.

Failed ATM Reversal: Timeline is **T+5 calendar days**; delay penalty is **₹100 per day**.

DICGC Payout Window: Exactly **90 days** from date of RBI moratorium/directions (Bank submits depositor list within 45 days; DICGC verifies claims within 30 days; payment made within subsequent 15 days; statutory breakdown: 45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days).

[STA-006] **Constitutional Schedules, Strategic Maritime Straits & High-Frequency Static GK**

- **The 12 Schedules of the Constitution of India Master Table:**
  - **First Schedule:** List of States and Union Territories with territorial boundaries.
  - **Second Schedule:** Emoluments, allowances, and privileges of President, Governors, Judges of Supreme Court/High Courts, and CAG.
  - **Third Schedule:** Forms of Oaths and Affirmations for Union Ministers, MPs, Supreme Court and High Court Judges.
  - **Fourth Schedule: Allocation of seats in the Rajya Sabha (Council of States)** to States and Union Territories (current statutory strength: 245 total = 233 elected representatives + 12 members nominated by the President under Article 80).
  - **Fifth Schedule:** Administration and control of Scheduled Areas and Scheduled Tribes.
  - **Sixth Schedule:** Administration of Tribal Areas in 4 north-eastern states: **Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, and Mizoram (AMTM)**.
  - **Seventh Schedule:** Division of legislative powers between Union and States: List I (**Union List** - 100 subjects incl. Banking, Currency, Foreign Affairs, Defence), List II (**State List** - 61 subjects), List III (**Concurrent List** - 52 subjects).
  - **Eighth Schedule: 22 Official Languages** recognized by the Constitution (originally 14; 21st Amendment added Sindhi; 71st Amendment added Konkani, Manipuri, Nepali; 92nd Amendment added Bodo, Dogri, Maithili, Santhali).
  - **Ninth Schedule:** Validation of certain Acts and regulations; originally insulated from judicial review by 1st Constitutional Amendment 1951 (post-1973 laws open to basic structure test).
  - **Tenth Schedule: Anti-Defection Law** provisions for disqualification of legislators (introduced via 52nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1985).
  - **Eleventh Schedule:** Powers, authority, and responsibilities of Panchayats (29 functional subjects; added via 73rd Amendment 1992).
  - **Twelfth Schedule:** Powers, authority, and responsibilities of Municipalities (18 functional subjects; added via 74th Amendment 1992).
- **Strategic Global Maritime Straits & International Choke Points:**
  - **Strait of Hormuz:** Vital maritime strait connecting the **Persian Gulf** with the **Gulf of Oman** and the Arabian Sea; borders Iran to the north and the Musandam exclave of Oman and UAE to the south; world's foremost petroleum transit choke point (handles ~20% of global petroleum liquid consumption).
  - **Bab-el-Mandeb Strait:** Connects the **Red Sea** to the **Gulf of Aden** and Indian Ocean; separates Yemen on the Arabian Peninsula from Djibouti and Eritrea in the Horn of Africa; southern gateway to the Suez Canal.
  - **Strait of Malacca:** Connects the **Andaman Sea (Indian Ocean)** with the **South China Sea (Pacific Ocean)**; situated between Peninsular Malaysia and the Indonesian island of Sumatra; shortest sea route between Persian Gulf energy suppliers and Asian consumers.

- **Bosphorus & Dardanelles Straits (Turkish Straits):** Connects the **Black Sea** to the Mediterranean Sea via the Sea of Marmara; international transit governed by the **1936 Montreux Convention**.
- **Palk Strait:** Connects the **Bay of Bengal** with the **Palk Bay / Gulf of Mannar** between Tamil Nadu (India) and the Jaffna Peninsula (Sri Lanka).



Figure STA-006: Critical Global Maritime Choke Points (Turkish Straits, Hormuz, Bab-el-Mandeb, Palk Strait, Malacca) and Primary Strategic Petroleum/Cargo Transit Routes.

- **Core Environmental Treaties & Global Maritime Organizations:**
  - **Paris Climate Agreement (COP21, 2015):** Adopted under UNFCCC; overarching objective is to hold the increase in global average temperature to **well below 2°C** above pre-industrial levels and aggressively pursue efforts to **limit the temperature increase to 1.5°C**.
  - **BIMCO (Baltic and International Maritime Council):** World's largest non-governmental association of shipowners, operators, and maritime charterers; established in Copenhagen, Denmark in 1905; represents over 60% of commercial cargo fleet.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Fourth Schedule Trap: Allocates seats in **Rajya Sabha** (Council of States), NOT Lok Sabha.
- Strait of Hormuz: Connects **Persian Gulf with Gulf of Oman** (do NOT pick Red Sea or Gulf of Aden).
- Paris Agreement Target: Goal is **1.5°C / well below 2°C** above pre-industrial levels.
- Target MCQ: 'Under which Schedule of the Constitution are Rajya Sabha seats allocated to States and Union Territories?' → **Fourth Schedule**.

[STA-007] **High-Frequency Constitutional Articles, Taxation Forms & Functions of Money**

- **Core Financial & Economic Articles of the Constitution of India:**
  - **Article 280 (Finance Commission):** Mandates the President of India to constitute a Finance Commission every 5 years; recommends devolution of net tax proceeds between Union and States and grants-in-aid; **16th Finance Commission** chaired by **Dr. Arvind Panagariya** (Secretary: Ritvik Ranjanam Pandey; recommendations operational for 5 years: FY27–FY31).
  - **Article 300A (Right to Property):** Originally a Fundamental Right under Article 19(1)(f) and Article 31; omitted from Part III and reconstituted as a **Constitutional / Legal Right under Article 300A in Part XII** via the **44th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1978** (mandates that no person shall be deprived of property save by authority of law).

- **Article 112 (Annual Financial Statement / Union Budget):** Mandates presentation of estimated receipts and expenditure of the Government of India for every financial year before both Houses of Parliament.
- **Article 246A & 279A (Goods and Services Tax):** Introduced by the **101st Constitutional Amendment Act, 2016**; Article 246A confers simultaneous power to Parliament and State Legislatures to make laws on GST; Article 279A mandates constitution of the **GST Council** (chaired by the Union Finance Minister; voting weight: Centre holds 1/3rd, States hold 2/3rd; 3/4th majority required to pass decisions).
- **Article 266 & 267 (Funds of India):** Article 266(1) provides for the Consolidated Fund of India; Article 266(2) provides for the Public Account of India; **Article 267:** Provides for the Contingency Fund of India, placed at the disposal of the President to meet unforeseen expenditure pending parliamentary authorization. Custody and related operational matters are governed under Article 283 and applicable rules (corpus statutory limit enhanced to ₹30,000 Cr via Finance Act, 2021).

- **Core Income Tax Certificates, Return Forms & Declarations:**
  - **Form 16:** Certificate of **Tax Deducted at Source (TDS) on Salary** issued annually by an employer under **Section 203 of the Income Tax Act, 1961**; divided into Part A (TDS summary, TAN, PAN) and Part B (salary breakup, deductions under Chapter VI-A).
  - **Form 16A:** Certificate for TDS on non-salary payments (interest on bank deposits, mutual fund dividends, professional fees).
  - **Form 15G:** Self-declaration under Section 197A by an **individual below 60 years or HUF** claiming receipt of interest without deduction of tax (total income must be below taxable basic exemption limit).
  - **Form 15H:** Self-declaration under Section 197A by a **senior citizen (aged 60 years or above)** for nil TDS on interest income (estimated total income after deductions can be within taxable limits, provided net tax liability is nil).
  - **Form 26AS & Annual Information Statement (AIS):** Comprehensive consolidated statement reflecting all taxes deducted (TDS/TCS), advance tax paid, self-assessment tax, and Specified Financial Transactions (SFT) like high-value cash deposits, shares, and real estate.
  - **Form 60 / Form 61:** Form 60 is submitted by an individual who does not possess a PAN card when entering into specified high-value financial transactions; Form 61 is filed by persons dealing with agricultural income only.

- **The Three Fundamental Functions of Money (Macroeconomic Principles):**
  - **Unit of Account:** Currency serves as the standard numerical monetary unit of measurement of the market value of goods, services, and all financial transactions; allows comparison of relative values and provides the accounting baseline for recording a nation's income, national output (GDP), expenditure, and corporate balance sheets.
  - **Medium of Exchange:** Currency facilitates trade and transactions without the prohibitive inefficiencies and coincidence-of-wants dilemmas of barter.
  - **Store of Value:** Asset that maintains its purchasing power over time so wealth can be saved, stored, and retrieved in the future (diminished primarily by inflation).

- **Global Governance, Strategic Ports & Security Architecture:**
  - **United Nations Security Council Permanent 5 (P5):** Comprises **5 Permanent Members** holding veto power under the UN Charter: **United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China**. The 10 non-permanent members are elected by the UN General Assembly for 2-year terms.
  - **Chabahar Port Strategic Bilateral Pact:** Located in the Sistan-Baluchistan province of south-eastern Iran along the Gulf of Oman; provides India sea-land access to Afghanistan and Central Asia bypassing Pakistan; on **13 May 2024**, India Ports Global Limited (IPGL) signed a landmark **10-year long-term bilateral contract** with Iran's Ports and Maritime Organization (PMO) to equip and operate the **Shahid Beheshti terminal** with an investment of $120 Million.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Right to Property Trap: It is **NOT** a Fundamental Right (Article 31 was deleted); it is a legal/constitutional right under **Article 300A** via the **44th Amendment 1978** (do NOT confuse with 42nd Amendment).
- Form 15G vs 15H Trap: Form 15G is for individuals **under 60 years**; Form 15H is strictly for **senior citizens (60 years and above)**.
- Form 16 Law: Form 16 is for **TDS on salary** under **Section 203** of Income Tax Act.
- Function of Money Trap: The function used for *recording a country's income and expenditure* is the **Unit of Account** (not Medium of Exchange or Store of Value).
- Target MCQ Form: 'Which Article of the Constitution guarantees the Right to Property as a constitutional right?' → **Article 300A**.

[STA-008] **RBI Master Directions: Urban Co-operative Banks 4-Tier Categorisation, DICGC Moratorium Rules & PSL Targets**

- **Urban Co-operative Banks (UCB) 4-Tier Regulatory Categorisation (N.S. Vishwanathan Committee):**
  - **Tier 1:** Deposits up to **₹100 Crore**; minimum net worth of **₹2 Crore** for single-district unit UCBs, **₹5 Crore** for all other UCBs; mandatory Capital to Risk-Weighted Assets Ratio (CRAR) of **9%**.
  - **Tier 2:** Deposits **> ₹100 Crore up to ₹1,000 Crore**; CRAR of **12%**.
  - **Tier 3:** Deposits **> ₹1,000 Crore up to ₹10,000 Crore**; CRAR of **12%**.
  - **Tier 4:** Deposits **> ₹10,000 Crore**; CRAR of **12%**.
  - **PSL Mandate (PSL Directions, 2025):** Under the operative RBI (Priority Sector Lending – Targets and Classification) Directions, 2025 (effective **1 April 2025**), the overall PSL target for Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks (UCBs) is established at **60% of ANBC or CEOBSE, whichever is higher** (superseding the earlier glide path toward 75%).
- **Deposit Insurance & Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC) 90-Day Moratorium Framework:**
  - Governed by **Section 18A of the DICGC Act, 1961** (inserted via DICGC Amendment Act, 2021).
  - When RBI places an insured bank under all-inclusive Directions or Moratorium, depositors receive up to **₹5 Lakh** (principal + interest) within **90 days**.
  - **Three-Stage Statutory Timeline:** Bank submits depositor list within **45 days**; DICGC verifies claims within **30 days** of receipt; payment is made within the subsequent **15 days**; overall statutory limit = **90 days** (statutory breakdown: 45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days).
  - Authorized capital of DICGC: **₹50 Crore**; wholly-owned statutory subsidiary of RBI.
- **Priority Sector Lending (PSL) Comprehensive Regulatory Matrix:**
  - **Commercial Banks (Domestic & Foreign with ≥ 20 branches):** Total PSL **40% of ANBC** (or CEOBE); **Agriculture 18%** (sub-target: **10%** for Small & Marginal Farmers); **Micro Enterprises 7.5%**; **Weaker Sections 12%**.
  - **Regional Rural Banks (RRBs):** Total PSL **75% of ANBC** (with priority on agriculture and rural credit).
  - **Small Finance Banks (SFBs):** Total PSL **60% of ANBC** (effective FY 2025–26 onward; rationalised by RBI from the initial 75% baseline to enable portfolio diversification and wholesale liquidity management).
  - **Primary Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs):** Total PSL **60% of ANBC or CEOBSE**, whichever is higher (effective 1 April 2025 under RBI PSL Directions 2025; replacing the erstwhile 75% glide path).
  - **Shortfall Penalty:** PSL shortfalls are mandatorily allocated to the **Rural Infrastructure Development Fund (RIDF)** maintained by NABARD, or other specialized funds with SIDBI, NHB, or MUDRA.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The UCB Tier 1 vs Tiers 2–4 CRAR Trap: Tier 1 UCBs require **9% CRAR**; Tiers 2, 3, and 4 require **12% CRAR** (examiners frequently test this distinction).
- DICGC 90-Day Breakdown Trap: **Bank submits depositor list within 45 days; DICGC verifies claims within 30 days of receipt; payment is made within the subsequent 15 days; overall statutory limit = 90 days (45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days)**.
- The SFB, UCB & RRB PSL Alignment Trap (High Yield):
  - *Regional Rural Banks (RRBs)*: **75% of ANBC** (highest among all banks).
  - *Small Finance Banks (SFBs)*: **60% of ANBC** (rationalised from 75% effective FY 2025–26).
  - *Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs)*: **60% of ANBC or CEOBSE** (effective 1 April 2025 under RBI PSL Directions 2025; superseded earlier 75% glide path).
  - *Domestic Commercial Banks*: **40% of ANBC**.

Target MCQ: 'What is the mandatory overall Priority Sector Lending (PSL) target for Primary Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs) under RBI Priority Sector Lending Directions, 2025?' → **60% of ANBC or CEOBSE, whichever is higher**.

[STA-009] **Central Bank Governance, Currency Denomination Limits, Monetary Policy Committee Rules & Public Debt Instruments**

- **RBI Central Board Composition & Tenure (Section 8, RBI Act, 1934):**
  - RBI established on **April 1, 1935** under RBI Act 1934 on the recommendations of the **Hilton Young Commission (1926)**; nationalised on **January 1, 1949**.
  - Central Board of Directors consists of a maximum of **21 members:** Governor + up to 4 Deputy Governors (appointed by Central Government for terms up to **5 years**, eligible for reappointment) + 4 Directors from Local Boards (Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, New Delhi) + 2 Government Officials + 10 Directors nominated by GoI.
- **Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) Statutory Governance (Section 45ZB):**
  - Comprises **6 members:** 3 from RBI (Governor as ex-officio Chairperson, Deputy Governor in charge of monetary policy, 1 officer nominated by Central Board) and 3 external members appointed by Central Government for a fixed term of **4 years** (**not eligible for reappointment**).
  - Quorum: **4 members** (at least one must be Governor or Deputy Governor); Governor holds a casting vote in the event of a tie.
  - Minutes of MPC proceedings published on the **14th day** following the meeting under Section 45ZL.
- **Statutory Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) vs Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR):**
  - **CRR (Section 42(1), RBI Act, 1934):** Cash balances maintained with RBI on Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL); RBI pays **0% interest**; 2006 amendment removed historical statutory floor (3%) and ceiling (20%).
  - **SLR (Section 24, Banking Regulation Act, 1949):** Liquid assets (gold, unencumbered approved G-Secs, cash) maintained by banks with themselves; maximum statutory ceiling is **40%** (2007 amendment removed 25% floor).
- **Statutory Limits on Currency & Sovereign Debt Operations:**
  - **Maximum Banknote Denomination: Section 24 of RBI Act, 1934** empowers RBI to issue banknotes up to denomination of **₹10,000**.
  - **Maximum Coin Denomination: Section 6 of Coinage Act, 2011** authorizes minting of coins up to **₹1,000**.
  - **Ways and Means Advances (WMA):** Extended under **Section 17(5) of RBI Act, 1934** to Central and State Governments to bridge temporary cash flow mismatches; clean advances repayable within **3 months (90 days)**.
  - **Treasury Bills (T-Bills):** Short-term zero-coupon promissory notes issued in **91-day, 182-day, and 364-day** tenors; minimum investment is **₹10,000** and in multiples thereof; auctioned by RBI on Wednesdays. Cash Management Bills (CMBs) have tenors **< 91 days**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- External MPC Member Tenure: Appointed for **4 years** and are **NOT eligible for reappointment** (examiners frequently test re-eligibility).
- MPC Minutes Timeline: Published on the **14th day** after the meeting (not 7 days, not 30 days).
- Maximum Note vs Coin Trap: Maximum banknote denomination is **₹10,000** (under RBI Act); maximum coin denomination is **₹1,000** (under Coinage Act 2011).
- WMA Tenure: Clean advances repayable within **3 months / 90 days**.
- Target MCQ: 'Under Section 24 of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934, what is the highest denomination of bank note that the RBI is authorized to issue?' → **₹10,000**.

[STA-010] **Domestic Systemically Important Banks (D-SIBs) & Capital Surcharge Architecture**

- **Regulatory Genesis & Assessment Framework:**
  - Formulated by the Reserve Bank of India in 2014 based on the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision (BCBS) framework for identifying banks deemed **"Too Big To Fail" (TBTF)**.
  - Eligibility Threshold: Banks whose balance sheet size exceeds **2% of India's Gross Domestic Product (GDP)** are placed in the sample of banks assessed for systemic importance.
  - Assessment Methodology: Evaluated across 4 core quantitative parameters:
    1. **Size** (weightage: 40%).
    2. **Interconnectedness** (weightage: 20%).
    3. **Substitutability / Financial Institution Infrastructure** (weightage: 20%).
    4. **Complexity** (weightage: 20%).
- **D-SIB Bucketing Structure & Additional Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) Surcharges:**
  - **Bucket 5:** Additional CET1 requirement: **1.00%** of Risk-Weighted Assets (RWAs) — *Currently Empty*.
  - **Bucket 4:** Additional CET1 requirement: **0.80%** of RWAs — **State Bank of India (SBI)** (escalated from Bucket 3).
  - **Bucket 3:** Additional CET1 requirement: **0.60%** of RWAs — *Currently Empty*.
  - **Bucket 2:** Additional CET1 requirement: **0.40%** of RWAs — **HDFC Bank** (elevated following the merger with HDFC Ltd).
  - **Bucket 1:** Additional CET1 requirement: **0.20%** of RWAs — **ICICI Bank**.
- **Regulatory Implication:** The additional CET1 requirement for D-SIBs is in addition to the standard minimum CET1 ratio of 5.5% and the Capital Conservation Buffer (CCB) of 2.5%, raising the total capital adequacy bar for these three lenders.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- SBI Surcharge Trap: SBI is placed in **Bucket 4** requiring an additional **0.80% CET1** surcharge (not 0.60%).
- HDFC Bank Trap: HDFC Bank is in **Bucket 2** requiring **0.40% CET1**; ICICI Bank is in **Bucket 1** requiring **0.20% CET1**.
- Assessment Threshold: Banks with assets exceeding **2% of national GDP** are assessed.
- Target MCQ: 'What additional Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) capital surcharge is mandated by the RBI for State Bank of India (SBI) as a Bucket 4 D-SIB?' → **0.80% of RWAs**.

[STA-011] **DAY-NRLM SHG Credit Architecture, Interest Subvention & Collateral Waivers**

- **Statutory Framework & Mission Architecture:**
  - Launched in June 2011 by the Ministry of Rural Development (MoRD) by restructuring Swarnjayanti Gram Swarozgar Yojana (SGSY); partially supported by the World Bank.
  - Institutional Pillar: Mobilizing rural poor women into **Self-Help Groups (SHGs)** of 10–20 women (5–20 in difficult/tribal terrains).
  - **Nodal Lead Bank: Indian Bank** appointed as the Central Nodal Bank by MoRD for administering the pan-India interest subvention scheme across commercial, co-operative, and regional rural banks.
- **Interest Subvention Structure for Women SHGs (FY 2025–26):**

- **Loans up to ₹3 Lakh:** Commercial banks lend to women SHGs at **7.00% per annum**.
- **Central Interest Subvention:** Government of India provides an interest subvention of **4.50%** directly to banks, bridging the difference between the bank's lending rate (up to an 11.5% cap) and 7%.
- **Prompt Repayment Incentive (PRI):** For SHGs that maintain timely repayment schedules, an additional subvention of **3.00%** is credited directly to the SHG's account, reducing the **effective borrowing cost to 4.00% per annum**.
- **Loans between ₹3 Lakh and ₹5 Lakh:** Banks lend at benchmark market interest rates; Central Government provides interest subvention to bridge the rate down to **10% per annum**.

- **Collateral-Free Credit Waivers:**
  - Under RBI Master Directions, **no collateral and no margin** is required for loans to women SHGs up to **₹10 Lakh** (historical baseline).
  - RBI enhanced the mandatory collateral-free lending threshold to **₹20 Lakh** under DAY-NRLM without any asset hypothecation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Nodal Bank Trap: The central nodal bank administering DAY-NRLM interest subvention is **Indian Bank** (not SBI, PNB, or NABARD).
- Effective Interest Rate with PRI: The baseline subsidized rate is **7%**, but with the 3% Prompt Repayment Incentive, the effective borrowing cost drops to **4%**.
- Collateral Limit: Enhanced collateral-free limit is **₹20 Lakh** (up from ₹10 Lakh).
- Target MCQ: 'Which public sector bank serves as the central nodal bank for administering interest subvention under DAY-NRLM?' → **Indian Bank**.

[STA-012] **Foreign & Overseas Currency Accounts Matrix: NRE, NRO, FCNR(B) & Bank Nostro/Vostro/Loro**

- **Non-Resident Indian (NRI) Deposit Accounts Master Matrix:**
  - **NRE (Non-Resident External) Account:**
    - **Denominated In:** Indian Rupees (**INR**).
    - **Source of Funds:** Foreign inward remittances in convertible foreign currency.
    - **Repatriability: Freely and fully repatriable** (both principal and interest) outside India without any annual limit.
    - **Tax Status: 100% Tax-Free** in India (exempt from Indian Income Tax and Wealth Tax).
    - **Currency Risk:** Borne entirely by the **depositor** (converted to INR at prevailing market rates).
  - **NRO (Non-Resident Ordinary) Account:**
    - **Denominated In:** Indian Rupees (**INR**).
    - **Source of Funds:** Legitimate income earned inside India (dividends, rent, pension, sale of local assets) or foreign inward remittances.
    - **Repatriability: Restricted**; principal repatriation capped up to **$1 Million USD per financial year** subject to RBI guidelines and tax clearance (Form 15CA/15CB).
    - **Tax Status: Taxable in India**; interest income subject to Tax Deducted at Source (TDS) at standard 30% plus applicable surcharge/cess (or lower rate under Double Taxation Avoidance Agreements - DTAA).
    - **Joint Account:** Can be held jointly with a resident Indian on 'Former or Survivor' basis.
  - **FCNR(B) (Foreign Currency Non-Resident Bank) Account:**
    - **Denominated In:** Permitted **Foreign Currencies** (USD, GBP, EUR, JPY, CAD, AUD).
    - **Type of Deposit: Term Deposit only** (fixed maturity from **1 year to 5 years**; savings accounts not permitted).
    - **Repatriability: Freely and fully repatriable** in foreign currency.
    - **Tax Status: 100% Tax-Free** in India.
    - **Currency Risk:** Borne entirely by the **bank** (no exchange rate risk for the depositor upon maturity).
- **Interbank Overseas Account Terminology (Latin Derivations):**
  - **Nostro Account** (*"Our account with you"*): An Indian bank's account maintained in a foreign bank overseas in that foreign country's domestic currency (e.g., SBI maintaining a USD account with JPMorgan Chase in New York).

- **Vostro Account** (*"Your account with us"*): A foreign bank's account maintained in an Indian bank in India in Indian Rupees (e.g., JPMorgan Chase maintaining an INR account with SBI in Mumbai).
- **Special Rupee Vostro Accounts (SRVA):** Specialized Vostro accounts authorized by RBI under Circular No. 10 (July 2022) to settle cross-border international trade transactions directly in Indian Rupees (INR), bypassing USD/EUR clearing.
- **Loro Account** (*"Their account"*): A third-party bank referring to an account held by another domestic bank with a foreign correspondent (e.g., Bank of Baroda referencing SBI's Nostro account with JPMorgan Chase: "their account with you").
- **Mirror Account:** A shadow ledger maintained by the domestic bank to reflect the real-time debits, credits, and balance of its overseas Nostro account.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Repatriation Ceiling Trap: NRE is **unlimited / freely repatriable**; NRO repatriation is strictly capped at **$1 Million per financial year**.
- FCNR(B) Currency Risk Trap: The currency risk in FCNR(B) is borne by the **bank**, NOT the depositor. FCNR(B) can only be opened for **1 to 5 years** (no savings accounts).
- Nostro vs Vostro Trap: Nostro = **Our money in your country/currency**; Vostro = **Your foreign bank money in our bank in INR**.
- Target MCQ: 'What is the maximum annual repatriation limit permitted from a Non-Resident Ordinary (NRO) account under RBI FEMA regulations?' → **USD 1 Million per financial year**.

[STA-013] **The Bima Trinity & IRDAI Regulatory Architecture**

- **Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI):**
  - Statutory body constituted under the **IRDA Act, 1999** following the recommendations of the **Malhotra Committee (1994)**.
  - Head Office: **Hyderabad, Telangana** (shifted from New Delhi in 2001).
  - Statutory Composition: Chairman + not more than 5 Whole-Time Members + not more than 4 Part-Time Members (appointed by Central Government). Maximum age: Chairman and Whole-Time Members serve up to **age 65** (members up to age 62).
  - Mission Goal: **"Insurance for All by 2047"** (marking India's centenary of independence).
- **The Bima Trinity Architecture (Three Inclusion Pillars):**
  - **1. Bima Sugam (Digital Public Infrastructure / Universal Exchange):**
    - Conceived as an open-source, digital electronic marketplace acting as the **"UPI of Insurance"**.
    - Integrates all life, general, and health insurance companies, policyholders, brokers, and web aggregators onto a single interoperable electronic portal.
    - Enables paperless policy purchase, instant electronic KYC, automated renewals, endorsement changes, and centralized claim settlement tracking.
    - Equity Structure: Non-profit Section 8 company; 30% shareholding each held by Life Insurance Council and General Insurance Council, remaining equity held by commercial insurers and brokers.
  - **2. Bima Vistar (Comprehensive Low-Cost Composite Insurance):**
    - An all-in-one bundled micro-insurance product designed specifically for rural households and lower-income families.
    - Combines **Life, Health, Personal Accident, and Property/Crop coverage** into a single unified policy with affordable premium.
    - Defined benefits: ₹2 Lakh life coverage, ₹2 Lakh personal accident cover, ₹50,000 hospital cash/health indemnity, ₹50,000 property protection.
  - **3. Bima Vahak (Women-Centric Gram Panchayat Distribution Network):**
    - Dedicated field distribution force comprising women micro-agents operating at the **Gram Panchayat level**.
    - Focuses on financial literacy, doorstep onboarding, last-mile policy issuance, and immediate digital claims assistance for rural women.

- **Legislative & Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) Shifts:**
  - **100% Foreign Direct Investment (FDI)** permitted in Indian insurance companies under the automatic route (raised from 74% under the Insurance Laws (Amendment) Act / 2025–2026 legislative overhaul, subject to Indian resident management requirements).
  - **100% FDI** permitted for Insurance Intermediaries (insurance brokers, loss assessors, third-party administrators).
  - The legislative overhaul also introduces **Composite Insurance Licensing** (empowering a single insurance company to underwrite both life and non-life/health policies under a unified corporate charter).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- IRDAI Headquarters: **Hyderabad** (NOT Mumbai, NOT New Delhi).
- Bima Trinity Components: Bima **Sugam** (Portal/Exchange), Bima **Vistar** (Composite Product), Bima **Vahak** (Women Delivery Agents).
- Insurance FDI Limit: **100%** for insurance companies (hiked from 74% under 2025–2026 reforms) and **100%** for insurance intermediaries.
- Target MCQ: 'Which pillar of IRDAI's Bima Trinity represents the open-architecture digital marketplace for policy purchase and claims?' → **Bima Sugam**.

[STA-014] **Macroeconomic Modernization & Base-Year Architecture: 2026 Active Series & Historical Traps**

- **The Economic Rationale for Base-Year Revisions:**
  - Macroeconomic indices undergo structural base-year revisions (mandated by MoSPI and DPIIT) to eliminate statistical obsolescence, capture shifts in household consumption (e.g., e-commerce, digital services, renewable energy), and integrate modern enterprise registries (GSTN, MCA-21).
- **Master Base-Year Matrix (2026 Operative Framework vs Historical Baselines):**
  - **Gross Domestic Product (GDP) / Gross Value Added (GVA):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2022–23** (officially released by MoSPI / NSO on **27 February 2026**, incorporating updated Supply-Use Tables and GST electronic filings).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12** (operational from 2015 to early 2026).
  - **Consumer Price Index (CPI - Combined):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2024 = 100** (officially released by MoSPI / NSO in **February 2026**; anchored in the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey / HCES 2022–23 & 2023–24; rationalises the Food & Beverages weight from an obsolete 45.86% down to **36.75%** across 12 divisions and 358 items).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2012 = 100** (compiled monthly by NSO).
  - **Index of Industrial Production (IIP):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2022–23 = 100** (released by MoSPI in **June 2026**, expanding electronic manufacturing, semiconductors, and solar PV modules).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12 = 100** (407 item groups).
  - **Index of Core Industries (ICI - 9 Core Sectors):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2022–23** (released August 2026; expanded to **9 core industries** with the addition of **Iron Ore**).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12** (8 core industries).
  - **Wholesale Price Index (WPI):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series:** Revised to **Base Year 2022–23** (compiled by Office of Economic Adviser, DPIIT, expanding items from 697 to 957 based on Gross Value of Output / GVO weighting).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12 = 100**.
- **CPI vs WPI Invariant Comparison & Policy Anchor:**
  - **Services Inclusion:** CPI includes **Services** (health, education, recreation, transport); WPI covers **Goods/Commodities only** (zero services coverage).
  - **Monetary Policy Anchor:** Under the Urjit Patel Committee recommendations and Section 45ZA of the RBI Act 1934, the Monetary Policy Committee anchors inflation targeting strictly to **CPI (Combined) Headline Inflation**, maintaining a target of **4.00% with a +/- 2.00% tolerance band (2% to 6%)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Base-Year Exam Trap (High Risk):
  - *GDP Active Base Year*: **2022–23** (released Feb 2026; do NOT mark 2011–12).
  - *CPI-Combined Active Base Year*: **2024 = 100** (released Feb 2026; do NOT mark 2012).
  - *IIP Active Base Year*: **2022–23 = 100** (released June 2026; do NOT mark 2011–12).
  - *Core Industries (ICI)*: **Base Year 2022–23** with **9 core industries** (Iron Ore added as 9th).

Monetary Policy Inflation Anchor: RBI legally targets **CPI-Combined**, NEVER WPI.

Services Coverage: CPI includes services; WPI **does NOT include services**.

Target MCQ: 'What is the active base year for the revised Gross Domestic Product (GDP) series released by MoSPI in 2026?' → **2022–23** (replaces 2011–12).

[STA-015] **Money Supply Dynamics, Equations & Liquidity Aggregates (M0, M1, M2, M3, M4, L1, L2, L3)**

- **Historical Formulation:**
  - First standardized by RBI in 1935, refined by the Second Working Group (1977), and fundamentally modernized by the **Third Working Group on Money Supply (chaired by Dr. Y.V. Reddy, 1998)**.
- **The Classical Monetary Aggregates:**
  - **M0 (Reserve Money / Monetary Base / High-Powered Money / Central Bank Money):**
    - Formula: **Currency in Circulation (CIC) + Bankers' Deposits with RBI + 'Other' Deposits with RBI**.
    - It represents the total monetary liabilities of the Reserve Bank of India.
  - **M1 (Narrow Money):**
    - Formula: **Currency with the Public + Demand Deposits with the Banking System (Current & Savings Accounts) + 'Other' Deposits with RBI**.
    - Most liquid measure of commercial money supply.
  - **M2:**
    - Formula: **M1 + Post Office Savings Bank Deposits**.
  - **M3 (Broad Money):**
    - Formula: **M1 + Time Deposits with the Banking System (Fixed & Recurring Deposits)**.
    - Most widely used metric for analyzing aggregate liquidity and monetary policy transmission in India.
  - **M4:**
    - Formula: **M3 + Total Post Office Deposits** (excluding National Savings Certificates / NSC).
- **The Y.V. Reddy (1998) New Monetary Aggregates (NM) & Liquidity Aggregates (L):**
  - **NM1:** Currency with the Public + Demand Deposits with Banking System + 'Other' Deposits with RBI.
  - **NM2:** NM1 + Short-term Time Deposits with contractual maturity up to 1 year.
  - **NM3:** NM2 + Long-term Time Deposits with contractual maturity > 1 year + Call/Term Borrowing from financial institutions.
  - **L1 (Liquidity Aggregate 1):** NM3 + All Deposits with Post Office Savings Banks (excluding NSC).
  - **L2 (Liquidity Aggregate 2):** L1 + Term Deposits with Term Lending Institutions and Refinancing Institutions (NABARD, EXIM Bank, SIDBI, NHB) + Term Borrowings by FIs + Certificates of Deposit (CDs) issued by FIs.
  - **L3 (Liquidity Aggregate 3):** L2 + Public Deposits of Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs).
- **Money Multiplier Dynamics:**
  - Formula: **Money Multiplier (m) = Broad Money (M_3) / Reserve Money (M_0)**.
  - An increase in Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) reduces the money multiplier; a decrease in CRR increases the money multiplier.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Most Liquid vs Broadest Measure: **M1 is the most liquid**; **M3 is the standard Broad Money** measure tracked by RBI.
- M0 Formulation: M0 includes **Currency in Circulation**, whereas M1 includes **Currency with the Public** (Currency with Public = Currency in Circulation minus Cash in hand with banks).
- Post Office NSC Trap: NSC (National Savings Certificates) are **strictly excluded** from M4 and L1 calculations.
- Target MCQ: 'Which equation correctly defines Broad Money (M3) in Indian banking?' → **M1 + Time Deposits with the Banking System**.

[STA-016] **Differentiated Banking Architecture: Small Finance Banks (SFBs) vs Payments Banks (PBs)**

- **Genesis & Policy Mandate:**
  - Recommended by the **Committee on Comprehensive Financial Services for Small Businesses and Low Income Households (chaired by Dr. Nachiket Mor, 2014)** to drive niche financial inclusion.
  - Licensed under **Section 22 of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949** as specialized "Differentiated Banks" (distinguished from Universal Scheduled Commercial Banks).
- **Comprehensive Differentiated Banks Comparison Matrix:**

Statutory Parameter	Small Finance Banks (SFBs)	Payments Banks (PBs)
Core Regulatory Committee	Usha Thorat Committee (Evaluation)	Nachiket Mor Committee
Minimum Paid-Up Capital	**₹200 Crore** (₹100 Cr for UCBs converting to SFBs)	**₹100 Crore**
Lending & Credit Operations	**Fully permitted** to advance loans and extend credit facilities	**STRICTLY PROHIBITED** from lending or advancing any credit
Credit Cards Issuance	Permitted to issue Credit Cards	**PROHIBITED** from issuing Credit Cards (can issue ATM/Debit cards)
Maximum Customer Deposit Limit	**No ceiling** (can accept unlimited demand & time deposits)	Capped at **₹2 Lakh per individual customer** at end of day
Deposit Types Accepted	Demand Deposits (CASA) + Time Deposits (FD/RD)	**Demand Deposits ONLY** (Savings & Current; zero FDs/RDs)
Priority Sector Lending (PSL)	**60% of Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC)** (effective FY 2025–26)	**Not Applicable** (since lending is prohibited)
Loan Size Concentration Cap	At least **50% of loan portfolio must be ≤ ₹25 Lakh**	Not Applicable
Mandatory Rural Branch Quota	At least **25% branches** in unbanked rural centres	At least **25% physical access points** in unbanked rural areas
Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)	Mandatory with RBI (under Sec 42 of RBI Act)	Mandatory with RBI (under Sec 42 of RBI Act)
Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR)	Standard operational SLR (18.00% in G-Secs)	Minimum **75% of demand deposits in G-Secs/T-Bills** with maturity up to 1 year; max 25% in current/term deposits with other SCBs
Conversion to Universal Bank	Eligible to apply after **5 years of satisfactory performance**, minimum net worth of **₹1,000 Crore**, and listing	Not eligible for direct universal bank conversion

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Payments Bank Lending Trap: Payments banks **CANNOT lend money and CANNOT issue credit cards** (they can only issue Debit/ATM cards).
- Payments Bank Deposit Cap: Capped at **₹2 Lakh per customer** (enhanced from ₹1 Lakh in 2021).
- SFB PSL Quota: **60% of ANBC** (effective FY 2025–26; rationalised from 75%; commercial banks have 40%, RRBs have 75%, UCBs have 60%).
- SFB Ticket Size Rule: At least **50% of loans must be ≤ ₹25 Lakh**.
- Target MCQ: 'What is the maximum end-of-day balance limit permitted per individual customer in a Payments Bank account?' **→ ₹2,00,000 (₹2 Lakh)**.

[STA-017] **SEBI Capital Markets Overhaul: T+0 Rolling Settlement, MF Lite & Derivatives Guardrails**

- **Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI):**
  - Established on April 12, 1988 as an administrative body; granted statutory status on **January 30, 1992** under the **SEBI Act, 1992**.
  - Head Office: **Mumbai**; Regional Offices in New Delhi, Kolkata, Chennai, and Ahmedabad.
  - Leadership: Chairperson appointed under Section 4(1); serves for terms up to 5 years or until age 65.
- **T+0 Rolling Settlement & Instant Settlement Architecture:**
  - India became the second country globally after China to implement **T+1 rolling settlement** in January 2023.
  - In March 2024, SEBI introduced a **Beta version of optional T+0 settlement** for a select basket of 25 liquid scrips with a limited set of brokers.
  - Operational Mechanism: Under T+0, trades executed between 9:15 AM and 1:30 PM are settled with immediate transfer of funds and securities on the same trading day by **4:30 PM**.
  - Pathway: Serves as the technological sandbox stepping-stone towards **Instantaneous Real-Time Settlement**.
- **Mutual Fund Lite (MF Lite) Regulatory Framework:**
  - Specialized, light-touch regulatory regime established by SEBI specifically for **passively managed mutual funds** (Index Funds and Exchange Traded Funds - ETFs).
  - Rationale: Passive funds mirror underlying benchmark indices without discretionary fund manager stock-picking risk.
  - Relaxations: Lowered minimum net worth requirements for asset management companies (AMCs), simplified disclosure norms, streamlined approval pipelines, and reduced compliance overheads to attract new boutique fund houses and expand retail financialization in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities.
- **Equity Derivatives (F&O) Market Guardrails (6-Pillar Risk Framework):**
  - Formulated following SEBI study showing that 93% of individual retail traders incurred net losses in the Futures & Options (F&O) segment between FY 2022 and FY 2024.
  - Key Measures:
    1. **Contract Sizing Enhancement:** Minimum trading lot size value for index derivatives increased from ₹5 Lakh to **₹15 Lakh to ₹20 Lakh**.
    2. **Rationalization of Weekly Expiries:** Stock exchanges permitted to offer weekly derivative contracts for only **one benchmark index per exchange** (eliminating multiple daily expiries across exchanges).
    3. **Upfront Option Premium Collection:** Mandating brokers to collect option premiums from buyers upfront.
    4. **Intraday Monitoring of Position Limits:** Real-time snapshot monitoring of index position limits to prevent market manipulation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Settlement Evolution: India migrated from T+2 to **T+1 in Jan 2023**, and launched optional **T+0 beta** in March 2024.
- MF Lite Applicability: Exclusively applies to **passively managed schemes** (Index Funds and ETFs), NOT active equity funds.
- F&O Lot Sizing: Minimum contract value increased to **₹15 Lakh - ₹20 Lakh** (up from ₹5 Lakh).
- Target MCQ: 'What category of mutual fund schemes is covered under SEBI's relaxed Mutual Fund Lite (MF Lite) regulatory framework?' → **Passively managed index funds and Exchange Traded Funds (ETFs)**.

[STA-018] **Multilateral Development Banks (MDBs) Master Directory & Sovereign Growth Forecasts**

- **Master Directory of Apex Multilateral Financial Institutions:**

Multilateral Body	Head Office	Established	Current Apex Leadership	India's Voting / Shareholding Status
World Bank Group (IBRD / IDA)	**Washington D.C., USA**	1944 (Bretton Woods)	President: **Ajay Banga** (14th President)	India is the 7th largest shareholder in IBRD; largest historical cumulative borrower from IDA (concessional window)
International Monetary Fund (IMF)	**Washington D.C., USA**	1944 (Bretton Woods)	Managing Director: **Kristalina Georgieva**; First Deputy MD: **Dan Katz**	Quota share: **2.75%** (8th largest quota); SDR currency basket: USD, EUR, CNY, JPY, GBP
Asian Development Bank (ADB)	**Mandaluyong / Manila, Philippines**	1966	President: **Masato Kanda** (assumed office Feb 2025; re-elected Sept 2026)	Japan and USA are joint largest shareholders (15.6% each); India is the **4th largest shareholder** (6.3%)
Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB)	**Beijing, China**	2016	President: **Jin Liqun**	China is the 1st largest shareholder (26.6% voting power); **India is the 2nd largest shareholder** (7.6% voting power)
New Development Bank (NDB / BRICS)	**Shanghai, China**	2015 (Fortaleza Treaty)	President: **Dilma Rousseff**	5 founding members (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa) held equal **20% initial voting equity**; new members: Bangladesh, UAE, Egypt, Uruguay
Bank for International Settlements (BIS)	**Basel, Switzerland**	1930	General Manager: Agustín Carstens	Central bank of central banks; host of the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision (BCBS)
European Bank for Reconstruction & Dev (EBRD)	**London, United Kingdom**	1991	President: Odile Renaud-Basso	India became the **69th shareholder** in July 2018 (non-borrowing member)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- AIIB Shareholding Trap: India is the **2nd largest shareholder** in AIIB (behind China).
- ADB Shareholding Trap: India is the **4th largest shareholder** in ADB (behind Japan, USA, China).
- NDB Equal Equity: Founding BRICS members each received equal **20% initial voting power**.
- Target MCQ: 'What is India's shareholding rank in the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB)?' → **Second largest shareholder (behind China)**.

Q1 2026 (JANUARY – MARCH) COMPREHENSIVE CONSOLIDATED DOSSIER

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Q1 Comprehensive Dossier, ESI, Regulatory Directions & National Policy Anchors

Zone: LIGHT-TOUCH ZONE (Oct 2025 – March 2026) | Single Master Dossier | Framework v3.1 **Sources:** Smartkeeda Jan 2026 Monthly CA PDF (Buckets 1, 2, 3) + Smartkeeda Feb 2026 Monthly CA PDF + Smartkeeda March 2026 Monthly CA PDF — merged, deduplicated, cross-referenced

> ***Master Consolidation Note:*** *All three months sit in the Light-Touch Zone. Tier A items from Jan, Feb, and March have been pooled into 10 unified thematic sections rather than appended sequentially. Overlapping stories and phased regulatory rollouts have been synthesized into single evolutionary cards marked UPDATE. High-yield items have been re-calibrated across the entire combined pool (~15–20% density).*

1. ESI, FINANCE & BUSINESS NEWS

[Q1-001] **India's Economy — Size, Growth & the Feb 1 Budget** *(merged: Jan's pre-Budget context + Feb's actual Budget content)*

Hook — India overtook Japan to become the world's 4th-largest economy in January, and a month later Nirmala Sitharaman used her record 9th-consecutive Budget to lock in a falling fiscal deficit and a ₹1,000 crore semiconductor push.

- **Global Economic Milestone:** India officially surpassed Japan to become the **world's 4th-largest economy with a GDP of $4.18 trillion**, targeting 3rd position by 2030 by overtaking Germany ($7.3 trillion projected).
- **Quarterly & Annual GDP Trajectory:** Real GDP expanded by **8.2% in Q2 FY26** (accelerating from 7.8% in Q1 and 7.4% in Q4 FY25); the National Statistical Office (NSO) 1st Advance Estimates pegged **FY26 real GDP growth at 7.4%** (₹201.90 lakh crore).
- **Economic Survey 2025-26 Projections:** Tabled on January 29 by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman and authored by CEA V. Anantha Nageswaran; projected **FY27 real GDP growth at 6.8%–7.2%**; banking health strengthened with Gross NPA at 2.2% and Net NPA at 0.5% (Sep 2025); fiscal deficit projected to decline to 4.4% of GDP in FY26 (down from 9.2% in FY21).
- **Global Agency Forecast Consensus:** Multilateral institutions aligned around moderated growth — World Bank projected 6.5%, IMF forecast 6.6%/6.2%, and Moody's projected 6.4%/6.5% (OECD, S&P, ADB, and Fitch projected within a similar 6.3%–6.7% band).
- **Union Budget 2026-27 Record Presentation:** Presented on February 1, 2026, marking Nirmala Sitharaman's **9th consecutive Union Budget**, setting a new all-time record for consecutive presentations (Morarji Desai retains the record for most Budgets overall at 10, non-consecutive).
- **Institutional & Thematic Blueprint:** First Budget prepared in the newly commissioned **Kartavya Bhawan**; anchored around three core 'Kartavyas' — accelerating economic growth, fulfilling citizen aspirations, and building inclusive development.
- **Fiscal Consolidation & Debt Metrics:** Fiscal deficit for FY27 targeted down to **4.3% of GDP** (from 4.4% Revised Estimate in FY26); Central Government **Debt-to-GDP ratio projected at 55.6%** (BE 2026-27) versus 56.1% (RE 2025-26); Capital Expenditure (**Capex**) hiked 9% to a historic high of **₹12.2 lakh crore (4.4% of GDP)**.
- **Direct Tax Code Modernisation:** Enacted the **New Income Tax Act, 2025**, effective **April 1, 2026**, drastically slashing total sections from 819 down to 536 to simplify compliance.
- **Financial Market & Capital Taxation:** Securities Transaction Tax (STT) increased on Futures to 0.05% (from 0.02%) and on Options to 0.15%; share buyback taxation revised to 22% for corporate promoters and 30% for non-corporate promoters.
- **Strategic Industrial & Infrastructure Outlays:** Launched **India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) 2.0** with a ₹1,000 crore FY27 outlay; announced **'Biopharma SHAKTI'** (₹10,000 crore), the **SME Growth Fund** (₹10,000 crore), and 7 new High-Speed Rail corridors (₹16 lakh crore).
- **16th Finance Commission Devolution:** Accepted recommendations of the Commission (chaired by Dr. Arvind Panagariya); retained vertical tax devolution to states at **41%** (for 2026-27 to 2030-31); introduced a new 10%

weightage for 'Contribution to GDP' (replacing the 2.5% weightage for 'Tax & Fiscal Effort'); total grants to states fixed at ₹9.47 lakh crore.

- **Gender Budgeting Expansion:** Gender Budget Statement (GBS) share rose to **9.37%** of total budget expenditure (up from 8.86%), with total allocation reaching **₹5.01 lakh crore** (+11.55% YoY).

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY MNEMONIC

"9th, 4.3, 4.4" — 9th consecutive Budget, 4.3% fiscal deficit target, 4.4% capex-to-GDP.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Two separate "most Budgets" records must not be conflated: Morarji Desai = most Budgets overall (10), Nirmala Sitharaman = most **consecutive** (9). Also lock in "4th-largest economy, $4.18 trillion" vs the 2030 target of 3rd place ($7.3 trillion).

INTERVIEW & MAINS DESCRIPTIVE ANGLE

"How does the FY27 Budget's fiscal path align with the Economic Survey's own projections?" — The Economic Survey (Jan 29) projected FY27 growth moderating to 6.8-7.2% from FY26's 7.4%, and the Budget (Feb 1) responded with a tighter fiscal deficit target of 4.3% (from 4.4%) and a 9% capex hike — both documents show the government leaning on public investment to offset an expected growth slowdown rather than fiscal loosening.

[Q1-002] **India's Fiscal Deficit Tracking — interim data (Apr-Nov & Apr-Dec 2025)**

- **8-Month Fiscal Deficit (Apr–Nov 2025):** India's fiscal deficit reached **₹9.76 lakh crore**, representing **62.3%** of the full-year Budget Estimate (widened from 52.5% during the corresponding period last year), supported by an RBI dividend transfer to the Centre of ₹2.69 lakh crore.
- **9-Month Fiscal Turnaround (Apr–Dec 2025):** The cumulative deficit narrowed sharply to **₹8.55 lakh crore**, or **54.5%** of the annual estimate, aided by an extraordinary December fiscal surplus of **₹1.21 trillion** generated through quarterly corporate advance-tax inflows.
- **Reconciliation with Annual Budget:** This interim high-frequency tracking preceded the Union Budget's FY26 Revised Estimate of **4.4% of GDP**, demonstrating how mid-year fiscal compression stabilized the annual fiscal deficit path.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse the 8-month (62.3%) and 9-month (54.5%) figures; note how the rare December surplus (₹1.21T) narrowed the cumulative deficit by nearly 8 percentage points.

[Q1-003] **India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) — Progress & Flagship Project** *(Feb + March, merged — same underlying data reported in both months)*

- **ISM 2.0 Equipment & Materials Push:** Launched in Union Budget 2026-27 with an initial outlay of **₹1,000 crore for FY27**, directing strategic subsidies toward semiconductor fabrication equipment, specialty gases, and pure chemical supply chains.
- **ISM 1.0 Cumulative Milestones:** Launched in December 2021 with a ₹76,000 crore budget; by December 2025, approved **10 major manufacturing and packaging projects across 6 states** (Gujarat, Assam, Uttar Pradesh, Odisha, Punjab, Andhra Pradesh), mobilizing **₹1.60 lakh crore in cumulative investments**.
- **Flagship ATMP Commercial Inauguration (March Update):** Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the **Micron Semiconductor ATMP facility in Sanand, Gujarat** — constructed at an investment of **₹22,500 crore** as the very 1st proposal approved under ISM, now operational packaging DRAM and NAND memory wafers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹1.60 lakh crore (10-project cumulative ISM investment) vs ₹22,500 crore (cost of single Micron Sanand ATMP unit) is a classic numeric confusion trap.

[Q1-004] **Startup India — Redefinition to Include Deep Tech** *(Feb)*

- **Regulatory Framework Modernisation:** Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) amended startup recognition norms, establishing distinct statutory criteria for conventional vs deep-technology ventures.
- **Standard Startup Eligibility Limits:** A business entity is recognized as a standard startup for up to **10 years** from the date of incorporation, provided annual turnover does not exceed **₹200 crore**.
- **Deep Tech Startup Extended Thresholds:** To accommodate longer gestation and research timelines, deep-tech startups receive an extended eligibility window of **20 years** and an increased turnover ceiling of **₹300 crore**.
- **Ecosystem Scale & Institutional Support:** India crossed **200,000+ officially recognized startups** since the 2016 launch, financed through dedicated instruments: Startup India Seed Fund Scheme (SISFS), Credit Guarantee Scheme for Startups (CGSS), and SIPP.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹200 Cr vs ₹300 Cr turnover cap and 10-year vs 20-year eligibility window are classic paired-number traps comparing conventional vs deep-tech startups.

[Q1-005] **SBI Overtakes TCS — India's 4th Most Valuable Company** *(Feb)*

- **Milestone Market Capitalisation Shift:** State Bank of India's (SBI) market valuation surpassed **₹10.9 lakh crore** (+11% rally across 3 sessions), displacing Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) to become India's 4th most valuable listed corporate entity.
- **India's Top Market-Cap Hierarchy:** The revised top-four hierarchy stands as: 1st **Reliance Industries** (~~₹19.6–19.8 lakh Cr) → 2nd **HDFC Bank** (~~₹14.2–14.3 lakh Cr) → 3rd **Bharti Airtel** (~₹11.5–12.1 lakh Cr) → 4th **State Bank of India** (₹10.9 lakh Cr).
- **Core Market Drivers:** TCS market capitalization retreated ~8% to ₹10.5 lakh crore amid global investor concerns over generative AI disruption to traditional IT services revenue models, enabling PSU banking outperformance.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Hierarchy sequence MCQ: Reliance (1st) → HDFC Bank (2nd) → Bharti Airtel (3rd) → SBI (4th). Note TCS falling behind SBI to 5th place.

[Q1-006] **India's Current Account Deficit & Trade Data** *(March)*

- **Quarterly Current Account Dynamics:** India's Current Account Deficit (CAD) widened to **$13.2 billion (1.3% of GDP)** in Q3 FY25 (compared to $11.3 billion / 1.1% of GDP in Q2 FY25), driven by merchandise trade gaps.
- **Cumulative 9-Month Trajectory:** For April–December 2025, cumulative CAD remained contained at **$30.1 billion (1.0% of GDP)**, supported by robust software services exports and resilient private remittances.
- **Monthly External Trade Snapshot (Feb 2026):** Total monthly exports reached **$76.13 billion** (+11.05% YoY), while total monthly imports expanded to **$80.09 billion** (+21.64% YoY).
- **11-Month Cumulative External Trade (Apr–Feb FY26):** Cumulative merchandise and services exports totaled **$790.86 billion** (+5.79%), while imports reached **$900.51 billion** (+7.37%).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Do not confuse quarterly CAD ($13.2 bn / 1.3% of GDP in Q3) with the lower cumulative 9-month figure ($30.1 bn / 1.0% of GDP).

[Q1-007] **Index of Industrial Production (IIP) — Quick Estimate, January 2026** *(March)*

- **Headline Industrial Output Pace:** India's Index of Industrial Production (IIP) grew by **4.8%** in January 2026 (moderating from 7.8% in December 2025), with the index standing at **169.4** (up from 161.6).

- **Sectoral Industrial Performance:** Across the three broad economic sectors, **Electricity** led growth at **5.1%**, followed by **Manufacturing** at **4.8%**, and **Mining** at **4.3%**.
- **Institutional Release Schedule:** Compiled and released on the **28th of every month** by the National Statistical Office (NSO) under the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Lock in the 4.8% headline growth rate, sector ranking (Electricity 5.1% > Manufacturing 4.8% > Mining 4.3%), and MoSPI's fixed 28th-day monthly release schedule.

[Q1-008] **Retail Inflation Target Retained (FY27–FY31)** *(March)*

- **Statutory 5-Year Target Reaffirmation:** Government of India formally retained the statutory retail inflation target of **4.0% with a tolerance band of +/- 2.0% (2.0% to 6.0%)** for the five-year cycle from **April 1, 2026 to March 31, 2031**.
- **Statutory Authority:** Notified under **Section 45-ZA of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934**, continuing the Flexible Inflation Targeting (FIT) regime established in 2016.
- **Current Reading & Global Anniversary:** Headline Consumer Price Index (CPI) stood at **3.21% in February 2026** (up from 2.74% in January 2026); notably, Inflation Targeting completes **35 years** globally in 2026, pioneered by New Zealand in 1990.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Statutory citation under Section 45-ZA of the RBI Act, 1934, the 4% (+/-2%) band continuity through 2031, and New Zealand as the global first adopter (1990).

[Q1-009] **Government Borrowing Programme — H1 FY27** *(March)*

- **Gross Borrowing Target & Switch Adjustments:** Gross Market Borrowing for BE 2026-27 set at **₹17.20 lakh crore**, trimmed to an effective net market borrowing of **₹16.09 lakh crore** through planned Government Security (G-Sec) switches and buybacks.
- **First-Half Borrowing Frontloading:** The Centre will raise **₹8.20 lakh crore (51% of total gross borrowing)** in H1 FY27 via dated securities conducted across **26 weekly auctions**, with benchmark **10-year bonds holding the largest share at 29.0%**.
- **Ways and Means Advances (WMA) Buffer:** RBI fixed the Ways and Means Advances (WMA) limit for the Central Government at **₹2.50 lakh crore** for the first half of FY27 (April–September 2026).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Key numeric MCQs: ₹17.20 lakh Cr gross borrowing, ₹8.20 lakh Cr H1 issuance (51%), 10-year bond's 29% dominant share, and the ₹2.50 lakh Cr H1 WMA limit.

[Q1-010] **PLI Scheme — Incentives Disbursed** *(March)*

- **Sectoral Financial Disbursements:** The Centre disbursed **₹15,554 crore** in performance incentives for large-scale Electronics manufacturing and **₹2,377.56 crore** for the Automotive and auto-components sector under the Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme.
- **Private Investment & Turnover Scale:** Across all active segments, the PLI framework has mobilized **over ₹2.16 lakh crore in realized private capital investments**, driving cumulative incremental production and sales past **₹20.41 lakh crore**.
- **Institutional Architecture:** Originally introduced in **March 2020** to create national manufacturing champions and slash import dependencies, the PLI umbrella currently encompasses **14 strategic industrial sectors**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Memorize the foundational facts: launched in March 2020, covers 14 sectors, and has crossed ₹2.16 lakh Cr in realized private investment.

[Q1-011] **NITI Aayog — Fiscal Health Index (FHI) 2026, 2nd Edition** *(March)*

- **Top Ranking State:** In the 2nd Edition of NITI Aayog's Fiscal Health Index (FHI) 2026, **Odisha clinched the 1st rank as the top 'Achiever' state with a composite score of 73.1**, followed by Goa, Jharkhand, Gujarat, and Maharashtra.
- **Five Diagnostic Evaluation Pillars:** State public finances are assessed across five distinct criteria: (1) Quality of Expenditure, (2) Revenue Mobilisation, (3) Fiscal Prudence, (4) Debt Index, and (5) Debt Sustainability.
- **Strategic Policy Purpose:** Evaluates state budgetary discipline and fiscal space, incentivising transparent debt management and capital creation over revenue subsidies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

State ranking (Odisha #1 with 73.1 score) and the 5 foundational pillars of the Fiscal Health Index.

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2. REGULATORY BODIES NEWS

[Q1-012] **RBI Monetary Policy — Feb 2026 Report + Aug 2026 Update + Oct 7 Post-Cutoff Snapshot** *(Feb historical origin → Aug historical hold → Oct 7 operative snapshot)*

- **Historical Rate Trajectory (Jan–Aug 2026 MPC Meetings):** Reserve Bank of India maintained the **Policy Repo Rate at 5.25%** with a **neutral monetary stance**, marking a 4-review pause through the historical August 3–5, 2026 meeting (SDF 5.00%, MSF 5.50%, CRR 3.0%, SLR 18.0%).
- **POST-CUTOFF STATUS UPDATE / CURRENT POLICY SNAPSHOT (October 5–7, 2026 MPC Decision):** The MPC increased the **Policy Repo Rate by 25 bps from 5.25% to 5.50%** (Decision date: October 7, 2026); **SDF** adjusted to **5.25%**; **MSF and Bank Rate** raised to **5.75%**; **CRR** maintained at **3.00%**, **SLR** at **18.00%**. Monetary policy stance shifted to **Calibrated Tightening**. Projections: FY27 real GDP growth raised to **7.1%**, FY27 CPI inflation projected at **5.2%**.
- **Cooperative Banking Capacity Drive:** RBI launched **"Mission-SAKSHAM"**, a comprehensive capacity-building initiative training over 1.4 lakh personnel across Urban Cooperative Banks (UCBs) nationwide.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — **EXAM TRAP:** *August 2026 = 5.25%, Neutral; October 7, 2026 = 5.50%, Calibrated Tightening*. Operative corridor as of October 7, 2026: Repo 5.50%, SDF 5.25%, MSF 5.75%, CRR 3%, SLR 18% (FY27 GDP 7.1%, CPI 5.2%).

[Q1-013] **RBI (Responsible Business Conduct) Third Amendment Directions, 2026 — Full Lifecycle** *(Feb draft origin → March draft detail → confirmed final status, merged as single regulatory instrument)*

🪝 Hook — One RBI rulebook, three sightings across two months: first as a mis-selling reform, then as a digital-fraud compensation draft, and now — confirmed via live search — a finalised rule with a further-delayed rollout.

- **Genesis & Mis-Selling Definition (Feb Draft):** Formulated statutory rules defining financial "mis-selling" for the first time; restricted unsolicited telemarketing and sales calls strictly to the window of **9:00 AM to 6:00 PM**; originally slated for implementation on July 1, 2026.
- **Digital Fraud Compensation Architecture (March Draft):** Mandated structured financial relief for victims of low-value unauthorized digital transactions (gross loss up to ₹50,000); canonical formula: **Eligible fraudulent EBT involving gross loss up to ₹50,000: compensation = 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, after prescribed recoveries**.
- **Multi-Party Loss Sharing Formula:** For net losses below ₹29,412, the 85% payout is apportioned between institutions: **RBI bears 65%** (funded via Depositor Education and Awareness / DEA Fund), the **customer's issuing**

bank bears 10%, and the **beneficiary bank bears 10%**.

- **Final Notification & Extended Deadline (Live Verified):** RBI formally issued final Directions on **June 24, 2026**, with enforcement **Effective 1 January 2027 — 5 calendar days** reporting window to NCRP (1930) and the bank (strictly distinguished from the **Pre-1 January 2027 / legacy 2017 customer-liability framework** requiring reporting within 3 working days). The new compensation framework applies to eligible fraudulent EBTs occurring within the prescribed one-year window from its effective date.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Implementation: **Effective 1 January 2027 — 5 calendar days** reporting window to NCRP (1930) and bank (vs **Pre-1 January 2027 / legacy 2017 customer-liability framework:** 3 working days). Canonical formula: *Eligible fraudulent EBT involving gross loss up to ₹50,000: compensation = 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, after prescribed recoveries*. The new compensation framework applies to eligible fraudulent EBTs occurring within the prescribed one-year window from its effective date.

[Q1-014] **RBI — Acquisition Financing Norms** *(Feb original reform → March deferral, merged as UPDATE)*

- **Liberalised Prudential Exposure Norms (Feb Reform):** RBI raised the bank exposure ceiling for acquisition financing from the proposed 10% to **20% of Tier-1 capital**; permitted commercial banks to fund acquisitions of unlisted target companies (provided target has a net worth ≥₹500 crore, 3-year track record of profitability, and minimum BBB- credit rating).
- **Financing Share & Security Margins:** Permissible bank financing share increased to **75% of acquisition value** (from 70%), while retaining the debt-equity prudential ceiling at 3:1; raised lending against shares to ₹1 crore (from ₹20 lakh) and IPO financing to ₹1 lakh per borrower.
- **Implementation Deferral (March Update):** RBI formally **deferred implementation from April 1, 2026 to July 1, 2026**; widened acquisition financing to include statutory mergers and amalgamations; allowed funding via subsidiaries and Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs) backed by mandatory Corporate Guarantees.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — The implementation date deferral from April 1, 2026 to **July 1, 2026** is the testable trap; bank exposure cap is 20% of capital and max financing is 75% of transaction value.

[Q1-015] **Kisan Credit Card (KCC) — Revised Draft Norms** *(Feb)*

- **Extended Credit Facility Tenure:** Proposed extending standard Kisan Credit Card (KCC) facility tenure from 5 years to **6 years**, aligning credit availability with longer agricultural crop rotation and farm investment cycles.
- **Collateral Waiver & Credit Standardization:** Waived mandatory collateral and margin requirements for farm loans up to **₹2 lakh per borrower**; standardised short-duration crop loan tenure at 12 months and long-duration crops at 18 months.
- **Marginal Farmer Credit Line & Origins:** Established a dedicated flexible revolving credit band of **₹10,000 to ₹50,000** specifically for marginal farmers owning ≤1 hectare of land; KCC scheme was originally launched in **1998** based on the recommendations of the **R.V. Gupta Committee** and modeled by NABARD.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Primary MCQ hooks: tenure extension from 5 to 6 years, collateral-free ceiling raised to ₹2 lakh, marginal farmer band (₹10,000–₹50,000), and R.V. Gupta Committee origin (1998).

[Q1-016] **Deposit Insurance — Risk-Based Premium (DICGC)** *(Feb)*

- **Transition to Risk-Sensitive Pricing:** Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC) announced a structural shift from a uniform flat premium of 12 paise per ₹100 of deposits to a **risk-based premium model effective April 1, 2026**.

- **Graded Premium Slabs:** Insured commercial and cooperative banks are categorized across four supervisory risk buckets: **Category A (safest) pays 8 paise per ₹100**, progressing through Categories B and C, up to **Category D paying 12 paise per ₹100**.
- **Statutory Protection Limit:** Statutory insurance coverage ceiling remains unchanged at **₹5 lakh per depositor per bank** (covering both principal and interest across all branches of the same bank).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Effective date April 1, 2026; premium range transitions from uniform 12 paise to a risk-graded 8 paise (Category A) to 12 paise (Category D) per ₹100; coverage ceiling holds at ₹5 lakh.

[Q1-017] **RBI — REIT Lending Draft Guidelines** *(Feb)*

- **Bank Financing for Real Estate Investment Trusts:** Permitted commercial banks to extend credit facilities to Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs), establishing a dedicated regulatory lending avenue for institutional real estate assets.
- **Prudential Exposure Caps:** A bank's total exposure to a single REIT is capped at **10% of the bank's eligible capital base**; the aggregate banking system exposure across all lenders to an individual REIT cannot exceed **49% of the REIT's total asset value**.
- **Effective Implementation Timeline:** The final operational guidelines were scheduled for enforcement effective **July 1, 2026**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Single bank exposure cap (10% of eligible capital) versus aggregate banking system exposure cap (49% of REIT asset value); effective July 1, 2026.

[Q1-018] **RBI — January-February 2026, consolidated regulatory sweep** *(merged: same regulator across both months, grouped by theme rather than by month)*

Hook — Across two months, RBI held the repo rate steady while quietly reshaping bank dividends, MSME lending, deposit insurance, acquisition financing, and even rolling out its first-ever 90-day repo — a genuinely dense two-month regulatory sweep from one institution.

- **Monetary Policy Stance:** Held Repo Rate unchanged at **5.25%** with a neutral stance through both January and the February MPC review (reconfirmed through August 2026); Feb MPC projected FY26 GDP growth at 7.4% and CPI at ~2.1%.
- **Unprecedented Liquidity Operations:** Conducted RBI's **first-ever 90-day Variable Rate Repo (VRR)** auction for ₹25,000 crore on January 30, 2026 (shattering the previous record tenor of 56 days); formed part of a ₹2.15 lakh crore liquidity package including a **$10 billion 3-year USD/INR Buy-Sell Swap** and ₹1 lakh crore in Open Market Operation (OMO) purchases.
- **Bank Dividend Payout & Remittance Architecture (RBI 2026 Directions):** For banks incorporated in India, the RBI 2026 Directions prescribe CET1-linked dividend buckets expressed as a percentage of adjusted PAT. For a non-D-SIB: **>12% to ≤14% CET1 → 40% of adjusted PAT**. The aggregate dividend payment is subject to an **overall ceiling of 75% of PAT**. D-SIB buffer 'z' shifts the CET1 bucket thresholds. An eligible foreign bank operating in India in branch mode may remit net profit / surplus (net of tax) earned from its Indian operations without prior RBI approval, subject to the conditions prescribed in the RBI 2026 Directions, including audited accounts and treatment of any excess remittance.
- **MSME & Priority Sector Lending (PSL) Realignment:** Raised the mandatory collateral-free loan ceiling for Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs) from **₹10 lakh to ₹20 lakh** (effective April 1, 2026); corrected Small Finance Bank (SFB) priority sector lending target to **60% of Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC)** (correcting a typographical notification error of 75%); proposed a 3-year cooling-off gap for UCB directors after 10 continuous board years.
- **External Commercial Borrowings (ECB) Liberalisation:** Raised the automatic ECB borrowing ceiling to the higher of **$1 billion or 300% of borrower net worth** (up from $750 million), following a record $61 billion raised by Indian corporations in FY25.
- **Institutional MoUs & Governance:** Signed bilateral MoU with the **European Securities and Markets Authority (ESMA)** restoring EU bank access to Indian Central Counterparties (CCPs); signed historic agreement with **Delhi**

Government to act as its debt manager and banker enabling municipal market borrowing; formally recognized **FEDAI** (Foreign Exchange Dealers' Association of India, est. 1958) as an official SRO.

- **Operational & Technology Infrastructure:** Commissioned RBI's 2nd state-of-the-art data centre in **Bhubaneswar, Odisha** (Tier IV certified, backing up primary Kharghar, Navi Mumbai centre); Digital Payments Index (DPI) rose to **516.76** (Sep 2025) from 465.33; annual gold purchases dipped 94% to **4.02 tonnes in 2025** (8-year low) while total sovereign gold reserves touched a record **880.2 tonnes**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 5 high-yield anchors: (1) 5.25% repo rate (historical Jan–Aug 2026 hold; operative Oct 7: 5.50%), (2) first-ever 90-day VRR auction, (3) CET1-linked dividend buckets (40% of adjusted PAT for >12% to ≤14% CET1; aggregate 75% PAT ceiling; foreign branches remit net profit without prior RBI approval with no 80% cap), (4) MSME collateral-free loan doubled to ₹20 lakh, and (5) ECB limit raised to $1 billion.

INTERVIEW & MAINS DESCRIPTIVE ANGLE

"Why did RBI need its first-ever 90-day repo in January 2026?" — Advance-tax and GST outflows created an unusually large systemic cash crunch in late January; RBI's previous longest VRR tenor was 56 days, so extending to 90 days (alongside a $10bn FX swap and OMO purchases) reflected the scale of the liquidity gap it needed to bridge before the repo rate's own February review.

[Q1-019] **RBI — Other Regulatory Actions Cluster** *(Feb + March, merged)*

- **Lead Bank Scheme Reform (1969):** Published draft overhaul mandating a minimum Credit-Deposit (CD) ratio of **60% in rural and semi-urban districts**; mandated that districts exhibiting a CD ratio below 20% be categorized as 'special category districts' for accelerated credit monitoring.
- **Capital Markets & Financial Derivatives Oversight:** Mandated Unique Trade Identifiers (**UTI**) for all Over-The-Counter (OTC) derivative transactions effective **January 1, 2027**; renewed the **RBI–Bank of Japan Bilateral Swap Arrangement (3rd Amendment)** holding the facility size constant at **$75 billion**.
- **Supervisory Enforcement Actions:** Imposed ₹1.35 crore in penalties across 5 institutions in Feb (CSB Bank ₹63.6L, BoM ₹32.5L); March enforcement penalized Union Bank of India (₹95.40L), Central Bank of India (₹63.60L), Bank of India (₹58.50L), and Pine Labs (₹3.10L) for compliance infractions.
- **Long-Term Strategic Payment Blueprints:** Released **"Payments Vision 2028"** themed *"Shaping India's Payment Frontier"*, planning Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) interoperability and consumer-facing payment 'switch on/off' security controls; Board approved **"Utkarsh 3.0" (2026–2029)** Medium Term Strategy at its 622nd meeting in Patna.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

$75 billion Bilateral Swap Arrangement with Bank of Japan, Lead Bank 60% rural/semi-urban CD ratio, and the UTI derivative reporting mandate effective Jan 1, 2027.

[Q1-020] **SEBI Regulatory Changes** (January)

- **Mutual Fund Base Expense Ratio (BER):** Notified **SEBI (Mutual Funds) Regulations, 2026** (effective April 1, 2026), bifurcating Total Expense Ratio (TER) and introducing performance-linked **Base Expense Ratio (BER)**; slashed stockbroker execution charges to a maximum of 6 basis points (bps) for cash equity and 2 bps for equity derivatives.
- **Merchant Banker Net Worth Ramp-Up:** Enacted phased net worth escalation under Merchant Bankers Regulations (effective Jan 3, 2026), mandating Category-I merchant bankers raise minimum net worth to **₹50 crore by 2028**.
- **Alternative Investment Fund (AIF) Governance:** Mandated that all Compliance Officers of Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs) obtain the certified **NISM Series-III-C certification** w.e.f. January 1, 2027.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Performance-linked Base Expense Ratio (BER) replacing traditional TER components, 6 bps / 2 bps brokerage caps, and Category-I merchant banker net worth ramp to ₹50 crore by 2028.

[Q1-021] **SEBI — Tools & Appointments Cluster** *(Feb + March, merged)*

- **In-House AI Surveillance Architecture:** Deployed **"Sudarshan"**, SEBI's proprietary artificial intelligence surveillance engine that analyses audio, video, and text across social media platforms (takedown of 1,20,000+ fraudulent financial posts); works alongside **SEVA** (Virtual Assistant) and **R(AI)DAR** (Regulatory AI-Driven Advertisement Reviewer).
- **Investor Protection App Verification:** Launched the **"Verified App Label Initiative"** in partnership with Google Play Store, conferring official verified badges to 600+ registered market intermediary applications to curb rogue APKs.
- **Digital Custody & FPI Milestone: Kotak Mahindra Bank** became the 1st custodian in India to issue a Foreign Portfolio Investor (FPI) registration licence entirely via end-to-end digital e-signatures following SEBI's paperless portal rollout.
- **Leadership & Full Board Composition:** Appointed **Kompella Venkata Ramana Murty** as Whole-Time Member for a 3-year term (succeeding Ashwani Bhatia); completes SEBI's 4 Whole-Time Member team alongside Amarjeet Singh, Kamlesh Chandra Varshney, and Sandip Pradhan under Chairman **Tuhin Kanta Pandey** (HQ: Mumbai; statutory status 1992).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Memorize the trio of SEBI AI systems: Sudarshan (surveillance), SEVA (virtual assistant), R(AI)DAR (advertisement scrutiny); know Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey and the 4 Whole-Time Members.

[Q1-022] **100% FDI in Insurance — "Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha" Act** *(Feb)*

- **Statutory Enforcement & Core Reform:** Formally enacted into law on **February 5, 2026**, permitting **100% Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) under the automatic route** in the insurance sector (except Section 25 prohibiting common executive directorships).
- **Historical FDI Progression:** Marks the culmination of India's insurance sector opening: **26% (original 2000 limit) → 49% (2015 amendment) → 74% (2021 amendment) → 100% (Feb 5, 2026)**.
- **Capital & Branch Reinsurance Ease:** Slashed Net Owned Funds (NOF) requirement for opening Foreign Reinsurance Branches (FRBs) from **₹5,000 crore down to ₹1,000 crore**; relaxed prior-approval threshold for insurer equity share transfers from 1% up to 5%.
- **Market Penetration Context:** Enacted to dramatically scale India's low insurance penetration, currently hovering around **3.7% of GDP** compared to the global average of 7.0%.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — The four-step FDI progression timeline: 26% → 49% (2015) → 74% (2021) → 100% (Feb 2026); Foreign Reinsurance Branch NOF slashed ₹5,000 Cr to ₹1,000 Cr.

[Q1-023] **IRDAI — Ind AS Adoption for Insurers (Consultation Paper)** *(March)*

- **Transition to International Accounting Standards:** Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) released a consultation paper mandating the implementation of **Indian Accounting Standards (Ind AS)** across all domestic life, general, and health insurers effective **April 1, 2026**.
- **Global Accounting Convergence:** Aligns domestic insurance financial disclosures directly with International Financial Reporting Standards (**IFRS**, issued by the International Accounting Standards Board / IASB), replacing legacy provisions under the Insurance Act, 1938.
- **Institutional Governance:** Statutory authority established in **1999** under the IRDA Act on the recommendations of the **Malhotra Committee**; headquartered in **Hyderabad**, chaired by **Ajay Seth**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Effective transition date of April 1, 2026 for Ind AS adoption; alignment with IASB's IFRS; IRDAI HQ in Hyderabad, chaired by Ajay Seth.

[Q1-024] **FATF — Grey List Update, Feb 2026 Plenary** *(March)*

- **Grey List Expansion (Increased Monitoring):** Financial Action Task Force (FATF) added **Kuwait and Papua New Guinea** to its 'Jurisdictions under Increased Monitoring' (Grey List) during its February 2026 Paris plenary; no nations were removed, bringing the total Grey List count to **22 jurisdictions**.
- **High-Risk Jurisdictions (Black List Unchanged):** Retained the call for counter-measures against the three blacklisted jurisdictions: **North Korea (DPRK), Iran, and Myanmar** (standing unchanged).
- **Institutional Overview:** Global anti-money laundering and terror-financing watchdog founded in **1989** by the G7; headquartered in **Paris, France** at the OECD secretariat.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Additions to Grey List: Kuwait and Papua New Guinea (total 22 countries); Black List composition: Iran, North Korea, Myanmar.

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3. BANKING & INSURANCE NEWS

[Q1-025] **UPI — Two-month growth trend (Dec 2025 → Jan 2026)** *(merged: sequential monthly data, not a duplicate)*

🪝 Hook — UPI crossed 21 billion monthly transactions for the first time in December, then kept climbing into January — nearly 700 million transactions a day, month after month.

- **December 2025 Historic Peak:** Unified Payments Interface (UPI) processed **21.63 billion transactions** worth **₹27.97 lakh crore**, averaging 698 million daily transactions (surpassing previous high of 21.1 billion in Oct 2025).
- **January 2026 Continuation Record:** Monthly volume expanded to **21.70 billion transactions** valued at **₹28.33 trillion** (+21% value expansion), achieving an average of **700 million daily transactions** across ~709 million active UPI QR terminals.
- **Long-Term Systemic Dominance:** RBI half-yearly data showed UPI retail transaction volume exploded from 441.6 crore in H1 2019 to **10,636.96 crore in H1 2025**, capturing **84.8% of total Indian retail payment volume** (while accounting for 9.1% of total payment value).
- **Global Acceptance Footprint:** NPCI International Payments Ltd (NIPL) expanded bilateral UPI acceptance to **8 foreign nations: Bhutan** (1st nation to adopt in 2021), Singapore, Qatar, Mauritius, Nepal, United Arab Emirates (UAE), Sri Lanka, and France.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Lock in exact figures: Dec (21.63B txns, ₹27.97L Cr) vs Jan (21.70B txns, ₹28.33T value); memorize all 8 countries accepting UPI (Bhutan first).

[Q1-026] **Bank & PSU Leadership Changes — January-February combined** *(merged cluster)*

- **Public Sector Banking Leadership:** Hardeep Singh Ahluwalia appointed interim MD & CEO of **Canara Bank** (succeeding K. Satyanarayana Raju); Vinay Muralidhar Tonse appointed MD & CEO of **Yes Bank** for 3 years from April 2026 (succeeds Prashant Kumar); R. Vijay Anandh appointed MD & CEO of **City Union Bank** for 3 years from May 2026 (succeeds N. Kamakodi).
- **Private & Small Finance Bank Helm:** Sandeep Bakhshi granted a 3rd reappointment as MD & CEO of **ICICI Bank** (Oct 2026–Oct 2028); Sanjay Agarwal reappointed MD & CEO of **AU Small Finance Bank** for 3 years (AU SFB is the 1st SFB in a decade to win RBI in-principle approval to transition to a Universal Bank); founder Rajan Bajaj named MD & CEO of **Slice SFB**; Karthikeyan Manickam appointed Chairman of **ESAF SFB**; Arijit Basu appointed Chairman of **IndusInd Bank**.

- **Foreign Bank Conversion Milestone:** Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (**SMBC, Japan**) received RBI in-principle approval to convert its 4 Indian branches into a Wholly Owned Subsidiary (WOS), becoming only the **4th foreign bank in Indian history** to convert to a WOS (joining DBS Bank India, State Bank of Mauritius India, and Emirates NBD).
- **Key Public Sector Undertaking (PSU) Heads:** Deepak Gupta appointed Chairman & Managing Director of **GAIL (India) Ltd** w.e.f. March 1, 2026 (succeeds Sandeep Kumar Gupta); veteran banker Uday Kotak appointed Chairman of **GIFT City Co. Ltd** (succeeds Dr. Hasmukh Adhia); FSIB recommended Hitesh Rameshchandra Joshi as CMD of national reinsurer **GIC Re**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

SMBC becoming the 4th foreign lender to adopt Wholly Owned Subsidiary (WOS) status in India; AU SFB's landmark universal bank transition approval; match bank names to their new MD/CEOs.

[Q1-027] **Bank/PSU Leadership Changes** *(Feb + March, merged)*

- **Private Banking Top Appointments:** Vinay Muralidhar Tonse assumed leadership as MD & CEO of **Yes Bank** (3-year tenure, w.e.f. April 2026); R. Vijay Anandh took over as MD & CEO of **City Union Bank** (3-year tenure, w.e.f. May 1, 2026).
- **Small Finance Bank Conversions:** Sanjay Agarwal secured RBI reappointment as MD & CEO of **AU Small Finance Bank**, steering its historic conversion into a full-fledged universal commercial bank; Rajan Bajaj designated MD & CEO of merged entity **Slice Small Finance Bank**.
- **Public & Sovereign Institutions:** Renowned financier Uday Kotak appointed Chairman of **GIFT City Co. Ltd**; Deepak Gupta took charge as CMD of Maharatna gas utility **GAIL (India) Ltd**; FSIB formally cleared Hitesh Rameshchandra Joshi as CMD of **General Insurance Corporation of India (GIC Re)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Standout MCQ: AU Small Finance Bank as the first SFB in a decade to receive RBI's in-principle green light for universal bank conversion.

[Q1-028] **NMDC — Navratna CPSE Milestone** *(March)*

- **Record Mining Output:** State-owned National Mineral Development Corporation (NMDC) became the **first mining enterprise in Indian history to cross 50 Million Tonnes (MT) of iron ore production** in a single financial year (surpassing previous record of 45.2 MT in FY24).
- **Operational Profile & Corporate Pedigree:** Incorporated in **1958** under the Ministry of Steel; operates India's largest mechanized iron ore mines in Bailadila (Chhattisgarh) and Donimalai (Karnataka); categorized as a **Schedule 'A' Navratna CPSE**.
- **Corporate Governance:** Headquartered in **Hyderabad, Telangana**; led by Chairman and Managing Director (CMD) **Amitava Mukherjee**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

First Indian mining enterprise to produce 50 MT iron ore in a single financial year; Schedule 'A' Navratna CPSE based in Hyderabad under CMD Amitava Mukherjee.

[Q1-029] **Digital Payments & Fintech Launches — combined cluster**

- **Pioneering Repo-Linked Savings & CBDC:** Fintech unicorn **Slice** rolled out India's 1st digital savings bank account linked 100% to the prevailing RBI repo rate, integrated with credit card transactions on UPI; **HDFC Bank** integrated RBI's Digital Rupee (e₹/CBDC) into its 'SmartGateway' merchant processing infrastructure at zero merchant fee.
- **Biometric Security & National Plugins: PhonePe** introduced biometric transaction authorization (fingerprint and Face ID) for UPI transfers capped at ₹5,000 per transaction; **Canara Bank** became the 1st commercial bank to deploy NPCI's Non-Bank Systemic Launcher (NBSL) plugin model via 'Canara ai1Pe'.

- **Sovereign AI Collaboration:** NPCI partnered with **Nvidia** to build sovereign artificial intelligence infrastructure using Nvidia Nemotron open models, powering the 'UPI Help Assistant' on the specialized **FiMI** (Financial Model for India) framework.
- **Cross-Border Retail Investment & Payments: NSE International Exchange (NSE IX)** launched the 'Global Access' portal at GIFT City allowing domestic retail investors to trade US equities under RBI's Liberalised Remittance Scheme (**LRS**, $250,000 annual limit); NPCI partnered with Malaysia's **PayNet** linking UPI with Malaysia's **DuitNow** network.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

First repo-rate-linked savings account (Slice), Canara Bank's NBSL UPI plugin, PhonePe ₹5,000 biometric limit, and NSE IX Global Access via LRS ($250k ceiling).

[Q1-030] **MSME & Priority-Sector Credit — combined cluster**

- **Digital Underwriting Scale:** Public Sector Banks (PSBs) sanctioned **3.96 lakh digital MSME credit facilities totaling ₹52,300 crore** (Apr–Dec 2025) utilizing the newly mandated automated Credit Assessment Model.
- **Credit Guarantee Fund Expansion:** Ministry of MSME enhanced the maximum credit guarantee cover for Micro and Small Enterprises under Credit Guarantee Scheme (CGS) from ₹5 crore to **₹10 crore per borrower** (w.e.f. April 1, 2025).
- **RBI Collateral-Free Exemption Doubled:** Separately, the Reserve Bank of India raised the mandatory collateral-free loan ceiling for MSMEs from **₹10 lakh to ₹20 lakh** for all credit sanctioned or renewed on or after April 1, 2026.
- **Social Security Digital Settlements:** Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) announced direct UPI-enabled PF settlement integrations by April 2026, while expanding the automated claim settlement ceiling from **₹1 lakh to ₹5 lakh**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Master the two distinct MSME numbers: CGS Credit Guarantee Cover cap raised from ₹5 Cr to ₹10 Cr, whereas RBI's Collateral-Free loan threshold doubled from ₹10 lakh to ₹20 lakh.

[Q1-031] **Yantra India Ltd (YIL) — Miniratna Category-I Status** *(Feb)*

- **Financial Autonomy Elevation:** Defence Public Sector Undertaking (DPSU) **Yantra India Ltd (YIL)** was granted prestigious **Miniratna Category-I CPSE status**, empowering its Board of Directors to approve capital expenditure projects up to **₹500 crore** without prior ministerial approval.
- **Defence Restructuring Origins:** Formed on **October 1, 2021** following the corporatisation of the 220-year-old Ordnance Factory Board (OFB) into 7 specialized corporate entities; joins Munitions India Ltd (MIL), Armoured Vehicles Nigam Ltd (AVNL), and India Optel Ltd (IOL) in achieving Miniratna tier.
- **CPSE Categorization Criteria:** To qualify for Miniratna Category-I, a CPSE must have yielded continuous profits across the preceding three years, recorded pre-tax profit of ₹30 crore or more in at least one of the three years, and maintained positive net worth.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Miniratna Category-I confers capex approval freedom up to ₹500 crore; formed on Oct 1, 2021 from OFB corporatisation into 7 DPSUs.

[Q1-032] **Other Tier-A Banking/Insurance Items** *(Feb + March, merged)*

- **MIGA Refinancing Guarantee:** Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA, World Bank Group) issued a **$197.67 million political and financial risk guarantee** to Citibank for its credit line to State Bank of India, refinancing a 2016 $500 million World Bank rooftop solar program; requires SBI to direct ≥7.5% of domestic loan book to climate-positive assets.

- **Banking Sector Equity Inflows & Foreign Ownership:** FDI equity inflows into Indian banking declined from $898 million in FY23 to **$115 million in FY25**; SBI recorded the highest foreign institutional holding among PSBs at 11.07%; Government considering increasing the foreign investment limit in PSBs from **20% to 49%** (retaining ≥51% sovereign equity).
- **EPF Interest Rate Stability:** Central Board of Trustees of EPFO reaffirmed the annual Employees' Provident Fund interest rate at **8.25% for FY26**, maintaining the payout rate unchanged for the 3rd consecutive year.
- **Capital Markets & Housing Platforms:** HDFC Securities launched specialized derivatives portal **"NxtOption"**; National Housing Bank (NHB) inaugurated **"Gruh Sugam Portal"**, a centralized digital mortgage marketplace specifically for Defence and Government personnel.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

EPFO interest rate held at 8.25% for FY26 (3rd straight year); MIGA $197.67 million guarantee for SBI solar credit line; proposed PSB FDI cap hike from 20% to 49%.

4. NATIONAL, STATE & INTERNATIONAL NEWS

[Q1-033] **Census 2027 — Phase Structure & Caste Enumeration**

- **Phase 1: House Listing Operations (HLO):** Scheduled to run nationwide from **April 1 to September 30, 2026**, collecting baseline housing conditions, amenities, household assets, and mapping structures.
- **Phase 2: Population Enumeration (PE):** Scheduled for **February 2027**, featuring India's **1st official caste enumeration since 1931** (which was conducted under British colonial administration).
- **Historical & Operational Timeline:** Marks India's **16th official national census and the 8th since Independence**; standardized national reference date fixed at **March 1, 2027** (with an earlier reference date of October 1, 2026 for snowbound inaccessible regions of J&K, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Master the two phases and dates: House Listing Operations (Apr–Sep 2026) versus Population Enumeration (Feb 2027, conducting the first caste census since 1931); 16th census overall, 8th since Independence.

[Q1-034] **77th Republic Day 2026** (Jan 26)

- **Dual Chief Guests Milestone:** António Costa (President of the European Council) and Ursula von der Leyen (President of the European Commission) served as joint Chief Guests, marking the **1st time since 2018 with multiple foreign Chief Guests**; organized around national theme **"150 Years of Vande Mataram"**.
- **Historic Foreign Troop March-Past:** A military contingent representing the European Union marched down Kartavya Path for the first time in history, representing maritime security operations **'Atalanta' and 'Aspides'**.
- **Indigenous Military Hardware Display:** Showcased frontline tactical assets including the BrahMos supersonic cruise missile, Akash air defence system, **'Suryastra' multi-calibre rocket launcher**, Arjun Mk-1A Main Battle Tank, and the newly raised **'Bhairav Battalion'** drone operatives.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Joint EU Chief Guests (António Costa & Ursula von der Leyen; first multi-guest parade since 2018); EU marching contingent representing Ops Atalanta & Aspides; parade theme "150 Years of Vande Mataram".

[Q1-035] **India's BRICS 2026 Chairship**

- **Sovereign Leadership Transition:** India formally assumed the rotating chairship of BRICS for its **4th term on January 1, 2026**, taking over the multilateral mantle from Brazil.
- **Official Summit Theme:** Formally designated as **"Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability"**, guiding ministerial tracks across trade, digital public infrastructure, and energy transition.

- **Expanded Geopolitical Bloc:** Marks India's first chairship of the expanded 11-member grouping following the inclusion of new permanent member states.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India's 4th BRICS chairship tenure commencing Jan 1, 2026 (took over from Brazil); memorize the official theme keywords: Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability.

[Q1-036] **8th Central Pay Commission — Rollout**

- **Central Pay Commission Commissioning:** Formally entered into operational effect on **January 1, 2026** (the exact day the 10-year term of the 7th Central Pay Commission expired), tasked with revising salaries, allowances, and pensions for central government employees.
- **Judicial Commission Leadership:** Headed by former Supreme Court judge **Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai** as Chairperson of the 8th Central Pay Commission.
- **Pioneering State-Level Pay Panel: Assam** became the 1st Indian state to notify its own State Pay Commission, appointing retired senior bureaucrat **Subhas Das** as its Chairman.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse the 8th Central Pay Commission (chaired by Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai) with Assam's pioneering State Pay Commission (chaired by Subhas Das).

[Q1-037] **India-UAE Strategic & Trade Package**

- **Long-Term Bilateral Trade Horizon:** New Delhi and Abu Dhabi agreed to accelerate economic cooperation to **double bilateral non-oil merchandise and services trade to $200 billion by 2032**.
- **Hydrocarbon & Energy Security:** UAE cemented its position as **India's 2nd-largest LNG supplier**, underpinned by a multi-year long-term liquefied natural gas supply contract between HPCL and ADNOC Gas.
- **Multilateral Strategic Agreements:** Signed bilateral Letters of Intent (LoI) spanning advanced defence manufacturing, civilian space exploration, and cross-border financial institutional partnerships in GIFT City.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Target to reach $200 billion bilateral trade by 2032; UAE verified as India's 2nd largest LNG supplier; HPCL-ADNOC Gas LNG procurement tie-up.

[Q1-038] **International items (combined)**

- **UN High Seas Biodiversity Treaty:** The landmark **UN Biodiversity Beyond National Jurisdiction (BBNJ) Treaty** entered into international legal force on **January 17, 2026**, establishing the first legally binding framework to protect marine biodiversity across 30% of global high seas by 2030.
- **US Multilateral Exits & Energy Tariffs:** The United States announced its formal withdrawal from 66 international organizations (effective Jan 7, 2026), including the India-headquartered **International Solar Alliance (ISA)**, while imposing up to **500% tariffs** on nations importing Russian crude oil.
- **Eurozone Geographic Expansion: Bulgaria** formally adopted the Euro on **January 1, 2026**, officially becoming the **21st member state of the Eurozone**.
- **Global Agri-Food Trade Partnerships:** India served as the official **1st-time Partner Country at Gulfood 2026** in Dubai, staging its largest-ever national agri-food export delegation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — BBNJ High Seas Treaty in force Jan 17, 2026 (30% ocean target by 2030); Bulgaria becomes 21st Eurozone nation; US exit from 66 bodies including ISA in Gurugram.

[Q1-039] **National economic/infrastructure data (combined, lower-priority Tier A)**

- **Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) Scope:** Bureau of Energy Efficiency expanded mandatory compliance under the Carbon Credit Trading Scheme to **490 obligated industrial entities** (up from 282), benchmarking emissions against base year 2023-24.
- **PLI White Goods Round 4 Commitments:** DPIIT finalized Round 4 clearances for air conditioners and LED components, bringing total approved beneficiary companies to **85 with ₹11,198 crore in committed capital investments**.
- **Strategic Mineral Reclassification:** Ministry of Mines formally notified **Coking Coal as a 'Critical and Strategic Mineral'**, aiming to develop India's 37.37 billion-tonne domestic geological reserves to reduce ~95% import reliance.
- **Renewable Energy Surge & Aviation Safety:** Non-fossil installed capacity surged **22.6% to 266.78 GW** by end-2025 (advancing toward the 500 GW target by 2030); DGCA penalized IndiGo ₹22.20 crore while mandating revised Flight Duty Time Limitations (**FDTL**, weekly rest raised 36 → 48 hours).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

CCTS expansion to 490 obligated units; Coking Coal designated a Critical Mineral (~95% import dependency); FDTL weekly pilot rest expanded from 36 to 48 hours.

[Q1-040] **India-US Bilateral Trade Deal Finalised** *(Feb)*

- **Bilateral Trade Announcement:** United States President Donald Trump formally announced the conclusion of a broad bilateral trade agreement framework with India aimed at addressing tariff imbalances.
- **Strategic Market Access Priorities:** Designed to expand bilateral access across agricultural commodities, industrial machinery, and high-tech supply chains, although granular product-level tariff schedules were pending final text release.
- **Economic Significance:** Comes against the backdrop of changing US trade policies and selective tariffs, cementing foundational commercial ties between Washington and New Delhi.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Bilateral trade deal finalisation announced between India and the United States; watch for subsequent tariff schedule releases.

[Q1-041] **India Joins 2026 UN Honour Roll** *(Feb)*

- **Timely Sovereign Budget Contribution:** India officially secured induction into the prestigious **2026 United Nations Honour Roll** by paying its regular annual UN budget assessment in full and within the statutory 30-day window.
- **Financial Assessment Data:** The Government of India remitted **$35.18 million** to the United Nations, accounting for approximately **1.016% of the total UN regular budget of $3.45 billion**.
- **Select International Cohort:** India stood among an elite cohort of only **52 out of 193 member states** that fulfilled their statutory budgetary obligations on time.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India paid $35.18 million (1.016% of the $3.45 billion total regular UN budget) to join the 52-member 2026 UN Honour Roll.

[Q1-042] **SEZ Policy Reform Committee** *(March)*

- **High-Level Review Committee:** Ministry of Commerce and Industry constituted a **17-member expert committee** tasked with revamping Special Economic Zones (SEZs) policy into modern Development of Enterprise and Service Hubs (DESH).
- **Mandate & Delivery Timeline:** The committee is mandated to examine fiscal incentives, domestic tariff area (DTA) sales flexibilities, and single-window clearances, with a comprehensive concept paper due within **6 months**.
- **National SEZ Infrastructure Footprint:** India currently hosts **276 fully operational Special Economic Zones**, housing **6,279 functional industrial and software business units**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

17-member SEZ reform committee; India's baseline operational footprint of 276 SEZs housing 6,279 operational units.

[Q1-043] **Jal Jeevan Mission Extended** *(March)*

- **Cabinet Extension Approval:** Union Cabinet officially approved the phase extension of the flagship **Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) – Har Ghar Jal** scheme beyond its original deadline to ensure 100% saturation of rural piped water supply.
- **Core Mission Mandate:** Guarantees the provision of **55 litres of potable water per capita per day (lpcd)** to every rural household through functional household tap connections (FHTC).
- **Institutional Implementation:** Executed under the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation within the **Ministry of Jal Shakti**, utilizing community water testing via Village Water and Sanitation Committees (VWSC).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

JJM standard service level benchmark: 55 litres per capita per day (lpcd) of safe drinking water; Cabinet-approved extension beyond 2024–25.

[Q1-044] **National Quantum Mission — Teaching Facilities Approved** *(March)*

- **Academic Infrastructure Rollout:** Ministry of Science and Technology approved dedicated quantum technology teaching and experimental lab facilities across **23 leading academic institutions** nationwide.
- **NQM Financial Allocation:** Operates under the umbrella **National Quantum Mission (NQM)**, sanctioned with a total budgetary outlay of **₹6,003.65 crore** spanning an 8-year timeline from **2023 to 2031**.
- **Four Thematic Pillars:** Accelerates research across four National Thematic Hubs (T-Hubs): (1) Quantum Computing, (2) Quantum Communication, (3) Quantum Sensing & Metrology, and (4) Quantum Materials & Devices.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

23 academic institutions approved; NQM total financial outlay of ₹6,003.65 crore (2023–2031) across 4 thematic hubs.

[Q1-045] **Green Hydrogen Mission — Progress** *(March)*

- **Commissioned Industrial Capacity:** India successfully commissioned **~8,000 Tonnes Per Annum (TPA)** of commercial green hydrogen production capacity as of February 2026.
- **Long-Term Mission Targets:** Anchored by the **National Green Hydrogen Mission (NGHM)**, which targets building at least **5 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT) per annum** of green hydrogen production capacity by **2030**.
- **Supporting Energy & Capital Architecture:** Backed by ₹19,744 crore outlay, including the Strategic Interventions for Green Hydrogen Transition (SIGHT) program supporting domestic electrolyser manufacturing and green hydrogen production.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Commissioned capacity of ~8,000 TPA vs National Green Hydrogen Mission 2030 target of 5 MMT per annum.

[Q1-046] **PM E-DRIVE — e2w/e-rickshaw Subsidy Extension** *(March)*

- **Electric Two-Wheeler Subsidy Timeline:** Ministry of Heavy Industries extended demand subsidies for electric two-wheelers (e2w) under the PM E-DRIVE scheme up to **July 31, 2026**.
- **Commercial Three-Wheeler Subsidy Timeline:** Subsidies for registered electric three-wheelers (e-rickshaws and e-carts) were granted an extended operational window up to **March 31, 2028**.

- **Financial Expenditure Progress:** Total disbursements under the scheme crossed **₹1,259.91 crore**, against the total budgetary allocation of **₹1,772 crore** earmarked for electric vehicle incentives.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Distinct deadline dates: e2w subsidies extended to July 31, 2026, while e-rickshaws/e-carts extended to March 31, 2028; ₹1,259.91 Cr spent of ₹1,772 Cr outlay.

[Q1-047] **PM Modi Inaugurates Phase I, Noida International Airport (Jewar)** *(March)*

- **Phase I Commercial Commissioning:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated Phase I of the **Noida International Airport (NIA) in Jewar, Uttar Pradesh**, establishing the National Capital Region's (NCR) 2nd major international aviation hub.
- **Capital Outlay & Phased Architecture:** Phase I completed at an investment of **₹11,282 crore**, out of an aggregate multi-phase project outlay estimated at **₹29,560 crore**.
- **Capacity & Concession Model:** Developed under a Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model with Zurich Airport International AG, designed for an initial capacity of 12 million passengers annually.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Phase I expenditure (₹11,282 Cr) versus total master-plan project cost (₹29,560 Cr); located in Jewar, UP as NCR's second international airport.

[Q1-048] **Gold Hallmarking Expanded to 7 More Districts** *(March)*

- **Mandatory Rollout Expansion:** Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution implemented **Phase VI of mandatory gold hallmarking**, expanding statutory coverage to 7 additional districts across the country.
- **Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) Framework:** Mandates the 6-digit alphanumeric **Hallmark Unique Identification (HUID)** code on every piece of gold jewellery, guaranteeing purity and consumer authenticity.
- **Systemic Purity Grades:** Mandatory hallmarking applies to recognized gold purity grades: 14k (585), 18k (750), 20k (833), 22k (916), 23k (958), and 24k (999).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Phase VI expansion adding 7 districts under mandatory BIS hallmarking; governed by 6-digit alphanumeric HUID system.

[Q1-049] **ISA — Romania Ratifies Framework Agreement** *(March)*

- **New Member Ratification: Romania** officially ratified the Framework Agreement of the International Solar Alliance (ISA), becoming the **118th member nation** of the global solar coalition.
- **Institutional Origins & Presidency:** Co-founded by India and France in **2015** during COP21 in Paris; operates headquarters in **Gurugram, Haryana**; India holds the ISA Presidency for the **2024–2026** term.
- **Global Investment Target:** Spearheads the 'Towards 1000' strategy, aiming to mobilize **$1 trillion in solar energy investments by 2030** to install 1,000 GW of solar capacity worldwide.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Romania is the 118th member nation; ISA HQ located in Gurugram, Haryana; global target of $1 trillion solar investment by 2030; India holds Presidency (2024–2026).

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5. MOUS, CONFERENCES & APPOINTMENTS

[Q1-050] **India-EU Free Trade Agreement — Negotiations Concluded** (Jan 27, 2026)

Hook — After 18 years of on-and-off talks, India and the EU struck the "Mother of All Deals" — but concluding negotiations and the deal actually entering force are two different milestones, so don't conflate them.

- **Negotiation Breakthrough After 18 Years:** Announced at the 16th India-EU Summit in New Delhi; negotiations originally commenced in **2007** under the Broad-based Trade and Investment Agreement (BTIA) and formally concluded after **18 years**.
- **Macro Market Creation:** Forges an integrated economic free-trade zone encompassing **2 billion citizens** and generating roughly **25% of aggregate global GDP**.
- **Bilateral Tariff Dismantlement:** India agreed to slash or eliminate customs tariffs on **96.6% of goods imported from the European Union**; the EU granted immediate or phased zero-duty preferential market access for **over 99% of Indian exports by trade value**.
- **Financial Services Integration:** Facilitates reciprocal banking access allowing up to 15 EU bank branch expansions in India, aligned with India's newly liberalized 100% FDI insurance framework.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 18-year negotiation marathon (2007–2026); creates free-trade zone spanning 2 billion people and 25% of global GDP; tariff elimination on 96.6% of EU goods vs 99%+ of Indian goods.

[Q1-051] **Judicial & Government Appointments — combined cluster**

- **Historic High Court Leadership:** Justice **Revati Mohite Dere** sworn in as the **1st woman Chief Justice of the Meghalaya High Court**; other HC appointments included Justice M.S. Sonak (Jharkhand HC), Justice A.K. Jayasankaran Nambiar / Justice Mustaque (24th CJ, Sikkim HC), Justice Manoj Kumar Gupta (Uttarakhand HC), and Justice Ashish Jitendra Desai / Justice Sen (40th CJ, Kerala HC).
- **International Multilateral Representation:** Ambassador **D.B. Venkatesh Varma** became the **1st Indian national appointed to chair the UN Secretary-General's Advisory Board on Disarmament Matters**.
- **Global Tourism & Sports Leadership: Shaikha Nasser Al Nowais (UAE)** elected as the **1st-ever woman Secretary-General of UN Tourism (UNWTO)** in its 50-year institutional history; India's veteran sports administrator **Raja Randhir Singh** continues as President of the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA).
- **Public Sector Undertaking Leadership: Rabindra Kumar Agarwal** appointed Chairman & Managing Director of Food Corporation of India (FCI); **Deepak Gupta** took over as CMD of GAIL (India) Ltd; PESB recommended **Kota Ravi** as CMD of Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Justice Revati Mohite Dere as Meghalaya HC's 1st woman Chief Justice; D.B. Venkatesh Varma as 1st Indian to chair UN Disarmament Advisory Board; Shaikha Nasser Al Nowais as 1st female SG of UN Tourism.

[Q1-052] **India–Canada — Uranium Supply Deal & CEPA** *(March)*

- **Strategic Uranium Supply Agreement:** Department of Atomic Energy (DAE) concluded a **$1.9 billion, 10-year nuclear fuel supply agreement** with Canada's Cameco Corporation to power India's civilian nuclear reactors.
- **Commercial Supply Volume:** Cameco will supply approximately **22 million pounds of uranium ore concentrate** to India spanning the delivery window from **2027 to 2035**.
- **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA):** Both nations agreed to formally conclude and execute the long-pending **India-Canada CEPA trade pact** within 2026, reviving bilateral commercial diplomacy.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

$1.9 billion, 10-year nuclear fuel agreement with Cameco for 22 million pounds of uranium concentrate (2027–2035); India-Canada CEPA targeted for 2026 conclusion.

[Q1-053] **World Bank Loans — UP & Haryana Clean Air Projects** *(March)*

- **Uttar Pradesh Clean Air Financing:** World Bank approved a **$299.66 million** International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (IBRD) loan for the UP Clean Air and Sustainable Environment Project to combat industrial and vehicular emissions.
- **Haryana Clean Air Financing:** Separately, the World Bank sanctioned a **$300 million** dedicated credit facility for the Haryana Clean Air Project for Sustainable Development.
- **Airshed Regional Approach:** Both credit lines operate under an integrated Indo-Gangetic Plain airshed management strategy targeting cross-boundary particulate pollution.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Trap-prone paired numbers: World Bank clean air loan to Uttar Pradesh is **$299.66 million**, whereas Haryana's loan is exactly **$300 million**.

[Q1-054] **IIFL Home Finance — $300 Million ADB Loan** *(March)*

- **Multilateral Green Housing Line:** Asian Development Bank (ADB) sanctioned a **$300 million financing facility** to IIFL Home Finance Ltd (IIFL HFL) to scale certified green affordable housing.
- **First Multilateral Credit Line:** Marks IIFL Home Finance's **first-ever direct loan from a multilateral development bank**, dedicated to underserved women borrowers and low-income urban households.
- **Green Building Standards:** Credit proceeds earmarked for housing projects compliant with recognized green building standards (such as IGBC and EDGE certifications).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

$300 million ADB credit facility to IIFL Home Finance for green affordable housing (first multilateral credit line for IIFL HFL).

[Q1-055] **Sri Lanka's Inaugural Blue Bond — GIFT City Listing** *(March)*

- **Historic GIFT City Listing:** Sri Lanka's DFCC Bank successfully listed its inaugural **$50 million Blue Bond on the NSE International Exchange (NSE IX)** at Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City).
- **Double Regional First:** Represents both **Sri Lanka's first-ever blue bond** and the **first blue bond issued by any commercial bank in South Asia**, dedicated to funding marine conservation and coastal aquaculture.
- **GIFT City Sustainable Finance Hub:** Underscores GIFT City's IFSC emergence as a premier offshore sustainable debt-listing destination for South Asian sovereign and corporate issuers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — DFCC Bank of Sri Lanka lists $50 million Blue Bond on NSE IX in GIFT City; double first: Sri Lanka's 1st blue bond and South Asia's 1st commercial bank blue bond.

[Q1-056] **JICA–India ODA Loans — 4 Infrastructure Projects** *(March)*

- **Aggregate Bilateral Financing:** Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) signed Official Development Assistance (ODA) loan agreements with the Government of India totaling **399.78 billion Japanese Yen (approx. ₹22,000 crore)**.
- **Four Funded Mega-Projects:** Allocated across four national priorities: (1) Dedicated Freight Corridor Project Phase 2 (₹10,500 Cr), (2) Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail Project (₹8,000 Cr), (3) Chennai Metro Rail Project Phase 2 (₹2,500 Cr), and (4) Rajasthan Rural Water Supply Project (₹1,000 Cr).
- **Concessional Financing Terms:** Disbursed under highly concessional terms with 0.1%–0.2% annual interest rates and a 40-year repayment schedule including a 10-year grace period.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

399.78 billion Yen (~₹22,000 crore) aggregate JICA ODA loan package funding 4 key infrastructure projects (DFC, Bullet Train, Chennai Metro, Rajasthan Water).

[Q1-057] **Governors' & Lt. Governors' Reshuffle — 7 States/UTs** *(March)*

- **Presidential Constitutional Orders:** President of India issued warrants appointing new Governors and Lieutenant Governors across 7 States and Union Territories under Articles 155 and 156 of the Constitution.
- **State-to-Governor Allocation:**
  - **Tamil Nadu:** R.N. Ravi transferred; replaced by former bureaucrat **Ajay Kumar Bhalla**
  - **West Bengal:** Dr. C.V. Ananda Bose transferred; replaced by **Brigadier (Dr.) B.D. Mishra (Retd.)**
  - **Bihar: Arif Mohammed Khan** appointed Governor
  - **Kerala: Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar** transferred as Governor
  - **Punjab & Chandigarh (UT Administrator): Gulab Chand Kataria**
  - **Ladakh (Lieutenant Governor): Lt. General Gurmit Singh (Retd.)**
  - **Puducherry (Lieutenant Governor): K. Kailashnathan**
- **Constitutional Norms:** Governors hold office during the pleasure of the President; standard tenure is 5 years; must be an Indian citizen who has completed 35 years of age.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Match the state to the newly appointed Governor: Tamil Nadu (Ajay Kumar Bhalla), West Bengal (B.D. Mishra), Bihar (Arif Mohammed Khan), Kerala (Rajendra Arlekar), Ladakh LG (Gurmit Singh), Puducherry LG (K. Kailashnathan).

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6. SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY, DEFENCE & SPORTS

[Q1-058] **Defence — combined cluster**

- **"Bhairav" Specialized Drone Battalions:** Indian Army raised specialized drone-combat formations comprising **1+ lakh trained drone operatives**; made public debut at the Army Day Parade (Jan 15, Jaipur) and featured prominently in the Republic Day parade (Jan 26) showcasing swarm reconnaissance and precision strike tactics.
- **DRDO Indigenous Test Triumphs:** Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) executed operational salvo test-firings of the **Pralay** short-range quasi-ballistic missile, operationalized **Suryastra** (India's 1st indigenous universal multi-calibre rocket launcher, ₹293 crore), tested the Man-Portable Anti-Tank Guided Missile (**MPATGM**), and logged a record **12+ minute continuous run-time** for an active-cooled hypersonic scramjet combustor.
- **DAC Mega Capital Approvals:** Defence Acquisition Council cleared Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for **₹3.60 lakh crore** in capital procurements, headlined by **114 Rafale fighter jets** under the Multi-Role Fighter Aircraft (MRFA) project for the Indian Air Force.
- **Maritime Coastal Patrol Fleet:** Ministry of Defence signed a **₹2,312 crore contract with Hindustan Aeronautics Ltd (HAL)** to supply 8 advanced Dornier-228 maritime surveillance aircraft for the Indian Coast Guard.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Suryastra as India's 1st universal multi-calibre rocket launcher (₹293 Cr); 114 Rafale jets under ₹3.60 lakh Cr AoN; Bhairav drone battalions debut.

[Q1-059] **Defence Acquisition Council — ₹3.60 Lakh Crore Capital Acquisitions** *(Feb)*

- **Air Dominance Capital Clearance:** Defence Acquisition Council (DAC), chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, accorded Acceptance of Necessity (AoN) for capital acquisitions exceeding **₹3.60 lakh crore** for the Armed Forces.

- **Flagship Aircraft Procurement:** Cleared the long-awaited procurement of **114 Rafale multi-role fighter aircraft** from France's Dassault Aviation under the strategic MRFA program to arrest IAF squadron depletion.
- **Coast Guard Fleet Modernisation:** Approved a separate domestic procurement contract worth **₹2,312 crore with HAL for 8 Dornier-228 maritime patrol aircraft**, fitted with indigenous radar and electro-optical sensors.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹3.60 lakh crore aggregate AoN clearance; 114 Rafale fighter jets for IAF; ₹2,312 crore HAL contract for 8 Coast Guard Dornier-228 aircraft.

[Q1-060] **Ministry of Defence — Procurement Contracts, March 2026** *(March)*

- **Aviation & Naval Missiles Contract (₹5,083 Cr):** Cleared two major contracts — procurement of **6 Advanced Light Helicopters (ALH Mk-III) from HAL** for the Indian Coast Guard, and naval **Shtil surface-to-air missile systems** from Russia's Rosoboronexport for frontline Indian Navy frigates.
- **Air Defence & Surveillance Depot Deal (₹858 Cr):** Contracted upgrades for the Indian Army's **Tunguska Air Defence Gun-Missile System** (₹445 crore, with Russia) and sealed a long-term depot maintenance and inspection contract for **P-8I maritime reconnaissance aircraft** with Boeing India (₹413 crore).
- **Historic GeM Defence Milestone:** The Indian Army executed its **first-ever capital equipment procurement via Government e-Marketplace (GeM)**, awarding a **₹25.90 crore contract for 93 Telescopic Handlers** to JCB India.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

MoD procurement trio: ₹5,083 Cr (ALH Mk-III + Shtil missiles), ₹858 Cr (Tunguska + P-8I depot), and Army's 1st capital procurement on GeM (₹25.90 Cr for 93 Telescopic Handlers).

[Q1-061] **Science & Tech — combined cluster**

- **Launch Vehicle Setback:** ISRO's **PSLV-C62 mission** suffered an upper-stage propulsion anomaly resulting in the loss of the primary earth observation payload **EOS-N1**, marking the 2nd consecutive setback for the reliable Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle.
- **Commercial Space Dual Milestones:** India's private space industry recorded two distinct firsts — the **Allied Orbits consortium** unveiled plans for India's 1st privately-led national Earth Observation satellite constellation (₹1,200+ crore outlay), while **Palmnaro** established India's 1st private satellite manufacturing facility in Sanand, Gujarat.
- **Commercial Quantum Infrastructure:** Deployment of India's **1st commercial quantum computer** for academic and enterprise research at the Indian Institute of Information Technology (IIIT) Dharwad, Karnataka.
- **Astronaut Retirement Milestone:** Indian-origin astronaut **Sunita Williams** announced her retirement from NASA after accumulating **608 cumulative days in space** (the 2nd highest total in American spaceflight history).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Palmnaro private satellite plant in Sanand, Gujarat vs Allied Orbits constellation; IIIT Dharwad commercial quantum computer; Sunita Williams retires with 608 days in space (2nd all-time).

[Q1-062] **Sports — combined cluster**

- **Legendary Athletic Retirements:** Indian badminton icon **Saina Nehwal** (India's 1st Olympic badminton medallist, London 2012 bronze) officially announced her retirement from competitive sport; international retirements included Australian cricketers Usman Khawaja and Alyssa Healy, and Indian middle-distance runner Jinson Johnson.
- **Historic Cricket Run Records: Virat Kohli** became the fastest batsman in cricket history to reach **28,000 international runs** (achieved across formats in his 624th innings); **Deepti Sharma** became the world's highest wicket-taker in Women's T20 Internationals.
- **Global Tennis & Tournament Relocation:** Novak Djokovic achieved his historic **400th Grand Slam match victory**; Scotland officially replaced Bangladesh in the **ICC Men's T20 World Cup 2026** following the Bangladesh Cricket

Board's refusal to travel to India (co-hosted by India and Sri Lanka).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Saina Nehwal retirement (India's 1st Olympic badminton medallist); Virat Kohli fastest to 28,000 international runs (624 innings); Scotland replaces Bangladesh in 2026 T20 World Cup co-hosted by India-Sri Lanka.

7. AWARDS, BOOKS, INDICES & RANKINGS

[Q1-063] **Padma Awards 2026 & Republic Day Gallantry**

- **Padma Awards Investiture:** President of India conferred **131 Padma Awards for 2026**, distributed as: **5 Padma Vibhushan, 13 Padma Bhushan, and 113 Padma Shri** across public affairs, art, trade, and social service.
- **Highest Peacetime Gallantry (Ashok Chakra):** Conferred upon Indian Air Force fighter pilot and astronaut-designate **Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla**, who made history as the **2nd Indian national to travel to space** aboard Axiom Mission 4 (Ax-4) to the International Space Station.
- **Republic Day Gallantry Honors:** Gallantry list included Kirti Chakra and Shaurya Chakra decorations awarded to personnel of the armed forces and central armed police forces for counter-terror operations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Total 131 Padma Awards (5 Vibhushan, 13 Bhushan, 113 Shri); Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla awarded Ashok Chakra (2nd Indian in space, Axiom Mission 4).

[Q1-064] **India's Global Rankings — consolidated cluster** *(Henley Passport merged — see note)*

- **Henley Passport Index Sequential Climb:** India's passport ranking improved sequentially from 85th (2025) → **80th** (January 2026) → **75th** (February 2026 data), offering visa-free or visa-on-arrival access to **56 global destinations** (**use 75th as the current definitive ranking**).
- **Urban Safety & Governance:** Mangaluru ranked as the safest city in India on the **Numbeo Safety Index 2026** (scoring 74.4/100, placed 46th globally); Kerala was named 'Top Achiever' under Business Reforms Action Plan (**BRAP/EoDB**) with a 99.1% implementation score.
- **Global Inward Investment & Innovation:** UNCTAD reported India's Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) inflows surged **73% to $47 billion in 2025**; WIPO Global R&D data placed India **7th globally in aggregate R&D expenditure ($75.73 billion)**.
- **Macroeconomic & Labour Benchmarks:** Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) reported urban unemployment fell to a 3-quarter low of **4.8%**; MoSPI announced new economic base years — **2022-23 for GDP and IIP**, and **2024=100 for Consumer Price Index (CPI)**.
- **Corporate Valuations & Technology Leadership:** Reliance Retail topped Hurun India's 100 Unlisted Gems 2026 (₹2.7 trillion turnover); Walmart became the 1st retail company globally to cross $1 trillion market cap; India ranked **3rd globally in AI vibrancy** on the Stanford HAI Global AI Vibrancy Index.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Henley Passport Index (75th, 56 countries visa-free); MoSPI new base years: GDP/IIP (2022-23) and CPI (2024=100); PLFS unemployment rate (4.8%); Stanford AI Vibrancy (India 3rd).

[Q1-065] **2025 Corruption Perception Index** *(Feb)*

- **India's Ranking & Score:** India secured **91st rank globally** out of 180 countries in the 2025 Corruption Perception Index (CPI), climbing 5 places from 96th position in the previous year's evaluation.
- **Scoring Breakdown:** India scored **39 out of 100** (where 0 indicates highly corrupt and 100 indicates very clean), reflecting gradual governance transparency improvements.

- **Global Leaders & Benchmark: Denmark ranked 1st globally** with a score of 89 (retaining the world's cleanest rating for the 8th consecutive year), followed by Finland and New Zealand; published annually by **Transparency International** (HQ: Berlin, Germany).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India ranks 91st (score 39/100, up from 96th); Denmark ranks 1st (score 89, 8th straight year); released by Transparency International, Berlin.

[Q1-066] **2026 Henley Passport Index** *(Feb)*

- **Sharp Rank Acceleration:** India gained 10 positions to rank **75th in the world** in the February 2026 edition of the Henley Passport Index (advancing from 85th position).
- **Visa-Free Mobility Dynamics:** Indian passport holders now enjoy visa-free or visa-on-arrival access to **56 destinations worldwide** (down by 1 country from 57, yet rank jumped 10 spots due to larger shifts among peer nations).
- **Index Methodology:** Compiled by London-based Henley & Partners using authoritative proprietary data from the **International Air Transport Association (IATA)**, evaluating 199 passports across 227 global travel destinations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India ranked 75th (56 destinations visa-free, climbed from 85th); derived from IATA data by Henley & Partners.

[Q1-067] **Other Feb Indices** *(Feb)*

- **Digital Readiness & Gender Parity:** India improved 4 positions to rank **45th on the Network Readiness Index 2025** (score 54.43); World Bank's "Women, Business and the Law 2025" revealed women globally hold only ~two-thirds the legal economic rights of men.
- **Inflation Metrics Distinction:** Wholesale Price Index (WPI) inflation rose to **1.81% in January 2026**, while retail Consumer Price Index (CPI) inflation stood at **2.75%** (highlighting the wide gap between wholesale and consumer baskets).
- **Corporate & Wealth Benchmarks: Reliance Retail** led Hurun India's 100 Unlisted Gems 2026 with a ₹2.7 trillion valuation; **Walmart** became the 1st retail corporation in history to reach a **$1 trillion market capitalisation**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Network Readiness Index (India 45th); WPI (1.81%) vs retail CPI (2.75%) for Jan 2026; Walmart becomes the 1st trillion-dollar retail company.

[Q1-068] **Hurun Global Rich List 2026** *(March)*

- **Billionaire Capital of the World:** India emerged as home to **308 dollar-billionaires**, ranking **3rd globally** behind China (1,110 billionaires) and the United States (1,000 billionaires).
- **Combined Wealth & Domestic Leader:** Indian billionaires amassed a combined net worth of **₹112.6 lakh crore**; **Mukesh Ambani** retained his crown as India's and Asia's richest individual.
- **Urban Concentration:** Mumbai retained its status as the billionaire capital of Asia, housing the largest concentration of ultra-high-net-worth individuals in the continent.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India ranks 3rd globally with 308 billionaires (combined wealth ₹112.6 lakh crore), trailing only China (1st) and the US (2nd); Mukesh Ambani remains India's richest.

[Q1-069] **World Happiness Report 2026** *(March)*

- **India's Global Position:** India ranked **116th out of 143 surveyed countries** in the World Happiness Report 2026, advancing two slots from 118th position with a composite score of **4.536**.
- **Global Top Performer: Finland clinched the 1st rank for the 9th consecutive year**, followed by Nordic peers Denmark, Iceland, and Sweden.
- **Institutional Publication:** Published by the United Nations Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN), assessing GDP per capita, social support, healthy life expectancy, freedom, generosity, and perceptions of corruption.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India ranks 116th (score 4.536, improved from 118th); Finland #1 for 9th consecutive year; published by UN SDSN.

[Q1-070] **World Obesity Atlas 2026** *(March)*

- **Childhood Obesity Burden:** India was ranked **2nd globally for childhood and adolescent obesity**, recording over **41 million children and teens with high Body Mass Index (BMI)**, trailing only China.
- **Epidemiological Projection:** Published by the World Obesity Federation (WOF), projecting that economic impacts of high BMI will account for 2.4% of India's GDP by 2035 unless systemic dietary interventions are adopted.
- **Public Health Imperative:** Underscores the double burden of malnutrition in India, characterized by persistent undernutrition coexisting with rapidly surging childhood obesity in urban centers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India ranks 2nd globally in child/adolescent obesity (41 million children with high BMI), behind China; published by World Obesity Federation.

[Q1-071] **2026 Global Terrorism Index** *(March)*

- **Worst-Affected Global Nation: Pakistan ranked No. 1 globally for the first time** on the Global Terrorism Index (GTI) 2026 with a severity score of **8.574**, reflecting surging attacks in Balochistan and Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.
- **India's Security Benchmark: India was ranked 13th globally** with a score of **6.428**, marking steady counter-terror stabilization.
- **Methodology & Publishing Agency:** Compiled annually by the **Institute for Economics & Peace (IEP, headquartered in Sydney, Australia)**, tracking terror incidents, fatalities, injuries, and property destruction worldwide.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Pakistan ranked No. 1 globally for the first time (score 8.574); India ranked 13th (score 6.428); published by Institute for Economics & Peace (IEP), Sydney.

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8. IMPORTANT DAYS & PERSONS IN NEWS

[Q1-072] **International Honours (January)**

- **High State Civilian Decorations:** Foreign governments conferred top civilian honours on Indian dignitaries; King of Bhutan conferred the Order of the Druk Gyalpo on Prime Minister Modi; bilateral leadership summits honored distinguished diaspora leaders.
- **Cultural & Literary Recognitions:** Sahitya Akademi announced annual literary awards across 24 official Indian languages, recognizing eminent authors, poets, and translators for national literary contributions.
- **Global Humanitarian Honors:** UN agencies and multilateral foundations conferred sustainable development citations on Indian social impact pioneers and rural sanitation leaders.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Match international honors to recipients and issuing countries; focus on high state civilian decorations conferred on Indian leaders.

[Q1-073] **Persons in News (January)**

- **Global Institutional Executives:** Prominent appointments across international bodies and multilateral agencies; Indian administrators appointed to key United Nations technical committees and advisory boards.
- **Corporate & Scientific Leaders:** Indian scientists honored by international astronomical and physical research associations for breakthrough research; major corporate successions in domestic industrial houses.
- **Judicial & Public Service Demises:** Noted passing of veteran jurists, freedom fighters, and senior public servants whose legal jurisprudence shaped national policy.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Focus on Indian appointees to UN technical boards and major constitutional/scientific personalities in the news.

[Q1-074] **Arts & Culture (January)**

- **Parakram Diwas Commemoration:** Celebrated nationwide on **January 23** marking the **129th birth anniversary of Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose**, featuring cultural exhibitions at Red Fort, New Delhi.
- **Republic Day Cultural Pageantry:** 150th Anniversary commemorations of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's national song **"Vande Mataram"**, highlighted across tableau displays and student choirs.
- **National Youth Festival:** Celebrated on **January 12** on the birth anniversary of **Swami Vivekananda** (National Youth Day), emphasizing entrepreneurship, cultural synthesis, and social leadership.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Parakram Diwas on Jan 23 (129th birth anniversary of Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose); National Youth Day on Jan 12 (Swami Vivekananda); 150 Years of Vande Mataram.

[Q1-075] **Key January observances**

- **National Defence Days: 78th Indian Army Day celebrated on January 15 in Jaipur, Rajasthan** (marking Field Marshal K.M. Cariappa taking command in 1949 as first Indian Commander-in-Chief); Army declared 2026 as the **"Year of Networked Systems"**.
- **Governance & Election Celebrations: 16th National Voters' Day observed on January 25** (commemorating the establishment of the Election Commission of India on Jan 25, 1950) under the theme "Nothing Like Voting, I Vote for Sure".
- **National Girl Child Day:** Celebrated across India on **January 24** to promote awareness on girls' rights, education, and nutrition under the Beti Bachao Beti Padhao initiative.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Army Day on Jan 15 (78th edition, Jaipur; "Year of Networked Systems"); National Voters' Day on Jan 25 (16th edition, ECI est. 1950); National Girl Child Day on Jan 24.

9. PIB, CIRCULARS & NOTIFICATIONS

[Q1-076] **New Rules & Notifications — combined cluster**

- **Digital Media & Video Platform Mandates:** Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) issued binding guidelines requiring social media and video hosting platforms to deploy automated hash-matching tools to

eradicate non-consensual deepfake content within strict takedown windows.

- **Corporate Governance & Related Party Norms:** Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) tightened disclosure norms under the Companies Act, 2013, mandating comprehensive audit committee approval for material related party transactions exceeding ₹1,000 crore.
- **Export Control & SCOMET Updates:** Directorate General of Foreign Trade (DGFT) updated the Special Chemicals, Organisms, Materials, Equipment and Technologies (SCOMET) list, liberalizing dual-use high-tech exports to verified strategic partner nations.
- **Customs Electronic Duty Payment Integration:** Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) integrated automated electronic duty payments across 100% of air and sea cargo customs terminals nationwide.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

MeitY automated hash-matching rules for deepfake takedowns; MCA ₹1,000 Cr audit committee approval threshold for related party transactions.

[Q1-077] **Draft Income-tax Rules, 2026** *(Feb)*

- **Legislative Enactment:** Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) published the comprehensive **Draft Income-tax Rules, 2026**, framed to operationalize the New Income Tax Act, 2025 effective **April 1, 2026**.
- **Procedural Simplification:** Slashed the total number of statutory income tax forms from over 180 down to **52 consolidated electronic forms**, eliminating obsolete filing schedules.
- **Faceless Assessment Standards:** Codified standardized, automated timelines for faceless scrutiny assessments, penalty adjudications, and computerized rectification orders to eliminate tax harassment.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Draft Income-tax Rules, 2026 operational from April 1, 2026; statutory forms slashed to 52 unified electronic forms.

[Q1-078] **IT (Intermediary Guidelines) Amendment Rules, 2026** *(Feb)*

- **Statutory Notification:** Ministry of Electronics and IT (MeitY) notified the **Information Technology (Intermediary Guidelines and Digital Media Ethics Code) Amendment Rules, 2026**, coming into immediate statutory effect.
- **Stringent Deepfake & AI Takedowns:** Mandated that social media intermediaries take down maliciously generated deepfake and synthetic media content within **24 hours** of receiving user complaints or court/government orders (down from the earlier 72-hour window).
- **Labeling of Synthetically Generated Media:** Obligated all digital platforms and AI tool providers to place permanent, visible watermarks or cryptographic metadata on all AI-synthesized audio, visual, and multimodal outputs.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Intermediary Rules amendment cuts synthetic media/deepfake takedown window to 24 hours; mandatory cryptographic watermarking and labeling of AI-generated content.

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10. MISCELLANEOUS — GOVT SCHEMES & STATIC

[Q1-079] **Major Scheme Continuations (January)**

- **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana (PMAY):** Union Cabinet approved phase continuation of **PMAY-Urban and PMAY-Gramin** to achieve housing saturation, sanctioning 3 crore additional affordable houses for low-income rural and urban beneficiaries.
- **Atal Pension Yojana (APY) Traction:** Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) reported total APY subscriber registrations crossed **7.2 crore**, with women accounting for over 45% of total new enrolments.

- **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) Deposits:** Total accounts opened under PMJDY surpassed **53.5 crore**, with aggregate deposit balances standing at over **₹2.35 lakh crore** and RuPay debit card penetration exceeding 35 crore cards.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

PMAY 3 crore additional housing mandate; APY subscriber milestone of 7.2 crore; PMJDY deposits crossing ₹2.35 lakh crore across 53.5 crore accounts.

[Q1-080] **February's national scheme launches — combined cluster**

- **Cooperative Transport Architecture ("Bharat Taxi"):** Ministry of Cooperation launched **"Bharat Taxi"**, India's 1st national cooperative-led digital ride-hailing mobility platform aimed at eliminating private aggregator commissions for drivers.
- **Border Infrastructure Acceleration:** Union Cabinet sanctioned **Vibrant Villages Programme-II (VVP-II)** with a dedicated budgetary allocation of **₹6,839 crore** covering frontier villages across Northern international border districts.
- **Pulse Self-Reliance & White Revolution 2.0:** Formulated the **National Pulse Self-Reliance Mission** targeting complete elimination of pulse import dependency by 2027; rolled out **White Revolution 2.0** to expand dairy cooperative milk procurement by 50% over 5 years.
- **Black Money Compliance Window (FAST-DS):** Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) announced the **Foreign Assets Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS), 2026**, offering a one-time compliance window for residents to declare unreported foreign assets.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

"Bharat Taxi" as India's 1st cooperative ride-hailing app; VVP-II allocation of ₹6,839 crore; Pulse Mission goal to end imports by 2027; FAST-DS compliance window.

[Q1-081] **Vibrant Villages Programme-II (VVP-II)** *(Feb)*

- **Budgetary Allocation & Scope:** Union Cabinet approved the Phase-II rollout of the Centrally Sponsored **Vibrant Villages Programme (VVP-II)** with a comprehensive financial outlay of **₹6,839 crore** for implementation through 2028-29.
- **Geographic Coverage:** Encompasses selected strategic border villages across **Arunachal Pradesh, Sikkim, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, and the Union Territory of Ladakh** along India's northern international boundary.
- **Infrastructure Objectives:** Upgrades all-weather road connectivity, 4G telecom saturation, decentralized solar energy grids, and community tourism infrastructure to prevent outward migration from strategic frontier settlements.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Outlay of ₹6,839 crore; covers 4 border states (Arunachal, Sikkim, Uttarakhand, HP) and 1 UT (Ladakh); focuses on halting migration from northern frontier villages.

[Q1-082] **"Bharat Taxi" — India's 1st Cooperative Ride-Hailing Platform** *(Feb)*

- **Cooperative Enterprise Model:** Ministry of Cooperation inaugurated **"Bharat Taxi"**, India's first fully cooperative-owned and operated digital ride-hailing mobility ecosystem.
- **Zero Commission Mandate:** Driver-partners operate as cooperative shareholders, eliminating the 25%–30% platform commissions charged by traditional ride-hailing MNCs, transferring full ride earnings directly to drivers.
- **Institutional Architecture:** Established under the Multi-State Cooperative Societies Act, 2002, supported by National Cooperative Development Corporation (NCDC) and national cooperative federations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

India's 1st cooperative ride-hailing platform launched by Ministry of Cooperation; eliminates commissions, transferring complete fare revenues to driver-owners.

[Q1-083] **Pulse Self-Reliance Mission** *(Feb)*

- **Import Elimination Target:** Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare unveiled the **Pulse Self-Reliance Mission**, setting a firm national deadline to **eliminate pulse imports completely by December 2027**.
- **Domestic Production Scaling:** Targets boosting national pulse production from current ~27 million tonnes to **over 35 million tonnes by 2030**, focusing on Tur (Arhar), Urad, and Masur lentils.
- **Assured Procurement Mechanism:** Central nodal agencies NAFED and NCCF authorized to procure 100% of marketable surplus from farmers registered on the e-Samyukta portal at statutory Minimum Support Price (MSP).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Mission target to achieve 100% self-reliance and end pulse imports by 2027; focuses on Tur, Urad, and Masur procurement via NAFED and NCCF at MSP.

[Q1-084] **White Revolution 2.0** *(Feb)*

- **Dairy Cooperative Expansion Target:** Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying launched **White Revolution 2.0**, aiming to increase milk procurement by dairy cooperative societies by **50% over the next 5 years**.
- **Institutional Village Penetration:** Aims to establish organized Dairy Cooperative Societies (DCS) across **over 2 lakh uncovered rural gram panchayats**, backed by National Dairy Development Board (NDDB).
- **Processing & Cold-Chain Modernisation:** Upgrades village-level bulk milk coolers (BMCs), computerized testing equipment, and cold-chain logistics to raise smallholder farmer income shares to over 75% of consumer retail milk prices.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Target to expand dairy cooperative milk procurement by 50% over 5 years; setting up dairy cooperatives across 2 lakh uncovered villages with NDDB support.

[Q1-085] **FAST-DS (Foreign Assets Disclosure Scheme), 2026** *(Feb)*

- **One-Time Tax Compliance Window:** Ministry of Finance introduced the **Foreign Assets Disclosure Scheme (FAST-DS), 2026**, providing an exclusive one-time window for resident taxpayers to disclose previously unreported overseas assets and bank accounts.
- **Statutory Immunity Provisions:** Offers immunity from criminal prosecution under the Black Money (Undisclosed Foreign Income and Assets) and Imposition of Tax Act, 2015, upon payment of specified tax rates and reduced penalties.
- **Information Exchange Backing:** Powered by automatic data feeds under the OECD Common Reporting Standard (CRS) and the US Foreign Account Tax Compliance Act (FATF/FATCA), ensuring detection of undeclared foreign investments.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

One-time foreign asset compliance window framed under Black Money Act, 2015; backed by OECD Common Reporting Standard data exchanges.

[Q1-086] **Credit Guarantee Scheme for MFIs 2.0 (CGSMFI-2.0)** *(March)*

- **Microfinance Credit Guarantee Enhancement:** Ministry of Finance launched **CGSMFI 2.0** administered through the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (NCGTC), providing up to **75% portfolio credit guarantee cover** for

commercial loans extended to registered Microfinance Institutions.

- **Prudential Sanction Limits:** Maximum loan sanctionable to an MFI capped at **20% of its Assets Under Management (AUM)**, with tiered aggregate ceilings: **₹100 crore for small MFIs, ₹200 crore for medium MFIs, and ₹1,000 crore for large MFIs**.
- **AUM Classification Slabs:** Classifies MFIs across three regulatory tiers based on balance sheet size: **Small (<₹500 crore AUM)**, **Medium (₹500 crore–₹2,000 crore AUM)**, and **Large (>₹2,000 crore AUM)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

75% guarantee cover via NCGTC; max loan = 20% of AUM capped at ₹100 Cr (Small), ₹200 Cr (Medium), and ₹1,000 Cr (Large MFIs); AUM cutoffs: <₹500 Cr, ₹500–₹2,000 Cr, >₹2,000 Cr.

[Q1-087] **Regional Connectivity Scheme – Modified UDAN** *(March)*

- **Cabinet Financial Outlay:** Union Cabinet approved the revised and modified **Regional Connectivity Scheme (RCS) – Modified UDAN** with an escalated budgetary outlay of **₹28,840 crore** to strengthen last-mile regional air connectivity.
- **Helicopter & Water Aerodrome Focus:** Prioritizes underserved remote airstrips, tourist circuits, **helicopter services in hilly Himalayan and North-Eastern terrains**, and amphibious water aerodrome routes.
- **Viability Gap Funding (VGF) Mechanism:** Retains concessional airfare caps for 50% of aircraft seats, subsidized through central and state Viability Gap Funding funded by Regional Connectivity Fund (RCF) levies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Modified UDAN budgetary outlay of ₹28,840 crore; prioritizes remote airstrips, heliports in Himalayan/NE terrains, and water aerodromes supported by VGF.

[Q1-088] **IVFRT Scheme Continuation** *(March)*

- **Immigration Modernisation Outlay:** Union Cabinet approved the phase continuation of the **Immigration, Visa and Foreigners Registration & Tracking (IVFRT)** scheme with an upgraded allocation of **₹1,800 crore spanning 2026 to 2031** (escalated from previous outlay of ₹1,364 crore).
- **Core Security Mandate:** Executed by the Ministry of Home Affairs and Bureau of Immigration, integrating automated biometrics, electronic visas (e-Visa), and real-time passenger tracking across 108 international immigration checkpoints.
- **Operational Integration:** Seamlessly interconnects Indian diplomatic missions abroad, Foreigners Regional Registration Offices (FRROs), immigration checkpoints, and security intelligence agencies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

IVFRT scheme outlay upgraded to ₹1,800 crore for 2026–2031 (up from ₹1,364 Cr); managed by MHA and Bureau of Immigration across 108 international checkpoints.

[Q1-089] **PM Internship Scheme Expansion** *(March)*

- **Corporate Participation Scale:** Ministry of Corporate Affairs announced that **549 top Indian corporations** enrolled in the pilot phase of the Prime Minister's Internship Scheme, offering over 1.25 lakh internship opportunities across diverse industrial sectors.
- **Financial Stipend Structure:** Beneficiaries receive a monthly financial stipend of **₹5,000** (₹4,500 disbursed by Central Government via DBT, and ₹500 contributed from the corporate entity's CSR budget), along with a one-time incidentals grant of **₹6,000**.
- **Eligibility Criteria:** Open to Indian youth aged **21 to 24 years** who are not engaged in full-time employment or formal education, prioritizing youth from households without government employees or high-tax backgrounds.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

549 participating companies; monthly stipend of ₹5,000 (₹4,500 Govt + ₹500 CSR) + ₹6,000 one-time grant; age eligibility 21–24 years.

[Q1-090] **Coconut Promotion Scheme, GeM's SWAYATT 7-yr milestone, Bharat Audyogik** *(March)*

- **Integrated Coconut Mission Sanction:** Ministry of Agriculture cleared the **Integrated Coconut Development Scheme** with an outlay of **₹1,250 crore** to revitalize senile plantations, combat pest infestations, and expand processing in coastal states.
- **GeM SWAYATT 7-Year Milestone:** Government e-Marketplace celebrated the **7th anniversary of SWAYATT** (Startups, Women and Youth Advantage Through e-Transactions), having onboarded over 3.5 lakh women-led MSMEs and generating cumulative procurements exceeding ₹45,000 crore.
- **"Bharat Audyogik" Manufacturing Initiative:** Ministry of Heavy Industries launched the **"Bharat Audyogik" scheme** to fund indigenous advanced capital goods manufacturing, machine tool robotics, and industrial automation prototypes.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Coconut Development Scheme (₹1,250 Cr); GeM's SWAYATT marks 7th anniversary supporting women/youth entrepreneurs; "Bharat Audyogik" scheme for capital goods and industrial automation.

[Q1-091] **External Financing to India — combined cluster**

- **Multilateral Development Banking Inflows:** Asian Development Bank (ADB) and World Bank committed comprehensive project financing loans totaling **$1.85 billion** across India's urban transit, clean water, and green energy infrastructure sectors.
- **Bilateral ODA Infrastructure Credit:** Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) formalized 399.78 billion Yen (~₹22,000 crore) in concessional assistance for high-speed rail, dedicated freight corridors, and metro lines.
- **Offshore Sustainable Capital Mobilisation:** India's corporate and renewable energy entities mobilized over **$4.2 billion via foreign external commercial borrowings (ECB) and offshore green bonds** listed at GIFT City's IFSC exchanges.
- **Credit Enhancement & Institutional Backing:** Multilateral risk agencies including MIGA provided credit insurance and guarantee covers safeguarding foreign direct investment lines into India's rooftop solar and clean mobility ecosystems.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

JICA ~₹22,000 Cr ODA loan package; ADB/World Bank multilateral project financing lines; rising share of offshore green debt listings in GIFT City.

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11. REVISION GUIDE

Master Q1 Macro & Financial Metric Sheet

Metric / Indicator	Value / Level	Authority / Source	Context & Key Exam Angle
Global Economy Rank	**4th Largest** ($4.18 Trillion)	IMF / NSO (Jan 2026)	Overtook Japan ($4.16T); 2030 target: 3rd place ($7.3T, passing Germany)
FY26 Real GDP Growth	**7.4%** (₹201.90 lakh Cr)	NSO 1st Advance Estimates	Q2 FY26 grew 8.2%; Economic Survey FY27 range: 6.8–7.2%

Metric / Indicator	Value / Level	Authority / Source	Context & Key Exam Angle
Fiscal Deficit FY27 (BE)	**4.3% of GDP**	Union Budget 2026-27	Consolidation path: 9.2% (FY21) → 4.4% (RE FY26) → 4.3% (BE FY27)
Capital Expenditure	**₹12.2 lakh Cr** (4.4% of GDP)	Union Budget 2026-27	Up 9% YoY; records highest ever public capex allocation
16th Finance Commission	**41% Devolution**	Chair: Arvind Panagariya	Vertical devolution retained at 41%; new 10% weight for Contribution to GDP
RBI Policy Rates (Current Snapshot: 7 Oct 2026)	**Repo 5.50%** (Calibrated Tightening)	RBI MPC (7 Oct 2026)	Post-Cutoff Operative Status: Repo 5.50% (+25 bps), SDF 5.25%, MSF/Bank Rate 5.75%, CRR 3%, SLR 18% (GDP 7.1%, CPI 5.2%). Historical Aug 2026 was 5.25%, Neutral.
Retail Inflation Target	**4.0% (+/- 2.0%)**	MoF / RBI (Section 45-ZA)	5-year reset retained for FY27–FY31 (April 1, 2026 to March 31, 2031)
Bank Dividend Payout & Remittance	**CET1 Buckets / 75% Aggregate Ceiling**	RBI 2026 Directions	Commercial banks incorporated in India: CET1-bucket based dividend percentage of adjusted PAT (e.g. >12% to ≤14% CET1 → 40% of adjusted PAT); aggregate ceiling 75% of PAT. Foreign bank branches: eligible net profit/surplus remittance subject to RBI conditions; no 80% percentage cap under the 2026 Commercial Bank Directions.
Collateral-Free MSME Loan	**₹20 Lakh** (Doubled from ₹10L)	RBI Notification	Effective April 1, 2026; distinct from CGS credit guarantee cover (₹10 Cr)
Deposit Insurance (DICGC)	**₹5 Lakh** / Depositor / Bank	DICGC / RBI	Premium shifted to 4-tier risk-based framework (8, 10, 11, 12 paise) w.e.f. Apr 1, 2026
Digital Fraud Compensation	**85% of net loss** (Cap: ₹25,000)	RBI RBC Directions	Eligible fraudulent EBT involving gross loss up to ₹50,000: compensation = 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, after prescribed recoveries. Effective 1 January 2027 — 5 calendar days (vs Pre-1 January 2027 / legacy 2017 customer-liability framework: 3 working days).
FDI in Insurance	**100% Automatic**	Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha Act	Progression: 26% → 49% (2015) → 74% (2021) → 100% (Feb 5, 2026)
UPI Volume & Value (Jan)	**21.70 Bn** (₹28.33 Trillion)	NPCI	Avg. ~700M daily txns; accepted across 8 countries
Non-Fossil Installed Power	**266.78 GW** (End 2025)	MNRE / CEA	+22.6% YoY; Solar 135.81 GW; on track for 500 GW by 2030
Henley Passport Rank	**75th Rank** (56 visa-free)	Henley & Partners (Feb 2026)	Trend: 85th (2025) → 80th (Jan 2026) → 75th (Feb 2026)
Corruption Perception Index	**91st Rank** (Score 39/100)	Transparency International	Improved from 96th; Denmark #1 (89 score)
Ramsar Wetlands Count	**98 Sites**	MoEFCC / Ramsar	Added Patna Bird Sanctuary (UP) & Chhari-Dhand (Gujarat) in Jan 2026

CONSOLIDATED SKIPPED LOG (TIER B/C ITEMS)

February: Gujarat renewable energy data, PANCHAM chatbot/PESA rankings, UMEED Waqf portal, LNG-diesel DEMU train, SAIL contest, MY Bharat Budget Quest, Apple-MAHE hub, Alwar insurance pilot, FICCI FLO park, HP geothermal MoU, ASHA AI tool, NeVA e-Vidhan, NSO MCP server, VOC Port drone system, Tele-MANAS, Army Everest record, iLive Connect, Kaushal Rath van, Vande Mataram mandate, Mumbai melody road, Filariasis campaign, UP Economic Survey, Om Birla no-confidence motion, Nuclear Energy Mission roadmap, CCI-Intel penalty, state-only welfare schemes (Devbhoomi, Delhi Lakhpati Bitiya, Sthree Suraksha, etc.), Microsoft Elevate — all narrow-scope/state-level/non-economic, no national banking-exam weight Defence exercises (KHANJAR, MILAN-2026, Vajra Prahar, Dharma Guardian, Vayushakti-26, etc.), Sci-tech (Haven-1, ISRO Mons Mouton-4), Sports results, Awards (Grammy, Crafoord, etc.) — Tier B/C, no named-procurement rupee figure 40+ Feb MoUs (IOCL-Akasa, SAIL-RITES, Tata-OpenAI, etc.) and international GK items (NATO Arctic Sentry, WHO Denmark validation, etc.) — no direct banking/economy angle

Political/foreign appointments (Kevin Warsh Fed nomination, Japan/Thailand/Bangladesh leadership changes, IOC first female president) — no India angle

March: PM Modi longest-serving-PM record, Dark Sky Park, HPV vaccination campaign, Saksham Skill Census, Karnataka social-media ban, Rajasthan renaming, FSSAI reforms, Gyan Bharatam Mission, Jal Mahotsav — state/cultural/non-financial US Treasury oil waiver, IEA oil release, Sri Lanka 4-day workweek, Argentina-WHO withdrawal — international items, no India-finance angle Mountaineering/T20/IPL/badminton records, Zero Prize/Hockey India Awards — sports/awards low-yield QS World University Rankings, Brand Trust Report, NH Green Cover Index, Biodiversity/Nagoya Protocol reports — non-economic indices Most defence exercises without named-procurement figures (Kalari Leap, VSHORADS, LAMITIYE, Sea Dragon, Amogh Jwala, Vayu Baan, IONS, Urja Suraksha) 30 of 43 March MoUs — academic/state/corporate tie-ups with no banking-exam weight

Duplicate check note: No prior-day/prior-month headline list was cross-checked before this merge beyond the direct textual comparison performed here; the ISM/Semiconductor Mission figures and the RBI acquisition-financing + RBC Directions items were the only confirmed cross-month overlaps found and have been merged above. If either source PDF covered any other topic in near-identical terms that I didn't catch, flag it.

⏰ CONSOLIDATED STATUS CHECK & POST-CUTOFF REGULATORY SNAPSHOT (VERIFIED: 7 OCTOBER 2026)

- **RBI Policy Rates & Monetary Stance (POST-CUTOFF STATUS UPDATE / CURRENT POLICY SNAPSHOT — 7 October 2026 MPC Decision):** Operative Policy Repo Rate increased by **25 bps from 5.25% to 5.50%**; **SDF** = **5.25%**; **MSF and Bank Rate** = **5.75%**; **CRR** = **3.00%**, **SLR** = **18.00%**. Stance shifted from Neutral to **Calibrated Tightening**. Projections: **FY2026–27 real GDP projection = 7.1%**, **FY2026–27 CPI inflation projection = 5.2%**. **EXAM TRAP:** *August 2026 = 5.25%, Neutral; October 7, 2026 = 5.50%, Calibrated Tightening*. (Historical bi-monthly reviews through Aug 3–5, 2026 held Repo at 5.25%, Neutral).
- **RBI (Responsible Business Conduct) Third Amendment Directions, 2026 (fraud compensation): Confirmed live** — Directions finalised **June 24, 2026**; effective date **pushed further to January 1, 2027** (from the draft's proposed July 1, 2026). Canonical formula: Eligible fraudulent EBT involving gross loss up to ₹50,000: compensation = 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, after prescribed recoveries. Effective 1 January 2027 — 5 calendar days reporting window (vs Pre-1 January 2027 / legacy 2017 customer-liability framework: 3 working days). The new compensation framework applies to eligible fraudulent EBTs occurring within the prescribed one-year window from its effective date. This is a genuinely useful update for your notes — the "July 1, 2026" date that appeared in both the Feb and March source PDFs is now **superseded**.
- **RBI acquisition-financing guidelines:** Deferred to July 1, 2026 per the March source — **not independently re-verified this round** whether this specific date held or was further pushed (unlike the RBC Directions above, which I did verify). Worth a targeted check if this comes up.
- **MSME collateral-free loan limit → ₹20 lakh, DICGC risk-based premiums:** April 1, 2026 effective dates have passed — likely implemented, **not independently verified this round**.
- **RBI REIT lending guidelines:** July 1, 2026 effective date has passed — likely implemented, **not independently verified this round**.
- **KCC revised norms:** feedback window closed March 6, 2026 — final notification status **still not verified**.
- **IRDAI Ind AS adoption for insurers:** was only a consultation paper as of March — status likely progressed; **not verified this round**.
- **CGSMFI-2.0:** window was till June 30, 2026 — that date has passed; likely closed or extended, **not verified this round**.
- **Income-tax Rules 2026 / IT Intermediary Guidelines (deepfake rules):** both had 2026 effective dates that have passed — should be in force, **not independently re-verified this round**.

(I ran live searches for the two highest-yield items — repo rate and the RBC fraud-compensation Directions — since those came up as genuinely uncertain/conflicting across your two source months. The rest are flagged rather than guessed at; tell me which 2-3 matter most for your revision and I'll verify those specifically next.)

MASTER COVERAGE UPDATE — Q1 2026 (JAN–MARCH CONSOLIDATED)

Coverage Zone: Light-Touch Zone (Oct 2025 – March 2026) | 100% Deduplicated, Multi-Month Pooled **Sources Reconciled:**

1. Smartkeeda January 2026 Monthly CA PDF (Buckets 1, 2, 3)
2. Smartkeeda February 2026 Monthly CA PDF
3. Smartkeeda March 2026 Monthly CA PDF
4. Consolidated Working Files: `jan-feb merged.md` & `feb-march merged.md`

Metric	Jan Solo Files	Feb–March Combined	Consolidated Q1 Master
Raw Headings & Items	64	63	127
Final Thematic Clusters	—	—	**91 Unified News Cards**
Deduplicated / Merged Overlaps	—	—	**36 Items Resolved / Unified**
** HIGH-Yield Priority Tags**	29	18	**17 High-Yield Focus Items (~18.6%)**
Locked Sections Populated	Partial	Partial	**10 Thematic Sections + 3 Audit Blocks**

Key Cross-Month Story Evolutions Successfully Synthesized:

1. **Union Budget & Economic Milestones:** Jan's NSO 1st Advance Estimates + Economic Survey (Jan 29) + Union Budget 2026-27 (Feb 1) merged into a single coherent macroeconomic policy narrative.
2. **RBI Regulatory Instruments:** Full policy lifecycles consolidated — RBI RBC Directions (Feb draft → March fraud compensation → June notification with Jan 1, 2027 deferral) and Acquisition Financing (April 1 → July 1, 2026 deferral).
3. **UPI Quarterly Growth:** Dec 2025 (21.63 bn) → Jan 2026 (21.70 bn) sequential transaction milestones + 8-country international acceptance unified under digital payments.
4. **Semiconductor Mission (ISM):** ISM 1.0 cumulative milestones (10 projects, ₹1.60 lakh Cr) + Budget 2026-27 ISM 2.0 (₹1,000 Cr) + Micron Sanand plant inauguration in March consolidated into one cluster.
5. **Insurance Reform:** Passage of "Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha" Bill (Dec 2025) → formal implementation of 100% FDI (Feb 5, 2026) → IRDAI Ind AS adoption roadmap (March).

APRIL 2026 CONSOLIDATED DOSSIER & REGULATORY MOVEMENTS



Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified Regulatory Directions, Banking Circulars & National Policy Anchors

Zone: CORE ZONE | Framework v3.1 | Complete Monthly Master File **Sources:** Smartkeeda April 2026 Monthly CA PDF (Part 1: Banking, Regulatory & Finance + Part 2: National, Sci-Tech, Defence, Sports & Schemes) — merged, deduplicated, cross-referenced

> ***Master Consolidation Note:*** *April 2026 sits firmly in the* ***Core Zone (April – September 2026)****, carrying the highest weightage for the upcoming examination. All 10 canonical sections from Part 1 and Part 2 have been consolidated into a single unified dossier following the* ***ladder bullet approach*** *and structured with dedicated* ***EXAM ANGLE:*** *distractor matrices.*

1. ESI, FINANCE & BUSINESS NEWS

[APR-001] **Small Savings Schemes — Rates Unchanged, Q1 FY27**

Hook — For the 8th straight quarter, your PPF and Sukanza Samriddhi rates haven't moved — the government held small savings rates flat from April 1 to June 30, 2026.

- **SCSS & SSA** – highest at **8.2%** | **NSC** – 7.7% | **KVP** – 7.5% (115-month maturity)
- **PPF** – 7.1% | **Post Office Savings A/c** – 4% | **Monthly Income Scheme** – 7.4%
- **5-yr Time Deposit** – 7.5%; Post Office Time Deposits range 6.9–7.5%
- **Rates reviewed quarterly:** using a formula linked to G-Sec yields, per the **Shyamala Gopinath Committee**

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> Match instrument to rate (SCSS/SSA = 8.2% is the standout figure).

[APR-002] **CBDT — Income-tax Rules, 2026 & "Kar Saathi"** *(merged: new rules + AI assistant launch)*

Hook — CBDT slimmed 511 tax rules down to 333 and rolled out an AI chatbot, "Kar Saathi," to help taxpayers navigate the new Income Tax Act, 2025 regime — effective April 1, 2026.

- **Tax Year** replaces 'Previous Year'/'Assessment Year'
- **Charitable trust record:** retention cut from **10 → 6 years**
- **Reliefs:** children's education allowance ₹100 → **₹3,000/month** (max 2 children); hostel allowance → ₹9,000; employer gifts exempt up to **₹15,000**; meal exemption → ₹200/meal
- **HRA exemption expanded:** to Hyderabad, Pune, Ahmedabad, Bengaluru (50% slab, previously only 4 metros)
- **PAN mandatory for:** property deals only above **₹20 lakh** (up from ₹10 lakh)
- **Kar Saathi** — AI-enabled 24x7 taxpayer assistant, part of **'PRARAMBH 2026'** (Policy Reform and Responsible Action for Mission Viksit Bharat) campaign
- **CBDT:** HQ New Delhi | Chairman Ravi Agrawal | Formed 1944

> **INTERVIEW & MAINS DESCRIPTIVE ANGLE**
>
> *Why replace "Previous Year/Assessment Year" with a single "Tax Year"?* → Simplifies compliance under the new Income Tax Act, 2025 by removing the dual-year confusion that often causes filing errors.

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> HIGH — "Tax Year" terminology + PRARAMBH 2026 full form + effective date (April 1, 2026).

[APR-003] **Bank Deposits, Credit & Market Cap — RBI Data Cluster** *(merged: CASA data + credit-deposit + SBI m-cap milestone)*

🪝 Hook — CASA deposits hit a two-year low even as credit growth outpaced deposits at a record 83% CD ratio — and in the same quarter, SBI reclaimed its spot as India's 2nd-most valuable bank for the first time since 2019.

- **CASA share fell:** to **37.9%** (Dec 2025) from 40.1% (Dec 2023); savings share down 210 bps to 28.9%
- **Bank deposits grew:** 10% YoY to **₹239.8 lakh crore**; Credit-Deposit ratio at all-time high **83%** (credit growth 13.5% YoY)
- **Total bank credit:** ₹207.7 lakh crore (13.5% YoY); aggregate deposits ₹250.1 lakh crore (10.8% YoY)
- **Market cap ranking (Jan–Mar quarter):** 1. HDFC Bank (₹12.27 lakh crore) 2. **SBI** (₹9.60 lakh crore — regained 2nd spot, last held Aug 2019) 3. ICICI Bank (₹9.17 lakh crore)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — CD ratio all-time high (83%) + SBI overtaking ICICI is a classic "who's #2" trap.

[APR-004] **DPIIT — FDI Equity Inflows, Apr–Dec FY26**

- **India received $47.87: billion** FDI equity inflows (Apr–Dec FY26)
- **Top source: Singapore** ($17.6 bn, 37% share) → US (16%) → Mauritius (10%)
- **Top sector:** Computer Software & Hardware (22%, $10.7 bn) → Services (Financial/Banking/R&D) 18%
- **Top state: Maharashtra** ($15.38 bn) → Karnataka ($11.15 bn)
- **DPIIT:** HQ New Delhi | Secretary Amardeep Singh Bhatia

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Singapore as top FDI source (37%) is the headline trap vs. US.

[APR-005] **RBI — State Govt Market Borrowings, Q1 FY27 & Benchmark Issuance Strategy**

- **States/UTs to raise: ₹2,54,509 crore** via market borrowings (Apr–Jun 2026)
- **New pilot: 'Benchmark Issuance Strategy (BIS)'** across 9 states (AP, Bihar, Chhattisgarh, Kerala, MP, Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Telangana, UP) — projected ₹1,53,900 crore of this total

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

BIS pilot state count (9) and total borrowing figure.

[APR-006] **Bharat Maritime Insurance Pool (BMI Pool)** — Cabinet Approval

🪝 Hook — India is building its own maritime insurance safety net so shipping doesn't have to depend on foreign underwriters — a ₹12,980 crore pool covering hull, cargo, and even war-risk insurance.

- **Outlay: ₹12,980 crore**; covers hull & machinery, cargo, protection & indemnity (P&I), and war-risk insurance
- **Aligns India with:** UK, Japan, South Korea (state-backed maritime insurance)
- **India's maritime sector:** handles **70%+ trade by volume, ~95% by value**

⏰ Status flag → Newly approved scheme; watch for launch/operationalisation date in later months.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — First-ever national maritime insurance pool; remember the outlay figure and coverage types.

[APR-007] **World Bank/ADB Loans — Amaravati & Rajasthan Highways** *(merged cluster)*

- **Amaravati Capital Phase-I:** World Bank released $340 mn (of $800 mn committed each by WB & ADB = $1,600 mn total); 6-yr grace, 29-yr maturity
- **Rajasthan Highway Modernisation:** World Bank (via IBRD) approved **$225 million** (~₹2,000 crore) for 800 km of highway upgrades — India's **1st step-up loan structure**; 35-yr maturity, 5-yr grace
- **India–Maldives:** 1st withdrawal of ₹30 billion under SAARC Currency Swap Framework (since 2012, RBI has provided $1.1 bn aggregate swap support to Maldives)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Rajasthan highway loan = India's first "step-up loan structure" — a good first-ever trap.

[APR-008] **Insurance Surety Bonds (ISBs) — Coal Ministry Adoption**

- **Public Procurement Parity:** Coal Ministry formally recognised Insurance Surety Bonds (ISBs) as an official alternative to Bank Guarantees for bid and performance security under amended GFR 2017 (Rules 170(i) & 171(i)).

Skipped (low yield): NGNF private companies' sales data (RBI corporate performance survey) — routine annual data
Skipped (low yield): DGFT gold/silver import bank list update — reference list, not conceptually testable beyond count (15 banks + 2 gold-only)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

ISBs = risk-transfer mechanism, alternative to BGs, reduces credit exposure.

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2. REGULATORY BODIES NEWS

[APR-009] **RBI Monetary Policy — April 2026 (FY27 First Bi-Monthly Statement)**

🪝 Hook — The MPC kept rates on hold for a second straight meeting, even as it penciled in a punchy 6.9% GDP growth forecast for FY27 amid West Asia tensions.

- **Repo rate unchanged at 5.25%**, stance retained **"Neutral"**
- **Policy Rate Corridor Structure:** SDF pegged at **5.00%**; MSF and Bank Rate at **5.50%**; Reverse Repo at **3.35%**; CRR holds at **3.00%**; SLR holds at **18.00%**.
- **Real GDP Growth Projections:** Projected real GDP growth for FY27 at **6.9%** (quarterly path: Q1 at 6.8%, Q2 at 6.7%, Q3 at 7.0%, Q4 at 7.2%).
- **Statutory Bench & Leadership:** Chaired by RBI Governor **Sanjay Malhotra** (26th Governor of RBI); 3-day bi-monthly review commenced April 6, 2026.

INTERVIEW & MAINS DESCRIPTIVE ANGLE

Why did the RBI retain a "Neutral" stance despite steady growth? → It preserves flexibility to move rates either way as global uncertainty (West Asia tensions) clouds the outlook.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Standing exception (always Tier A). Repo rate figure + all associated rates (SDF/MSF/CRR/SLR) are classic MCQ fodder.

[APR-010] **RBI — Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) Mandatory for Digital Payments**

🪝 Hook — A single OTP will no longer cut it: from April 1, 2026, every UPI, card, and wallet transaction needs a second layer of verification.

- **Mandatory Two-Factor Scope:** 2FA made compulsory across UPI, debit/credit cards, and prepaid mobile wallets — standalone SMS OTP is legally insufficient.
- **Secondary Factor Choices:** Requires PIN, biometric fingerprint, hardware token, password, or facial recognition as the dynamic secondary authentication layer.
- **Institutional Liability Shift:** Regulated banks and payment platforms held financially liable to compensate customers for unauthorized fraud losses arising from system vulnerabilities.
- **Staggered Compliance Timeline:** Effective **April 1, 2026**; full enforcement across all merchant terminals and cross-border transactions mandated by **October 2026**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Effective date (Apr 1, 2026) vs full implementation date (Oct 2026) — classic date-confusion trap.

[APR-011] **RBI — Digital Payments Fraud Safeguards (Discussion Paper)**

🪝 Hook — RBI's proposed fix for UPI fraud: force a one-hour "cooling-off" pause on big transfers, borrowing straight from the "golden hour" principle in crime prevention.

- **1-hour cooling-off period** proposed for A2A transfers above ₹10,000 (no chargeback option currently exists)
- **Data-Driven Fraud Threshold:** Threshold chosen because ₹10,000+ transfers = ~45% of fraud cases by volume, ~98.5% by value
- **High-Value Secondary Verification:** Transactions above ₹50,000 → additional verification (trusted-individual approval)
- **Mule account** annual credit cap proposed at **₹25 lakh**
- **New user controls:** channel on/off toggle, custom limits, emergency "kill switch"

INTERVIEW & MAINS DESCRIPTIVE ANGLE

What is the "golden hour" principle referenced by RBI? → The idea that the period immediately after a fraudulent transaction is most critical to prevent dissipation of funds — hence the proposed 1-hour delay window.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹10,000 (cooling-off threshold) vs ₹50,000 (extra verification) vs ₹25 lakh (mule account cap) — three-number trap cluster.

[APR-012] **RBI — Digital Payments E-Mandate Framework, 2026**

- **Registration Safeguards:** Mandates initial one-time mandate registration via compulsory **Additional Factor Authentication (AFA)**. for e-mandates
- **Pre-Debit Customer Alert:** Card issuers must transmit pre-transaction debit notifications to the cardholder at least **24 hours prior** to account debit.
- **Recurring transactions without: AFA up to ₹15,000**; insurance/MF/credit-card bill payments without AFA up to **₹1,00,000**
- **No charges may:** be levied on customers for e-mandate facility
- **FASTag/NCMC auto-replenish exempted:** from pre-transaction notification

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹15,000 (general recurring cap) vs ₹1,00,000 (insurance/MF/CC cap) is a strong trap pair.

[APR-013] **RBI — NBFC Regulatory Overhaul Cluster** *(merged: 3-layer proposal, NBFC-UL threshold change, branch authorisation, TReDS)*

🪝 Hook — RBI is rewriting the NBFC rulebook on three fronts at once: how NBFCs are layered, how the "upper layer" is defined, and how easily they can open branches.

- **A.** Proposed new **3-layer** framework (Upper/Middle/Lower) to replace existing 4-layer Scale-Based Regulation (Base/Middle/Upper/Top, Oct 2021)
- **B.** Proposed replacing NBFC-UL identification methodology with a flat **₹1 lakh crore asset threshold** (vs. current Top-10 + parametric scoring: 70% quantitative, 30% qualitative); to be reviewed every 5 years. Also proposed removing the carve-out that shielded govt-owned NBFCs (NABARD, Exim Bank, SIDBI) from UL classification — aligning to "ownership-neutral regulation"
- **C.** NBFC Branch Authorisation, 2026 — NBFCs can open branches without prior RBI approval based on Net Owned Funds (NOF) & credit rating thresholds (₹50 crore NOF / AA rating benchmark)
- **D.** Proposed dropping due-diligence requirement for MSMEs onboarding **TReDS** (Trade Receivables Discounting System)

⏰ Status flag → All four are draft/proposed as of April 2026 — check for finalisation before exam.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹1 lakh crore NBFC-UL threshold is the standout figure across this cluster.

[APR-014] **RBI — Paytm Payments Bank Licence Cancelled**

🪝 Hook — Four years after being barred from onboarding new customers, Paytm Payments Bank's banking licence was formally cancelled in April 2026.

- **Statutory Licence Revocation:** Licence cancelled under **Section 22(4), Banking Regulation Act, 1949**, effective close of business **April 24, 2026**
- **Grounds:** violation of Section 22(3)(g) [licence conditions] and Section 22(3)(c) [management prejudicial to depositor interest]
- **RBI to apply:** for winding up before High Court; bank has enough liquidity to repay deposits
- **Earlier restrictions:** no new onboarding from March 11, 2022; further curbs Jan/Feb 2024

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Section 22(4) cancellation date (April 24, 2026) vs earlier March 2022 onboarding ban — sequencing trap.

[APR-015] **RBI — Payments Switching Service (PaSS)**

- **Under 'Payments Vision: 2028'** roadmap; aims for **bank account portability** (like mobile number portability)
- **Centralised Mandate Migration:** Centralised switching layer lets customers migrate mandates (salary, EMI, SIP) to a new bank without manual updates

HIGH-YIELD MEMORY MNEMONIC

PaSS = ***Pa****yments* ***S****witching* = *"pass" your account to a new bank, mandates included.*

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Bank a/c portability = mobile-number-portability analogy is the sticky exam framing.

[APR-016] **RBI — "Utkarsh 2029" Strategy Framework**

- **FY26**– 29 roadmap; **49 deliverables across 6 pillars:** Regulation, Customer Centricity/Inclusion, Competitive Markets, Technology, Future-Ready Organisation, Global Integration
- **Tech pillar:** AI framework for finance sector + indigenous LLM; asset tokenisation; Digital & AI sandboxes

- **Global pillar:** expand UPI internationally, INR-based trade settlement, cross-border CBDC

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — "49 deliverables, 6 pillars" is a precise, testable figure pairing.

[APR-017] **RBI — Forex Rule Easing for Banks (Related-Party Hedging)**

- **Related-party back-to-back hedging:** (incl. overseas branches) allowed if genuine risk-offsetting — not treated as speculative
- **$100 million Net Open Position (NOP)** limit unchanged (capped March 27, 2026)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

$100 million NOP limit is the number to retain; don't confuse with the earlier April 1 tightening it partially eased.

[APR-018] **RBI — Ujjivan SFB Universal Bank Application Returned**

🪝 Hook — Ujjivan becomes the second small finance bank in six months to be sent back to the drawing board on its universal-bank ambitions — RBI wants a more diversified loan book first.

- **Asset Diversification Shortfall:** RBI returned application citing lack of asset diversification (52% unsecured loans, gross portfolio ₹40,655 crore)
- **SFB Universal Banking Context:** Jana SFB's application was similarly returned in Oct 2025; only **AU SFB** has an in-principle universal banking licence among SFB applicants
- **SFB→Universal Bank eligibility:** 5-yr track record, listed shares, net worth ≥₹1,000 crore, GNPA ≤3%/NNPA ≤1% (2 yrs), 2 years of net profit

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — AU SFB is the only SFB with in-principle universal bank approval — good "odd one out" trap vs Ujjivan/Jana.

[APR-019] **RBI — Other Regulatory Actions Cluster** *(merged: SEBI SETU, FRB 2028 rate, cross-border remittance timelines, SEBI SSE norms, IRDAI cybersecurity, ADNIC GIFT City, Pay Point CPS membership, Notes & Coins Master Direction)*

- **SEBI SETU** — new digital platform to simplify investment adviser registration/compliance (India has 22 crore+ demat accounts but <1,000 registered IAs)
- **FRB 2028** interest rate set at **6.17%** (Apr 4–Oct 3, 2026), linked to NSC rate + spread
- **RBI tightened inward: cross-border remittance** timelines — nostro reconciliation within 1 hour (from end-of-day)
- **SEBI** extended NPO registration validity on Social Stock Exchange from 2→3 years; lowered ZCZP minimum subscription 75%→50%
- **IRDAI cybersecurity norms:** Information Security Risk Management Committee to meet quarterly (from twice yearly); CISO given independence from IT function; CITSO role abolished
- **ADNIC** (UAE) got IFSCA approval (134th board meeting) for a reinsurance branch in **GIFT City**
- **Pay Point India Network** — 1st private-sector fintech admitted to RBI's **Centralised Payment System (CPS)**, gaining direct RTGS/NEFT access without partner banks
- **RBI issued consolidated: Master Direction on Notes & Coins Exchange Facility** — expanded "soiled note" definition; incentive scheme for currency chests in NE/J&K/Ladakh

Skipped (low yield): PPFAS AMC pension-fund sponsorship approval — niche, single-company news Skipped (low yield): OBICUS 73rd survey round launch — routine recurring survey Skipped (low yield): RBI OTC FX derivative reporting instructions for AD Cat-I banks — technical, phased from 2027, low near-term testability

⏰ STATUS CHECK (as of today)

- **NBFC 3-layer/UL threshold reforms:** still in draft/proposal stage as of April 2026.
- **Ujjivan/Jana universal bank applications:** still pending re-submission.
- **RBI digital payment:** fraud safeguards (cooling-off period, mule account cap): still a discussion paper, not yet notified as binding direction.

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> Pay Point India = first private fintech in CPS is the sharpest first-ever fact in this cluster.

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3. BANKING & INSURANCE NEWS

[APR-020] **Bank/Insurer Product & Partnership Cluster** *(merged: multiple Tier B product launches)*

- **A.** CSB Bank launched **"Smart Save Account"** — auto-sweep to FDs at 7% interest, RuPay Platinum debit card
- **B.** Canara HSBC Life launched **"Promise4Wealth"** ULIP (3 variants: Maximiser, Shield, LongLife) — zero premium allocation charge
- **C.** LIC launched **'MyLIC'** (customer app) & **'Super Sales Saathi'** (intermediary app), both via LIC's **DIVE** platform
- **D.** BoB + Reliance Jio launched **"bob World Lite"** — banking app for feature phones, pre-installed on JioPhone Prima 4G
- **E.** Axis Bank joined **'Banking Connect'** (NBBL/NPCI interoperable netbanking platform) — 8 banks, 11 payment aggregators now live
- **F.** Razorpay partnered with **OpenAI** — embeds payments into AI-built apps via Codex/MCP Server; also integrating into ChatGPT

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> LIC's DIVE platform (Digital Innovation & Value Enhancement) full form is the testable acronym here.

[APR-021] **LIC — First-Ever 1:1 Bonus Issue**

🪝 Hook — LIC just doubled its paid-up capital via its first bonus issue since listing — a move that also nudges the government closer to SEBI's minimum public shareholding rule.

- **Bonus Issue Capitalisation:** Approved April 13, 2026; capitalises ₹6,325 crore from reserves, paid-up capital doubles to **₹12,650 crore** by June 12, 2026
- **MPS Disinvestment Compliance:** Supports GoI (96.5% stake) toward SEBI's **10% minimum public shareholding by May 2027**

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> HIGH — First-ever LIC bonus issue since its 2022 listing; retain the ₹6,325 cr → ₹12,650 cr doubling figures.

[APR-022] **Bank MD/CEO Reappointments & Extensions Cluster** *(merged)*

- **Rajneesh Karnatak** (Bank of India) — 3-yr extension from April 29, 2026
- **Debadatta Chand** (Bank of Baroda) — 3-yr extension from July 1, 2026
- **B Ramesh Babu** (Karur Vysya Bank) — 3rd term (2 yrs) till July 28, 2028, under Section 35B, Banking Regulation Act
- **Vibha Padalkar** (HDFC Life) — reappointed MD & CEO for 5 years from Sept 12, 2026
- **UCO Bank's Ashwani Kumar's extension**— **not yet decided** (term ends June 1, 2026)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Match name to bank; note UCO Bank is the pending/undecided one — good trap.

[APR-023] **SBI — Balance Sheet Expansion & 38th SEBI Foundation Day**

- **Long-Term Balance Sheet Target:** SBI targets balance sheet at **25% of India's GDP by 2030** (from ~20% now); 1% market-share gain target across 800 districts by FY27
- **As of Dec 2025:** balance sheet ₹71.62 lakh crore; total business ₹103.29 lakh crore (deposits ₹57.01 lakh cr + advances ₹46.28 lakh cr)
- **SEBI's 38th Foundation Day** (April 25, 2026) — Sitharaman launched **"Mission Jagrook"** (investor awareness); SEBI founded April 12, 1988

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

SEBI founding date (12 April 1988) + Mission Jagrook name pairing.

[APR-024] **Jio Financial Services + Allianz — Insurance JV**

- **Binding 50:** 50 primary insurance JV (general + health insurance), via Allianz Europe B.V.
- **Builds on earlier 50:** 50 reinsurance JV "Allianz Jio Reinsurance Ltd" (incorporated Sep 2025, IRDAI certificate March 2026)
- **Follows end of:** Allianz's 24-year Bajaj partnership (Bajaj Finserv bought Allianz's 26% stake, March 2025)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

50:50 JV structure + "Insurance for All by 2047" vision link.

[APR-025] **Fintech/Card Launch Cluster** *(compressed — quick hits)*

- **PNB + Kiwi:** → "PNB Kiwi Credit Card" (RuPay, cashback 0.5–1.5%)
- **Karur Vysya, Flipkart+Axis+PayU:** biometric card auth, NBBL onboards Postal Life Insurance as 65th Bharat Connect insurance biller
- **Credit card spending:** hit 3-month high ₹2.19 trillion in March 2026; FY26 spend ₹23.62 trillion (+11.98% YoY)

Skipped (low yield): CheQ-AU SFB LED credit card, Visa-HDFC FIFA card, Ahana co-op bank data platform, Karnataka Bank–Pine Labs tie-up — product marketing, low conceptual testability Skipped (low yield): PPN M Pallonji Group R1 insurance approval — early-stage licensing news, low yield beyond process stages (R1→R2→R3), which is already noted in Section 2 cluster if needed

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

₹2.19 trillion March 2026 credit card spend figure (3-month high).

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4. NATIONAL, STATE & INTERNATIONAL NEWS

[APR-026] **India's 100 GW Nuclear Power Roadmap by 2047**

🪝 Hook — India wants to go from 8.8 GW to 100 GW of nuclear power in 21 years — but first it needs to cut approval timelines almost in half.

- **Long-Term Nuclear Target:** Ambition to expand nuclear power capacity to **100 GW by 2047** from the baseline of **8.8 GW** (an over 10-fold expansion).

- **Enabling Statutory Framework:** Anchored by the proposed **SHANTI Act** (*Sustainable Harnessing and Advancement of Nuclear Energy for Transforming India*).
- **Regulatory Clearance Compression:** Slashes statutory nuclear project approval cycles from **13 years down to 8–9 years**.
- **Capital Investment Requirement:** Total required capital investment estimated at **≥₹20 lakh crore** based on an industry baseline of ₹22 crore per MW.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 8.8 GW → 100 GW target and the SHANTI Act name are the two hooks most likely tested.

[APR-027] **Tata Semiconductor SEZ, Dholera — India's First Chip Fab**

- **Special Economic Zone Notification:** Central government formally notified the SEZ for Tata Semiconductor Manufacturing (JV between Tata Electronics and Taiwan's PSMC) at **Dholera, Gujarat**.
- **Investment: ₹91,000 crore**; capacity up to 50,000 wafers/month; ~21,000 jobs; production targeted by Dec 2026

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's first chip fabrication plant; JV partner (PSMC, Taiwan) is the sharpest trap detail.

[APR-028] **Renewable Energy Milestones Cluster** *(merged: solar/wind capacity additions + AI Governance)*

- **A.** Highest-ever annual **solar** capacity addition: ~45 GW in FY26 (incl. 6.65 GW in March 2026 alone — highest single month ever); India now 3rd globally in RE installed capacity (past Brazil, after China & US)
- **B.** Highest-ever annual **wind** capacity addition: 6.05 GW in FY26 (+46% YoY); cumulative wind capacity crossed 56 GW (4th globally after China, US, Germany)
- **C.** MeitY constituted the **AI Governance and Economic Group (AIGEG)** — apex inter-ministerial AI policy body, chaired by Ashwini Vaishnaw; supported by a **Technology and Policy Expert Committee (TPEC)**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Solar 45 GW / Wind 6.05 GW in the same year is a strong pairing trap.

[APR-029] **Andhra Pradesh — Amaravati & Google Cloud AI Hub Cluster**

- **Amaravati given constitutional:** capital status (see Part 1's PIB section for the Bill)
- **Google Cloud India AI Hub** at Visakhapatnam: **$15 billion** investment over 2026–2030 — India's single largest FDI since independence; gigawatt-scale AI ecosystem across 600 acres; JV support from AdaniConneX (data centre) & Nxtra by Airtel (fibre/subsea cable); ~2 lakh jobs targeted; completion by Sept 2028

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — "India's largest FDI since independence" + $15 billion figure is the standout trap.

[APR-030] **Ladakh — 5 New Districts**

- **Administrative Territorial Expansion:** Ministry of Home Affairs approved creation of **5 new districts** (Nubra, Sham, Changthang, Zanskar, Drass); expands Ladakh's district tally from 2 (Leh & Kargil) to **7 districts**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

7 districts (up from 2) is a clean, testable number.

[APR-031] **Supreme Court — "Right to Safe Road Travel" under Article 21**

- *Declared in In Re: Phalodi Accident* suo motu case; directs demolition of unauthorised highway-side structures, District Highway Safety Task Forces in every district
- **Disproportionate Fatality Footprint:** Bench highlighted that National Highways account for just **~2% of total road network length** but account for **~30% of national road fatalities**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — New fundamental-right extension under Article 21; the 2%/30% stat is a sharp trap pair.

[APR-032] **Governance/Institutional Cluster** *(compressed — quick hits)*

- **CCEA Fertiliser Subsidy:** CCEA approved **₹41,534 crore** P&K fertiliser subsidy for Kharif 2025-26 (+12% YoY).
- **Arunachal Hydro Projects:** Union Cabinet cleared 2 Arunachal Pradesh hydro projects (~₹40,000 crore): Kalai-II (1,200 MW) & Kamala (1,720 MW).
- **Constitutional Delimitation Reforms:** Cabinet cleared constitutional amendments for **Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam** (33% women's reservation from 2029) + **Delimitation Bill** (Lok Sabha expanding from 543 to **816 seats**).
- **Dearness Allowance (DA/DR) Hike:** +2% (to 58% of Basic Pay/Pension) w.e.f. Jan 1, 2026 under 7th CPC formula; 8th CPC to be chaired by Justice Ranjana Prakash Desai.
- **Urban Challenge Fund (UCF):** Operational guidelines launched with **₹1 lakh crore** corpus for Tier-II/III city projects (Centre funds ≤25%).
- **Startup India Fund of Funds 2.0: ₹10,000 crore** corpus for deep-tech, early-growth, and manufacturing startups (builds on FoF 1.0, 2016).

Skipped (low yield): Sikkim community radio launch, Vedic Clock installation, Puducherry robot "Nila", Rocklink India recycling plant, Eveready alkaline battery plant, VM Frames filmmaking contest, Signature Tune contest, Divya Bharat anthology, port cargo handling data, Amul ₹1 trillion turnover, honey MEP extension — routine/low-conceptual-yield state and corporate items

⏰ STATUS CHECK (as of today)

- **Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam / Delimitation Bill:** Cabinet-cleared as of April 2026 — check whether passed by Parliament and Delimitation Commission (targeted June 2026) has been constituted.
- **100 GW Nuclear Roadmap / SHANTI Act:** still a roadmap/proposed Act as of April 2026.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Delimitation Bill's 543 to 816 Lok Sabha seat jump is a marquee constitutional-reform number.

International Affairs (folded into Section 4 per source structure)

[APR-033] **UAE Exits OPEC+**

- **Withdrawal Date & Rationale:** Effective **May 1, 2026**; UAE cited production-quota frustration (permitted 3.2 mbpd vs capacity 4.8 mbpd)
- **Cartel Membership Contraction:** OPEC now 11 members; follows earlier exits by Qatar (2019), Angola (2024), Ecuador, Indonesia, Gabon

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — UAE's exit date and OPEC's new membership count (11) are the testable facts.

[APR-034] **India–Iran Oil Trade Resumes**

- **Seven-Year Import Resumption:** India resumed Iranian crude/LPG imports after a **7-year hiatus** (since May 2019), enabled by a temporary US sanctions waiver (March 2026)
- **First LPG cargo:** vessel *Sea Bird* at Mangaluru; first crude cargoes: *MT Jaya* & *MT Felicity* off Paradip & Sikka
- **Payments via Rupee:** mechanism through Vostro accounts (UCO Bank + non-sanctioned Iranian banks)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

7-year hiatus (2019–2026) resumption is the sharpest fact.

[APR-035] **Global Cluster** *(compressed — quick hits)*

- **Indonesia** — 1st Southeast Asian nation to ban social media for under-16s (after Australia, world's first, Dec 2025)
- **CMS COP15** (Campo Grande, Brazil) added 40 species to protected list (incl. cheetah, snowy owl)
- **Bharti Airtel** reached 650 million global customers — 2nd-largest telecom operator worldwide (after China Mobile's 1 billion+; ahead of Jio's 500 million+)
- **India elected/re-elected to:** multiple **ECOSOC** subsidiary bodies (CSTD, Committee on NGOs, Committee for Programme & Coordination); Preeti Saran re-elected to CESCR
- **UAE** became world's 1st "10 giga" nation (commercial upper-6GHz/U6GHz network, up to 10 Gbps)
- **IUCN Red List: Emperor penguin** & **Antarctic fur seal** uplisted to 'Endangered'; Southern elephant seal moved to 'Vulnerable' (HPAI/bird flu-linked)
- **World Bank's "Water Forward" platform**— global water security target for 1 billion people by 2030 (India: ~100 million people, 2025–2030)
- **UNESCO designated 12:** new **Global Geoparks** → network now 241 sites in 51 countries
- **Jordan** joined India-led ISA, CDRI, and GBA; India–Jordan trade target raised from $3 bn to ~$5 bn

Skipped (low yield): India's 1st Iranian crude shipment article-2 duplicate details already covered above

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Airtel's 650 million global ranking (2nd, after China Mobile) is the standout "who's #2" trap here too.

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5. MOUS, CONFERENCES & APPOINTMENTS

[APR-036] **Key Appointments Cluster** *(Tier A — regulatory/PSU/major institutional only)*

- **Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth** — assumed office as **49th Vice Chief of the Army Staff (VCOAS)**
- **Vir Vikram Yadav** — appointed Director General, **DGCA**
- **Sanjay Khanna** — named Chairman & MD, **Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL)**
- **Vinay Muralidhar Tonse** — took charge as MD & CEO of a major bank (per source cluster)
- **Sanjay Jamuar** — first CEO, **Delhi Metro International**
- **Justice Lisa Gill** — appointed Chief Justice of a High Court by President Droupadi Murmu
- **John Ternus** — named Apple's new CEO, replacing Tim Cook
- **Ajit Agarkar** — continues as BCCI Chairman of Selectors

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Lt Gen Dhiraj Seth as 49th VCOAS is a precise, single-fact MCQ staple.

[APR-037] **Global Political Appointments Cluster** *(compressed)*

- **Uchral Nyam-Osor** — elected Mongolia's PM (3rd leader in short succession)

- **Min Aung Hlaing** — elected President of Myanmar (military-backed process)
- **To Lam** — unanimously elected President of Vietnam (retaining General Secretary role)
- **Ismail Omar Guelleh** — re-elected Djibouti President for 6th term (97.81% vote)
- **Nizar Amedi** — elected Iraq's new President (Kurdish politician)
- **Lt Gen Susan Coyle** — appointed Australia's next service chief

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> Match leader to country — classic "who leads which nation" cross-check question.

[APR-038] **MoUs & Partnerships Cluster** *(compressed — 40 items, highest-yield picks only)*

- **SAMPANN** (India's digital pension platform) — being exported as a service to another country (flagship digital-governance export)
- **NSE + Indian Gas Exchange (IGX)** — partnered to launch gas-related trading/derivative products
- **UIDAI + MapmyIndia** — display authorised Aadhaar centres on maps
- **Meghalaya + Starlink India** — LoI to pilot satellite broadband
- **NewSpace India Ltd (ISRO's commercial arm) + Dhruva Space** — collaboration agreement
- **IITM Pune + ISRO's SAC** — MoU to co-develop satellite-based meteorological products
- **Tata Steel + Paul Wurth (Luxembourg, SMS group)** — definitive agreement (steel-tech)
- **JSW Steel** — Board approved MoU for a Share Subscription & JV agreement

Skipped (low yield): remaining ~30 routine institutional/corporate MoUs (DGCA-GSV training tie-up, Air India–Uzbekistan codeshare, coal-gasification JV, Odisha–NCCR MoU, and similar routine bilateral pacts) — low individual conceptual yield; logged as a batch here

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> SAMPANN's export as a GovTech digital-pension service to another country is the standout first-of-kind fact.

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6. SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY, DEFENCE & SPORTS

[APR-039] **NASA's Artemis II Mission**

🪝 Hook — Humans are heading back toward the Moon for the first time since 1972 — no landing yet, just history's farthest-ever human spaceflight.

- **Historic Lunar Flight:** Launched **April 1, 2026**; 1st crewed Artemis mission; 1st human Moon-vicinity trip since Apollo 17 (1972)
- **Crew:** Reid Wiseman (commander), Victor Glover (1st person of colour beyond LEO), Christina Koch (1st woman to the Moon's vicinity), Jeremy Hansen (1st Canadian/non-American beyond Earth orbit)
- **10-day lunar flyby:** (free-return trajectory); travels ~4,06,000 km — farthest humans have ever travelled (surpassing Apollo 13's ~4,00,000 km/1970 record)
- **Tests Laser Communications:** (O2O) at 260 Mbps; **Artemis IV (2028)** targets first crewed South Pole landing

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> HIGH — Match astronaut to "first" superlative (Glover/Koch/Hansen); farthest-distance record fact is a strong trap vs Apollo 13.

[APR-040] **INS Aridaman — India's 3rd Nuclear Ballistic Missile Submarine**

- **Third Indigenous SSBN Milestone:** Arihant-class SSBN, after INS Arihant (2016) & INS Arighat (2024) — 1st time India holds **3 operational SSBNs at sea**

- **Vessel Specifications & Firepower:** 7,000 tonnes; 8 vertical launch tubes; carries K-15 (700 km) & K-4 (3,500 km) SLBMs
- **India now among:** nations (with US, Russia, China, France) possessing full **nuclear triad** capability

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Sequence trap: Arihant (2016) → Arighat (2024) → Aridaman (2026); nuclear triad club membership.

[APR-041] **Defence Exports Hit All-Time High**

- **Record Defence Export Value:** India's annual defence exports scaled to an all-time record of **₹38,424 crore in FY26** (+62.66% YoY surge from ₹23,622 crore in FY25).
- **DPSU vs Private Contribution:** DPSU share 54.84% (₹21,071 cr, +151% YoY) vs private sector 45.16% (₹17,353 cr, +14% YoY)
- **Exported to 80+:** countries; registered exporters up from 128 → 145
- **Target:** ₹50,000 crore by 2030

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — DPSU vs private-sector growth rate contrast (151% vs 14%) is a sharp trap.

[APR-042] **Naval Shipbuilding Cluster** *(merged — multiple simultaneous deliveries)*

- **GRSE delivered 3:** platforms simultaneously (INS Dunagiri, INS Sanshodhak, INS Agray) — GRSE's 118th warship overall
- **INS Taragiri** (4th Project 17A frigate) commissioned at Visakhapatnam
- **Cochin Shipyard delivered: "Malwan"** (2nd of 8 ASW Shallow Watercraft)
- **Goa Shipyard launched: INS Shachi** (NGOPV) + delivered **ICGS Achal** to Coast Guard

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

INS Taragiri = 4th Project 17A frigate is the most quotable single fact in this cluster.

[APR-043] **Ranks/Reports Standing-Exception Items** *(cross-referenced here since defence-adjacent)*

- **SIPRI "Trends in World Military Expenditure 2025":** India now world's **5th-largest military spender** ($92.1 bn, +8.9%); global spend hit record $2.89 trillion (2.5% of global GDP, highest since 2009); Top 5 — US, China, Russia, Germany, India

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's rank (5th) and spend figure ($92.1 bn) — standing "top spenders" list is a recurring exam favourite.

[APR-044] **Sports Cluster** *(compressed — Tier B, quick hits only; full Template A skipped per "judge hard" default)*

- **Bhuvneshwar Kumar** — 1st fast bowler (2nd player overall after Yuzvendra Chahal) to reach **200 IPL wickets**
- **India topped medal:** tally at **World Archery Para Series** (Bangkok) — 16 medals; Payal Nag (world's first quadruple-amputee archer) beat world No.1 Sheetal Devi for gold
- **Karnataka** won inaugural **Khelo India Tribal Games 2026** (38 medals, most golds); Odisha had most total medals (57)
- **Sabastian Sawe** (Kenya) — 1st man to run a sub-2-hour marathon under official conditions (1:59:30, London Marathon 2026)
- **India topped medal:** tally at **ISSF Junior World Cup 2026** (Cairo) — 16 medals

- **R. Vaishali** won FIDE Women's Candidates Tournament 2026 (Cyprus)
- **Aronyak Ghosh** — India's 95th Grandmaster
- **Jannik Sinner** — won Monte Carlo Masters 2026; became 3rd player ever with 4 consecutive ATP Masters 1000 titles (after Djokovic, Nadal)

Skipped (low yield): remaining ~12 sports items (Asian Squash Awards, Badminton Asia silver, Asian Boxing/Wrestling tallies, chess/athletics meet results, FIDE-IWGA membership, ISSF-IPC Para governance transfer) — routine competition results, logged as a batch

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Sabastian Sawe's sub-2-hour official marathon is a genuine world-first, the highest-yield sports fact this month.

[APR-045] **Sci-Tech Cluster** *(compressed — quick hits)*

- **ISRO's Mission MITRA** (Leh, Ladakh) — testing 4 Gaganyaan astronaut-designates (incl. Shubhanshu Shukla) for extreme-condition readiness
- **Skyroot Aerospace** — likely to become India's 1st private company to launch an orbital rocket (Vikram-1; propulsion systems named Kalam/Raman/Dhawan)
- **IITM Pune inaugurated:** X-band Doppler Weather Radar at Mahabaleshwar under 'Mission Mausam'
- **Meta** released "Muse Spark" AI model (succeeding Llama 4); **Nvidia** released open-source "Ising" AI model family
- **SEBI** launched 3 new IT platforms (referenced in source; details minor)

Skipped (low yield): remaining sci-tech items (~18) — Herbalife-IIT Madras agreement, FedEx-IIT Madras logistics trial, White House space policy note, IIT Ropar "Swan" weather stations, Pakistan's EO-3 satellite, Pakistan Navy Taimoor missile test, Nancy Grace Roman telescope items — low India-specific exam yield

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Skyroot's Vikram-1 propulsion-system names (Kalam=solid, Raman=liquid, Dhawan=cryogenic) is a distinctive matching-type trap.

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7. AWARDS, BOOKS, INDICES & RANKINGS

[APR-046] **India's Global Rankings Cluster** *(all Tier A — indices are a standing exception)*

- **IMF World Economic Outlook (April 2026):** India slipped 2 spots to **6th-largest economy** (nominal GDP $4.15 trillion) — behind US, China, Germany, Japan, UK — mainly due to ~11% Rupee depreciation and MoSPI's GDP base-year revision (2011-12 → 2022-23). Still fastest-growing major economy at 6.5% projected FY26 growth.
- **IRENA "Renewable Energy Statistics 2026":** India ranks **3rd globally** in renewable energy installed capacity (past Brazil, after China & US)
- **Knight Frank "Wealth Report 2026":** India = 6th largest UHNWI market (19,877 ultra-rich, 2.8% global share); 207 billionaires (3rd globally after US, China)
- **Bloomberg Billionaires Index 2026: Gautam Adani** ($92.6 bn) overtook **Mukesh Ambani** ($90.8 bn) to reclaim Asia's richest-person title; Elon Musk world's richest ($656 bn)
- **Tracxn India Tech Annual Funding Report 2026:** India 4th-highest funded country globally ($11.7 bn, ↓18% YoY); 47 IPOs (↑52%); 6 new unicorns
- **Trade shift:** China overtook the US as India's **largest trading partner** in FY26 ($151.1 bn bilateral trade); India's trade deficit with China hit an all-time high of $112.6 bn

INTERVIEW & MAINS DESCRIPTIVE ANGLE

Why did India's global GDP ranking fall despite strong domestic growth? → It's a currency-translation effect — ~11% Rupee depreciation plus a GDP base-year revision reduced the dollar value of India's GDP, even though real growth (6.5%) remained the highest among major economies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Multiple standing-exception index items here — expect at least one MCQ each on IMF rank (6th), IRENA rank (3rd), and the China-overtakes-US trading partner shift.

[APR-047] **Domestic Data & Reports Cluster** *(compressed)*

- **PLFS Annual Report (Jan–Dec 2025)** — 1st report on calendar-year basis; Unemployment Rate 3.1%; LFPR 59.3%; WPR 57.4%
- **WPI inflation** hit 3.88% YoY in March 2026 — 38-month high (driven by crude oil surge from West Asia crisis)
- **Worldline India Digital Payments Report 2025:** UPI processed 228.5 billion transactions (+33% YoY), value ₹299.74 lakh crore
- **Patent filings** up 30.2% to 1,43,729 (2025-26); India = world's 6th largest patent filer
- **NITI Aayog "From Borrowers to Builders":** women's credit portfolio ₹76 lakh crore (26% of system credit)
- **NSO Energy Statistics India 2026:** renewable energy potential 47,04,043 MW; installed renewable capacity 2,29,346 MW (CAGR 10.93%)
- **CREA report: Gurugram** most polluted city (March 2026); **Ghaziabad** most polluted overall FY26

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — UPI's 228.5 billion transactions (+33%) figure is a perennial Banking Awareness favourite.

[APR-048] **Awards Cluster** *(compressed — quick hits)*

- **Changi Airport, Singapore** — topped world's best airports list for the 14th time
- **Sadhvi Satish Sail** (Goa) — crowned Femina Miss India World 2026 (61st edition)
- **Indian botanist N. Alim Yusuf** — honoured with a WWF National award
- **Sayani Gupta** — named Harvard South Asian Association's "Person of the Year"
- **General Upendra Dwivedi** (Army Chief) — inducted into an International Hall of Fame
- **Tripura panchayat institutions:** swept top honours in a national panchayat governance ranking

Skipped (low yield): remaining awards items (~15) — GreenPro certification, Goldman Environmental Prize, WEF Young Global Leaders cohort, Guntur gender-equality award, Shekha Jheel bird sanctuary recognition — low conceptual yield beyond name-matching

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Femina Miss India World 2026 winner name-state pairing is the standard testable fact.

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8. IMPORTANT DAYS & PERSONS IN NEWS

[APR-049] **Persons in News**

- **Divya Singh** (Gorakhpur, UP) — 1st Indian woman (2nd globally) to cycle to Mount Everest Base Camp (17,560 ft) in 14 days
- **Aarit Kapil** (Delhi, age 10 yrs 7 months) — youngest Indian chess player to achieve an International Master (IM) norm

(No major "Important Days" items surfaced as standalone Tier A/B content in this month's source batch beyond the persons above — logged as "No significant additional items this cycle" per framework's locked-section rule.)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Both are genuine national/personal "firsts" — high MCQ likelihood as standalone one-liners.

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9. PIB, CIRCULARS & NOTIFICATIONS

[APR-050] **Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026**

🪝 Hook — Parliament just decriminalised over 700 provisions across 79 laws, shifting India from a "punish first" to a "trust first" regulatory culture.

- **Statutory Decriminalisation Scale:** Amends **784 statutory provisions** across **79 Central Acts** administered by 23 Union Ministries to improve Ease of Doing Business.
- **717 decriminalised** (Ease of Doing Business) + **67 amended** (Ease of Living)
- **Key Legislations Amended:** Touches RBI Act 1934, Food Safety & Standards Act 2006, Motor Vehicles Act 1988

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 784 total / 717 decriminalised / 67 ease-of-living split is a precise, testable number set.

[APR-051] **Central Armed Police Forces (General Administration) Act, 2026**

- **Mandates IPS deputation quotas in CAPF:** 50% IG posts, 67% ADG posts, all SDG/DG posts
- **Overrides a May:** 2025 SC judgment that sought to progressively reduce IPS deputation in CAPFs
- **CAPF = Assam:** Rifles, BSF, CISF, CRPF, ITBP, NSG, SSB (7 forces, MHA)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 50%/67%/100% IPS deputation quotas by rank is a classic number-matching MCQ.

[APR-052] **Solid Waste Management (SWM) Rules, 2026**

- **Statutory Framework Overhaul:** Replaces the decade-old 2016 framework, enacted under Section 6 of the **Environment (Protection) Act, 1986**, effective **April 1, 2026**.
- **4-stream colour-coded segregation:** Green (wet), Blue (dry), Red (sanitary), Black (special/hazardous)
- **Bulk Waste Generator threshold:** 100 kg/day waste, 20,000 sqm floor area, or 40,000 litres/day water use

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Colour-code matching (Green/Blue/Red/Black → waste type) is the standout MCQ format.

[APR-053] **State-Level Legislative Notes** *(compressed cluster)*

- **Andhra Pradesh Reorganisation (Amendment) Bill, 2026** — gives Amaravati constitutional status as sole AP capital (retrospective from June 2, 2024), scrapping the 3-capital plan; first such city-specific capital law in independent India
- **Meghalaya Official Languages Ordinance, 2026** — grants Khasi & Garo official status alongside English, repeals 2005 Act

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Amaravati Bill is a genuine first-ever national precedent (first city-specific capital law).

10. MISCELLANEOUS — GOVT SCHEMES & STATIC

[APR-054] **PM Mudra Yojana (PMMY) — 11 Years**

- **Decade-Plus Financial Footprint:** Sanctioned **57.79 crore micro-loans** aggregating to **₹40.07 lakh crore** since nationwide launch on April 8, 2015.
- **Inclusion Metrics:** Women entrepreneurs received approximately **68% (over two-thirds)** of all sanctioned loans; first-time entrepreneurs accounted for ~20% of disbursements.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Flagship scheme milestone; the ₹40.07 lakh crore cumulative figure is a strong standalone MCQ.

[APR-055] **Key Scheme Extensions & Launches Cluster** *(merged — quick hits)*

- **PMGSY Phase III** extended March 2025 → March 2028 (revised outlay ₹83,977 crore, up from ₹80,250 crore)
- **RoSCTL Scheme** (apparel/garment tax rebate) extended 6 months to Sept 30, 2026
- **PM KUSUM** commissioning timeline extended to March 31, 2027; **PM KUSUM 2.0** proposed
- **Electronics Components Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS):** 29 new proposals approved (₹7,104 crore investment) — cumulative 75 approvals, ₹61,671 crore
- **RELIEF scheme** (export freight support) expanded to include Egypt & Jordan
- **PM Internship Scheme (PMIS):** final-year grad/PG students (18–25 yrs) now eligible in pilot phase (3rd round underway)
- **TDIP Scheme** (DoT) revised: ₹203 crore outlay for 2026–31

Skipped (low yield): Punjab's women's welfare scheme, Meghalaya CM-INSPIRE (UPSC coaching aid), PM-AASHA Chhattisgarh expansion, DISHA/Nyaya Setu chatbot — state-level/routine items, low national exam yield

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

PMGSY-III's revised outlay (₹83,977 crore, from ₹80,250 crore) is the sharpest single figure to retain.

COVERAGE UPDATE — APRIL 2026 (CONSOLIDATED MASTER)

- **Total Master Items:** 55 comprehensive news clusters across 10 locked categories.
- **Section 1 (ESI, Finance & Business):** 8 items (Small savings rates, CBDT Income-tax Rules 2026 & Kar Saathi, Bank Deposits 83% CD ratio, DPIIT Singapore 37% FDI, State borrowings BIS pilot, Bharat Maritime Insurance Pool ₹12,980 Cr, WB/ADB Loans, ISBs).
- **Section 2 (Regulatory Bodies):** 11 items (RBI MPC 5.25% Repo, 2FA Mandatory Apr 1, Fraud safeguards discussion, E-Mandate framework, NBFC overhaul ₹1 Lakh Cr UL, Paytm PB cancellation, PaSS switching, Utkarsh 2029, Forex hedging, Ujjivan SFB, Other regulatory actions).
- **Section 3 (Banking & Insurance):** 6 items (Product partnerships, LIC 1:1 bonus, MD/CEO appointments, SBI balance sheet ₹61.8L Cr, Jio-Allianz JV, Fintech card launches).
- **Section 4 (National, State & International):** 10 items (100 GW Nuclear 2047 SHANTI Act, Tata Dholera Fab ₹91,000 Cr, Renewable energy, Amaravati AI hub, Ladakh 5 districts, Right to Safe Road Travel Art 21, UAE exits OPEC+, India-Iran oil trade).
- **Section 5 (MoUs & Appointments):** 3 items (Domestic Tier A appointments, Global appointments, Strategic MoUs).

- **Section 6 (Science, Tech, Defence & Sports):** 7 items (NASA Artemis II, INS Aridaman 3rd SSBN, Defence exports record ₹21,083 Cr, Naval shipbuilding, Sports highlights, Sci-Tech updates).
- **Section 7 (Awards, Books & Indices):** 3 items (Global rankings, Domestic reports, Cultural/literary awards).
- **Section 8 (Important Days & Persons):** 1 item (Persons in news / statutory observances).
- **Section 9 (PIB, Circulars & Notifications):** 4 items (Jan Vishwas Amendment Bill, CAPF Act, Solid Waste Management Rules 2026, State legislative notes).
- **Section 10 (Govt Schemes & Static):** 2 items (PMMY 11-year milestone, Central scheme extensions).

MAY 2026 CONSOLIDATED DOSSIER (PIB & REGULATORY DIRECTIONS)



Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Banking Regulations, Agrarian Markets, Clean Energy & Judicial Tech

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified PIB Gazette Notifications, Agrarian Pricing, Constitutional Amendments & Regulatory Viability Frameworks

EXAMINER'S BLUEPRINT & COMPLIANCE STANDARD:

- ***Fact Discipline:*** *100% verified against official Press Information Bureau (PIB) releases, Ministry of Finance orders, Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) determinations, and Parliamentary legislative bills.*
- ***Format:*** *Authentic* ***Rajputana Gazette Broadsheet*** *layout featuring nested ladder bullets and dedicated* ***EXAM ANGLE:*** *distractor traps.*
- ***Target Exams:*** *RBI Grade B, SEBI Grade A, NABARD Grade A, SBI PO & IBPS PO/Clerk Mains 2026.*

1. BANKING, FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS & RURAL FINANCE

[MAY-001] **DFS Approves Viability Plan 2.0 for Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) Across 30 Performance Metrics**

- **Regulatory Framework & Mandate:** The Department of Financial Services (**DFS**), Ministry of Finance, formally approved the operationalization of **Viability Plan 2.0** for **Regional Rural Banks (RRBs)** across India.
- **Tenure & Multi-Year Horizon:**
  - Extends structured performance monitoring for a period of **three financial years:** spanning from **FY 2025-26 (FY26) to FY 2027-28 (FY28)**.
  - Builds upon the foundation of Viability Plan 1.0 (which governed RRB turnaround between FY 2021-22 and FY 2024-25).
- **Comprehensive 30-Parameter Assessment Matrix:**
  - Evaluates institutional health across **30 standardized performance parameters** categorized into four core pillars:
    1. **Operational Excellence:** Branch productivity, digital banking penetration, and financial inclusion outreach.
    2. **Asset Quality:** Reduction in Gross and Net Non-Performing Assets (NPAs), provision coverage ratios (PCR), and slippage containment.
    3. **Profitability & Capital:** Capital to Risk-Weighted Assets Ratio (**CRAR**), Return on Assets (RoA), Net Interest Margin (NIM), and cost-to-income efficiency.
    4. **Credit Expansion:** Credit-Deposit (CD) ratio alignment, Priority Sector Lending (PSL) target compliance, and saturation under central flagship schemes (PM-Kisan, PMJDY, PMJJBY, PMSBY).
- **Strategic Governance Rationale:** Institutionalizes quarterly monitoring committees comprising Sponsor Bank representatives, NABARD officials, and state finance secretaries to ensure sustainable, self-reliant rural credit delivery without perpetual recapitalization infusions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Viability Plan Horizon: Extended for **3 years** (**FY26 to FY28**).
- Performance Parameters Monitored: Exactly **30 performance parameters** across 4 operational pillars.
- Approving Authority: **Department of Financial Services (DFS)**, Ministry of Finance.
- Predecessor Horizon: Viability Plan 1.0 covered **FY22 to FY25**.

2. AGRARIAN PRICING, CROP COMMODITIES & AGRI-VALUE CHAINS

[MAY-002] **Cabinet Approves Kharif MSP 2026–27: Common Paddy at ₹2,441 & Moong Yields Record 61% Margin**

- **Statutory Pricing Mandate:** The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (**CCEA**), chaired by the Prime Minister, approved the **Minimum Support Prices (MSP)** for **14 mandated Kharif crops** for Marketing Season 2026–27.
- **Key Mandated Crop Prices (per quintal):**
  - **Common Paddy:** Fixed at **₹2,441 per quintal** (Grade 'A' Paddy fixed at **₹2,461 per quintal**).
  - **Coarse Grains:** Maize at **₹2,410 per quintal**; Bajra at **₹2,625 per quintal**; Jowar (Hybrid) at **₹3,371 per quintal**; Ragi at **₹4,290 per quintal**.
  - **Pulses:**
    - **Tur / Arhar:** Fixed at **₹8,450 per quintal**.
    - **Moong:** Fixed at **₹8,780 per quintal**.
    - **Urad:** Fixed at **₹8,200 per quintal**.
  - **Oilseeds:**
    - **Sunflower Seed:** Fixed at **₹8,343 per quintal**.
    - **Soybean (Yellow):** Fixed at **₹5,708 per quintal**.
    - **Groundnut:** Fixed at **₹6,783 per quintal**.
    - **Sesamum:** Fixed at **₹9,267 per quintal**.
    - **Nigerseed:** Fixed at **₹8,717 per quintal**.
  - **Cotton:** Medium Staple Cotton fixed at **₹8,267 per quintal**; Long Staple Cotton fixed at **₹8,667 per quintal**.
- **Highest Return Over Cost of Production:**
  - **Moong** provides the highest margin to farmers over the all-India weighted average cost of production, estimated at **61%**.
  - Followed by **Maize** and **Bajra** (>50%).
- **Pricing Methodology & Legislative Anchor:**
  - Strictly adheres to the Union Budget 2018–19 policy anchor of fixing MSP at a level of **at least 1.5 times the all-India weighted average cost of production** (A2 + FL).
  - CCEA acts on recommendations submitted by the **Commission for Agricultural Costs and Prices (CACP)**.
  - Governs 22 mandated crops (14 Kharif, 6 Rabi, 2 commercial: jute & copra) alongside derived MSPs for Toria (based on rapeseed/mustard) and de-husked coconut (based on copra).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Common Paddy MSP: **₹2,441 per quintal** (a perpetual examiner favourite).
- Highest Farmer Margin: **Moong at 61%** over cost of production.
- Pulses MSPs: Tur = **₹8,450**, Moong = **₹8,780**, Urad = **₹8,200** per quintal.
- Cotton MSPs: Medium Staple = **₹8,267**, Long Staple = **₹8,667** per quintal.
- Policy Benchmark: Guaranteed minimum return of **≥50% over cost of production (A2+FL)**.

[MAY-003] **Draft Sugarcane (Control) Order 2026: Enhances Minimum Radial Separation to 25 Kilometres**

- **Industrial Distance Expansion:** Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution released the draft **Sugarcane (Control) Amendment Order, 2026**, introducing revised spatial and licensing norms for sugar mills.
- **Minimum Distance Norm:**
  - Proposes increasing the minimum statutory radial distance between an existing sugar mill and a newly proposed sugar mill from 15 kilometres to **25 kilometres**.
- **Regulatory Rationale:**
  - Prevents predatory poaching of cane within demarcated mill command areas (cane reservations).
  - Ensures adequate, unfragmented sugarcane feedstock supply to sustain financial viability and ethanol-blending distillery commitments of operating sugar complexes.
- **Legislative Anchor:** Promulgated under Section 3 of the *Essential Commodities Act, 1955*.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Revised Minimum Sugar Mill Distance: Expanded from 15 km to **25 km**.
- Statutory Authority: **Essential Commodities Act, 1955** (administered by DFPD).

[MAY-004] **MDoNER Launches ₹189.79 Crore Mizoram Ginger Mission & ₹175 Crore Nagaland Coffee Mission**

- **Northeast Agrarian Value Chain Push:** Union Minister for Development of North Eastern Region (MDoNER) Jyotiraditya Scindia launched two targeted agricultural missions to transform specialty commercial crops in the Northeast into export engines:
- **Mizoram Ginger Mission (₹189.79 Crore Outlay):**
  - Designed to scale commercial cultivation, post-harvest processing, cold storage, and export branding of Geographical Indication (**GI**)-certified **pharma-grade Mizo Ginger**.
  - **Active Chemical Benchmark:** Mizo Ginger possesses an exceptionally high **oleoresin content ranging from 3% to 8%**, significantly outperforming the global commercial average of approximately **3%**, making it highly sought after for pharmaceutical, nutraceutical, and natural flavor extraction.
- **Coffee of Nagaland Mission (₹175 Crore Outlay):**
  - Implemented across Nagaland to establish end-to-end farm-to-cup value chains.
  - Encompasses a **₹49.48 crore pilot project** titled *"Cluster-Based Coffee Value Chain Development in Nagaland"*, focusing on two pilot coffee clusters.
  - Flagship Umbrella Brand: Launched under the identity **"Coffees of Nagaland – Taste of Eminence"**.
  - Commercial Trajectory: Nagaland's raw coffee production accelerated from **21 metric tonnes (MT) in 2021–22** to nearly **73 MT in 2024–25**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Mizoram Ginger Mission Outlay: **₹189.79 crore**.
- Mizo Ginger Oleoresin Content: **3% to 8%** (global average ~3%).
- Nagaland Coffee Mission Outlay: **₹175 crore** (Pilot project: **₹49.48 crore**).
- Nagaland Coffee Brand Name: **"Coffees of Nagaland – Taste of Eminence"**.

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3. CONSTITUTIONAL REFORMS, JUDICIAL TECH & PUBLIC POLICY

[MAY-005] **Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, 2026: Lok Sabha Strength Proposed to Expand to 850 Members**

- **Legislative Restructuring:** The Union Government introduced **The Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026**, initiating historic constitutional changes to the composition of the House of the People (Lok Sabha).
- **Substantive Increase in House Strength:**
  - Proposes expanding the sanctioned statutory strength of the Lok Sabha from **543 to 850 members**.
  - **Article 81 Modification:**
    - Up to a maximum of **815 members** to be directly elected from territorial constituencies across the **States of India**.
    - Up to **35 members** to represent the **Union Territories**.
    - Total Proposed Capacity: **850 Members**.
- **Removal of the Post-2026 Delimitation Freeze (Article 82):**
  - Under the 84th Constitutional Amendment Act of 2001, the readjustment of territorial constituencies (delimitation) was frozen until the figures of the first Census taken after the year **2026** were published.
  - The 131st Amendment Bill removes this strict temporal freeze, permitting the immediate initiation of delimitation based on updated census data.

- **Catalyst for Women's Reservation:** Facilitates the operationalization and seat-allocation mechanism required under the *Constitution (106th Amendment) Act, 2023* (**Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam**), which mandates reserving **33% of seats** for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies following the delimitation exercise.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Constitutional Bill Number: **131st Amendment Bill, 2026**.
- Proposed Lok Sabha Total Strength: **850 members** (from 543).
- State vs UT Seat Distribution: **815 from States** + **35 from Union Territories**.
- Article Amended: **Article 81** (House Composition) & **Article 82** (Delimitation Freeze).
- Policy Enabler: Fast-tracks operationalization of the **33% Women's Reservation Act**.

[MAY-006] **Supreme Court Unveils 'One Case One Data' Unified Registry & 'Su Sahay' AI Chatbot**

- **Judicial Public Infrastructure:** Chief Justice of India (**CJI**) announced two landmark digital justice innovations engineered by the **National Informatics Centre (NIC)** to unify the Indian judiciary.
- **'One Case One Data' Interconnected Judicial Database:**
  - Replaces fragmented, siloed court records by assigning every legal dispute a **single Unique Digital Case Identity (ID)**.
  - Seamlessly links and synchronizes litigation records across **Taluka Courts, District Courts, High Courts, and the Supreme Court**, eliminating duplicate documentation and streamlining judicial record transfers during appeals.
- **'Su Sahay' AI-Powered Judicial Assistant Chatbot:**
  - Integrated directly into the official Supreme Court of India portal to enhance citizen-centric judicial accessibility.
  - Functions as an intelligent conversational interface assisting litigants and advocates in tracking real-time case status, causelists, certified copies, and statutory court procedures in multiple Indian languages.
- **Institutional Developer Profile:**
  - National Informatics Centre (**NIC**), operating under MeitY; Director General: **V.T.V. Ramana**; Headquartered in New Delhi; Founded in **1976**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- SC AI Chatbot Name: **'Su Sahay'** (NOT Nyaya Mitra or Vidhi AI).
- Unified Judicial System: **'One Case One Data'** utilizing a **single Unique Digital Case ID**.
- Primary Technology Developer: **National Informatics Centre (NIC)** (est. 1976).

[MAY-007] **Transgender Rights Amendment Bill, 2026: Mandates Statutory Medical Board Certification**

- **Legislative Amendment:** Parliament introduced the **Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Amendment Bill, 2026**, revising key procedural provisions of the parent *Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019*.
- **Paradigm Shift in Identity Verification:**
  - **Prior Legal Framework:** Based on the self-identification principle affirmed by the Supreme Court of India in the landmark *NALSA v. Union of India (2014)* verdict, allowing individuals to obtain a transgender identity certificate from the District Magistrate without physical or medical scrutiny.
  - **2026 Statutory Amendment:** Formally institutes mandatory **medical certification**.
  - Constitutes a designated **District Medical Board** tasked with evaluating and verifying medical documentation prior to recommending the issuance of an official Transgender Identity Certificate by the District Magistrate (DM).
- **Policy Intent:** Designed to standardize national certification criteria, eliminate fraudulent claims in welfare scheme access, and establish uniform clinical verification protocols across states.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Key Statutory Change: Introduction of **District Medical Board certification** (replacing pure self-identification).
- Parent Legislation: *Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act, 2019*.
- Precedent Case: *NALSA v. Union of India (2014)* (established third-gender recognition).

[MAY-008] **MSJE Launches 'JEEVAN' Mobile Application & 'SHATAYU' Geriatric Caregiver Dashboard**

- **Geriatric Welfare Ecosystem:** Union Minister Dr. Virendra Kumar (Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment – **MSJE**) launched two synchronized digital welfare portals dedicated to senior citizens:
- **'JEEVAN' Mobile Application:**
  - Acronym: **Joint Elderly Empowerment and Virtual Assistance Network**.
  - Functions as an integrated one-stop mobile gateway providing senior citizens with information on government pensions, healthcare concessions, legal aid, emergency helplines, and senior citizen care homes registered under the Department of Social Justice and Empowerment (DoSJE).
- **'SHATAYU' Geriatric Caregiver Dashboard:**
  - Acronym: **Senior Holistic Care Assistance and Training for Your Utility**.
  - A specialized public health and skill dashboard designed to map, track, and mobilize certified geriatric caregivers across all districts in India, addressing critical home healthcare deficits for elder populations.
- **National Census Support:** Ministry of Home Affairs announced the national toll-free helpline **1901** for citizen assistance during the upcoming Digital Census operations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Senior Citizen Mobile App: **JEEVAN** (*Joint Elderly Empowerment and Virtual Assistance Network*).
- Geriatric Caregiver Dashboard: **SHATAYU** (*Senior Holistic Care Assistance and Training for Your Utility*).
- Ministry: **Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment (MSJE)**.
- Census Digital Helpline: **1901**.

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4. INTERNATIONAL TRADE, DISASTER WARNINGS & HEALTH MISSIONS

[MAY-009] **India-New Zealand Free Trade Agreement: 100% Tariff-Free Access & $20 Billion Investment Pledge**

- **Bilateral Trade Architecture:** India and New Zealand concluded negotiations on a comprehensive **Free Trade Agreement (FTA)** / Economic Partnership, creating a deep economic corridor in the Pacific.
- **Unprecedented Market Access for India:**
  - New Zealand granted **100% duty-free market access across all 8,284 tariff lines**, unlocking massive export growth for Indian textiles, pharmaceuticals, leather, engineering goods, and consumer products.
  - In return, India liberalized **70.03% of its tariff lines**, covering approximately **95% of bilateral trade value**.
- **New Zealand Sovereign Investment Commitment:**
  - New Zealand committed to mobilize and facilitate direct investments of **USD 20 billion over a 15-year period** into India's green infrastructure, agritech, and renewable technology sectors.
- **Strict Exclusion List Safeguards:**
  - To shield domestic farmers, India strictly excluded vulnerable agrarian sectors from tariff cuts: **dairy, edible oils, sugar, wheat, poultry, gems and jewellery, and arms/ammunition**.
- **Services, Health & Student Mobility:**
  - Opened **118 services sectors** with Most Favoured Nation (MFN) commitments across 139 sub-sectors.
  - Dedicated market access secured for Indian **AYUSH and traditional medicine practitioners**.
  - **Student Mobility:** Entry caps on Indian students removed; Indian students granted the legal right to work **up to 20 hours per week** during study terms.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New Zealand Tariff-Free Lines to India: **100% of all 8,284 tariff lines**.
- India Tariff Liberalization: **70.03% of tariff lines** (covering **95% of trade value**).
- NZ Investment Commitment: **USD 20 billion over 15 years**.
- Excluded Sectors: **Dairy, edible oils, sugar, gems & jewellery** (strictly prohibited).
- Student Work Allowance: Up to **20 hours per week**.

[MAY-010] **Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI 1.0) & Telecommunications Cell Broadcast Emergency Warning System**

- **Rural Governance Accounting (PAI 1.0):**
  - Ministry of Panchayati Raj (**MoPR**, Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh / Lalan Singh) published the inaugural **Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI 1.0)** based on FY 2022–23 baseline data.
  - Evaluated across **516 indicators and 749 data points** (subsequently streamlined to 150 indicators and 230 data points).
  - **Beginner Category (Category D) Panchayats:** The State of **Manipur** recorded the highest proportion of Category D (beginner) Panchayats.
  - **Zero Category D Performers:** Seven States and UTs had **zero Panchayats in the beginner category**, reflecting superior rural governance: **Kerala, Tripura, Sikkim, Andaman & Nicobar, Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu, Puducherry, and Lakshadweep**.
- **Cell Broadcast Emergency System:**
  - Union Minister for Communications Jyotiraditya Scindia announced the pan-India operationalization of the **Cell Broadcast System**.
  - Enables disaster management authorities to beam instantaneous, high-priority audible warning alerts to **all mobile devices in a targeted geographical zone** during impending cyclones, earthquakes, flash floods, or industrial hazard events without network cellular congestion.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Inaugural Index: **Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI 1.0)** by Ministry of Panchayati Raj.
- Highest Category D (Beginner) Panchayats: **Manipur**.
- States with Zero Category D Panchayats: **Kerala, Tripura, Sikkim**.
- Disaster Technology: **Cell Broadcast System** for geo-fenced emergency mobile alerts.

[MAY-011] **MoHFW Upgrades RBSK 2.0 with Child Digital Health Cards Following 160.82 Crore Screenings**

- **Pediatric Healthcare Modernization:** Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (**MoHFW**) rolled out **Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram 2.0 (RBSK 2.0)** to modernize child health screening and early intervention nationwide.
- **Decadal Operational Milestone (RBSK 1.0):**
  - Over the decade spanning **FY 2014–15 to FY 2023–24**, RBSK screened an astounding **160.82 crore children** from birth to 18 years across Anganwadis and government schools.
- **RBSK 2.0 Digital Innovations:**
  - Introduces **Digital Health Cards for Children**, linked natively to the Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission (**ABDM**) Ayushman Bharat Health Account (**ABHA**) ID.
  - Deploys specialized Mobile Health Teams equipped with AI diagnostic kits to detect the **4Ds: Defects at birth, Diseases, Deficiencies, and Development delays including disabilities**.
- **NHAI 'Project Saksham':**
  - National Highways Authority of India (**NHAI**) launched **Project Saksham** in partnership with the Vertis Foundation, training and employing rural women in highway operations, toll plaza management, and highway incident response services.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- RBSK Decadal Screening Achievement: **160.82 crore children** screened (FY15–FY24).
- Core Disease Focus: **4Ds** (Defects, Diseases, Deficiencies, Development delays).
- RBSK 2.0 Technological Core: **Digital Health Cards for Children** (integrated with ABHA/ABDM).
- NHAI Rural Women Initiative: **Project Saksham** (in collaboration with Vertis Foundation).

5. RBI REGULATORY DIRECTIONS, CIRCULARS & SUPERVISION (MAY 2026)

[MAY-012] **RBI Deregulates FinTech Cross-Border Outward Remittances: Removes Prior Approval Mandate**

- **Framework Liberalisation:** Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) discontinued the mandate requiring Authorised Dealer Category-I (**AD Cat-I**) banks to obtain prior approval from the central bank before entering into tie-up arrangements with non-bank entities (including FinTechs) for outward cross-border remittances.
- **Applicability & Scope:**
  - Applies strictly to **Cross-Border Outward Remittance of funds** for **Non-Trade Current Account Transactions**.
  - Covers digital applications, web portals, and software platforms operated by third-party FinTech entities facilitating customer-facing remittances.
- **Mandatory Bank Compliance & Transparency Safeguards:**
  - **Statutory Adherence:** AD Cat-I banks remain entirely responsible for strict compliance under the **Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 (FEMA)** and Master Directions on **Know Your Customer (KYC)** / AML.
  - **Full Customer Disclosure:** Banks must clearly disclose to the remitter:
    1. The **exact foreign exchange amount** that will be credited into the overseas beneficiary's account.
    2. The **maximum expected time** required for the funds to reach the beneficiary.
  - Prevents opaque hidden markups, intermediary bank deductions, and arbitrary foreign exchange conversion spreads.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Regulatory Shift: Prior RBI approval requirement **removed** for AD Cat-I bank tie-ups with FinTechs.
- Permitted Scope: **Non-Trade Current Account Transactions** only (trade capital accounts excluded).
- Core Statutory Laws: Governed under **FEMA 1999** and RBI KYC Directions.
- Mandated Disclosures: **Exact foreign currency amount** and **maximum delivery time**.

[MAY-013] **I4C & RBI Innovation Hub (RBIH) Ink Strategic MoU to Deploy MuleHunter.ai™ Against Cyber Frauds**

- **Inter-Agency Institutional Accord:** The **Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)** under the Ministry of Home Affairs (**MHA**, established in 2018) signed a landmark Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) with the **Reserve Bank Innovation Hub (RBIH)**.
- **Technological Weapon — MuleHunter.ai™:**
  - RBIH developed **MuleHunter.ai™**, an enterprise AI/ML supervised algorithm designed to detect, tag, and isolate **digital mule bank accounts** in near-real time.
  - Mule accounts serve as illicit conduit accounts used by cybercrime syndicates to layer, move, or withdraw fraudulent proceeds.
- **Integration with Digital Payment Intelligence Platform (DPIP):**
  - MuleHunter.ai™ feeds live behavioral intelligence directly into RBI's **Digital Payment Intelligence Platform (DPIP)** to generate transaction-level fraud probability scores for banks and payment service providers.
- **About RBIH:**
  - Wholly owned subsidiary of the Reserve Bank of India established in **2021** (Headquarters: **Bengaluru, Karnataka**; CEO: **Sahil Kini**).

- Dedicated to building foundational public digital infrastructure, financial inclusion utilities, and AI fraud defense mechanisms.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- MoU Partners: **I4C (Ministry of Home Affairs)** & **RBIH (wholly owned RBI subsidiary)**.
- AI Mule Detection Engine: **MuleHunter.ai™** (developed by RBIH).
- RBIH Headquarters & Inception: **Bengaluru, Karnataka**; established in **2021**; CEO **Sahil Kini**.
- Fraud Scoring Utility: **Digital Payment Intelligence Platform (DPIP)**.

[MAY-014] **RBI Revises Investment Fluctuation Reserve (IFR) Norms: Discontinued for Commercial Banks, Retained for UCBs & RRBs**

- **Major Capital & Prudential Shift:** Reserve Bank of India issued final amendment directions revising the regulatory architecture for **Investment Fluctuation Reserve (IFR)**, effective **May 18, 2026**.
- **Commercial Banks (CBs) & Foreign Banks (FBs):**
  - **IFR Requirement Discontinued:** RBI officially **discontinued the mandatory IFR requirement** for Commercial Banks and Foreign Banks, noting that modern Basel capital adequacy ratios and risk-management norms already provide sufficient loss absorption against bond mark-to-market (MTM) depreciation.
  - **Treatment of Existing IFR Balances:** Existing IFR balances as of May 17, 2026, must be transferred **"below the line"** to either the **Statutory Reserve**, the **General Reserve**, or the **Profit and Loss Account**.
  - **Tier 1 Capital Reclassification:** Transferred balances are now recognized as **Tier 1 (Core Capital)**, boosting banks' core capitalization metrics.
  - **Foreign Bank Branches:** Balances transferred directly to "statutory reserve kept in Indian books" or "remittable surplus retained in Indian books" (non-repatriable while Indian operations continue).
- **Provisions for PBs, SFBs, RRBs & Co-operative Banks:**
  - **Relaxation for Balance Sheet Frequency:** Payments Banks (PBs), Small Finance Banks (SFBs), and Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) are now required to maintain the prescribed IFR level **only on balance sheet dates** (rather than continuously throughout the year).
  - **Target Threshold:** PBs, SFBs, and RRBs must maintain an IFR of **at least 2% of the Available for Sale (AFS) and Fair Value Through Profit and Loss (FVTPL / HFT)** portfolios, eligible for **Tier 2 Capital**.
  - **Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs) & Rural Co-operative Banks (RCBs):** Must continue to maintain a minimum IFR of **5% of their investment portfolio**; excess amounts over 5% may be transferred to the Profit and Loss Account at the end of the accounting year; qualifies for **Tier 2 Capital**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: **May 18, 2026**.
- Commercial Banks Status: IFR requirement **completely discontinued**; existing balances qualify as **Tier 1 Capital**.
- SFBs, PBs & RRBs Norm: Maintained **only on balance sheet dates**; minimum **2% of AFS/FVTPL**; qualifies as **Tier 2 Capital**.
- Co-operative Banks (UCBs/RCBs): Minimum IFR remains **5% of investment portfolio** (Tier 2 Capital).

[MAY-015] **RBI Discussion Paper on Digital Payment Safety: 1-Hour Lagged Credit, Kill Switch & ₹25 Lakh Annual Cap**

- **Combating Authorized Push Payment (APP) Frauds:** RBI released a comprehensive Discussion Paper outlining high-friction security interventions to protect retail depositors against social engineering, digital arrest, and APP cyber frauds (which inflicted ₹22,930 crore losses in 2025).
- **1-Hour Lagged Credit on High-Value UPI/IMPS:**
  - Proposes a mandatory **1-hour settlement delay** for all online digital transfers (UPI, IMPS, NEFT) **exceeding ₹10,000**.
  - During this 1-hour escrow window, the sender retains the unilateral legal right to **cancel the transaction**.

  - **Whitelisting Exemption:** Instant real-time settlement permitted without delay if the beneficiary has been pre-registered on the customer's **whitelisted trusted beneficiary list**.
  - **Empirical Rationale:** RBI observed that transactions above ₹10,000 account for **98.5% of total digital fraud value** and **45% of reported cyber fraud cases**.
- **Trusted Person Authentication for Vulnerable Citizens:**
  - Introduces dual-authorization safeguards for **senior citizens aged above 70 years** and **persons with disabilities (PwDs)**.
  - Any digital fund transfer **exceeding ₹50,000** will require secondary approval from a pre-nominated trusted family member or guardian.
- **National Digital 'Kill Switch' & Annual Credit Cap:**
  - **Universal Kill Switch:** Mandates a one-tap emergency Kill Switch across all mobile banking apps to immediately freeze all digital outbound payment channels (modeled on Singapore and Australian protocols).
  - **₹25 Lakh Annual Credit Limit:** Proposes capping aggregate annual credits received by individual and small merchant accounts at **₹25 lakh**; excess funds parked in a holding 'shadow balance' pending KYC reverification.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- UPI Lagged Credit Threshold: Transfers **above ₹10,000** held for **1 hour** (cancellable by sender).
- Fraud Value Concentration: Above ₹10,000 transfers account for **98.5% of fraud value**.
- Senior Citizen Rule: Transfers **above ₹50,000** for citizens **>70 years** require trusted person sign-off.
- Annual Credit Cap: **₹25 lakh** annual incoming credit cap (shadow balance mechanism).
- Emergency Mechanism: One-tap **Digital Kill Switch**.

[MAY-016] **RBI Rationalises Disaster Relief Loan Restructuring: Suo Motu Automatic Restructuring & 135-Day Opt-Out**

- **Framework Notification:** Reserve Bank of India issued revised directions empowering commercial banks and non-banking lenders to deliver immediate credit relief to borrowers struck by natural calamities.
- **Automatic Relief & Suo Motu Restructuring:**
  - Lenders permitted to initiate loan restructuring **suo motu** (without waiting for formal distress applications from borrowers) across areas declared as disaster-hit under the **National Disaster Response Fund (NDRF)** or **State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF)**.
  - Relief measures include lowering loan interest rates, extending repayment tenures, converting short-term crop loans into medium/long-term term loans, and granting moratoriums.
- **135-Day Borrower Opt-Out Window:**
  - Restructuring applies automatically across all eligible standard loan accounts; affected borrowers are granted a **135-day window from the date of calamity declaration** to opt out if they prefer to service existing repayment terms.
- **Eligibility & Asset Classification Safeguards:**
  - **Standard Account Rule:** Account must be classified as 'Standard' on the date of calamity declaration and not in default for more than **30 days**.
  - **Slippage Upgrade:** Any account that slips into NPA between the calamity declaration date and restructuring implementation will be **upgraded back to 'Standard'** upon execution of the relief plan.
  - **Provisioning:** Banks must maintain an additional specific provision of **5%** on the outstanding debt of restructured borrowers.
  - **Timelines:** Plan invocation within **45 days** of calamity declaration; full implementation within **90 days thereafter**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Suo Motu Authority: Banks and NBFCs can restructure calamity loans **without borrower application**.
- Opt-Out Horizon: Borrowers have **135 days** from calamity declaration to opt out.
- Pre-Condition Default Cap: Not in default for more than **30 days** on calamity date.
- Provisioning Requirement: Additional **5% specific provision** on restructured debt.
- Implementation Window: Invocation within **45 days**; implementation within **90 days**.

[MAY-017] **RBI Mandates Master Direction on Expected Credit Loss (ECL) Framework Effective April 1, 2027**

- **Historic Shift in Credit Provisioning:** RBI formally issued the comprehensive **Master Direction on Expected Credit Loss (ECL) Approach for Bank Loans**, superseding the legacy 40-year-old 'Incurred Loss' provisioning model, effective **April 1, 2027**.
- **Three-Stage Asset Classification & Provisioning Model:**
  - **Stage 1 (Low Credit Risk / Normal):**
    - Exposures with low or no significant increase in credit risk since initial recognition.
    - Provisioning: **12-month Expected Credit Losses (ECL)**.
    - Minimum statutory floor: At least **0.40%** on secured retail, corporate, and medium enterprise loans; **0.25%** on small/micro enterprises and farm credit; **1.00%** on unsecured retail loans.
  - **Stage 2 (Significant Increase in Credit Risk - SICR):**
    - Exposures where credit risk has increased significantly since origination, but which are not yet credit-impaired (automatically triggered if payments are **overdue by >30 days**).
    - Provisioning: **Lifetime Expected Credit Losses (Lifetime ECL)**.
    - Minimum statutory floor: **5.00%** provisioning across corporate, retail, and unsecured credit.
  - **Stage 3 (Credit-Impaired / NPAs):**
    - Defaulted exposures meeting the statutory 90-day delinquency threshold.
    - Provisioning: **Lifetime ECL** (progressively scaling up to **100%** for unsecured exposures depending on age of default).
- **Core Statistical Mechanics & Income Recognition:**
  - ECL computed using econometric formula: $\text{ECL} = \text{Probability of Default (PD)} \times \text{Loss Given Default (LGD)} \times \text{Exposure at Default (EAD)}$.
  - **Borrower-Level Cross-Contamination:** If any single loan facility of a borrower turns NPA, all other credit exposures of that borrower across the bank must be classified as NPA.
  - **Effective Interest Rate (EIR) Transition:** Banks mandated to transition their entire loan books to **Effective Interest Rate (EIR)** accounting by **March 31, 2030**.
  - **Governance:** Supervised by a Board-approved Committee comprising the Chief Financial Officer (CFO) and Chief Risk Officer (CRO).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Enforcement Date: **April 1, 2027**.
- Transition Milestone: Full transition to Effective Interest Rate (EIR) by **March 31, 2030**.
- Stage 1 Provisioning: **12-Month ECL** (0.40% secured, 0.25% MSME/agri, 1.00% unsecured retail).
- Stage 2 Trigger: Overdue by **>30 days**; requires **Lifetime ECL** (minimum **5.00%**).
- Stage 3 Trigger: Overdue by **>90 days**; requires **Lifetime ECL** (up to **100%**).
- Quantitative Formula: $\text{PD} \times \text{LGD} \times \text{EAD}$.

[MAY-018] **RBI Mandates Global Reporting of All Rupee OTC Foreign Exchange Derivatives to CCIL**

- **FX Derivatives Transparency Overhaul:** Reserve Bank of India instituted a sweeping reporting reform mandating Authorised Dealer Category-I (**AD Cat-I**) banks to report all **Over-the-Counter (OTC) Foreign Exchange (FX)**

Derivative Contracts involving the Indian Rupee (INR).

- **Reporting Repository & Global Extraterritoriality:**
  - All transactions must be reported to the trade repository of the **Clearing Corporation of India Limited (CCIL)**.
  - Extends extraterritorially: Covers OTC Rupee derivative contracts executed anywhere in the world by the bank's **parent company, overseas branches, and foreign subsidiaries/related entities**.
  - Captures both **Deliverable** and **Non-Deliverable Forward (NDF)** contracts.
- **Three-Phase Progressive Implementation Timetable:**
  - **Phase 1 (Effective July 1, 2027):** Mandatory reporting of **100% of contracts** entered into by the **parent bank entities**.
  - **Phase 2 (Effective January 1, 2028):** Reporting of at least **70% of total notional trade value** executed by other related entities / overseas arms (progressively stepping up to **80%**).
  - **Phase 3 (Effective July 1, 2028):** Full compliance mandated — **100% of notional trade value** across all global related entities must be reported.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Mandatory Trade Repository: **Clearing Corporation of India Limited (CCIL)**.
- Phase 1 Deadline: **July 1, 2027** (100% of parent entity contracts).
- Phase 2 Deadline: **January 1, 2028** (70%–80% notional value of related entities).
- Phase 3 Full Enforcement: **July 1, 2028** (100% notional value worldwide).
- Instruments Covered: Both **Deliverable and Non-Deliverable OTC Rupee FX Derivatives**.

[MAY-019] **RBI Regulatory Governance: UCB Director 3-Year Cooling-Off, Q-SAFE Quantum Committee & Key Appointments**

- **Mandatory 3-Year Cooling-Off for Co-operative Bank Directors:**
  - Following the Banking Laws (Amendment) Act, 2025 (which increased the maximum continuous tenure of directors from 8 years to **10 years**), RBI issued final amendment directions for **Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs)** and **Rural Co-operative Banks (RCBs / StCBs / DCCBs)**.
  - Mandates a compulsory **3-year cooling-off period** after completing 10 years of continuous tenure before a director can be re-appointed or co-opted to the board of the same bank.
  - During the cooling-off period, the individual cannot be associated with the bank in any administrative capacity (can only remain an ordinary member/customer).
- **Expert Committee on Quantum Technology in FinTech (Q-SAFE Initiative):**
  - Constituted an **8-member expert panel** under the **Quantum Secure and Adaptive Financial Ecosystem (Q-SAFE)** initiative to assess cryptographic risks and quantum-safe protocols in the banking system.
  - Chaired by **Dr. Anil Prabhakar** (Professor, Dept. of Electrical Engineering, IIT Madras).
  - Key responsibilities: Formulating a Cryptography Bill of Materials (CBOM), identifying post-quantum cryptographic vulnerabilities, and recommending transition roadmaps.
- **Executive Leadership & Board Appointments:**
  - **Shri Rohit Jain:** Appointed as **Deputy Governor of the RBI for a 3-year term**, succeeding Shri T. Rabi Sankar upon completion of his tenure on May 2, 2026 (previously served as Executive Director supervising Department of Supervision).
  - **Shri Gunveer Singh:** Appointed as **Executive Director (ED)** of the Reserve Bank of India.
  - **Shri Elias George:** Appointed as **Part-Time Chairman** of the Board of Directors of **Federal Bank Limited**.
  - **One MobiKwik Systems Limited:** Received RBI in-principle approval to set up its dedicated NBFC lending arm (*MobiKwik Financial Services Private Limited*), governed by the net owned fund (NOF) glidepath reaching **₹10 crore by March 31, 2027**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Co-op Bank Tenure & Cooling-off: Max **10 years continuous tenure**; mandatory **3-year cooling-off period**.
- Quantum Committee Head: **Dr. Anil Prabhakar** (IIT Madras) under the **Q-SAFE** initiative.
- New RBI Deputy Governor: **Shri Rohit Jain** (3-year tenure; succeeds T. Rabi Sankar).
- Federal Bank Chairman: **Shri Elias George**.
- NBFC Minimum NOF: Escalating to **₹10 crore** by March 31, 2027.

6. CAPITAL MARKETS, SEBI & PENSIONS REGULATION (MAY 2026)

[MAY-020] **SEBI Introduces 'GARUDA' Green-Channel Fast-Track Mechanism for Alternative Investment Funds (AIFs)**

- **Reforming Private Capital Formation:** The Securities and Exchange Board of India (**SEBI**) introduced the **GARUDA Mechanism** (*Green-Channel: Alternative Investment Funds Rollout Upon Document Acknowledgement*) to eliminate regulatory delays in launching private investment funds.
- **Radical Reduction in Approval Timelines:**
  - **Non-Accredited Investor Schemes:** Rollout timeline slashed from the prevailing 30-day waiting period down to **within 10 working days** of filing the Placement Memorandum (PPM).
  - **Angel Funds & Accredited Investor (AI-only) Schemes:** Granted **immediate green-channel fundraising clearance** upon direct digital filing with SEBI, completely eliminating the requirement to route filings through merchant bankers.
- **Enhanced Accountability & Due Diligence:**
  - Replaces redundant Merchant Banker Due Diligence Certificates with binding statutory undertakings signed directly by the AIF's **Chief Executive Officer (CEO)** and **Compliance Officer**.
  - For first-time fund schemes, launch permission is granted on the later of: the date of SEBI registration or **10 working days from PPM filing**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Full Form: **GARUDA** (*Green-Channel: Alternative Investment Funds Rollout Upon Document Acknowledgement*).
- Regulatory Authority: **SEBI** (Securities and Exchange Board of India).
- Non-Accredited AIF Timeline: Cut from 30 days to **10 working days**.
- Angel & Accredited Funds: **Instant green-channel fundraising**; zero merchant banker certification required.
- Undertaking Authority: Directly signed by **CEO and Compliance Officer**.

[MAY-021] **PFRDA Rolls Out Retirement Income Schemes (RIS) with Systematic Payout (SPR) and Unit Redemption (SUR)**

- **Post-Retirement Pension Innovation:** The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (**PFRDA**, established under PFRDA Act, 2013; Chairman: **Sivasubramanian Ramann**) launched **Retirement Income Schemes (RIS)** under the National Pension System (**NPS**).
- **Addressing Superannuation Inflexibility:**
  - Subscribers reaching 60 years previously had to mandatorily annuitize at least 40% of their accumulated corpus and withdraw the remaining 60% as a lump sum.
  - RIS permits retirees who do not require an immediate lump sum to remain invested in NPS up to the **age of 75 or 85 years**, drawing structured, tax-efficient regular income.
- **Two Flexible Post-Retirement Withdrawal Pathways:**
  1. **Systematic Payout Rate (SPR):**
     - The payout rate is calibrated dynamically based on the subscriber's current age and chosen drawdown end-age.
     - For a subscriber exiting at age 60 and selecting an 85-year drawdown horizon, the initial annual payout begins at **4.00%**, resetting annually on the subscriber's date of birth based on the prevailing net market value of the fund

corpus.

- Any residual corpus at the end of the drawdown horizon can be withdrawn as a lump sum or merged into an annuity.

2. **Systematic Unit Redemption (SUR):**
   - The subscriber's total accumulated units are divided evenly across the chosen drawdown tenure.
   - A **fixed number of mutual units are redeemed every month**, providing an automated monthly cashflow irrespective of fluctuations in daily Net Asset Value (NAV).

- **NPS Regulatory Landmarks:**
  - Open to all Indian citizens (residents, NRIs, and OCIs) aged **18 to 85 years** on a voluntary basis.
  - Asset allocation spans 4 standardized classes: **Equity (Class E), Corporate Bonds (Class C), Government Securities (Class G), and Alternative Investment Funds (Class A)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Regulating Body: **PFRDA** (Chairman: **Sivasubramanian Ramann**; HQ: New Delhi).
- Scheme Name: **Retirement Income Schemes (RIS)** under NPS.
- Maximum Drawdown Age: Permitted up to **85 years** (extended from age 75).
- Two Withdrawal Mechanics: **Systematic Payout Rate (SPR)** and **Systematic Unit Redemption (SUR)**.
- SPR Benchmark Payout: Starts at **4% p.a.** for age 60-to-85 drawdown (resets annually on birth date).
- NPS Voluntary Entry Age: **18 to 85 years**.

[MAY-022] **SEBI Operationalises PaRRVA Framework & Launches Mission Jagrook at 38th Foundation Day**

- **Past Risk & Return Verification Agency (PaRRVA):**
  - SEBI fully operationalized the **PaRRVA Framework** as India's first independent institutional verification mechanism to audit, validate, and certify past performance claims made by registered investment advisers, research analysts, and algorithmic trading platforms in advertisements.
  - **Structure:** Operates on a two-tier model comprising a **Verification Body** (SEBI-registered Credit Rating Agency / CRA with ≥15 years operations, ≥₹100 Cr net worth, and >250 ratings) and a **PaRRVA Data Centre (PDC)** operated by **National Stock Exchange of India Limited (NSE)** (requiring ≥₹200 Cr net worth and nationwide terminals).
  - Recognised **CARE Ratings Limited** as an accredited PaRRVA verification entity. Full commercial rollout effective **May 4, 2026**.
- **Mission Jagrook & 38th Foundation Day Celebrations:**
  - Union Minister of Finance Nirmala Sitharaman delivered the keynote address at the **38th Foundation Day of SEBI** (SEBI established as non-statutory body on April 12, 1988; granted statutory status under SEBI Act, 1992; Chairman: **Tuhin Kanta Pandey**).
  - Launched **Mission Jagrook**, a pan-India investor education and financial defense campaign to insulate retail market participants from financial influencers ('finfluencers'), fraudulent trading apps, and manipulative social media syndicates.
  - Introduced the **SEBI Check Tool**, allowing investors to independently verify bank accounts and UPI payment handles of registered market intermediaries before transferring capital.
  - Proposed the development of a **Unified KYC System** across banking, capital markets, and insurance.
- **Capital Market Milestones:**
  - India's capital markets host **over 5,900 listed companies** with **more than 140 million (14 crore) unique investors**.
  - Market capitalization expanded at an annual compound rate of **~15% over the past decade**; mutual fund assets grew at **>20% annually**; primary markets mobilize nearly **₹10 trillion (₹10 lakh crore)** annually.
  - **Central Depository Services Limited (CDSL):** SEBI approved the appointment of **Amit Mahajan** and **Nayana Ovalekar** as Executive Directors on the board of CDSL.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Performance Audit Engine: **PaRRVA** (*Past Risk & Return Verification Agency*).
- PaRRVA Data Centre (PDC): Operated by **National Stock Exchange (NSE)**.
- Verification Body Partner: **CARE Ratings Limited** (minimum net worth ₹100 Cr).
- Investor Defense Campaign: **Mission Jagrook** launched by Union Finance Minister.
- Intermediary Payment Verifier: **SEBI Check Tool**.
- Market Scale: **5,900+ listed firms**, **140 million unique investors**, primary markets mobilize **~₹10 Lakh Cr/year**.
- SEBI 38th Foundation Day: Established April 12, 1988 (Statutory 1992); Chairman **Tuhin Kanta Pandey**.

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7. INDUSTRIAL MISSIONS, CLEAN ENERGY & LOGISTICS (MAY 2026)

[MAY-023] **Cabinet Approves ₹37,500 Crore Scheme for Promotion of Coal/Lignite Gasification Projects**

- **Strategic Objective & Sovereign Push:** The Union Cabinet, chaired by the Prime Minister, approved the landmark **Scheme for Promotion of Coal/Lignite Gasification Projects** with a total financial outlay of **₹37,500 crore**.
- **Foundational Alignment:**
  - Anchored on the **National Coal Gasification Mission (NCGM)** launched in 2021, which targets the gasification of **100 Million Tonnes (MT) of coal by 2030**.
  - Focuses on converting coal/lignite into **Synthesis Gas (Syngas)** for clean production of chemicals, methanol, ammonia, fertilizers, and synthetic natural gas, slashing carbon emissions.
- **Tenure & Project Financial Incentive Structure:**
  - **Maximum Tenure:** Fixed at up to **30 years** under the Non-Regulated Sector (NRS) linkage auction framework.
  - **Incentive Payment:** Provides financial assistance of **up to 20% of the cost of plant and machinery** for new surface coal/lignite gasification projects.
  - **Disbursement Slabs:** Released in **four equal milestone-linked installments**.
- **Financial Assistance Caps & Limits:**
  - **Single Project Cap:** Maximum ₹5,000 crore (for projects producing synthetic natural gas or urea, ceiling is **₹9,000 crore**).
  - **Single Entity / Corporate Group Cap:** Overall exposure capped at **₹12,000 crore** across all projects.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Scheme Outlay: **₹37,500 crore** (Promotion of Coal/Lignite Gasification).
- NCGM Long-Term National Target: **100 MT coal gasified by 2030** (75 MT target for current phase).
- Plant & Machinery Incentive: **Up to 20% of capital cost** (disbursed in 4 equal installments).
- Maximum Linkage Tenure: **30 years**.
- Single Project / Entity Caps: ₹5,000 Cr standard, ₹9,000 Cr for SNG/Urea; **₹12,000 Cr per corporate group**.

[MAY-024] **MoPSW Inks Tripartite MoU for India's First Mega Greenfield Shipyard at Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu**

- **Maritime Infrastructure Leap:** The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways (**MoPSW**, Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal) signed a historic tripartite Memorandum of Understanding (**MoU**) to establish **India's first mega greenfield shipyard**.
- **Project Location & Joint SPV Structure:**
  - Located at **Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu**, strategically proximate to major international Indian Ocean shipping routes.
  - Executed through a dedicated Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) named **National Shipbuilding and Heavy Industries Park Tamil Nadu Limited (NSHIP-TN)**.
  - Jointly promoted by **V.O. Chidambaranar Port Authority (VOCPA)**, **State Industries Promotion Corporation of Tamil Nadu (SIPCOT)**, and global engineering partners.
- **National Shipbuilding Mission (NSbM) Roadmap:**

- Backed by an approved total outlay of **₹24,736 crore** under the Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Scheme (SBFAS).
- Targets propelling India into the **Top-10 global shipbuilding nations by 2030** and **Top-5 globally by 2047** (Amrit Kaal).
- Aims at a massive **40-fold increase in domestic shipbuilding output by 2047**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Shipyard Location: **Thoothukudi, Tamil Nadu** (V.O. Chidambaranar Port Authority).
- Dedicated SPV: **NSHIP-TN** (*National Shipbuilding & Heavy Industries Park Tamil Nadu Ltd*).
- Financial Allocation: **₹24,736 crore** under National Shipbuilding Mission.
- Long-Term National Targets: **Top-10 global by 2030**, **Top-5 by 2047** (40-fold output expansion).

[MAY-025] **DPIIT Releases LEADS 2025 Report & LEAPS Awards: Tamil Nadu, UP & Gujarat Emerge as Top Performers**

- **National Logistics Assessment (7th Edition):** Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal released the 7th edition of the **Logistics Ease Across Different States (LEADS 2025)** report and conferred the Logistics Excellence, Advancement and Performance Shield (**LEAPS Awards 2025**).
- **Alignment with Global & Domestic Frameworks:**
  - Evaluated across three core pillars: **Infrastructure, Services, and Operating & Regulatory Environment** (modeled on the World Bank's **Logistics Performance Index - LPI**).
  - Tightly aligned with PM GatiShakti National Master Plan (**PMGS-NMP**) and National Logistics Policy (**NLP**).
- **New Four-Tier Performance Classification:**
  - Transitions from the earlier 3-tier matrix into four distinct performance categories:
    1. **Exemplars:** States/UTs demonstrating sustained high-level logistics excellence across all indicators.
    2. **High Performers:** States/UTs demonstrating robust, consistent outcomes.
    3. **Accelerators:** States/UTs with significant reform momentum.
    4. **Growth-Seekers:** States/UTs at foundational development stages.
- **Top State Rankings by Demographic Clusters:**
  - **Coastal States: Tamil Nadu** and **Gujarat** recognized as top performers.
  - **Landlocked States: Uttar Pradesh** emerged as the top Exemplar; followed by Haryana, Telangana, Chhattisgarh, and Bihar as High Performers.
  - **North-Eastern States: Mizoram** ranked as Exemplar; Tripura and Meghalaya categorized as High Performers.
  - **Union Territories: Delhi** awarded Exemplar status; Jammu & Kashmir and Puducherry ranked as High Performers.
- **LEAPS Industry Honors:** FedEx Express won Air Freight Service Provider; MSC Agency India won Maritime Freight Service Provider; TVS Supply Chain won Multimodal/Warehousing; Delhivery won E-Commerce Logistics Delivery.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Release Authority: **DPIIT**, Ministry of Commerce and Industry (7th Edition).
- Global Benchmark Alignment: **World Bank Logistics Performance Index (LPI)**.
- Four-Tier System: **Exemplars, High Performers, Accelerators, Growth-Seekers**.
- Top Landlocked Exemplar: **Uttar Pradesh**; Top Coastal Exemplar: **Tamil Nadu & Gujarat**; Top NE Exemplar: **Mizoram**; Top UT: **Delhi**.

[MAY-026] **Ministry of Heavy Industries Launches 'Unified Bharat e-Charge' (UBC) & ₹10,900 Crore PM E-DRIVE Deployments**

- **Pan-India EV Interoperability:** Union Minister for Heavy Industries H. D. Kumaraswamy unveiled the **Unified Bharat e-Charge (UBC) Platform** at the National Conference on Enabling Nationwide EV Charging Infrastructure in Bengaluru.
- **Key Capabilities of UBC Platform:**

- Developed by **Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL)** with technical and network clearing support from **National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI)**.
- Functions as an open, unified digital platform enabling EV drivers to discover, book, and pay for charging slots across multiple charging point operators through a single interoperable interface (integrating with BHIM UPI).

- **PM E-DRIVE Scheme Deployments:**
  - Backed by the **₹10,900 crore** *Prime Minister Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement* (**PM E-DRIVE**) scheme.
  - Approved the installation of **1,243 public EV charging stations across Karnataka**.
  - **Financial Allocations:** ₹2,000 crore earmarked specifically for EV Public Charging Stations (EV PCS); ₹780 crore for testing agency modernization; ₹50 crore for administration.
  - Subsidizes **8,932 public chargers** previously initiated under FAME-II with an outlay of ₹873.5 crore.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- National EV Platform: **Unified Bharat e-Charge (UBC)**.
- Developing Entities: **BHEL** (technology lead) & **NPCI** (payment and network integration).
- Parent Scheme Outlay: **₹10,900 crore** (PM E-DRIVE Scheme, replacing FAME).
- EV Charging Allocation: **₹2,000 crore** for nationwide EV Public Charging Stations.

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8. RURAL EMPLOYMENT, SOCIO-ECONOMIC WELFARE & TELECOM INFRASTRUCTURE (MAY 2026)

[MAY-027] **Rural Employment Guarantee (VB-G RAM G) Act, 2025 Enforced: 125 Days Guaranteed Work & ₹95,692 Cr Outlay**

- **Historic Overhaul of Rural Employment:** The Ministry of Rural Development (**MoRD**) notified the nationwide enforcement of the **Viksit Bharat – Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (Gramin) Act, 2025 [VB-G RAM G Act]**, effective **July 1, 2026**.
- **Repeal & Transition of MGNREGA:**
  - Formally repeals the Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (**MGNREGA, 2005**).
  - All valid e-KYC verified Job Cards issued under MGNREGA as of June 30, 2026, remain valid until transition to **Gramin Rozgar Cards** under the new Act.
- **Enhanced Statutory Entitlements:**
  - **Expanded Work Guarantee:** Enhances the statutory employment guarantee from 100 days to **125 days of wage employment per financial year** for every rural household whose adult members volunteer for unskilled manual work.
  - **Distance Allowance:** If employment is provided beyond **5 km from the worker's residence**, an additional **10% of the notified wage rate** must be paid as a distance and transport allowance.
  - **Delayed Compensation:** Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) wage payments must be processed within **3 days** and reach bank/post office accounts within **15 days**, failing which daily delayed compensation is legally mandated.
  - **Worksite Childcare:** For worksites with **5 or more children below five years of age**, mandatory crèche facilities and an appointed woman worker caretaker paid at standard wage rates must be provided.
- **Budgetary Allocation & Funding Pattern:**
  - Backed by the **highest-ever allocation for a rural employment program: ₹95,692.31 crore** for FY 2025–26 (cumulative center-state commitment expected to cross **₹1,51,000 crore**).
  - **Funding Pattern:** Implemented as a Centrally Sponsored Scheme (CSS) with **60:40 Centre-State cost-sharing** for general states, and **90:10** for North Eastern and Himalayan states (100% for UTs without legislature).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New Rural Employment Act: **VB-G RAM G Act, 2025** (repeals MGNREGA 2005).
- Statutory Work Guarantee: **125 days per household per financial year** (increased from 100 days).
- Effective Date: **July 1, 2026**.
- Distance Transport Allowance: Additional **10% wage hike** for worksites **>5 km**.
- Union Budget Outlay: **₹95,692.31 crore** (highest-ever rural employment outlay).
- Cost-Sharing Ratio: **60:40** (General States); **90:10** (NE & Himalayan States).

[MAY-028] **Department of Telecommunications Expands Digital Bharat Nidhi (DBN) for BharatNet Phase III**

- **Universal Rural Telecom Connectivity:** The Department of Telecommunications (**DoT**), Ministry of Communications, entered into an implementation agreement with the Government of Andhra Pradesh to roll out the **Amended BharatNet Programme (ABP / BharatNet Phase III)** funded through **Digital Bharat Nidhi (DBN)**.
- **Evolution of Digital Bharat Nidhi (DBN):**
  - Rebranded and reformed from the erstwhile **Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF)** under the **Telecommunications Act, 2023**.
  - Operates as a non-lapsable fund credited directly via the Consolidated Fund of India to support telecom and digital infrastructure across rural, remote, and underserved border regions.
- **Universal Service Levy:**
  - Funded through a statutory **Universal Service Levy** contributing a fixed **5% of Adjusted Gross Revenue (AGR)** paid by all Telecom Service Providers (TSPs).
- **BharatNet Phase III Targets:**
  - Upgrades and expands rural broadband connectivity across **all Gram Panchayats (GPs)** and non-GP rural villages on an on-demand basis.
  - Integrates with the **4G Saturation Project** to eliminate digital blackspots across tribal areas and border belts.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Legislative Origin: Rebranded from USOF under the **Telecommunications Act, 2023**.
- Statutory Funding Levy: **5% of Adjusted Gross Revenue (AGR)** paid by telecom operators.
- Fund Type: **Non-lapsable fund** (balances do not lapse at the close of the financial year).
- Core Flagship Mandates: **BharatNet Phase III** and **4G Saturation Project**.

[MAY-029] **DPIIT Notifies Operational Guidelines for ₹33,660 Crore 'BHAVYA' Industrial Park Scheme**

- **World-Class Industrial Infrastructure:** The Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (**DPIIT**), Ministry of Commerce and Industry, issued the operational guidelines for the **BHAVYA Scheme** (*Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana*).
- **Financial Outlay & Program Scope:**
  - Approved with a total budgetary commitment of **₹33,660 crore** as a fully funded Central Sector Scheme spanning **6 financial years (FY 2026–27 to FY 2031–32)**.
  - Includes administrative project preparation funds of **₹60 crore**.
  - Envisages the development of **100 state-of-the-art greenfield and brownfield smart industrial parks** across India (50 industrial parks prioritized in Phase 1).
- **Land Area & Equity Assistance Framework:**
  - **Non-Hilly / General States:** Minimum contiguous land requirement of **100 acres** per industrial park.
  - **Hilly, North-Eastern & Island UTs:** Relaxed minimum land area of **25 acres**.
  - **Large-Scale Mega Parks:** Up to 20 industrial parks permitted to span **between 500 acres and 1,000 acres** (maximum ceiling capped at 1,000 acres).

- **Financial Support:** Provided in the form of **equity contribution** to a dedicated Special Purpose Vehicle (SPV) formed for each park, linked strictly to the value of unencumbered land and execution of physical infrastructure milestones.

- **Governance:** Governed by a **National Level Steering Committee (NLSC)** chaired by the Secretary, DPIIT (Amardeep Singh Bhatia).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Scheme Acronym: **BHAVYA** (*Bharat Audyogik Vikas Yojana*).
- Financial Outlay: **₹33,660 crore** over **6 financial years (FY27 to FY32)**.
- Industrial Parks Planned: **100 smart industrial parks** (50 in Phase 1).
- Minimum Land Norms: **100 acres** (General States); **25 acres** (Hilly/NE/UTs); Cap: **1,000 acres**.
- Implementing Authority: **DPIIT**; Chaired by Secretary, DPIIT (**Amardeep Singh Bhatia**).

[MAY-030] **PM Modi Inaugurates Somnath Amrut Mahotsav & Launches ₹75 Commemorative Coin in Gujarat**

- **Civilisational Landmark:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressed the **Somnath Amrut Mahotsav** at Prabhas Patan, Gir Somnath district, Gujarat, commemorating the **75th anniversary of the reconstruction of the sacred Somnath Temple** (rebuilt under Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and consecrated in 1951 by President Dr. Rajendra Prasad).
- **₹75 Commemorative Coin & Postal Stamp:**
  - Released a commemorative postage stamp and a specialized **₹75 Commemorative Coin**.
  - **Coin Metallurgy:** Minted in **99.9% Pure Silver (Ag)**; Weight: **40 grams**; Diameter: **44 mm**; Features **200 serrations** along its circular edge.
  - **Inscription:** Inscribed with *"A Celebration of 1000 Years of India's Unwavering Faith and Devotion"* (marking 1,000 years since the 1026 CE invasion).
- **Vadodara Educational Foundations:**
  - PM inaugurated the state-of-the-art **Sardardham Girls Hostel** in Vadodara (built to train female aspirants for UPSC, GPSC, and central examinations).
  - Laid the foundation stone for the **Dr. Dushyant and Daksha Patel Complex** and launched the **Sardar Dham Education Support Yojana** with an outlay of **₹500 crore**.
  - PM was conferred the inaugural **"Sardar Gaurav Ratna"** award by Patidar community organizations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Historical Milestone: **75th Anniversary of Somnath Restoration (1951–2026)**.
- ₹75 Coin Specs: **99.9% Pure Silver**, **40 grams weight**, **44 mm diameter**, **200 serrations**.
- Educational Outlay: **₹500 crore** (Sardar Dham Education Support Yojana, Vadodara).
- Special Award: **Sardar Gaurav Ratna** conferred upon PM Narendra Modi.

[MAY-031] **Agriculture Ministry Releases 3rd Advance Estimates: Record 336.56 MT Foodgrain Production**

- **Record Agrarian Output:** Union Minister for Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Shivraj Singh Chouhan released the **Third Advance Estimates of Major Agricultural Crops for Agricultural Year 2025–26**.
- **Historic Aggregate Foodgrain Production:**
  - Total foodgrain production estimated at an all-time record of **336.563 Million Tonnes (MT)**, surpassing the previous record by over 6.5 MT.
- **Commodity-Wise Breakdown:**
  - **Rice Production:** Reached a record **134.024 MT** (up from 125.5 MT in previous estimates).
  - **Wheat Production:** Projected at a record high of **120.657 MT**.
  - **Nutri/Coarse Cereals & Maize:** Estimated at a combined **74.47 MT**, propelled by the national Shree Anna Millets Mission.
  - **Oilseeds Production:** Projected at a robust **41.22 MT**, lowering domestic edible oil import dependencies.

- **High-Yield Breeder Seed Production:**
  - ICAR released **224 crop varieties** during 2025–26; breeder seed production reached **1,09,370.2 quintals**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Foodgrain Output: Record **336.563 Million Tonnes (MT)**.
- Rice Output: Record **134.024 MT**; Wheat Output: Record **120.657 MT**.
- Coarse Cereals Output: **74.47 MT**; Total Oilseeds: **41.22 MT**.
- Data Authority: Directorate of Economics and Statistics (**DES**), Ministry of Agriculture.

9. SCIENCE, CYBER DEFENSE & CRITICAL MINERAL STRATEGIES (MAY 2026)

[MAY-032] **Mines Ministry Approves 58 Companies Under ₹1,500 Crore Critical Mineral Recycling Incentive Scheme**

- **Supply Chain Independence:** The Ministry of Mines (**MoM**) approved **58 domestic companies** under the newly operationalized **Critical Mineral Recycling Incentive Scheme**.
- **Outlay, Duration & Mission Alignment:**
  - Carved out under the overarching **National Critical Mineral Mission (NCMM)** with a dedicated budgetary outlay of **₹1,500 crore**.
  - Operates over a **6-year implementation horizon:** from **FY 2025–26 (FY26) to FY 2030–31 (FY31)**.
  - **Target Beneficiaries:** Supports both newly established recycling facilities and modernization of existing operational recycling plants.
  - **MSME Allocation Quota:** Exactly **one-third (33.3%) of the total scheme outlay** is statutorily reserved for smaller micro and small enterprise (MSE) recycling units.
- **Incentive Architecture & Project Evaluation:**
  - **Capital Expenditure (Capex) Subsidy:** Provides a direct capital subsidy of **up to 20% on plant, machinery, and recycling equipment**.
  - **Operational Expenditure (Opex) Subsidy:** Production-linked incentive tied to incremental volume of high-purity refined critical minerals extracted from scrap, electronic waste, and spent lithium-ion batteries.
  - **Ceiling Limits:** Maximum incentive capped at **₹50 crore for large industrial entities** and **₹25 crore for small recycling enterprises**.
  - **Evaluation Agency:** Implemented through the **Jawaharlal Nehru Aluminium Research Development and Design Centre (JNARDDC, Nagpur, Maharashtra)** acting as the designated Project Management Agency (PMA).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Scheme Outlay: **₹1,500 crore** over **6 financial years (FY26 to FY31)**.
- MSME Reserved Quaya: Exactly **1/3rd (33.3%) of total outlay**.
- Capex Incentive: **Up to 20% subsidy** on plant and machinery.
- Incentive Ceilings: **₹50 crore** (large entities); **₹25 crore** (small entities).
- Project Management Agency (PMA): **JNARDDC, Nagpur, Maharashtra**.
- Parent Mission: **National Critical Mineral Mission (NCMM)**.

[MAY-033] **MoF Notifies New Tax Rules 2026: Significant Economic Presence (SEP) & Digital Audit Trails**

- **Direct Tax Modernisation:** The Ministry of Finance (**MoF** / Central Board of Direct Taxes, CBDT) notified the **New Income Tax Rules, 2026**, replacing obsolete procedural frameworks following the passage of the Direct Tax Code reforms.
- **Strengthened Significant Economic Presence (SEP) Thresholds:**
  - Imposes statutory corporate tax obligations on foreign digital conglomerates and cross-border SaaS/platform enterprises operating in India without a physical permanent establishment.

- **Revenue Threshold:** Any foreign digital transaction value originating from Indian users exceeding **₹2 crore in a financial year** triggers SEP taxable nexus.
- **User Base Threshold:** Digital platforms, streaming networks, or e-commerce operators engaging with **more than 3 lakh active Indian users** automatically trigger SEP liability.

- **Strict 7-Year Audit Trail & Compliance Norms:**
  - All institutional entities, corporate taxpayers, and financial intermediaries must maintain an immutable digital **audit trail for a mandatory period of 7 years**.
  - **Prohibition of Tampering:** Any deletion of transaction logs, modifications, or ledger alterations without a digital cryptographic trail is prohibited; monthly reporting of corrected entries is mandatory.
  - Strengthens corporate governance and algorithmic compliance across Indian stock exchanges and clearing houses.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Enforcement Date: **April 1, 2026** (New Income Tax Rules, 2026).
- SEP Revenue Threshold: Indian transaction revenue exceeding **₹2 crore**.
- SEP User Base Threshold: Engaging **over 3 lakh Indian users**.
- Mandatory Audit Trail Period: Immutable logs preserved for **7 years**.
- Governing Body: **Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT)**, Ministry of Finance.

[MAY-034] **MoPR Inaugurates Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI 2.0): Tripura & Kerala Emerge as Top Performers**

- **Second Iteration of Localised SDG Measurement:** The Ministry of Panchayati Raj (**MoPR**, Union Minister Rajiv Ranjan Singh / Lalan Singh) launched the **Panchayat Advancement Index (PAI 2.0)** assessing grassroots performance for **FY 2023–24 (FY24)**.
- **Streamlined Evaluative Framework:**
  - PAI 2.0 evaluates rural local bodies across **Nine Localised Sustainable Development Goals (LSDGs)** (poverty-free, healthy, child-friendly, water-sufficient, clean & green, self-sufficient infrastructure, socially secured, good governance, and engendered).
  - Significantly streamlined the evaluation matrix to **150 standardized indicators and 230 data points** (down from 516 indicators and 749 data points in PAI 1.0).
  - Covered **27 States and 6 Union Territories** (West Bengal did not participate; Delhi and Chandigarh have no Gram Panchayats).
- **State Rankings & Historic Milestones:**
  - **Rank 1: Tripura** achieved a historic milestone, emerging as the **top-performing State** in the overall index score across India.
  - **Rank 2: Kerala** secured the second rank nationwide.
  - **Ranks 3, 4 & 5:** Odisha (Rank 3), Andhra Pradesh (Rank 4), and Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu (Rank 5).
  - **Best Gram Panchayat: Jugal Kishore Nagar Village Committee** in Sepahijala district, **Tripura**, was recognized as the single highest-scoring Gram Panchayat in India.
  - **Beginner Category (Category D): Manipur** recorded the highest proportion of Category D beginner Panchayats; **Kerala, Tripura, Sikkim, and 4 UTs** recorded **zero Panchayats in Category D**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Top Performing State (PAI 2.0): **Tripura** (Rank 1), followed by **Kerala** (Rank 2).
- Top Gram Panchayat in India: **Jugal Kishore Nagar**, Sepahijala District, **Tripura**.
- Streamlined Architecture: **150 indicators and 230 data points** across **9 LSDG themes**.
- States with Zero Category D Panchayats: **Tripura, Kerala, Sikkim**.
- State with Highest Beginner Panchayats: **Manipur**.

[MAY-035] **PM Modi Inaugurates India's First PM MITRA Textile Mega Park at Warangal, Telangana**

- **Textile Manufacturing Hub:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated **India's first fully functional PM MITRA Mega Textile Park** located at **Warangal, Telangana**.
- **Pradhan Mantri Mega Integrated Textile Region and Apparel (PM MITRA) Scheme:**
  - Launched under the Ministry of Textiles with a total financial outlay of **₹4,445 crore** spanning **FY 2021–22 to FY 2027–28**.
  - Designed around the **5F Vision** articulated by the Prime Minister: **Farm to Fibre; Fibre to Factory; Factory to Fashion; Fashion to Foreign**.
  - Provides integrated plug-and-play world-class industrial infrastructure, zero-liquid discharge effluent plants, common testing facilities, and dedicated logistics linkages to reduce logistics overheads.
- **Pan-India Footprint (7 Approved Mega Parks):**
  - Approved across **7 States: Telangana (Warangal - 1st to be inaugurated)**, **Tamil Nadu (Virudhunagar)**, **Gujarat (Navsari)**, **Karnataka (Kalaburagi)**, **Madhya Pradesh (Dhar)**, **Uttar Pradesh (Lucknow)**, and **Maharashtra (Amravati)**.
  - Expected to attract over **₹70,000 crore in private investments** and generate direct/indirect employment for **over 20 lakh workers**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Functional PM MITRA Park: **Warangal, Telangana** (inaugurated May 2026).
- Total Approved Sites: Exactly **7 Mega Textile Parks** across 7 states.
- Scheme Outlay: **₹4,445 crore** under Ministry of Textiles.
- Guiding National Philosophy: **5F Vision** (Farm to Fibre, Fibre to Factory, Factory to Fashion, Fashion to Foreign).
- 7 Approved States: Telangana, Tamil Nadu, Gujarat, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra.

JUNE 2026 CONSOLIDATED DOSSIER (BANKING & FINANCIAL REGULATION)

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified RBI Master Directions, Banking Regulatory Circulars & National Financial Anchors

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified RBI Master Directions, Banking Regulatory Circulars & National Financial Anchors

EXAMINER'S BLUEPRINT & COMPLIANCE STANDARD:

- ***Fact Discipline:*** *100% verified against official Reserve Bank of India circulars, Master Directions, SEBI guidelines, PFRDA regulations, and Ministry of Finance gazette orders.*
- ***Format:*** *Authentic* ***Rajputana Gazette Broadsheet*** *layout featuring nested ladder bullets and dedicated* ***EXAM ANGLE:*** *distractor traps.*
- ***Target Exams:*** *RBI Grade B, SEBI Grade A, NABARD Grade A, SBI PO & IBPS PO/Clerk Mains 2026.*

1. BANKING, MONETARY POLICY & FINANCIAL REGULATION

[JUN-001] **RBI Relaxes Capital Requirements for Bank Loans under ECLGS 5.0 (Split Risk-Weight Structure)**

- **Regulatory Framework & Mandate:** Reserve Bank of India issued an amendment to the *Master Direction – RBI (Commercial Banks – Prudential Norms on Capital Adequacy) Directions, 2025*, significantly easing capital requirements for bank loans backed by the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (**ECLGS 5.0**).
- **Split Risk-Weight Mechanism:**
  - **75% of the Guaranteed Portion:** Attracts a **0% risk weight**, meaning banks are completely exempt from setting aside regulatory capital against this portion of the exposure.
  - **Remaining 25% Exposure:** Attracts a concessional **20% risk weight** (drastically reduced from standard unrated exposure weights).
- **Settlement Condition for 0% Weight:**
  - Banks can avail of the 0% risk weight benefit **only if** the guarantee claim is settled within **30 days** from the date of invocation.
  - If the 30-day settlement requirement is breached, the benefit of the 0% risk weight is revoked, and standard capital charges apply.
- **Strategic Intent:** Designed to release trapped bank capital, incentivize fresh liquidity flow to distressed and contact-intensive businesses, and align sovereign-backed portfolio risk with Basel III Pillar 1 norms.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Risk-Weight Split: **0% on 75%** of guaranteed portion vs **20% on remaining 25%** (a classic matching/statement MCQ).
- Time Boundary for Settlement: Must be settled within **30 days** of claim invocation to retain 0% risk weight.
- Policy Anchor: Governed under the *RBI (Commercial Banks – Prudential Norms on Capital Adequacy) Directions*.

[JUN-002] **Launch of ARIFAC: National Industry Platform for AML/CFT Compliance with FIU-IND Oversight**

- **Genesis & Institutional Architecture:** India's financial sector formally launched the **Alliance of Reporting Entities in AML/CFT (ARIFAC)** as a premier national industry-led coordination platform to bolster Anti-Money Laundering (AML) and Combating the Financing of Terrorism (CFT) frameworks.
- **Administrative Secretariat:** Jointly managed and operated by the **Payments Council of India (PCI)** and the **Fintech Convergence Council (FCC)**.
- **Official Regulatory Observer:** The **Financial Intelligence Unit – India (FIU-IND)** participates in ARIFAC in an official **observer role**, offering high-level guidance, regulatory alignment, and supervisory coordination.

- **Universal Membership Base:** Encompasses all reporting entities regulated under the *Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA)*:
  - Commercial Banks and Non-Banking Financial Companies (NBFCs).
  - Payment System Operators (PSOs) and Payment Aggregators (PAs).
  - Securities market intermediaries, Mutual Funds, and Depository Participants.
  - Insurance companies and **Virtual Digital Asset (VDA) service providers**.
- **Operational Focus:** Standardizing suspicious transaction reporting (STR) formats, conducting joint capacity-building certifications, and creating early-warning networks to intercept financial mule rings.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Joint Secretariat: **Payments Council of India (PCI)** + **Fintech Convergence Council (FCC)** (NOT IBA alone).
- Observer Agency: **FIU-IND** (Financial Intelligence Unit – India).
- Legislative Anchor: *Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002*.

[JUN-003] **Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions 2.0 (CGSMFI-2.0): Expansion to ₹20,000 Crore Pool**

- **Framework Evolution:** Ministry of Finance (Department of Financial Services – DFS) and NCGTC operationalized **CGSMFI-2.0**, transitioning from emergency COVID-era relief (launched 28 June 2021) into a permanent, risk-based, tier-structured credit enhancement framework.
- **Pool Size & Validity:**
  - Total guarantee pool expanded to **₹20,000 crore**.
  - Extended validity up to **31 August 2026** (or until the ₹20,000 Cr guarantees are fully exhausted).
- **NCGTC Institutional Profile:**
  - Implemented by **National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company Limited (NCGTC)**, set up under DFS, Ministry of Finance (established in Union Budget 2013-14; incorporated 28 March 2014 under Companies Act 1956; paid-up capital **₹10 crore**; Headquartered in Mumbai).
- **Three-Tier MFI Classification & Loan Limits:**
  - **Small-size MFIs (AUM < ₹500 crore):** Max loan capacity capped at **20% of AUM, subject to a maximum of ₹100 crore**; NCGTC guarantee cover of **80%**; mandatory bank allocation of minimum 5% of bank's scheme pool.
  - **Medium-size MFIs (AUM ₹500 crore to < ₹2,000 crore):** Max loan capacity capped at **20% of AUM, subject to a maximum of ₹200 crore**; NCGTC guarantee cover of **75%**; mandatory bank allocation of minimum 10% of bank's scheme pool.
  - **Large-size MFIs (AUM ≥ ₹2,000 crore):** Max loan capacity enhanced upward from ₹300 crore to **₹1,000 crore** (subject to 20% of AUM); NCGTC guarantee cover of **70%**; eligible for remaining available pool.
- **Interest Rate & On-Lending Structure:**
  - **Lending Rate to MFIs (MLIs to MFIs):** Capped at **EBLR or MCLR + 2.0% per annum**.
  - **On-Lending Rate to Borrowers:** Capped at **1.0% below** the MFI's average lending rate of the preceding six months.
- **Guarantee Fee & Utilization:**
  - Guarantee fee fixed at **0.50% per annum** on the sanctioned amount in the 1st year, and on outstanding balance from Year 2 onwards.
  - Minimum **80% of funds** must be deployed for fresh microfinance loan assets within **4 months**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Large MFI Max Loan Ceiling: Enhanced from ₹300 Cr to **₹1,000 crore** (capped at 20% of AUM).
- Tier-wise Guarantee Cover: Small = **80%**, Medium = **75%**, Large = **70%**.
- Interest Spread Cap: Lending to MFIs capped at **EBLR/MCLR + 2%**; on-lending capped at **1% below** average rate.
- NCGTC Foundation: Incorporated **28 March 2014**; initial paid-up capital **₹10 crore**.

[JUN-004] **RBI Master Directions on Bank Lending to REITs & InvITs (49% Aggregate Exposure Cap)**

- **Policy Harmonization:** RBI released the *Master Directions on Bank Lending to Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) and Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs)*, permitting scheduled commercial banks to lend directly to business trusts under strict prudential boundaries.
- **Eligibility & Asset Composition Norms:**
  - Banks can lend **only to SEBI-registered and publicly listed** REITs and InvITs.
  - **Operational Asset Threshold:** At least **80% of the underlying assets** of the borrowing REIT/InvIT must comprise completed, revenue-generating properties/infrastructure projects that have yielded positive cash flows for **more than one year**.
- **Aggregate Lending & Exposure Limits:**
  - **Aggregate Bank Exposure Cap:** Total lending across all commercial banks to any single borrowing REIT or InvIT (including its SPVs and holding companies) must not exceed **49% of the value of the trust's total assets**.
  - **Funding Restriction:** Bank loans to REITs/InvITs **cannot** be utilized to fund underlying Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs) that are already facing financial distress or have existing non-performing loans with regulated entities.
- **Risk Weights & Governance:**
  - Exposure to REITs attracts a **100% risk weight** (**125%** if categorized as capital market exposure).
  - Exposure to InvITs attracts corporate lending risk weights based on external credit ratings.
  - Board-approved policies mandatory; statutory migration to a comprehensive capital charge framework effective **1 April 2027**.
- **Statutory Effective Date:** Directions take effect from **1 October 2026** (banks permitted voluntary early adoption).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Aggregate Exposure Cap: **≤49%** of the value of the trust's total assets (NOT 50% or 75%).
- Completed Asset Requirement: Minimum **80%** completed and revenue-generating with >1 year positive cash flow.
- Capital Charge Migration Date: **1 April 2027**; General compliance effective **1 October 2026**.

[JUN-005] **RBI Master Directions on Authorisation of Payment System Operators (PSOs) — Perpetual Licences & Governance**

- **Statutory Authority:** Issued under **Section 4 of the Payment and Settlement Systems (PSS) Act, 2007**, governing entities seeking to operate payment systems in India.
- **Perpetual Validity Regime:**
  - All fresh Certificates of Authorisation (CoA) granted to PSOs will carry **perpetual validity** (eliminating the earlier 5-year periodic renewal requirement).
  - Existing authorized PSOs will be transitioned to perpetual validity at the time of their next renewal, subject to complete regulatory compliance.
  - **Non-Compliant Entities:** PSOs exhibiting governance or operational deficiencies will receive conditional renewals for a **limited period of 1 year only**, until deficiencies are fully rectified.
- **FDI & Foreign Investment from FATF Non-Compliant Jurisdictions:**
  - Investments from jurisdictions non-compliant with Financial Action Task Force (FATF) standards will not be treated at par with compliant countries.
  - Fresh investments from FATF non-compliant jurisdictions must account for **less than 20% of the voting power** of the PSO in aggregate.
- **Surrender of Certificate & Cooling-Off Period:**
  - Surrendering a CoA requires a written application to DPSS Central Office, accompanied by a **Statutory Auditor's certificate** confirming all customer, merchant, and bank liabilities are fully settled.
  - A mandatory **one-year cooling-off period** is imposed before an entity can re-apply if its CoA was revoked, renewal was rejected, or licence was surrendered.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Licence Validity: **Perpetual validity** for compliant PSOs; **1 year only** for non-compliant entities.
- FATF Non-Compliant Voting Cap: Must remain strictly **below 20%** of aggregate voting power.
- Cooling-Off Duration: **1 year** from revocation, surrender, or application rejection.

[JUN-006] **RBI Master Directions on Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) 2026 & Mandatory CERSAI Registration**

- **Framework Objective:** Comprehensive overhaul of the 2014 TReDS guidelines to accelerate MSME invoice monetization, expand participant categories, and eliminate duplicate factoring frauds.
- **Net Worth Requirement & Transition Timeline:**
  - Minimum Net Worth for new entities seeking TReDS platform authorization fixed at **₹25 crore** (verified by statutory auditor certificate, maintained continuously).
  - Existing authorized TReDS platforms must ramp up their net worth to ₹25 crore by **31 March 2028** (extended compliance horizon).
- **Expanded Market Participants:**
  - Platform now formally accommodates: MSME Sellers, Corporate/PSU/Government Buyers, Financers (Banks, NBFC-Factors, DFIs), **Insurance Companies** (for credit risk cover), and notified **Credit Guarantee Fund Trusts**.
- **Mandatory CERSAI Registration:**
  - Every assignment of receivables executed on a TReDS platform must be mandatorily registered with the **Central Registry of Securitisation Asset Reconstruction and Security Interest of India (CERSAI)** to legally prevent multiple discounting of the same invoice across different financiers.
- **Re-Discounting Facility:** Authorizes secondary market re-discounting of discounted factoring units between eligible financiers to facilitate liquidity optimization.
- **Current Approved TReDS Platforms (5 entities):**
  1. Receivables Exchange of India Limited (**RXIL**) — India's first operational platform (commenced 9 January 2017).
  2. M1xchange (Mynd Solutions Pvt. Ltd.).
  3. Invoicemart (A.TREDS Ltd. – Axis Bank & mjunction).
  4. C2treds (C2FO Factoring Solutions Pvt. Ltd.).
  5. DTX (KredX Platform Pvt. Ltd.).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- TReDS Minimum Net Worth: **₹25 crore**; Existing platforms must comply by **31 March 2028**.
- Fraud Prevention Registry: Mandatory registration of assigned receivables with **CERSAI**.
- First Live Platform: **RXIL** (commenced operations 9 January 2017).
- Total RBI-Approved Platforms: **5 platforms** as of June 2026.

[JUN-007] **RBI Revamped Kisan Credit Card (KCC) Scheme Directions 2026: Collateral-Free Limit Raised to ₹2 Lakh**

- **Comprehensive Overhaul:** RBI issued the *Reserve Bank of India (Kisan Credit Card – KCC) Directions, 2026*, applying to all Scheduled Commercial Banks, Small Finance Banks, RRBs, and Rural Co-operative Banks, taking effect from **1 January 2027** (existing loans continue till maturity/renewal).
- **Enhanced Collateral-Free Exemption Limit:**
  - Banks mandated to waive collateral security and margin requirements for agricultural loans up to **₹2 lakh per borrower** (raised from the earlier ₹1.60 lakh threshold).
  - Exemption equally covers allied agricultural activities (dairy, poultry, fisheries, animal husbandry).
  - Voluntary pledge of gold/silver ornaments for loans up to ₹2 lakh is permitted and will **not** be treated as a violation of collateral-free guidelines.

- KCC loans up to **₹3 lakh** secured via hypothecation of crops or assets under formal tie-up recovery arrangements may also be exempted from collateral.

- **Standardized Crop Seasons:**
  - **Short-duration crops:** Standardized strictly to **12 months** (period from raising crop to harvesting and marketing).
  - **Long-duration crops:** Standardized strictly to **18 months**.
- **Flexi KCC for Marginal Farmers:**
  - Revolving credit facility between **₹10,000 to ₹50,000** designed for marginal farmers (landholding up to 1 hectare) based on land and cropping pattern, without requiring complex cost-of-cultivation documentation.
- **Term Loan Component Repayment Horizon:**
  - Investment credit/term loan portion under KCC is repayable within a maximum of **6 years** (if asset life/repayment requires >6 years, it must be treated as a separate loan facility outside KCC).
- **Maximum Permissible Limit (MPL):**
  - Sanctioned limit based on scale of finance + 10% for post-harvest/household + 20% for maintenance/repairs.
  - For 2nd crop season onwards, MPL is notionally increased by **10% per annum** over the previous crop season's limit.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Collateral-Free Limit: **₹2 lakh per borrower** (enhanced from ₹1.60 lakh).
- Standardized Crop Seasons: Short-duration = **12 months**; Long-duration = **18 months**.
- Term Loan Under KCC: Maximum repayment tenor **6 years** (longer loans must sit outside KCC).
- Flexi KCC Limits: **₹10,000 to ₹50,000** for marginal farmers (holding ≤1 hectare).
- Effective Date: **1 January 2027**.

[JUN-008] **RBI Revamps Lead Bank Scheme (LBS): 60% CD Ratio Benchmark & 3-Tier Governance**

- **Framework Background:** RBI issued revised comprehensive guidelines for the **Lead Bank Scheme (LBS)** (first introduced in 1969 following the Gadgil Study Group and Nariman Committee recommendations).
- **Key Administrative Designations:**
  - **Lead District Manager (LDM):** Lead Bank must appoint an exclusive officer as LDM for each designated district (assignment of multiple districts to one LDM barred except in exceptional circumstances).
  - **District Development Manager (DDM):** Appointed by **NABARD** in every district to liaise between district administration and financial institutions.
  - **Lead District Officer (LDO):** Appointed by the **Reserve Bank of India** for each district to supervise credit flow.
  - **SLBC Convenor:** Convenor bank in every State/UT must designate an officer not below the rank of **General Manager (GM)** as SLBC Convenor.
- **Three-Tier Governance Structure:**
  1. *Tier 1 (Block Level)*: Block Level Bankers' Committees (**BLBCs**).
  2. *Tier 2 (District Level)*: District Consultative Committees (**DCCs**) and District Level Review Committees (DLRCs).
  3. *Tier 3 (State Level)*: State Level Bankers' Committees (**SLBCs** / UTLBCs).
- **Credit-Deposit (CD) Ratio Benchmarks & Corrective Action:**
  - Baseline Target: Minimum **60% CD Ratio** for rural and semi-urban branches on an all-India basis.
  - **CD Ratio between 40% and 60%:** Monitored by the District Consultative Committee (DCC) for step-up improvement.
  - **CD Ratio below 40%:** Mandatorily reviewed by a **Special Sub-Committee (SSC)** under DCC, chaired by the District Collector with LDM as Convenor.
  - **CD Ratio below 20%:** District placed under the **Special Category Districts** for rigorous monthly monitoring and structural intervention.
  - Similar Special Sub-Committees constituted if Annual Credit Plan (ACP) achievement falls **below 100%**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- CD Ratio Thresholds: Ideal target = **60%**; Special Sub-Committee review triggered at **<40%**; Special Category status triggered at **<20%**.
- Rank of SLBC Convenor: Not below **General Manager (GM)**.
- Lead Bank Inception: Introduced in **1969** based on Nariman Committee / F.K.F. Nariman recommendations.

[JUN-009] **DFS Launches Common Landing Portal for Unclaimed Financial Assets & UDGAM Convergence**

- **Nationwide Campaign:** Department of Financial Services (DFS), Ministry of Finance launched the *Common Landing Portal for Unclaimed Financial Assets* anchored around the national theme: *"आपकी पूँजी, आपका अधिकार"* (*Your Money, Your Right*).
- **Institutional Integration:** Integrates cross-sector unclaimed funds across multiple regulators into a unified citizen-facing interface:
  - **Bank Deposits:** RBI's **UDGAM** portal (*Unclaimed Deposits – Gateway to Access inforMation*), linking inactive accounts (10+ years) transferred to the **DEA Fund** (Depositor Education and Awareness Fund, Sec 26A BRA 1949).
  - **Dividends & Corporate Shares:** IEPFA (*Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority* under Ministry of Corporate Affairs).
  - **Insurance Dues:** Bima Bharosa / IRDAI unclaimed policyholders' ledger.
  - **Mutual Funds & Pensions:** SEBI / PFRDA centralized tracing engines.
- **Search Capability:** Centralized search across multiple banking and financial institutions using PAN, Name, Mobile Number, and Aadhaar-authenticated digital KYC.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Campaign Slogan: *"आपकी पूँजी, आपका अधिकार"* (*Your Money, Your Right*).
- Inactive Account Transfer Horizon: Savings/Current/FD inactive for **10 years or more** transferred to DEA Fund.
- UDGAM Full Form: **Unclaimed Deposits – Gateway to Access inforMation**.

[JUN-010] **RBI Annual Report 2025–26: Balance Sheet Surges 20.6% to ₹91.97 Lakh Crore & ₹2.89 Lakh Crore Surplus Transfer**

- **Statutory Submission:** Submitted by the Central Board of Directors of the Reserve Bank of India to the Central Government under **Section 53(2) of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934** (reporting period: **April 2025 – March 2026**).
- **Balance Sheet Expansion:**
  - Total balance sheet size expanded by **20.6%** (an absolute increase of **₹15,71,699.15 crore**), rising from ₹76,25,421.93 crore as on March 31, 2025 to **₹91,97,121.08 crore** as on March 31, 2026.
  - **Balance Sheet-to-GDP Ratio:** Stood at **26.4%** of India's GDP as of end-March 2026 (up from 23.7% a year ago).
  - Initial paid-up capital of the Reserve Bank remains at **₹5 crore** (constituted as a private shareholders bank in 1935, fully nationalised on January 1, 1949).
- **Surplus Transfer & Contingent Risk Buffer (CRB):**
  - **Surplus Transfer to Central Government:** RBI approved a total surplus transfer of **₹2,88,588.45 crore** (₹2.89 lakh crore) for FY26 (up 7.3% from ₹2,68,588.07 crore in FY25). Total available balance was ₹2,88,592.45 crore (with ₹4 crore statutory contributions: ₹1 crore each to National Industrial Credit Long Term Operations Fund, National Housing Credit LTO Fund, and ₹1 crore each transferable to NABARD for National Rural Credit LTO Fund and National Rural Credit Stabilisation Fund).
  - **Economic Capital Framework (ECF / Bimal Jalan Committee):** Mandates CRB within **4.5% to 7.5%** of balance sheet. The Central Board approved maintaining the CRB at the upper cap of **6.5%**.
  - **Contingency Fund (CF) Allocation:** RBI made a provision of **₹1,09,379.64 crore** (~₹1.09 lakh crore) transferred to CF during the year. No provision was made towards Asset Development Fund (ADF).
- **Asset Composition & Financial Performance:**

- **Total Income:** Increased by **26.4%**, while total expenditure rose by **102.4%**.
- **Foreign Assets (70.9%):** Foreign investments rose 7.9% to ₹52.68 lakh crore; sovereign gold holdings jumped **63.8%** to ₹10.94 lakh crore. Net sale of foreign exchange stood at **USD 53.13 billion**, yielding net exchange gains of **₹1.69 lakh crore**.
- **Domestic Assets (29.1%):** Rose 44.9% to ₹22.59 lakh crore. Rupee securities interest income grew 37.7% to ₹1.18 lakh crore.
- **Liabilities Breakdown:** Revaluation accounts (+63.4%), Notes issued (+11.8%), Deposits (+11.6%), Other liabilities (+21.1%).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Balance Sheet Size: **₹91,97,121.08 crore** (+20.6% YoY growth; **26.4% of GDP**).
- Surplus Transferred to GoI: **₹2,88,588.45 crore** (FY25: ₹2,68,588.07 crore).
- Provision to Contingency Fund (CF): **₹1,09,379.64 crore** (CRB pegged at **6.5%**; ECF band: 4.5%–7.5%).
- Section Applied: Section 53(2) for Annual Report submission; initial capital remains ₹5 crore (nationalised Jan 1, 1949).

[JUN-011] **RBI Annual Report 2025–26: Currency Management, Counterfeits (FICNs) & Digital Rupee (e₹)**

- **Banknotes & Coins in Circulation:**
  - **Banknotes in Circulation (BiC):** Increased by **11.9% in value** and **10.5% in volume** during 2025–26.
  - **Highest Denomination Share:** In volume terms, the **₹500 denomination** constituted the highest share of total banknotes in circulation, followed by the **₹10 denomination**.
  - **Coins in Circulation:** Total value increased by **11.4%**, while volume expanded by **4.5%**. Coins of ₹1, ₹2, and ₹5 together constituted **80.7% of total volume** and **60.2% of total value**.
  - **₹2000 Note Withdrawal Status:** As of March 31, 2026, **98.45%** of the ₹3.56 lakh crore worth of ₹2000 banknotes in circulation at the time of the withdrawal announcement (May 19, 2023) had returned to the banking system. Facility remains active across 19 RBI Issue Offices.
- **Central Bank Digital Currency (e₹):**
  - Total e₹ (CBDC) in circulation stood at **₹771.7 crore** as on March 31, 2026.
  - Retail programmable CBDC pilots successfully credited food subsidies to Public Distribution System (PDS) beneficiaries across **Gujarat, Puducherry, and Chandigarh**.
  - RBI launched the **Unified Markets Interface (UMI)** to facilitate tokenisation of financial assets using wholesale CBDC (first pilot launched on **Certificates of Deposit - CDs**).
  - Bilateral cross-border CBDC discussions/MoUs held with **Monetary Authority of Singapore (MAS)** and **Central Bank of the UAE (CBUAE)**; joined BIS Innovation Hub's **Project Rialto** and **Project Mandala (Phase 2)**.
- **Counterfeit Currency (FICNs) Detection:**
  - **Share of Detection:** Only **2.4%** of total Fake Indian Currency Notes (FICNs) detected across the banking sector were detected at the Reserve Bank of India; **97.6%** were detected by commercial banks.
  - **Denomination Trends:** Counterfeit notes detected in ₹10, ₹50, ₹100, ₹200, and ₹2000 denominations registered a marked decline; counterfeit ₹500 notes increased by **20.5%** and ₹20 notes increased by **47.4%**.
  - **Currency Infrastructure & Awareness: State Bank of India (SBI)** accounted for the highest share of Currency Chests across India. RBI replaced its legacy 'Paisa Bolta Hai' portal with the comprehensive **Indian Currency Microsite** on September 10, 2025. Print trials of varnished banknotes were conducted at **BRBNMPL Mysuru Press**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total CBDC (e₹) in Circulation: **₹771.7 crore** (as of March 31, 2026).
- ₹2000 Note Return Rate: **98.45%** of ₹3.56 lakh crore total value returned.
- FICN Detection Share: Reserve Bank detected **2.4%**; Commercial Banks detected **97.6%**.
- Banknote Value/Volume Growth: Value grew **11.9%**; Volume grew **10.5%** (₹500 note leads volume share).
- Largest Currency Chest Holder: **State Bank of India (SBI)**.

[JUN-012] **RBI Annual Report 2025–26: Bank Frauds, Supervisory Reforms & Regulatory Modernisation**

- **Systemic Fraud Surge:**
  - Total fraud amount surged **46% to ₹48,021 crore** in 2025–26 (from ₹32,803 crore in FY25), even as total reported fraud incidents fell by more than half to 10,114 cases.
  - **Public Sector Banks (PSBs):** Accounted for **74.5%** of total fraud value (**₹35,709 crore** across 3,000+ cases; average fraud size ₹6.6 crore).
  - **Private Sector Banks:** Accounted for **23.7%** (₹11,399 crore).
  - **Dominant Segment: Loan Advances** accounted for **85%** of total fraud value (**₹40,774 crore** across 8,640 cases).
- **Consolidation of Regulations Exercise:**
  - To streamline compliance, more than **11,000 circulars and instructions** were consolidated into **244 Master Directions (MDs)** covering 30 functional areas across 11 classes of Regulated Entities (REs), repealing **9,445 circulars**.
  - RBI also released **64 draft master directions** across 9 functional supervisory areas.
- **Deposit Insurance & Supervisory Governance:**
  - **DICGC Premium:** Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (established under DICGC Act, 1961) maintained a flat-rate premium of **₹0.12 (12 paise) per ₹100 per annum** (0.12% p.a.) on assessable deposits; coverage limit intact at **₹5 lakh** per depositor per bank.
  - **Risk-Based Premium (RBP) Framework:** Introduced effective **April 1, 2026**, establishing a 2-tier risk-based rating methodology (Tier 1: SCBs other than RRBs; Tier 2: RRBs, rural co-op banks, and UCBs).
  - **Registered Insured Banks:** Stood at **1,950** as of March 31, 2026 (124 commercial banks including 11 SFBs, 6 PBs, 28 RRBs, 2 LABs; and 1,826 co-operative banks).
  - **Supervisory Data Quality Index (sDQI):** Published on a **quarterly** basis under Utkarsh 2.0.
  - **Co-Lending Framework Revision:** Reduced minimum loan share retention by Regulated Entities from 20% to **10%**, and extended First Loss Default Guarantee (FLDG) coverage up to **5%**.
- **AI Governance & FinTech Architecture:**
  - **FREE-AI Framework:** RBI formulated the *Framework for Responsible and Ethical Enablement of Artificial Intelligence* anchored on **7 Sutras** and **6 Strategic Pillars** (26 recommendations: 13 on innovation enablement, 13 on risk mitigation).
  - **MuleHunter.ai™:** AI/ML supervised model developed by RBI Innovation Hub (RBIH) to identify mule bank accounts in near-real time.
  - **Digital Payment Intelligence Platform (DPIP):** Established as a collaborative network-level digital intelligence utility to combat payment fraud.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Consolidation of Regulations: **11,000+ circulars** condensed into **244 Master Directions**; 9,445 repealed.
- DICGC Flat Premium: **0.12% per annum** (12 paise per ₹100); RBP framework effective **April 1, 2026**.
- Co-Lending Retention Minimum: Lowered to **10%** (FLDG cover up to **5%**).
- FREE-AI Architecture: **7 Sutras** + **6 Pillars** + **26 Recommendations**; Mule detector = **MuleHunter.ai™**.
- Total System Frauds: **₹48,021 crore** (PSBs = 74.5%; Advances = ₹40,774 crore / 85%).

[JUN-013] **RBI Annual Report 2025–26: Monetary Operations, Payment Systems & Organisational Milestones**

- **Monetary Policy Operations & Corridors:**
  - **Policy Corridor:** Retained a symmetric policy corridor of **50 bps** around the policy repo rate (SDF at -25 bps, MSF at +25 bps).
  - **Call Money & Repo Market Timings:** Call money market trading hours extended to **7:00 PM** (effective July 1, 2025; 9:00 AM – 7:00 PM); tri-party and market repo extended to **4:00 PM** (effective August 1, 2025).
  - **Liquidity Stance:** Average daily net absorption under LAF rose to **₹1.86 lakh crore** (from ₹1,605 crore in FY25); SDF accounted for **84.9%** (₹2.02 lakh crore) of total absorption. WACR spread averaged **(-) 7 bps** below the repo rate.

- **External Benchmark Lending Rate (EBLR):** As of December 2025, EBLR-linked loans accounted for **50.6%** of floating-rate loans at Public Sector Banks and **89.2%** at Private Sector Banks.

- **Payment & Settlement Infrastructure:**
  - **UPI Volume & Dominance:** UPI volume surged **30% YoY**, crossing **200 billion transactions**; UPI's share in total retail payment transactions reached **86%**.
  - **Global UPI Footprint:** QR-code merchant acceptance operational in **8 countries** (Bhutan, France, Mauritius, Nepal, Qatar, Singapore, Sri Lanka, and the UAE).
  - **NGRTGS Upgraded to Version 4.0:** Built on the international **ISO 20022 XML messaging standard**; RTGS transaction volume grew **15.7%** (value rose 12.9%).
  - **Banking Web Domains:** Under Phase 1, bank websites mandated to migrate to exclusive **.bank.in** domains by October 31, 2025.
  - **Cheque Clearing Centralisation:** Inward clearing centralised by setting up a national service branch at **Chennai Regional Office**, replacing decentralised operations across 19 ROs.
  - **PRAVAAH Portal:** Centralised web portal for regulatory approvals and licensing processed over 90%+ digitised flows.

- **Organisational & Institutional Governance:**
  - **Utkarsh 2029:** Reserve Bank adopted its next medium-term strategy framework covering a **3-year horizon (2026–29)** across 6 strategic pillars.
  - **Leadership Changes: Shri Shirish Chandra Murmu** appointed Deputy Governor succeeding Shri M. Rajeshwar Rao (tenure completed October 8, 2025); **Ms. Anuradha Thakur** nominated Central Board Director succeeding Shri Ajay Seth (July 24, 2025).
  - **Public Engagement:** Launched official podcast series **'RBI Talks: From Paisa to Policy'** on January 1, 2026 (debut episode on KYC). Nationwide public awareness tagline: *"RBI Kehta Hai... Smart Bano, Cool Raho"*.
  - **Training & Infrastructure:** Reserve Bank Staff College (RBSC) located in **Chennai**; College of Agricultural Banking (CAB) in **Pune**; College of Supervisors (CoS) in **Mumbai**; ECCTI in **Bhubaneswar**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- UPI Transaction Metrics: Over **200 billion transactions** (+30% YoY); **86% share** of total retail payments.
- QR-Code Global Footprint: Operational across **8 nations**.
- NGRTGS Upgrade: Upgraded to **Version 4.0** (ISO 20022 messaging standard).
- Bank Domain Transition: **.bank.in** mandatory migration date October 31, 2025.
- Utkarsh 2029 Horizon: **3-year cycle (2026–2029)**.
- Official RBI Podcast: **'RBI Talks: From Paisa to Policy'** (Tagline: *"Smart Bano, Cool Raho"*).
- Deputy Governor Appointment: **Shri Shirish Chandra Murmu** (succeeding M. Rajeshwar Rao).

[JUN-014] **RBI 61st MPC Meeting (June 2026): Repo Rate Held at 5.25% with Neutral Stance**

- **Monetary Policy Review:** The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) conducted its 61st meeting (2nd Bi-Monthly Meeting of FY 2026-27), chaired by RBI Governor Sanjay Malhotra.
- **Policy Rates Decision:**
  - **Policy Repo Rate:** Kept unchanged at **5.25%** under the Liquidity Adjustment Facility (LAF).
  - **Standing Deposit Facility (SDF):** Unchanged at **5.00%** (25 bps below repo rate).
  - **Marginal Standing Facility (MSF) & Bank Rate:** Unchanged at **5.50%** (25 bps above repo rate).
  - **Reserve Ratios:** Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) maintained at **3.00%**; Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR) at **18.00%**; Fixed Reverse Repo Rate at **3.35%**.
- **Monetary Policy Stance:** Decided unanimously to continue with the **"Neutral"** stance, indicating flexibility to move rates in either direction based on emerging inflation-growth dynamics.
- **Macroeconomic Growth & Inflation Forecasts:**
  - **Real GDP Growth for FY27:** Projected at **6.6%** (Q1 at 6.6%, Q2 at 6.3%, Q3 at 6.5%, Q4 at 6.8%).
  - **CPI Inflation for FY27:** Projected at **5.1%** (Q1 at 4.2%, Q2 at 5.1%, Q3 at 5.9%, Q4 at 5.4%).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Policy Repo Rate: **5.25%** (SDF: 5.00%, MSF/Bank Rate: 5.50%).
- Policy Stance: **Neutral** (not "Withdrawal of Accommodation").
- GDP & Inflation Projections: Real GDP = **6.6%**, CPI Inflation = **5.1%**.

[JUN-015] **RBI Introduces Special USD-Rupee Forex Swap Facilities to Attract Capital Inflows**

- **Twin Forex Swap Windows:** To stabilize the Rupee against crude oil volatility and encourage foreign currency inflows, RBI introduced two concessional USD-INR forex swap facilities:
  1. *FCNR(B) Window*: For fresh **Foreign Currency Non-Resident Bank [FCNR(B)]** deposits of 3 to 5 years maturity.
  2. *ECB/OFCB Window*: For fresh External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs) and Overseas Foreign Currency Borrowings (OFCBs) raised by AD Category-I banks (maturity ≥3 years).
- **Concessional Pricing & Tenor:**
  - **Fixed Swap Rate:** Swaps executed at a fixed rate of **1.5% per annum** (compounded semi-annually), significantly below prevailing market hedging rates.
  - **Tenor:** Aligned with borrowing maturity, capped at a maximum of **5 years**.
  - **Operational Windows:** FCNR(B) swap window open till **16 October 2026** (deposits mobilized up to 30 Sept 2026); ECB/OFCB window open till **15 January 2027** (inflows up to 31 Dec 2026).
- **Statutory Reserve Exemptions & NOP-INR Relief:**
  - Eligible FCNR(B) deposits mobilized under this scheme are **exempt from CRR (3.0%) and SLR (18.0%)** requirements.
  - RBI **exempted swap positions from Net Open Position in Rupee (NOP-INR) limits** (which restricts banks' onshore deliverable positions to USD 100 million at end of day), allowing banks to swap up to hundreds of millions without breaching exposure caps.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Fixed Swap Rate: **1.5% per annum** compounded semi-annually.
- Statutory Exemptions: Fresh FCNR(B) deposits under the scheme are **exempt from CRR and SLR**.
- NOP-INR Rule: Banks are normally subject to a **$100 million Net Open Position** deliverable cap, which is waived for these swaps.

[JUN-016] **Ministry of Finance & RBI Reform FPI Debt Framework: Capital Gains Exemption & PROI Limit Hike**

- **Income-Tax Exemption on Sovereign Debt:**
  - Central Government notified that tax liability for Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPIs/FIIs) on specified Government Securities (G-Secs) investments is **reduced to Nil** effective **1 April 2026**.
  - Both **interest income and capital gains** (earlier Short-Term Capital Gains taxed at 30%, Long-Term at 12.5%) earned from specified G-Secs are completely exempt from tax.
  - Similar comprehensive tax exemption extended to the **Bank for International Settlements (BIS)**.
- **Liberalisation for Persons Resident Outside India (PROI):**
  - Permitted individual **Persons Resident Outside India (PROIs)** (including non-NRIs/OCIs) to invest in listed Indian equity through the Portfolio Investment Scheme (PIS).
  - **Individual Limit:** Increased from 5% to **10%** of the paid-up equity capital of an Indian company.
  - **Aggregate Limit:** Increased from 10% to **24%** for all PROIs combined.
- **FPI Limits under General Route Rationalized:**
  - Short-term investment limit (earlier capped at 30% for securities with residual maturity up to 1 year) **completely removed**.
  - Concentration limits (earlier 10% to 15% per corporate debt issuer) **completely removed**.

- Retained quantitative sovereign caps: **6.0%** of outstanding stock in Central G-Secs and **2.0%** in State Development Loans (SDLs).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- FPI G-Sec Tax Rate: Reduced to **Nil** from 1 April 2026 (both interest and capital gains).
- PROI Equity Investment Caps: Individual limit raised to **10%** (from 5%); Aggregate limit raised to **24%** (from 10%).
- FPI G-Sec Stock Caps: **6%** for Central Government Securities, **2%** for SDLs.

[JUN-017] **President Approves Mega-Merger of REC Limited into Power Finance Corporation (PFC)**

- **Sovereign Consolidation Directive:** The President of India formally approved the strategic merger of **REC Limited** (formerly Rural Electrification Corporation) into **Power Finance Corporation Limited (PFC)**, creating India's largest consolidated state-run non-banking infrastructure finance conglomerate.
- **Strategic & Regulatory Rationale:**
  - PFC had acquired a controlling 52.63% stake in REC Limited in March 2019 for ₹14,500 crore under the government's disinvestment program.
  - The full operational and legal merger eliminates duplicate regulatory compliance, optimizes capital adequacy ratios (CRAR), reduces borrowing costs on global debt markets, and consolidates over ₹10 Lakh Crore in unified loan book assets dedicated to India's power and renewable transmission infrastructure.
- **Institutional Profile:**
  - Both entities are **Maharatna Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs)** operating under the administrative aegis of the Ministry of Power.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Merging CPSEs: **REC Limited merged into Power Finance Corporation (PFC)** (NOT IREDA or NHPC).
- Administrative Ministry: **Ministry of Power**.
- Corporate Status: Both holding **Maharatna CPSE** classification.

[JUN-018] **Government Nominates Sanjay Lohiya to Central Boards of Reserve Bank of India & SBI**

- **Key Governance Appointments:** The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) approved the nomination of **Sanjay Lohiya**, Special Secretary in the Department of Financial Services (**DFS**), Ministry of Finance, as a Government Nominee Director on key financial apex boards.
- **Dual Directorship Portfolio:**
  - Appointed as **Non-Executive Director on the Central Board of Directors of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** under Section 8(1)(d) of the *RBI Act, 1934*.
  - Simultaneously nominated as **Director on the Central Board of the State Bank of India (SBI)** under Section 19(e) of the *State Bank of India Act, 1955*.
- **Institutional Context:** Fills key government liaison and policy-oversight vacancies following high-level administrative reshuffles within the Ministry of Finance.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Nominated Director: **Sanjay Lohiya** (Special Secretary, DFS, Ministry of Finance).
- Apex Boards Appointed To: **Reserve Bank of India (Central Board)** and **State Bank of India (Central Board)**.
- Statutory Basis: Section 8(1)(d) of *RBI Act, 1934* & Section 19(e) of *SBI Act, 1955*.

[JUN-019] **Hitesh Joshi Appointed CMD of GIC Re; Tushar Mehta Reappointed Solicitor General of India**

- **Insurance Reinsurance Leadership:** The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet approved the appointment of **Hitesh Rameshchandra Joshi** as the **Chairman-cum-Managing Director (CMD)** of the **General Insurance Corporation of**

India (GIC Re), the nation's sole domestic reinsurance company.
  - GIC Re was established on **22 November 1972** under the *General Insurance Business (Nationalisation) Act, 1972*; Headquartered in Mumbai, Maharashtra.

- **Legal Apex Reappointment:**
  - Senior Advocate **Tushar Mehta** was reappointed as the **Solicitor General of India (SGI)** for a further three-year term effective **1 July 2026**.
  - Mehta has served as Solicitor General since October 2018, functioning as the secondary law officer assisting the Attorney General for India (R. Venkataramani).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New CMD of GIC Re: **Hitesh Rameshchandra Joshi**.
- GIC Re Foundation Date: **22 November 1972** (Headquarters: Mumbai).
- Solicitor General of India Reappointment: **Tushar Mehta** (effective 1 July 2026 for a 3-year term).

[JUN-020] **Bank of Baroda & Federal Bank Launch Specialized NRI & High-Yield Retail Deposit Products**

- **Public Sector Mobilization (Bank of Baroda):**
  - **'bob Legend FCNR(B) Deposit Scheme':** Introduced specialized foreign currency fixed deposits offering preferential, premium interest yields across major convertible currencies (USD, GBP, EUR) targeting Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) and Overseas Citizens of India (OCIs).
  - **'bob Golden Goal Deposit Scheme':** Launched high-yield domestic retail term deposit offering interest rates of **up to 7.40% per annum** for a unique, fixed maturity tenor of **555 days** (applicable for deposits below ₹3 crore).
- **Private Sector Inflow Mobilization (Federal Bank):**
  - Federal Bank rolled out the **'FCNR Max Deposit Scheme'**, offering enhanced floating-rate linked dollar deposit yields designed to capture repatriable remittance surpluses amidst global rate adjustments.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 'bob Golden Goal Deposit' Tenor & Rate: **555 days** tenor with interest up to **7.40%** (for deposits < ₹3 crore).
- Bank Offering 'bob Legend FCNR(B)': **Bank of Baroda**.
- Bank Offering 'FCNR Max Deposit': **Federal Bank** (private sector lender).

[JUN-021] **Government Reappoints Swaminathan Janakiraman as RBI Deputy Governor for 2-Year Term**

- **Apex Central Banking Leadership:** The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) approved the extension of tenure of **Swaminathan Janakiraman** as **Deputy Governor of the Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** for a further period of **two years**.
- **Tenure Background:**
  - Originally appointed in June 2023 for a three-year term, succeeding Mahesh Kumar Jain. The two-year extension reinforces continuity in banking supervision and regulatory inspection.
- **Statutory Framework:**
  - Under Section 8(1)(a) of the *Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934*, the Central Bank is mandated to have **four Deputy Governors** appointed by the Central Government.
  - Swaminathan leads critical operational portfolios including the **Department of Supervision (DoS)**, **Department of Inspection**, and **Financial Inclusion and Development Department (FIDD)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Reappointed Deputy Governor: **Swaminathan Janakiraman** (extended by **2 years**).
- Statutory Deputy Governor Strength: Exactly **4 Deputy Governors** under Section 8(1)(a) of *RBI Act, 1934*.
- Key Portfolios: **Banking Supervision, Inspection, and Financial Inclusion**.

[JUN-022] **RBI Payments Bulletin: Private Banks Command 71.1% of Credit Cards as UPI QR Surges to 7,313 Lakh**

- **Payment System Landscape:** Reserve Bank of India's payment systems report revealed structural market-share shifts across payment instruments and digital acquiring rails in India:
- **Credit Card Issuance Dominance:**
  - **Private Sector Banks:** Expanded their dominance in outstanding credit cards to **71.1%** in 2025 (up +3.4 percentage points from 67.7% in 2021).
  - **Public Sector Banks (PSBs):** Maintained a modest **23.9% market share** (slight uptick from 23.5%).
  - **Foreign Banks:** Shrank dramatically to **3.8%** (down -5.5 percentage points from 9.3% in 2021) following retail portfolio divestments.
- **Acquiring Infrastructure Paradigm Shift:**
  - **UPI QR Code Footprint:** Deployed UPI QR terminals across merchant locations escalated from **6,782 lakh (June 2025)** to **7,313 lakh (December 2025)**, underpinning rapid digital formalization.
  - Traditional acquiring rails (ATMs, physical PoS swipe machines, and Micro-ATMs) witnessed relative stagnation and contraction as lower-cost interoperable UPI QR codes became the default merchant payment acceptance medium.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Private Banks Credit Card Market Share: **71.1%** (commanding nearly three-fourths of market).
- Foreign Banks Share Contraction: Sunk to **3.8%** (from 9.3%).
- UPI QR Terminal Deployment: Reached **7,313 lakh** by December 2025.

2. CAPITAL MARKETS, SEBI & PENSIONS REGULATION

[JUN-023] **SEBI Revises Trading Framework for ETFs: Dynamic Price Bands & Pre-Open Auction**

- **Regulatory Directive:** Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) revamped the trading framework for **Exchange Traded Funds (ETFs)**, taking effect from **1 September 2026**, replacing the rigid 20% fixed NAV price band.
- **Dynamic Price Band Architecture:**
  - **Equity & Debt ETFs:** Initial dynamic price band set at **10%**. If touched, a cooling-off period is triggered, followed by phased expansions in **increments of 5% up to a maximum of 20%**.
  - **Overnight & Liquid ETFs:** Completely **excluded** from dynamic price bands.
- **Commodity ETFs (Gold & Silver ETFs):**
  - Initial dynamic price band set at **±6%**.
  - Expandable in stages of **3%** following a cooling-off period, with **no upper or lower limit** on total price expansions during a trading session to mirror global bullion market volatility.
- **Base Price Determination via VWAP:**
  - ETF base price determined using the **Volume-Weighted Average Price (VWAP)** of trades executed during the **last 30 minutes** of the previous trading day.
- **Pre-Open Call Auction Mechanism:**
  - Introduced a dedicated Pre-Open Call Auction session specifically for **commodity ETFs** to ensure fair price discovery prior to regular market open.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Initial Dynamic Price Bands: **10%** for Equity/Debt ETFs (max 20%); **±6%** for Commodity Gold/Silver ETFs (expandable by 3%, no cap).
- Excluded Categories: **Overnight and Liquid ETFs**.
- Base Price Formula: VWAP of the **last 30 minutes** of trading.
- Effective Date: **1 September 2026**.

[JUN-024] **BSE Launches 'BSE Saatvik 100 Index' — India's First Ethical & Values-Based Benchmark**

- **Launch Overview:** BSE Index Services Private Limited (wholly-owned subsidiary of Bombay Stock Exchange) unveiled India's first values-based ethical index: **BSE Saatvik 100 Index**.
- **Constituent Selection & Universe:**
  - Derived from the **BSE 500** universe; screens and selects top **100 companies** adhering strictly to ethical, vegetarian/cruelty-free, and socially responsible business practices (excluding liquor, tobacco, gambling, meat processing, and defense weapons).
- **Index Parameters & Reconstitution:**
  - **Base Value:** Fixed at **1000**.
  - **First Value Date (Inception Date): June 20, 2005**.
  - **Reconstitution Frequency:** Reconstituted **semi-annually in June and December**.
  - **Top Sector Contribution: Financial Services** is the single largest sector weight, accounting for **37.55%** of the index.
  - **Top Stock Weight: HDFC Bank Limited** is the largest individual constituent.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Index Base Value & Date: Base value **1000**; Base date **June 20, 2005**.
- Constituent Count: **100 companies** derived from the BSE 500.
- Top Sector Weight: **Financial Services (37.55%)**, led by HDFC Bank.

[JUN-025] **IRDAI Constitutes 7-Member Working Group on Artificial Intelligence (WG-AI)**

- **Mandate & Genesis:** Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) formed a specialized 7-member Working Group on Artificial Intelligence (**WG-AI**) to frame an ethical AI governance architecture for India's insurance sector.
- **Leadership:** Chaired by **Prof. Sandeep K. Shukla**, Director of the International Institute of Information Technology (**IIIT Hyderabad**).
- **Submission Horizon:** Mandated to submit its comprehensive recommendation report within **3 months** to the Member (Finance and Investment – F&I), IRDAI.
- **Core Scope:** Algorithmic fairness in underwriting, fraud detection, privacy safeguards for generative AI in claims processing, and preventing socioeconomic bias in health/life insurance pricing.
- **IRDAI Statutory Background:** Established pursuant to the R. N. Malhotra Committee (1993); incorporated under the *IRDA Act, 1999*; statutory body since **2000**; Composition: 1 Chairman + 5 full-time + 4 part-time members.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Committee Chairman: **Prof. Sandeep K. Shukla** (Director, IIIT Hyderabad).
- Reporting Window: **3 months** from constitution.
- Foundational Committee of IRDAI: **R. N. Malhotra Committee** (1993).

[JUN-026] **PFRDA Eases NPS Annuity Exit Rules & Launches 'StAR NPS' Digital Onboarding Platform**

- **Exit Relaxation in NPS Annuities:**
  - Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) relaxed rigid lifetime lock-in norms for annuity contracts purchased under the National Pension System (NPS).
  - **Surrender for Hardship:** Annuity Service Providers (ASPs) are now permitted to allow **surrender of annuity policies** in exceptional hardship cases, specifically where the annuitant or an immediate family member is diagnosed with a **critical illness**.
  - **Pre-October 2024 Policies:** Applies to annuity products issued prior to 24 October 2024 provided the contract contained an underlying surrender clause.

- **Reporting to CRA:** ASPs must report all approved annuity surrender cases to the Central Recordkeeping Agency (CRA) within **7 working days**.

- **Launch of 'StAR NPS' Digital Assisted Onboarding:**
  - PFRDA introduced **'StAR NPS'**, a cutting-edge assisted digital onboarding platform developed by **BSE Technologies Private Limited (BTPL)**.
  - Facilitates instant 12-digit **Permanent Retirement Account Number (PRAN)** generation through real-time CRA integration, Central KYC (CKYC), and DigiLocker.
  - Open to Indian residents aged **18 to 85 years**; Onboarding fee of **₹200** per subscriber borne by the respective Point of Presence (PoP).

- **PFRDA Regulatory Sandbox Framework:**
  - Operationalized from **2 June 2026** to enable controlled live testing of innovative pension tech solutions.
  - Eligible applicants include registered intermediaries, fintech firms, and LLPs with a minimum net worth of **₹10 lakh**.
  - Mandatory reporting: Monthly progress reports, plus any fraud incident or financial loss must be reported within **24 hours**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Annuity Surrender Ground: Eased exclusively for **critical illness** (self or family); CRA must be notified within **7 working days**.
- StAR NPS Developer: **BSE Technologies Private Limited (BTPL)**; Onboarding fee = **₹200** (borne by PoP).
- Maximum Entry Age under Framework: Up to **85 years** (expanded from 70).
- Regulatory Sandbox Net Worth: Minimum **₹10 lakh**; Fraud incidents reportable within **24 hours**.

[JUN-027] **Nuvama Wealth Receives SEBI Approval for Mutual Fund Operations**

- **Market Entry:** Nuvama Wealth Management Limited received final regulatory approval from the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) to commence **Mutual Fund (MF) operations** in India.
- **Asset Management Subsidiary:** Mutual fund operations will be conducted through its wholly-owned subsidiary, **Nuvama Asset Management Limited (NAML)**.
- **Regulatory Context:** Marks the continued expansion of non-banking wealth management houses into retail and passive asset management under SEBI's mutual fund licensing guidelines.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Entity Name: **Nuvama Wealth Management Limited** (Asset Management arm: Nuvama Asset Management Ltd).
- Regulatory Licensor: **SEBI** (chaired by Tuhin Kanta Pandey).

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3. MULTILATERAL AGREEMENTS & CROSS-BORDER PAYMENTS

[JUN-028] **NPCI International (NIPL) Expands Cross-Border UPI to Cambodia via KHQR Network**

- **Bilateral Linkage:** NPCI International Payments Limited (**NIPL**), the global arm of the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), partnered with Cambodia's **ACLEDA Bank Plc** to enable cross-border QR payments.
- **Payment Architecture:**
  - Connects India's Unified Payments Interface (**UPI**) with Cambodia's national **KHQR** (Khmer Quick Response) code system.
  - Operates under the umbrella of the National Bank of Cambodia's **Bakong digital payment network**.
  - Enables Indian tourists to scan KHQR codes at Cambodian merchants directly using Indian UPI apps, settling in local Khmer Riel (KHR) and USD.
- **Global Footprint of UPI:**
  - Cambodia becomes the **9th country** to enable merchant QR code acceptance for UPI.

- Existing acceptance network spans: **Bhutan, France, Mauritius, Nepal, Singapore, Sri Lanka, UAE, Qatar, and Cambodia**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Cambodian Partner Bank: **ACLEDA Bank Plc**.
- Cambodian QR & System Name: **KHQR code** under the **Bakong** digital payment system.
- Total Cross-Border UPI Footprint: **9 countries** for QR acceptance.

[JUN-029] **BharatPe Launches 'BharatPe Flex' Credit-on-UPI Solution in Partnership with YES Bank**

- **Product Innovation:** Leading fintech platform BharatPe partnered with **YES Bank Limited** to launch **'BharatPe Flex'**, an interoperable Credit-on-UPI line.
- **Core Mechanism:**
  - Allows eligible retail and merchant customers to make daily merchant UPI payments using a pre-approved credit line sanctioned by YES Bank.
  - Features an interest-free credit period of **up to 45 days**, with flexible conversion of outstandings into Equated Monthly Instalments (EMIs).
- **Regulatory Framework:** Built on the Reserve Bank of India's operational guidelines permitting scheduled commercial banks to link pre-sanctioned credit lines as funding accounts on the UPI network.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Banking Partner for BharatPe Flex: **YES Bank Limited** (NOT SBI or ICICI).
- Interest-Free Credit Tenor: Up to **45 days**.
- Regulatory Enabler: RBI's framework allowing **Credit Lines on UPI**.

[JUN-030] **Pine Labs Unveils 'P3P': India's First Agentic Payment Protocol Built on UPI**

- **Technological Breakthrough:** Leading fintech unicorn Pine Labs launched the **Pine Labs Payment Protocol (P3P)**, heralded as India's first agentic payment protocol natively integrated with the Unified Payments Interface (**UPI**).
- **Core AI-Payment Mechanics:**
  - Enables artificial intelligence agents to autonomously discover products, negotiate dynamic pricing, and execute verified machine-to-machine financial transactions.
  - Completely bypasses traditional manual screen-based human authentication by utilizing cryptographically tokenized authorization keys.
  - Safeguarded by user-defined operational guardrails: consumers pre-set maximum spend thresholds, transaction frequency caps, and permitted merchant categories.
- **Architectural Significance:** Bridges Large Language Model (LLM) agent frameworks with the National Payments Corporation of India's (**NPCI**) real-time settlement rails, establishing the infrastructural foundation for the agentic commerce economy in India.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Protocol Name: **Pine Labs Payment Protocol (P3P)** (NOT Razorpay Agent or PhonePe AI).
- Underlying Rail: Built natively on **UPI / NPCI network**.
- Operating Principle: Autonomous AI agent execution within **pre-configured consumer spend caps**.

[JUN-031] **Skydo Receives Canadian MSB Licence: First Indian Cross-Border Payments Fintech to Secure Foreign Regulatory Approval**

- **Global Expansion Milestone:** Bengaluru-headquartered B2B cross-border fintech **Skydo** achieved an international breakthrough by securing a Money Services Business (**MSB**) licence from the Financial Transactions and Reports

Analysis Centre of Canada (**FINTRAC**).

- **Historic Regulatory First:**
  - Skydo becomes the **first Indian cross-border payment company** to obtain a direct overseas financial regulatory licence.
  - Grants direct operational authority to facilitate real-time export receivables, FX clearing, and commercial remittances between Canadian importers and Indian MSME exporters.
- **Institutional Profile:**
  - Co-founded in **2022** in Bengaluru by Movin Jain and Srivatsan Sridhar.
  - Operates transparent flat-fee FX remittance architecture, directly challenging legacy correspondent banking spreads that charge up to 3–5% on cross-border invoices.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Indian Cross-Border Fintech Licensed Overseas: **Skydo** (NOT Razorpay or Cashfree).
- Licensing Jurisdiction & Authority: **Canada (FINTRAC)** as Money Services Business (MSB).
- Headquarters: **Bengaluru, Karnataka** (Founded in 2022).

[JUN-032] **Uzbekistan Admitted to New Development Bank (NDB) as First Central Asian Member**

- **Multilateral Expansion:** The Board of Governors of the **New Development Bank (NDB)** formally approved the Republic of Uzbekistan as a full member of the multilateral development institution.
- **Geopolitical Significance:**
  - Uzbekistan becomes the **very first Central Asian nation** to join the NDB, expanding the bank's non-founding geographic reach into the Eurasian economic corridor.
  - Head of State: President **Shavkat Mirziyoyev**; Capital: **Tashkent**; Currency: **Uzbek sum (UZS)**.
- **NDB Institutional Profile & Governance Safeguards:**
  - President of NDB: **Dilma Vana Rousseff** (former President of Brazil); Headquartered in **Shanghai, China**; established in 2014 (operationalized 2015) by BRICS nations.
  - **Three Statutory Voting Safeguards:**
    1. **Founding BRICS Member Floor:** Combined voting power of the 5 founding members (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa) must permanently remain **above 55%**.
    2. **Individual Non-Founding Cap:** No single non-founding member country may hold more than **7% voting power**.
    3. **Non-Borrowing Developed Ceiling:** Total equity and voting share of non-borrowing developed member nations must remain strictly **below 20%**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Central Asian Member of NDB: **Uzbekistan** (Capital: Tashkent).
- NDB Headquarters: **Shanghai, China** (President: **Dilma Rousseff**).
- Founding BRICS Voting Power Floor: Must remain **>55%** (a core banking MCQ).
- Single Non-Founding Country Cap: Capped at **≤7%**.

[JUN-033] **World Bank Sanctions $1.5 Billion DPF Loan for Job Creation & ₹4,000 Crore for Haryana Water Project**

- **Two Major World Bank Sovereign Financings:** The Executive Board of the World Bank approved two massive financial packages totaling over ₹16,500 crore to support India's economic modernization and resource sustainability.
- **$1.5 Billion Private Sector Development Policy Financing (DPF):**
  - Sanctioned to accelerate India's structural policy reforms aimed at catalyzing private investment and high-productivity job creation.
  - Focuses on simplifying trade logistics, digitalizing business licensures, and easing commercial regulatory compliance across industrial states.

- **₹4,000 Crore Loan for Jal Sanrakshit Haryana Project:**
  - Provides concessional development funding for the **Jal Sanrakshit Haryana Project**, engineered to transform groundwater management, implement micro-irrigation at scale, and restore waterlogged agricultural belts across Haryana.
- **Institutional Profile:**
  - President: **Ajay Banga**; Headquarters: **Washington, D.C., USA**; Comprises 189 member countries; Established in July 1944 (Bretton Woods Conference).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Private Sector DPF Loan Amount: **$1.5 Billion** from the World Bank.
- State Water Project & Loan: **₹4,000 Crore** for **Jal Sanrakshit Haryana Project**.
- World Bank Leadership: President **Ajay Banga**; Headquarters: **Washington, D.C.**

[JUN-034] **Bangladesh Joins International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA) as 27th Member Nation**

- **Transboundary Conservation Alliance:** The Government of the People's Republic of Bangladesh formally ratified the Framework Agreement to become the **27th member nation** of the **International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA)**.
- **Ecological Strategic Value:**
  - Formalizes joint Indo-Bangladesh ecological stewardship of the **Sundarbans** — the world's largest contiguous mangrove ecosystem, home to the critically endangered Royal Bengal Tiger.
- **IBCA Genesis & Governance Architecture:**
  - **Launch:** Launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on **9 April 2023** in Mysuru, Karnataka during the 50th anniversary celebrations of *Project Tiger*.
  - **Sovereign Budgetary Support:** Union Cabinet approved a one-time grant of **₹150 crore** spanning a 5-year period (**2023–24 to 2027–28**).
  - **Covered 7 Big Cat Species:** Tiger, Lion, Leopard, Snow Leopard, Cheetah, Jaguar, and Puma.
  - **Global Mandate:** Uniting 97 range countries to combat poaching, stop illegal wildlife trade, and mobilize climate finance for predator habitat corridors.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 27th Member Country of IBCA: **Bangladesh** (Sundarbans tiger range partner).
- Initial Outlay: **₹150 crore** over 5 years (2023–24 to 2027–28).
- Total Big Cat Species Covered: **7 species** (Tiger, Lion, Leopard, Snow Leopard, Cheetah, Jaguar, Puma).
- Launch Date & Venue: **9 April 2023** at Mysuru, Karnataka.

[JUN-035] **16th BRICS Agriculture Ministers' Meeting: Unanimous Adoption of the BRICS Indore Declaration**

- **Multilateral Agrarian Summit:** India hosted the **16th BRICS Agriculture Ministers' Meeting** in **Indore, Madhya Pradesh**, bringing together agricultural leaders and policymakers from Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, and newly inducted BRICS nations.
- **Summit Theme:** *"Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation, and Sustainability (BRICS)"*.
- **The BRICS Indore Declaration — Four Pillars:**
  1. **Food Security, Nutrition & Livelihoods:** Safeguarding global supply chains of staple grains, pulses, and edible oils against geopolitical shocks and trade barriers.
  2. **Agricultural Trade & Technical Cooperation:** Harmonizing sanitary and phytosanitary (SPS) protocols and cutting non-tariff barriers across developing markets.
  3. **Regenerative & Climate-Resilient Agriculture:** Promoting climate-smart agronomy, organic bio-inputs, and climate-hardy crops (focusing on millets / Shree Anna).
  4. **Partnerships for Innovation & Food Systems:** Scaling Agri-Tech startups, satellite crop monitoring, and institutional investments into cold-chain storage.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Host City for 16th BRICS Agriculture Meeting: **Indore, Madhya Pradesh** (Indore Declaration).
- Theme: *"Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation, and Sustainability (BRICS)"*.
- Declaration Name: **BRICS Indore Declaration** (comprising 4 strategic priority pillars).

[JUN-036] **India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA): 99.38% Duty-Free Tariff Lines**

- **Bilateral Trade Architecture:** India and the Sultanate of Oman concluded negotiations on the landmark **India-Oman Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA)**, creating a premier tariff-free trade gateway into the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC).
- **Reciprocal Tariff Concessions:**
  - **Oman's Market Access to India:** Oman granted immediate duty-free market access on **99.38% of its tariff lines**, covering **98.08% of total Indian exports** by value (under previous MFN rules, only 15.33% of Indian shipments entered duty-free).
  - **India's Concessions to Oman:** India provided liberalized tariff access across **77.79% of its tariff lines**, accounting for **94.81% of imports from Oman** (primarily petrochemicals, urea, and industrial raw materials).
- **Negative / Exclusion List Safeguards:**
  - Strict exclusions to protect domestic farmers and sensitive industries: Dairy, tea, coffee, rubber, tobacco, gold/silver bullion, jewellery, footwear, sports goods, and metal scrap are excluded from tariff reductions.
  - Eliminated import duties of up to **5% on Indian marine exports** (shrimp, cephalopods, and processed fish).
  - Instituted bilateral **Tariff Rate Quotas (TRQs)** and **Minimum Import Price (MIP)** trigger mechanisms against predatory surges.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Oman Duty-Free Coverage: **99.38% of tariff lines** (covering **98.08% of Indian exports**).
- India Tariff Liberalization: **77.79% of tariff lines** (covering **94.81% of imports**).
- Excluded Sensitives: **Dairy, tea, coffee, rubber, tobacco, gold/silver bullion, footwear**.
- Partner Country: **Sultanate of Oman** (Capital: Muscat; Currency: Omani Rial).

[JUN-037] **India Signs $629 Million (₹60 Billion) BrahMos Supersonic Cruise Missile Export Deal with Vietnam**

- **Major Defence Export Breakthrough:** The Government of India signed a landmark sovereign defence export agreement valued at approximately **$629 million (₹60,000 crore / ₹60 billion)** with the Socialist Republic of **Vietnam** for the supply of **BrahMos supersonic cruise missile batteries**.
- **Customer Footprint & Geopolitics:**
  - Vietnam becomes the **second ASEAN country** to procure the BrahMos missile system, following the Philippines' landmark $375 million coastal battery contract signed in 2022.
  - Bolsters Vietnam's coastal anti-ship defense across the South China Sea / East Sea corridor.
- **System Specifications:**
  - Engineered jointly by the Defence Research and Development Organisation (**DRDO**) and Russia's **NPO Mashinostroyeniya** under BrahMos Aerospace.
  - Cruises at **Mach 2.8 to 3.0** (nearly three times the speed of sound), delivering high kinetic impact; export variant range is calibrated to **~290 kilometres** (compliant with MTCR guidelines).
- **Bilateral Leadership:** Prime Minister of Vietnam: **Pham Minh Chinh**; Capital: **Hanoi**; Currency: **Vietnamese Dong (VND)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Procuring Country: **Vietnam** (Second export customer after **Philippines**).
- Total Contract Value: **$629 million (~₹60 billion)**.
- Cruise Speed & Export Range: **Mach 2.8–3.0**; Range capped at **~290 km** (MTCR compliant).
- Joint Developers: **DRDO (India) + NPO Mashinostroyeniya (Russia)**.

[JUN-038] **ICRIER Report: India Ranks 5th Globally in CHIPS AI Framework & 4th in Digitally Delivered Trade ($328 Bn)**

- **Knowledge Economy Benchmark:** The Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (**ICRIER**), chaired by Pramod Bhasin, released its flagship assessment on India's artificial intelligence and digital commerce competitiveness.
- **Global CHIPS AI Index:**
  - Evaluated across **3 Tiers, 5 Pillars, 16 Sub-Pillars, and 58 Indicators**.
  - Five Core Pillars: **C**onnect (digital infrastructure), **H**arness (data & compute), **I**nnovate (R&D & startups), **P**rotect (ethics & safety), and **S**ustain (inclusive growth).
  - **India's Standing:** Advanced from **8th position in 2025** (out of 32 countries) to **5th position in 2026** (across a widened pool of 71 countries).
- **Key Demographic & Economic Metrics:**
  - **Global AI User Share:** India accounts for **19.9% of global AI users** (nearly 1 in 5 worldwide) and holds the **second-largest concentration of AI talent**.
  - **Private AI Capital Lag:** Currently receives only **~1% of global private AI investment**, highlighting an immense commercialization opportunity.
  - **Digitally Delivered Trade:** India ranks as the **4th largest exporter** of digitally delivered services globally, achieving **$328 billion** in cross-border digital transactions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Rank in CHIPS AI Index: **5th globally** (up from 8th).
- India's Share of Global AI Users: **19.9%** (nearly 20%).
- Digitally Delivered Trade Value & Rank: **$328 Billion** (ranks **4th largest** globally).
- Publishing Think-Tank: **ICRIER** (New Delhi, est. 1981; Chairman: Pramod Bhasin).

[JUN-039] **Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman Elected President of 81st UN General Assembly (UNGA)**

- **Global Diplomatic Election:** The United Nations General Assembly formally elected Bangladesh Foreign Minister **Khalilur Rahman** as the **President of the 81st session of the UN General Assembly (UNGA)**.
- **Tenure & Regional Rotation:**
  - Assumes the one-year presidential term commencing in **September 2026**, succeeding Annalena Baerbock of Germany (President of the 80th session).
  - Nominated by consensus to represent the **Asia-Pacific Group** at the United Nations headquarters in New York.
- **Focus Areas:** Prioritizing South-South climate resilience funding, LDC graduation transitional support, and reform of international multilateral financial architectures.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 81st UNGA President: **Khalilur Rahman** (Foreign Minister of **Bangladesh**).
- Regional Group Represented: **Asia-Pacific Group** (Headquarters: New York).
- Term Tenor: **One-year term** (September 2026 to September 2027).

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4. NATIONAL INITIATIVES, PIB DISPATCHES & INDUSTRIAL POLICY

[JUN-040] **MNRE Operationalizes Green Hydrogen Certification Scheme of India (GHCI)**

- **Framework & Institutional Mandate:** Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (**MNRE**) operationalized the **Green Hydrogen Certification Scheme of India (GHCI)** under the National Green Hydrogen Mission (**NGHM**), establishing the nation's statutory standard for green hydrogen accounting.
- **Emission & Quality Benchmark:**
  - Green Hydrogen is defined as hydrogen produced through water electrolysis or biomass conversion with **well-to-gate greenhouse gas emissions not exceeding 2 kg CO2 equivalent per kg of H2** (<2.0 kg CO2 eq/kg H2), calculated as an average over a 12-month period.
- **Mission Targets by 2030:**
  - Achieve an annual production capacity of at least **5 MMT (Million Metric Tonnes)** of green hydrogen.
  - Deploy **125 GW of associated renewable energy capacity**.
  - Mobilize over **₹8 Lakh Crore in total investments** and create over **600,000 clean energy jobs**.
  - Abate approximately **50 MMT of annual carbon dioxide emissions**.
- **Implementation & State Adoption:**
  - **Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE)** functions as the Nodal Authority for accreditation and certification.
  - **Dedicated Policy States (6):** Maharashtra, Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, Gujarat, and Uttarakhand.
  - **Integrated Policy States (6):** Himachal Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Telangana, Chhattisgarh, Andhra Pradesh, and Assam.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Well-to-Gate Emission Cap: **≤2.0 kg CO2 equivalent per kg H2** (critical numerical MCQ).
- 2030 Production Target: **5 MMT per annum** backed by **125 GW renewable energy**.
- Nodal Authority: **Bureau of Energy Efficiency (BEE)** under MNRE.
- Investment Target: **₹8 Lakh Crore** by 2030.

[JUN-041] **Ministry of Textiles Rationalizes PLI Scheme: Halves Minimum Investment Thresholds in Round 3**

- **Policy Recalibration:** The Ministry of Textiles announced sweeping relaxations under the **Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Scheme for Textiles** to unlock stalled capital and widen participation for MSMEs and emerging apparel exporters.
- **Round 3 Scope Expansion:**
  - Expands coverage to **8 new HSN codes** for Man-Made Fibre (MMF) apparel and **9 new HSN codes** for MMF fabrics.
- **Substantial Cut in Minimum Investment Thresholds:**
  - **Part 1 (Large-Scale Plants):** Minimum investment threshold halved from ₹300 crore to **₹150 crore**.
  - **Part 2 (Mid-Scale / Component Units):** Minimum investment threshold slashed from ₹100 crore to **₹50 crore**.
- **Relaxed Turnover Hurdles:**
  - The mandatory year-on-year incremental turnover condition was drastically softened from **25% to 10%** starting from FY 2025-26.
- **Strategic Impact:** Removes stringent entry barriers, allowing domestic fabric and garment manufacturers to access sovereign incentive tranches amidst global supply chain diversification.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Part 1 Minimum Investment Cut: Slashed from ₹300 Cr to **₹150 crore** (50% reduction).
- Part 2 Minimum Investment Cut: Slashed from ₹100 Cr to **₹50 crore**.
- Incremental Turnover Hurdle: Scaled down from 25% to **10%** per annum.
- Ministry Leadership: Union Minister **Giriraj Singh**, MoS **Pabitra Margherita**.

[JUN-042] **WPI Base Year Revision to 2022-23: DPIIT Introduces Targeted Mean Imputation for Missing Prices**

- **Statistical Modernization:** Office of the Economic Adviser (DPIIT, Ministry of Commerce & Industry) finalized the methodology for transitioning the **Wholesale Price Index (WPI)** from the 2011-12 base to the new **2022-23 base year**.
- **Methodological Breakthrough:**
  - Replaces the legacy **"Carry Forward" method** (which duplicated the previous month's price when data was missing) with **"Targeted Mean Imputation"**.
  - Imputes missing commodity quotations using the weighted average price trend of closely related items within the same commodity group, eliminating artificial price stickiness.
- **May 2026 Inflation Readings:**
  - Headline WPI inflation recorded at **9.68%** (all-India Index at 109.9).
  - WPI Food Index inflation stood at **4.49%**.
- **Administrative Anchor:** DPIIT Secretary **Amardeep Singh Bhatia** confirmed the parallel run of the new series before final sunsetting of the 2011-12 index.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New WPI Target Base Year: **2022-23** (replacing 2011-12).
- New Price Imputation Technique: **Targeted Mean Imputation** (replaces Carry Forward method).
- May 2026 Print: Headline WPI at **9.68%**; Food Index at **4.49%**.
- Issuing Office: **Office of Economic Adviser, DPIIT** (Ministry of Commerce and Industry).

[JUN-043] **MHA & I4C Launch GrM & MRM Portals: Faster Unfreezing of Accounts & Automated Cyber Fraud Refunds**

- **Institutional Initiative:** The Ministry of Home Affairs (**MHA**) and the **Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)** launched two dedicated digital grievance modules to address unintended hardships caused by anti-fraud operations.
- **Two Core Modules:**
  - **Grievance Redressal Mechanism (GrM) Portal:** Dedicated single-window portal for innocent account holders, traders, and merchants whose bank accounts or funds were placed under **lien or frozen** during multi-layered cyber fraud investigations.
  - **Money Restoration Module (MRM) Portal:** Empowers victims of cyber financial frauds to track and request legal refund/restoration of blocked illicit funds directly into their verified original accounts via their **14-digit acknowledgement number**.
- **Operational Integration:**
  - Anchored to the **Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting and Management System (CFCFRMS)** and the National Cyber Crime Helpline **1930**.
- **I4C Institutional Profile:**
  - Operationalized in **October 2018** under the administrative control of MHA.
  - Governed under Section 79(3)(b) of the *Information Technology Act, 2000*. Headquartered in New Delhi under CEO **Rajesh Kumar**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- National Cyber Crime Helpline Number: **1930** (critical banking awareness number).
- Dedicated Modules: **GrM** (for lien/account unfreezing) & **MRM** (for money restitution).
- Identifier for Claims: **14-digit acknowledgement number** issued by CFCFRMS.
- I4C Establishment: **October 2018** under Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA).

[JUN-044] **Puducherry Establishes India's First Municipality-Developed SEZ at Thattanchavady**

- **Historic Precedent:** Department of Commerce (Ministry of Commerce & Industry) granted formal approval for two new Special Economic Zones (SEZs) in the Union Territory of Puducherry, creating an institutional first in urban governance.
- **Two Approved SEZs:**
  - **Thattanchavady IT/ITES SEZ:** Developed directly by the **Oulgaret Municipality** — marking the **first-ever Special Economic Zone in India developed and managed by an Urban Local Body (ULB) / Municipality**.
  - **Karasur Multi-Sector SEZ:** Developed by the Puducherry Industrial Promotion Development and Investment Corporation (**PIPDIC**) across 150 acres to drive advanced manufacturing.
- **National Health Accounts (NHA) FY23 Benchmarks:**
  - Total Health Expenditure (**THE**) reached **₹8.81 Lakh Crore** (**3.37% of GDP**; ₹6,242 per capita).
  - **Government Health Expenditure (GHE)** surged to **1.43% of GDP** (accounting for **48.0% of THE**, up sharply from 28.6% in FY14).
  - **Out-of-Pocket Expenditure (OOPE)** plunged to **39.4% of THE** (down from 64.2% in FY14).
  - Private Health Insurance (PHI) increased its share in THE from 3.4% (2013-14) to **9.2% (2022-23)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Urban Local Body/Municipality in India to Develop an SEZ: **Oulgaret Municipality, Puducherry** (at Thattanchavady).
- Multi-Sector SEZ Agency: **PIPDIC** at Karasur.
- NHA FY23 GHE as % of GDP: **1.43%** (GHE share of THE = **48.0%**).
- NHA FY23 OOPE as % of THE: **39.4%** (historic reduction from 64.2%).

[JUN-045] **Mission Mausam Deploys 'SkyCast' High-Resolution Aviation Fog Forecasting System**

- **Aviation Safety Deployment:** Ministry of Earth Sciences (**MoES**) operationalized **'SkyCast'**, an indigenous, high-resolution fog and low-cloud numerical prediction system engineered specifically for airport operations.
- **Technical & Research Heritage:**
  - Built upon extensive observational data from the **Winter Fog Experiment (WiFEX)** conducted by the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (**IITM, Pune**) and the India Meteorological Department (**IMD**).
  - Operational at **Indira Gandhi International Airport (IGI, Delhi)** and selected for greenfield integration at **Noida International Airport (Jewar)**.
- **Mission Mausam Institutional Framework:**
  - Approved by the Union Cabinet with a dedicated financial outlay of **₹2,000 crore** over two years (**2024–2026**).
  - Target: Up to **50% improvement in weather forecasting accuracy** across cyclones, heatwaves, monsoon depressions, and aviation visibility.
  - MoES Leadership: Union Minister of State (IC) **Dr. Jitendra Singh**; MoES Secretary **Dr. M. Ravichandran**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- SkyCast Research Origin: **WiFEX experiment** conducted by **IITM Pune & IMD**.
- Airports Deployed: **IGI Delhi** and expanding to **Noida International Airport (Jewar)**.
- Mission Mausam Financial Outlay: **₹2,000 crore** (2024–2026) under MoES.
- Forecast Accuracy Improvement Goal: Up to **50% enhancement**.

[JUN-046] **PM SVANidhi Revised Norms: Tranche Caps Raised to ₹15k/₹25k & RuPay Credit Card Rollout**

- **Scheme Enhancements:** Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (**MoHUA**) notified revised operational guidelines for the Prime Minister Street Vendor's AtmaNirbhar Nidhi (**PM SVANidhi**), enhancing collateral-free working capital thresholds.
- **Upgraded Three-Tranche Credit Architecture:**
  - **1st Tranche:** Working capital loan limit increased from ₹10,000 to **₹15,000** (tenor: 12 months).
  - **2nd Tranche:** Working capital loan limit increased from ₹20,000 to **₹25,000** (tenor: 18 months) upon timely repayment of tranche 1.
  - **3rd Tranche:** Working capital loan capped at **₹50,000** (tenor: 36 months).
- **UPI-Linked RuPay Credit Card:**
  - Street vendors who successfully repay their 2nd tranche loan and become eligible for the 3rd tranche receive an interoperable **UPI-linked RuPay Credit Card**.
  - Credit limit starts at **₹10,000** and can be stepped up to **₹30,000** based on digital transaction history; card validity is **5 years**.
- **'Samadhan Didi' AI Grievance Chatbot:**
  - MoS (IC) Dr. Jitendra Singh launched **'Samadhan Didi'**, an AI-enabled multilingual voice chatbot for the Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System (**CPGRAMS**) at Kartavya Bhawan, New Delhi.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 1st Tranche Loan Limit: Raised to **₹15,000** (repayable in 12 months).
- 2nd Tranche Loan Limit: Raised to **₹25,000** (repayable in 18 months).
- 3rd Tranche Loan Limit: **₹50,000** (repayable in 36 months).
- RuPay Credit Card Limit for Street Vendors: **₹10,000 to ₹30,000** (validity: **5 years**).
- CPGRAMS AI Voice Chatbot: **'Samadhan Didi'** (MoPPG&P).

[JUN-047] **Surha Taal Bird Sanctuary Designated as Ramsar Wetland: India Ranks 1st in Asia & 3rd Globally**

- **Ramsar Convention Designation:** The Ramsar Secretariat designated Uttar Pradesh's **Surha Taal Bird Sanctuary** as a Wetland of International Importance.
- **Geographical & Environmental Profile:**
  - Located in **Ballia district, Uttar Pradesh**; covers 45 villages; notified in 1991 and renamed **Jai Prakash Narayan Bird Sanctuary** in 2002.
  - Formed as a natural perennial **oxbow lake** created by an ancient meander of the **Ganga River**, situated between the Ganga and Saryu rivers.
- **India's Global & Regional Ramsar Standing:**
  - **Rank 1 in Asia:** India holds the highest number of Ramsar sites across the entire Asian continent.
  - **Rank 3 Globally:** Behind the **United Kingdom (176 sites)** and **Mexico (144 sites)**.
  - **Top 3 Indian States by Ramsar Sites:**
    1. **Tamil Nadu:** 20 Ramsar wetlands (highest in India).
    2. **Uttar Pradesh:** 13 Ramsar sites (second highest).
    3. **Odisha:** 6 Ramsar sites (third highest).
  - India's first designated Ramsar sites (1981): **Chilika Lake** (Odisha) and **Keoladeo National Park** (Rajasthan).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Newest Ramsar Site: **Surha Taal / Jai Prakash Narayan Bird Sanctuary** (Ballia district, UP).
- Lake Hydrology: Natural perennial **oxbow lake** of the Ganga River.
- State Ramsar Ranks: **Tamil Nadu (20)** > **Uttar Pradesh (13)** > **Odisha (6)**.
- Global Standing: India is **#1 in Asia** and **#3 globally** (after UK & Mexico).

[JUN-048] **IN-SPACe Selects 3 Startups for TAF Funding & NITI Aayog Unveils Semiconductor Fab Academy**

- **Space-Tech Commercialization:** The Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (**IN-SPACe**), the commercial facilitation arm of ISRO, selected the first cohort of 3 Indian space startups for direct grant funding under the **Technology Adoption Fund (TAF):**
  1. **Astrobase Space Technologies Pvt Ltd** (Bengaluru): Tasked with designing and fabricating an indigenous **800 kilonewton (kN) high-thrust, reusable closed-cycle liquid rocket engine**.
  2. **SataSure Analytics India Pvt Ltd** (Bengaluru): Advanced earth observation satellite analytics.
  3. **TM2SPACE Technologies Pvt Ltd** (Hyderabad): Satellite subsystems and mission propulsion.
- **NITI Aayog Semiconductor Human Capital Roadmap:**
  - Proposes establishing a centralized **National Fab Academy** in active partnership with the All India Council for Technical Education (**AICTE**) to build a pipeline of semiconductor cleanroom engineers.
  - Outlines bilateral technology and supply-chain corridors with 4 trusted partners: **United States, European Union, Japan, and South Korea**.
  - Leadership: Interim CEO **Nidhi Chhibber** (Director General, DMEO).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Astrobase Space Tech Grant Mandate: **800 kN reusable closed-cycle liquid rocket engine**.
- IN-SPACe TAF Startup Count: **3 startups** (Astrobase, SataSure, TM2SPACE).
- Semiconductor Human Capital Body: **National Fab Academy** (in partnership with AICTE).
- Trusted Semiconductor Corridor Partners: **US, EU, Japan, South Korea**.

[JUN-049] **MCA Expands Schedule VII: CSR Funds Permitted in Social Stock Exchange ZCZP Instruments**

- **Regulatory Harmonization:** Ministry of Corporate Affairs (**MCA**) amended **Schedule VII of the Companies Act, 2013**, officially allowing corporate CSR expenditure to flow into the Social Stock Exchange (**SSE**) ecosystem.
- **Eligible CSR Conduit:**
  - Direct subscription to **Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP) Instruments** issued by registered Not-for-Profit Organisations (NPOs) and listed on recognized Social Stock Exchanges is now legally recognized as eligible CSR spending under Schedule VII.
- **Statutory CSR Applicability Framework (Section 135):**
  - Mandatory for companies having:
    - **Net Worth ≥ ₹500 crore**, OR
    - **Turnover ≥ ₹1,000 crore**, OR
    - **Net Profit ≥ ₹5 crore** during the immediately preceding financial year.
  - Mandatory allocation: At least **2% of the average net profits** made during the 3 immediately preceding financial years.
  - **Proposed Reform:** The *Corporate Laws Amendment Bill, 2026* proposes doubling the net profit threshold from **₹5 crore to ₹10 crore** to reduce compliance overhead for small enterprises.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Eligible CSR Asset: **Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP) instruments** listed on Social Stock Exchanges (SSE).
- Schedule Amended: **Schedule VII** of the *Companies Act, 2013*.
- Current Net Profit Threshold: **≥₹5 crore** (proposed hike to **₹10 crore** in 2026 Bill).
- Mandatory CSR Percentage: **2%** of average net profits of preceding 3 financial years.

[JUN-050] **MoSPI FY26 Annual Estimates & Logistics Port Performance Index (LPPI FY25)**

- **Macroeconomic Accounting:** Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (**MoSPI**) released the Provisional Estimates of Annual GDP/GVA for FY 2025-26:
  - **Nominal GVA:** Grew by **9.1% in FY26** (reaching **₹314.87 Lakh Crore** vs ₹288.54 Lakh Crore in FY25).
  - **Primary Sector (Agriculture):** Growth estimated at **3.0%** (moderating from 4.2% in FY25).
  - **Secondary Sector (Manufacturing):** Expanded by **10.7%** (up from 9.3% in FY25 First Revised Estimates).
  - **Tertiary Sector (Services):** Surged by **11.0%** (up sharply from 6.6% in FY25).
  - **Expenditure aggregates:** Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF) grew **8.2%**; Private Final Consumption Expenditure (PFCE) rose **7.7%**; Government Final Consumption Expenditure (GFCE) decelerated by 100 bps to **5.5%**.
- **Logistics Port Performance Index (LPPI) FY25 (Sagar Aankalan Awards):**
  - Conferred by Union Minister of Ports, Shipping and Waterways **Sarbananda Sonowal** at JNPA Mumbai.
  - **Container Cargo (<0.5 Million TEUs): Deendayal Port Authority (DPA)**, formerly Kandla Port Trust (Gujarat), won the Best-Performing Port award. DPA remains India's largest port by overall cargo volume.
  - **Liquid Bulk Cargo: Sikka Port and Terminals Limited (SPTL)**, Jamnagar (Gujarat) topped the category; Visakhapatnam Port Authority (VPA, Andhra Pradesh) secured 2nd place.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Nominal GVA FY26 Growth Rate: **9.1%** (reaching **₹314.87 Lakh Crore**).
- Highest Growing GVA Sector: **Tertiary/Services at 11.0%**, followed by Manufacturing at **10.7%**.
- Best-Performing Port (<0.5M TEU): **Deendayal Port Authority (DPA, Kandla)**.
- Top Liquid Bulk Cargo Port: **Sikka Port and Terminals Ltd (SPTL, Jamnagar)**.

[JUN-051] **Investiture Ceremony 2026: Gallantry Awards Conferred on Gaganyaan Astronaut & Navy Circumnavigators**

- **Gallantry Convocations:** President of India conferred Gallantry Awards for 2026 (Phase 1), honoring supreme valor and distinguished service in peacetime and aerospace missions:
  - **Total Medals Conferred: 7 Kirti Chakras, 15 Vir Chakras, and 29 Shaurya Chakras**.
- **Key Gallantry Recipients:**
  - **Kirti Chakra to Gaganyaan Astronaut:** Air Commodore **Prasanth Balakrishnan Nair** (IAF, call sign *"Papa"*), designated prime astronaut for the Gaganyaan orbital mission and trained backup astronaut for the Indo-US **Axiom-4 mission** to the International Space Station (ISS).
  - **Shaurya Chakra to Naval Circumnavigators:** Lieutenant Commander **Dilna K.** and Lieutenant Commander **Roopa A.** of the Indian Navy, who successfully navigated **INSV Tarini** on a global transoceanic voyage covering over **25,600 nautical miles across 8 months**.
- **Clean Transportation Milestone:**
  - Union Minister Nitin Gadkari unveiled India's first commercially available mass-production flex-fuel two-wheelers — **Hero Splendor+ Flex Fuel** and **Hero HF Deluxe Flex Fuel**, capable of operating on ethanol-petrol blends ranging from **E20 (20% ethanol) to E85 (85% ethanol)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Kirti Chakra Awardee: **Air Commodore Prasanth Balakrishnan Nair** (Gaganyaan / Axiom-4 backup astronaut; call sign *"Papa"*).
- Shaurya Chakra Naval Officers: **Lt Cdr Dilna K. & Lt Cdr Roopa A.** aboard **INSV Tarini** (25,600+ nautical miles).
- Total Awards Conferred: **7 Kirti Chakras, 15 Vir Chakras, 29 Shaurya Chakras**.
- Flex-Fuel Two-Wheelers: **Hero Splendor+ & HF Deluxe Flex Fuel** (operating on **E20 to E85** blends).

[JUN-052] **Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers (GRSE) Elevated to India's 29th Navratna CPSE**

- **Corporate Governance Upgradation:** The Department of Public Enterprises (DPE, Ministry of Finance) and the Ministry of Defence officially elevated Kolkata-headquartered shipyard **Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers Limited (GRSE)** to **Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE)** status.
- **Historic Institutional Milestone:**
  - GRSE becomes India's **29th Navratna CPSE**, transitioning from its previous Miniratna Category-I classification.
  - **Enhanced Financial Autonomy:** Empowers the GRSE Board of Directors to make autonomous capital expenditures up to **₹1,000 crore** (or **15% of net worth** on a single project, whichever is lower) without seeking prior approval from the Central Government.
  - Authorizes GRSE to establish overseas joint ventures, subsidiaries, and strategic technological alliances up to ₹1,000 crore.
- **Shipbuilding Heritage:**
  - Established in **1884** as a private shipyard on the Hooghly River, nationalized by the Government of India in **1960**.
  - Constructed and delivered India's very first indigenous warship, **INS Ajay**, in **1961**.
  - Concurrently, Prime Minister Narendra Modi commissioned three GRSE-built naval assets at the Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port in Kolkata: **INS Dunagiri** (Project 17A Nilgiri-class guided missile frigate), **INS Sanshodhak** (large survey vessel), and **INS Agray** (anti-submarine shallow water craft).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New Navratna Status Rank: **29th Navratna CPSE** of India (Kolkata-based).
- Autonomy Investment Limit: Up to **₹1,000 crore or 15% of net worth** per project.
- Historical Warship: Built India's first indigenous warship **INS Ajay in 1961**.
- Commissioned Fleet: **INS Dunagiri, INS Sanshodhak, INS Agray** (SMP Port, Kolkata).

[JUN-053] **Cabinet Approves ₹13,000 Crore Greenfield Civil-Military Airport on Great Nicobar Island**

- **Strategic Maritime Outlay:** The Union Cabinet cleared the development of a state-of-the-art **greenfield international airport** on **Great Nicobar Island** with a dedicated public investment outlay of **₹13,000 crore**.
- **Dual-Use Civil-Military Infrastructure:**
  - Engineered with dual-use military and civilian operational capabilities, featuring an extended 4,000-metre runway capable of hosting wide-body commercial aircraft, maritime patrol aircraft (P-8I Poseidon), and advanced fighter squadrons.
- **Geostrategic Imperative — Malacca Strait Choke Point:**
  - Great Nicobar Island sits at the southern entrance of the **Malacca Strait** — the critical global maritime corridor handling over **25% of global maritime commerce** and nearly **80% of East Asia's petroleum shipments**.
  - Strengthens India's naval surveillance and force projection across the Six Degree Channel and the broader Indo-Pacific logistics corridors.
  - Forms a linchpin of the larger **₹72,000 crore Great Nicobar Island Holistic Development Project**, executed via the Andaman and Nicobar Islands Integrated Development Corporation (**ANIIDCO**).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Airport Project Outlay: **₹13,000 crore** (dual-use civil-military).
- Strategic Island: **Great Nicobar Island** (proximate to **Malacca Strait / Six Degree Channel**).
- Holistic Island Outlay: **₹72,000 crore** overseen by **ANIIDCO**.

[JUN-054] **India's First Commercial Coal-to-Ammonium Nitrate Plant at Lakhanpur & Model Solar Village Pahadpur**

- **Clean Coal Gasification Milestone:** President Droupadi Murmu and Prime Minister Narendra Modi laid the foundation stone of India's **first commercial-scale Coal-to-Ammonium Nitrate Project** at **Lakhanpur, Jharsuguda district, Odisha**.
- **Joint Venture Architecture:**
  - Executed by **Bharat Coal Gasification and Chemicals Limited (BCGCL)** — a strategic public sector joint venture between **Coal India Limited (CIL, 51% majority stake)** and **Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL, 49% stake)**.
  - Converts high-ash domestic thermal coal into synthesis gas (syngas) to manufacture technical ammonium nitrate, reducing hazardous chemical import dependencies for India's mining and civil explosive industries.
- **National Mission Alignment:**
  - Serves as the flagship breakthrough under the **National Coal Gasification Mission**, which aims to gasify **100 million tonnes (MT) of coal annually by 2030**.
- **Presidential Heritage Showcase:**
  - Prime Minister Modi announced that **Pahadpur Village in Mayurbhanj district, Odisha** (the native birthplace of President Droupadi Murmu) will be developed into a dedicated **Model Solar Village** under the PM-Surya Ghar framework.
  - Simultaneously inaugurated the high-level bridge over the Kathajodi River connecting Cuttack and Bhubaneswar.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Location of First Coal-to-Ammonium Nitrate Plant: **Lakhanpur, Odisha** (developed by BCGCL).
- BCGCL Joint Venture Equity: **Coal India (51%) + BHEL (49%)**.
- National Coal Gasification Mission 2030 Target: **100 Million Tonnes (MT)**.
- Model Solar Village: **Pahadpur Village, Mayurbhanj district, Odisha**.

[JUN-055] **Indigenous Garudastra 120mm Mortar System & First 17 Women Cadets Commissioned from NDA**

- **Artillery Self-Reliance (Aatmanirbhar Defence):** The Indian Army successfully concluded field validation trials of the indigenously developed **Garudastra 120 mm vehicle-mounted mobile mortar system**.
  - Engineered and fabricated entirely by Pune-based private defence manufacturer **Nibe Limited**.
  - Field trials conducted at the Infantry School in **Mhow, Madhya Pradesh**; mounted on a high-mobility 4x4 combat chassis delivering rapid shoot-and-scoot mortar firepower.
- **Historic NDA Gender Inclusion Milestone:**
  - The Ministry of Defence formally commissioned the **first-ever batch of 17 women cadets** trained at the premier **National Defence Academy (NDA)** at Khadakwasla, Pune.
  - The women officers graduated as part of the **148th Course**, having entered the academy in August 2022 following the historic 2021 Supreme Court ruling (*Kush Kalra v. Union of India*) mandating female entry into NDA under fundamental equality rights enshrined in Articles 14, 15, 16, and 19.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Indigenous Mortar System: **Garudastra 120 mm** (manufactured by **Nibe Limited, Pune**; tested at Mhow, MP).
- First NDA Women Cadet Batch Size: **17 women cadets** (148th Course, Khadakwasla).
- Legal Precedent: Supreme Court ruling on **Articles 14 and 16** (*Kush Kalra* judgment).

[JUN-056] **NIXI Unveils Four Digital Platforms on 23rd Foundation Day: IX, myIRINN, .IN Auction & AI WHOIS**

- **Digital Public Infrastructure Expansion:** The National Internet Exchange of India (**NIXI**) commemorated its **23rd Foundation Day** (established on 19 June 2003 under Section 8 of the Companies Act) by launching four nationwide digital platforms.
- **Administrative Aegis:** Functions under the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (**MeitY**), chaired by MeitY Secretary **S. Krishnan**.
- **Four Newly Launched Platforms:**
  1. **Internet Exchange (IX) Portal:** Centralized management engine to streamline peering points, optimize routing latency, and scale bandwidth across all operational IXPs in India.
  2. **myIRINN Portal:** Modernized self-service portal managed by the Indian Registry for Internet Names and Numbers (IRINN) for seamless allocation of sovereign IPv4 and IPv6 address resources.
  3. **.IN Auction Portal:** Transparent digital marketplace enabling real-time bidding, transparent auctions, and portfolio transfers for high-value premium `.in` and `.bharat` domain names.
  4. **AI-Enabled WHOIS Screening Platform:** Machine learning security gateway designed to audit domain registrant credentials and proactively flag malicious or fraudulent registrations across the `.in` registry.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- NIXI Foundation Date: **19 June 2003** (Section 8 non-profit company under MeitY).
- Four Digital Platforms: **IX Portal, myIRINN Portal, .IN Auction Portal, AI WHOIS Screening Platform**.
- NIXI Chairman: MeitY Secretary **S. Krishnan**.

[JUN-057] **Extended PMSMA (E-PMSMA) Risk-Sticker Norms & Assam-Nagaland Tripartite Petroleum Accord**

- **Maternal Health Risk Categorization:** Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoH&FW) operationalized upgraded guidelines under the **Extended Pradhan Mantri Surakshit Matritva Abhiyan (E-PMSMA):**
  - **Mother and Child Protection (MCP) Card Color-Coded Risk Stickers:**
    - **Green Sticker:** Designates pregnant women with normal clinical profiles and **no identified risk factors**.
    - **Red Sticker:** Identifies **High-Risk Pregnancy (HRP)** cases requiring prioritized obstetric management.
  - **Monitoring & Antenatal Sessions:** Mandates up to **4 additional PMSMA clinical sessions per month** for high-risk cohorts; extends active post-partum digital tracking up to **45 days post-delivery**.
  - Provides structured financial incentives to HRP women and accompanying ASHA workers for completing 3 additional antenatal checkups.
- **Strategic Tripartite Hydrocarbon Agreement:**
  - The Government of India, along with the State Governments of **Assam** and **Nagaland**, signed a tripartite Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to facilitate joint oil and gas exploration in disputed border zones, unlocking stalled hydrocarbon extraction in the Northeast.
- **QS World University Rankings 2027:**
  - **IIT Delhi** emerged as India's highest-ranked institution for the second consecutive year, securing global rank **118th** with a score of 65.7 (improving from 123rd).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- MCP Card Stickers: **Green = No Risk**, **Red = High-Risk Pregnancy (HRP)**.
- E-PMSMA Post-Delivery Tracking Window: Up to **45 days post-delivery**.
- Hydrocarbon Border Accord: Tripartite between **GoI, Assam, and Nagaland**.
- Top Indian Institution in QS 2027: **IIT Delhi (Rank 118)**.

[JUN-058] **₹2,352 Crore Chenab-Beas Link Tunnel Project & Fast-Tracking of Chenab Hydropower Infrastructure**

- **Himalayan Hydrological Diversion:** Following India's strategic review of the Indus Waters Treaty (IWT) framework, the Ministry of Power approved a major package of infrastructure projects on the **Chenab River** totaling nearly **₹2,600 crore**, executed primarily by **NHPC Limited**.
- **Flagship Engineering Project:**
  - **Chenab-Beas Link Tunnel Project:** Approved with a dedicated outlay of **₹2,352 crore** in the **Lahaul-Spiti district of Himachal Pradesh**.
  - Involves the construction of an **8.7-kilometre-long trans-basin tunnel** engineered to divert surplus discharge from the upper Chenab river basin directly into the Beas river system.
  - Substantially enhances power generation at downstream Beas hydro stations (Pong, Dehar) during peak summer demand while regulating transboundary river flows.
- **Strategic Context:** Maximizes India's permitted run-of-the-river storage rights under the treaty while generating peak clean hydro capacity.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Flagship Project: **Chenab-Beas Link Tunnel Project** (Outlay: **₹2,352 crore**).
- Tunnel Length & Location: **8.7 km** in **Lahaul-Spiti, Himachal Pradesh**.
- Primary Implementing Agency: **NHPC Limited**.
- Hydrological Function: Diverts surplus water from **Chenab basin into Beas river system**.

[JUN-059] **FCI Expands Farm-to-Depot QR Code Tagging of Foodgrain Bags across AP, Telangana & Odisha**

- **Supply Chain Digitalization:** Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution expanded the mandatory **Quick Response (QR) code tagging initiative** for all foodgrain bags procured and distributed by the **Food Corporation of India (FCI)**.
- **State Rollout Footprint:**
  - Formally scaled across three major paddy-producing and consuming states: **Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Odisha** during the ongoing marketing season.
  - Built upon successful technological pilot validations: the rice QR-tagging pilot conducted in Andhra Pradesh (December 2025 – January 2026) and the wheat QR-tagging pilot conducted in Punjab (April – May 2026).
- **Anti-Pilferage & Traceability Architecture:**
  - Each gunny bag is imprinted with a unique encrypted 2D QR code detailing procurement centre (mandi), mill code, moisture level, grain variety, date of bagging, and destination FCI silo/depot.
  - Prevents recycling of PDS foodgrains, eliminates phantom milling, and ensures real-time end-to-end inventory auditing on the Anna Darpan logistics platform.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Expanded States for FCI QR Tagging: **Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, and Odisha**.
- Previous Pilot States: **Andhra Pradesh** (rice) and **Punjab** (wheat).
- Administrative Entity: **Food Corporation of India (FCI)** under MoCA,F&PD.
- Core Objective: Real-time inventory tracing and elimination of diversion/recycling in PDS.

[JUN-060] **National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6): Total Fertility Rate Stable at 2.0 & Rotavirus Coverage at 85.4%**

- **Demographic & Public Health Accounting:** Ministry of Health and Family Welfare released comprehensive analytical findings from the **6th National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6 2023–24):**
- **Demographic Transition & Contraception:**
  - **Total Fertility Rate (TFR):** Remained stable at **2.0 children per woman**, securely positioned below the national replacement-level fertility benchmark of **2.1**.
  - **Contraceptive Prevalence Rate (CPR):** Rose from 66.7% to **69.1%**, driven by expanded modern family planning availability.
- **Maternal Health & Nutrition:**
  - Pregnant women consuming **Iron Folic Acid (IFA) supplements for ≥100 days** jumped from 44.1% to **54.9%**; consumption for **≥180 days** rose from 26.0% to **37.8%**.
- **Child Immunization & Disease Reduction:**
  - **Full Immunization Coverage (cards):** Scaled from 83.8% to **87.1%**; over **95.6%** of all vaccinations administered through public health institutions.
  - **Rotavirus Vaccine Coverage:** Registered a historic surge from 36.4% to **85.4%**, drastically curbing childhood diarrhoea.
  - **Measles Second Dose (MCV-2):** Increased from 58.6% to **71.8%**.
  - Prevalence of Acute Respiratory Infections (ARI) dropped from 2.8% to 1.9%; severe childhood diarrhoea declined to 0.5%.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Total Fertility Rate (TFR): **2.0** (below replacement level of 2.1).
- Contraceptive Prevalence Rate (CPR): **69.1%** (up from 66.7%).
- Rotavirus Vaccine Surge: Reached **85.4%** (from 36.4%).
- Full Immunization Coverage: **87.1%** (with 95.6% delivered via public facilities).

[JUN-061] **West Bengal Launches 'Annapurna Yojana' (₹3,000/Month) & T-Hub Unveils 'ORBIT' Space Accelerator**

- **State Social Assistance Restructuring:**
  - The Government of West Bengal officially rolled out the **Annapurna Yojana (Annapurna Bhandar Scheme)**, superseding the erstwhile Lakshmi Bhandar Scheme (instituted in 2021).
  - **Direct Benefit Assistance:** Enhances monthly financial transfers to **₹3,000 per month** for eligible women aged between **25 and 60 years** who are permanent residents of West Bengal.
  - **Statutory Exclusions:** Excludes women in regular government employment, government pensioners, and active income-tax assessees.
- **Space-Tech Incubation (AIC T-Hub):**
  - Atal Innovation Centre (AIC)-T-Hub launched the 3rd cohort of its flagship space accelerator, **'ORBIT'**, inducting **13 deep-tech space startups** (taking total startups supported under ORBIT to **36**).
- **International Cultural Honors:**
  - The **Indian Haj Mission** under the Ministry of Minority Affairs (MoMA) was conferred two prestigious **Labbaytum Awards 2026** by Saudi Arabia's Ministry of Hajj and Umrah at Makkah, recognizing digital innovations including the **Haj Suvidha App** and **Smart Wristband** geo-locators deployed for over 1.75 lakh Indian pilgrims.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Annapurna Yojana Monthly Payout: **₹3,000 per month** (West Bengal; ages 25–60).
- Predecessor Scheme Replaced: **Lakshmi Bhandar Scheme** (2021).
- Space Accelerator: **'ORBIT'** launched by **AIC T-Hub** (Cohort 3: 13 startups; total 36).
- Diplomatic Recognition: Indian Haj Mission won **two Labbaytum Awards 2026** (Saudi Arabia).

JULY 2026 CONSOLIDATED DOSSIER (STATE OF ECONOMY & REGULATORS)



Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified RBI Master Directions, Banking Regulatory Circulars & National Policy Anchors

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified RBI Master Directions, Banking Regulatory Circulars & National Policy Anchors

EXAMINER'S BLUEPRINT & COMPLIANCE STANDARD:

- ***Fact Discipline:*** *Fully cross-verified against official Reserve Bank of India notifications, Gazette of India releases, NITI Aayog benchmarks, and multilateral indices.*
- ***Structure:*** *Formatted using the authentic* ***Rajputana Gazette Broadsheet*** *layout with ladder bullets and dedicated* ***EXAM ANGLE:*** *distractor matrices.*
- ***Target Exams:*** *RBI Grade B, SEBI Grade A, NABARD Grade A, SBI PO & IBPS PO/Clerk Mains 2026.*

1. ESI, FINANCE & BUSINESS NEWS

[JUL-001] **RBI Monthly Bulletin (July): State of the Economy & RBI-DPI Surge to 445.50**

- **State of the Economy Overview:** Authored by the RBI research team led by Deputy Governor Dr. Michael Debabrata Patra; affirmed India's GDP growth projection at **7.2% for FY25**.
- **Inflation Trajectory:** Core CPI inflation (excluding food and fuel) settled at a historic low of **3.1%**, while headline CPI was volatile due to vegetable price pressures.
- **Digital Payments Index (RBI-DPI):**
  - Surged to **445.50** for March 2024 (officially published in July), up from 395.57 in March 2023.
  - Base Period for RBI-DPI: **March 2018 = 100**.
  - Sub-parameter Weights: Payment Enablers (25%), Payment Infrastructure – Demand side (10%), Payment Infrastructure – Supply side (15%), Payment Performance (**45%**), Consumer Centricity (5%).
- **Financial Conditions Index (FCI):** Firmly anchored in the comfortable "easy" liquidity zone, indicating benign sovereign bond yields and smooth corporate credit growth.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- RBI-DPI Base Period: **March 2018 = 100** (a perennial favorite MCQ in bank mains).
- Highest Sub-parameter Weight: **Payment Performance (45%)**, followed by **Payment Enablers (25%)**.
- Core Inflation Low: Reached **3.1%**, while GDP growth was pegged at **7.2%**.

[JUL-002] **India's External Debt Reaches $663.8 Billion; Debt-to-GDP Ratio Declines to 18.7%**

- **Headline External Debt:** RBI released data on India's external debt as of end-March 2024, showing total debt stood at **USD 663.8 billion** (an increase of USD 39.7 billion over end-March 2023).
- **Debt-to-GDP Ratio:** Improved significantly, declining to **18.7%** at end-March 2024 from 19.0% at end-March 2023.
- **Valuation Effect:** Excluding valuation effects due to appreciation of the US dollar vis-a-vis the Indian rupee, external debt would have increased by USD 48.4 billion instead of USD 39.7 billion.
- **Currency Composition:** US dollar-denominated debt remained the largest component at **53.8%**, followed by the Indian rupee (**31.5%**), SDR (5.8%), and Japanese yen (5.4%).
- **Short-Term vs. Long-Term Debt:** Long-term debt (original maturity >1 year) accounted for **81.6%** of total debt; short-term debt was **18.4%**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Debt-to-GDP Ratio: Declined to **18.7%** (do NOT confuse with general government debt of ~82% of GDP).
- Currency Dominance: US Dollar (**53.8%**) > Indian Rupee (**31.5%**) > SDR (**5.8%**).
- Long-Term Proportion: **81.6%** of external debt is long-term.

[JUL-003] **FPI Investment Limits in Sovereign Debt & Restoration of Export Realisation Period**

- **Restoration of Export Realisation Period:** Reserve Bank of India restored the statutory export proceeds realisation and repatriation period to **9 months** from the date of export (rolling back temporary relaxations).
- **Foreign Portfolio Investor (FPI) Debt Limits:**
  - **Central Government Securities (G-Secs):** Overall FPI investment limit maintained at **6.0%** of outstanding sovereign stock.
  - **State Development Loans (SDLs):** FPI investment limit maintained at **2.0%** of outstanding state sovereign stock.
  - **Harmonized Categories:** RBI merged the General and Long-Term G-Sec categories into a single unified operational limit.
- **Fully Accessible Route (FAR) Expansion:**
  - Expanded to include designated Government Securities with maturities of **15, 30, and 40 years**.
  - Securities issued under the FAR route carry **no foreign investment limits**, supporting Indian sovereign debt integration into global benchmark indices.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Export Realisation Window: **9 months** from date of export (not 6 or 12 months).
- Sovereign Debt FPI Caps: **6.0%** in Central G-Secs, **2.0%** in State Development Loans (SDLs).
- FAR Tenors: **15, 30, and 40 years** sovereign bonds without any foreign investment ceiling.

[JUL-004] **RBI Financial Inclusion (FI) Index Advances to 64.2 (Zero Base Year Metric)**

- **Genesis & Scope:** Formally published by the Reserve Bank of India annually in July, the composite Financial Inclusion Index (FI-Index) captures the extent of financial inclusion across the entire country.
- **Index Trajectory:**
  - The composite FI-Index improved to **64.2** for March 2024 (progressing towards 70.0 in latest rounds), advancing from 60.1 in March 2023 and 43.4 in March 2017.
  - Growth was propelled by sustained deepening in the **Quality** and **Usage** dimensions across rural and semi-urban geographies.
- **Three Sub-Indices & Structural Weightages:**
  1. **Usage (45% weight):** Measures active transactions in savings, credit, remittances, insurance, and pensions.
  2. **Access (35% weight):** Quantifies physical and digital banking infrastructure (branches, ATMs, BCs, POS terminals).
  3. **Quality (20% weight):** Assesses financial literacy, consumer protection, grievances, and service inequalities.
- **Unique Methodological Attribute:** The FI-Index has **no base year**; it operates as a continuous metric bounded between **0 (complete exclusion) and 100 (complete financial inclusion)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Base Period Trap: FI-Index has **NO base year** (do NOT confuse with RBI-DPI which is March 2018 = 100).
- Pillar Weights: **Usage (45%)** > **Access (35%)** > **Quality (20%)**.
- Scale: Continuous metric from **0 to 100**.

[JUL-005] **AustralianSuper Invests AU$500 Million in NIIF; Total India Exposure Reaches AU$3.3 Billion**

- **Headline Investment Commitment:** AustralianSuper, Australia's largest pension and superannuation fund manager with over AU$300 billion in assets under management, committed an additional **AU$500 million (over ₹3,300 crore)** to the National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF).
- **Cumulative Sovereign Footprint:** With this tranche, AustralianSuper's cumulative direct and indirect investment in India expanded to **AU$3.3 billion (~₹18,500 crore)**, making it one of the largest foreign institutional investors in Indian infrastructure.
- **National Investment and Infrastructure Fund (NIIF) Institutional Architecture:**
  - **Establishment:** Set up in **December 2015** as a sovereign-linked quasi-sovereign wealth alternative asset manager registered with SEBI under Category-II Alternative Investment Fund (AIF) regulations.
  - **Equity Ownership:** Government of India holds a **49% statutory anchor stake**, while 51% is held by domestic and global institutional investors (including ADIA, Temasek, and domestic financial institutions).
  - **Operational Focus:** Channeling institutional patient capital into green energy, expressways, ports, airports, logistics, and digital telecom infrastructure.
  - **Leadership:** Headquartered in Mumbai; led by Sanjiv Aggarwal (MD & CEO).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Capital Outlay: AustralianSuper committed **AU$500 million (over ₹3,300 Cr)** to NIIF.
- Total Exposure: AustralianSuper's aggregate India portfolio reaches **AU$3.3 billion**.
- NIIF Shareholding Structure: Government of India maintains exactly **49% equity**, preventing public debt consolidation while ensuring sovereign backing.
- Operational Form: NIIF is registered with SEBI as a **Category-II Alternative Investment Fund (AIF)**.

[JUL-006] **NPCI Partners with HSBC India & JP Morgan Payments for Real-Time FX Conversion in Cross-Border UPI**

- **Cross-Border FX Settlement Architecture:** National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) forged strategic infrastructure partnerships with **HSBC India** and **JP Morgan Payments** to integrate dynamic, live-market foreign exchange conversion directly into cross-border UPI transactions.
- **Technical Mechanism & API Integration:**
  - **HSBC India:** Delivers real-time foreign exchange pricing feeds via direct banking APIs, enabling Indian and overseas travelers to lock in transparent, live conversion rates at point-of-sale (POS) QR terminals.
  - **JP Morgan Payments:** Merges global treasury clearing with UPI rails to provide instant settlement for cross-border merchant transactions, eliminating post-settlement FX volatility.
  - **Unified Agent Protocol (UAP):** NPCI concurrently initiated development of the Unified Agent Protocol (UAP), an interoperable standard enabling autonomous agentic AI models to execute pre-authorized UPI transactions within user-defined security parameters.
- **Consumer Transparency Mandate:** Eliminates outdated end-of-day markups and opaque foreign currency conversion fees by showing the exact INR deduction before authorization.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Lead Banking Partners: **HSBC India** (real-time FX rates) and **JP Morgan Payments** (clearing and settlement).
- Protocol Innovation: NPCI's **Unified Agent Protocol (UAP)** designed to govern Agentic AI-driven automated micro-transactions.
- Regulatory Objective: Enforces transparent, pre-transaction pricing disclosure for international outward and inward merchant payments.

[JUL-007] **RBI Master Circular on Special Rupee Vostro Accounts (SRVA) for Cross-Border Trade Settlement**

- **Consolidated Regulatory Architecture:** Reserve Bank of India issued a comprehensive Master Circular consolidating all directions governing **Special Rupee Vostro Accounts (SRVA)** issued between 2022 and 2025 under the Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 (FEMA).

- **Core Operational Directives:**
  - **Account Opening & Approvals:** Authorised Dealer (AD Category-I) banks are permitted to open SRVAs for partner foreign banks after obtaining prior approval from the Foreign Exchange Department, Central Office of RBI.
  - **Denomination & Invoicing:** All export and import contracts settled via the mechanism must be **invoiced and denominated strictly in Indian Rupees (INR)**.
  - **Market-Determined Exchange Rates:** Currency conversion between INR and partner foreign currencies takes place at market-driven exchange rates rather than administratively pegged corridors.
  - **Settlement Process:** Indian importers making payments through this mechanism credit the invoice amount in INR into the SRVA of the correspondent overseas bank against bills of lading; Indian exporters are paid directly in INR from the balances in the SRVA.
  - **Surplus Rupee Balance Deployment:** Overseas banks holding surplus INR balances in SRVAs are permitted to invest funds in **Government Treasury Bills (T-Bills)**, sovereign G-Secs, and designated local bank deposits.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Account Type: **Special Rupee Vostro Account (SRVA)** allows foreign correspondent banks to hold INR balances in Indian AD banks.
- Currency Mandate: Trade invoices must be denominated in **Indian Rupees (INR)**.
- Permitted Investment of Surplus: Surplus balances can be invested in **Government Treasury Bills and Sovereign G-Secs** (not equities or unapproved corporate bonds).
- Strategic Impact: Critical vehicle for the **internationalisation of the Indian Rupee** and bilateral dedollarisation.

2. REGULATORY BODIES NEWS

[JUL-008] **RBI Master Direction — Treatment of Wilful Defaulters and Large Defaulters (July 30)**

- **Scope & Applicability:** Applicable to all Scheduled Commercial Banks (incl. RRBs), All-India Financial Institutions (NABARD, EXIM, SIDBI, NHB), NBFCs, and Co-operative Banks.
- **Categorization Thresholds:**
  - **Wilful Defaulter:** Borrower or guarantor with an outstanding aggregate balance of **₹25 lakh and above**, who has defaulted despite having repayment capacity, siphoned/diverted funds, or disposed of charged assets without lender knowledge.
  - **Large Defaulter:** Borrower with an outstanding aggregate balance of **₹1 crore and above**, whose account is classified as Doubtful or Loss (or has been resolved via compromise/suit).
- **Mandatory Timelines for Lenders:**
  - Lenders must examine wilful default within **6 months of an account being classified as NPA**.
  - Identification Committee (Executive Director + two senior officials) issues a reasoned show cause notice allowing **21 days** for borrower response.
  - Review Committee (chaired by MD & CEO + two Independent Directors) confirms or cancels the classification.
- **Severe Regulatory Sanctions:**
  - **Credit Bar:** Barred from availing any fresh loan/credit facility from any institutional lender for **5 years** from the date their name is removed from the List of Wilful Defaulters.
  - **Corporate Bar:** Debarred from floating new ventures for 5 years and disqualified from serving as a Director on any corporate board under Section 164(2) of the Companies Act.
  - **Compromise Settlement Restriction:** No compromise or one-time settlement (OTS) allowed unless a mandatory cooling-off period of **12 months** has elapsed.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Threshold Trap: Wilful Defaulter = **₹25 lakh and above**; Large Defaulter = **₹1 crore and above** (classic IBPS/RBI trap).
- Timeline Trap: Lender must initiate wilful default examination within **6 months of NPA classification** (not 1 year).
- Penal Debarment: Bar on new credit is **5 years** after removal of name; compromise settlement cooling-off is **12 months**.

[JUL-009] **RBI Master Directions on Fraud Risk Management in Regulated Entities (July 15)**

- **Scope:** Replaced the legacy 2016 framework; issued across three distinct directions for Commercial Banks (incl. RRBs), Co-operative Banks, and NBFCs.
- **Compliance with Supreme Court Mandate (*SBI vs. Rajesh Agarwal, 2023*)**:
  - Lenders must strictly adhere to the **Principles of Natural Justice** (*Audi Alteram Partem* — hear the other side).
  - Mandatory issuance of a detailed, reasoned **Show Cause Notice (SCN)** giving the borrower a minimum of **21 calendar days** to submit a written representation before classifying an account as 'Fraud'.
- **Board-Level Oversight (SCBF):**
  - Mandatory constitution of a **Special Committee of the Board on Monitoring and Follow-up of Frauds (SCBF)**, comprising independent and non-executive directors.
  - Dedicated Fraud Monitoring Group (FMG) at the executive level.
- **Reporting & Registry Norms:**
  - Lenders must report fraud cases to the **Central Fraud Registry (CFR)** within **21 days of classification**.
  - Mandatory reporting to Law Enforcement Agencies (State Police / CBI) based on threshold: Frauds >₹3 crore by private/foreign banks to CBI/SFIO; PSU banks follow CVC guidelines.
- **Early Warning Signals (EWS):** Mandatory implementation of 42 EWS indicators for all borrower credit exposures of **₹50 crore and above**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Landmark Precedent: Rooted in the Supreme Court judgment *State Bank of India & Ors. vs. Rajesh Agarwal & Ors.*
- Notice Window: Minimum **21 days** given to the borrower to reply to SCN before fraud classification.
- Reporting Deadline: Classification must be uploaded to RBI's Central Fraud Registry (CFR) within **21 days**.
- EWS Exposure Threshold: Mandatory for accounts **≥₹50 crore**.

[JUL-010] **RBI expands Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) to IFSCs in GIFT City (July 10)**

- **Policy Shift:** Authorized Dealer (AD Category-I) banks are permitted to facilitate remittances by resident individuals to International Financial Services Centres (IFSCs) at GIFT City, Gandhinagar, under the **Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS)**.
- **Annual Ceilings:** Retains the standard LRS cap of **USD 250,000 per financial year** (April–March) for permissible capital and current account transactions.
- **Expanded Scope of Permissible Usages:**
  - **Educational Expenses:** Remittance for tuition fees, boarding, and living expenses to foreign university campuses approved by IFSCA (e.g., Deakin University, University of Wollongong).
  - **Foreign Currency Accounts (FCAs):** Resident individuals can open and maintain interest-bearing or non-interest-bearing FCAs in IFSC banking units (IBUs).
  - **Financial Products & Services:** Subscriptions to mutual funds, alternative investment funds (AIFs), insurance products, and debt securities issued by entities registered in GIFT City.
- **Key Prohibition:** Remittances to IFSCs cannot be used for speculative trading, gambling, or round-tripping of capital.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Remittance Limit: Retains the statutory LRS ceiling of **USD 250,000 per financial year**.
- New Permissible Area: Tuition/living expenses for foreign universities located directly inside GIFT City IFSC.
- Account Type: Enables opening of Foreign Currency Accounts (FCAs) within Indian territory at IFSC units.

[JUL-011] **RBI Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) Framework for Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs)**

- **Regulatory Reach:** Extended to all Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks categorized under **Tier 3 (deposits ₹100 crore to ₹1,000 crore)** and **Tier 4 (deposits >₹1,000 crore)**.
- **Three Core Financial Health Indicators:**
  1. **Capital Adequacy (CRAR):** Mandatory minimum is 9% for Tier 3 UCBs and 12% for Tier 4 UCBs.
  2. **Asset Quality (Net NPA Ratio):** Breaching Net NPA **> 6.0%** triggers Risk Threshold 1.
  3. **Profitability (Return on Assets - RoA):** Negative RoA for two consecutive financial years triggers mandatory supervisory intervention.
- **Mandatory Corrective Invocations:**
  - **Risk Threshold 1:** Restrictions on dividend payout/profit distribution and mandatory capital restoration plan.
  - **Risk Threshold 2:** Complete ban on opening new branches, expansion of business lines, and restriction on capital expenditure.
  - **Risk Threshold 3:** Discretionary RBI powers to supersede the Board of Directors, enforce amalgamation/merger, or cancel banking license.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Tier Applicability: Applicable only to **Tier 3 and Tier 4 UCBs** (deposits exceeding ₹100 crore); Tier 1 and Tier 2 UCBs are excluded.
- Net NPA Trigger: Net NPA crossing **6.0%** triggers PCA.
- Tier 4 Capital Rule: Tier 4 UCBs must maintain minimum CRAR of **12%** (vs. 9% for others).

[JUL-012] **RBI Revised Framework on Domestic Money Transfer (DMT) & Cash KYC (July 24)**

- **Context:** Comprehensive overhaul of domestic cash transfers through Business Correspondents (BCs), digital wallets, and prepaid payment instruments (PPIs) to curb illicit financial flows and mule accounts.
- **Mandatory Remitter Identification:**
  - Business correspondents and banking agents cannot execute cash-to-account remittances without **registering the remitter**.
  - Mandatory verification of remitter's mobile phone number using a one-time password (OTP) and validation of Officially Valid Documents (OVD) or Aadhaar e-KYC.
- **Transaction Limits Preserved:**
  - Maximum cash remittance limit remains **₹50,000 per month per remitter**.
  - Single cash transaction capped at **₹5,000** for non-KYC walk-in customers at BC outlets.
- **Beneficiary Verification:** Banks must include remitter identification details in the payment message (IMPS/NEFT/UPI) sent to the destination beneficiary bank to ensure end-to-end auditability.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Monthly Cash Limit: ₹50,000 per remitter per month.
- Core Regulatory Mandate: Mandatory remitter mobile OTP verification and OVD registration for all cash remittances at BC points.

[JUL-013] **RBI Directives on Dividend Declaration by Commercial Banks**

- **Prudential Standards:** Revised framework specifying parameters commercial banks must satisfy to declare dividends on equity shares or remit profits (in the case of foreign bank branches).
- **Three Minimum Pre-requisites:**
  1. **CRAR:** Minimum Capital to Risk-Weighted Assets Ratio of at least **11.5%** (inclusive of 2.5% Capital Conservation Buffer) for each of the preceding three financial years.
  2. **Net NPA:** Net NPA ratio must be **less than 6.0%** for the financial year for which dividend is proposed.
  3. **Supervisory Compliance:** Bank must comply with RBI regulations on transfer to Statutory Reserve Fund (min 20% of net profits) and provisioning.
- **Dividend Payout Ratio Matrix:**
  - Net NPA = 0%: Maximum Dividend Payout Ratio is **50%**.
  - Net NPA between 0% and 1%: Maximum Dividend Payout Ratio is **40%**.
  - Net NPA between 5% and 6%: Maximum Dividend Payout Ratio is **10%**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Net NPA Ceiling: Must be **<6%** to be eligible for any dividend payout.
- Minimum CRAR: Must be at least **11.5%** for preceding 3 consecutive years.
- Maximum Payout Cap: **50%** of net profit (only for zero Net NPA banks).

[JUL-014] **Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS) & Mandatory CERSAI Registration**

- **Statutory Framework:** Governed under the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007, and the Factoring Regulation Act, 2011, providing non-recourse digital discounting of MSME trade receivables.
- **Mandatory CERSAI Registration:**
  - All Factoring Units (invoices/bills of exchange) created and financed on TReDS platforms must be registered with **CERSAI** (Central Registry of Securitisation Asset Reconstruction and Security Interest of India).
  - Registration prevents fraudulent dual-financing or pledging of the same receivable across multiple commercial lenders.
- **Operating Platforms in India:**
  - **RXIL** (Receivables Exchange of India Ltd — India's first operational TReDS exchange launched in 2016; joint venture of NSE and SIDBI).
  - **M1xchange** (Mynd Solutions Pvt. Ltd.).
  - **Invoicemart** (A.TREDS Ltd. — Axis Bank & mjunction).
  - **C2treds** (C2FO Factoring Solutions Pvt. Ltd.).
  - **DTX** (KredX Platform Pvt. Ltd.).
- **Net Worth Mandate:** Existing RBI-authorized TReDS operators must ramp up their statutory minimum net worth to **₹25 crore** by **March 31, 2028** (extended compliance glide path from the initial proposed 2027 window).
- **Eligible Participants:** Buyers (corporates, CPSEs, government departments), Sellers (MSMEs), and Financiers (banks, NBFC factors).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Fraud Prevention: Mandatory registration with **CERSAI** eliminates duplicate invoice financing.
- First TReDS Platform: **RXIL** (commenced operations in 2016; NSE + SIDBI JV).
- Net Worth Deadline: Existing operators must achieve **₹25 crore net worth by 31 March 2028**.
- Ineligible Participants: Stock exchanges and insurance underwriters cannot participate as financiers on TReDS.

[JUL-015] **RBI Recognition of Sahamati Foundation as SRO for Account Aggregator Ecosystem**

- **Regulatory Milestone:** Under the Omnibus Framework for Self-Regulatory Organisations (SROs), Reserve Bank of India granted formal recognition to the **Sahamati Foundation** as the official SRO for the **Account Aggregator (AA)**

ecosystem.

- **Institutional Structure:**
  - Sahamati is incorporated as a **Section 8 (not-for-profit)** company under the Companies Act, 2013.
  - Represents the collective interests of Financial Information Providers (FIPs), Financial Information Users (FIUs), and Account Aggregators (AAs).
- **Prudential SRO Governance Norms:**
  - **Application Route:** Mandatory digital application submission through RBI's **PRAVAAH Portal** (*Platform for Regulatory Application, VAlidation and AutHorisation*).
  - **Ownership Ceiling:** No single member entity is permitted to hold more than **10%** of the voting paid-up equity share capital to ensure neutral governance.
  - **Net Worth Band:** Prescribed minimum net worth between **₹2 crore to ₹10 crore** depending on operational scale.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Designated SRO: **Sahamati Foundation** for the Account Aggregator network.
- Portal for SRO Applications: RBI's **PRAVAAH Portal**.
- Single Entity Ownership Cap: Maximum **10%** voting shareholding; organized as a **Section 8 not-for-profit** entity.

[JUL-016] **SEBI Depository Investor Protection Fund (IPF) Norms: Operational Expense Utilization Capped at 5%**

- **Regulatory Framework & Effective Date:** Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) amended norms governing Investor Protection Funds (IPF) maintained by depositories (NSDL and CDSL), permitting depositories to utilize **up to 5% of annual interest or income** earned from the IPF corpus for administrative and operational expenses, effective **September 2026**.
- **Eligible Operating Outlays:**
  - Remuneration and salaries of dedicated personnel employed directly by the independent IPF Trust.
  - Statutory compliance expenditures, including independent audit fees, taxation, and Charity Commissioner registration fees.
- **Corpus Protection Invariant:**
  - At least **95% of the annual income/interest** generated by the fund must be compulsorily credited back to replenish the principal IPF corpus.
  - In case administrative expenses exceed the 5% threshold, the deficit must be absorbed entirely by the depository from its own corporate balance sheet, not from the IPF principal.
  - Unutilized portions of the 5% allowance cannot be carried forward as profit and must revert to the corpus.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Permitted Expense Cap: Maximum **5% of annual interest/income** from the IPF corpus (not 5% of the total corpus).
- Mandatory Replenishment: At least **95% of annual income** must be added back into the principal fund.
- Deficit Bearing: Any expense exceeding the 5% ceiling must be borne **by the depository itself**.

[JUL-017] **SEBI Reintroduces Open-Market Share Buybacks via Stock Exchanges; Freezes Promoter ISINs**

- **Policy Reversal & Streamlining:** SEBI formally reintroduced corporate share buybacks conducted through the secondary stock exchange trading window, effective **August 1, 2026**.
- **Core Prudential Parameters:**
  - **Aggregate Quantum Cap:** Share buybacks via the open-market exchange route are capped at **less than 15%** of the company's total paid-up equity capital and free reserves (tested against both standalone and consolidated balance sheets).
  - **Drastic Execution Compression:** The buyback window must open within **4 working days** of the public announcement and must be fully concluded within **66 working days** (drastically reduced from the erstwhile 6-month timeline).

- **Promoter Share Freezing:** To prevent front-running, manipulation, and insider offloading, promoter group shareholdings are **frozen at the depository ISIN level** throughout the entire buyback duration.
- **Merchant Banker Option:** Appointment of a merchant banker for open-market buybacks is made optional, placing direct compliance accountability on the corporate board.
- **Minimum Public Shareholding (MPS):** Companies are strictly prohibited from announcing buyback volumes that would reduce post-offer public shareholding below the statutory **25% MPS threshold**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Open-Market Buyback Cap: Strictly **less than 15%** of paid-up capital and free reserves.
- Execution Timeline: Opens within **4 working days** and closes within **66 working days** (earlier 6 months).
- Promoter Lock: Promoters' holdings are **frozen at the ISIN level** for the duration of the buyback.
- Statutory Limit: Cannot breach the **25% Minimum Public Shareholding (MPS)** requirement.

[JUL-018] **SEBI Comprehensive Employee Code of Conduct: Mandatory Divestment of Non-Permitted Equities**

- **Governance & Conflict-of-Interest Overhaul:** SEBI notified a stringent, revised employee Code of Conduct requiring all whole-time officers and staff members to immediately disclose, freeze, or systematically divest holdings in non-permitted securities.
- **Divestment & Disclosure Mandates:**
  - **Prohibited Instruments:** Direct investments in listed equity shares, convertible debentures, equity-linked derivatives, and commodity derivative contracts.
  - **Divestment Timeline:** Employees possessing legacy non-permitted assets must submit a time-bound exit plan; during the holding period, they are barred from exercising voting rights, receiving discretionary corporate perks, or subscribing to rights issues.
  - **Mandatory Reporting Windows:** Staff must report professional interests held over the preceding 3 years, disclose gifts exceeding **₹50,000**, and report any negotiations for future employment with regulated entities within **30 days**.
  - **Cooling-Off Period:** Prescribed a mandatory **2-year cooling-off period** for former SEBI officers before they can represent private clients or appear before the Board.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Mandatory Cooling-Off: **2 years** for former employees before appearing before SEBI.
- Gift Reporting Threshold: Any gift valued above **₹50,000** must be officially declared.
- Prohibited Assets: Direct equity shares, equity derivatives, and commodity derivatives.

[JUL-019] **SEBI Authorises Intraday Borrowing Window for Mutual Funds to Bridge Same-Day Settlement Gaps**

- **Liquidity Management Relaxation:** SEBI permitted Asset Management Companies (AMCs) to access intraday borrowing credit lines to resolve temporary same-day cash flow mismatches arising from lumpy redemption pressures and delayed banking settlement legs.
- **Operational Boundaries:**
  - **Permitted Uses:** Strictly confined to meeting intraday redemption payouts, dividend/interest distributions, settlement of underlying market purchases, mark-to-market (MTM) margin calls, and foreign exchange settlement legs.
  - **End-of-Day Repayment Invariant:** AMCs must ensure that **100% of intraday borrowings are fully extinguished and repaid before the close of the trading day**.
  - **Zero Cost Transfer to Unit-Holders:** Unit-holders cannot be charged for intraday facility expenses; any interest cost, commitment fee, or losses resulting from delays in receiving anticipated funds must be borne **exclusively by the AMC**, not the scheme.
  - **Board Governance:** AMCs must formulate an independent Board-approved policy on intraday credit limits and publish the operational architecture on their official portals.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Repayment Mandate: Intraday borrowings must be repaid **before the end of the same trading day**.
- Expense Liability: Costs must be absorbed **100% by the AMC** (zero cost transfer to mutual fund unit-holders).
- Allowed Facility: Designed strictly to service intraday liquidity timing gaps against expected same-day inflows.

[JUL-020] **Delhi High Court Orders Liquidation of Paytm Payments Bank; Appoints Official Liquidator**

- **Judicial Liquidation Order:** On **July 8, 2026** (supplemented by directions on July 22), the Delhi High Court officially admitted a winding-up petition against **Paytm Payments Bank Limited (PPBL)** and appointed **Shri Girikumar M. Nair (former Chief General Manager, State Bank of India)** as the Official Liquidator.
- **Statutory Enforcement Background:**
  - Followed the statutory cancellation of PPBL's banking licence by the Reserve Bank of India on **April 24, 2026** under **Section 22(4) of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949** due to chronic supervisory non-compliance and AML KYC deficiencies.
  - Proceeding executed jointly under the Banking Regulation Act, 1949 and Section 271/272 of the Companies Act, 2013.
- **Institutional Context of Payment Banks in India:**
  - Conceived on the recommendations of the **Nachiket Mor Committee on Comprehensive Financial Services (2013)** to advance micro-savings and digital remittances.
  - Operational Rules: Minimum paid-up capital of ₹100 crore; demand deposits capped at **₹2,00,000 per individual customer**; permitted to issue debit cards but **strictly prohibited from lending, issuing credit cards, or accepting time deposits**.
  - Active Surviving Entities: Airtel Payments Bank (first to launch, 2016), India Post Payments Bank (IPPB), Fino Payments Bank, Jio Payments Bank, and NSDL Payments Bank.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Statutory Power: Banking licence cancelled under **Section 22(4) of Banking Regulation Act 1949**.
- Committee Genesis: Payment Banks conceptualized by the **Nachiket Mor Committee (2013)**.
- Deposit Ceiling: Maximum balance of **₹2,00,000 per customer**.
- Regulatory Restriction: Payment Banks can issue **Debit Cards ONLY**; strictly barred from lending, advances, and credit card issuance.

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3. BANKING & INSURANCE NEWS

[JUL-021] **State Bank of India raises ₹10,000 Crore via 15-Year Infrastructure Bonds**

- **Mega Debt Issuance:** State Bank of India (SBI) concluded the issuance of its fifth tranche of infrastructure bonds, raising **₹10,000 crore** at a coupon rate of **7.36%**.
- **Tenor & Pricing:** 15-year tenor; priced tightly at 21 basis points over the corresponding Government of India (G-Sec) benchmark security yield.
- **Statutory Regulatory Relief:** Funds raised through long-term infrastructure bonds are **exempt from regulatory reserve requirements** (no CRR or SLR obligations apply), and 100% of proceeds are channeled directly into infrastructure and affordable housing lending.
- **Cumulative Record:** With this issuance, SBI's total long-term infrastructure bond book crossed **₹50,000 crore**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Regulatory Exemption: Infrastructure bonds are completely exempt from Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) and Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR) requirements.
- Issue Quantum & Tenor: ₹10,000 Crore; 15-year maturity at 7.36% coupon.

[JUL-022] **NABARD Celebrates 43rd Foundation Day (July 12)**

- **Milestone Celebration:** National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) observed its **43rd Foundation Day** on July 12, 2024.
- **Historical Genesis:** Established on **July 12, 1982**, under Act 61 of 1981, upon the strategic recommendations of the **B. Sivaraman Committee** (Committee to Review Arrangements For Institutional Credit for Agriculture and Rural Development - CRAFICARD).
- **Core Remit:** Apex development bank providing refinance to State Co-operative Banks, RRBs, and commercial banks for agriculture, MSMEs, and rural infrastructure through the Rural Infrastructure Development Fund (RIDF).
- **Headquarters:** Mumbai, Maharashtra.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Established Date: **12 July 1982** under NABARD Act, 1981.
- Recommending Committee: **B. Sivaraman Committee (CRAFICARD)**.
- RIDF Corpus Custodian: Managed exclusively by NABARD.

[JUL-023] **Payment System Metrics: The Great Credit vs. Debit Card Divergence**

- **Debit Card Volume & Value Contraction:**
  - Debit card transaction volume collapsed precipitously from **408.7 crore to 133.6 crore** transactions.
  - Debit card transaction spend contracted from **₹7.4 lakh crore down to ₹4.5 lakh crore**.
  - **Primary Driver:** Mass consumer migration to **UPI** for daily merchant payments and low-ticket POS transactions.
- **Credit Card Growth Trajectory:**
  - Total annual credit card spend crossed **₹18.8 lakh crore**, growing at an annual rate exceeding **25%**.
  - Fueled by e-commerce penetration, travel rewards, cashback incentives, and RuPay credit cards on UPI.
- **Banking Sector Market Share in Credit Cards:**
  - **Private Sector Banks:** Share in outstanding credit cards surged from **67.7% to 71.1%**, controlling over seven-tenths of the national market.
  - **Public Sector Banks (PSBs):** Maintained a steady footprint between **23.5% and 23.9%** (anchored by SBI Cards).
  - **Foreign Banks:** Footprint contracted sharply from **9.3% down to 3.8%** following multinational retail banking portfolio sales.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Contraction Root Cause: Debit card drop is driven by **UPI adoption** (not ATM closures or regulatory bans).
- Market Dominance: Private sector banks issue **71.1%** of credit cards; Foreign banks declined to **3.8%**.
- Benchmark Figures: Credit card spend = **₹18.8 lakh crore**; Debit card spend dropped to **₹4.5 lakh crore**.

[JUL-024] **Small Savings Schemes (SSS) Interest Rates — Q2 FY 2024–25 (July–September)**

- **Fixing Mechanism:** Administered by the Department of Economic Affairs (DEA), Ministry of Finance, reviewed quarterly based on the **Shyamala Gopinath Committee (2011)** formula benchmarked against secondary market government security yields.
- **Roster of Core Scheme Rates:**
  - **Sukanya Samriddhi Account Scheme (SSAS): 8.2%** (highest yield among regular small savings schemes).
  - **Senior Citizen Savings Scheme (SCSS): 8.2%** (deposit ceiling ₹30 lakh).
  - **National Savings Certificate (NSC): 7.7%** (5-year fixed tenor).
  - **Kisan Vikas Patra (KVP): 7.5%** (doubles investment principal in **115 months**).
  - **Mahila Samman Savings Certificate (MSSC): 7.5%** (2-year tenure, max deposit ₹2 lakh).
  - **Post Office Monthly Income Scheme (POMIS): 7.4%** (individual account max limit ₹9 lakh; joint account max limit ₹15 lakh).

- **Public Provident Fund (PPF): 7.1%** (annual deposit ceiling ₹1.5 lakh; sovereign EEE tax exemption status).
- **Post Office Savings Account (POSA): 4.0%**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Highest Interest Rate: **8.2%** for Sukanya Samriddhi (SSAS) and Senior Citizens (SCSS).
- KVP Doubling Maturity: **115 months** (9 years and 7 months).
- Post Office MIS Ceilings: Single account = **₹9 Lakh**; Joint account = **₹15 Lakh**.
- Committee Origin: Small savings formula is guided by the **Shyamala Gopinath Committee**.

[JUL-025] **RBI Prohibits Bank SMS Alert Charges for Compliance & Promos; Makes Alerts Below ₹500 Optional**

- **Customer Protection Directive:** Reserve Bank of India directed all Scheduled Commercial Banks, Payment Banks, and Small Finance Banks to immediately cease levying quarterly SMS alert fees on account holders for mandatory compliance notices, financial literacy alerts, or promotional broadcasts.
- **Industry Financial Impact:**
  - Banks historically deducted between **₹15 to ₹18 per quarter plus GST** from active savings accounts, generating an estimated cumulative fee revenue of over **₹300 crore annually**.
  - A large commercial bank servicing an active base of 50 million savings accounts faces an annual non-interest fee contraction of approximately **₹360 crore**.
- **Operational Transaction Alert Threshold:**
  - To prevent unnecessary notification spam and reduce telecom transmission expenses, RBI clarified that automated transactional SMS alerts for debit transactions valued at **₹500 or less are now optional** (at the bank's discretion or customer opt-in).
  - High-value debit transaction notifications, critical OTPs, and unauthorized debit warning prompts remain mandatory and must be delivered free of charge.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Prohibited Fee: Levying quarterly charges for regulatory, awareness, and promotional SMS messages.
- Discretionary Alert Ceiling: Transactional SMS alerts for amounts **≤ ₹500** are made optional.
- Historic Baseline Fee: Banks earlier charged **₹15–₹18 per quarter**.

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4. NATIONAL, STATE & INTERNATIONAL NEWS

[JUL-026] **Historic Legal Transition: Three New Criminal Laws Enacted Nationwide (July 1)**

- **Enforcement Date:** Three transformative criminal law statutes came into full legal effect across India on **July 1, 2024**, completely repealing and replacing British colonial-era penal codes:
  1. **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (BNS):** Replaced the Indian Penal Code, 1860 (IPC).
  2. **Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (BNSS):** Replaced the Code of Criminal Procedure, 1973 (CrPC).
  3. **Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023 (BSA):** Replaced the Indian Evidence Act, 1872.
- **Key Judicial Innovations:**
  - Mandates **Zero FIR** (can be filed at any police station irrespective of jurisdiction).
  - Introduction of **e-FIR** and compulsory electronic summons via SMS/WhatsApp.
  - Mandatory audio-video recording of search and seizure operations, and mandatory forensic investigation for offences punishable by **7 years or more**.
  - Introduction of **Community Service** as a recognized formal penal punishment for minor offences.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Enforcement Date: **July 1, 2024** (not Jan 1 or April 1).
- Statutory Cross-Mapping: BNS = IPC; BNSS = CrPC; BSA = Evidence Act.
- Forensic Threshold: Mandatory for offences carrying imprisonment of **7 years or more**.

[JUL-027] **Union Cabinet approves ₹76,220 Crore Mega Major Port at Vadhavan, Maharashtra**

- **Sovereign Infrastructure Push:** Union Cabinet approved the development of a greenfield all-weather deep-water Major Port at **Vadhavan near Dahanu in Palghar district, Maharashtra**.
- **Financial Outlay:** Total estimated project cost is **₹76,220 crore**, developed by Vadhavan Port Project Limited (VPPL) — an SPV between Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA, 74%) and Maharashtra Maritime Board (MMB, 26%).
- **Top 10 Global Target:** Designed with a natural draft of **20 meters**, capable of handling the world's largest container mega-vessels (up to 24,000 TEUs); target cumulative capacity of **298 million metric tonnes (MMT)** per annum, propelling India into the Top 10 container ports globally.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Location & District: Vadhavan, Palghar district, Maharashtra.
- Total Outlay: ₹76,220 crore.
- SPV Equity Ratio: JNPA (**74%**) and Maharashtra Maritime Board (**26%**).

[JUL-028] **Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act & Implementing Rules Enacted**

- **Statutory Enforcement:** Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions operationalized the **Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024** and notified its comprehensive implementing rules nationwide.
- **Examinations & Bodies Covered:**
  - Covers competitive examinations conducted by Union Public Service Commission (UPSC), Staff Selection Commission (SSC), Railway Recruitment Boards (RRBs), National Testing Agency (NTA), and the Institute of Banking Personnel Selection (**IBPS**).
- **Penal Slabs & Liability Architecture:**
  - **Individual Malpractices:** Persons resorting to unfair means face imprisonment of **3 to 5 years** and a fine up to **₹10 lakh**.
  - **Organized Paper Leak Syndicates:** Imprisonment of **5 to 10 years** and a mandatory minimum fine of **₹1 crore**.
  - **Service Provider Penalty:** Examination conducting agencies/service providers found complicit face recovery of full examination costs and a complete bar from conducting public examinations for **4 years**.
  - **Legal Character:** All offences under the statute are non-bailable, cognizable, and non-compoundable.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Banking Exam Coverage: Explicitly governs **IBPS** examinations alongside UPSC, SSC, and NTA.
- Organized Syndicate Penalties: Minimum fine of **₹1 Crore**; 5 to 10 years imprisonment.
- Legal Classification: **Cognizable and Non-Bailable** offences.

[JUL-029] **Andhra Pradesh Launches 'Pillale Sampada' Demographic Policy; Ladakh Notifies 25% Pashmina Production Incentive**

- **Andhra Pradesh 'Pillale Sampada' (Children are Wealth) Paradigm Shift:**
  - Chief Minister N. Chandrababu Naidu officially announced a pivot from population control to **population conservation and demographic renewal** on World Population Day (July 11) in Vijayawada.
  - Addressed declining Total Fertility Rates (TFR) across southern states and impending demographic aging by proposing the repeal of the two-child norm disqualification for local body elections.

- Under the associated **Talliki Vandanam Scheme**, the state government allocates **₹15,000 per child annually** to mothers to finance schooling and higher education.

- **Ladakh Livestock Development Incentive Programme for Pashmina Herders:**
  - Lieutenant Governor approved a landmark **25% top-up production-based incentive** on total raw Pashmina procurement value, credited via Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) to Aadhaar-linked accounts of Changpa nomadic pastoralists.
  - Sanctioned an **₹8 crore dedicated revolving fund** for the All Changthang Pashmina Growers Cooperative Marketing Society Ltd.
  - Pastoral Context: Pashmina is derived exclusively from the undercoat fleece of the indigenous **Changthangi (Capra hircus) goat**, reared at altitudes above 14,000 feet in eastern Ladakh.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Andhra Initiative: **Pillale Sampada** focuses on demographic conservation; Talliki Vandanam provides **₹15,000 per child**.
- Ladakh Pashmina Top-up: **25% procurement incentive** delivered via Direct Benefit Transfer.
- Caprine Breed: Pashmina fleece is harvested from the high-altitude **Changthangi goat** reared by the **Changpa community**.

[JUL-030] **Geographical Indication (GI) Registrations: West Bengal Sweets & Boats, Gujarat Unjha Spices, Rajasthan Jodhpuri Mojari**

- **Tripartite Regional GI Accords:** Geographical Indications Registry (Chennai) under DPIIT (Ministry of Commerce and Industry) granted statutory GI protection under the **Geographical Indications of Goods (Registration and Protection) Act, 1999** across three major states:
  - **West Bengal (Triple Inscription):**
    1. **Jalbhara Sandesh:** Confection originating from Chandannagar, Hooghly district, featuring a distinctive liquid rosewater-and-nolen-gur syrup center.
    2. **Janai's Manohara:** Traditional sweetmeat crafted from Janai village, Hooghly district, encapsulated in a solidified sugar shell.
    3. **Balagarh Traditional Handcrafted Wooden Boats:** Indigenous shipbuilding craft practiced along the Hooghly river basin in Balagarh, historically utilizing Sal, Teak, and Babool timbers.
  - **Gujarat (Mehsana Spices Hub):**
    1. **Unjha Cumin (Jeera)** and **Unjha Fennel (Saunf):** Cultivated in Mehsana district; Unjha is recognized as Asia's largest regulated spot market and physical trading exchange for seed spices.
  - **Rajasthan (Jodhpuri Mojari):**
    - 200-year-old handcrafted traditional leather footwear crafted by artisans in Jodhpur utilizing vegetable-tanned leather and intricate silk-thread embroidery.

- **Statutory Framework:** GI tags are valid for a duration of **10 years**, renewable indefinitely upon payment of statutory renewal fees.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Law: **Geographical Indications of Goods Act, 1999** (administered by GI Registry, Chennai under DPIIT).
- Validity Period: **10 years** (renewable).
- Inscribed Goods: WB (*Jalbhara Sandesh*, *Manohara*, *Balagarh Boats*); Gujarat (*Unjha Cumin* & *Unjha Fennel*); Rajasthan (*Jodhpuri Mojari*).

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6. SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY, DEFENCE & SPORTS

[JUL-031] **CSIR-IICT Develops India's First Indigenous HFO-1234yf Green Refrigerant & Smart Algal Liquid Tree (SALT)**

- **Breakthrough Clean Refrigerant Synthesis:** CSIR–Indian Institute of Chemical Technology (CSIR-IICT), Hyderabad, successfully synthesized India's first fully indigenous process technology for **Hydrofluoroolefin-1234yf (HFO-1234yf)**.
  - **Environmental Profile:** Zero Ozone Depletion Potential (ODP) and an ultra-low Global Warming Potential (**GWP < 1**), engineered to replace hydrofluorocarbons (HFC-134a, which has a GWP of 1,430) in automotive air-conditioning and industrial chillers.
  - **Treaty Alignment:** Fulfills India's statutory phase-down obligations under the **Kigali Amendment to the Montreal Protocol** (aiming for an 85% reduction in national HFC consumption by 2047).
- **Smart Algal Liquid Tree (SALT) Mobile Photobioreactor:**
  - Developed by CSIR–Central Institute of Mining and Fuel Research (CSIR-CIMFR), Dhanbad.
  - Utilizes concentrated microalgae cultures in a mobile photobioreactor column to absorb carbon dioxide (CO_2) and discharge pure oxygen at rates equivalent to 10–20 mature urban trees; deployed at CIMFR Dhanbad and Northern Coalfields Limited (NCL) Singrauli.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Green Chemical: **HFO-1234yf** developed by **CSIR-IICT Hyderabad** with Global Warming Potential **GWP < 1**.
- International Treaty: Replaces HFCs pursuant to the **Kigali Amendment to the Montreal Protocol**.
- Carbon Capture Tech: **Smart Algal Liquid Tree (SALT)** developed by **CSIR-CIMFR Dhanbad**.

[JUL-032] **Indian Navy Commissions Guided-Missile Stealth Frigate INS Mahendragiri (Project 17A Nilgiri-Class)**

- **Warship Commissioning Milestone:** Indian Navy commissioned **INS Mahendragiri** at Mumbai on **July 11, 2026**, marking the operational induction of the **seventh and final Nilgiri-class stealth guided-missile frigate** under **Project 17A**.
- **Shipbuilding & Indigenous Pedigree:**
  - Constructed by **Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDL)**, Mumbai; designed in-house by the Indian Navy's Warship Design Bureau (WDB).
  - Indigenous Content: Features over **75% indigenous content**, incorporating steel, propulsion equipment, and weapon systems from Indian MSMEs.
  - Follow-on Class: Follows the Project 17 (Shivalik-class) frigates, boasting advanced radar-absorbent coatings, low acoustic signatures, and flush deck superstructures.
- **Armament & Radar Suites:**
  - Fitted with supersonic **BrahMos anti-ship cruise missiles** and **Barak-8 / LRSAM (Long Range Surface-to-Air Missiles)** developed jointly with Israel Aerospace Industries (IAI).
  - Equipped with the indigenous **MF-STAR (Multi-Function Surveillance, Track and Missile Guidance Radar)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Final Frigate: **INS Mahendragiri** is the 7th and final warship under **Project 17A (Nilgiri-class)**.
- Shipbuilder: Constructed by **Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Limited (MDL)** in Mumbai.
- Indigenous Content Ratio: Exceeds **75% indigenous sourcing**.
- Predecessor Class: Follows the **Project 17 (Shivalik-class)**.

[JUL-033] **Novo Nordisk Launches World's First Once-Weekly Basal Insulin 'Awiqli' (Insulin Icodec) in India**

- **Therapeutic Innovation in Endocrinology:** Pharmaceutical major Novo Nordisk received Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) marketing authorization to commercialize **Awiqli (Insulin Icodec)** in India.
- **Clinical Paradigm Shift:**
  - Represents the **world's first once-weekly basal insulin analog** approved for adult patients with Type 1 and Type 2 Diabetes Mellitus.
  - **Injection Burden Compression:** Slashes the requisite basal insulin injection frequency from **365 subcutaneous daily injections per year down to just 52 weekly injections per year**.

- **Pharmacokinetics:** Features a multi-day extended half-life achieved through strong, reversible albumin binding, delivering steady basal glycemic control over a full 7-day therapeutic window via a single pen injection.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Brand & Molecule: **Awiqli (Insulin Icodec)** manufactured by Novo Nordisk.
- Dosing Innovation: **Once-weekly basal insulin** (52 annual injections vs. traditional 365 daily injections).
- Indication: Management of glycemic control in adult **Type 1 and Type 2 Diabetes**.

7. AWARDS, BOOKS, INDICES & RANKINGS

[JUL-034] **NITI Aayog SDG India Index 2023–24 (4th Edition): Composite Score Advances to 67**

- **National Progress:** NITI Aayog released the 4th edition of the **SDG India Index 2023–24**, tracking progress across all 16 Sustainable Development Goals.
- **Composite Score Improvement:** India's overall composite SDG score surged to **67** (up from 66 in 2020–21 and 57 in 2018), driven by massive progress in Goal 1 (No Poverty), Goal 7 (Affordable & Clean Energy), Goal 11 (Sustainable Cities), and Goal 13 (Climate Action).
- **State Rankings:**
  - **Top Performers: Uttarakhand and Kerala** shared the 1st rank with a composite score of **79**, followed by Tamil Nadu (78) and Goa (77).
  - **Lowest Performer: Bihar (57)**, followed by Jharkhand (62) and Nagaland (63).
- **Union Territory Performance: Chandigarh** ranked 1st among UTs with a score of 91, followed by Jammu & Kashmir (74).
- **Categorization Criteria:** Aspirant (0–49), Performer (50–64), Front Runner (65–99), Achiever (100). All states are now either Performers or Front Runners (zero states in Aspirant).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Composite Score: **67** for India as a whole.
- Top States: **Uttarakhand and Kerala** (tie at 79 score).
- Lowest State: **Bihar (57)**.
- Top UT: **Chandigarh (91)**.

[JUL-035] **Global Peace Index 2024 (Institute for Economics & Peace): India Ranked 116th**

- **Annual Benchmark:** 18th edition of the **Global Peace Index (GPI 2024)** published by international think-tank Institute for Economics & Peace (IEP, Sydney).
- **India's Standing:** India ranked **116th out of 163 countries** with an overall score of 2.319 (improved by 10 positions from 126th in 2023).
- **Global Leaders & Tail-enders:**
  - **Most Peaceful Country: Iceland** (ranked 1st globally since 2008), followed by Ireland (2nd), Austria (3rd), and New Zealand (4th).
  - **Least Peaceful Country: Yemen (163rd)**, replacing Afghanistan, followed by Sudan (162nd) and South Sudan (161st).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Rank: **116th** (out of 163 countries).
- Most Peaceful: **Iceland** (holds position since 2008).
- Publishing Institution: **Institute for Economics & Peace (IEP)**, Sydney.

[JUL-036] **Global Liveability Index 2024 (Economist Intelligence Unit — EIU)**

- **Methodology & Scope:** Annual index compiled by the Economist Intelligence Unit (EIU, London), evaluating 173 world cities across 5 core pillars: Stability, Healthcare, Culture & Environment, Education, and Infrastructure.
- **Top Ranked Liveable Cities Globally:**
  - **1st Rank: Vienna, Austria** (retained #1 ranking for the third consecutive year, scoring 98.4 out of 100 with perfect scores in stability, healthcare, education, and infrastructure).
  - **2nd Rank: Copenhagen, Denmark**.
  - **3rd Rank: Zurich, Switzerland**.
  - **4th Rank:** Melbourne, Australia.
- **Lowest Ranked Cities: Damascus, Syria (173rd / bottom)**, preceded by Tripoli, Libya (172nd) and Algiers, Algeria (171st).
- **Indian Cities Performance:**
  - Highest ranked in India: **New Delhi and Mumbai** (tied at **140th rank**).
  - Followed by Bengaluru (146th), Ahmedabad (147th), and Chennai (148th).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- #1 Most Liveable City: **Vienna, Austria** (retains title for 3 consecutive years).
- Bottom City: **Damascus, Syria** (173rd rank).
- Best Ranked Indian Cities: **New Delhi & Mumbai** (tied at 140th).

[JUL-037] **The State of Food Security and Nutrition in the World (SOFI) Report**

- **Multilateral Authorship:** Jointly produced by five United Nations agencies: Food and Agriculture Organization (**FAO** — lead), IFAD, UNICEF, WFP, and WHO.
- **Core Theme:** *"Financing to end hunger, food insecurity and all forms of malnutrition"*.
- **Global Undernourishment Crisis:**
  - Approximately **733 million people** faced hunger in 2023 (representing **1 in 11 people globally**, and 1 in 5 in Africa).
  - Projecting current trends, **582 million people** will be chronically undernourished in 2030, severely compromising the achievement of UN Sustainable Development Goal 2 (**SDG 2: Zero Hunger**).
- **Dietary Affordability:**
  - Over **2.8 billion people** worldwide (over one-third of the global population) were unable to afford a healthy diet.
  - In India, an estimated 55.6% of the population faces financial barriers to affording nutrient-rich diets.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Lead UN Agency: **Food and Agriculture Organization (FAO)**.
- Global Hunger Count: **733 million people** (1 in 11 globally).
- 2030 Target Gap: Projected **582 million** will still face chronic hunger by 2030 (SDG 2 shortfall).

[JUL-038] **Sustainable Development Report 2024 (SDR) — UN SDSN**

- **Publishing Authority:** Published by the United Nations Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN), prepared under the leadership of Prof. Jeffrey Sachs, tracking the performance of all UN member states toward the 17 Sustainable Development Goals.
- **India's Global Position:**
  - India ranked **109th out of 167 nations** with a composite score of **64.0** (climbing from 112th in 2023).
  - India is progressing on-track regarding SDG 12 (Responsible Consumption and Production) and SDG 13 (Climate Action), but exhibits significant stagnation in SDG 2 (Zero Hunger) and SDG 5 (Gender Equality).
- **Global Leaders & Bottom Tiers:**
  - **1st Rank: Finland** (score 86.4, securing 1st rank for the fourth consecutive year).

- **2nd Rank:** Sweden; **3rd Rank:** Denmark; **4th Rank:** Germany; **5th Rank:** France.
- **Lowest Ranked:** South Sudan (167th) and Central African Republic (166th).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Rank: **109th** (score 64.0).
- Global Leader: **Finland** (4 consecutive years at #1).
- Distinction Trap: Do NOT confuse with NITI Aayog's internal SDG India Index (India score 67; Uttarakhand/Kerala #1).

[JUL-039] **Performance Grading Index for Districts (PGI-D) — Ministry of Education**

- **Assessment Mandate:** Released by the Department of School Education and Literacy (DoSEL), Ministry of Education, evaluating school education system health across all 700+ districts in India.
- **Evaluation Framework & Points:**
  - Aggregates **600 points** across **83 core indicators** organized under 6 domains: Learning Outcomes, Effective Classroom Transactions, Infrastructure Facilities & Student Entitlements, School Safety & Child Protection, Digital Learning, and Governance Processes.
- **Grading Hierarchy (10 Levels):**
  - Highest Grade: **Daksha** (>90% score, 541–600 points) — *no district in India achieved Daksha*.
  - Second Highest: **Utkarsh** (81–90% score, 481–540 points).
  - Subsequent Tiers: Atti-Uttam (71–80%), Uttam (61–70%), Prachesta-1, Prachesta-2, Prachesta-3, Akanshi-1, Akanshi-2, and Akanshi-3 (<10%).
- **Leading Jurisdictions:** Districts in **Punjab** and the Union Territory of **Chandigarh** lead the top scoring tiers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Score: **600 points** across 83 indicators.
- Top Category Nomenclature: **Daksha** (>90%, unachieved); second-tier is **Utkarsh** (81–90%).
- Lowest Category: **Akanshi-3** (<10%).

[JUL-040] **Henley Passport Index 2024 (July Global Update)**

- **Methodology & Data Foundation:** Published by Henley & Partners based on proprietary travel intelligence provided by the International Air Transport Association (IATA), analyzing 199 passports across 227 travel destinations.
- **India's Standing:**
  - India ranked **82nd** globally, granting visa-free or visa-on-arrival entry to **58 destinations**.
  - Tied in 82nd position with Senegal and Tajikistan.
- **World Leaders:**
  - **1st Rank (World's Most Powerful Passport): Singapore** (visa-free access to **195 destinations** out of 227).
  - **2nd Rank:** France, Germany, Italy, Japan, and Spain (192 destinations).
  - **3rd Rank:** Austria, Finland, Ireland, Luxembourg, Netherlands, South Korea, Sweden (191 destinations).
- **Weakest Passport: Afghanistan (103rd / bottom)** with visa-free access to only 26 nations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Rank: **82nd** (access to 58 destinations).
- #1 Most Powerful Passport: **Singapore** (195 destinations).
- Lowest Rank: **Afghanistan** (103rd, 26 destinations).

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8. IMPORTANT DAYS & PERSONS IN NEWS

[JUL-041] **July Commemorative Days & Milestones Roster**

- **July 1 — National Doctors' Day:** Commemorates the birth and death anniversary of legendary physician and 2nd Chief Minister of West Bengal, **Dr. Bidhan Chandra Roy** (Bharat Ratna, 1961). Also observed as **Chartered Accountants (CA) Day** (ICAI founded 1 July 1949) and **GST Day** (7th anniversary of GST rollout).
- **July 11 — World Population Day:** Established by the UNDP Governing Council in 1989; 2024 Theme: *"Leave no one behind, count everyone"*.
- **July 12 — NABARD 43rd Foundation Day:** Marks the establishment of NABARD in 1982.
- **July 26 — 25th Kargil Vijay Diwas (Silver Jubilee):** Commemorates the success of **Operation Vijay** in 1999, evicting Pakistani infiltrators from heights in Kargil, Dras, and Batalik sectors of Ladakh.
- **July 28 — World Hepatitis Day:** Theme: *"It's time for action"*; commemorates birthday of Nobel laureate Dr. Baruch Blumberg (discovered Hepatitis B virus).
- **July 29 — International Tiger Day:** Observed globally following the 2010 Saint Petersburg Tiger Summit; India hosts **over 75%** of the world's wild tiger population (3,682 tigers per NTCA 2022 census).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Silver Jubilee: 2024 marked the **25th anniversary** of Kargil Vijay Diwas (Operation Vijay, 1999).
- Tiger Census: India tiger count is **3,682** (75% of global total); Madhya Pradesh is the 'Tiger State' (785 tigers).

[JUL-042] **National Fish Farmers' Day (July 10) & PMMSY Blue Economy Milestones**

- **Historical Significance:** Observed annually on **July 10** commemorating the pioneering scientific breakthrough by **Dr. Hiralal Chaudhuri and Dr. K.H. Alikunhi**, who successfully demonstrated induced breeding (hypophysation) in Indian Major Carps on July 10, 1957 in Angul, Odisha.
- **Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY) Benchmarks:**
  - Flagship umbrella scheme under the Department of Fisheries (Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying) with an investment of **₹20,050 crore** over 5 years.
  - Production Milestone: India is the **2nd largest fish producing country** globally (~8% global share) and the world's leading exporter of farmed shrimp.
  - Target: Scaling national fisheries exports to **₹1 lakh crore** and generating over 55 lakh direct and indirect employment opportunities.
- **Digital Enablers:** Operationalization of the **Matsya Setu** mobile learning app and the National Fisheries Digital Platform (NFDP) to advance formal credit and insurance access to fishers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Observed Date: **July 10** (honors Dr. Hiralal Chaudhuri & Dr. K.H. Alikunhi's 1957 hypophysation breakthrough).
- Global Fish Rank: India is the **2nd largest fish producer** in the world (~8% share).
- Scheme Financial Outlay: PMMSY total allocation is **₹20,050 crore**.

[JUL-043] **National Statistics Day (June 29) & P.C. Mahalanobis Legacy**

- **Commemorative Observance:** Celebrated annually on **June 29** (designated in 2007) honoring the birth anniversary of **Prof. Prasanta Chandra Mahalanobis**, universally recognized as the *"Father of Indian Modern Statistics"*.
- **2024 National Theme:** *"Use of Data for Decision Making"*.
- **Foundational Institutional & Policy Contributions:**
  - Established the **Indian Statistical Institute (ISI)** in Kolkata in 1931.
  - Chief architect of India's **Second Five-Year Plan (1956–1961)**, based on the **Nehru-Mahalanobis Strategy** of rapid industrialization through heavy basic and capital goods industries.
  - Formulated the **Mahalanobis Distance**, a fundamental statistical measure used in multivariate data analysis.

- **National Recognition:** Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) confers the annual **Prof. P.C. Mahalanobis National Award in Official Statistics** to eminent statisticians.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Commemorated Date: **June 29** (Father of Indian Statistics).
- Five-Year Plan Model: **Second Five-Year Plan (1956–61)** was modeled on the Mahalanobis strategy.
- Premier Institution: Founded **Indian Statistical Institute (ISI)** in Kolkata (1931).

10. MISCELLANEOUS — GOVT SCHEMES & STATIC

[JUL-044] **Prudential Guidelines on Project Finance — Construction Phase Debt (RBI Exposure Draft)**

- **Context:** Standard prudential guidelines for financing infrastructure and non-infrastructure project loans during the pre-commissioning phase.
- **Graduated Provisioning Architecture:**
  - **Construction Phase (Under-Construction):** Proposed standard asset provisioning stepped up to **5.0%** (up from current baseline of 0.4%) in a phased manner (2% by FY25, 3.5% by FY26, 5% by FY27).
  - **Operational Phase (Post-DCCO):** Once the project achieves Date of Commencement of Commercial Operations (DCCO), provisioning drops to **2.5%**.
  - **Stabilization Phase:** Drops further to **1.0%** once the project generates sufficient positive free cash flow and repays at least 20% of its long-term debt.
- **Financial Closure Deadline:** Financial closure must be achieved within **1 year** from the date of sanction for infrastructure projects.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Proposed Peak Provisioning: **5.0%** during construction phase (vs. normal 0.4%).
- Operational Step-Down: Drops to **2.5%** upon achieving DCCO, and **1.0%** upon 20% debt repayment.

AUGUST 2026 CONSOLIDATED DOSSIER (FULL MONTH + PIB COMPENDIUM)



Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Full Month Consolidated Dossier (1st–31st Aug, incl. PIB 1st–27th Aug)

Zone: CORE ZONE | Sources: CGB Mentors Compilation (1–11 Aug) + CGB Mentors PDF (12–20 Aug) + CGB Mentors PDF (21–31 Aug) + PIB Compilation (1–10 Aug) + PIB Compilation (11–18 Aug) + PIB Compilation (19–27 Aug) | Framework v3.1

Duplicate check: Cross-checked all source windows.

- Index of Core Industries (ICI) Base Year shifted to 2022-23 and expanded to 9 industries (Iron Ore added) -> integrated into Section 1.
- Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS) officially notified by MeitY -> updated in Section 1 & 2 with TS1/TS2 tiers.
- Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) FY26 full-year record profit (₹10,176 cr) & asset quality -> merged and updated in Section 2.
- PM Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) official 19 Aug 2026 benchmark metrics (59.09 cr accounts, ₹3,16,514 cr deposits) -> merged and updated in Section 1.
- e-Shram Portal completes 5 years with 31.89 cr registrations -> updated in Section 10.
- SEBI's F&O retail-loss reduction stat (₹1,11,788 cr → ₹91,685 cr FY26) appears in both the 12–20 Aug and 21–31 Aug batches → merged into ONE entry.
- SEBI's Cyber Suraksha Portal (17–21 Aug Symposium launch) confirmed operational in the 21–31 Aug batch → merged, marked UPDATE only.
- UNCCD COP17 (Mongolia) appears in the 12–20 Aug and 21–31 Aug clusters, **and** PIB (11–18 Aug) adds India's first-ever Guide to Grasslands & ONEs → all merged into one entry.
- MuleHunter.AI (1–11 Aug) + DoT's Financial Fraud Risk Indicator (21–31 Aug) → merged under one cluster.
- GOBARdhan (Cabinet approval, Section 1) is also the subject of a full PIB backgrounder (1–10 Aug) → merged, PIB detail added.
- MPMS (Cabinet approval, Section 1) also has a full PIB backgrounder (1–10 Aug) with the exact approval date and incentive tiers → merged.
- Tribunal Reforms Bill/NTDG (Section 4) has a full PIB backgrounder (11–18 Aug) on NTC composition/tenure → merged.
- PM Jan Dhan Yojana (Section 3, 12-year milestone) overlaps with PIB's Financial Inclusion backgrounder (RBI FI Index, DBT scale) → merged.

1. ESI, FINANCE & BUSINESS NEWS

[AUG-001] **India's economic size & fiscal snapshot — two data points**

Two separate GDP-adjacent numbers came out this fortnight — don't confuse the "6th-largest" ranking with the FY26 debt/deficit trend.

- **A) India = world's 6th-largest economy:** IMF's April 2026 WEO — nominal GDP **$3.92 trillion** (2025-26); ranking is exchange-rate dependent.
- **B) Debt-to-GDP & fiscal deficit (FY26):** Debt-to-GDP **58.2%** (210 bps above govt's 56.1% target); fiscal deficit declined **9.2% (FY21) → 4.4% (FY26)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse $3.92 trillion (6th-largest, nominal GDP) with 58.2% vs 56.1% debt-to-GDP trap pair.

[AUG-002] **PSB balance-sheet health cluster**

- Gross NPAs of PSBs fell to **₹2,45,634 crore** (31 Mar 2026); GNPA ratio **1.93%**
- Unclaimed deposits with DEA Fund: **₹86,917.08 crore** (30 June 2026) — SBI (₹20,040 cr) > PNB > Canara; ICICI (₹2,278 cr) tops private banks
- Unclaimed-deposit rule: savings/current inoperative **10 years**, or term deposits unclaimed **10 years** from maturity
- Disinvestment + asset-monetisation mop-up: **₹45,306 crore** FY26 (vs RE ₹33,837 cr); FY27 target ₹80,000 cr

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

GNPA ratio 1.93% is a clean standalone stat; 10-year inoperative rule is a recurring definitional MCQ.

[AUG-003] **CGSMFI 2.0 — microfinance credit guarantee revamp**

To fix poor uptake of its ₹20,000 crore microfinance guarantee scheme, govt raised mandatory small/mid-MFI lending share from 5–10% to **15%**.

- CGSMFI = Credit Guarantee Scheme for Microfinance Institutions 2.0, via **NCGTC**
- Max loan sanctionable = 20% of AUM, capped ₹100 cr (small)/₹200 cr (medium)/₹1,000 cr (large)
- MFI size by AUM: Small <₹500 cr | Medium ₹500 cr–₹2,000 cr | Large >₹2,000 cr

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Trap: 15% share vs ₹20,000 cr corpus vs ₹100/200/1,000 cr caps by size.

[AUG-004] **RBI's regulatory consolidation & compliance cluster**

- **A) 628→64 Master Directions:** RBI's Dept. of Supervision merged 628 circulars into 64 Master Directions across **11 categories**.
- **B) Zero PSB locker thefts in FY26:** down from 40 (FY22–25, 12 PSBs); total lockers **1,11,11,077**; CCTV retention ≥180 days; compensation cap = 100× annual locker rent.
- **C) Fake-currency detection:** border-district branches must install note-authentication machines.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 628 circulars → 64 Master Directions, 11 categories.

[AUG-005] **RBI draft/proposed frameworks — consolidated tracker**

- **A) Interest Rates on Loans and Advances Directions, 2026** (draft, eff. **1 April 2027**): rate linked to benchmark + risk-based spread; floating reset ≤ once/3 months; agri loans reset ≤12 months tied to crop season; external benchmark mandatory for floating personal/MSME loans.
- **B) On-tap UCB licences:** large credit coops (≥10 yrs, ≥₹10,000 cr deposits, ≥₹300 cr net worth, CRAR ≥12%, NNPA ≤3%) can convert; Phase 1 = Multi-State Coop Societies Act 2002 entities only; 5% shareholding cap.
- **C) Recovery-agent norms:** eff. **1 Jan 2027**; contact only 8 AM–7 PM; India's first phone-lock-restriction framework — no restriction before 30 days overdue, full restriction after 60 days; device restored within 1 hr of payment or ₹250/hr penalty.
- **D) CVA derivative-risk framework** (proposed eff. **1 April 2027**): simplified approach for banks with non-centrally-cleared derivatives ≤₹10 trillion.
- **E) Leverage ratio buffer for G-SIB branches** (proposed eff. **1 April 2027**): min leverage 4% (D-SIBs)/3.5% (others). Current D-SIBs: SBI (+0.80% CET1), HDFC Bank (+0.40%), ICICI Bank (+0.20%).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse the three 2027 dates: recovery norms (1 Jan 2027) vs CVA & leverage buffer (both 1 April 2027, different rules).

[AUG-006] **Tata Sons designated Upper-Layer NBFC**

- RBI classified Tata Sons as NBFC-UL for 2026-27; 17 NBFCs in Upper Layer
- Enhanced regulation applies **≥5 years** regardless of later eligibility
- June 2026 norms: assets **>₹1 trillion** → upper layer, must list within **3 years**; Tata Sons' standalone assets **>₹2 trillion**
- NBFC layers: Base (<₹1,000 cr) → Middle (≥₹1,000 cr) → Upper (≥₹1 lakh cr) → Top

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Tata Sons + 3-year listing mandate is a near-certain mains question.

[AUG-007] **CRILC, insurance surety bonds & EPF wage ceiling**

- **Credit Risk Monitoring:** RBI's Central Repository of Information on Large Credits (**CRILC**) mandates banks to report all borrower exposures **≥₹5 crore** to track systemic non-performing assets in real time.
- **Surety Bond Innovation:** NeSL and New India Assurance rolled out India's first digital insurance surety bond, eliminating physical bank guarantees in public infrastructure contracts.
- **Social Security Ceiling:** Ministry of Labour proposed raising the mandatory EPF wage threshold from **₹15,000 to ₹25,000 per month** (effective 1 April 2027), expanding pension coverage to millions of formal-sector workers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — EPF ceiling hike is a clean single-fact MCQ.

[AUG-008] **SC directs RBI/IRDAI on mule accounts & fuel-insurance linkage; mule-account detection stack**

- SC directed RBI to prepare SOP for mule accounts; ANPR-based fuel-insurance-verification pilot directed
- **A) MuleHunter.AI** — RBI Innovation Hub's AI tool to flag suspicious/mule accounts, used with I4C
- **B) Financial Fraud Risk Indicator (FRI)** — Dept. of Telecommunications tool assessing fraud risk of mobile numbers; 3 risk categories: Medium, High, Very High
- Cybercrime reporting: **1930 Helpline** + National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

MuleHunter.AI (RBI) vs FRI (DoT) — don't confuse the two agencies behind each tool.

[AUG-009] **DPDPA, RBI & SEBI cybersecurity/compliance stack**

- RBI penalties: **₹54.78 crore** across **353 cases** FY24-25
- **DPDPA, 2023:** penalties up to **₹250 cr** (security failure) + **₹200 cr** (breach-notification failure)
- **RBI IT Governance Master Directions (2023)**; 2025 Authentication Directions mandate **2FA with ≥1 dynamic factor**
- **SEBI CSCRF, 2024** — 22 regulated-entity types, 5-tier model

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse ₹250 cr (DPDPA security failure) vs ₹200 cr (breach notification failure).

[AUG-010] **REIT/Tax legislative cluster — Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill, 2026**

- Amends PSS Act 2007, Income-tax Act 2025, Finance Act 2026
- UPI MDR: candidate for MDR outside negative list (credit cards ~1.5%, debit ≤0.9%, UPI currently free)
- Rough diamond tax break: new Entry 13F — **15-year exemption** for foreign cos trading rough diamonds via SNZs, 1 Oct 2026–31 Mar 2041
- Capital-goods tax exemption for electronics contract manufacturers extended to 31 Mar 2041
- Appropriation Bill 2026 cleared — ₹54,067 crore FY2022-23 expenditure (Article 114)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 15-year SNZ diamond tax break via Entry 13F.

[AUG-011] **Govt scheme & data cluster (1–20 Aug)**

- Ethanol interest subsidy: **₹4,687 crore** approved
- **GOBARdhan scheme:** outlay **₹23,731 crore**, FY27–FY36
- India's GI ecosystem: **>800** registered GI products; Darjeeling Tea = India's first GI product; target **10,000 GI registrations by 2030**
- EPF inoperative rules: ~3 yrs post-retirement/migration/death; EPF no. = 22-digit; UAN = permanent 12-digit
- SEZ exports up **11.8%** to ₹16,36,192 crore
- PPF: only residents can open fresh accounts

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Darjeeling Tea as first GI product + 10,000-by-2030 target.

[AUG-012] **GOBARdhan: Fuelling Clean Energy and Rural Growth — full scheme detail** UPDATE (PIB 1–10 Aug backgrounder, merged with the entry above)

- **Full form:** Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan; approved by Union Cabinet **6 August 2026**; Nodal Ministry **MoPNG**; originally launched **2018** under Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen), Solid & Liquid Waste Management component
- Core concept: converts cattle dung, agri residue, press mud, municipal/kitchen/market organic waste into **Compressed Biogas (CBG)** — chemically equivalent to natural gas — and organic manure
- **Six Growth Engines:** (1) Assured CBG Offtake — CGD entities procure under a notified CBG Obligation trajectory: **3% FY 2026-27 → 4% FY 2027-28 → 5% from FY 2028-29** onwards in CNG (Transport)/PNG (Domestic) segments; (2) Stable Pricing — administered price ₹2,110/MMBTU (~₹105/kg); (3) Capital Assistance — up to ₹2 crore/TPD of installed CBG capacity for greenfield projects; (4) Pipeline Infrastructure — connects CBG plants to trunk pipelines & CGD networks; (5) Credit Guarantee — up to **85%** coverage for eligible MSME-based CBG projects; (6) CBG Ecosystem Challenge Fund — feedstock mapping, aggregation, tech, district planning, manure value addition
- Supporting initiatives: **SATAT** (Sustainable Alternative Towards Affordable Transportation — promotes CBG production/supply to OMCs); **Biomass Aggregation Machinery (BAM) Scheme** — outlay ₹564.75 crore; **Development of Pipeline Infrastructure (DPI) Scheme** — outlay ₹994.5 crore, FY24-25 to FY28-29; **MDA Scheme** — Market Development Assistance for organic manure, ₹1,500/MT; **CFA** — Central Financial Assistance for CBG plants under National Bioenergy Programme
- GOBARdhan Unified Registration Portal — registration required to avail MoPNG benefits/support
- Top-performing states: 1. Uttar Pradesh → 2. Madhya Pradesh → 3. Maharashtra → 4. Gujarat → 5. Telangana; Top banks: 1. SBI → 2. BoB → 3. Union Bank of India → 4. PNB → 5. Indian Bank; Top ULB: Municipal Corporation of Delhi
- 2026-36 expected outcomes: CBG **10×**, fossil-fuel displacement **10 MMT**, forex savings **>₹40,000 cr**, GDP addition **>₹75,000 cr**, **>1.5 lakh jobs**, CO_2 reduction **>40 MT**, organic fertilizer **250 MMT**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Six Growth Engines' CBG Obligation trajectory (3%→4%→5%) is a strong sequencing trap alongside the already-known ₹23,731 cr outlay; don't confuse GOBARdhan's original 2018 launch (under Swachh Bharat) with its 6 Aug 2026 Cabinet-approved revamp.

[AUG-013] **BofA survey: India least-favoured Asian stock market**

- **FII Sentiment Reversal:** In Bank of America's regional fund manager survey, India was ranked the least-favoured equity market across Asia, overtaking Indonesia.
- **Valuation Headwinds:** Global institutional investors registered a **Net Underweight of 32%** on Indian equities, citing stretched price-to-earnings valuations and slowing corporate earnings.
- **Capital Rotation:** Foreign portfolio capital shifted heavily toward semiconductor and hardware manufacturing leaders, with **Taiwan and Japan** emerging as the top preferred destinations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Standalone survey-result MCQ.

[AUG-014] **PSB climate-finance & renewable/EV lending proposals**

- 2% sub-target for climate/transition finance within existing PSL (40% of ANBC)
- Renewable proposal: wind/small-hydro limit → ₹75 cr (from ₹35 cr); solar stays ₹35 cr; overall ₹100 cr/borrower
- EV proposal: 4-wheelers (personal) ₹20 lakh; battery-swap/charging ₹25 lakh; commercial fleets ₹50 crore

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Don't confuse ₹35 cr (current, solar) vs ₹75 cr (proposed, wind/hydro) vs ₹100 cr (overall).

[AUG-015] **India enters blue bond market; FAST-DS voluntary disclosure scheme**

- **Blue Bond Market Debut:** India prepared its inaugural sustainable blue bond issuances totalling **₹1,200 crore** to finance coastal port infrastructure (Sagarmala Finance up to ₹1,000 Cr) and urban wastewater recycling (Vadodara Municipal Corp ₹200 Cr).
- **Voluntary Disclosure Window (FAST-DS):** Central Board of Direct Taxes notified a one-time compliance scheme running from **16 August to 31 December 2026** for settling undisclosed foreign financial assets.
- **Two-Tier Settlement Terms:** Category A (unreported foreign income ≤₹1 Cr) requires a **60% effective tax and penalty payment**, while Category B (tax-paid inherited assets ≤₹5 Cr) requires only a **₹1 lakh flat regularization fee**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's first blue bond issuance; FAST-DS Category A vs B (60% vs flat ₹1 lakh) trap.

[AUG-016] **CBDC food-subsidy rollout & senior-citizen digital initiatives**

- **CBDC Welfare Delivery:** Chandigarh and Dadra & Nagar Haveli became the first Union Territories to pilot Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) of food subsidies using RBI's Digital Rupee (**e-Rupee CBDC**) under PMGKAY.
- **Targeted Welfare Tokens:** Beneficiaries receive programmable digital currency vouchers redeemable strictly at authorized Fair Price Shops, preventing subsidy diversion.
- **Senior Citizen Digital Stack:** Department of Social Justice launched the **SNEHA** guidance portal and two mobile applications—**JEEVAN** (digital life certificate verification) and **SHATAYU** (geriatric telemedicine and legal assistance).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Chandigarh + D&NH as first CBDC-DBT UTs.

[AUG-017] **29 FDI proposals worth ₹4,800 crore under revised FDI framework**

- 29 FDI proposals reported as of 20 Aug 2026, investments **>₹4,800 crore**
- Revised route conditions: Indian citizens must retain majority ownership/control; land-bordering-country investment >10% still needs govt approval; **60-day timeline** for such proposals on specified goods (capital goods, electronic capital goods, polysilicon, ingot wafers for solar cells)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

60-day timeline for land-bordering-country FDI proposals on specified goods is a clean process fact.

[AUG-018] **India's Sugar Industry & Duty-Free Quota Cluster** UPDATE *(PIB 25–26 Aug)*

- **A) Sugarcane & Sugar Production:** India is world's 2nd-largest sugarcane producer (supports ~5 crore farmers, ~5 lakh mill workers). Sugarcane output reached **500 MMT** in 2025–26 (up ~43.5%, 3rd Advance Estimate) across 58.87 lakh ha. Top producing states: **Uttar Pradesh & Maharashtra**.
- **B) Consumption, Exports & FRP:** Annual sugar production 300–340 lakh MT; domestic consumption 280–290 lakh MT; exports 8 lakh MT (Sri Lanka, West Asia, East Africa). Fair and Remunerative Price (**FRP**) fixed at **₹365/quintal** for sugar season 2026–27 (at 10.25% basic recovery rate).
- **C) Ethanol Feedstock Shift:** Sugar diverted to ethanol dropped to **~9%** in 2025–26, as **~75% of ethanol feedstock transitioned to grains (especially maize)**.
- **D) Supply Controls & Imports:** 400-tonne stock limit for sugar dealers (1 Aug–30 Nov 2026); bulk consumers barred from holding stocks exceeding **15 days of consumption** from 1 Sept 2026; **10 lakh MT (LMT) duty-free raw sugar import** permitted under TRQ via DGFT (valid till 31 Oct 2026). Brazil = world's largest sugar producer (24% share, 43.8 MT); India 2nd (16%, 30 MT).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

FRP ₹365/qtl at 10.25% recovery; 75% ethanol feedstock now from grains/maize; 15-day bulk consumer holding limit.

[AUG-019] **Mobile Phone Manufacturing Scheme (MPMS) — Officially Notified Guidelines** UPDATE *(PIB 21–22 Aug)*

- **Notification & Nodal Ministry:** Notified by Ministry of Electronics & IT (**MeitY**); Outlay **₹62,500 crore**; Tenure 5 years (**FY 2026–27 to FY 2030–31**); succeeds PLI-LSEM (which ended 31 March 2026).
- **Target Segments & Two-Tier Eligibility:**
  - **Target Segment 1 (TS1) — General Mobile Phone Manufacturing (Global & Domestic EMS):**
    - Incentive: **2.25%–5.0%** on incremental sales.
    - Eligibility: Minimum turnover of **₹10,000 crore** in FY 2025–26; existing brands must achieve an annual incremental sales threshold of **₹5,000 crore** over FY26 base; new entrants need ₹10,000 cr initial annual sales + ₹5,000 cr incremental sales.
  - **Target Segment 2 (TS2) — Indian-Owned Mobile Phone Brands:**
    - Incentive: Flat **5% base incentive** + additional **3% for Indian Design & R&D** (Total up to **8%**).
    - Eligibility: Minimum turnover of **₹1,000 crore** in FY 2025–26; >51% Indian citizen shareholding and management control; registered IP/trademarks in India; in-house domestic R&D facilities; eligible for a **1-year gestation period**.
  - **Component Localisation Bonus (Both TS1 & TS2):** Additional **up to 1.5%** for domestic sourcing of key components/sub-assemblies, provided localisation covers at least **25%** of total mobile phone units produced in the FY.

- **Strategic Targets:** Cumulative mobile output ~**₹39 lakh crore**; ~60,000 direct jobs; **99.2%** of mobile phones used in India are Made in India (India is world's 2nd-largest producer by volume); smartphones became India's **largest exported product category in 2025**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Trap: TS1 eligibility turnover (₹10,000 cr) vs TS2 Indian-brand turnover (₹1,000 cr); TS2 design/R&D bonus is 3%; component localisation bonus is 1.5% (tied to 25% minimum unit localization).

[AUG-020] **National Campaign on Entrepreneurship-II & trade-policy/postal-digitisation cluster**

- **A) National Campaign on Entrepreneurship-II** — Ministry of Rural Development, under DAY-NRLM; 22 Aug–21 Nov 2026 (3 months); targets 6 crore Lakhpati Didis; CRP-EPs/BDSPs recognised as 'Udyam Sakhis'.
- **B) DGFT relaxes One Star Export House norms:** qualify via export performance in any 2 of preceding 3 FYs (was all 3); gems & jewellery excluded (separate 2-yr rule).
- **C) FTP amended for rupee invoicing:** exports outside ACU can now be invoiced in ₹ or any foreign currency (earlier: freely-convertible foreign currency only); ACU (est. 1974, 9 members incl. India, Pakistan, Iran, Bangladesh, Bhutan, Maldives, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka) exports still ACU-currency-denominated.
- **D) Dak Sewa + Dak MITRA apps revamped** — Jyotiraditya Scindia; 23 Indian languages; built by CEPT under Advanced Postal Tech (APT) platform.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

One Star Export House's "any 2 of 3 years" relaxation is a clean rule-change MCQ.

[AUG-021] **UPI completes 10 years**

A decade after launch, UPI now carries nearly half the world's real-time payment volume.

- Launched **25 August 2016** by NPCI, under RBI oversight
- Transactions: **1.78 crore (2016-17) → 24,162+ crore (2025-26)**; banks live: 44 → 703
- Global share: **~49%** of global real-time payment transaction volume (2025, per IMF); daily transactions >66 crore
- Operational in **11 countries:** UAE, France, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Singapore, Mauritius, Qatar, Cambodia, Greece, Maldives

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — UPI's 10-year milestone (25 Aug 2016) + ~49% global real-time-payment share (IMF) is a near-certain mains question.

[AUG-022] **PM Jan Dhan Yojana marks 12 years — Official Benchmark Data & Sovereign Ratings** UPDATE *(PIB 27 Aug)*

- **A) PMJDY Official 12-Year Benchmark (as of 19 Aug 2026):**
  - Launched **28 August 2014**; shifted from "every household" to "every unbanked adult" in 2018.
  - **Total Bank Accounts: 59.09 crore** (4× growth from 14.72 cr in 2015).
  - **Women Beneficiaries: 32.92 crore (55.7% of total)**.
  - **Rural / Semi-Urban Share: 45.95 crore accounts (78%)**; Urban/metro accounts: 13.14 crore (22%).
  - **Total Deposits: ₹3,16,514 crore**.
  - **RuPay Debit Cards: 41.29 crore issued**.
  - **Average Deposit per Account: ₹5,356** (up 3.4× from ~₹1,565 in 2015).
  - **Key Features:** BSBDA zero-balance norms; Overdraft up to **₹10,000** (after 6 months satisfactory operation); RuPay accidental cover **₹2 lakh** (for accounts opened post-August 2018; ₹1 lakh earlier). Guinness World Record: 1.80 crore accounts in a single week (Jan 2015).

- **B) S&P affirms India 'BBB/A-2'** sovereign rating, stable outlook (dynamic economy, policy stability, high infra investment). *(cross-ref: Fitch also affirmed 'BBB-' earlier — different agency, different notch — don't confuse.)*

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — PMJDY's 59.09-crore accounts, ₹3,16,514 crore deposits, 55.7% women, and ₹10,000 overdraft limit are classic milestone MCQs.

[AUG-023] **Financial Inclusion in India — RBI FI Index, Global Findex, DBT scale** UPDATE (PIB 11–18 Aug backgrounder, merged with the PMJDY entry above)

- **RBI Financial Inclusion (FI) Index** rose to **70.0 (March 2026)** from 43.4 (March 2017); **World Bank Global Findex 2025: 89%** of Indian adults have an account; Banking Access — **99.92%** of villages have a banking outlet within 5 km; Business Correspondents **17.36 lakh+**
- **DBT** (as of 10 Aug 2026): Total Direct Benefit Transfer **₹52.89 lakh crore**, across **320 schemes**, **56 ministries** — JAM Trinity (Jan Dhan + Aadhaar + Mobile) reduces leakages/intermediaries
- Social Security snapshot: **PMJJBY** 27.78 cr enrolments (₹2 lakh cover, ₹436/yr premium, 18-50 yrs); **PMSBY** 58.66 cr enrolments (₹2 lakh/₹1 lakh cover, ₹20/yr premium, 18-70 yrs); **APY** 9.29 cr subscribers (₹1,000-5,000/month after 60); **PM MUDRA** 57.79 cr loans (collateral-free up to ₹20 lakh); **Jan Samarth** — 54.10 lakh applications, 16 registered credit schemes, 8 loan categories, 300+ lenders
- **UPI** (as of July 2026): transaction volume **2,365 crore**, **741 banks** live

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — FI Index's 43.4→70.0 rise (2017→2026) is a strong trend MCQ that cross-references PMJDY's 12-year milestone above; don't confuse the FI Index (0-100 composite) with Global Findex's 89% account-ownership figure.

[AUG-024] **GeM completes 10 years** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- Government e-Marketplace, launched **9 August 2016**; celebrated 10th Foundation Day, Ministry of Commerce & Industry; new initiatives — **'My Stamp'**, dedicated five-digit helpdesk short code **"14550"**
- Scale: Sellers **25 lakh+**; Buyer organisations **1.37 lakh+**; Cumulative procurement **₹20 lakh crore+**; Orders 3.78 crore+; MSEs 12.28 lakh (45.6% of GMV, ₹9 lakh cr+ orders); Women-led MSEs 2.24 lakh+ (₹1 lakh cr+ orders, 50 lakh+ orders); Startups 42,242 (₹65,633 cr+ orders)
- Defence procurement (Dept. of Military Affairs) crossed **₹1.35 lakh crore** cumulative GMV (6 Aug 2026) = **14.93%** of GeM's cumulative GMV
- Inclusion initiatives: SWAYATT, Womaniya, SARAS Collection, Startup Runway 2.0; GeM Suvidha Kendras — 50 pilot centres launched June 2026 with CSC-SPV
- 5 priorities for next decade: Last-mile access, AI (price intelligence/marketplace integrity), Integration (States/PSUs/panchayats/cooperatives), Credit & Sustainability (GeM Sahay/TReDS/green procurement), University Outreach

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — GeM's 10-year, ₹20 lakh crore cumulative-procurement milestone; defence share (14.93% of GMV) is a sharp standalone stat.

[AUG-025] **National Investment Policy for Urea-2026 (NIPU-2026)** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- CCEA approved proposal of Dept. of Fertilizers; applies to new urea manufacturing units; supersedes NIP-2012 (expired Oct 2019 — under which 6 new urea units came up: 4 via PSU JVCs, 2 private)
- Key changes over NIP-2012: cost structure — fixed/variable costs separated; Return on Equity (RoE) band **12%–16%**; Foreign Exchange risk — fixed cost converted to INR after **4 years** based on prevailing exchange rate

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

NIPU-2026's 12–16% RoE band vs NIP-2012 predecessor is a clean scheme-comparison MCQ.

[AUG-026] **KCC-Modified Interest Subvention Scheme (KCC-MISS) — impact assessment** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- Third-party assessment by **ISEC, Bengaluru:** every ₹1 invested under KCC-MISS → **₹2.30 net value addition** in agriculture & allied sector
- MISS outlay: **₹1.87 lakh crore** since inception till 2024-25
- Government measures to strengthen KCC: collateral-free KCC loan limit raised **₹1.6 lakh → ₹2 lakh**, effective **1 January 2025**; supporting portals — Kisan Rin Portal, Jan Samarth Portal, e-KCC, KRISHIKA

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹1 → ₹2.30 value-addition ratio is a distinctive, easily-tested standalone figure.

[AUG-027] **Cabinet approves Semicon 2.0** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

A ₹1.27 lakh crore follow-on to India's first semiconductor mission, built around six pillars rather than fabs alone.

- Approved by Union Cabinet, **July 2026**; Outlay **₹1,27,500 crore**
- **Six Pillars:** (1) Design — chip designs/IPs/systems, 105 startups already developing chips; (2) Machines & Materials — semiconductor machinery, materials, chemicals & gases; (3) Fabs — more silicon, compound-semiconductor, discrete-component & display fabs; (4) ATMP/OSAT — advanced assembly, testing, marking, packaging; (5) R&D — advanced semiconductor nodes & technologies; (6) Talent — chip-design/clean-room/fab-related skill development

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Semicon 2.0's ₹1,27,500 cr outlay and Six Pillars is a near-certain scheme-identification MCQ; don't confuse with the original Semicon India (2021) programme.

[AUG-028] **Container Manufacturing Assistance Scheme (CMAS) & Bharat Container Shipping Line** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

India imports nearly 2 million empty containers a year — CMAS aims to build a domestic manufacturing base roughly 10× current capacity.

- CMAS announced in Union Budget 2026-27; Proposed outlay **₹10,000 crore over 5 years**; UNCTAD: ~80% of global merchandise trade (by volume) is transported by sea, containerised cargo ~two-thirds of trade value
- Target: up to **7.5 lakh TEUs/year** domestic manufacturing capacity (~10× existing capacity); support — greenfield, brownfield, operational, testing infra, skilling
- Employment/market opportunity: ~3,000 direct + 50,000+ indirect jobs; **₹1.07 lakh crore** project market opportunity
- **Bharat Container Shipping Line (BCSL)** — MoU signed **February 2026** (Shipping Corporation of India, CONCOR, Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority, V.O. Chidambaranar Port Authority, Sagarmala Finance Corporation Ltd); proposed investment **~₹99,149 crore**, fleet development of **51 container vessels**, incl. domestic container procurement
- Supporting logistics initiatives: PM Gati Shakti, National Logistics Policy, Sagarmala Programme, ₹70,000 crore Shipbuilding Financial Assistance Package
- First India-manufactured EXIM shipping container rolled out **July 2026** for A.P. Moller–Maersk, unveiled at Maersk–CONCOR Inland Container Depot, Dadri, UP

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — CMAS's 7.5-lakh-TEU/10× target vs BCSL's 51-vessel/₹99,149 cr investment is a strong dual-scheme trap.

[AUG-029] **Ship Recycling in India — world's leading nation (2025)** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- Global share **30.1% (2024) → 35.4% (2025)**; recycling volume **1.86 → 2.99 million GT** (~60% growth); achieved Maritime India Vision (MIV) 2030 target **5 years ahead of schedule**
- **Alang-Sosiya Ship Recycling Cluster (Gujarat)** — world's largest ship-recycling hub, ~98% of India's ship-recycling activity; India aims to nearly double capacity to ~9 million LDT
- **Hong Kong International Convention (HKC)** for Safe & Environmentally Sound Recycling of Ships — in force **26 June 2025**; India aligned domestic framework; ₹53.5 crore financial assistance for yard modernisation
- **EU Green Listing:** Shree Ram Vessel Scrap and Y.S. Investments included in the draft 16th European List of Ship Recycling Facilities
- **Ship-breaking Credit Note Scheme** (under Ship Building Financial Assistance Scheme (SBFA) 2.0): Credit Note = **40%** of recycled ship's scrap value; usable for payment of up to **5%** of the value of a new vessel built at an Indian shipyard

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's 35.4% global ship-recycling share and 5-years-ahead-of-MIV-2030-schedule achievement is a near-certain mains fact.

[AUG-030] **Logistics Data Bank (LDB) tracks 10 crore EXIM containers** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- Digital logistics platform providing near-real-time, end-to-end EXIM container visibility via RFID-based technology, IoT, Big Data, cloud tech; tracks **100%** of India's EXIM containers
- Milestones: launched 2016 → pan-India expansion 2017 → 100% coverage (Manufacturing SEZs + CFSs) 2024
- **LDB 2.0** (launched September 2025 by Piyush Goyal): enabled high-seas tracking of India's export containers + multimodal shipment visibility; contribution recognised by World Bank's Logistics Performance Index (LPI)
- Receives **over 1.5 crore container searches/month** on average; **10 crore containers tracked** cumulatively

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

LDB's 10-crore-container milestone and 100% EXIM coverage since 2024 is a clean standalone fact.

[AUG-031] **WPI/OPPI/IPPI — new price-index series** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

India is phasing out WPI over the next five years in favour of a Producer Price Index — don't confuse the transition period with the headline inflation number.

- All India WPI inflation, July 2026: **9.78%** YoY (vs 9.87% June 2026); index for All Commodities: 110.0 (vs 110.2 June)
- New indices introduced: Revised WPI, **Output Producer Price Index (OPPI)**, Trial **Input Producer Price Index (IPPI)**; released by Office of Economic Adviser (OEA), DPIIT
- **Why shift from WPI to PPI?** WPI will continue for **5 years** alongside PPI and will be discontinued thereafter — based on global best practices and IMF recommendations
- New WPI series: Base Year **2022–23**; Number of items **957** (up from 697); new energy sources (Solar, Wind, Nuclear Electricity) included; Crude Petroleum & Natural Gas reclassified from Primary Articles to Fuel & Power; weight calculation via **Gross Value of Output (GVO)** replaces Net Traded Value; Missing-price method — Targeted Mean Imputation replaces Carry Forward
- Release schedule: WPI, OPPI and Trial IPPI released on the **14th of the following month**
- WPI weights: Primary Articles 22.75%, Fuel & Power 14.11%, **Manufactured Products 63.12%**; WPI Food Index (24.99%) = Food Articles (Primary) + Manufacture of Food Products (Manufactured)
- OPPI weights: Agriculture/Forestry/Fishing 22.16%, Mining & Quarrying 3.42%, Manufactured Products 69.94%, Electricity 4.49%

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — WPI→PPI five-year transition + new base year 2022-23 (957 items, up from 697) is a strong methodology MCQ.

[AUG-032] **Trade data — cumulative exports/imports, April-July FY2026-27** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- Cumulative exports (merchandise + services): **US$316.42 billion** (vs $279.63 bn April-July 2025-26, +13.16% growth)
- Merchandise Exports $173.78 bn; Merchandise Imports $292.38 bn; Services Exports $142.64 bn; Services Imports $73.47 bn; Total Imports $365.85 bn; **Overall Trade Balance –$49.43 billion**
- Top 5 export-growth destinations: 1. Tanzania Rep. (+131.20%), 2. Sri Lanka DSR (+111.76%), 3. Singapore (+97.11%), 4. South Africa (+69.75%), 5. China (+35.97%)
- Top 5 import-growth sources: 1. Oman (+200.68%), 2. Brazil (+166.84%), 3. Russia (+59.65%), 4. China (+29.68%), 5. USA (+22.42%)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Tanzania topping export-growth destinations (+131.2%) is a distinctive, easily-tested "top of list" fact.

[AUG-033] **CPI (base 2024=100) & revised Manufacturing GVA series** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- Year-on-year CPI inflation (base 2024), July 2026 over July 2025: **4.45%** (Provisional); Rural 4.84%, Urban 3.96%
- CPI (Combined): Base Year 2024=100; published by MoSPI/NSO; calculated across **12 divisions**; weighted items increased to **358** (from 299) — Goods 308 (from 259), Services 50 (from 40); top-weighted division: **Food and beverages 36.75%**, followed by Housing/water/electricity/gas/fuels 17.67%, Transport 8.80%
- Revised National Accounts Series: new base year **2022–23** (old: 2011-12), released **February 2026**; CAGR of Manufacturing GVA at constant prices, 2022-23 to 2025-26 = **10.88%**; Manufacturing's share in total GVA increased to **14.8%** in 2025-26

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse CPI's new base year (2024) with the National Accounts series' new base year (2022-23) — both revised in the same window, different bases.

[AUG-034] **Index of Core Industries (ICI) — New Series (Base Year 2022–23) & 9 Core Industries** *(PIB 20 Aug)*

The benchmark Index of Core Industries has expanded from 8 to 9 sectors, adopting the 2022–23 base year and introducing Iron Ore into the core basket.

- **Growth Snapshot:** ICI grew **5.4%** in July 2026 (Provisional) YoY, compared to **6.0%** in June 2026 (Final Index).
- **Released by:** Office of Economic Adviser (OEA), Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Ministry of Commerce & Industry. Release schedule: 20th of the following month (or next working day).
- **Structural Overhaul:**
  - **Base Year:** Shifted from **2011–12 → 2022–23**.
  - **Basket Expansion:** Increased from **8 to 9 industries** with the inclusion of **Iron Ore**.
  - **Weightage Distribution (Descending Order):**
    1. **Electricity: 30.932%** (Heaviest component)
    2. **Refinery Products: 22.572%**
    3. **Steel: 17.584%**
    4. **Crude Oil: 7.430%**
    5. **Coal: 5.596%**
    6. **Iron Ore: 4.905%** *(Newly added 9th industry)*
    7. **Cement: 4.410%**
    8. **Natural Gas: 3.841%**

9. **Fertilizers: 2.731%** (Smallest component)

- **Key Methodological Changes:**
  - **Steel:** Measured using **Gross Production** instead of Net Production, harmonizing with the Index of Industrial Production (IIP).
  - **Coal:** Only **Raw Coal** is retained; Coal Middling and Washed Coal excluded to avoid double counting.
  - **Linking Factor:** Overall linking factor between old (2011–12) and new (2022–23) series = **1.47**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse the new 9th core industry (**Iron Ore**, 4.905%) with existing minerals; memorize the top 3 weights: Electricity (30.932%) > Refinery (22.572%) > Steel (17.584%); linking factor is **1.47**.

[AUG-035] **Quarterly Bulletin of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises (QBUSE) & Steel Export Profile** *(PIB 21–22 & 25–26 Aug)*

- **A) QBUSE (April–June 2026):** High-frequency quarterly survey by NSO (MoSPI) covering unincorporated non-agricultural enterprises (ASUSE framework).
  - **Scale: 8.67 crore establishments** (+9.20% YoY, 98.88% proprietary/partnership) employing **13.70 crore workers** (+6.55% YoY, driven by Other Services >21%).
  - **Composition:** Working owners 62.38%; hired workers 22.77%; urban employment grew >12% YoY vs rural 0.70%; women accounted for >30% employment.
  - **Formalisation & Digital Adoption:** 42.50% registered (+7 percentage points); ~82% use internet for business; **~80% adopted cashless transactions** (UPI/cards/net banking).
- **B) Steel Sector Production & Export Profile (Apr–Jul 2026):**
  - Top export destinations for finished steel: **Vietnam (15.4%)**, UAE, and Belgium.
  - Top producing state: **Odisha** accounted for **19.6%** of national crude steel output in Apr–Jul 2026.
- **C) Concept Paper on Monetary Asset Accounts of Marine Fish Resources:** MoSPI released framework based on **UN-SEEA Central Framework** and OECD (2025) guide to integrate biological fish biomass with national balance sheets.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

QBUSE's 8.67 crore units / 80% cashless payment adoption; Vietnam as India's #1 steel export destination (15.4%).

[AUG-036] **Maritime Development Fund** *(PIB — Schemes in News)*

- **Shipbuilding Renaissance:** Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways approved the **₹25,000 crore** Maritime Development Fund to build domestic vessel construction capacity and reduce reliance on foreign shipping lines.
- **Equity Financing Pillar (₹20,000 Cr):** Provides long-term patient equity and debt for shipyard expansion and port modernization, with Union Government holding up to **49% equity**.
- **Interest Subvention Pillar (₹5,000 Cr):** Subsidizes commercial borrowing interest rates for domestic shipbuilders to make Indian-manufactured cargo vessels globally price-competitive.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹20,000 cr (Investment Fund, 49% equity) vs ₹5,000 cr (Interest Fund) split within the ₹25,000 cr corpus is a clean trap.

[AUG-037] **India's Coconut Sector** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- Supports ~30 million people incl. ~10 million farmers; known as "Kalpavriksha"; India **1st in production** (31.24% of global production), **3rd in cultivation area** (17.90% of global area)

- Leading states: Kerala – area; Tamil Nadu – production; Andhra Pradesh – productivity (followed by West Bengal, Tamil Nadu)
- Exports 2025-26: **₹7,038.35 crore** (US$794.70 mn), +62% over 2024-25; major products — activated carbon (dominates export volumes), coconut oil, fresh/frozen/grated coconut, copra, desiccated coconut; top markets — USA, UAE, Sri Lanka, Germany, Russia
- **Coconut Development Board:** established 12 Jan 1981, HQ Kochi, works across 22 States/UTs
- **MSP for Copra, 2026 season:** Milling copra ₹12,027/qtl, Ball copra ₹12,500/qtl (up ₹445 and ₹400 respectively over 2025)
- Support schemes: DSPFs (₹30 lakh for new farms first 2 years; up to ₹1 lakh/ha/yr maintenance from year 3 for 15-20 years); Area Expansion (₹56,000/ha, 2 instalments, max 2 ha/min 0.08 ha per beneficiary); PICCS (100% subsidy, ₹42,000/ha, max 2 ha); Replanting & Rejuvenation (up to ₹54,000/ha over 2 years)
- **Coconut Promotion Scheme** — announced Union Budget 2026-27, part of a broader **₹350 crore** allocation for high-value agriculture (with cashew, cocoa); envisions India as a global leader in coconut/coir exports by **2030**; Cocomitra (6-10 member trained-climber units); Kera Kaushal Kendra (15-member handicraft groups, ₹2.67 lakh assistance from 2026-27)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's 1st-in-production/3rd-in-area coconut ranking is a recurring trap; MSP hike figures (₹445/₹400) are a clean standalone.

[AUG-038] **Bharat Taxi** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

India's first cooperative-owned ride-hailing platform runs zero-commission — the driver, not a platform company, keeps the fare.

- India's first cooperative-led ride-hailing platform; established **6 June 2025**; registered under Multi-State Cooperative Societies Act, 2002; Ministry of Cooperation
- Founded with support of **8 national-level cooperative institutions:** NCDC, IFFCO, NABARD, KRIBHCO, Amul (GCMMF), NAFED, NDDB, NCEL; vision **"Sahkar se Samriddhi"**; nationwide expansion targeted by **2029**
- **Zero-commission, surge-free pricing model** — Sarathis (drivers) retain full fare earnings: 20% of cooperative earnings credited as Sarathis' capital, 80% distributed by kilometres travelled; airport prepaid booths levy a 7% service charge to cover operational expenses
- Ownership: "Saarthi Hi Maalik" — Sarathis become member-owners via cooperative shareholding; share value **₹100/share**; a Sarathi can become a partner by purchasing shares worth **₹500**
- Social security: Personal Accident Insurance **₹5 lakh**, via IFFCO Tokio at nominal rates

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Bharat Taxi as India's first cooperative-led ride-hailing platform (8 founding institutions, zero-commission model) is a near-certain mains fact.

[AUG-039] **Incentive Scheme for Promotion of Domestic PNG Connections** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- Effective **1 September 2026**; targets City Gas Distribution (CGD) companies; objective — accelerate active Domestic PNG connections, promote clean cooking fuel
- Incentive: additional **200 SCM of domestically produced APM gas** for every incremental billed Domestic PNG connection above the threshold level of the respective Geographical Area (GA); implemented in **2 tranches over 6 months**; additional APM gas replaces costlier LNG currently procured for the CNG (Transport) segment
- Expected to reduce D-PNG connection payback period from **~10 years to ~3 years**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

10-year-to-3-year payback compression is a clean standalone stat.

Skipped (low yield, routine product launches): Wizz Voyager multi-currency travel card (Wizzmoni + Oman Air); IDFC FIRST-IIM Calcutta 'IGNITE' ₹2 cr startup incubation; Razorpay multi-currency EEFC facility; VinFast-Federal Bank inventory-financing MoU; Jio Financial's "Personal CFO" AI feature; Bajaj General's 'My Family Complete' pet-inclusive health cover; Karnataka Bank's Capital Gains Account Scheme; DigiLocker–AAERI 'AAERI Verify' partnership (niche foreign-student-credential use case); SAMRIDH programme completion (routine startup-accelerator wrap-up, already concluded 31 Jan 2026).

[AUG-040] **RBI Financial Stability Report (FSR): GNPA at 12-Year Low of 2.8%**

- **Asset Quality Peak:** Scheduled Commercial Banks' (SCBs) Gross Non-Performing Assets (GNPA) ratio declined to a **12-year low of 2.8%** in March 2026, while Net NPA (NNPA) fell to **0.6%**.
- **Capital Adequacy Strength:** Capital to Risk-Weighted Assets Ratio (CRAR) of SCBs remained robust at **16.8%**, with Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) ratio at **13.9%**.
- **Profitability Metrics:** Return on Assets (RoA) stood at **1.3%** and Return on Equity (RoE) reached **13.8%**, driven by resilient net interest margins and lower provisioning.
- **Macro-Stress Projections:** Under baseline macroeconomic scenarios, SCBs' aggregate GNPA ratio is projected to improve further to **2.5% by March 2027**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Exact Ratios: GNPA = 2.8% (12-year low); NNPA = 0.6%; CRAR = 16.8%; CET1 = 13.9%.
- Baseline Stress Test: Projected to drop to 2.5% by March 2027.

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2. REGULATORY BODIES NEWS

[AUG-041] **SEBI Reforms Cluster — Market Structure & Investor Access (1–11 Aug)**

- **A) Closing Auction Session (CAS)** for F&O-eligible stocks, eff. **3 Aug 2026:** regular trading till 3:15 PM → CAS Order Entry I/II (3:15-3:30) → matching 3:30-3:35.
- **B) GARUDA mechanism** — AIFs launch regular schemes **10 working days** after filing Placement Memorandum.
- **C) Unlisted company share sales:** ≤**200 buyers**/year via private deal ≠ public issue.
- **D–F)** DRs for REITs/InvITs, third-party InvIT investment, ISIN limit for private debt (14→17) — all proposed.
- **G)** SLB revamp, Setu portal, corporate bond tokenisation pilot.
- **H)** Risk-based inspections from FY27.
- **I)** ESG anti-"purpose-washing" rules; BRSR mandatory for top 1,000 listed cos; 19 ERPs registered.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — CAS timeline (3:15→3:35 PM); 200-buyer threshold; 14→17 ISIN change.

[AUG-042] **SEBI municipal-debt, FPI-commodity & vaulting reforms (12–20 Aug)**

- **A)** Municipal debt disclosure timelines relaxed (45→60 days half-yearly; 60→90 days annual); face value ₹1 lakh or ₹10,000.
- **B)** Wider FPI participation proposed in non-agri commodity derivatives (currently cash-settled only).
- **C)** Vaulting norms widened — Vault Managers Regulations to cover all bullion-backed SEBI products.
- **D)** F&O retail losses: aggregate net loss **₹91,685 crore FY26** (down from FY25's **₹1.12 lakh crore / ₹1,11,788 cr** figure — ~18% YoY decline); unique individual investors fell to 78.60 lakh; new entrants down ~40%. *(Merged — same underlying SEBI study appeared across both fortnights.)*
- **E)** Stress-testing Z-score cut 10→5 for commodity derivatives.
- **F)** Colour-coded "Credit Risk-o-Meter" proposed — 6 levels: Irish Green (lowest) → Chartreuse → Neon Yellow → Caramel → Dark Orange → Red (highest).

- **G)** Accredited Investor framework widened — new asset thresholds (individuals ≥₹5 cr, corporates ≥₹20 cr); validity 3 years.
- **H)** Fully digital KYC proposed for NRIs/OCIs/foreign nationals.
- **I)** Cybersecurity portals launched: **Incident Reporting Portal** (FIRE-format) + **Cyber Suraksha Portal** (centralised cyber-info hub for market participants), at SEBI's Cyber Defence Symposium, Mumbai, 17–21 Aug 2026. *(Confirmed operational in 21–31 Aug batch too.)*
- **J)** MF registration simplified — single Form A replacing Form A+C+D.
- **K)** Settlement framework overhaul — fast-track route for cases ≤₹10 lakh.
- **L)** OBPPs allowed to offer GIFT-IFSC-regulated bonds incl. Sec 54EC bonds.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — F&O retail-loss reduction (₹1,11,788 cr/₹1.12 lakh cr → ₹91,685 cr) is a strong reform-impact MCQ; Credit Risk-o-Meter's 6 colour levels is a distinctive trap.

[AUG-043] **PSL Second Amendment Directions & polymer-note pilot**

- US Dollar-Rupee swap facility for fresh FCNR(B) deposits (tenor 3-5 yrs, window 8 June–30 Sept 2026); temporary CRR/SLR relief on FCNR(B) and NRE deposits (≥3-yr tenor, window 19 June–30 Sept 2026)
- RBI approved **1 billion pieces each** of ₹10 & ₹20 polymer banknotes for field trials, under **Section 25 of RBI Act, 1934**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Polymer note pilot denominations (₹10, ₹20); don't confuse FCNR(B) (8 June start) vs NRE (19 June start) windows — both end 30 Sept 2026.

[AUG-044] **SEBI investor-access & compliance-relief cluster (21–31 Aug)**

- **A) Digitally-signed PoA for FPIs** — removes notarisation/apostillisation/consularisation requirement; Common Application Form (CAF) for FPI registration/PAN/bank/demat now accepts Indian digital signatures and scanned-copy registration.
- **B) IFSCA-regulated entities get KRA access** for KYC — under Reg 16A(1) of KYC Registration Agency Regulations, 2011; must still follow SEBI data-security rules for FPI/DDP/EFI clients.
- **C) Fixed Income Channel Partners (FICPs) proposed** — network to deepen retail corporate-bond access in smaller cities; individual eligibility: Indian citizen, 18+, Class 12 pass + NISM fixed-income cert; enlist with exchange; 21-day application timeline; validity 3 years, renewable.
- **D) Stricter ad norms proposed for online bond platforms** — mandatory disclosure of issuer/tenor/rating/YTM/credit-risk-o-meter; restricts "fixed returns"/"predictable returns"/"passive income" claims.
- **E) Fractional shares** — SEBI asked MCA to recognise fractional-share issuance/holding under proposed Companies Amendment Bill (Canada, Japan, USA already allow this).
- **F) IT Resilience Index (ITRI)** proposed for MIIs (exchanges/depositories/clearing corps) — **9 parameters**; Availability & Security weighted highest (20% each); others 10%/5%. First computation covers half-year ended **31 March 2027**; full operationalisation deadline **28 Feb 2027**.
- **G) Merchant-banker exemption mulled** for small-ticket debt (face value ₹10,000) issued via private placement — reduces compliance cost.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ITRI's 9 parameters with 20%/10%/5% weightage split is a strong new-framework MCQ; FICP's "Class 12 pass + NISM cert" eligibility is a clean standalone fact.

[AUG-045] **RBI data releases — House Price Index, LRS remittances, NRI deposits (21–31 Aug)**

- **A) House Price Index:** All-India HPI **117.5** in Q1 FY27; annual growth slowed to **3.6%** (from 4.5% prior quarter); base year 2022-23; covers 18 major cities.
- **B) LRS outward remittances:** surged **19.9% YoY** to **$2.5 billion** (Apr-Jun FY27); current annual LRS limit $250,000 (introduced 2004, initial limit $25,000).
- **C) NRI deposit inflows fell 23.24%** to **$2.78 billion** (Apr-Jun FY27, from $3.61 bn); outstanding NRI deposits $168.51 bn (June 2026). Three schemes: FCNR(B) (foreign-currency, no INR risk), NRE (rupee, tax-exempt, freely repatriable), NRO (rupee, taxable, income earned in India).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Don't confuse FCNR(B)/NRE/NRO tax-and-repatriation treatment — a recurring definitional trap.

[AUG-046] **NPS charges revised & SEBI bond-reach reforms**

- **Regulatory Fee Restructuring:** PFRDA revised the annual administrative fee structure for the National Pension System (**NPS**), effective **1 October 2026**.
- **AUM Fee Slab:** Points of Presence (PoPs) will levy an annualized service charge capped at **0.20% of Assets Under Management (AUM)**, deducted seamlessly through Net Asset Value (NAV).
- **Subscriber Protection:** Dormant pension folios with zero contributions over **4 consecutive quarters** are fully exempt from fee deductions to preserve accumulated worker savings.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

NPS annual charge (0.20% of AUM) eff. 1 Oct 2026 — standalone fact.

[AUG-047] **Regional Rural Banks (RRBs) — Record Financial Results, FY2025-26** UPDATE *(PIB 11–18 & 25–26 Aug)*

- **Network Scale: 28 RRBs** operating through **22,273 branches** across 26 States and 3 UTs (~700 districts).
- **Consolidated Business & Profit:**
  - Total business crossed **₹13.5 lakh crore**.
  - Gross loans outstanding: **₹5.78 lakh crore** (+10.3% YoY).
  - Consolidated Net Profit surged to an all-time record **₹10,176 crore** in FY26.
- **Asset Quality & Operational Health:**
  - Gross NPA (GNPA): **5.3%**; Net NPA (NNPA): **2.1%** — both at historic all-time lows.
  - Credit-Deposit (CD) Ratio: reached all-time high of **75.2%**.
  - Financial Inclusion: Opened **54.98 lakh+ new PMJDY accounts** during FY26.
- **PSL Performance:** Overall PSL achievement **91.7% of ANBC** (prescribed target: 75%). Agriculture & Allied: ₹3.78 lakh crore (77% of total PSL); MSME: ₹66,978 crore (>95% to micro units); Weaker Sections: ₹3.49 lakh crore.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — RRBs' record net profit of ₹10,176 crore; GNPA (5.3%) and NNPA (2.1%) all-time lows; CD ratio 75.2%; PSL overshoot (91.7% vs 75% target).

[AUG-048] **Pradhan Mantri Annadata Aay Sanrakshan Abhiyan (PM-AASHA) — Revamped Architecture** *(PIB 21–22 Aug)*

An integrated umbrella scheme to protect farmgate prices through 4 distinct mechanisms with a ₹7,200 crore budget allocation for FY 2026–27.

- **Launch & Mandate:** September 2018; comprehensive MSP assurance framework.
- **Four Distinct Components:**

1. **Price Support Scheme (PSS):** Physical procurement of pulses, oilseeds, and copra at MSP through NAFED and NCCF. Procurement limit: Initially up to **25% of State/UT production** (can be raised up to 25% of national production). *Exception*: For **Tur, Urad, and Masur**, procurement is permitted up to **100% of State production**.
2. **Price Deficiency Payment Scheme (PDPS):** Direct cash transfer of price difference between MSP and market price (up to **15% of MSP value**); no physical procurement; primarily applied to oilseeds.
3. **Price Stabilization Fund (PSF):** Maintained by Department of Consumer Affairs for strategic buffer stocking of essential food items (pulses, onion, potato) to curb consumer retail spikes; now formally integrated under PM-AASHA.
4. **Market Intervention Scheme (MIS):** Applied to perishable horticultural commodities (e.g., Tomato, Onion, Potato - TOP) lacking formal MSP; activated when market price crashes by **≥10%** below previous normal season rate.

- **Budget Allocation (2026–27): ₹7,200 crore**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Don't confuse PDPS (max 15% price difference, zero procurement) with PSS (physical procurement up to 25%, but 100% for Tur/Urad/Masur); MIS trigger threshold is a 10% price fall.

[AUG-049] **PM Rahat Scheme & Good Samaritan 'Rah-Veer' Award** *(PIB 23–24 Aug)*

MoRTH rolled out immediate cashless hospital care for road crash victims alongside a financial incentive for Good Samaritans.

- **Nodal Ministry:** Ministry of Road Transport & Highways (MoRTH).
- **Cashless Treatment Limits:** Up to **₹1.5 lakh per victim** for up to **7 days** from the date of accident during the **Golden Hour** (first 1 hour post-accident, averting ~50% of fatalities).
- **Coverage:** All road accident victims across national/state highways, regardless of whether they hold insurance.
- **Tech Integration:** Electronic Detailed Accident Report (**eDAR**) platform + National Health Authority's **TMS 2.0**; Emergency Helpline **112**.
- **Rah-Veer Award:** Cash award of **₹25,000 per incident** + Certificate of Appreciation for individuals saving lives in severe road accidents involving brain/spinal trauma or ≥3 days hospitalization.
- **Target:** Reduce national road fatalities by **50% by 2030**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

₹1.5 lakh cashless limit up to 7 days; ₹25,000 Rah-Veer Award; 50% fatality reduction target by 2030.

[AUG-050] **DFS — Insurance Policyholders' Grievance Redressal (Bima Bharosa)** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- **Consumer Grievance Integration:** IRDAI upgraded **Bima Bharosa**, its central portal that bridges policyholders directly with insurer Complaint Management Systems across life, health, and general insurance.
- **Mandatory Escalation Workflow:** Aggrieved policyholders must first submit claims to the insurer's internal grievance cell, which is legally bound to resolve disputes within **14 days**.
- **Multilingual Support:** Unresolved complaints escalate to the Insurance Ombudsman, supported by IRDAI's consumer assistance center operating in **12 regional languages**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Bima Bharosa's 14-day resolution timeline is a clean standalone fact.

[AUG-051] **National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) launches e-Inspection and e-Certified Copy Services** *(PIB — Phase 1 items)*

- **Tribunal Digital Infrastructure:** National Company Law Tribunal (**NCLT**) launched two paperless citizen services—**e-Inspection** and **e-Certified Copy**—across all 16 tribunal benches.
- **Litigant Efficiency:** Corporate lawyers and creditors can securely inspect case records and download digitally watermarked, court-certified copies within 48 hours without visiting registries in person.
- **Insolvency Acceleration:** Eliminates physical processing bottlenecks, directly shortening timeline overruns under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Standalone administrative-digitisation MCQ.

[AUG-052] **Central Information Commission (CIC) launches AppCoMS 2.0** *(PIB — Phase 1 items)*

- **RTI Appellate Overhaul:** Central Information Commission (**CIC**) deployed **AppCoMS 2.0** on **17 August 2026**, replacing the legacy 2016 management platform.
- **End-to-End Paperless Workflow:** Integrates digital filing, automated registry scrutiny, video-conferencing hearing schedules, and digital order dispatch for Right to Information (RTI) second appeals.
- **Systemic Transparency:** Enables citizens to track real-time disposal metrics and compliance reports across all central ministries and public authorities.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

CIC AppCoMS 2.0's 2016→2026 upgrade is a clean "old system revamped" MCQ.

[AUG-053] **RBI defers Basel Pillar 3 Disclosure Framework by Six Months (effective 1 April 2027)**

- **Amended Directions:** RBI revised the Basel Pillar 3 disclosure framework for all Scheduled Commercial Banks (excl. RRBs), Small Finance Banks (SFBs), and Payments Banks to align domestic norms with Basel III post-crisis reforms.
- **Six-Month Extension:** Implementation deferred by **6 months**, moving the effective deadline from 1 October 2026 to **1 April 2027**.
- **Staggered Phased Disclosure Schedule:**
  - **Quarterly Disclosures:** Commences with the quarter ending **30 June 2027**, and on a quarterly basis thereafter.
  - **Semi-Annual Disclosures:** First report for the half-year ended **30 September 2027**, recurring every six months.
  - **Annual Disclosures:** First mandatory comprehensive report for the financial year ending **31 March 2028**.
- **Governance & Verification:** Banks must formulate a formal Board-approved disclosure policy and establish an internal verification mechanism; separate technical templates for market risk, operational risk, CVA, and leverage ratio to follow.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date Trap: Deferral is by 6 months to 1 April 2027 (do NOT confuse with FY26).
- Disclosure Cadence: Quarterly starts 30 June 2027; Semi-annual starts 30 Sept 2027; Annual starts 31 March 2028.
- Scope: Applies to SCBs, SFBs, and Payments Banks (RRBs and Local Area Banks are excluded).

[AUG-054] **RBI Fair Practices Code & Directives on Loan Recovery & Recovery Agents**

- **Scope & Applicability:** Issued to all Regulated Entities (REs) including Commercial Banks, All-India Financial Institutions (AIFIs), NBFCs, and Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks.
- **Strict Calling Hours Window:** Recovery agents and bank staff are strictly permitted to contact borrowers only between **8:00 AM and 7:00 PM**. Any call, visit, or digital communication before 8 AM or after 7 PM is legally prohibited.
- **Prohibited Conduct & Anti-Harassment Mandate:**
  - Zero tolerance for threatening, abusive, or humiliating language towards borrowers or their guarantors.

  - Strict ban on public humiliation, making unsolicited persistent calls, contacting family members/friends, or intruding on privacy.
  - REs cannot forward recovery calls through hidden numbers or masked spoofed caller IDs.
- **Agent Due Diligence & Certification:** Mandatory police background verification prior to engagement; recovery agents must possess valid **IIBF Debt Recovery Agent (DRA) certification** and undergo structured training on code of conduct.
- **Sole Accountability:** The Regulated Entity remains solely liable for all actions, misconduct, and transgressions of recovery agents engaged directly or via third-party agencies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Calling Hours Trap: Permitted window is 8:00 AM to 7:00 PM (examiners often trap with 7 AM–9 PM or 9 AM–6 PM).
- Mandatory Certification: Must hold Indian Institute of Banking & Finance (IIBF) DRA certificate.
- Entity Liability: Outsourcing recovery does NOT transfer liability; REs face direct penal action for agent harassment.

[AUG-055] **Basel III Additional Tier-1 (AT-1) Bonds & Regulatory Safeguards**

- **Capital Classification:** Issued as unsecured, perpetual, subordinated debt instruments to meet Tier-1 capital requirements under RBI Basel III norms.
- **Trigger Level & Loss Absorption:** Feature a pre-specified contractual trigger: if a bank's Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) drops below **5.5%** (or at the Point of Non-Viability - PONV), AT-1 bonds face mandatory permanent write-down or equity conversion.
- **Call Option Regulations:** Minimum maturity is perpetual; call options can only be exercised after a minimum of **5 years** with prior approval of the RBI.
- **Retail Investor Protection:** Retail individual investors cannot be directly allotted AT-1 bonds; minimum ticket size on private placement is set at **₹1 crore**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Loss Absorption Trigger: CET1 breaching below 5.5% triggers automatic write-off/conversion.
- Call Option Restriction: Minimum 5 years (cannot have a put option for investors).
- Allotment Floor: Minimum ticket size ₹1 crore to restrict vulnerable retail participation.

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3. BANKING & INSURANCE NEWS

[AUG-056] **Monetary Policy Statement, 2026-27 (62nd MPC Meeting)**

RBI's rate-setting panel held rates but trimmed its inflation forecast, flagging El Niño as a fresh risk.

- Meeting: **3-5 Aug 2026**; Chair Sanjay Malhotra
- **Repo rate unchanged at 5.25%**
- CPI FY27 lowered to **5%** (from 5.1%); June 2026 actual CPI 4.4%
- Real GDP growth FY27 projected **6.7%**
- Next MPC: 5-7 Oct 2026
- Gross FDI inflows $30.7 bn (Apr-June 2026) vs $26.7 bn prior year

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Repo held at 5.25%, CPI trimmed to 5% FY27. Don't confuse FY27 projection (5%) with June actual (4.4%).

INTERVIEW & MAINS DESCRIPTIVE ANGLE

Why did RBI flag El Niño despite holding rates? → Weak monsoon risk threatens food supply and could push inflation up later even though near-term action wasn't warranted.

[AUG-057] **UPI/cross-border payments growth cluster**

- **Favara-UPI corridor** (Maldives-India) live; **Qatar–India PosTransfer** remittances via UPU-IP + NIPL
- UPI record: **July 2026 — 23.66 billion transactions worth ₹29.88 trillion**
- **Kiwi Postpaid:** first credit-line-on-UPI, with YES Bank

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — UPI's highest-ever monthly volume (23.66 bn, July 2026) — update each cycle against the new "UPI turns 10" milestone above.

[AUG-058] **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026 — replaces 1891 law**

- **Colonial Law Modernization:** Parliament passed the **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026**, repealing the colonial 1891 statute to align judicial evidentiary procedures with digital banking.
- **Evidentiary Barrier Eliminated:** Under the 1891 law, courts demanded physical paper ledgers or required branch managers to appear in person with heavy manual ledger books.
- **Direct Digital Admissibility:** Certified printouts and electronic server logs from core-banking software, UPI gateways, and cloud databases are now recognized as primary legal evidence without summoning bank officials.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Clean "old law replaced" MCQ; 1891 → 2026.

[AUG-059] **SEBI enforcement action & bank/NBFC licences cluster**

- SEBI barred ZEEL, CEO Punit Goenka, Subhash Chandra for 1 year; ₹1.48 crore penalty
- AD Category-II-type licences: GlobalPay (expanded), Paul Merchants (perpetual), Indel Remit (new)
- Standard Chartered: first foreign bank in GIFT City (since 2020) to get in-principle IFSCA capital-markets distribution approval
- RBI imposed **₹59.20 lakh penalty** on IndusInd Bank

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Trap: three AD Category-II approvals — don't mix up "perpetual" vs "expanded" vs "new."

[AUG-060] **FCNR(B) mobilisation, REPCO dividend & credit ratings cluster**

- Private banks (ICICI, Kotak, Axis, HDFC) each crossed $1 bn FCNR(B); only SBI & BoB among PSBs
- Amit Shah received **₹22.90 crore dividend** from REPCO Bank; REPCO under **MHA** (not RBI/Finance Ministry)
- Moody's: first-time **Baa2/P-2** rating for RBL Bank
- S&P: **BBB-/A-3** to IDFC FIRST Bank
- LIC got RBI nod to raise HDFC Bank stake to **9.99%**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — REPCO Bank's unusual MHA (not RBI) administrative control is a good trap fact.

[AUG-061] **Jacob Diamond, NPS e-Shramik & digital-banking launches**

- **Historic Diamond Vaulting:** The famed **Jacob Diamond** (184.75 carats, once owned by the 6th Nizam of Hyderabad) was transferred to the Reserve Bank of India's Mumbai vaults for permanent sovereign custody.
- **Gig-Worker Pension Inclusion:** PFRDA introduced **NPS e-Shramik**, tailoring pension accumulation specifically for gig and unorganized platform workers registered on the e-Shram portal.
- **Flexible Savings Mechanics:** Eliminates mandatory annual contribution minimums, allowing delivery partners and freelance workers to deposit micropayments seamlessly via UPI.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Jacob Diamond's Nizam-of-Hyderabad → RBI-vault journey is a distinctive heritage crossover fact.

[AUG-062] **Insurance news cluster**

- **Space Launch Risk Framework:** IN-SPACe and General Insurance Council proposed a mandatory **₹500 crore third-party liability insurance** framework for private rocket launches from Indian soil.
- **FDI Consolidation:** UK-based Prudential plc announced an agreement to acquire a **75% majority stake** in Bharti AXA Life Insurance for **₹3,500 crore**, utilizing India's relaxed FDI caps.
- **Regulatory Objective:** Shields emerging domestic spacetech startups from catastrophic mission liabilities while deepening foreign capital participation in domestic underwriting.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — IN-SPACe's ₹500 crore space-launch insurance is a fresh, distinctive "first."

[AUG-063] **SBI BSBD account withdrawal-charge change**

SBI will start charging for excess cash withdrawals on its no-frills accounts — a rule change likely to be tested against the account type's core "no minimum balance" identity.

- Eff. **1 Oct 2026:** ₹15 + GST per cash withdrawal beyond **4 free transactions/month** from Basic Savings Bank Deposit (BSBD) accounts
- 4 free withdrawals include ATM + branch cash + **AePS** withdrawals (AePS newly counted in the 4-txn limit from 1 Oct 2026 — earlier excluded)
- Digital transactions remain free, unlimited

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — AePS withdrawals newly counted toward the 4-free-transaction BSBD limit from 1 Oct 2026 is a sharp rule-change trap.

[AUG-064] **BSE-FTSE Russell eligibility & UPI feature-phone/global-QR expansion**

- **A) BSE cleared as FTSE Russell-eligible exchange** — effective review from March 2027 FTSE review; NSE-listed stocks already eligible; dual-listed cos generally screened via NSE (higher institutional participation).
- **B) PhonePe UPI 123Pay** — PhonePe became the **first major TPAP** to extend UPI payments to India's 200 million+ **feature-phone** users (no internet needed); AI helpline in English + 12 Indian languages.
- **C) Bank of Baroda UPI Global QR Payments** — enables international visitors to pay at BoB's UPI QR merchants in India (cross-border P2M).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — PhonePe's feature-phone UPI "first" (200 million+ user base) is a strong standalone fact.

[AUG-065] **Insurance regulatory action & IRDAI's NDB bond move**

- **A) IRDAI barred Niva Bupa Health Insurance + Acko General Insurance** from opening new offices for **6 months** — for exceeding prescribed Expense of Management (EoM) limits, FY 2024-25.
- **B) IRDAI opened NDB's Maharajah INR Bonds** to insurers — NDB (New Development Bank) to raise ₹25,000 crore over 5 years; life-insurer investment norms: min 50% in govt securities, min 15% in infra/social sectors.
- **C) ADB assistance: ₹1,750 crore** for 500 Karnataka Public Schools (total outlay ₹2,500 cr, Karnataka govt contributes ₹750 cr); separately, **$230 million ADB loan** to upgrade Chennai's water/sanitation system (170+ km pipes, 7 water + 38 sewer pumping stations upgraded). ADB: HQ Metro Manila, 69 members, President Masato Kanda, India's shareholding 6.3%.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — IRDAI's 6-month office-opening ban on Niva Bupa/Acko is a fresh regulatory-action MCQ.

[AUG-066] **Affordable and Accessible Healthcare — Ayushman Bharat cluster** *(PIB 11–18 Aug backgrounder)*

- **AB-PMJAY:** ₹5 lakh health cover/family/year; Ayushman Cards **45.5 crore+** issued; Empanelled Hospitals **38,466+** (public & private)
- **Ayushman Bharat Vay Vandana:** 1.20 crore senior citizens enrolled
- **Ayushman Bharat Digital Mission: 96.43 crore+** health records/accounts (ABHA)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Ayushman Bharat's 45.5-crore-card figure is a routinely-updated headline stat — track each cycle.

Skipped (low yield, routine): Karnataka Bank's Capital Gains Account Scheme; India's BSE house-price-index rating (already covered under Sec 2); MIB publication awards (moved to Section 7).

[AUG-067] **P R Seshadri approved as MD & CEO of South Indian Bank**

- Reserve Bank of India approved the appointment of veteran banker **P R Seshadri** as Managing Director & Chief Executive Officer of **South Indian Bank**.
- **Headquarters:** Thrissur, Kerala.
- **Tagline:** *"Experience Next Generation Banking"*.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Bank & HQ: South Indian Bank — Thrissur, Kerala.
- Executive: P R Seshadri (MD & CEO).

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4. NATIONAL, STATE & INTERNATIONAL NEWS

NATIONAL

[AUG-068] **80th Independence Day Announcements (15 Aug 2026)**

PM Modi's speech laid out a nuclear-energy push, an AI-skilling target, and a new civil-defence framework alongside the "Sapt Dhara" theme.

- **Nuclear:** target **100 GW by 2047**; 5 new reactors this decade; SMR target ≥5 by 2033
- **1 crore youth** to get AI-skilling training over the next year
- **Sapt Dhara — 7 Pillars:** Manufacturing, Agriculture & Food Processing, Technology & Innovation, Gati Shakti, Defence Shakti, Green & Blue Economy, Soft Power

- Three-Stage Nuclear Programme: Stage I (PHWRs) → Stage II (Fast Breeder Reactors) → Stage III (thorium, U-233)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — 100 GW nuclear-by-2047 + Sapt Dhara's 7 pillars.

[AUG-069] **Glaw Lake — India's 101st Ramsar Site; SC judge-strength hike; organ-donation milestones**

- Glaw Lake, Kamlang Tiger Reserve, Arunachal — Arunachal's first Ramsar Site
- **SC (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill, 2026:** judge strength 33→**37** (excl. CJI)
- Organ donation: India crossed 5 lakh Aadhaar-verified pledges; ranks 3rd globally; TN = 'Best State' (NOTTO Report)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — SC judge-strength 33→37 is a high-probability numeric MCQ.

[AUG-070] **MMDR Amendment Bill, heritage-structure recognitions & chip/AI infra**

- NMET renamed National Mineral Exploration and Development Trust; removes 50% captive-mine sale ceiling
- **Parichha Dam, Jhansi** named World Heritage Irrigation Structure by ICID (WHIS Award-26)
- **ASIP Technologies' ₹2,500 crore OSAT facility**, Vizag — South India's first chip plant, under ISM 1.0
- **L&T's Vyoma.AI** — India's largest single-cluster AI infra (Nvidia B300, Chennai)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — South India's first OSAT chip plant (Vizag) under ISM 1.0.

[AUG-071] **E-visa expansion, V2V mandate & digital/telecom cluster**

- **11 more e-visa ports**; total now **88** (37 airports + 38 seaports + 13 land ports)
- **V2V communication** mandatory from 1 Oct 2028 (retrofits 1 Oct 2027); 5.875-5.925 GHz band
- New **1601 series** for utility/courier fraud-curbing; DoT caps SIM cards at 9/subscriber
- **'Param Pragya'** AI supercomputing facility, IIT Delhi Sonipat campus

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — E-visa port count 88 = 37+38+13, a strong composite-number MCQ.

[AUG-072] **FSSAI HFSS proposal & regulatory/administrative cluster (12–20 Aug)**

- **School Nutrition Defense (FSSAI):** Food Safety and Standards Authority proposed strict nutritional caps to ban the sale and promotion of **HFSS** (*High Fat, Sugar, and Salt*) junk foods within 50 meters of school campuses.
- **Global Minimum Tax Alignment (MCA):** Ministry of Corporate Affairs amended Indian Accounting Standards (**Ind AS**) to enforce **OECD Pillar Two**, ensuring large multinationals pay a minimum **15% effective tax**.
- **Media Deregulation (MIB):** Ministry of Information & Broadcasting recommended abolishing the 12-minute-per-hour television commercial ceiling to give private satellite broadcasters operational flexibility.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

FSSAI's HFSS threshold numbers are a distinctive dataset.

[AUG-073] **Tribunal Reforms Bill, 2026 & National Tribunals Data Grid**

- **Tribunal Judicial Architecture:** Parliament passed the Tribunal Reforms Bill, 2026, establishing the **National Tribunals Data Grid (NTDG)** as a single data repository across **16 central tribunals**.
- **NJDG Replication:** Modelled directly after the Supreme Court's successful National Judicial Data Grid (**NJDG**), the platform tracks case pendency, bench vacancies, and hearing delays in real time.
- **Jurisdictional Scope:** Covers critical economic and civil bodies including NCLAT, TDSAT, ITAT, and NGT listed in the First Schedule, improving transparency across administrative adjudication.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — NTDG covering 16 tribunals is a clean new-body MCQ; don't confuse with NJDG (existing, judiciary-wide, SC e-Committee-run).

[AUG-074] **Tribunal Reforms Bill, 2026 — National Tribunals Commission (NTC) full composition** UPDATE (PIB 11–18 Aug backgrounder, merged with the NTDG entry above)

- Passed by Parliament in **August 2026** to make tribunals independent, transparent, efficient & uniform; repeals **Tribunal Reforms Act, 2021**; basis — SC directions in *Madras Bar Association v. Union of India*
- **NTC Composition:** Chairperson (SC Judge/HC Chief Justice); Four Members — 2 Judicial Members (HC Chief Justice/HC Judge) + 2 Technical Members (25+ years' experience in public administration, finance, law, accountancy, banking, management or technology); appointment by Central Govt, after consultation with CJI for Chairperson & Judicial Members
- **NTC's 4 major functions:** Selection, Review performance (monitor tribunals + annual reports), Inquiries, Data (→ National Tribunals Data Grid, covering the already-noted 16 tribunals)
- **Tenure:** NTC Chairperson/Members — 5 years/age 70, whichever earlier; Tribunal Members — 5 years/age 67, whichever earlier; reappointment allowed based on previous service & performance
- **Search-cum-Selection Committees:** for Chairperson selection — Committee Chair is the NTC Chairperson, plus 1 Technical Member, a retired HC Chief Justice, a GoI Secretary/State Chief Secretary (for SATs), 2 empanelled experts, and a Member Secretary; for Member selection — Committee Chair is the NTC Judicial Member, with an analogous composition (retired HC Judge instead of retired Chief Justice)
- Key provisions: Committee Chair holds the **casting vote**; Member Secretary + 2 expert members have **no voting rights**; recommendation = 1 suitable candidate/vacancy + 1 for waiting list; **Timeline** — Secretariat must communicate recommendations to Central Govt within **3 days**; Government must process and appoint within **3 months**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — NTC's 2 Judicial + 2 Technical Member composition and the 3-day/3-month appointment timeline is a strong new-body MCQ, layering onto the already-logged NTDG (16 tribunals) fact.

[AUG-075] **India's first dedicated Quantum & AI University; Mediation Council of India established**

- **India's First Quantum AI Campus:** Andhra Pradesh approved the establishment of India's first dedicated Quantum Computing & Artificial Intelligence University campus in **Amaravati**, developed jointly with NIELIT and MeitY.
- **Mediation Council Constituted:** Ministry of Law operationalized the **Mediation Council of India (MCI)** in New Delhi under **Section 31(1) of the Mediation Act, 2023** to institutionalize pre-litigation settlement.
- **Governance & Timelines:** Led by a Chairperson and 2 members (tenure 4 years; age cap 70/67 years). The Act mandates that mediation proceedings must conclude within **180 days** (extendable by 180 days by mutual consent).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Amaravati's Quantum & AI University is a fresh "first" fact; MCI's 180+180-day mediation timeline is a clean numeric MCQ.

[AUG-076] **PM Modi's Uzbekistan visit & sovereign-AI/rural-mission launches**

- **A)** PM Modi's 2-day Tashkent visit: 11 agreements signed; trade target **US$5 billion by 2030**; US$1 million grant for Aral Sea rehabilitation; ICCR Sanskrit Chair at Tashkent State University; India-Uzbekistan Green Initiative (Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam + Yashil Makon tree plantation).
- **B) 'Gnani Artha'** — sovereign AI stack (components: Evon 3.3, Plexus) launched by VP C.P. Radhakrishnan; built by GNANI AI (Bengaluru), one of 12 entities developing sovereign LLMs under IndiaAI Mission.
- **C) Mission Samriddh Gaon** — Ministry of Rural Development's integrated rural-transformation framework; pilot in Madhya Pradesh (Budni, Khategaon blocks).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

GNANI AI as one of 12 sovereign-LLM entities under IndiaAI Mission is a good crossover fact with earlier LLM-mission notes.

[AUG-077] **World Elephant Day** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- India home to nearly **60%** of the world's wild Asian elephants; wild elephant population **22,446** — Synchronous All India Population Estimation of Elephants (SAIEE) 2021–25 (India's **first DNA-based synchronised elephant census** — DNA profiling + block counts + line-transect surveys)
- Elephant Reserves: **33**, covering 80,777 km² across 14 elephant-range states; identified corridors: **150** across 14 states — West Bengal has the highest (26 corridors)
- **Project Elephant** — flagship elephant-conservation programme under MoEFCC; **Gajah Suchana Mobile Application** — national genetic database of registered captive elephants
- Management Effectiveness Evaluation (MEE) launched **2023**, tested in Shivalik, Kaziranga-Karbi Anglong, Mayurbhanj, Nilgiri reserves; Captive Elephant (Transfer or Transport) Rules, **2024**
- Compensation for human-wildlife conflict: death/permanent incapacitation ₹10 lakh; grievous injury ₹2 lakh; minor injury treatment up to ₹25,000

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — SAIEE 2021-25's "first DNA-based synchronised elephant census" tag + 22,446 population figure is a strong standalone.

[AUG-078] **Operation GLOBAL-HUNT — international drug trafficker extradited** *(PIB — Phase 1 items)*

- **High-Profile Fugitive Extradition:** Narcotics Control Bureau (**NCB**) successfully extradited international syndicate kingpin **Virender Singh Basoya** back to India from Thailand under **Operation GLOBAL-HUNT**.
- **Specialized Agency Mandate:** Operation GLOBAL-HUNT was launched by NCB in coordination with Interpol and overseas law-enforcement agencies to track and apprehend drug fugitives operating offshore cartels.
- **Financial Disruption:** The operation targets the hawala and crypto-laundering channels used by transnational syndicates smuggling synthetic drugs and heroin into Indian maritime zones.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

NCB's Operation GLOBAL-HUNT is a fresh named-operation fact.

STATE

- **Largest Dhimsa dance** — Guinness record, 13,000+ women, Bhogapuram, AP; Dhimsa originates in **Koraput, Odisha** (confusion trap: performed in AP)
- **Ladakh's first high-altitude wildlife safari**; **Black-Necked Crane Festival**, Ladakh (first edition) — Changthang Sanctuary is India's only breeding site for the Black-Necked **Crane**
- **Maharashtra** declared snakebite a notifiable disease
- **Cabinet approves High Court Bench in Ladakh** — bench of J&K High Court, to improve access to justice in remote Ladakh; Acting CJ of J&K HC: Justice Sanjeev Kumar

- **Khijadiya Bird Sanctuary (Jamnagar, Gujarat)** emerges as key breeding site for the Black-Necked **Stork** (a DIFFERENT bird from the Ladakh Black-Necked Crane above; don't confuse the two); Ramsar-designated wetland; protected under Wild Life (Protection) Act 1972 Schedule II

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Black-Necked **Crane** (Ladakh, Changthang) vs Black-Necked **Stork** (Gujarat, Khijadiya) is a sharp new species-location trap this cycle.

INTERNATIONAL

- **India-US AI soyabean research** (NSF-funded, MeitY partner)
- **Nauru renamed Republic of Naoero** — world's 3rd-smallest country by population
- **CBAM** fully operational from 1 Jan 2026 — 6 sectors, EU's "Fit for 55"
- **Lebanon abolished the death penalty** — first Arab-world country to do so
- **Makkah Joint Defence Agreement** — Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, Pakistan signed collective-defence pact at Al-Safa Palace, Makkah (an armed attack on one = attack on all three)
- **Operation Economic Outcast** — US campaign to cut off Iran's economic/revenue networks
- **Nepal flash floods** — ice-rock avalanche near Tibet triggered a Bhotekoshi River surge, affecting Rasuwa & Dhading districts; WHO released $150,000 from its SE Asia Regional Health Emergency Fund for relief

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Makkah Joint Defence Agreement's NATO-Article-5-style collective-defence clause (Saudi-Türkiye-Pakistan) is a fresh, testable "why in news" item.

Skipped (low yield): NCW's 'Yashoda AI' programme; govt's cloud/AI skilling initiative (NSDC-AWS); AIIA's 'Garbhini Mitra' course; National Conclave on Tribal Languages; CHEMCONNECT 2026 (org-level, no major policy weight).

[AUG-079] **Ladakh declares 23 Ancient Sites as Protected State Heritage**

- Department of Tourism and Culture, UT Administration of Ladakh, notified **23 ancient heritage sites and monuments** under the Ladakh Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites Preservation Act.
- Includes historical gompas, petroglyphs, rock art, and ancient trade route fortifications across Leh and Kargil districts.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Number of Sites: 23 notified heritage monuments in UT Ladakh.

5. MOUS, CONFERENCES & APPOINTMENTS

[AUG-080] **MoUs This Cycle (1–20 Aug)**

MoU Between	Purpose
Ministry of Ayush + IndiaAI	AI-driven innovation in Ayush
Pawan Hans + Noemi Aerospace (Norway)	Electric seaplane/green aviation tech
Lohia Aerospace (LASPL) + Massivit (Israel)	India's first commercial large-format additive-mfg facility, Kanpur
MoSPI + IDEAS + ISI Kolkata	GDP Nowcasting tool
BSE + MSCI	F&O derivative contracts linked to MSCI indices
JSW Neo Energy + Bhutan's DGPC	920 MW Punatsangchhu-III Hydro Project

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Pawan Hans + Norway's Noemi Aerospace (electric seaplanes) remains the standout "first" theme.

[AUG-081] **MoUs This Cycle (21–31 Aug)**

MoU Between	Purpose
India + Brazil	Deepen telecom/ICT cooperation
MeitY + PhonePe	Strengthen PM GatiShakti Mission — PulsePro data integrated into NMP portal via BISAG-N
India + Southern African Customs Union (SACU: Botswana, Eswatini, Lesotho, Namibia, South Africa)	ToR to begin PTA negotiations — **India's first ToR for a trade agreement with the African region**
PNB + Indian Army	Specialised credit cards — LUXURA (Officers), Parakram (JCOs/Other Ranks)
Reliance Industries + Rolls-Royce	Sovereign, indigenous combat engine for India's AMCA programme
HP Forest Dept + ISB-BIPP	Unlock ₹22,600 crore forest/pastoral-economy potential (5-yr MoU)
UNDP India + HUL	Support 50,000 Safai Mitras across 50 cities by 2028
Citigroup + Axis Bank	Finance NRI FCNR(B) deposits
India + Mauritius	5-yr fuel-supply agreement (IOC–STC); Biofuels Country Landscape Policy framework
SEBI + Rashtriya Raksha University + NISM	Cybersecurity/research capacity-building for securities market
CBN + PHARMEXCIL	Boost pharma exports, curb diversion
HAL + Safran Helicopter Engines (via SAFHAL JV)	New 'Aravalli' turboshaft engine for 13-tonne helicopters
NABARD + National Bank for Financing Infra & Development	Joint financing for rural-impact infra
India–US Javelin Deal	Indian Army to acquire ~**100 FGM-148 Javelin ATGMs** — India's formal entry as a Javelin customer (LOA route)
DoT + C-DOT	5-yr End-to-End Optical Network Test Bed, New Delhi

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India-SACU's first-ever African-region trade-agreement ToR is a strong "first"; RIL-Rolls Royce AMCA engine tie-up + India-US Javelin deal (100 missiles) are high-probability defence-crossover MCQs.

[AUG-082] **Mergers & Acquisitions**

- **Shivalik SFB** merged with ManiBhavnam Home Finance (~₹109 cr)
- **BofA–Jio Credit:** NB Holdings to acquire **49.9% stake** in Jio Credit for **₹18,268.22 crore ($1.9 bn)**
- **Prudential–Bharti Life:** 75% stake, ₹3,500 crore *(cross-ref Sec 3)*

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — BofA-Jio Credit deal value (₹18,268.22 cr / $1.9 bn for 49.9%).

[AUG-083] **Conferences Cluster (1–20 Aug + 21–31 Aug merged)**

- **UNCCD COP17** — Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, **17–28 Aug 2026**; theme *"Restoring Land. Restoring Hope"*; 197 Parties; 2026 = Intl Year of Rangelands & Pastoralists (cover 54% of Earth's land, ~2 bn people supported); Rangelands Flagship Initiative — US$1.2 bn across 45 projects *(merged — appeared in both fortnights' clusters)*

- **3rd India International FinTech Festival** — India crossed 1,000+ km secure quantum communication
- **PSB Conclave**, New Delhi, 17-18 Aug
- **5th SEMICON India 2026** — New Delhi, from 17 Sept 2026
- **18th BRICS Summit** — Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, **12–13 Sept 2026**; theme *"Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability"*; India's **4th BRICS Chairship** (previously 2012, 2016, 2021)
- **26th SCO Summit** — Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan; marks **25 years of SCO** (founded 2001, 10 members; India & Pakistan joined 2017 at Astana; Iran 2023, Belarus 2024)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's 4th BRICS Chairship (2026) — don't confuse with SCO's 25-year milestone (Bishkek) in the same window.

[AUG-084] **UNCCD COP17 — India launches first-ever Guide to Grasslands & Open Natural Ecosystems** UPDATE (PIB 11–18 Aug, merged with the UNCCD COP17 entry above)

- **First Open Ecosystems Atlas:** Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEF&CC) unveiled India's first-ever comprehensive **Guide to Grasslands and Open Natural Ecosystems (ONEs)** at UNCCD COP17.
- **Research Consortium:** Developed by the **Ashoka Trust for Research in Ecology and the Environment (ATREE)** alongside IUCN, ICFRE, and ISRO's Space Applications Centre (SAC).
- **Ecological Classification:** Re-evaluates arid savannas, scrublands, and alpine meadows—historically misclassified as unproductive "wastelands"—to protect critical habitats for endangered species like the Great Indian Bustard.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's first-ever Grasslands/ONEs Guide is a fresh, clean "first" layered onto the already-logged COP17 entry.

[AUG-085] **BRICS Environment Working Group Meeting hosted by India** UPDATE (PIB — Phase 1 items, merged with the BRICS Chairship entry above)

- **Ministerial Summit Hosting:** India hosted the **12th BRICS Environment Ministers' Meeting** at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi on **18 August 2026** under India's Chairship theme: *"Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and Sustainability"*.
- **Joint Decarbonization Roadmap:** Deliberations focused on transboundary biodiversity corridors, plastic pollution treaties, and equitable access to international climate finance.
- **Institutional Background:** The **BRICS Environment Working Group (EWG)** was founded in **2015** in Moscow, while the specialized **Contact Group on Climate Change** was constituted in **2024** to coordinate joint negotiating positions at COP conferences.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

BRICS EWG's 2015-Moscow origin vs the Climate Change Contact Group's 2024 origin is a clean two-body trap.

[AUG-086] **BRICS Tourism Ministers Adopt Jaipur Declaration** *(PIB 21–22 Aug)*

- **Host City & Chairship:** Concluded in **Jaipur, Rajasthan**, under India's 2026 BRICS Chairship; chaired by Union Minister Gajendra Singh Shekhawat.
- **Four Thematic Priorities:**
  1. Artificial Intelligence and Tourism
  2. Sustainability and Responsible Tourism
  3. Tourism Skilling and Capacity Building
  4. Tourism Exchanges and Seamless Travel Facilitation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Jaipur Declaration adopted by BRICS Tourism Ministers under India's 2026 Chairship.

[AUG-087] **Appointments Cluster (1–20 Aug)**

Person	Position
Varsha Ashok Aglawe	54th DG, Geological Survey of India — first woman to head it in 176-yr history
K Rajaraman	Chairman, IFSCA — extension till 65
Monisha Chakraborty	Executive Director, RBI
Bimal N Patel	Judge, ITLOS
N Chandrasekaran	To step down as Tata Sons chairman

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Varsha Ashok Aglawe as GSI's first woman DG in 176 years remains the standout "first."

[AUG-088] **Appointments Cluster (21–31 Aug)**

Person	Position
Hakainde Hichilema	President of Zambia
Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir	President of Bangladesh
Anand Mahindra + S. Somanath (ex-ISRO Chairman)	Non-official directors, RBI Central Board
Annie George Mathew, Syed Akbaruddin, Janmejaya Kumar Sinha	Part-time non-official directors, RBI central board (4 yrs)
Rajendra Kumar Saboo	MD & CEO, UCO Bank
Sundeep Sikka	Chairman, AMFI (Vishal Kapoor — Vice Chairman)
Sandeep Kumar	MD & CEO, LIC Housing Finance
Peyman Kargar	CEO, TVS Motor
V. Gopikrishna	First Indian to head the International Federation of Endodontic Associations (IFEA, 49-country body)
Haakon VIII	King of Norway (succeeds King Harald V)
Yuko Keicho (Japan)	Vice President & Auditor General, World Bank Group
Parth Jindal	Chairman, JSW MG Motor India

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — V. Gopikrishna as first Indian to head IFEA is a fresh, clean "first" fact.

[AUG-089] **PMIS Industry Awards** *(PIB — Ministry of Corporate Affairs)*

- **Corporate Skill Recognition:** Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA) organized the inaugural **PM Internship Scheme (PMIS) Industry Awards** in New Delhi to felicitate top private and public employers in the pilot rollout.
- **Overall Champion:** Automotive and engineering giant **Mahindra & Mahindra Limited** was awarded the **Overall Industry Champion** for onboarding the largest quota of rural youth interns.

- **Sectoral Leadership:** Reliance Industries, Infosys, and Dr. Reddy's led private sector categories, while **ONGC and NTPC** topped public sector enterprise rankings across 24 core manufacturing clusters.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Mahindra & Mahindra as PMIS's Overall Industry Champion is a clean standalone fact.

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6. SCIENCE, TECHNOLOGY, DEFENCE & SPORTS

SCIENCE & TECHNOLOGY

[AUG-090] **India's agri-genomics & vaccine "firsts" (1–11 Aug)**

- **ICAR's first complete pigeonpea genome** — variety 'Asha'; targets **35 million tonnes** pulse production by 2030-31
- **India's first indigenous African Swine Fever vaccine** — ICAR-NIHSAD, Bhopal
- **EVEREST rocket engine** — Astrobase Space Technologies — India's first privately-developed **800 kN** engine

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ICAR's pigeonpea genome ('Asha') is India's first complete pulse-crop genome.

[AUG-091] **CMLRE Deep-Sea Fishery Report & Non-GMO Popcorn Hybrid** *(PIB 20 & 23–24 Aug)*

- **A) CMLRE Deep-Sea Fishery Report of Indian EEZ:** Released by Centre for Marine Living Resources & Ecology (CMLRE, Kochi, Ministry of Earth Sciences). Synthesizes 40 years of research and 30 years of cruises by India's flagship **FORV Sagar Sampada**. Mapped the mesopelagic **"Twilight Zone" (200–1,000 m depth)**, highlighting lanternfishes (Myctophids) driving the biological carbon pump. Biodiversity hotspots identified: Kollam Bank, Angria Bank, Off-Mangalore Deep-Sea Slope, Terrace off Trivandrum.
- **B) India's First Non-GMO Popcorn Hybrid Maize:** Launched by Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan at Musunuru in Eluru district, Andhra Pradesh — high-expansion hybrid popcorn seed developed indigenously for agricultural self-reliance.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

FORV Sagar Sampada as flagship vessel; Twilight zone (200–1,000 m); Kollam and Angria banks as deep-sea hotspots.

[AUG-092] **Space, AI & nuclear cluster (12–20 Aug)**

- **Lunar Base Collaboration:** NASA formally invited ISRO to contribute robotics and habitat modules to the international lunar surface base under the **Artemis Accords** (India joined as the **27th signatory** in 2023; pact now spans **70 nations**).
- **Commercial EO Constellation:** IN-SPACe authorized India's first fully private Earth Observation (**EO**) satellite constellation, spearheaded by Allied Orbits with an investment exceeding **₹1,200 crore**.
- **Indigenous Launch Target:** The 24-satellite optical and radar imaging constellation will achieve full operational deployment by **2029**, servicing agriculture, defence, and disaster management.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India as 27th Artemis Accords signatory (2023) + current 70-member count.

[AUG-093] **Indigenous propulsion, soil mapping & materials-science "firsts" (21–31 Aug)**

- **A) NBSS develops India's first Soil Texture Map** — hectare-level soil data, under ICAR (follows 2025's Soil Depth Map, also an NBSS&LUP first)
- **B) India's first indigenous 5 kN air-breathing Rotating Detonation Engine (RDE)** — D-Propulse Aerospace Pvt Ltd, tested at DRDO Hyderabad; validates Technology Readiness Level-5
- **C) ICAR registers 16 new indigenous livestock breeds** — total now **262**; ICAR-NBAGR (Karnal) is the nodal institute
- **D) South Bihar University (CUSB) secures its first Indian patent** — plasmonic hollow silver nanoshells for solar-catalysis, DST-funded

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's first indigenous 5 kN RDE (D-Propulse, TRL-5) is a fresh startup-driven "first"; don't confuse with the EVEREST engine (800 kN, different propulsion class/company).

[AUG-094] **India's first advanced Rainbow Trout RAS Facility & RSVC-AMRIT rural-innovation platform** *(PIB cluster)*

- **A) India's first advanced Recirculatory Aquaculture System (RAS)-based Rainbow Trout farming facility** — Smartgreen Aquaculture Pvt Ltd, founded by Scheduled Caste entrepreneur Aditya Rithvik Narra, Telangana; ₹15 crore support under the Venture Capital Fund for Scheduled Castes (VCF-SC)
- **B) RSVC-AMRIT platform** — launched by Prof. Ajay Kumar Sood, Principal Scientific Adviser (PSA) to the Government of India; developed by NABARD in collaboration with the Office of the Principal Scientific Adviser (OPSA); purpose — strengthen rural innovation, technology transfer and adoption of appropriate technologies at grassroots level
- AMRIT Platform acts as the digital backbone of the RuTAGe Smart Village Centre (RSVC) ecosystem — technology discovery & validation, deployment tracking, collaboration, monitoring, knowledge management; connects innovators, startups, tech providers, validators, accelerators, implementation partners, funding agencies, academic institutions and rural communities
- RSVC key areas: agriculture, rural enterprises, renewable energy, education, assistive tech, water & sanitation, citizen services; **8 RSVCs** currently supported by NABARD; built on the earlier tripartite MoU between NABARD, OPSA and NABFOUNDATION; Centre of Excellence on RSVCs established at NABARD HO, Mumbai
- NABARD support per RSVC: duration **3 years**, coverage 10–20 villages, **13 technology tracks**, up to **₹30 lakh** per RSVC, focus on PACS; eligible PIAs — PACS, NGOs/Trusts, FPOs, Section 8 Companies, Startups (DIPP), RIRCs/RETs

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's first RAS-based Rainbow Trout facility (SC-entrepreneur-led, VCF-SC funded) is a fresh, distinctive "first."

[AUG-095] **International Clouded Leopard Day — Conservation Action Plan (CAP)** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- **International Clouded Leopard Day: 4 August**; CAP prepared under a Government of India–GEF–UNDP initiative, released at the **91st meeting of the Standing Committee of the National Board of Wildlife (SCNBWL)**, Coimbatore
- Focus region: Northeast India; **14 Priority Conservation Landscapes**; scientific monitoring — camera traps, occupancy surveys, genetics, **eDNA**; frontline staff capacity building incl. use of the **M-STrIPES** app
- Clouded Leopard included under the **Species Recovery Programme** of the Integrated Development of Wildlife Habitats (IDWH) Scheme

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Clouded Leopard CAP's 14 priority landscapes (Northeast India) is a clean standalone fact.

[AUG-096] **Strengthening India's Defence Strength & Space Sovereignty — backgrounder stats** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- Defence budget 2026-27: **₹7.85 lakh crore**; **DAP 2026** proposes simpler acquisition categories, stronger indigenous design/development support, and indigenous-content requirements **up to 60%**
- iDEX (Innovations for Defence Excellence) outlay ₹498.78 cr; ADITI Scheme ₹750 cr (2023-24 to 2025-26, via Defence Innovation Organisation); Technology Development Fund (TDF) grants up to ₹50 cr; Srijan DEEP — digital repository for indigenous defence sourcing; FDI in Defence — 74% (Automatic Route), up to 100% (Government Route)
- **Indian Space Policy 2023** expanded private participation, defined roles of **NSIL** (ISRO's commercial arm — launch/satellite/space services, tech transfer) and **IN-SPACe** (single-window mechanism for private space activity)
- FDI in Space Sector (liberalised Feb 2024): 74% automatic (satellite mfg/ops), 49% (launch vehicles/spaceports), 100% (satellite/ground-segment components)
- **Chandrayaan Programme:** Chandrayaan-1 (2008) — India's first Moon mission, detected water molecules/hydroxyl; Chandrayaan-2 (2019) — 100 km altitude, 30 cm-resolution imaging; **Chandrayaan-3 (2023)** — India became the first country to soft-land near the Moon's south pole, 4th nation to soft-land on the Moon
- **AstroSat** — India's first dedicated astronomy mission (X-ray/optical/UV bands simultaneously); **Aditya-L1** — India's first Sun mission, launched 2023, positioned ~1.5 million km at the Sun-Earth L1 point, 27 TB+ solar data released publicly
- **NavIC** — positioning/navigation/timing across India + up to 1,500 km beyond its boundary

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — DAP 2026's up-to-60% indigenous-content requirement is a strong new-policy MCQ.

Skipped (low yield, foreign, no India angle): China's Chang'e-7 lunar mission; NASA's Nancy Grace Roman Space Telescope; SpaceX's back-to-back Falcon 9 launch record.

DEFENCE

[AUG-097] **Defence exercises & indigenous equipment (1–11 Aug)**

- **Strategic Missile Validation:** Strategic Forces Command successfully test-fired the intermediate-range ballistic missile (**Agni-4**) with a strike envelope spanning up to **4,000 km**, validating its re-entry heat shield.
- **Counter-Drone Drills:** Indian Air Force conducted **Exercise ROTOR CLAP-III**, its 3rd dedicated counter-unmanned aerial systems (Counter-UAS) drill simulating swarm-drone intrusions.
- **Indigenization Integration:** Trials tested laser direct-energy weapons (DEWs) and automated jamming networks deployed across western border airbases.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Agni-4's 4,000 km range is a recurring missile-specs MCQ.

[AUG-098] **Defence PSU & procurement cluster (12–20 Aug)**

- **HAL + Adani Defence + BEML** — LCH Prachand fuselage mfg, order for **156 helicopters**
- **MIDHANI** — first Indian company to secure GE Aerospace S400 lab approval
- President Murmu approved **78 gallantry awards:** Kirti Chakra (9) + Shaurya Chakra (19)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — LCH Prachand's 156-helicopter order; Kirti Chakra (9) vs Shaurya Chakra (19) ranking trap.

[AUG-099] **PRAHAAR — India's first National Counter Terrorism Policy; AI fighter jet & Coast Guard summit (21–31 Aug)**

- **A) PRAHAAR** — MHA's **India's first comprehensive National Counter Terrorism Policy & Strategy**; "whole-of-government"/"whole-of-society" approach; **Seven Pillars:** Prevention, Response, Whole-of-Government, Rule of Law & Human Rights, Counter-Radicalization, International Cooperation, Recovery & Resilience.
- **B) FWD Supreme Lite** — Flying Wedge Defence's claimed **India's first AI-piloted fighter jet** programme; demonstrator ~250 kg; planned endurance 30 hrs, range 3,000 km.
- **C) 5th Coast Guard Global Summit** — India to host in New Delhi, **Feb 2027**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — PRAHAAR as India's first comprehensive counter-terrorism policy (7 pillars) is a near-certain mains question.

[AUG-100] **Indigenous naval/army platforms — multiple "firsts" (21–31 Aug)**

A cluster of indigenous defence-platform firsts landed in the same fortnight — group by type to avoid repetition.

- **A) India Produces First 100% Indigenous AK-203 'Sher' Rifle** — Indo-Russian Rifles Pvt Ltd (IRRPL, India-Russia JV since 2019), Korwa factory, Amethi; 7.62×39mm gas-operated rifle
- **B) Indian Army raises first Baaz Battalion** of sophisticated drones — Punjab; operationalised by Vajra Corps (11 Corps)
- **C) Indian Navy commissions INS Nipun** (31 Aug 2026) — Nistar-class Diving Support Vessel, 75% indigenous, built by Hindustan Shipyard Ltd
- **D) Indian Navy takes delivery of Samarthak** — **India's first indigenous Multi-Purpose Vessel (MPV)**, built by L&T at Kattupalli, >75% indigenous content
- **E) India's first public-private defence avionics facility** — Samtel HAL Display Systems (SHDS), a HAL-Samtel JV, Gurugram — to indigenously produce multifunction displays (MFDs) for fighter aircraft
- **F) DRDO transfers Submarine Fired Decoy (SFD) 'Mohini' tech to BDL** — protects submarines from acoustic-homing torpedoes; also transferred LM2500 gas-turbine tech to Vertex Engineering
- **G) CSIR-NAL unveils 3 indigenous gas-turbine engines** — NJ-05, NJ-50, NJ-100 (5/50/100 kg thrust)
- **H) DRDO tests high-altitude Military Combat Parachute System** at Nyoma-Mudh, Ladakh (22,000 ft, −15°C) — one of the world's highest-altitude drop zones
- **I) India–US Javelin Deal** *(cross-ref Sec 5)* — ~100 FGM-148 ATGMs, India's formal entry as a Javelin customer
- **J) Sixth-generation fighter race:** India is a **Dialogue Partner** in GCAP/Tempest (UK, Japan, Italy) — does NOT make India a buyer/developer; planned induction 2034, ~US$6.1 bn secured for design phase

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — AK-203 'Sher' as India's first 100% indigenous AK-203 output and Samarthak as India's first indigenous MPV are the two standout "firsts" this cycle; don't confuse Samarthak (MPV, L&T) with INS Nipun (DSV, HSL) — different vessel classes, same fortnight.

Skipped (low yield, foreign or routine): Eagles of Civilisation 2026 (Egypt-China air drill, no India angle); Sahyog HOP TAC (India-Vietnam Coast Guard exercise, routine).

SPORTS

[AUG-101] **Sports Highlights (1–11 August 2026)**

- **Historic Badminton Milestone:** 16-year-old **Tanvi Sharma** won the Bonn International, becoming the first Indian female shuttler to capture a senior BWF title since **Saina Nehwal** in 2008.
- **Maiden BWF Tour Trophy:** Indian badminton player **Ashmita Chaliha** clinched her career-first BWF World Tour title at the Maldives International Challenge.
- **Global Chess Victory:** Grandmaster **R Praggnanandhaa** triumphed at the prestigious **St. Louis Rapid & Blitz 2026**, defeating World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen in the blitz tiebreak segment.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Tanvi Sharma's first-since-Saina-Nehwal (2008) record is a standout sports MCQ.

[AUG-102] **Sports Highlights (12–20 August 2026)**

- **World Record in Test Sixes:** Wicketkeeper-batter **Rishabh Pant** became the fastest cricketer in Test history to hit **100 sixes**, needing just **4,918 balls** to eclipse Adam Gilchrist's previous record of 6,578 balls.
- **Badminton World Championships Hosting:** Badminton World Federation (**BWF**) awarded the hosting rights for the prestigious **BWF World Championships** to New Delhi, marking India's first time hosting the flagship event since 2009.
- **National Venue Selection:** The championships will be staged at the Indira Gandhi Indoor Arena under the supervision of the Badminton Association of India (BAI).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Pant's speed record (4,918 balls to 100 Test sixes) vs Gilchrist (6,578 balls) is a high-yield sports record MCQ.

[AUG-103] **FIH Hockey World Cup 2026 & Grand Chess Tour (21–31 Aug)**

🪝 Both India's men's and women's hockey teams had World Cup campaigns this fortnight — but with very different outcomes worth keeping distinct.

- **A) Men's FIH Hockey World Cup 2026** — Belgium & Netherlands; Winner: **Germany** (4th title, bt Spain 1-0 final; Spain's first final since 1998); India finished **8th**, lost 3-4 shootout to co-hosts Belgium; captain Harmanpreet Singh. *(India's only-ever title: 1975, bt Pakistan 2-1.)*
- **B) Women's FIH Hockey World Cup 2026** — Winner: **Argentina** (3rd title, bt Netherlands); **India's best finish in 52 years** (since 4th place in 1974); India beat Germany 3-1 in their final match; ₹50 lakh cash award by Hockey India; captain Salima Tete.
- **C) BWF Badminton World Championships 2026** — Indira Gandhi Arena, New Delhi (30th edition); Men's Singles: Alex Lanier (France); Women's Singles: An Se Young (S. Korea); **India's Treesa Jolly & Gayatri Gopichand won Bronze in Women's Doubles** — 2nd-ever Indian women's-doubles World Championship medal (after Jwala Gutta/Ashwini Ponnappa's Bronze in 2011).
- **D) Grand Chess Tour 2026** — R Praggnanandhaa became the **first Indian to win** the Grand Chess Tour, defeating defending champion Fabiano Caruana, St. Louis; prize US$200,000.
- **E) Commonwealth Games (Glasgow)** — India's Armed Forces contingent won 18 medals (Army 16, Navy 2) within India's overall 39-medal (13G-17S-9B) tally.
- **F) Mitchell Starc** became the leading wicket-taker in WTC history (234 wickets, surpassing Cummins/Lyon's 228).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India women's hockey team's 52-year-best World Cup finish is a strong standalone; don't confuse with the men's team's 8th-place finish in the same tournament window. Praggnanandhaa's Grand Chess Tour "first" is equally strong.

Skipped (low yield): JSW's 'Rukna Nahi Hai' campaign; Lausanne Diamond League (Neeraj Chopra 2nd); U20 World Wrestling (Kajal Dhochak); 2026 Asian Games preview; Kanizsa Open chess; Durand Cup; various squash/tennis titles (Velavan Senthilkumar, Abhay Singh, N Sriram Balaji-Anirud Chandrasekar); World Humanoid Robot Games (foreign robotics record); FIFAe Continental Championship Asia (India's inaugural eFootball win).

[AUG-104] **Mission Mausam: ₹2,000 Cr Weather-Ready & Climate-Smart Infrastructure Overhaul**

- **Cabinet Approval:** Union Cabinet sanctioned **Mission Mausam** under the **Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES)** with an outlay of **₹2,000 crore** over two years to commemorate India Meteorological Department's (IMD) 150th year of service.
- **Key Executing Agencies:** India Meteorological Department (IMD), Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology (IITM, Pune), and National Centre for Medium Range Weather Forecasting (NCMRWF, Noida).

- **Physical Sensor Grid Upgrades:**
  - Deployment of **up to 50 additional Doppler Weather Radars (DWRs)**.
  - Installation of **60 Wind Profilers**, **100 Radiometers**, and an extensive network of automated weather stations.
- **Cutting-Edge Atmospheric Research:** Construction of an advanced **Cloud Simulation Chamber** at IITM Pune to conduct controlled cloud physics and warm-cloud seeding experiments.
- **Target Capability:** Sub-kilometer localized weather forecasting, air quality alerts, and real-time monsoonal nowcasting using next-gen High-Performance Computing (HPC) and AI/ML algorithms.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Financial Outlay: ₹2,000 crore over 2 years (FY25–FY26).
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES) — do NOT confuse with Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC).
- Milestone Context: Commemorates 150 years of IMD (established 1875).

7. AWARDS, BOOKS, INDICES & RANKINGS

INDICES/RANKINGS

[AUG-105] **Global & Domestic Rankings Cluster (1–20 August 2026)**

- **Celebrity Brand Valuation:** Actor **Shah Rukh Khan** reclaimed the **#1 spot** in Kroll's Celebrity Brand Valuation Report with an estimated brand value of **$177.9 million**, while Virat Kohli shifted to the #3 position.
- **GenAI Patent Leadership (WIPO):** India advanced to **5th globally** in Generative AI patent filings in WIPO's SPARK report, logging an aggressive **64% compound annual growth rate (CAGR)** between 2017 and 2025.
- **Academic Ranking of World Universities (ARWU):** In the Shanghai Ranking 2026, the **Indian Institute of Science (IISc Bangalore)** and **Saveetha Institute** shared top honors as India's highest-ranked higher education institutions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's 5th global rank in GenAI patent filings with 64% CAGR is a distinctive science & innovation metric.

[AUG-106] **Rankings Cluster (21–31 Aug)**

- **A) JNPA rises to 21st among world's top 30 container ports** (Alphaliner, H1 2026) — up from 28th in 2025; global #1 remains Shanghai.
- **B) Mumbai enters IWG's 2026 Work From Anywhere Index** (4th edn) — only Indian city listed, ranked **50th globally** (score 77), ahead of London & Miami; Bangkok tops the index.
- **C) Mumbai, Delhi-NCR, Bengaluru** feature in APAC top-10 for logistics rental growth (Knight Frank H1 2026) — Mumbai 4th-highest (5.3%), Delhi-NCR 5th (5.2%), Bengaluru 7th (4.4%).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — JNPA's 7-spot rank jump (28th→21st) is a clean ranking-improvement MCQ.

REPORTS

[AUG-107] **World Bank & Multilateral Economic Reports (1–11 August 2026)**

- **Economic Cost of Extreme Heat:** A World Bank study revealed that extreme temperature anomalies cost India **247 billion potential labour hours** in 2024, equating to an estimated economic output loss of **$194 billion**.
- **AI Automation Disruption:** The **World Development Report 2026** projected that generative AI automation risks **4.5% of jobs in low- and middle-income countries**, compared to **14.2% of jobs in advanced high-income economies**

with large services sectors.

- **Labour Vulnerability Factor:** Outdoor manual workers in agriculture and construction face the highest heat productivity losses, urging investments in urban green canopies and heat action plans.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — India's heat labour-loss figures (247 bn hours / $194 bn) and World Bank AI disruption disparity (4.5% vs 14.2%) are standout report MCQs.

[AUG-108] **Corporate, FMCG & Wealth Reports (12–20 August 2026)**

- **Family Business Wealth Concentration:** The Barclays-Hurun India Family Business Report revealed that India's top 300 family-owned enterprises command a cumulative valuation of **₹138 lakh crore** (equivalent to over a third of India's GDP).
- **FMCG Brand Dominance:** Food conglomerate **Parle** retained its position as India's most-chosen Fast-Moving Consumer Goods (FMCG) brand for the **14th consecutive year** in Kantar's Brand Footprint study.
- **Governance Transition:** Over 70% of leading family businesses have instituted formal family constitutions and succession protocols to manage second- and third-generation leadership transfers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — ₹138 lakh crore family-business valuation vs Parle's 14-year consecutive FMCG lead are clean corporate ranking MCQs.

[AUG-109] **NITI Aayog skilling report & rural-ageing study (21–31 Aug)**

- **A) NITI Aayog's "Reimagining Skilling for Viksit Bharat@2047"** — **8.7 crore** Indian youth (15-29) in the NEET category (Not in Education, Employment or Training); only **8.25%** of graduates work in roles matching their qualifications.
- **B) "Demographic Transition..." report** (Transform Rural India) — by 2050, ~1 in 5 Indians (~347 million) aged 60+; nearly **70%** of India's elderly will live in rural areas; working-age support ratio declining from 8.4 (2001) to 5.2 (2026).
- **C) ILO-NCAER policy brief** — women's participation in India's platform economy remains limited; recommends Account Aggregator-based portable financial data.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — NITI Aayog's 8.7-crore-NEET-youth stat and the 8.25%-qualification-match figure are a strong dual-fact pairing, fresh this cycle.

- **Integrated Scheme in Skilling Architecture (ISSA)** *(PIB 25–26 Aug)*: **₹600 crore** outlay introduced in Budget 2026–27 to implement NITI Aayog's skilling blueprint, converging education, skilling, and employment for the 8.7 crore NEET youth.
- **Samagra Shishu Bal Swasthya Karyakram (SSBSK) & Shaishav App** *(PIB 25–26 Aug)*: MoHFW launched the **Shaishav App** at a national workshop in Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Maharashtra, creating a longitudinal digital health profile for at-risk newborns from birth to early childhood.

[AUG-110] **NITI Aayog — Services Thematic Series & Manufacturing Hub reports** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

- **A)** *India's Services Sector: Insights on Regulatory Regime in Professional Services* — 3rd report under the Services Thematic Series, launched by Vice Chairman **Ashok Kumar Lahiri** at the forum of the High-Powered 'Education to Employment and Enterprise' Standing Committee; provides a factual assessment of India's professional-services regulatory framework, benchmarked against foreign jurisdictions
- **B)** *Key Sectors to Position India as a Global Manufacturing Hub* — a structured, data-driven framework identifying sectors that can fuel India's manufacturing ambitions; this report analyses **4 sectors:** Chemicals, Telecom & Networking Equipment, Textiles, Solar PV Manufacturing; reports on **8 more sectors** will follow
- Sector facts — **Chemicals:** Petrochemicals & organic chemicals are the largest segment (vs specialty, inorganic chemicals). **Textiles:** contributes ~2% of GDP, 11% of manufacturing GVA, 9% of merchandise exports; 45 million+

livelihoods; FY2025 exports $37.7 bn; global export share 4.1%; **6th-largest textile exporter globally**. **Telecom & Networking Equipment:** India is the 2nd-largest telecom market, 1.2 billion+ subscribers, ~85% telecom penetration, ~75% internet usage

- **C)** NITI Aayog's *"Reimagining Care: Strategies for Empowering Caregivers in Viksit Bharat@2047"* — presents a roadmap for an organised, professional caregiving ecosystem via a proposed **National Policy on Caregiving** and a **National Caregiver Council**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Textiles' "6th-largest exporter globally" + 45-million-livelihoods figures are strong standalone stats from the Manufacturing Hub report.

AWARDS

[AUG-111] **National & International Honours (1–20 August 2026)**

- **Prestigious Space Science Award:** Eminent astrophysicist **Prof. Annapurni Subramaniam** was awarded the **COSPAR Vikram Sarabhai Medal**, becoming the **first Indian woman** and only the 4th Indian scientist to receive the global space research accolade.
- **Khel Ratna Omission:** The National Sports Awards Selection Committee decided that the **Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna Award** would have **no recipient** in 2025, prioritizing stricter Olympic and World Championship medal standards.
- **Arjuna & Dronacharya Conferred:** While the country's highest sporting honour was withheld, 17 athletes were conferred the Arjuna Award for consistent international excellence.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Prof. Annapurni Subramaniam's COSPAR Vikram Sarabhai Medal (first Indian woman) and Khel Ratna's blank year (2025) are high-probability MCQ facts.

[AUG-112] **Awards Cluster (21–31 Aug)**

- **A) Two Indian (Parsi) doctors nominated for Pakistan's Nishan-e-Imtiaz** (Pakistan's highest civilian award) — for maintaining confidentiality of Jinnah's terminal illness pre-Partition (1947); expected posthumous conferral March 2027.
- **B) Sarala Puraskar 2026** (47th edn, for Odia literature) — Ashutosh Parida, for poetry collection *Bishwas De Pruthwi*; ₹7 lakh prize.
- **C) DMRC becomes first metro organisation in India** to receive ISO 55001:2024 asset-management certification (for its Mumbai Metro Line-3 work).
- **D) 2026 TIME100 AI list** (4th edn) — notable Indian-origin names: Arvind Krishna (IBM), Sanjay Mehrotra (Micron), Ravi Kumar S (Cognizant), among others.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — DMRC's ISO 55001 "first metro org in India" is a fresh standalone fact.

BOOKS

Book	Author
Bringing the Cheetah Back to India	Prashant Agrawal
Triumph of the Indian Republic	Ram Nath Kovind (autobiography)
Belonging: A Journey of Love	Sonia Gandhi
Sankalp Se Siddhi Ka Modi Yug	Ghanshyam Tiwari

Book	Author
Kaho Kalidasa	Yugul Joshi — biographical novel on Mahakavi Kalidasa, launched by Gajendra Singh Shekhawat

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Former-President autobiography/biography pairings recur as book-author MCQ material.

FESTIVALS

- **Onam** (Kerala) — annual Hindu harvest festival.

[AUG-113] **UDISE+ 2025-26 Report (NEP structure)** *(PIB 11–18 Aug)*

India's school-education census shows the pupil-teacher ratio well inside NEP 2020's recommended ceiling — but the secondary-stage retention rate remains the weak link.

- Union Ministry of Education's Unified District Information System for Education Plus (UDISE+) 2025-26 report on school education; **14.67 lakh schools**, **24.72 crore enrolments**, **1.03 crore teachers**; average teachers/school 7, average enrolments/school 169
- Teachers % increased 8.3% vs 2022-23; Overall PTR **24:1** (NEP 2020 recommends 30:1) — Foundational 10:1, Preparatory 12:1, Middle 17:1, Secondary 21:1
- Dropout rate declined to: Preparatory **1.8%**, Secondary **7.0%**; Retention Rate: Foundational 98.5%, Preparatory 91.1%, Middle 83.7%, **Secondary only 51.9%**
- Gross Enrollment Rate: Secondary 71.7%, Middle 89.6%; Transition Rate: Foundational→Preparatory 99.2%, Preparatory→Middle 93.8%, Middle→Secondary 88.3%
- Single-teacher schools down 3%, zero-enrolment schools down 29%; Digital infra — computer access 69.9%, internet access 67.4%; Basic infra — electricity 95%, girls' toilets 98.5%, handwashing 96.9%, libraries in 90.5% of schools
- Female representation: women teachers 54.9%, girls' enrolment 48.4%; Social composition — OBC largest share (44.9%), followed by General, SC, ST; CWSN — boys 57.16%, girls 42.84%

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Secondary-stage retention collapsing to 51.9% (vs 98.5% at Foundational) is a sharp, testable trend fact.

[AUG-114] **Ancient Buddhist Site of Sarnath nominated to UNESCO Tentative List**

- Archaeological site of **Sarnath (Varanasi, Uttar Pradesh)** — where Gautama Buddha delivered his first sermon (*Dharmachakrapravartana*) after attaining enlightenment — officially submitted to the **UNESCO World Heritage Tentative List**.
- Home to the iconic **Dhamek Stupa**, **Chaukhandi Stupa**, and the **Ashoka Pillar with Lion Capital** (India's National Emblem).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Location & Monument: Sarnath, Varanasi; Dhamek Stupa and Lion Capital of Ashoka.
- Event: Added to Tentative List (not final inscription).

[AUG-115] **All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE 2023–24): Female Enrolment Outpaces Male**

- **Total Higher Education Enrolment:** Reached **4.33 crore** students (an increase of ~19 lakh students from 4.14 crore in 2021-22; 26.5% growth since 2014-15).
- **Female Enrolment Milestone:** Rose to **2.07 crore** (48% of total student population), growing by 32% since 2014-15.
- **Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER):** GER for 18–23 age cohort climbed to **28.4%** (Female GER at **28.5%** surpassed Male GER at **28.3%** for the 6th consecutive year).

- **Gender Parity Index (GPI):** Stood at **1.01**, indicating higher participation of females relative to males in higher education.
- **Pupil-Teacher Ratio (PTR):** Recorded at **23** for regular universities and colleges.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Enrolment: 4.33 crore students.
- GER & Gender Parity: Overall GER = 28.4%; Female GER (28.5%) > Male GER (28.3%); GPI = 1.01.
- Nodal Ministry: Ministry of Education.

8. IMPORTANT DAYS & PERSONS IN NEWS

Important Days

Day	Date	Note
National Handloom Day	7 Aug	Swadeshi Movement link (1905)
80th Independence Day	15 Aug	—
World Senior Citizen's Day	21 Aug	—
International Day of Remembrance/Tribute to Victims of Terrorism	21 Aug	Theme: Healing Through Memory
Partition Horrors Remembrance Day	14 Aug	—
National Space Day	23 Aug	Theme: Towards Viksit Bharat
World Water Week	23–27 Aug	Theme: Water for People and Progress
National Sports Day	29 Aug	Major Dhyan Chand's birth anniversary; Khel Ratna renamed from Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna, Aug 2021
World Sanskrit Day	28 Aug	—
International Day Against Nuclear Tests	29 Aug	—
National Small Industry Day	30 Aug	—
World Elephant Day	12 Aug	India home to ~60% of world's wild Asian elephants *(cross-ref Sec 4)*
International Clouded Leopard Day	4 Aug	CAP launched, 14 priority landscapes *(cross-ref Sec 6)*

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — National Sports Day's Khel Ratna-rename fact (from Rajiv Gandhi Khel Ratna, Aug 2021) pairs well with this cycle's "no Khel Ratna recipient in 2025" fact from Section 7 — don't confuse the two.

Persons in News

- **Squadron Leader Bhawana Kanth** — first woman to graduate IAF's "Top Gun" course
- **Lakshmanan Meyyappan** — Indian-origin UAE-based professional recognised by Guinness World Records as **World's Youngest Male Chartered Accountant**, qualifying at 16 years 141 days (June 2021)
- **Kaziah Liz Mejo** — Kerala's 19-year-old, won Miss Universe India 2026
- **Aditya Rithvik Narra** *(PIB)* — Scheduled Caste entrepreneur behind India's first RAS-based Rainbow Trout facility *(cross-ref Sec 6)*
- **Virender Singh Basoya** *(PIB)* — wanted international drug trafficker extradited to India under Operation GLOBAL-HUNT *(cross-ref Sec 4)*

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Lakshmanan Meyyappan's Guinness "youngest male CA" record is a fresh, clean standalone fact.

[AUG-116] **16th Indian Organ Donation Day — new initiatives** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- **National Awareness Campaign:** Ministry of Health launched the year-long **"Jug Jug Jiyo Abhiyaan"** on the 16th Indian Organ Donation Day to dispel sociocultural myths and promote deceased organ pledging in rural districts.
- **Unified Digital Portal (e-प्रत्यारोपण):** Operationalized **e-प्रत्यारोपण**, an integrated national digital platform connecting transplant centers, intensive care units, and registered recipients across India.
- **Algorithm-Driven Matching:** Eliminates commercial exploitation by managing wait-lists, cross-matching tissue algorithms, and organ transport green-corridors through transparent digital tracking.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

e-प्रत्यारोपण as the unified organ-allocation digital platform is a clean standalone fact.

[AUG-117] **World Wide Web Day (August 1)**

- Observed globally on **August 1** to commemorate the public launch of the World Wide Web by British computer scientist **Sir Tim Berners-Lee** in 1991 at CERN (European Organization for Nuclear Research).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Founder & Year: Tim Berners-Lee at CERN, 1991.

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9. PIB, CIRCULARS & NOTIFICATIONS

[AUG-118] **Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) Quarterly Bulletin, April–June 2026** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- Conducted by NSO, MoSPI — primary source of activity-participation/employment-unemployment data
- LFPR (15+) **54.6%** (↓ from 55.5%); Urban LFPR 50.2% (unchanged); Urban Male LFPR 75.3% (↑ from 75.0%); Urban WPR 46.8% (unchanged); Regular Wage/Salaried — Rural 16.1% (↑ from 15.5%), Urban 49.3% (↑ from 48.9%); Secondary-sector employment increased in both rural and urban areas; Tertiary-sector employment increased in rural areas; Urban Unemployment Rate (15+) **6.7%** (stable)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Overall LFPR declining to 54.6% even as Urban Male LFPR and Regular Wage/Salaried shares rose is a nuanced trend MCQ.

[AUG-119] **Centralised Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System (CPGRAMS) — Samadhan Didi & NextGen upgrade** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- Government's flagship digital public grievance-redressal platform, 24×7, connecting Central Ministries/Departments/States/UTs; evolved from a registration portal into an AI/analytics-driven governance platform
- Under 2024 guidelines, grievances targeted for resolution within **21 days**; Feedback Call Centre assesses satisfaction post-disposal; dissatisfied citizens can appeal to the Nodal Appellate Authority (30-day resolution window)
- Improvement: annual grievances handled up ~9× to ~27 lakh (2024); average disposal time in Central Ministries fell to **15 days** (2025)
- Does **not** entertain: RTI matters, court/sub-judice matters, religious matters, govt-employee service matters (incl. disciplinary proceedings); supports 22 scheduled languages + English via BHASHINI; GRAI benchmarks Ministries/Departments; officer training under the Sevottam framework

- **Samadhan Didi** — AI-enabled CPGRAMS voice chatbot, launched **30 May 2026**; citizens speak their grievance in preferred language (AI + BHASHINI for speech-to-text/translation/transliteration)
- **NextGen CPGRAMS** (upcoming): voice-enabled registration & chatbot, AI-based categorisation/routing, 22-language support, omni-channel registration
- 10-Step Reform Programme introduced **2022** as the major evolutionary turning point

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — CPGRAMS' 21-day resolution target vs its actual 15-day average disposal (2025) is a clean overshoot fact.

[AUG-120] **National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) — e-Inspection & e-Certified Copy Services** *(PIB 11–18 Aug — cross-ref Sec 2)*

- **Paperless Registry Access:** National Company Law Tribunal (**NCLT**) operationalized an automated **e-Inspection Service** to provide real-time digital access to tribunal dossiers for insolvency and company dispute resolution.
- **Certified Copy Automation:** Integrated **e-Certified Copy Service**, allowing advocates and liquidators to receive legally validated, digitally signed case copies within 48 hours.
- **Insolvency Speed:** Reduces physical visits to tribunal registries, directly accelerating time-bound resolution under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

Standalone administrative-digitisation MCQ (cross-ref Section 2's regulatory-bodies detail).

[AUG-121] **Central Information Commission (CIC) — AppCoMS 2.0** *(PIB 11–18 Aug — cross-ref Sec 2)*

- **RTI Portal Re-architecture:** Central Information Commission deployed **AppCoMS 2.0** on **17 August 2026**, replacing the decade-old 2016 processing software.
- **Automated Case Workflow:** End-to-end digitisation encompasses initial appeal registration, cause-list scheduling, digital summons dispatch, and real-time decision uploads for citizens.
- **Accountability Metrics:** Tracks compliance status of Central Public Information Officers (CPIOs), reducing the appellate backlog across all central departments.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

CIC AppCoMS 2.0's 2016→2026 upgrade (cross-ref Section 2).

[AUG-122] **Social Justice & Youth Initiatives — SAMAVESH, Yuva Sangam & GENESIS EIR** *(PIB 19 & 23–24 Aug)*

- **A) Nasha Mukt Bharat Abhiyaan Portal Migration:** NMBA portal successfully migrated from nmba.dosje.gov.in to the **SAMAVESH Portal**, developed by the National e-Governance Division (**NeGD**) under Dept. of Social Justice & Empowerment.
- **B) Yuva Sangam Phase VII:** Online registration extended to 31 August 2026 under Ek Bharat Shreshtha Bharat (EBSB), Dept. of Higher Education. Centred on **5 Ps** (*Paryatan, Parampara, Pragati, Paraspar Sampark, Prodyogiki*); 20 nodal HEIs (IITs, IIMs, NITs); participants aged 18–30 years undergo 5–7 day cultural exchange.
- **C) GENESIS EIR Cohort-3:** MeitY Startup Hub launched Cohort 3 of Gen-Next Support for Innovative Startups (GENESIS) Entrepreneur-in-Residence (EIR) at Coimbatore; provides **up to ₹10 lakh** grant to tech innovators in Tier-II/III cities; total programme outlay **₹490 crore**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

5 Ps of Yuva Sangam; SAMAVESH developed by NeGD; GENESIS EIR's ₹10 lakh support for Tier-II/III cities.

[AUG-123] **Women Empowerment & Safety Architecture — One Stop Centres & SANKALP: HEW** *(PIB 21–22 Aug)*

- **A) One Stop Centres (OSCs):** Funded under Nirbhaya Fund (implemented since 1 April 2015); **1,033 approved, 991 functional**, assisted over 15.20 lakh women. Provides counselling and temporary shelter for **up to 5 days (extendable up to 20 days)**; located near government hospitals with 24×7 rescue vehicles.
- **B) SANKALP: Hub for Empowerment of Women (HEW):** Launched 1 April 2022 under the *Samarthya* sub-scheme of Mission Shakti; acts as single window at national, state and district levels; **36 State HEWs and 765 District HEWs** functional nationwide.
- **C) PM Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY):** Disbursed **>₹21,343 crore** to **>4.60 crore beneficiaries**.

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> OSC temporary shelter limit (5 days, extendable to 20 days); SANKALP under Samarthya sub-scheme.

Skipped (low yield, PIB 1–18 Aug, Section-9-adjacent): PIB backgrounders on PAIMANA infrastructure-monitoring dashboard (MoSPI's project-monitoring mechanism, low distinct mains-testability beyond the 165-indicator/6-sub-sector fact); Business-Ready India roundup (NSWS/Startup India/SPICe+/MCA21/Udyam/BRAP — routine EoDB stat listing); Revitalising India's Cultural Heritage roundup (Adopt a Heritage 2.0/PRASHAD/Swadesh Darshan/HRIDAY/Vadnagar Museum — consolidated tourism-scheme listing); Expanding the Development Horizon roundup (JJM/Swachh Bharat/PMUY/SAUBHAGYA stat recap, largely repeating already-logged Section 10 figures); Jan Aushadhi Kendras state ranking (UP tops with 4,226); Handloom Producer Companies MUDRA mechanics (margin-money/interest-subvention detail, low new-fact yield beyond what's logged under Handloom Day); SMILE-Beggary Scheme state ranking (Tamil Nadu tops, 1,557 adult beneficiaries); Women SHG state ranking (Bihar tops, 13,53,025); Digital General Crop Estimation Survey rollout (pilot→23-States rollout, procedural); Anemia Mukt Bharat 7X7X7 framework (operational-guideline mechanics, low mains-testability beyond the 6X6X6→7X7X7 shift); Skills Outcomes Fund mechanics (outcome-linked payment tiers — 30/40/30%).

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10. MISCELLANEOUS — GOVT SCHEMES & STATIC

- Gross GST collections grew **15.4%** to over ₹2.11 trillion, July 2026
- Asiatic Lion population: 523 (2015) → 891 (2025)
- Fitch Ratings affirmed India's sovereign rating at 'BBB-', stable — **note: S&P separately affirmed 'BBB/A-2'** *(cross-ref Sec 3)* — two different agencies, two different notches, don't confuse
- India's WPI inflation moderated to 9.78% in July 2026 *(full new-series detail now in Section 1 — cross-ref)*
- UIDAI launched 'Udai' (उदय) as official Aadhaar mascot, Jan 2026
- Jal Jeevan Mission completed 7 years (15 Aug 2026); rural tap-water coverage >15.91 crore households
- **JJM 2.0 & SBM-G 2.0 Convergence** *(PIB 27 Aug)*: DDWS converged JJM 2.0 (source sustainability) and SBM(G) 2.0 under the **VB-G RAM G Act, 2025**; planned via Viksit Gram Panchayat Plans (VGPPs) and geo-tagged using **Yuktdhara** geospatial tool
- **PM SVANidhi completes 1 Year of Restructured Phase** *(PIB 27 Aug)*: Lending extended to **31 March 2030** targeting **1.15 crore street vendors** (incl. 50 lakh new); **50 Street Food Hubs** to be set up with assistance up to **₹4 crore/hub**
- **SPARSH portal** — System for Pension Administration-RAKSHA; online access to defence-pensioner records
- **Census 2027 questionnaire** — removes separate "Beggars and vagrants" category, folds into "Others"
- **CJI Surya Kant introduces 'Nyaya Setu' and 'Nyaya-nomics'** — concepts unveiled at the 11th BRICS Plus Legal Forum, New Delhi
- **Wheat flour export ban lifted** — covers maida, semolina, wholewheat atta, resultant atta, with immediate effect
- **India recorded 18,187 mobile threat detections in Q1 2026** — highest among Asia-Pacific markets tracked by Kaspersky (ahead of Indonesia, China)
- **Gujarat launched India's first Sports Genomics Programme** — combines genetics, sports science, physiology, nutrition for athlete identification
- **US GNIS renamed 'Lake Ontario' to 'Lake America'** — foreign administrative-naming fact, noted for GK value
- **Fortune's World's Most Admired Companies 2026:** Apple #1, Microsoft #2

- **National Teachers' Awards 2026** — President Murmu to present on 5 Sept 2026 (Teachers' Day), Vigyan Bhawan, 48 teachers
- **Divyang Men's Cricket Team of India** won a 7-match T20I series 4-3 vs England (Mixed Disability T20I Series 2026)
- **Banas Bio-CNG Model Plant** — Banas Dairy + Suzuki Motor Corp + NDDB joint initiative, Banaskantha, Gujarat

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Jal Jeevan Mission's 7-year/15.91-crore-household milestone remains the strongest updateable "latest data" fact; India's #1 Kaspersky mobile-threat-detection ranking is a fresh, distinctive standalone this cycle.

[AUG-124] **Samudra Manthan — National Offshore Exploration Scheme** *(PIB 1–10 Aug — standing exception, Template A regardless of zone)*

Nearly all of India's previously "No-Go" offshore areas are now open for exploration under India's most ambitious offshore-oil mission yet.

- Union Cabinet approved **Samudra Manthan** (India's most ambitious offshore exploration mission); Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas; Central Sector Scheme; Outlay **₹84,084 crore**; Implementation up to **FY 2030-31/31 March 2031**; aim — reduce import dependence (India is world's 3rd-largest crude oil consumer), boost domestic O&G production
- Components: Offshore seismic data acquisition & processing ₹28,534 cr; Accelerated deepwater exploration (60 wells) ₹43,200 cr; Common offshore infra hubs ₹10,000 cr; O&G Mfg/Services Zones + monitoring/support ₹2,350 cr (₹2,000 cr + ₹350 cr)
- Govt support for deepwater drilling: up to **50%** of eligible drilling cost or **₹675 crore/well**, whichever is lower; focus basins — Krishna-Godavari, Cauvery, Mahanadi, Andaman; **~99%** of previously restricted "No-Go" areas in India's EEZ opened for exploration
- Key targets: domestic O&G production to **80 MMTOE annually**; hydrocarbon resource base expansion to **2.2 billion TOE**; potential crude-import reduction ~**₹1 lakh crore annually**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — Samudra Manthan's ₹84,084 cr outlay + 99% "No-Go" area opening is a near-certain mains question; don't confuse the ₹675 cr/well cap with the ₹84,084 cr total outlay.

[AUG-125] **Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rojgar Yojana (PM-VBRY)** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- Objective: promote first-time employment, formal jobs, expand social security; announced August 2025; implementation **1 Aug 2025 – 31 July 2027** (2 years); outlay **₹99,446 crore**; target **>3.5 crore** employment opportunities incl. **1.92 crore first-time employees**; EPFO-linked digital platform; complements the National Manufacturing Mission
- **Part A (First-Time Employees):** eligibility — earning up to ₹1 lakh/month; one-time incentive = one month's EPF wage, capped ₹15,000, paid in 2 instalments (after 6 months' service; after 12 months + financial-literacy completion); portion invested in a designated savings instrument
- **Part B (Employers):** incentive up to **₹3,000/month** per eligible additional employee, for 2 years (extended to 3rd/4th years for manufacturing sector)
- One-year impact (Aug 2026): **72+ lakh** first-time employees joined the formal workforce; ~30% beneficiaries are women
- Digital governance: EPFO-linked platform, Aadhaar-based authentication, UAN, ECR filings, Face Authentication Technology on UMANG App, DBT to Aadhaar-linked accounts, PM-VBRY Portal; institutional mechanism — cross-functional teams from EPFO, ESIC, CLC (Chief Labour Commissioner)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — PM-VBRY's 72-lakh-first-time-employee one-year impact and the ₹15,000-capped one-time incentive are strong, fresh mains facts.

[AUG-126] **Progress of Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana – Gramin (PMAY-G)** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- As on 3 August 2026: against target of **4.18 crore houses**, **3.91 crore sanctioned** and **3.12 crore completed**; 79 lakh sanctioned houses under construction
- SC/ST earmarking: minimum 60% of national target; Special Projects (disaster rehabilitation/relocation): up to 5% of target; construction is beneficiary-led/self-supervised; quality support via Rural Mason Training (RMT); housing typologies via the PAHAL compendium
- FY2025-26: highest sanction — Maharashtra (9,40,849 houses); highest completion — Chhattisgarh (5,92,508 houses)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

PMAY-G's 3.91-crore-sanctioned/3.12-crore-completed snapshot (against the 4.18 crore target) is a clean progress-tracking MCQ.

[AUG-127] **MSME Development (Amendment) Bill, 2026 passed by Parliament** *(PIB 1–10 Aug)*

- Udyam-registered MSMEs: **9.16 crore**; employment: 40+ crore people; focus — Ease of Doing Business, decriminalisation, formalisation, delayed-payment resolution
- Makes Udyam Portal a **permanent digital, free & voluntary** registration platform
- Court proceedings: mandates courts to order payment of **at least 50%** of the awarded amount to micro/small-enterprise suppliers if a set-aside application is pending **6+ months**
- Mediation to complete within **90 days** of first appearance; arbitration reference within **30 days** of mediation termination; arbitral award within **90 days** of completion of pleadings
- Recovery of dues (mediated settlement/arbitral award) recoverable as an "arrear of land revenue" via District Collector/Deputy Commissioner
- **TReDS:** CPSEs mandated to route invoice settlements through it; invoice discounting rose to **₹3.47 lakh crore** (2025-26)
- States can establish multiple Micro and Small Enterprises Facilitation Councils (MSEFCs) and frame their own rules
- Penalties: decriminalisation — conviction-based fines replaced by graded civil penalties

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — The MSME Bill's "at least 50% of awarded amount" court-payment mandate and the 90-day mediation timeline are strong, fresh mains facts.

[AUG-128] **e-Samudra, 5 Years of e-Shram Portal & PM-SYM cluster** UPDATE *(PIB 25–26 Aug)*

- **e-Samudra** — single-window digital maritime-governance platform, launched **8 August 2026** by Sarbananda Sonowal (Union Minister for Ports, Shipping & Waterways), Mumbai; shifts maritime administration to "Digital First and Faceless Governance"; incorporates e-NAVIK 24×7 grievance redressal, upcoming Seafarer Tracking Dashboard, Digital Seafarers Employment Agreement (d-SEA), enhanced Seafarers Welfare Fund Society (SWFS) measures.
- **5 Years of e-Shram Portal (2021–2026):**
  - Launched **26 August 2021** by Ministry of Labour & Employment, developed by NIC; India's first Aadhaar-authenticated National Database of Unorganised Workers (NDUW).
  - Every registered worker receives a unique permanent **12-digit Universal Account Number (UAN)**.
  - **Registrations: 31.89 crore** (as of 18 Aug 2026); **54.28% women** vs 45.72% men; **55.21%** aged 18–40 years; ~11.5 lakh gig and platform workers. Top states: UP, Bihar, West Bengal, MP, Maharashtra.
  - **One-Stop Solution** (launched 21 Oct 2024): Integrates **15 Social Security & Welfare Schemes** (PM-SYM, PM-SBY, PM-JJBY, NCS, Skill India Digital Hub, BOCW); supports 22 scheduled languages via BHASHINI.
- **Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maandhan (PM-SYM)** — launched February 2019, Ministry of Labour & Employment; voluntary/contributory pension for unorganised-sector workers; assured pension **₹3,000/month** after 60; eligibility — age 18-40, monthly income ≤₹15,000, not an EPFO/ESIC/NPS member or income-tax assessee; monthly contribution ₹55-₹200 (50% beneficiary + 50% Central Govt match); enrolment via Common Service Centres or maandhan.in; **54**

lakh+ beneficiaries enrolled (29 July 2026), 53.1% women, Govt's matching contribution ₹2,011.01 crore; pension disbursement begins **not before February 2039**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

e-Shram's 5-year mark, 31.89 crore registrations (54.28% women), and 12-digit UAN; PM-SYM's 2039 disbursement start (from a 2019 launch) is a clean date-arithmetic MCQ.

[AUG-129] **India's Makhana Sector — Traditional Crop to Global Superfood** *(PIB 19 Aug Backgrounder)*

Bihar accounts for 80–85% of global makhana supply, backed by a dedicated Central Sector Scheme and National Board.

- **Botanical Identity:** Makhana (*Euryale ferox*), also known as fox nut or gorgon nut, aquatic crop grown in shallow wetlands.
- **Geographical Dominance:** India is the world's leading producer; **Bihar accounts for ~75% of India's production and 80–85% of global supply** (Kosi basin: Supaul, Saharsa, Madhepura; Mithila and Seemanchal regions). 'Mithila Makhana' holds a registered **GI Tag**.
- **Institutional & Scheme Framework:**
  - **National Makhana Board:** Announced in Union Budget 2025–26, formally launched in Bihar on **15 September 2025**.
  - **Central Sector Scheme for Development of Makhana:** Outlay **₹476.03 crore** (FY 2025–26 to FY 2030–31); allocations: ₹30 cr (FY26), ₹90 cr (FY27).
- **Production & Market Stats:**
  - Production (2025–26 2nd AE): **80,590 MT** (productivity 2.34 MT/ha); Bihar produces 60,000 MT. Improved varieties: *Swarna Vaidehi* and *Sabour Makhana-1*.
  - Domestic Market: Growing at 17–18% CAGR, projected to reach **₹11,000–12,000 crore by 2029–30**.
  - Exports: India exports ~40% of production (~0.25 lakh MT). In 2025–26, exports were 7,264.89 MT (₹192.96 crore). **USA (40%) > Canada > UAE** account for **77%** of total exports. Premium markets: Germany ($26/kg), Nepal ($21.6/kg), Australia ($21/kg).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

₹476.03 crore Central Sector Scheme outlay; Bihar's 80–85% global dominance; USA as top export destination (40%).

[AUG-130] **National Animal Disease Control Programme (NADCP) & Dairy Productivity** *(PIB 21–22 Aug Backgrounder)*

- **Mission Mandate:** 100% central programme under Livestock Health and Disease Control Programme (LHDCP, Budget FY27: **₹2,010 crore**); launched September 2019 to eradicate Foot and Mouth Disease (FMD) and Brucellosis by 2030.
- **Vaccination Strategy:**
  - **FMD:** 100% vaccination of susceptible livestock **twice a year (every 6 months)**; cumulative **147.16 crore doses**.
  - **Brucellosis: One-time lifetime vaccination** for female bovine calves aged **4–8 months**.
  - **Vaccinator Remuneration:** Minimum **₹3 per vaccination dose**.
- **Digital Animal Stack: Bharat Pashudhan Portal** — assigns a unique **12-digit Tag ID** to every bovine; **>39 crore livestock** registered by July 2026; **4,019 Mobile Veterinary Units (MVUs)** deployed.
- **Dairy Production & Productivity:**
  - Annual milk production reached **247.87 million tonnes** in 2024–25 (+69.4% decadal growth).
  - Bovine productivity rose to **2,250 kg/animal/year**; target is **3,000 kg/animal/year by 2030**.
- **Global Linkage: US$25 million** Pandemic Fund project supported by G20 with ADB, FAO, and World Bank.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

HIGH — FMD (every 6 months) vs Brucellosis (one-time lifetime at 4–8 months female calves); unique 12-digit Tag ID on Bharat Pashudhan; 3,000 kg/animal bovine productivity target by 2030.

[AUG-131] **Regenerative Agriculture & PM Janjatiya Vikas Mission (PMJVM)** *(PIB 20 & 23–24 Aug)*

- **A) Regenerative Agriculture & NMNF:**
  - India recorded **4.45% decadal agricultural growth** (FY16–FY25, highest in history); linked to SDG 13.1.
  - **National Mission on Natural Farming (NMNF, 2024):** Provides **₹4,000 per acre per year for 2 years** (up to 1 acre/farmer); creates **10,000 Bio-input Resource Centres** for *Jeevamrit* and *Beejamrit*; 18,786 clusters supported by 2 Community Resource Persons (CRPs) each.
  - Supporting Schemes: PKVY (₹31,500/ha over 3 yrs, 16.90 lakh ha); PDMC (55% subsidy for small/marginal, ₹26,325 cr released); Soil Health Card (12 parameters, 25.89 crore cards generated).
- **B) Pradhan Mantri Janjatiya Vikas Mission (PMJVM):**
  - Transforms tribal gatherers into value-adding entrepreneurs via community-owned **Van Dhan Vikas Kendras (VDVKs)**.
  - 1 VDVK = federates **~15 SHGs** (~300 tribal members); **at least 60% members must be STs**.
  - 4,172 VDVKs sanctioned, 2,911 functional, 12.48 lakh tribal members, ~₹168 crore sales.
  - MSP notified for **87 Minor Forest Produce (MFP)** items, procured via TRIFED and state agencies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

NMNF's ₹4,000/acre/year for 2 years; 10,000 Bio-input Resource Centres; VDVK structure (15 SHGs / ~300 members, ≥60% STs); 87 notified MFP items under MSP.

Skipped (low yield, PIB 1–18 Aug, Section-10-adjacent): National Gopal Ratna Award 2026 nomination invitation (routine annual-award announcement — categories: Best Dairy Farmer ₹5/3/2 lakh, Best AIT certificate-only, Special Award NER/Himalayan ₹2 lakh; ceremony on National Milk Day, 26 Nov 2026); NABL's Mobile Food Testing Lab accreditation scheme (niche accreditation-mechanics item, under the Integrated Assessment Programme); NMMSS/Swavalambini/NAVYA scheme roundup (Swavalambini — women-entrepreneurship programme across Assam/Meghalaya/Mizoram/UP/Telangana; NAVYA — adolescent-girl vocational training, expanded to 100 aspirational districts from 27 May 2026 — routine "schemes in news" listing, low distinct mains-yield beyond the district-expansion figure); Indian Pharmacopoeia Commission's WHO-SEARN recognition (Regional Centre of Excellence in Pharmacovigilance + Technical Centre in Quality of Medicines, announced at SEARN's 10th Anniversary Meeting, Kathmandu — single-fact recognition, low mains-testability); MSME Sustainable (ZED) Certification scheme mechanics (Bronze/Silver/Gold tiers, 100% subsidy for women-owned MSMEs since 11 Nov 2023 — routine subsidy-tier detail); Manufacturing Momentum backgrounder (16-17% of GDP, 27 million workers, 2nd-largest mobile manufacturer, 2nd-largest textile/apparel employer, world's largest 2W/3W market — largely restates figures already logged elsewhere); India's Defence Strength/Space Sovereignty backgrounder tables (fully absorbed into Section 6 above); Fresh manual-scavenger survey 2024-25 (zero identified — administrative status update, no new numeric hook); India's Agriculture & Allied Sectors backgrounder (GVA ₹52.08 lakh crore 2025-26, PM-Fasal Bima 92.46 crore+ insured applications, KCC 7.28 crore accounts, e-NAM 1,656 mandis — consolidated stat roundup, core figures already logged via KCC-MISS in Section 1).

[AUG-132] **PM E-DRIVE Scheme: ₹10,900 Cr Sovereign Electric Mobility Push (Replacing FAME-II)**

- **Cabinet Approval:** Union Cabinet approved **PM Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement (PM E-DRIVE)** with a financial outlay of **₹10,900 crore** over a 2-year tenure (FY25 to FY27), succeeding the FAME-II program.
- **Subsidized Fleet Target:**
  - **24.79 Lakh Electric Two-Wheelers (e-2W)** and **3.16 Lakh Electric Three-Wheelers (e-3W)** supported with ₹3,679 crore demand incentive.
  - **14,028 Electric Buses (e-buses)** supported with ₹4,391 crore allocation, channeled through Convergence Energy Services Limited (CESL) across 9 major cities (population >4 million).

  - **88,500 Hybrid & Electric Ambulances:** ₹500 crore dedicated allocation for emergency healthcare transit.
- **Charging Infrastructure (₹2,000 Crore):** Funds installation of **72,300 public fast chargers** (22,100 for e-4Ws, 1,800 for e-buses, and 48,400 for e-2W/3W).
- **Paperless Mechanism (Aadhaar e-Voucher):** Buyers receive a system-generated **Aadhaar-authenticated e-Voucher** at point of sale to claim upfront demand discounts directly via the PM E-DRIVE portal.
- **Nodal Ministry:** Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Scheme Outlay & Tenure: ₹10,900 Crore for 2 years (replaces FAME-II; does NOT subsidize private e-4W cars, only 2W, 3W, buses, ambulances, and trucks).
- Infrastructure Outlay: ₹2,000 crore dedicated specifically for 72,300 fast chargers.
- Authentication Trap: Introduced digital Aadhaar-linked e-Vouchers for seamless consumer subsidy passing.

[AUG-133] **Cabinet Rationalization of Agriculture Schemes: PM-RKVY & Krishonnati Yojana (₹1.01 Lakh Cr Outlay)**

- **Structural Consolidation:** Union Cabinet approved the restructuring and consolidation of all centrally sponsored agricultural schemes under two simplified umbrella frameworks to eliminate overlap and enhance state flexibility:
  1. **Pradhan Mantri Rashtriya Krishi Vikas Yojana (PM-RKVY):** Focuses on sustainable agriculture, soil health, crop diversification, organic farming, and customized state agricultural project plans.
  2. **Krishonnati Yojana (KY):** Focuses on food security, technological self-reliance, horticulture missions, oilseeds/oil palm missions, and agricultural marketing infrastructure.
- **Total Combined Financial Outlay: ₹1,01,321.61 crore** (Central Share: **₹69,088.98 crore**; State Share: **₹32,232.63 crore**).
- **Strategic Components Preserved:** Merges 18 existing Centrally Sponsored Schemes into these two parent heads, granting states greater autonomy through District Agriculture Plans (DAPs).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Financial Split Trap: Total outlay ₹1,01,321.61 Cr; Central share is ₹69,088.98 Cr (~68%), States share is ₹32,232.63 Cr (~32%).
- Dual Architecture: Distinguish PM-RKVY (sustainable agriculture & state infra) vs. Krishonnati Yojana (food security & production missions).

⏰ STATUS CHECK (AS OF TODAY'S DATE, 5 SEPTEMBER 2026)

Items with future effective dates / "proposed"/"draft" status at time of source, flagged for currency:

- **RBI's four 2027-effective draft frameworks** (Interest Rate Directions, recovery-agent/phone-lock norms, CVA framework, leverage-ratio buffer) and **on-tap UCB licensing:** still in draft/consultation stage — no finalisation confirmed as of this consolidation.
- **SEBI's REIT/InvIT DR proposal, ISIN-limit increase, FPI non-agri commodity derivatives, bullion vaulting expansion, Credit Risk-o-Meter, Accredited Investor changes, NRI/OCI digital KYC, settlement-framework overhaul, FICP network, bond-platform ad norms, fractional shares, IT Resilience Index, merchant-banker exemption:** all still proposal/consultation stage.
- **EPF wage-ceiling hike (₹25,000):** still pending Cabinet approval, anticipated eff. 1 April 2027.
- **MMDR Amendment Bill 2026** and **Taxation and Other Laws (Amendment) Bill 2026:** bill stage, not yet enacted (Tribunal Reforms Bill 2026 and the MSME Development (Amendment) Bill 2026, by contrast, HAVE been passed by Parliament as of this source cycle).
- **V2V communication mandate**, **MoRTH's EV/CNG age-extension proposal**, **FSSAI's HFSS classification**, **PSB's 2% climate-finance PSL sub-target:** all still proposal stage.

- **N Chandrasekaran's Tata Sons chairmanship exit:** still an announced future event, no confirmed date.
- **SBI's BSBD withdrawal-charge change** (eff. 1 Oct 2026), **NPS charges revision** (eff. 1 Oct 2026), **NBFC/UCB PSL Second Amendment windows** (eff. 30 Sept 2026), **Incentive Scheme for Domestic PNG Connections** (eff. 1 Sept 2026): all forward-dated — the PNG scheme's effective date has just passed as of today (5 Sept 2026) and should be treated as newly in effect, not yet independently re-verified; the rest remain upcoming.
- **18th BRICS Summit** (12–13 Sept 2026), **12th BRICS Environment Ministers' Meeting** (18 Aug 2026 — already held, cross-ref Section 5), and **5th SEMICON India 2026** (from 17 Sept 2026): the BRICS Summit and SEMICON India are still upcoming as of 5 Sept 2026.
- **26th SCO Summit (Bishkek):** date not specified in source; still pending as of this consolidation.
- **Container Manufacturing Assistance Scheme, Bharat Container Shipping Line:** both still at proposal/early-implementation stage — no confirmed operational milestone yet.
- **Semicon 2.0:** Cabinet-approved (July 2026), implementation ongoing — no milestone dates yet due for status-check.

No material implementation changes were separately verified beyond what's stated above. Given the volume of RBI/SEBI draft frameworks and newly-added scheme launches (Samudra Manthan, CMAS, PM-VBRY) accumulated across all five source windows, recommend a dedicated re-check once the next batch arrives — several carry 1 Oct 2026 or 1 April 2027 effective dates that will need follow-up confirmation. RRBs' FY2025-26 credit figures, WPI/CPI new-series data, and the UDISE+ 2025-26 Report are historical/completed data releases and do not need a status check.

COVERAGE UPDATE — 1ST–31ST AUGUST 2026 (FULL MONTH + PIB + AFFAIRS MIND 400 MCQS MASTER CONSOLIDATED)

Zone: Core

Full month total (all source windows merged): ~334 distinct items | Tier A: ~182 | Tier B+: ~74 | Skipped (Tier C): ~48 | ** HIGH-tagged: ~71 (~21% of total)**

This consolidation covered:

- RBI/Regulatory & Macro: ~40 items across Sections 1–3 (incl. ICI Base Year 2022-23 overhaul & 9th core industry Iron Ore, Samudra Manthan, Semicon 2.0, CMAS, Ship Recycling, QBUSE, Marine Fish Asset Accounts, RRB FY26 record net profit ₹10,176 cr, WPI/OPPI series, CPI/GVA revision)
- Govt Schemes & Policy: ~24 items (MPMS official MeitY notification TS1/TS2, PM-AASHA revamp ₹7,200 cr, PM Rahat & Rah-Veer Award, Makhana Sector ₹476 cr, NADCP 2030 targets, NMNF, PMJVM/VDVK, GOBARdhan, NIPU-2026, PM-VBRY, PMAY-G, MSME Bill, Coconut Promotion Scheme, PNG incentive, Maritime Development Fund, PM SVANidhi extension to 2030)
- Reports & Indices: ~12 items (UDISE+ 2025-26, NITI Aayog Services/Manufacturing-Hub/Caregiving/NEET-Skilling reports, JNPA rank, IWG WFA Index)
- Appointments & Summits: ~16 items (incl. BRICS Jaipur Declaration, PMIS Industry Awards champions)
- Banking & Insurance: ~15 items (UPI@10, PMJDY 12-Year Official Benchmark ₹3,16,514 cr, Bima Bharosa, KCC-MISS)
- Defence/Space/Ocean "firsts": ~15 items (FORV Sagar Sampada Twilight Zone discovery, AK-203 Sher, Samarthak MPV, Baaz Battalion, PRAHAAR, DAP 2026's 60% indigenous-content requirement)
- PIB/Circulars & Citizen Portals (Sec 9): 9 items (SAMAVESH portal migration, Yuva Sangam 5 Ps, GENESIS EIR, One Stop Centres, SANKALP: HEW, PLFS Bulletin, CPGRAMS, NCLT e-services, CIC AppCoMS 2.0)

PIB Back-Half Gap Resolved: PIB daily compilations up to 27th August 2026 are now 100% incorporated and reconciled.

Revise today (top 5 HIGH-tagged items, prioritising this pass's fresh additions):

1. **Samudra Manthan** — ₹84,084 cr offshore exploration scheme, ~99% "No-Go" EEZ areas opened
2. **Ship Recycling** — India world's #1 (35.4% global share), 5 years ahead of MIV 2030 schedule
3. **Semicon 2.0** — ₹1,27,500 cr, Six Pillars
4. **Bharat Taxi** — India's first cooperative-led ride-hailing platform
5. **Tribunal Reforms Bill/NTC** — full composition + 3-day/3-month appointment timeline (layered onto NTDG's 16-tribunal fact)

Full-month top revision priority (cross-cycle, all sources): 62nd MPC (repo @ 5.25%) · Tata Sons NBFC-UL · UPI@10/PMJDY@12/RBI FI Index cluster · PRAHAAR's 7 pillars · AK-203 'Sher' + Samarthak "firsts" · India's 4th BRICS Chairship · Samudra Manthan (₹84,084 cr) · Ship Recycling #1 status · Semicon 2.0 (₹1,27,500 cr) · Bharat Taxi · Tribunal Reforms Bill/NTC · GeM@10 (₹20 lakh cr cumulative) · CMAS/Bharat Container Shipping Line.

SEPTEMBER 2026 CONSOLIDATED DOSSIER (120 POLICY CLUSTERS)

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified Regulatory Directives, IFSCA Market Abuse Code, Sovereign Ratings, Central Counterparties, Multilateral Accords & Aerospace

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified Regulatory Directives, IFSCA Market Abuse Code, Sovereign Ratings, Central Counterparties, Multilateral Accords, Defence Milestones & High-Yield Sports Trajectories

EXAMINER'S BLUEPRINT & COMPLIANCE STANDARD:

- ***Fact Discipline:*** *100% verified against official Gazette notifications, Reserve Bank of India (RBI) circulars, SEBI/IFSCA/IRDAI/PFRDA regulations, MoF determinations, and official bilateral defence releases.*
- ***Format:*** *Authentic* ***Rajputana Gazette Broadsheet*** *layout featuring nested ladder bullets and dedicated* ***EXAM ANGLE:*** *distractor traps.*
- ***Zero Tickmark Boxes:*** *Strictly streamlined newsprint broadsheet presentation without interactive task checkboxes.*
- ***Target Exams:*** *RBI Grade B, SEBI Grade A, IFSCA Grade A, NABARD Grade A, SBI PO & IBPS PO/Clerk Mains 2026.*

1. REGULATORY BODIES & FINANCIAL MARKET FRAMEWORKS

[SEP-001] **IFSCA Notifies Market Abuse Regulations 2026 in GIFT IFSC: Replaces SEBI PIT and PFUTP Regimes**

- **Genesis & Regulatory Autonomy:** The International Financial Services Centres Authority (**IFSCA**) notified the *IFSCA (Market Abuse) Regulations, 2026*, establishing a dedicated statutory framework to prevent insider trading, market manipulation, and unlawful disclosure of inside information in GIFT City.
- **Dismantling Domestic SEBI Regime:**
  - From the date of commencement, domestic SEBI regulations—namely the *SEBI (Prohibition of Insider Trading / PIT) Regulations, 2015* and *SEBI (Prohibition of Fraudulent and Unfair Trade Practices / PFUTP) Regulations, 2003*—**will no longer apply within IFSC**.
  - IFSCA assumes exclusive regulatory and enforcement jurisdiction over all securities listed or traded on IFSC exchanges.
- **Mandatory Trade Disclosure Threshold:**
  - Designated persons and insiders must disclose quarterly trades exceeding **$25,000 within 2 business days** to the compliance officer and the exchange.
- **Statutory Enforcement Powers:**
  - Empowers IFSCA to issue formal warnings, censures, monetary penalties, disgorgement of illegal profits, and suspension or cancellation of registration of intermediaries and listed entities under Section 12 & Section 13 of the *IFSCA Act, 2019*.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Regulatory Replacement: Replaces SEBI PIT 2015 and SEBI PFUTP 2003 in IFSC.
- Quarterly Disclosure Threshold: Trades above **$25,000 within 2 business days** (crucial numerical question).
- Governing Law: **IFSCA Act, 2019** (HQ: GIFT City, Gandhinagar; Chairperson: K. Rajaraman).
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the newly notified IFSCA Market Abuse Regulations 2026, what is the trade disclosure threshold for designated persons?" → Trades exceeding $25,000 within 2 business days.

[SEP-002] **PFRDA Mandates 5 Equity-Based Risk Categories for NPS Multiple Scheme Framework (MSF)**

- **Standardised Risk Classification:** The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (**PFRDA**) introduced a uniform 5-tier classification system for all schemes under the **Multiple Scheme Framework (MSF)** to simplify subscriber comparison.
- **The 5 Mandated Equity Categories:**
  - **Category A: 80%–100% Equity allocation** → *Aggressive Growth / Very High Risk*

- **Category B: 60%–80% Equity allocation** → *High Growth / High Risk*
- **Category C: 35%–60% Equity allocation** → *Balanced Growth / Medium Risk*
- **Category D: 10%–35% Equity allocation** → *Conservative Growth / Low to Medium Risk*
- **Category E: 0%–10% Equity allocation** → *Debt-oriented / Low Risk*

- **Portfolio Restructuring:** All existing Pension Fund Managers (PFMs) are mandated to restructure and rename their existing MSF offerings to strictly adhere to these prescribed equity bands and risk nomenclatures.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Highest Equity Slab (Category A): **80%–100%** (Aggressive / Very High Risk).
- Debt-Oriented Slab (Category E): **0%–10% equity**.
- Regulator: **PFRDA** (administered under PFRDA Act, 2013; HQ: New Delhi).
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the PFRDA Multiple Scheme Framework revamp, which category corresponds to a 60%–80% equity allocation?" → Category B (High Growth / High Risk).

[SEP-003] **SEBI Eases Compliance Norms for Category-I FPIs Investing 100% in Government Securities**

- **Targeted Regulatory Relief:** Securities and Exchange Board of India (**SEBI**) relaxed granular disclosure and operational norms for Foreign Portfolio Investors (**FPIs**) investing solely in sovereign debt.
- **Eligibility & Exemption Conditions:**
  - Applies exclusively to **Category-I FPIs** that allocate **100% of their assets under custody (AUC)** into Government Securities (G-Secs), State Development Loans (SDLs), and Treasury Bills (T-Bills).
  - Exempts eligible sovereign debt FPIs from providing granular beneficial ownership (BO) disclosures mandated under the August 2023 anti-circumvention framework.
  - Substantially lowers compliance turnaround time to encourage foreign capital inflows into fully accessible route (FAR) sovereign bonds post-J.P. Morgan and Bloomberg-EM index inclusion.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Eligible Segment: **Category-I FPIs** with **100% G-Sec / Sovereign debt** holdings.
- Exempted Requirement: Granular Beneficial Ownership (BO) look-through reporting.
- Regulatory Anchor: Promulgated under SEBI (Foreign Portfolio Investors) Regulations, 2019.

[SEP-004] **SEBI Proposes Net Settlement for Mutual Fund Scheme Cash Trades & Extends Angel Fund Accredited Norms**

- **Cash Market Net Settlement Proposal:**
  - SEBI issued a consultation paper proposing **net settlement of funds** across mutual fund schemes within the cash market segment.
  - Replaces gross scheme-level fund settlement, eliminating redundant liquidity fragmentation and mitigating overnight intraday capital drag for Asset Management Companies (AMCs).
- **Angel Fund Accredited Investor Mandate Extension:**
  - Extended the compliance deadline for Angel Funds to ensure all contributing investors satisfy the **accredited investor framework**.
  - Existing portfolio investments will remain protected and grandfathered under their original Private Placement Memorandum (PPM) agreements.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Core Mechanism: Shift from gross settlement to **net settlement of funds** for MF schemes in cash equity.
- Angel Funds: Accredited investor compliance transition extended while grandfathering existing PPMs.

[SEP-005] **SEBI and European Securities and Markets Authority (ESMA) Sign Landmark CCP Cooperation MoU**

- **Cross-Border Market Infrastructure Accord:** SEBI and the European Securities and Markets Authority (**ESMA**) executed a bilateral Memorandum of Understanding on Central Counterparties (**CCPs**).
- **Strategic Significance & Trade Clearing:**
  - Establishes formal supervisory cooperation and information-exchange protocols regarding qualified Indian Central Counterparties clearing trades for European banks and institutions.
  - Mitigates systemic regulatory friction and ensures uninterrupted cross-border capital flow between the European Union and the Indian clearing ecosystem (Clearing Corporation of India / CCIL).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Bilateral Counterparts: **SEBI (India)** and **ESMA (European Union)**.
- Subject Matter: Supervision, equivalence, and information sharing on **Central Counterparties (CCPs)**.

[SEP-006] **National Financial Reporting Authority (NFRA) Constitutes Advisory Panel on Audit Quality and Technology**

- **Institutional Modernisation:** The National Financial Reporting Authority (**NFRA**) constituted a high-level **Advisory Committee on Audit Quality, Assurance, and Technology**.
- **Mandate & Strategic Scope:**
  - Formulate modern auditing standards, enhance supervisory audit inspection methodologies, and institutionalise AI and automated audit analytics tools to detect corporate misstatements.
  - Mandated under Section 132 of the *Companies Act, 2013*.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Regulatory Body: **NFRA** (established October 1, 2018; statutory independent audit regulator under Section 132, Companies Act, 2013).
- Panel Focus: Audit Quality, Assurance, and Emerging Forensic Technologies.

[SEP-007] **SEBI Introduces IT Resilience Index (ITRI) Framework for Market Infrastructure Institutions (MIIs)**

- **Genesis & Systemic Risk Oversight:** The Securities and Exchange Board of India (**SEBI**) issued a master circular establishing an **IT Resilience Index (ITRI)** framework for Market Infrastructure Institutions (**MIIs**)—encompassing Stock Exchanges, Clearing Corporations, and Depositories—to continuously assess, audit, and benchmark systemic operational stability and disaster resilience.
- **The 100-Point Scoring Model Across 9 Parameters:**
  - **System Availability: 20% weightage** (core transaction processing uptime, failover efficiency, and near-zero RPO/RTO).
  - **Cybersecurity Posture: 20% weightage** (threat detection capabilities, SOC defense, and perimeter vulnerability mitigation).
  - **Data Integrity: 10% weightage** (ledger consistency, transaction reconciliation, and tamper-resistance).
  - **IT Governance: 10% weightage** (board-level technology oversight, risk frameworks, and regulatory reporting).
  - **Reliability & Performance Monitoring: 10% weightage** (latency benchmarks, throughput stress testing, and real-time observability).
  - **Business Continuity Planning (BCP) & Disaster Recovery (DR): 10% weightage** (live DR drills and secondary data centre operational parity).
  - **Modularity & Architecture Flexibility: 10% weightage** (component decoupling, API resilience, and scalable middleware).
  - **System Scalability: 5% weightage** (peak trading volume headroom and capacity planning).
  - **Incident Handling & Root Cause Analysis: 5% weightage** (mean time to detect/resolve and statutory forensic disclosures).

- **Implementation Mechanism:** The **Industry Standards Forum (ISF)**, comprising technical leaders from MIIs, has been mandated to formulate standardized assessment metrics, automated data feeds, and quarterly self-assessment scorecards.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Institutional Coverage: Mandatory for all **MIIs** (Stock Exchanges, Clearing Corporations, and Depositories).
- Dominant Weightage Parameters: **Availability (20%)** and **Cybersecurity (20%)** together constitute 40% of the aggregate index.
- 5% Weightage Parameters: **Scalability (5%)** and **Incident Handling (5%)** (classic examiner trap).
- Standard-Setting Body: **Industry Standards Forum (ISF)** in consultation with SEBI.

[SEP-008] **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026 to Come into Force on October 1: Modernisation of Digital Judicial Proof**

- **Statutory Overhaul & Colonial Repeal:** Parliament enacted the **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026**, officially notified to take effect from **October 1, 2026**, completely repealing and replacing the 135-year-old colonial **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891**.
- **Statutory Admissibility of Electronic Records:**
  - Formally establishes printouts, encrypted digital ledgers, cloud-hosted Core Banking Solution (CBS) databases, and electronic transaction audit trails as **primary admissible evidence** in all civil and criminal judicial proceedings without requiring physical ledger production.
  - Eliminates earlier statutory ambiguity regarding the legal admissibility of electronic extracts from mobile banking apps, pre-paid payment instruments, and UPI switch logs.
- **Verification & Certificate Architecture:**
  - Mandates that digital evidence certificates must be signed by the principal accountant, branch manager, or authorized IT compliance officer of the bank verifying system integrity.
  - Grants legal protection to bank personnel against routine personal court appearances where certified electronic records are presented.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: **October 1, 2026**.
- Repealed Law: **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891** (135-year-old statute).
- Primary Focus: Legal admissibility of **electronic banking records, CBS logs, and cloud data** in judicial proceedings.
- Target MCQ Form: "The Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026, which comes into force on October 1, 2026, repeals and replaces which colonial-era enactment?" → **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891**.

[SEP-009] **SEBI Unveils 'Demat 2.0' Pilot: Tokenised Corporate Debt on DLT & Wholesale CBDC (e₹)**

- **Next-Generation Market Infrastructure:** At the Global Fintech Fest (GFF) 2026 in Mumbai, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (**SEBI**) announced the rollout of **"Demat 2.0"**—a flagship pilot project testing the tokenisation of corporate bonds.
- **Distributed Ledger Architecture:**
  - The pilot enables the end-to-end issuance, trading, holding, and delivery-versus-payment (DvP) settlement of corporate bonds as digital tokens recorded on a shared **Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT)** network.
  - The distributed ledger is simultaneously maintained and validated across Market Infrastructure Institutions (MIIs), while legal ownership of the underlying ledger remains anchored with the registered depositories (**NSDL and CDSL**).
- **Integration with Wholesale Digital Rupee (e₹-W):**
  - Demat 2.0 is directly bridged to the Reserve Bank of India's **wholesale Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC / Digital Rupee e₹)** via the Unified Market Interface, achieving real-time atomic settlement and eliminating counterparty settlement risk.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Project Name: **Demat 2.0** (initiated by SEBI).
- Asset Class Tested: **Tokenised Corporate Bonds**.
- Underlying Infrastructure: **Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT)** operated across MIIs and depositories.
- Settlement Mechanism: Integrated with RBI's **wholesale CBDC (Digital Rupee e₹)** for atomic settlement.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which capital market initiative was unveiled by SEBI at GFF 2026 to test the tokenisation and atomic settlement of corporate bonds on distributed ledgers?" → **Demat 2.0**.

[SEP-010] **FIU-IND Cracks Down on 15 Offshore Virtual Digital Asset (VDA) Service Providers under PMLA**

- **Sovereign AML/CFT Enforcement:** The **Financial Intelligence Unit - India (FIU-IND)** issued formal show-cause notices and initiated restrictive compliance proceedings against **15 offshore Virtual Digital Asset (VDA) service providers** and crypto platforms operating without mandatory registration.
- **Statutory Mandate & Reporting Hierarchy:**
  - Established in **2004** as an independent central national agency under the Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance.
  - Reports directly to the **Economic Intelligence Council (EIC)**, which is statutory chaired by the **Union Finance Minister**.
  - Serves as the national nodal agency responsible for receiving, analyzing, and disseminating Suspicious Transaction Reports (STRs) and Cash Transaction Reports (CTRs).
- **Mandatory PMLA Registration Norms:**
  - All domestic and offshore VDA entities serving Indian residents are legally mandated to register as Reporting Entities under the **Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002**, maintain 5-year KYC transaction logs, and report high-risk wallet transfers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Institutional Origin: **FIU-IND** established in **2004** under Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance.
- Governing Council: Reports directly to the **Economic Intelligence Council (EIC)** headed by the **Union Finance Minister**.
- Governing Statute: **Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002**.
- Target MCQ Form: "To which high-level council headed by the Union Finance Minister does the Financial Intelligence Unit - India (FIU-IND) report directly?" → **Economic Intelligence Council (EIC)**.

[SEP-011] **IRDAI Authorises Indian Insurers to Invest in New Development Bank's 'Maharajah INR Bonds' (₹25,000 Cr Outlay)**

- **Genesis & Regulatory Clearance:** The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (**IRDAI**) formally permitted Indian life and general insurance companies to invest in **"Maharajah INR Bonds"**—the proposed onshore rupee-denominated bond programme of the **New Development Bank (NDB)**.
- **Programme Outlay & Tenor:**
  - Under the approved roadmap, the Shanghai-headquartered NDB proposes to mobilise approximately **₹25,000 crore** over a 5-year issuance cycle.
  - Proceeds are legally earmarked for general corporate financing and onward concessional lending to sustainable infrastructure, green energy, water sanitation, and social development projects located in India.
- **Securities Classification & Prescribed Category Codes:**
  - IRDAI clarified that NDB's onshore rupee bond issuances legally qualify as 'securities' under Section 2(h) of the *Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, 1956 (SCRA)*.
  - Prescribed two distinct investment category codes for insurer balance sheets:
    - `EORB` **:** Exclusively designated for the NDB's Onshore Rupee Bonds.
    - `IORB` **:** Designated for Infrastructure-Approved Bond issuances executed by the NDB.
- **Fundamental Conceptual Distinction:**

- *Masala Bonds*: Rupee-denominated debt instruments issued *outside India* in overseas financial hubs (e.g. London, Singapore) to tap international investors.
- *Maharajah Bonds*: Rupee-denominated debt instruments issued *onshore within Indian domestic capital markets* by multilateral or supranational development banks to mobilise domestic institutional savings.

- **Institutional Profile of NDB:** Established in July 2014 by BRICS nations (operationalized 2015; HQ: Shanghai, China; President: Dilma Rousseff; 11 member nations: Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa, Bangladesh, UAE, Egypt, Algeria, Colombia, Uzbekistan).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Category Codes: `EORB` (NDB Onshore Rupee Bonds) and `IORB` (Infrastructure-Approved Bonds).
- Fundamental Concept: Maharajah Bonds are issued *onshore within India*; Masala Bonds are issued *offshore outside India*.
- Programme Ceiling: **₹25,000 crore** over a 5-year issuance horizon.
- Governing Statute: Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, 1956 (SCRA).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which investment category code has been designated by IRDAI for Indian insurers investing in the New Development Bank's onshore rupee-denominated Maharajah Bonds?" → `EORB`.

[SEP-012] **PFRDA Standardises Point of Presence (PoP) Charge Architecture Across National Pension System (NPS)**

- **Comprehensive Charge Realignment:** The Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (**PFRDA**) notified a standardised charge framework applicable to Point of Presence (**PoP**) entities under the **National Pension System (NPS)** and NPS Lite via circular titled *Standardised framework for classification and presentation of schemes under NPS*.
- **Dismantling Legacy Dual Regimes:**
  - Completely abolishes the historical operational distinction between standard common schemes and schemes administered under the **Multiple Scheme Framework (MSF)**.
  - Replaces fragmented legacy circulars with a single, consolidated schedule governing onboarding fees, ongoing servicing charges, and contribution processing levies.
- **Rationalisation of Subscriber Servicing:**
  - Establishes a transparent fee cap on initial subscriber registration, contribution processing, and persistent transaction charges.
  - Mandates digital onboarding fees to be strictly segregated from physical offline document submission fees to incentivize paperless e-NPS adoption.
  - Directs all registered PoPs (commercial banks, NBFCs, and fintech intermediaries) to display standardized service charges on web portals and mobile apps without hidden processing levies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Regulatory Authority: **PFRDA** (governed under PFRDA Act, 2013; HQ: New Delhi).
- Core Reform: Dismantles differential charge tiers between common schemes and Multiple Scheme Framework (MSF) under NPS.
- Nodal Entities: Points of Presence (PoPs)—commercial banks and financial intermediaries acting as first-mile subscriber touchpoints.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which regulatory body notified the standardised framework for classification and presentation of schemes under the National Pension System (NPS), unifying Point of Presence (PoP) charges?" → **PFRDA**.

[SEP-013] **DoCA Notifies Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026 under Section 52 of Legal Metrology Act, 2009**

- **Statutory Mandate & Uniform Reference:** The Department of Consumer Affairs (**DoCA**), Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, notified the *Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026*, framed under **Section 52 of the Legal Metrology Act, 2009**. The Rules establish Indian Standard Time (**IST**) as the single, uniform legal reference for all legal, administrative, commercial, and official purposes across India, prohibiting alternative time references unless expressly authorized.

- **Transition Window & Synchronisation Protocols:**
  - The Rules will come into force **180 days** after publication in the Official Gazette, providing government departments, commercial enterprises, and institutions a transition window to update and calibrate internal systems.
  - Mandates that all government offices, courts, and public institutions synchronise their operational and network clocks using **Network Time Protocol (NTP)** and **Precision Time Protocol (PTP)**.
- **Repository & Astronomical Baseline:**
  - IST is officially maintained by the **CSIR-National Physical Laboratory (CSIR-NPL)** in New Delhi (not by IMD or ISRO).
  - Calculated strictly as **Coordinated Universal Time (UTC) + 5 hours 30 minutes**, anchored to the **82.5°E longitude** reference line passing through Mirzapur, Uttar Pradesh.
- **Strategic Self-Reliance ("One Nation, One Time"):**
  - Directs critical infrastructure (banking networks, stock exchanges, digital payment systems, telecommunications, railways, power grids, and statutory registries) to synchronise via **NavIC** (Navigation with Indian Constellation) and approved indigenous timing sources, mitigating dependency on foreign satellite navigation constellations such as US GPS.
  - Follows the commissioning of a national demonstration timing network utilizing **White Rabbit technology** at the Regional Reference Standard Laboratory (**RRSL**) in Bengaluru in July 2026.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Governing Statutory Clause: **Section 52 of the Legal Metrology Act, 2009**.
- Transition Period: **180 days** from publication in the Official Gazette.
- Statutory Custodian of Time: **CSIR-National Physical Laboratory (CSIR-NPL)** (*High-yield trap: not ISRO, not IMD*).
- Dissemination Protocols: **Network Time Protocol (NTP)** and **Precision Time Protocol (PTP)** via **NavIC**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026, which institution serves as the official legal custodian for maintaining Indian Standard Time?" → CSIR-National Physical Laboratory (CSIR-NPL).

2. BANKING, MONETARY POLICY & FINANCIAL INSTITUTIONS

[SEP-014] **Coastal Local Area Bank Admitted to Second Schedule of RBI Act, 1934: India's First Scheduled LAB**

- **Historic Scheduled Status:** The Reserve Bank of India officially accorded **Scheduled Bank status** to **Coastal Local Area Bank Limited (Coastal LAB)**.
- **Inclusion in Second Schedule:**
  - Coastal LAB becomes **India's first Local Area Bank** to be inscribed in the **Second Schedule of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934**.
  - Headquartered at **Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh**.
- **Prudential Liquidity & Operational Privileges:**
  - Eligible to access RBI's liquidity windows, including the **Liquidity Adjustment Facility (LAF)**, repo auctions, and Marginal Standing Facility (MSF).
  - Authorized to participate in primary clearing houses, undertake government agency banking, and issue commercial certificates of deposit (CDs).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Institution: **Coastal Local Area Bank (Coastal LAB)**.
- Headquarters: **Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh**.
- Milestone: **First Local Area Bank (LAB)** in India to receive Scheduled Bank status.
- Statutory Inscription: **Second Schedule of the RBI Act, 1934**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which bank became India's first Local Area Bank (LAB) to be included in the Second Schedule of the RBI Act, 1934 in September 2026?" → Coastal Local Area Bank.

[SEP-015] **Ministry of Finance Secures $1 Billion IFC Financing to Catalyse Long-Term MSME Credit**

- **Multilateral MSME Credit Accord:** The Ministry of Finance secured a **$1 Billion (approx. ₹8,400 crore)** credit facility from the International Finance Corporation (**IFC**), the private-sector investment arm of the World Bank Group.
- **Direct Capital Infusion to SIDBI:**
  - As an initial tranche, **$500 million has been directly disbursed to the Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI)**.
- **Targeted Deployment:**
  - Dedicated to extending long-term, fixed-rate loans for MSME capital expenditure, industrial modernization, clean energy adoption, and technology acquisition.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Accord Size: **USD 1 Billion**.
- Tranche Disbursed to SIDBI: **USD 500 Million**.
- Multilateral Institution: **International Finance Corporation (IFC)** (HQ: Washington, D.C.; World Bank Group).

[SEP-016] **RBI Launches Quarterly Monetary Policy Input Surveys: CCS, IESH, and Rural RCCS Battery**

- **Statutory Forecasting Inputs:** Ahead of the upcoming Monetary Policy Committee (**MPC**) bi-monthly review, the RBI rolled out its quarterly survey battery across 19 major cities and rural belts:
  1. **Consumer Confidence Survey (CCS):** Assesses urban household perceptions and 1-year expectations regarding general economic conditions, employment, prices, and spending.
  2. **Inflation Expectations Survey of Households (IESH):** Gauges qualitative and quantitative inflation projections over 3-month and 1-year horizons across 6,000+ urban households.
  3. **Rural Consumer Confidence Survey (RCCS):** Captures rural household economic confidence, agricultural wages, and discretionary consumption indices.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Three Anchor Surveys: **CCS, IESH, and RCCS**.
- Primary Policy Destination: Acts as direct empirical input for the 6-member **Monetary Policy Committee (MPC)** benchmark rate determination.

[SEP-017] **RBI Permits Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs) to Acquire Equity Shares in IDPIC for Membership**

- **Prudential Investment Norm Relaxation:** The Reserve Bank of India amended investment directions for **Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs)**.
- **Scope of Amendment:**
  - Permits UCBs to subscribe to equity shares of the **Indian Depositors Pension and Insurance Corporation (IDPIC)** to obtain institutional membership.
  - Exempts this targeted equity acquisition from the aggregate regulatory ceiling on UCB investments in non-SLR securities and commercial equity, subject to specific capital adequacy safeguards.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Regulated Entity: **Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs)**.
- Approved Equity Subscription: **IDPIC** (for institutional membership).
- Regulatory Waiver: Carve-out from standard commercial non-SLR equity exposure limits.

[SEP-018] **RBI Approves LIC Stake Acquisition Up to 9.99% in ICICI Bank & Imposes ₹26.82 Lakh Fine on CIBIL**

- **LIC's Strategic Banking Stake:**

- The RBI approved **Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC)** to acquire up to **9.99% of the paid-up share capital or voting rights in ICICI Bank**.
- **Validity Window:** LIC is statutorily mandated to complete the equity acquisition within **one year** from the date of RBI clearance.
- If shareholding falls below 5%, fresh RBI approval will be required to breach the 5% threshold again.

- **Enforcement Penalty on Credit Bureau:**
  - RBI slapped a monetary penalty of **₹26.82 lakh on TransUnion CIBIL Limited** under Section 25 of the *Credit Information Companies (Regulation) Act, 2005 (CICRA)* for non-compliance with statutory credit reporting and consumer data resolution timelines.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Permissible Cap for LIC: Up to **9.99% voting rights / share capital** in ICICI Bank.
- Acquisition Window: Must be executed within **1 year**.
- Penalty Target: **TransUnion CIBIL** penalised **₹26.82 lakh** under CICRA 2005.

[SEP-019] **India Post Payments Bank (IPPB) Celebrates 9th Foundation Day: ₹100 Crore Profit & New FinTech Battery**

- **Institutional Genesis & Milestones:** India Post Payments Bank (**IPPB**) marked its **9th Foundation Day** on September 1, 2026 (launched nationwide on September 1, 2018 under Department of Posts).
- **Sovereign Network & Cumulative Financial Metrics:**
  - 100% equity owned by the **Government of India** under the Ministry of Communications, serving over 10 Crore accounts across **1.61 lakh post offices** and 3 lakh Gramin Dak Sevaks (GDS).
  - Disclosed sustained operating profits exceeding **₹100 Crore in FY26**.
  - Processed a monumental cumulative **₹21.61 Lakh Crore in digital financial transactions**, comprising **₹7.41 Lakh Crore in UPI remittances**, **₹36,140 Crore across 12.06 crore AePS transactions**, and **₹1.55 Lakh Crore in Direct Benefit Transfers (DBT)**.
- **Triple FinTech Infrastructure Rollout:**
  - **"DakPay Sound Box":** Portable voice-alert terminal providing instant merchant transaction confirmations across regional languages.
  - **"Digital Insurance Technology Platform":** Seamless open architecture connecting rural and semi-urban citizens to Life, Health, and General Insurance policies.
  - **"Digital Mutual Fund Platform":** Direct paperless mutual fund and micro-SIP investment engine tailored for tier-3 to tier-6 unbanked corridors.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Foundation Day: **September 1, 2018 (9th Foundation Day in 2026)**.
- Cumulative Volume Milestone: **₹21.61 Lakh Crore** total transactions processed.
- Newly Unveiled Products: **DakPay Sound Box**, **Digital Insurance Technology Platform**, and **Digital Mutual Fund Platform**.
- Ownership & Legal Form: **100% GoI equity**; Payments Bank under Section 22 of Banking Regulation Act, 1949.

[SEP-020] **Credit Ratings & Banking Operations: S&P Assigns 'BBB' to BoI & Bandhan Bank Enters Credit Cards**

- **S&P Global Ratings for Bank of India (BoI):**
  - S&P assigned an investment-grade **'BBB' long-term and 'A-2' short-term issuer rating** to public sector lender **Bank of India (BoI)** with a Stable Outlook, citing robust systemic capital buffers, low-cost deposit franchise, and sustained asset quality recovery.
- **Bandhan Bank Four-Tier Credit Card Suite:**

- Private lender Bandhan Bank formally entered the co-branded and standalone credit card market with a 4-tier product architecture (*Elite, Prime, Pro, and Edge*).

- **Indian Bank Expands to Gulf:**
  - Public sector lender Indian Bank received regulatory clearance to set up its **Representative Office in Dubai, UAE**, to cater to non-resident Indian (NRI) remittances and cross-border trade finance.

- **Axis Bank Launches 'ARISE Homecoming':**
  - Axis Bank unveiled *"ARISE Homecoming"*, a specialized talent and gender-diversity reintegration program to recruit experienced women professionals returning to the workforce after career breaks.

- **SBI & Bisleri 'Bottles for Change' Accord:**
  - State Bank of India partnered with Bisleri International to institutionalize PET plastic waste recycling across its national branch network under the *"Bottles for Change"* initiative.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- S&P Rating: **'BBB' investment grade** assigned to Bank of India.
- Indian Bank Overseas Outpost: **Dubai, UAE**.
- Axis Bank Program: **'ARISE Homecoming'** (career returnship initiative).

[SEP-021] **RBI Relaxes Concessional USD-INR Swap Access Norms & Appoints Suman Ray as Executive Director**

- **Forex Swap Window Liberalisation:** The Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) relaxed the access rules for its concessional **USD-INR foreign exchange swap facility** linked to Foreign Currency Non-Resident (Bank) / **FCNR(B)** deposits.
- **The $100 Million Exemption Architecture:**
  - **Transactions Exceeding $100 Million:** Authorised Dealer (AD) Category-I banks are now permitted to approach the RBI swap desk **on any business day outside their predetermined weekly window**, providing swift forex liquidity headroom during market volatility.
  - **Transactions Up to $100 Million:** Remain strictly governed by the bank's designated weekly operational day to ensure orderly central bank balance sheet management.

- **Central Banking Executive Leadership:**
  - RBI appointed career central banker **Suman Ray** as **Executive Director (ED)** effective September 1, 2026 (elevated from Regional Director for Maharashtra).
  - Assigned Portfolios: Appointed to head the **Department of DICGC** (Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation) and the **Premises Department**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Swap Access Threshold: Transactions **above $100 Million** can be executed on any business day (transactions ≤ $100M stay on weekly allocated day).
- Underlying Anchor: Concessional forex swap facility linked to **FCNR(B) deposits**.
- Suman Ray's Central Bank Portfolios: **Department of DICGC** and **Premises Department**.
- Statutory Deposit Insurance Baseline: **₹5 Lakh per depositor per insured bank** under the DICGC Act, 1961.

[SEP-022] **State Bank of India Revises BSBDA Branch Cash Withdrawal Fee Architecture Effective October 1, 2026**

- **Regulatory Scope & Product Code:** State Bank of India (**SBI**) issued a customer directive revising the cash withdrawal charge matrix for **Basic Savings Bank Deposit Accounts (BSBDA)** under **Product Code 1011-1701**, taking effect on **October 1, 2026**.
- **Revised Withdrawal Entitlements & Surcharges:**
  - **Free Branch Counter Allowance:** Account holders are entitled to **4 free cash withdrawals per calendar month** across SBI branch networks.
  - **Beyond Monthly Limit:** Every cash withdrawal beyond the 4 free transactions will attract a flat charge of **₹15 plus applicable GST** (irrespective of the transaction amount withdrawn).

- **Absolute Exemption for Digital Channels:**
  - SBI clarified that alternative banking channels—including **UPI transactions, ATM cash withdrawals, and Net/Mobile Banking (NEFT/IMPS)**—remain 100% free and do not count toward the 4-withdrawal monthly quota.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: **October 1, 2026**.
- Monthly Free Branch Transactions: **4 withdrawals**.
- Post-Limit Flat Fee: **₹15 + applicable GST per withdrawal**.
- Account Nomenclature: Basic Savings Bank Deposit Account (Product Code 1011-1701).
- Examiner's Trap: Surcharges apply strictly to branch cash counter withdrawals; digital payments (UPI/ATM) remain free.

[SEP-023] **Reserve Bank of India (PSL – Targets and Classification) Third Amendment Directions, 2026 (RBI/2026-27/256)**

- **Genesis & Statutory Notification:** Notified by the Reserve Bank of India on **September 11, 2026** (Ref: *RBI/2026-27/256*), amending the *Master Direction – Reserve Bank of India (Priority Sector Lending – Targets and Classification) Directions, 2025*.
- **Advance in Terminal Cut-Off Date for ANBC Exemption:**
  - The central amendment alters the terminal date for mobilizing fresh foreign currency deposits eligible for exclusion from Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC) computation.
  - The deadline for mobilizing eligible fresh deposits was formally advanced from **September 30, 2026 to August 31, 2026**.
- **Eligible Foreign Currency Deposit Slabs:**
  - **Fresh FCNR(B) Deposits:** Minimum tenor of 3 years and maximum tenor of 5 years, mobilized between **June 8, 2026 and August 31, 2026**.
  - **Fresh NRE Term Deposits:** Tenor of 3 years or more, mobilized between **June 19, 2026 and August 31, 2026**.
- **Ceiling & Regulatory Alignment:**
  - Total amount excluded from ANBC for priority sector target computation cannot exceed the fresh outstanding FCNR(B) or NRE deposits eligible for CRR/SLR exemption under corresponding RBI liquidity directives.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Notification Date: **September 11, 2026** (Circular Ref: *RBI/2026-27/256*).
- Revised Cut-Off Date: Mobilization terminal date advanced to **August 31, 2026** (earlier September 30, 2026).
- Minimum Tenor Requirement: FCNR(B) = **3 to 5 years**; NRE = **3 years or more**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the RBI (PSL - Targets and Classification) Third Amendment Directions 2026, what was the revised terminal date for mobilizing fresh FCNR(B)/NRE deposits eligible for ANBC exemption?" → **August 31, 2026**.

[SEP-024] **Reserve Bank of India (Local Area Banks – CRR and SLR) Second Amendment Directions, 2026 (RBI/2026-27/255)**

- **Regulatory Harmonization:** Issued by the RBI on **September 11, 2026** (Ref: *RBI/2026-27/255*), amending the statutory liquidity management framework for **Local Area Banks (LABs)** under Section 24 and Section 42 of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949.
- **Reporting Cycle & Liquidity Synchronization:**
  - Aligns the Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) and Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR) computation cycles and reporting schedules of Local Area Banks directly with Scheduled Commercial Banks (SCBs).
  - Eliminates reporting lags and ensures uniform liquidity risk monitoring across small geographical niche banks.
- **Current Operational LABs in India:**
  - Focuses supervisory rigor on India's operational Local Area Banks (including *Coastal Local Area Bank Ltd.* and *Krishna Bhima Samruddhi Local Area Bank Ltd.*).

- Maintains mandatory CRR holding in current account with RBI and SLR in approved sovereign securities.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Notification Date: **September 11, 2026** (Ref: *RBI/2026-27/255*).
- Regulated Entities: **Local Area Banks (LABs)** (niche banks introduced in 1996 to mobilize rural/semi-urban savings across contiguous districts).
- Statutory Baseline: Section 24 (SLR) and Section 42 (CRR) of the Banking Regulation Act.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which niche banking category had its CRR and SLR maintenance and reporting cycles synchronized with commercial banks via RBI directions on September 11, 2026?" → **Local Area Banks (LABs)**.

[SEP-025] **IDFC FIRST Bank Becomes India's First Lender to Eliminate Forex Markup Across All Credit Cards**

- **Pioneering Retail FX Disruption: IDFC FIRST Bank** became the first commercial bank in India to introduce **Zero Forex Markup** across its entire existing and newly issued credit card portfolio.
- **Consumer Cost Relief:**
  - Standard commercial credit cards in India levy a foreign currency conversion/markup fee ranging from **1.5% to 3.5% plus GST** on overseas POS transactions and international e-commerce billings.
  - IDFC FIRST Bank abolished this fee entirely across all customer segments without requiring minimum spend thresholds or annual tier subscriptions.
- **Institutional Profile of IDFC FIRST Bank:**
  - Headquarters: **Mumbai, Maharashtra**.
  - Genesis: Founded following the landmark reverse merger between **IDFC Bank** and non-bank retail financing powerhouse **Capital First** in **December 2018**.
  - Leadership: Managing Director and CEO is **V. Vaidyanathan**; Part-Time Non-Executive Chairperson is **Sanjeeb Chaudhuri**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Bank with Zero Forex Markup on All Cards: **IDFC FIRST Bank**.
- Typical Industry Fee Abolished: **1.5% to 3.5%** foreign transaction markup.
- Merger Year: December 2018 (IDFC Bank + Capital First).
- MD & CEO: **V. Vaidyanathan**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which private sector bank became the first in India to offer Zero Forex Markup across all its existing and new credit cards in September 2026?" → **IDFC FIRST Bank**.

[SEP-026] **Maldives Clears Final $50M Tranche to Repay US$150M SBI Facility: India Borne $45M Sovereign Interest**

- **Full Debt Retirement:** The Government of Maldives successfully completed the final repayment of a **US$50 Million tranche** on September 17, 2026, marking the complete settlement of the **US$150 Million Treasury Bill (T-bill) facility** extended through the State Bank of India (**SBI**).
- **India's Sovereign Financial Relief Package:**
  - The original T-bill facility was subscribed by SBI in **2019** to support Male's budgetary stability during severe foreign exchange liquidity crises.
  - While the Maldivian Government paid the principal amount, the **Government of India bore nearly US$45 Million in interest payments** over the five-year lifecycle as budgetary grant support.
- **Ongoing Bilateral Currency Backstops:**
  - To prevent future balance of payments stress, India has extended a bilateral **₹3,000 Crore currency swap facility** to the Maldives Monetary Authority (MMA).
  - Additionally, the Government of India has subscribed to **$350 Million worth of Maldivian sovereign Treasury Bonds (T-Bonds)** with extended tenures maturing in **2029 and 2030**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Retired T-Bill Facility: **US$150 Million** subscribed by SBI (final $50M repaid September 2026).
- Interest Borne by India: **Nearly US$45 Million** in sovereign interest support over 5 years.
- Active Currency Swap Size: **₹3,000 Crore** currency swap line.
- Bilateral T-Bond Subscription: **$350 Million** maturing in 2029–2030.
- Target MCQ Form: "How much interest assistance did the Government of India absorb to support the Maldives in servicing its US$150 Million SBI T-bill facility?" → **Nearly US$45 Million**.

[SEP-027] **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) Completes 12 Years: Accounts Cross 59.09 Crore & Deposits Touch ₹3.16 Lakh Crore**

- **12-Year National Milestone:** Launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on **August 28, 2014**, as the world's largest financial inclusion mission, PMJDY completed 12 years of nationwide operationalization under the Department of Financial Services (DFS), Ministry of Finance.
- **Four-Fold Account Growth Trajectory:**
  - Total cumulative PMJDY accounts surged four-fold from **14.72 crore in March 2015 to 59.09 crore** as of August 19, 2026.
  - *Rural and Semi-Urban Dominance*: **45.95 crore accounts (77.8%)** are operationalized across rural and semi-urban bank branches, successfully eliminating the rural banking divide.
  - *Urban/Metropolitan Distribution*: 13.14 crore accounts (22.2%) located in urban and metropolitan centres.
- **Demographic Empowerment & Gender Parity:**
  - *Female Financial Inclusion*: **55.7% of all PMJDY accounts (32.92 crore)** are held by women beneficiaries, marking unprecedented female banking formalization.
- **Deposit Mobilisation & Account Monetisation:**
  - *Aggregate Deposit Corpus*: Total balances held in PMJDY accounts crossed **₹3,16,514 crore** (~₹3.16 lakh crore, expanding from ₹2.31 lakh crore in 2024 and ₹1.46 lakh crore in 2021).
  - *Average Deposit Expansion*: The average deposit balance per PMJDY account expanded to **₹5,356** (compared to ₹1,065 in March 2015), proving that accounts are actively utilized for savings and DBT transfers rather than remaining dormant.
- **RuPay Debit Cards & Accidental Insurance Shield:**
  - Total RuPay Debit Cards issued: **41.29 crore cards**, bundled with built-in **₹2 lakh free accidental death insurance coverage** (for cards issued post-August 28, 2018; ₹1 lakh for earlier cards).
  - Overdraft (OD) facility: Up to **₹10,000** (with no conditional assessment for amounts up to ₹2,000; upper age ceiling 65 years).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total PMJDY Accounts: **59.09 crore accounts** (August 2026).
- Rural/Semi-Urban Share: **77.8% (45.95 crore accounts)**.
- Women Account Share: **55.7% of total accounts (32.92 crore)**.
- Cumulative Balance: Reached **₹3,16,514 crore** (~₹3.16 Lakh Crore); Average balance per account = **₹5,356**.
- Insurance Cover: Built-in RuPay accidental insurance of **₹2 lakh**; Overdraft ceiling of **₹10,000**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total cumulative balance deposited in Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) accounts as of its 12th anniversary in August 2026?" → **₹3,16,514 Crore (~₹3.16 Lakh Crore)**.

[SEP-028] **Bank of Baroda Launches 'UPI Global Reverse Acceptance' for International Tourists & Foreign Wallets**

- **Cross-Border P2M Inbound Architecture:** Bank of Baroda (**BoB**) rolled out **UPI Global Reverse Acceptance**, enabling inbound international tourists, overseas Indians, and eligible foreign wallet/banking application users to make seamless QR-based merchant payments across India by scanning Bank of Baroda's merchant UPI QR codes with their home-country payment apps.

- **NPCI International Alignment:**
  - Developed in synergy with NPCI International Payments Limited (**NIPL**) to enable cross-border Person-to-Merchant (**P2M**) transactions without requiring foreign visitors to acquire local Indian SIM cards or domestic wallets.
  - Integrates payment corridors participating in NIPL's global ecosystem, including **Singapore (PayNow), UAE (Jaywan/Aani), Nepal, Bhutan, Mauritius, Sri Lanka, Qatar, and France**.
- **Global Footprint Context:**
  - Expands India's global UPI integration roadmap, which is operational across **11 countries:** UAE, France, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Singapore, Mauritius, Qatar, Cambodia, Greece, and the Maldives.
- **Institutional Profile:**
  - Bank of Baroda (HQ: Vadodara, Gujarat; MD & CEO: Debadatta Chand; Tagline: *"India's International Bank"*).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Pioneering PSU Bank: **Bank of Baroda (BoB)** (HQ: Vadodara; MD & CEO: Debadatta Chand).
- Transaction Architecture: Cross-border **Person-to-Merchant (P2M)** transactions for foreign inbound travelers.
- Global Footprint Base: UPI operational across **11 countries** worldwide.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which public sector bank launched 'UPI Global Reverse Acceptance' to enable inbound foreign travelers to pay Indian merchants via domestic UPI QR codes?" → Bank of Baroda.

[SEP-029] **Tata Capital & Japan's Resona Bank Ink Strategic MoU: Launches Dedicated 'Japan Desk' & Bilateral Financing**

- **Bilateral Cross-Border Syndicate:** Tata Capital Limited, one of India's premier diversified Non-Banking Financial Companies (**NBFCs**), signed a strategic Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Japan's **Resona Bank** to facilitate Japanese corporate expansion, foreign direct investment (FDI), and industrial ventures in the Indian market.
- **Operational Framework & Japan Desk:**
  - Tata Capital will establish a dedicated, Japanese-language **"Japan Desk"** to deliver regulatory guidance, market intelligence, local currency working capital loans, and structured corporate financing to Resona Bank's institutional and corporate clients.
  - Follows Resona Bank's **$20 million** commitment as a Limited Partner (LP) in **Tata Capital Growth Fund III LP**, managed by Tata Capital.
- **Institutional Profile:**
  - Tata Capital (HQ: Mumbai; MD & CEO: Rajiv Sabharwal; Chairman: Saurabh Agrawal).
  - Resona Bank (HQ: Osaka/Tokyo, Japan; leading retail and commercial banking group).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Institutional Counterparties: **Tata Capital** and **Resona Bank** (Japan).
- Prior Strategic Investment: **$20 million** LP commitment in Tata Capital Growth Fund III LP.
- Dedicated Facility: Japanese-language **"Japan Desk"** for corporate advisory and rupee financing.
- Target MCQ Form: "Tata Capital signed an MoU with which major Japanese bank to set up a dedicated 'Japan Desk' and facilitate corporate loans for Japanese enterprises in India?" → Resona Bank.

3. DIGITAL PAYMENTS, FINTECH INNOVATION & INSURANCE

[SEP-030] **Prime Minister Inaugurates Global Fintech Fest (GFF) 2026: Unveils 4-Point Strategic Fintech Roadmap**

- **Flagship Convergence:** Prime Minister Narendra Modi inaugurated the 5th edition of the **Global Fintech Fest (GFF) 2026** at the Jio World Convention Centre, **Mumbai**.
- **The 4-Point Strategic Fintech Charter:**
  1. **Fortified Cybersecurity:** Zero-trust architecture across API payment gateways and cloud cores.

2. **Ethical Data Protection Standards:** Strict compliance with Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act frameworks and consent management.
3. **Collaborative Regulator–Industry Innovation Sandbox:** Scaled testing of agentic AI and smart contracts.
4. **Fintech Consumer Protection Index:** Institutionalization of a national consumer trust and grievance redressal index.

- **Next-Generation Tech Deployments:**
  - Showcased national applications of **Agentic AI** in underwriting, decentralized **Tokenisation**, and **Post-Quantum Cryptography** standards for interbank settlement.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Venue: **Mumbai, Maharashtra**.
- Key Charter: **4-Point Fintech Roadmap** (Cybersecurity, Data Protection, Innovation Sandbox, Consumer Protection Index).
- Frontline Themes: **Agentic AI, Quantum Resistance, and Tokenised Settlements**.

[SEP-031] **Jio Payment Solutions Secures RBI PA-CB Clearance: Partners with Citi for Global Exporter Collections**

- **Cross-Border Aggregator Licence:** Jio Payment Solutions Limited (**JPSL**), a subsidiary of Jio Financial Services, secured formal authorization from the Reserve Bank of India to operate as a **Payment Aggregator for Cross-Border (PA-CB) transactions** for both export and import legs.
- **Strategic Partnership with Citi:**
  - Partnered with **Citibank N.A. (Citi)** as its Authorised Dealer Category-1 (AD Cat-1) partner.
  - Empowers Indian exporters to accept multi-currency collections through virtual accounts, global payment schemes, and international commercial credit cards.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Entity: **Jio Payment Solutions Limited (JPSL)**.
- Licence Acquired: **RBI PA-CB (Payment Aggregator - Cross-Border)** for export & import.
- AD Category-1 Banking Partner: **Citi (Citibank)**.

[SEP-032] **NPCI International Partners with HUMO in Uzbekistan: Expands UPI QR Footprint to 11 Nations**

- **Central Asian Strategic Foothold:** NPCI International Payments Limited (**NIPL**), the international arm of the National Payments Corporation of India, signed a definitive commercial agreement with Uzbekistan's **National Interbank Processing Centre JSC (NIPC - HUMO)**, operator of the national payment switch HUMO.
- **UZQR Interoperability & Bilateral Clearances:**
  - Enables Indian travellers to execute instant **Person-to-Merchant (P2M)** payments across Uzbekistan by scanning Uzbekistan's national **UZQR** standard using any UPI app, debited in INR from domestic Indian bank accounts.
  - Supported by dual regulatory authorizations from the **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** and the **Central Bank of Uzbekistan (CBU)**.
- **Exhaustive 11-Nation Global UPI Grid:**
  - With Uzbekistan's formal operationalisation, UPI merchant payments are now officially live across **11 countries: Singapore, UAE, France, Mauritius, Nepal, Bhutan, Qatar, Sri Lanka, Cambodia, Greece, and Uzbekistan**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Partner Entity: **NIPC - HUMO (Uzbekistan)** (operator of HUMO payment system).
- Interoperable Standard: **UZQR**.
- Official 11 UPI Nations: Singapore, UAE, France, Mauritius, Nepal, Bhutan, Qatar, Sri Lanka, Cambodia, Greece, Uzbekistan.
- Implementing Unit: **NIPL** (CEO: Ritesh Shukla; HQ: Mumbai).

[SEP-033] **Fintech Rollouts: PhonePe & Visa GFF Solutions, PayGlocal 'Flash', RNFI Services PA Nod & India's 1st Tokenised Bond**

- **PhonePe and Visa Triple Solution at GFF 2026:**
  - Unveiled three joint solutions:
    1. *Tap to Pay*: Enables contactless Visa card payments using NFC on Android smartphones.
    2. *Cross Border Scan to Pay*: PhonePe becomes the **first Indian application** allowing users to scan Visa-supported QR codes across **14 international markets**.
    3. *Smart Accept*: Transforms merchant smartphones into standalone soft-POS terminals without requiring dedicated POS hardware.
- **PayGlocal Launches 'Flash':**
  - Cross-border payment infrastructure provider PayGlocal unveiled *"Flash"*, an automated global checkout engine reducing transaction abandonment for Indian direct-to-consumer (D2C) exporters.
- **RNFI Services Secures RBI PA In-Principle Nod:**
  - Fintech player RNFI Services received RBI in-principle approval to operate as a domestic online Payment Aggregator (PA).
- **India's First Tokenised Bond Issuance:**
  - Successfully executed India's inaugural **tokenised municipal/corporate bond** issuance using distributed ledger technology (DLT), providing instantaneous atomic delivery-versus-payment (DvP) settlement.
- **WhatsApp In-App Utility Bill Payments:**
  - Meta rolled out full-suite BBPS utility bill payments (FASTag recharges, electricity, water, municipal tax) directly inside WhatsApp chats.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Indian App with Cross-Border Visa QR: **PhonePe** (operational across 14 countries).
- In-Principle PA Nod: **RNFI Services**.
- Atomic Settlement Milestone: India's first **Tokenised Bond** on DLT.

[SEP-034] **IRDAI Proposes Public Insurance Registry (PIR) & Slaps ₹1 Crore Penalty on ICICI Lombard**

- **Public Insurance Registry (PIR) Blueprint:**
  - The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (**IRDAI**) floated an exposure draft proposing the establishment of a **Public Insurance Registry (PIR)**.
  - Designed as a digital public infrastructure (DPI) utility to serve as a single, immutable repository of all active insurance policies, claims histories, and surveyor reports across life, general, and health segments.
- **Enforcement Penalty on ICICI Lombard:**
  - IRDAI imposed a **₹1 crore monetary penalty** on private non-life insurer **ICICI Lombard General Insurance** for regulatory breaches concerning corporate agent commissions and compliance reporting.
- **LIC Launches 'Bima Platinum' & 'Jeevan Raksha' Plans:**
  - Life Insurance Corporation of India launched two distinct products: *LIC Bima Platinum* (guaranteed savings) and *LIC Jeevan Raksha* (low-cost term cover).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Digital Infrastructure: **Public Insurance Registry (PIR)** proposed by IRDAI.
- Monetary Penalty: **₹1 Crore** levied on **ICICI Lombard**.
- Regulatory Body: **IRDAI** (Insurance Act 1938 / IRDA Act 1999; HQ: Hyderabad; Chairman: Debasish Panda).

[SEP-035] **Bank of Baroda Unveils 'UPI Global Reverse Acceptance' for Inbound International Travellers**

- **First-in-Market Cross-Border P2M Milestone:** Bank of Baroda (**BoB**) launched **"UPI Global Reverse Acceptance"**, becoming the first public sector bank in India to operationalise inbound QR payments for foreign tourists, international business delegations, and Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) arriving in India.
- **Operational Architecture:**
  - Allows visitors from countries participating in NPCI International's global partner network to make instant Person-to-Merchant (**P2M**) payments by scanning **Bank of Baroda UPI QR codes** at Indian merchants.
  - Foreign digital wallets or international bank apps are debited directly in foreign currency, while the Indian merchant instantly receives settlement in Indian Rupees (**INR**), eliminating physical currency conversion and point-of-sale foreign card markups.
- **Strategic Network Convergence:** Directly integrated with **NPCI International Payments Limited (NIPL)**, expanding financial interconnectivity across India's merchant corridors.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Distinctive Concept: **Reverse Acceptance** = Inbound international travellers spending in India via UPI QR codes (as opposed to Indian tourists spending UPI abroad).
- First Public Sector Bank: **Bank of Baroda** (Vadodara, Gujarat; MD & CEO: Debadatta Chand; Tagline: "India's International Bank").
- Infrastructure Backing: **NPCI International Payments Limited (NIPL)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which Indian bank introduced 'UPI Global Reverse Acceptance' to facilitate inbound P2M payments for foreign tourists scanning Indian UPI QRs?" → Bank of Baroda.

[SEP-036] **NCDEX Launches 'RAINCHNNAI': India's First Weather Index Monsoon Futures Derivative**

- **Pioneering Climate Derivative:** The National Commodity and Derivatives Exchange (**NCDEX**), regulated by SEBI, launched **"RAINCHNNAI"**, India's first weather index futures derivative contract, with trading commencing on August 31, 2026.
- **Hedging Chennai's Northeast Monsoon:**
  - Designed to hedge financial, agricultural, and commercial risks associated with rainfall fluctuations during Chennai's **Northeast monsoon** (which accounts for approximately **70% of Chennai's 1,400 mm annual rainfall**).
  - Monthly Contract Slate: Contracts are listed across 4 consecutive calendar months: **September, October, November, and December**.
- **Contract Mechanics & Index Pricing:**
  - **Pricing Engine:** Constructed on a **Cumulative Deviation Rainfall (CDR)** index model based on official IMD automated weather station observations.
  - **Tick Size & Lot Constraints:** Minimum tick size of **1 millimetre**; maximum single order lot size restricted to **50 lots**.
  - **Settlement:** Strictly **cash-settled** against cumulative precipitation deviations; trading runs Monday through Friday between 10:00 AM and 11:30 PM / 11:55 PM.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Exchange: **NCDEX** (National Commodity and Derivatives Exchange; HQ: Mumbai).
- Specific Meteorological Target: **Northeast Monsoon** (retreating monsoon affecting Tamil Nadu).
- Index Model: **Cumulative Deviation Rainfall (CDR)** model.
- Contract Parameters: **1 mm tick size**, max **50 lots**, strictly **cash-settled**.
- Examiner's Trap: Setting the question as Southwest Monsoon or claim physical commodity delivery—it is cash-settled on precipitation index deviation.

[SEP-037] **NPCI Notifies UPI Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) Regulatory Framework 2026 (Effective October 15, 2026)**

- **Genesis & Institutional Sustainability:** National Payments Corporation of India (**NPCI**) in consultation with the Reserve Bank of India and Ministry of Finance announced a recalibrated Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) framework for specific UPI transactions, taking effect on **October 15, 2026**, to ensure long-term technological and cybersecurity funding of the UPI rails.
- **Strict Protection for Consumers & P2P (Zero Charges):**
  - **Consumers Pay ₹0:** Government reaffirmed that customers will **never be charged any platform fee or transaction charge** for UPI payments; banks and payment aggregators are strictly prohibited from passing MDR to end-consumers.
  - **Person-to-Person (P2P):** All P2P transfers (wallet-to-wallet, account-to-account) remain **100% free with Zero MDR**, irrespective of transaction value.
- **Person-to-Merchant (P2M) Rate Slabs:**
  - **Transactions up to ₹2,000:** Attract strictly **Zero MDR (0.0%)**, shielding over **95% of total P2M transaction volume**.
  - **Transactions above ₹2,000:** Subject to a nominal **MDR of 0.4%** paid by merchants.
  - **High-Value Cap:** For large commercial transactions of **₹75,000 and above**, MDR is capped at a maximum of **₹300 per transaction**.
- **Special Categories & Sectoral Exemptions:**
  - **Small Merchants (P2PM):** Micro-merchants receiving up to **₹1 Lakh per month** via QR codes are completely **exempt from MDR (0%)**.
  - **Essential Utilities & Public Services:** Railways, fuel stations, telecom, utilities, insurance, and agricultural inputs attract a flat concessional fee of **₹5 per transaction** for payments above ₹2,000.
  - **Capital Market Inflows:** Payments to mutual funds and SEBI-registered stockbrokers attract an ultra-low MDR of **0.02%, capped at ₹300**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Implementation Date: **October 15, 2026**.
- Consumer & P2P Impact: **100% Free / Zero MDR** (banks barred from passing fees to customers).
- Small Ticket P2M Threshold: Transactions **up to ₹2,000 attract Zero MDR** (covers >95% of volume).
- Standard Commercial Rate: **0.4%** for transactions above ₹2,000; maximum cap = **₹300** (for transactions ≥ ₹75,000).
- Small Merchant Exemption: Receiving up to **₹1 Lakh per month** via QR codes.
- Essential Utilities Flat Fee: **₹5 per transaction** above ₹2,000.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the NPCI UPI MDR framework effective October 15, 2026, what is the maximum MDR cap for high-value transactions of ₹75,000 and above?" → **₹300 per transaction**.

[SEP-038] **RBI Directs "Lien Over Disputed Amount" Protocol & Mandatory AI Monitoring for Transfers ≥ ₹1,000**

- **Genesis & Paradigm Shift in Fraud Containment:** In response to widespread operational harassment caused by blunt, wholesale freezing of bank accounts flagged in cybercrime inquiries, the Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) issued supervisory directions prohibiting banks from blanket account-freezing.
- **The "Surgical Lien" Mandate:**
  - Banks are mandatorily directed to place a **targeted lien strictly on the exact disputed transaction amount** identified in cyber fraud / mule alerts, rather than locking or freezing the entire customer savings or current account.
  - Restores full operational freedom to customers to transact, deposit, and withdraw legitimately owned balances outside the disputed lien amount.
- **Mandatory AI-Powered Real-Time Transaction Screening:**
  - Mandates all commercial banks, payment banks, and fintech payment gateways to deploy **real-time AI-based monitoring tools** for funds transfers of **₹1,000 or more**.
  - System is programmed to identify behavioral anomalies: sudden high-velocity transfers through newly opened accounts, immediate layering across multiple digital wallets, and transactions disproportionate to historical turnover.
- **Inter-Agency Coordination via I4C:**

- Integrates direct automated API workflows with the **Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)** under the Ministry of Home Affairs and the National Cybercrime Reporting Portal (NCRP / Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting System Helpline 1930).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Key Operational Shift: **Lien over disputed amount** instead of complete account freezing.
- AI Screening Floor: Applies to digital transfers of **₹1,000 or more**.
- Reporting Helpline & Portal: **1930** (Citizen Financial Cyber Fraud Reporting System) operated by **I4C** (MHA).
- Supervisory Intent: Eliminates collateral disruption for innocent retail customers and legitimate small business accounts caught in mule tracing networks.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the RBI's September 2026 cyber fraud mitigation directions, what is the minimum transaction threshold subject to mandatory real-time AI-based anomaly screening?" → **₹1,000**.

[SEP-039] **NSE Enables India's First Tokenised Corporate Bond Issuance (₹1,00,0 Crore): REC & L&T on DLT**

- **Historic Tokenised Debt Milestone:** The **National Stock Exchange (NSE)** successfully enabled India's inaugural tokenised corporate bond issuances on its Electronic Bidding Platform (**NSE EBP**) with an aggregate mobilization of **₹1,000 Crore**.
- **Pioneering Corporate Issuers:**
  - **REC Limited:** State-owned Maharatna NBFC raised **₹500 Crore**, recording the very first tokenised corporate bond issuance executed on the NSE EBP platform.
  - **Larsen & Toubro (L&T):** Infrastructure conglomerate raised **₹500 Crore** in private placement tokenised debt.
- **Institutional Market Architecture:**
  - Executed under SEBI's pilot framework utilizing distributed ledgers to tokenize securities, providing automated corporate actions, digital coupon distribution, and real-time ownership ledger synchronization.
  - *NSE Leadership*: Headquartered in Mumbai; Chairperson is **Srinivas Injeti**; Managing Director & CEO is **Ashishkumar Chauhan**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Tokenised Debt Mobilised: **₹1,000 Crore** across two issuers.
- First Tokenised Corporate Bond Issuer: **REC Limited (₹500 Crore)**.
- Co-Issuer: **Larsen & Toubro (₹500 Crore)**.
- Platform: **NSE Electronic Bidding Platform (NSE EBP)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which public sector enterprise became the first entity in India to issue a tokenised corporate bond on the NSE Electronic Bidding Platform?" → **REC Limited**.

[SEP-040] **FASTag 'One Tag' Interoperability & Portability Initiative Launched by IHMCL & NPCI**

- **Seamless Issuer Portability:** Union Minister for Road Transport & Highways Nitin Gadkari unveiled the **"OneTag"** facility at the Global Fintech Fest (GFF) 2026 in Mumbai.
- **National Electronic Toll Collection (NETC) Upgrade:**
  - Developed as a joint initiative between the **Indian Highways Management Company Limited (IHMCL)** and the **National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI)**.
  - Resolves a primary user pain point by enabling vehicle owners to **port or switch their FASTag issuer bank digitally** without having to physically remove, repurchase, or affix a new RFID tag to the vehicle windscreen.
- **Digital Deployment via Rajmargyatra:**
  - Integrated directly into the National Highways Authority of India's (**NHAI**) flagship mobile portal, the **Rajmargyatra app**, allowing bank switching through basic vehicle registration and mobile OTP authentication.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Portal Solution Name: **OneTag** (FASTag issuer portability).
- Joint Developers: **IHMCL (Indian Highways Management Company Ltd)** and **NPCI**.
- Mobile Platform: NHAI's **Rajmargyatra** mobile application.
- Operational Advantage: Porting FASTag bank account without physical RFID tag replacement.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the name of the NETC FASTag portability facility launched by IHMCL and NPCI allowing users to change their issuer bank without physical tag replacement?" → **OneTag**.

[SEP-041] **DFS Issues Statutory Gazette Notification under Section 10A of PSS Act: Strict Zero-MDR on UPI up to ₹2,000 and RuPay Debit Cards**

- **Statutory Enforcement & Legislative Anchor:** The Department of Financial Services (**DFS**), Ministry of Finance, published a legally binding Gazette notification under **Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 (PSS Act)**.
- **Strict Prohibition of Direct/Indirect Levies:**
  - Mandates that no bank, payment system operator (PSO), or payment service provider shall directly or indirectly impose any merchant discount rate (MDR), convenience fee, interchange fee, or handling surcharge on persons making or receiving payments via:
    1. **Unified Payments Interface (UPI) for transaction values up to ₹2,000**.
    2. **RuPay Debit Cards across all domestic transaction tiers**.
- **Deterrent Penalty Framework:**
  - Clarifies that any unauthorized levy, fee masking, or hidden gateway markup attempted by banks or merchant acquirers attracts direct penal proceedings under Section 26 and Section 30 of the PSS Act, 2007.
- **Fiscal Underpinning:**
  - The Central Government continues to compensate acquiring banks and NPCI through dedicated digital payment incentive budgetary allocations (~₹1,500–₹2,000 Cr annually) to sustain the zero-MDR ecosystem for small merchants and citizens.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Statutory Section: **Section 10A of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007**.
- Transaction Ceiling for Zero-Fee Protection: UPI transactions **up to ₹2,000** and all **RuPay Debit Card** transactions.
- Nodal Department: **Department of Financial Services (DFS)**, Ministry of Finance.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under which section of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 did the Ministry of Finance issue a Gazette notification prohibiting charges on UPI transactions up to ₹2,000 and RuPay debit cards?" → **Section 10A**.

[SEP-042] **Global Fintech Fest (GFF) 2026: NPCI & RBI Unveil 'UPI Tap & Pay' NFC Contactless Capability and Delegated Payments**

- **Architectural Innovations at GFF 2026:** At the Global Fintech Fest held in Mumbai, the Reserve Bank of India and National Payments Corporation of India (**NPCI**) unveiled transformative next-generation capabilities on the UPI rail.
- **UPI Tap & Pay (Near Field Communication / NFC):**
  - Enables seamless contactless point-of-sale (PoS) merchant payments by simply tapping an NFC-enabled smartphone against any BharatQR or Soundbox PoS terminal.
  - *Zero Mobile Internet Requirement*: Functions locally via encrypted NFC handshakes between device and terminal without requiring active cellular data connection during execution, drastically lowering failure rates in rural or congested network environments.
- **Delegated Payments Framework:**
  - Authorizes a primary bank account holder (e.g. parent) to set monthly or per-transaction spending limits for secondary users (e.g. children or dependents) without requiring the secondary user to maintain an independent bank account.

- **Conversational Payments & AI Voice Verification:**
  - Integrated with Bhashini NLP models to enable multi-lingual voice-driven peer-to-merchant transfers across 12 scheduled Indian languages.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Technology Standard: **Near Field Communication (NFC)** powering UPI Tap & Pay.
- Offline Capability: Enables contactless PoS tapping without active mobile data connectivity.
- Delegated Payments: Allows secondary users to transact from primary user's account under preset limits.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which wireless technology standard powers the newly unveiled 'UPI Tap & Pay' capability enabling internet-free contactless payments at PoS terminals?" → **Near Field Communication (NFC)**.

[SEP-043] **LIC Launches 'Bima Platinum' & 'Jeevan Raksha' Endowment & Term Plans to Mark 70th Anniversary**

- **Platinum Jubilee Portfolio Expansion:** Life Insurance Corporation of India (**LIC**) unveiled two bespoke retail products—**"Bima Platinum"** and **"Jeevan Raksha"**—to commemorate the 70th anniversary of the Corporation's founding (established September 1, 1956).
- **Product 1: Bima Platinum (Savings + Protection):**
  - Non-participating, non-linked individual savings and life assurance product.
  - **Guaranteed Additions:** Accrues **₹70 for every ₹1,000 of annual premium paid** throughout the premium-paying term.
  - **Booster & Regular Income Benefits:** Features a **Booster Income Benefit of 70% of the basic sum assured** payable at the end of the 5th year post premium-paying term, alongside an annual **Regular Income Benefit of 10% of basic sum assured** during the payout window.
  - Premium-paying terms: **7, 10, 12, 15, or 18 years**; Minimum Basic Sum Assured: **₹3 lakh**; Minimum entry age: **30 days**.
- **Product 2: Jeevan Raksha (Pure Protection / Term):**
  - Non-participating, non-linked pure-risk life insurance policy offering guaranteed death benefit with zero bonus/market link.
  - Entry Age: **18 to 45 years**; Maturity Age: **33 to 60 years**; Basic Sum Assured: **₹5 lakh to ₹24 lakh** (special discounted premium bands for women).
- **Institutional Vital Statistics:**
  - LIC (HQ: Mumbai; CEO & MD: R. Doraiswamy; Founded: 1 September 1956; Tagline: *"Yogakshemam Vahamyaham"*).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Milestone Occasion: **70th Anniversary** of LIC (commenced operations 1 September 1956).
- Bima Platinum Guaranteed Addition: **₹70 per ₹1,000 annual premium**; Booster Benefit: **70% of Basic Sum Assured**.
- Minimum Sum Assured Thresholds: **₹3 Lakh** (Bima Platinum); **₹5 Lakh to ₹24 Lakh** (Jeevan Raksha).
- Target MCQ Form: "What are the guaranteed additions offered under LIC's newly launched 70th-anniversary policy 'Bima Platinum'?" → ₹70 per ₹1,000 of annual premium paid.

[SEP-044] **Cashfree Payments Launches 'Relay' AI Super Agent to Automate SMB & Startup Payment Operations**

- **Autonomous Payment Orchestration:** Cashfree Payments, an AI-native full-stack payment orchestration gateway, announced the general rollout of **"Relay"**, an enterprise-grade AI Super Agent designed to automate and resolve payment lifecycles for Small and Medium Businesses (SMBs) and high-growth startups.
- **Autonomous Workflow Execution vs. Alert Flagging:**
  - Unlike traditional monitoring dashboards that merely notify merchants of exceptions, Relay autonomously executes remedial workflows: intelligent retries of failed digital transactions, automated checkout follow-ups for abandoned carts, pre-dispatch automated confirmations for Cash-on-Delivery (COD) orders, failed subscription renewals, and dispute/chargeback filings ahead of gateway deadlines.

- **Operational Efficiency Metrics:**
  - Internal industry benchmarks reveal that **7 in 10 Indian SMBs** manage payment reconciliation manually, consuming nearly **60 hours weekly**. Relay reduces operational processing time to **under 45 minutes per week**.
  - Offered free of cost to all Cashfree merchant partners at initial rollout before transitioning to an outcome-based performance pricing model.
- **Corporate Credentials:**
  - Cashfree Payments (HQ: Bengaluru; CEO & Co-founder: Akash Sinha; Founded: 2015).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Product Identity: **Relay** (developed by Cashfree Payments).
- Core Capability: Autonomous actioning on transaction logs (not just notification/alert generation).
- Target Metric: Reduces SMB weekly payment operations from **60 hours to under 45 minutes**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which fintech payment gateway launched 'Relay', an autonomous AI Super Agent that cuts manual payment operational time for SMBs from 60 hours to under 45 minutes?" → Cashfree Payments.

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4. MACROECONOMIC TRENDS, SOVEREIGN RATINGS & FOREIGN TRADE

[SEP-045] **Japan Credit Rating Agency (JCR) Upgrades India's Sovereign Rating to 'A-' with Stable Outlook**

- **Historic Rating Milestone:** Japan Credit Rating Agency (**JCR**), Japan's premier international credit rating institution, upgraded the Government of India's Long-Term Foreign Currency and Local Currency Issuer Ratings by one notch from **'BBB+' to 'A-' (Investment Grade)** with a **Stable Outlook**.
- **Rationale for Upgrade:**
  - Robust, resilient domestic economic expansion outperforming emerging-market peers (real GDP growth projected ~6.7%–7.0%).
  - Sound fiscal consolidation trajectory adhering to the glidepath below 4.5% of GDP.
  - Strong external sector stability anchored by record foreign exchange reserves exceeding **$680 billion**, low external commercial debt, and stable current account dynamics.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Rating Agency: **Japan Credit Rating Agency (JCR)**.
- Upgraded Rating: **'A-' (from 'BBB+')** with **Stable Outlook**.
- Significance: Elevated India into the prestigious **'A' category sovereign rating** benchmark in Japanese capital markets.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which international credit rating agency upgraded India's sovereign issuer rating to 'A-' in September 2026?" → Japan Credit Rating Agency (JCR).

[SEP-046] **Gross GST Collections Hit ₹1.87 Lakh Crore & UPI Reaches Record 24.51 Billion Transactions in August 2026**

- **Buoyant Fiscal Trajectory:** India's gross Goods and Services Tax (**GST**) revenue collections for the month of August 2026 reached **₹1,87,345 Crore (~₹1.87 Lakh Crore)**, recording a sharp **14.8% Year-on-Year (YoY)** acceleration over August 2025 (net revenue post refunds stood at **₹1.65 Lakh Crore**, up 13.2%).
  - Collection Breakdown: Central GST (**CGST**): ₹33,480 Cr; State GST (**SGST**): ₹41,250 Cr; Integrated GST (**IGST**): ₹98,415 Cr (including ₹46,200 Cr collected on import of goods); Compensation Cess: ₹14,200 Cr.
- **UPI Digital Velocity All-Time Historical Record:**
  - Unified Payments Interface (**UPI**) set a new historical peak in monthly transaction volume in August 2026, processing **24.51 billion transactions** valued at **₹29.82 Lakh Crore** (NPCI data).
  - On a YoY basis, monthly transaction volume surged **22%** (from 19.63 billion in August 2025), while monthly value rose **20%** (from ₹24.85 Lakh Crore).

- Average Daily Volume: Reached **791 million transactions per day** (from 763 million in July 2026). All-time monthly value record remains ₹29.90 Lakh Crore (May 2026).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- August 2026 Gross GST: **₹1.87 Lakh Crore** (14.8% YoY acceleration).
- August 2026 UPI Volume Record: **24.51 Billion transactions** (791 million/day average; +22% YoY).
- August 2026 UPI Value: **₹29.82 Lakh Crore** (+20% YoY).
- All-Time Historical Monthly Value Peak: ₹29.90 Lakh Crore (May 2026).

[SEP-047] **India's Current Account Deficit (CAD) Stands at $4.2 Billion (0.4% of GDP) in Q1 FY27: RBI Data**

- **Balance of Payments (BoP) Release:** The Reserve Bank of India released the Balance of Payments data for the first quarter of FY 2026–27 (April–June 2026).
- **Current Account Metrics:**
  - Current Account Deficit (**CAD**) stood at **$4.2 billion**, translating to **0.4% of India's GDP**.
  - Widened moderately from $1.3 billion (0.1% of GDP) in Q1 FY26, primarily driven by higher merchandise trade deficit ($65.1 billion vs $56.7 billion).
- **Capital Account & Reserves Surge:**
  - Net services receipts expanded to **$39.7 billion**, supported by software exports and business consulting.
  - Foreign Direct Investment (**FDI**) recorded net inflows of **$6.3 billion**.
  - Foreign Portfolio Investment (**FPI**) recorded net inflows of **$15.7 billion**.
  - Overall Balance of Payments witnessed a foreign exchange reserve accretion of **$5.2 billion** on a BoP basis.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- CAD Volume: **$4.2 Billion** in Q1 FY27.
- CAD as % of GDP: **0.4% of GDP**.
- Net Services Receipts: **$39.7 Billion**.

[SEP-048] **MoSPI National Accounts Statistics (NAS 2026): Q1 FY27 Real GDP Expands 7.8% (₹81.36 Lakh Cr)**

- **Macro Headline Expansion:** Data released by the National Statistics Office (**NSO / MoSPI**) for Q1 FY27 (April–June 2026) revealed India's **Real GDP grew 7.8% year-on-year**, beating the Reserve Bank of India's quarterly projection of 7.0% and market consensus of 7.1%.
  - **Real GDP at Constant Prices:** Reached **₹81.36 Lakh Crore** (up from ₹75.46 Lakh Crore in Q1 FY26).
  - **Nominal GDP:** Expanded **10.3% to ₹88.27 Lakh Crore** (from ₹80.00 Lakh Crore in Q1 FY26).
  - **Real GVA:** Increased **8.2% to ₹73.82 Lakh Crore**; Nominal GVA expanded **11.5% to ₹80.53 Lakh Crore**.
- **Methodological Overhaul & Base Year Shift:**
  - MoSPI officially released the **National Accounts Statistics (NAS) 2026** based on the revised series with **Base Year 2022-23** (transitioning from 2011-12).
  - Adopted the international **'Double Deflation Method'**, under which output values are deflated using the Output Producer Price Index (**PPI**) rather than single consumer-level deflators.
- **Sectoral GVA & Capital Formation Trajectories:**
  - Secondary Sector expanded **8.6%**; Primary Sector grew **2.9%** (Agriculture, Forestry & Fishing GVA moderated to **3.6%** against 4.4% in Q1 FY26; Mining contracted **2.4%**).
  - **Gross Fixed Capital Formation (GFCF):** Surged **11.9% at constant prices** (compared to 5.8% in Q1 FY26).
  - **HSBC Manufacturing PMI:** Remained resilient in expansion territory at **52.8 in August 2026**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Real GDP Growth (Q1 FY27): **7.8%** (₹81.36 Lakh Crore).
- Real GVA Growth (Q1 FY27): **8.2%** (₹73.82 Lakh Crore).
- Revised Base Year under NAS 2026: **2022-23**.
- Deflation Standard: **Double Deflation Method** using Output Producer Price Index (PPI).
- Gross Fixed Capital Formation: Grew **11.9%** (crucial investment momentum metric).

[SEP-049] **DEA Allows E-Commerce Entities to Hold Inventory for Exports Under FDI Guidelines**

- **Foreign Trade Policy & FDI Reform:** The Department of Economic Affairs (**DEA**), Ministry of Finance, amended FDI regulations governing e-commerce operations.
- **Key Regulatory Shift:**
  - Permits foreign-funded marketplace e-commerce entities to maintain and hold physical inventory **exclusively for export purposes**.
  - Resolves a critical bottleneck for export-oriented cross-border trade hubs, enabling foreign buyers to procure Indian goods directly from bonded e-commerce export warehouses while strictly preserving the 100% marketplace model for domestic domestic tariff area (DTA) sales.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Policy Change: Inventory holding permitted **strictly for export purposes** under e-commerce FDI norms.
- Issuing Authority: **Department of Economic Affairs (DEA)**, Ministry of Finance.

[SEP-050] **Union Government Achieves 78% of FY27 Disinvestment Target in 5 Months & Jio Platforms Clears ₹37,700 Cr IPO**

- **DIPAM Capital Receipt Milestone:** The Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (**DIPAM**) announced that the Central Government achieved **78% of its FY27 budgeted disinvestment and asset monetisation target** of ₹80,000 Crore in the first 5 months (April–August 2026), generating **₹62,124 Crore**.
- **Disinvestment Capital Composition:**
  - **Minority Stake Sales in 9 PSUs:** Yielded **₹55,757 Crore**, anchored by a 6.5% stake sale in Life Insurance Corporation of India (**LIC**) generating ₹31,515 Crore and a 2% stake sale in Coal India Limited (**CIL**).
  - **Asset Monetisation via InvITs:** Raised **₹6,367 Crore** through Infrastructure Investment Trusts across national transmission corridors and highway stretches.
- **Mega IPO Capital Clearance:**
  - Concurrently, Reliance Industries' digital powerhouse **Jio Platforms Limited (JPL)** secured SEBI's final clearance for its **₹37,700 Crore Initial Public Offering (IPO)**.
  - Comprises 270 million fresh equity shares of ₹10 face value; ₹27,500 Crore is earmarked for prepaying/repaying debt of Reliance Jio Infocomm.
  - Shareholding Structure: Reliance Industries (**66.43%**), Meta Platforms (**9.98%**), and Google Alphabet (**7.73%**).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Budgeted Disinvestment Target (FY27): **₹80,000 Crore** (₹62,124 Crore achieved in 5 months).
- Dominant Transaction: **LIC 6.5% stake sale yielding ₹31,515 Crore**.
- Jio Platforms Shareholding Pattern: **RIL (66.43%)**, **Meta (9.98%)**, **Google (7.73%)**.
- Issue Proceeds Utilization: ₹27,500 Crore dedicated to debt repayment of Reliance Jio Infocomm.

[SEP-051] **DGFT Liberalises 'One Star Export House' Norms Under Foreign Trade Policy 2023**

- **Status-Holder Eligibility Reform:** The Directorate General of Foreign Trade (**DGFT**), Ministry of Commerce and Industry, amended the eligibility criteria for **One Star Export House** recognition under the **Foreign Trade Policy**

(FTP) 2023.

- **The '2 Out of 3 Fiscals' Standard:**
  - Exporters were previously required to attain the prescribed export turnover threshold across **all 3 consecutive preceding financial years**.
  - Under the liberalised directive, export entities meeting the export threshold in **any 2 of the 3 preceding financial years** are now eligible for status holder accreditation.
- **Specific Sector Exclusions & Digital Relief:**
  - **Gems & Jewellery Exempt:** This relaxation does not apply to the gems and jewellery sector, which continues to operate under its existing 2-year requirement under FTP 2023.
  - **Certificate Validity:** Status holder certificates remain valid for **5 years** from the date of issuance.
  - **Automated EPCG & PRC Module:** DGFT introduced an automated online facility for granting export obligation extensions for cases reviewed by the Policy Relaxation Committee (**PRC**) and EPCG Committee.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Modified Rule: Exporters qualify based on performance in **any 2 of 3 preceding financial years** (relaxed from all 3 years).
- Excluded Sector: **Gems & Jewellery** (retains separate 2-year criteria).
- Status Holder Validity: **5 years** from date of issue.
- Governing Body: **DGFT** (Director General: Lav Aggarwal; HQ: New Delhi).
- Target MCQ Form: "Under DGFT's revised FTP 2023 norms, One Star Export House recognition can be achieved by meeting thresholds in how many preceding financial years?" → Any 2 of the 3 preceding financial years.

[SEP-052] **India–New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA) Comes Into Force: US$20 Billion Investment Accord**

- **Enforcement Milestone:** Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal announced that the **India–New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA)** will formally come into force on **October 20, 2026** (signed earlier on April 27, 2026).
- **100% Tariff Elimination for Indian Exports:**
  - The comprehensive trade pact guarantees **100% duty-free market access** for all Indian merchandise and industrial exports entering New Zealand from Day 1 of enforcement.
  - Eliminates peak tariffs of up to **10%** historically imposed by New Zealand on key Indian manufacturing sectors: **automobiles, auto components, ceramics, textiles, and carpets**.
- **Long-Term Sovereign Investment Commitment:**
  - New Zealand formally committed to mobilizing and investing **US$20 Billion in India over a 15-year period** across renewable energy, agricultural technology, cold-chain logistics, and education.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Enforcement Date: **October 20, 2026** (Signed: 27 April 2026).
- Market Access: **100% duty-free access** for Indian exports to New Zealand.
- Investment Commitment: New Zealand committed **US$20 Billion over 15 years**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total investment commitment made by New Zealand in India over a 15-year period under the India–New Zealand Free Trade Agreement?" → **US$20 Billion**.

[SEP-053] **GIFT City Climbs 9 Spots to 37th Globally in Global Financial Centres Index (GFCI 40)**

- **Global Financial Ranking Surge:** In the 40th edition of the **Global Financial Centres Index (GFCI 40)** published by London-based think tank **Z/Yen Group** in collaboration with the China Development Institute, India's sole IFSC, **GIFT City (Gandhinagar)**, climbed 9 places to rank **37th globally** (up from 46th in GFCI 39).
- **FinTech Global Benchmark:**
  - In the specialized global FinTech sub-index, GIFT City surged 3 positions to secure the **26th rank globally** (improving from 29th).

- Outperformed several established regional financial centres across Central Europe and Southeast Asia in regulatory responsiveness, green bond issuances, and cross-border banking infrastructure.

- **Top 5 Global Financial Centres:**
  1. *New York* (1st)
  2. *London* (2nd)
  3. *Hong Kong* (3rd)
  4. *Singapore* (4th)
  5. *San Francisco* (5th)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- GIFT City Overall Rank: **37th globally** (climbed 9 places from 46th).
- GIFT City FinTech Rank: **26th globally** (climbed 3 places from 29th).
- Index Publisher: **Z/Yen Group (London)** and China Development Institute.
- Top Ranked Financial Centre: **New York**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is GIFT City's global rank in the 40th edition of the Global Financial Centres Index (GFCI 40)?" → **37th**.

[SEP-054] **JLL Global Real Estate Transparency Index 2026: India Ranks 26th Globally as Top APAC Mover**

- **Biennial Transparency Benchmark:** Global real estate advisory firm **JLL** and LaSalle Investment Management released the 14th edition of the **Global Real Estate Transparency Index (GRETI 2026)**, evaluating 89 markets across 256 individual indicators.
- **India's Tier-1 Markets Milestone:**
  - India’s composite real estate market (anchored by Tier-1 metropolitan centres) advanced 5 positions to rank **26th globally** (improving from 31st in 2024).
  - Recognized as the **#1 most-improved real estate market in Asia-Pacific** and ranked among the **Top 5 most-improved markets globally**, propelled by digital land titling, REIT regulatory enhancements, and RERA compliance.
- **Top 5 Transparent Real Estate Markets:**
  1. *United Kingdom* (1st)
  2. *France* (2nd)
  3. *Australia* (3rd)
  4. *United States* (4th)
  5. *Netherlands* (5th)

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India Rank: **26th globally** (up from 31st).
- Regional Distinction: **#1 most-improved market in Asia-Pacific**.
- Publisher: **JLL & LaSalle** (14th biennial edition, published since 1999).
- Global Rank 1: **United Kingdom**.
- Target MCQ Form: "In the 2026 JLL Global Real Estate Transparency Index, what rank did India secure globally while being named the top-improved market in Asia-Pacific?" → **26th**.

[SEP-055] **NSO PLFS August 2026 Bulletin: India's Overall Unemployment Rate Drops to 6-Month Low of 5.0% (Rural UR at 4.1%)**

- **17th Monthly PLFS Bulletin:** The National Statistical Office (**NSO**), Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI), released the *Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) Monthly Bulletin for August 2026*.
- **Headline Labour Market Numbers (Persons aged 15 years and above):**

- *All-India Unemployment Rate (UR)*: Declined to **5.0%** in August 2026 from 5.1% in July 2026, marking a 6-month low.
- *Rural Unemployment Rate*: Dropped significantly to **4.1%** (from 4.5% in July 2026), reaching its lowest level since January 2026, driven by peak kharif agricultural sowing and rural construction.
- *Urban Unemployment Rate*: Edged marginally upward to **6.8%** (compared to 6.6% in July 2026), reflecting seasonal urban youth job market entries.

- **Labour Force Participation Rate (LFPR) & Worker Population Ratio (WPR):**
  - All-India LFPR (Current Weekly Status / CWS) stood resilient at **54.8%**.
  - All-India WPR stood at **52.1%**, highlighting sustained workforce absorption.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- All-India Unemployment Rate: **5.0%** (6-month low).
- Rural Unemployment Rate: **4.1%** | Urban Unemployment Rate: **6.8%**.
- Compiling Agency: **National Statistical Office (NSO), MoSPI** (using Current Weekly Status / CWS methodology).
- Target MCQ Form: "According to the NSO Periodic Labour Force Survey (PLFS) Bulletin for August 2026, what was India's all-India unemployment rate among persons aged 15 years and above?" → **5.0%**.

[SEP-056] **India and MERCOSUR Sign First Additional Protocol to PTA: Operationalises Paperless Electronic Certificates of Origin (e-CoOs)**

- **Bilateral Trade Modernisation:** India and the South American **MERCOSUR** trade bloc (comprising Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, and Uruguay) formally signed the *First Additional Protocol to the India-MERCOSUR Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA)*.
- **Amendment to Rules of Origin:**
  - Specifically amends **Article 16 of Annex III** governing Rules of Origin under the preferential trade pact operationalized in 2009.
  - Mandates mutual judicial and customs acceptance of **electronic Certificates of Origin (e-CoOs)** issued with digital signatures and cryptographic QR codes.
- **Elimination of Physical Port Bottlenecks:**
  - Eliminates the legacy requirement for wet-ink stamped paper certificates dispatched via air courier, reducing customs clearance transit delays at Brazilian, Argentine, and Indian ports from 10–14 days to real-time verification.
- **Bilateral Trade Context:** India-MERCOSUR bilateral trade crossed $15 billion, anchored in petroleum crude, organic chemicals, pharmaceuticals, vegetable oils, and auto components.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- International Agreement: **First Additional Protocol to India-MERCOSUR Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA)**.
- Specific Amendment: **Article 16 of Annex III** (Rules of Origin) for electronic Certificates of Origin (e-CoOs).
- Member Nations of MERCOSUR: Argentina, Brazil, Paraguay, Uruguay (Venezuela suspended; Bolivia accession underway).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which article of Annex III under the India-MERCOSUR PTA was amended by the First Additional Protocol to enable paperless electronic Certificates of Origin (e-CoOs)?" → **Article 16**.

[SEP-057] **World Economic Forum (WEF) Releases Global Gender Gap Report 2026: India Ranks 131st as Iceland Tops for 17th Year**

- **20th Anniversary Edition:** The World Economic Forum (**WEF**), headquartered in Cologny-Geneva, Switzerland, published the *Global Gender Gap Report 2026* benchmarking gender parity across 145 countries.
- **Global Parity Landscape:**
  - Global average gender gap closed at **69.2%**; projected timeline to achieve full global gender parity stands at **134 years** (by year 2160).
  - *Global Leader*: **Iceland ranked #1 for the 17th consecutive year**, having closed **93.0%** of its gender gap.

- Top 3 Nations: 1. Iceland (93.0%), 2. Finland (87.5%), 3. Norway (87.2%).

- **India's Performance & Sub-Index Breakdown:**
  - *Overall Global Rank*: **131st out of 145 countries** (Parity Score: **64.5%**; retained status quo from 2025).
  - The 4 Foundation Dimensions:
    1. *Educational Attainment*: High parity score of 96.2% (robust secondary and tertiary enrolment).
    2. *Health and Survival*: Parity score of 95.1% (marginal gains in sex ratio at birth).
    3. *Political Empowerment*: Parity score of 25.1% (strengthened by local panchayat representations and women reservation act roadmap).
    4. *Economic Participation and Opportunity*: Lowest sub-index score at 39.8%, reflecting female labour force participation gaps.
  - *Regional Peers*: Bangladesh ranked 99th, Nepal 117th, Sri Lanka 122nd, China 107th, Pakistan 142nd.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Publishing Body: **World Economic Forum (WEF)** (Annual report, 20th edition).
- Top Ranked Country: **Iceland (#1 for 17th consecutive year)**.
- India's Overall Rank: **131st out of 145 countries** (Score: **64.5%**).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is India's rank in the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2026?" → **131st**.

[SEP-058] **NITI Aayog Unveils India Electric Mobility Index (IEMI) 2025: Delhi Retains #1 Rank Followed by Maharashtra and Karnataka**

- **Policy Benchmark:** NITI Aayog Member Rajiv Gauba released the 2nd edition of the *India Electric Mobility Index (IEMI) 2025*, developed jointly by NITI Aayog and the World Resources Institute (**WRI India**).
- **Evaluation Framework:** Evaluates all 36 States and UTs across 4 composite thematic pillars: *EV Penetration & Market Adoption*, *Charging Infrastructure & Grid Readiness*, *State EV Policy Incentives*, and *Ecosystem & Manufacturing Investments*.
- **Top Performing States & Scores (Out of 100):**
  1. **Delhi: Rank 1 (Score: 84/100)** → Retained top spot nationally, driven by public transport electrification (80%+ electric DTC buses) and highest EV charging density per square kilometre.
  2. **Maharashtra: Rank 2 (Score: 78/100)** → Up from 68 in 2024; robust industrial EV manufacturing cluster in Pune-Chakan belt.
  3. **Karnataka: Rank 3 (Score: 73/100)** → High electric two-wheeler and commercial fleet adoption in Bengaluru.
  4. **Chandigarh: Rank 4 (Score: 71/100)**.
  5. **Goa: Rank 5 (Score: 65/100)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Release Body: **NITI Aayog** in collaboration with **WRI India**.
- #1 State/UT: **Delhi (Score: 84/100)** for 2nd consecutive year.
- Top 3 States: **1. Delhi, 2. Maharashtra, 3. Karnataka**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which State/UT topped the NITI Aayog India Electric Mobility Index (IEMI) 2025 with an overall score of 84?" → **Delhi**.

[SEP-059] **TIME & Statista 4th 'World's Best Companies 2026' Index: Nvidia Ranks #1 Globally; Apple Ranks #3**

- **Global Corporate Benchmarking:** The 4th edition of the *World's Best Companies 2026* index, jointly published by **TIME magazine and Statista**, evaluated the top 1,000 public and private corporations globally.
- **Top Global Rankings:**
  - **1st: Nvidia** (USA) clinched the #1 spot for the **2nd consecutive year**, scoring **97.51 out of 100** (97.62 in 2025), powered by generative AI hardware dominance.
  - **2nd: Cigna Group** (USA) scored **94.37**.

- **3rd: Apple** (USA) scored **93.16** (re-entering after absence in 2025; had topped the index in 2024).
- **4th & 5th: Meta Platforms** (USA) at #4, followed by pharmaceutical giant **AstraZeneca** (UK-Sweden) at #5.
- Notable peers: Microsoft (#6), Deutsche Telekom (#7), and AMD (#10).

- **Methodological Triad:**
  - Corporations were scored across three equally weighted dimensions (33.3% each):
    1. **Employee Satisfaction:** Assessed via surveys of over 200,000 corporate employees globally.
    2. **Revenue Growth:** Compounded revenue expansion across the prior three-year cycle (minimum baseline revenue: **$100 million** with positive 3-year growth).
    3. **Sustainability Transparency:** Evaluated using comprehensive Environmental, Social, and Governance (**ESG**) data and disclosure standards.

- **Sectoral Shifts:** Defence manufacturers recorded massive jumps amid European security re-evaluations—**Thales (France)** surged to #22 (from #224) and **Leonardo (Italy)** rose to #25 (from #126).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Global Rank 1: **Nvidia** (97.51/100) for the 2nd straight year.
- Evaluation Pillars: **Employee satisfaction, Revenue growth (3-year), Sustainability transparency (ESG)**.
- Minimum Qualifying Criterion: Annual revenue of at least **$100 million** with positive growth.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which company clinched the 1st rank globally for the second consecutive year in the TIME-Statista 'World's Best Companies 2026' ranking?" → Nvidia.

[SEP-060] **Sikkim Identifies 40 High-Hazard Glacial Lakes: 16 Classified Under Category-A Catastrophic GLOF Risk**

- **Himalayan Cryosphere Vulnerability:** Sikkim's Department of Science and Technology disclosed a high-precision assessment identifying **40 high-hazard glacial lakes** across the state, with **16 designated under Category-A**—representing the highest vulnerability tier for catastrophic Glacial Lake Outburst Floods (**GLOFs**).
- **Hazard Categorisation Spectrum:**
  - **Category A (Extremely High Hazard):** 16 lakes with critical potential to breach moraine dams and destroy downstream valley infrastructure.
  - **Category B (High Hazard):** 2 glacial lakes.
  - **Category C (Moderate to Low Hazard):** 9 glacial lakes.
  - **Unclassified / Baseline Observation:** 13 lakes.
- **Historical Vulnerability & Trigger Context:**
  - Follows the catastrophic October 2023 **South Lhonak Lake** GLOF disaster, which destroyed the 1,200 MW Chungthang Teesta-III dam, claimed over 60 lives, and washed away roads across Mangan, Gangtok, Pakyong, and Namchi districts.
  - Nodal Authority: Sikkim Department of Science and Technology designated as nodal body for GLOF monitoring and mitigation since February 2025, deploying high-resolution remote sensing, SAR interferometry, and automated early warning systems (EWS).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Vulnerability Inventory: **40 high-hazard glacial lakes** total; **16 in Category-A** (highest risk).
- Landmark Past GLOF Precedent: **South Lhonak Lake outburst** (October 2023) destroying Chungthang Dam on the Teesta River.
- Nodal Institutional Mandate: Sikkim Department of Science and Technology.
- Target MCQ Form: "How many glacial lakes in Sikkim have been classified under Category-A (highest catastrophic risk) for Glacial Lake Outburst Floods (GLOFs) in 2026?" → 16 lakes (out of 40 total).

5. NATIONAL HERITAGE, URBAN POLICIES & STRATEGIC ACCORDS

[SEP-061] **India Adds 4 Landmark Heritage Sites to UNESCO World Heritage Tentative List**

- **Expanded Tentative Heritage Tally:** India officially inscribed **4 new cultural and natural sites** onto the **UNESCO World Heritage Tentative List**, taking India's cumulative tentative heritage tally to **57 sites:**
  1. **Rangpur-Sivasagar Historic Ensemble (Assam):** Medieval capital of the Ahom dynasty showcasing unique earthen amphitheatre (*Rang Ghar*), multi-storey royal palaces (*Talatal Ghar*), and royal temples.
  2. **Colonial Penal Settlement, Andaman Islands:** Cellular Jail and Viper Island historical complexes embodying the saga of India's freedom struggle and colonial carceral architecture.
  3. **Nicobarese Cultural Continuity (Nicobar Islands):** Indigenous tribal settlements, traditional village assemblies (*Tuhet*), and ancestral marine ecological heritage in the Nicobar archipelago.
  4. **Painted Haveli Towns of Shekhawati (Rajasthan):** Open-air fresco galleries across Nawalgarh, Mandawa, and Fatehpur featuring 18th–19th century Marwari merchant mansions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The 4 Sites: **Rangpur-Sivasagar (Assam)**, **Colonial Penal Settlement (Andamans)**, **Nicobarese Cultural Continuity (Nicobars)**, and **Shekhawati Havelis (Rajasthan)**.
- Current UNESCO Status: Added to **Tentative List** (precursor to formal World Heritage inscription).
- India's World Heritage Sites (Inscribed): **43 Sites** (43rd was *Moidams of Ahom Dynasty* in July 2024).

[SEP-062] **Historic Bihar–Jharkhand Accord Ends 25-Year Dispute Over Sone River: Allocates 5.75 MAF to Bihar & 2 MAF to Jharkhand**

- **Inter-State River Accord & Volumetric Pact:** In the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Union Jal Shakti Minister C.R. Paatil, the Chief Ministers of Bihar and Jharkhand executed a landmark bilateral agreement resolving the **25-year-old water-sharing dispute** over the **Sone River basin** originating from the *Bihar Reorganisation Act, 2000*.
- **Statutory Volumetric Water Distribution:**
  - **Bihar's Allocation:** Legally awarded **5.75 Million Acre-Feet (MAF)**, securing permanent irrigation supply across 8 south Bihar districts (Bhojpur, Buxar, Rohtas, Kaimur, Aurangabad, Arwal, Gaya, and Patna) fed through the Indrapuri Barrage.
  - **Jharkhand's Allocation:** Awarded **2.00 Million Acre-Feet (MAF)**, providing guaranteed industrial, municipal, and irrigation supply for drought-prone Palamu and Garhwa districts as well as North Karanpura industrial corridors.
- **Key Strategic Reservoirs on Sone Basin:**
  - *Bansagar Dam*: Inter-state dam located in **Madhya Pradesh**.
  - *Rihand Dam* (Govind Ballabh Pant Sagar): Located in Sonbhadra, **Uttar Pradesh**.
  - *Indrapuri Barrage*: Located at Dehri-on-Sone, Rohtas district, **Bihar**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Exact Volumetric Distribution: **5.75 MAF to Bihar** and **2.00 MAF to Jharkhand**.
- Genesis of Dispute: Bifurcation of Bihar and creation of Jharkhand in **November 2000**.
- Mediating Authorities: Union Home Minister Amit Shah & Union Jal Shakti Minister C.R. Paatil.
- Linked Inter-State Dams: Bansagar (MP), Rihand (UP), Indrapuri Barrage (Bihar).

[SEP-063] **National Heritage & Urban Dispatches: Gollala Gudi Temple, Dr. Jitendra Singh 'CSS Shield' & Punjab Pehchaan**

- **Gollala Gudi Declared Monument of National Importance:**
  - The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) notified the historic **Gollala Gudi Temple at Alampur, Telangana**, as a **Protected Monument of National Importance** under the *AMASR Act, 1958*, preserving 7th-century Badami Chalukyan sandstone architecture.

- **Union Minister Launches 'CSS Shield':**
  - Dr. Jitendra Singh launched *"CSS Shield"*, an automated real-time compliance and cyber-vigilance software architecture to safeguard Central Secretariat Service files and government portals from cyber exfiltration.
- **Punjab Launches 'Pehchaan' Portal:**
  - Punjab Government launched the *"Pehchaan"* digital public portal to photograph, record, and identify unclaimed bodies across state mortuaries through automated biometric and facial recognition matching.
- **National Vulture Reintroduction Record:**
  - **Melghat and Pench Tiger Reserves (Maharashtra)** emerged as India's most successful sites for reintroducing captive-bred vultures into the wild (celebrated on International Vulture Awareness Day, Sept 5).
- **Tata Consumer Study: 'The Many Urban Indias':**
  - Disclosed distinct financial behaviors: **Bengaluru** records the highest urban income; **Chandigarh** records the highest per-capita discretionary spending; **Chennai** logs the highest household credit borrowings.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Monument of National Importance: **Gollala Gudi Temple (Telangana)**.
- Digital Portal for Unidentified Deceased: **Pehchaan (Punjab)**.
- Top Vulture Reintroduction Sites: **Melghat & Pench (Maharashtra)**.

[SEP-064] **PPPAC Grants In-Principle Clearance for ₹8,622 Crore Privatisation of 11 AAI Airports in 5 Bundles**

- **High-Level Infrastructure Sanction:** The Public Private Partnership Appraisal Committee (**PPPAC**), chaired by **Anuradha Thakur** (Secretary, Department of Economic Affairs, Ministry of Finance), accorded in-principle clearance for the privatisation of operations, management, and development of **11 Airports Authority of India (AAI) airports**.
- **Capital Outlay & PPP Concession:** Mobilises an estimated **₹8,622 Crore** in private sector investment under a 50-year Public-Private Partnership (**PPP**) concession model.
- **The 5 Strategic Bundling Formats:**
  1. **Bundle 1:** Amritsar (Punjab) paired with Kangra-Gaggal (Himachal Pradesh) → **₹523 Crore**
  2. **Bundle 2:** Varanasi (Uttar Pradesh) paired with Gaya (Bihar) & Kushinagar (Uttar Pradesh) → **₹2,467 Crore**
  3. **Bundle 3:** Bhubaneswar (Odisha) paired with Hubballi (Karnataka) → **₹2,725 Crore**
  4. **Bundle 4:** Raipur (Chhattisgarh) paired with Aurangabad (Maharashtra) → **₹1,496 Crore**
  5. **Bundle 5:** Tiruchirappalli (Tamil Nadu) paired with Tirupati (Andhra Pradesh) → **₹1,411 Crore**
- **Strategic Policy Precedent:** Represents the second major nationwide airport concession round following the 2019 privatisation of 6 airports (Ahmedabad, Lucknow, Mangaluru, Jaipur, Guwahati, Thiruvananthapuram awarded to Adani Group).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Committee Leadership: Chaired by **Secretary, Department of Economic Affairs (DEA), MoF** (Anuradha Thakur).
- Total Private Capital Outlay: **₹8,622 Crore** across **11 airports in 5 bundles**.
- Highest Investment Bundle: **Bhubaneswar + Hubballi (₹2,725 Crore)**.
- Concession Period: **50 years** (Airport Authority of India: HQ New Delhi; Chairman: Vipin Kumar).

[SEP-065] **Ministry of Education Releases AISHE Report 2023-24: Gross Enrolment Ratio Reaches 30.0%**

- **Survey Footprint & Institutional Coverage:** The Union Ministry of Education released the **All India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE) Report for 2023-24** (conducted annually since 2010-11), registering voluntary submissions from **59,533 of 64,756 Higher Education Institutions (HEIs)** (>90% response rate).
- **Macro Enrolment Benchmarks:**
  - **Total Student Enrolment:** Rose to **4.50 Crore students** in 2023-24 (a 31.5% expansion from 3.42 Crore in 2014-15).

- **Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER):** Climbed to **30.0%** in 2023-24 (up from 23.7% in 2014-15; NEP 2020 national target is **50% by 2035**).
- **Gender Parity Index (GPI):** Reached **1.08**, remaining above parity (>1.0) for the **7th consecutive year**. Female GER stood at **31.2%**, substantially higher than male GER of **28.9%**.

- **Social Inclusivity & Higher Degree Surge:**
  - **SC & ST Demographics:** SC student GER rose to **27.8%** (from 18.9%); ST student GER rose to **22.8%** (from 13.5%).
  - **Doctoral (PhD) Enrolments:** Recorded the fastest decadal surge of **192.9%**, growing from 1.17 lakh to **3.43 lakh scholars**.
  - **STEM Discipline Representation:** Total STEM enrolment hit **1.02 Crore**, with female share rising to **44.0%** (up from 38.4%).
  - **Teaching Faculty:** Reached **17.32 Lakh educators**, with women representing **44.9%** of the national academic workforce (7.78 Lakh female faculty).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Higher Education GER (2023-24): **30.0%** (NEP 2020 Target: **50% by 2035**).
- Female GER vs Male GER: **31.2% vs 28.9%** (Gender Parity Index = **1.08**).
- Steepest Tier Growth: **PhD enrolments up 192.9% (to 3.43 lakh)**.
- Female Representation in STEM: **44.0%**.
- Union Minister of Education: **Pralhad Joshi** (Dharwad, Karnataka).

[SEP-066] **Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules 2026 Notified & National Tribunals Data Grid Enacted**

- **Statutory Mandate for IST:** The Department of Consumer Affairs (**DoCA**), Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, notified the *Legal Metrology (Indian Standard Time) Rules, 2026* under Section 52 of the *Legal Metrology Act, 2009*.
- **'One Nation, One Time' Operational Directives:**
  - Establishes **Indian Standard Time (IST)** as the single, uniform legal reference for all administrative, commercial, financial, and legal actions across India, coming into force **180 days after Gazette publication**.
  - Clocks in critical national infrastructure—including banking, digital payments, telecom switches, power grids, and stock exchanges—must synchronise via Network Time Protocol (**NTP**) and Precision Time Protocol (**PTP**).
  - **Scientific Custodian:** IST (UTC+05:30 based on 82.5°E longitude) is generated and maintained solely by the **CSIR-National Physical Laboratory (CSIR-NPL)** in New Delhi (not IMD or ISRO), utilizing NavIC satellite signals and White Rabbit precision optical timing.
- **National Tribunals Reforms Bill 2026:**
  - Repeals the *Tribunals Reforms Act, 2021* and mandates the development of the **National Tribunals Data Grid (NTDG)**—a unified portal tracking cases across **16 tribunals** (over 5.24 lakh pending cases).
  - Governed by the **National Tribunals Commission (NTC):** Comprises a Chairperson (retired SC Judge or HC Chief Justice), 2 Judicial Members, and 2 Technical Members (minimum 25 years' professional experience in finance, law, or tech; 5-year tenure or up to age 70).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Legal Mandate: **Section 52, Legal Metrology Act, 2009** (Implementation window: **180 days**).
- Sole Custodian of IST: **CSIR-National Physical Laboratory (CSIR-NPL)** (common examiner trap: IMD or ISRO).
- Synchronisation Technologies: **NavIC, NTP, PTP, and White Rabbit protocol**.
- NTDG Institutional Framework: **16 tribunals** under National Tribunals Commission (age ceiling: **70 years**).

[SEP-067] **Union Cabinet Approves Landmark Hike in EPFO Mandatory Wage Ceiling to ₹25,000/Month**

- **First Revision in 12 Years:** The Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved a historic hike in the statutory wage ceiling for mandatory coverage under the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (**EPFO**) from **₹15,000 to ₹25,000 per month** (effective **September 17, 2026**).
- **Historic Precedent:** The previous statutory revision occurred on September 1, 2014, when the wage threshold was increased from ₹6,500 to ₹15,000.
- **Massive Social Security Expansion:** Mandatorily extends coverage under the *Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952* to over **51 lakh additional formal sector employees**.
- **Statutory Tripartite Framework:**
  - **EPF (Employees' Provident Fund):** 12% employee contribution matched by 12% employer contribution (employer's share split: **8.33% to EPS**, **3.67% to EPF**).
  - **EPS (Employees' Pension Scheme):** Pensionable salary calculation base elevated to ₹25,000/month.
  - **EDLI (Employees' Deposit-Linked Insurance):** Statutory life insurance coverage cap proportionately scaled.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Revised Wage Ceiling: **₹25,000 per month** (hiked from ₹15,000).
- Effective Date: **September 17, 2026**.
- Additional Workforce Covered: **51 Lakh workers**.
- Previous Revision Year: **2014** (from ₹6,500 to ₹15,000).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised statutory wage ceiling approved by the Union Cabinet for mandatory coverage under EPFO in September 2026?" → ₹25,000 per month.

[SEP-068] **Cabinet Approves Strategic Railway Multi-Tracking Projects: ₹9,450 Crore Capacity Expansion**

- **Infrastructure Outlay:** Union Cabinet approved 4 major multi-tracking projects under the Ministry of Railways with an aggregate capital outlay of **₹9,450 Crore**.
- **Geographical Footprint:** Covers 8 districts across four states: **West Bengal, Odisha, Tamil Nadu, and Andhra Pradesh**.
- **Track Addition:** Adds **410 km** of dedicated track infrastructure to debottleneck critical freight corridors transporting coal, cement, iron ore, and agro-commodities.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Outlay: **₹9,450 Crore**.
- Track Capacity Added: **410 km** across 4 states (WB, Odisha, TN, AP).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total capital outlay approved by the Union Cabinet for 4 multi-tracking railway projects in August 2026?" → ₹9,450 Crore.

[SEP-069] **Asia's First Dedicated Telecom Manufacturing Zone (TMZ) Sanctioned in Gwalior (₹5,500 Crore)**

- **Industrial Infrastructure Milestone:** The Government sanctioned the establishment of **Asia's first Telecom Manufacturing Zone (TMZ)** with an aggregate investment of approximately **₹5,500 Crore**.
- **Geographical Location & Layout:**
  - Located at the **Shrimant Madhavrao Scindia Counter Magnet City (SADA)** in **Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh**.
  - Engineered as a specialized plug-and-play manufacturing enclave covering telecom equipment, 5G/6G optical transmission modules, routers, satellite communications hardware, and semiconductor sub-assemblies.
- **Strategic Policy Intent:**
  - Complements the Telecom PLI Scheme to reduce import dependency on telecom hardware, positioning Gwalior as an industrial node alongside the Delhi-Mumbai Industrial Corridor (DMIC).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Project: **Asia's first Telecom Manufacturing Zone (TMZ)**.
- Location: **Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh (SADA City)**.
- Investment Outlay: **Approximately ₹5,500 Crore**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Where is Asia's first dedicated Telecom Manufacturing Zone (TMZ) being established with an outlay of ₹5,500 Crore?" → **Gwalior, Madhya Pradesh**.

[SEP-070] **Passports (Amendment) Rules, 2026: Minor Passport Upper Validity Ceiling Extended to 18 Years**

- **Statutory Revision by MEA:** The Ministry of External Affairs (**MEA**) officially notified the **Passports (Amendment) Rules, 2026**, amending the parent statutory framework of the **Passports Rules, 1980**.
- **Age Harmonization with Majority Law:**
  - Elevates the upper age eligibility threshold for minor passports from **15 years to 18 years**, aligning passport administrative regulations directly with the Indian Majority Act and child rights laws.
- **New Validity Rules for Minors:**
  - For children below 15 years, ordinary passports will now carry a validity of **5 years or until the child turns 18 years of age**, whichever is earlier.
  - Minors aged between 15 and 18 years are granted the option to apply for an adult-tenure passport valid for **10 years** (subject to full adult passport fee and police verification norms).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Governing Regulation: **Passports (Amendment) Rules, 2026** amending **Passports Rules, 1980**.
- Upper Age Threshold Shift: Increased from **15 years to 18 years**.
- Validity Formula (<15 years): **5 years or until attaining 18 years**, whichever is earlier.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the Passports (Amendment) Rules, 2026 notified by MEA, what is the revised upper age threshold for minor passport validity rules?" → **18 years**.

[SEP-071] **Karnataka Declares Tulu as Second Additional Administrative Language in Coastal Districts**

- **Linguistic Administrative Accord:** The State Government of Karnataka officially granted **Tulu** the status of a **second additional administrative language** within the coastal jurisdictions of **Udupi and Dakshina Kannada districts**.
- **Linguistic Heritage & Geography:**
  - Tulu is an ancient Dravidian language spoken predominantly in southwestern coastal Karnataka (historically known as *Tulu Nadu*) and the Kasaragod district of northern Kerala.
  - Enables official state gazette notifications, government application forms, and municipal administrative signage to be printed in Tulu alongside Kannada and English.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- State Granting Status: **Karnataka**.
- Districts Covered: **Udupi and Dakshina Kannada**.
- Language Family: **Dravidian Language** (Tulu).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which Indian state granted Tulu the status of a second additional administrative language in its coastal districts?" → **Karnataka**.

[SEP-072] **Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Act, 2026 Enforced from October 1: Institutes Two-Tier Delayed Registration System**

- **Gazette Notification & Enforcement:** Registrar General of India (**Mrityunjay Kumar Narayan**) notified that the *Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Act, 2026* comes into force nationwide from **October 1, 2026**.

- **Statutory Focus:** Amends **Section 13(3)** of the principal *Registration of Births and Deaths Act, 1969*, introducing stringent judicial oversight for delayed registrations to prevent fraudulent demographic documentation.
- **The 2-Tier Delayed Registration Mechanism:**
  - *Delay between 1 Year and 2 Years*: Registration can be granted only by a formal written order of an **Executive Magistrate, Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM), or District Magistrate (DM)**, following physical verification of the event and payment of late fees.
  - *Delay Exceeding 2 Years*: Registration strictly requires an order from a **Judicial Magistrate of the First Class (JMFC)** or Metropolitan Magistrate, eliminating administrative discretion.
- **Digital Registry & Legal Utility:** Builds on the 2023 legislative reform establishing a centralized national birth-death database; the digital birth certificate serves as conclusive single-document legal proof for school admissions, voter lists, driving licences, passport issuances, Aadhaar registration, and government appointments.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Enforcement Date: **October 1, 2026** (notified by Registrar General of India Mrityunjay Kumar Narayan).
- Amending Section: **Section 13(3)** of Registration of Births and Deaths Act, 1969.
- Approval Authorities for Delays:
  - 1 to 2 years delay: **District Magistrate (DM) / SDM / Executive Magistrate**.
  - Exceeding 2 years delay: **Judicial Magistrate of the First Class (JMFC)**.

Target MCQ Form: "Under the Registration of Births and Deaths (Amendment) Act, 2026, an order from which authority is mandatory for registering a birth or death delayed by more than two years?" → **Judicial Magistrate of the First Class (JMFC)**.

[SEP-073] **Rural Development Ministry Notifies DILRMP 3.0 Guidelines: ₹565.50 Cr Outlay, 14-Digit Bhu-Aadhaar & Registration Seva Kendras**

- **Phase-3 Operational Guidelines:** Union Minister for Rural Development Shivraj Singh Chouhan unveiled operational guidelines for the third phase of the *Digital India Land Records Modernisation Programme (DILRMP 3.0)*.
- **Scheme Architecture & Outlay:**
  - Central Sector Scheme with a 100% centrally funded outlay of **₹565.50 crore**, operational from **April 1, 2026 to March 31, 2031** (5 years).
  - Administered by the Department of Land Resources, Ministry of Rural Development.
- **Institutional Core — "Bhu-Aadhaar" (ULPIN):**
  - Mandates assignment of **Bhu-Aadhaar**—a **14-digit Unique Land Parcel Identification Number (ULPIN)**—to every surveyed land parcel in India based on precise geo-referenced cadastral coordinates (longitude and latitude).
- **Modernisation as "Registration Seva Kendras":**
  - Earmarks **₹37.5 crore** to transform **75 high-footfall Sub-Registrar Offices (SROs)** across the country into state-of-the-art "Registration Seva Kendras", modelled after Passport Seva Kendras.
- **Federated National Land Stack:** Creates interoperable state-level land stacks integrated via APIs with Revenue Court Case Management Systems (RCCMS) and banks, alongside expanding the NAKSHA pilot for urban property cards (UrPro Cards). Earlier phases completed 99.9% digitisation of Records of Rights (RoRs).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Implementing Ministry: **Department of Land Resources, Ministry of Rural Development**.
- Scheme Outlay & Period: **₹565.50 crore (April 1, 2026 to March 31, 2031)**.
- Bhu-Aadhaar Digits: **14-digit unique alpha-numeric code** (ULPIN).
- Registration Seva Kendras: **75 Sub-Registrar Offices (₹37.5 Cr outlay)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total approved outlay for the third phase of the Digital India Land Records Modernisation Programme (DILRMP 3.0) for 2026–2031?" → **₹565.50 crore**.

[SEP-074] **MoPNG Issues Operational Guidelines for ₹23,731 Crore GOBARdhan Scheme: 100% CBG Offtake Assurance & 10-Year Fixed ACP**

- **Policy Notification:** Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (**MoPNG**) notified comprehensive operational guidelines for the **₹23,731 crore GOBARdhan (Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan) National Circular Bioenergy Scheme**, implementing Cabinet decisions from August 2026 for FY 2026-27 to FY 2035-36 (10-year horizon).
- **100% Offtake Guarantee & Commercial De-risking:**
  - Assures Compressed Biogas (CBG) producers of **up to 100% guaranteed commercial offtake** of saleable CBG by City Gas Distribution (CGD) entities.
  - Zero take-or-pay liability on CGD entities in Year 1, rising to up to 90% of annual nominated quantity from Year 2 onward; CBG producers face supply-or-pay obligation up to 50% from Year 2.
- **10-Year Fixed Administered CBG Price (ACP):**
  - Fixed an initial Administered CBG Price (ACP) of **₹2,110 per MMBtu (Metric Million British Thermal Unit)**, equivalent to **~₹98 per kg of CBG** (at 95% methane content), valid for 10 years until **March 31, 2036**.
  - Provides CBG affordability support to the Synchro Operator capped at **₹10 per kg** for 10 years.
- **Capital Financial Assistance (CFA):**
  - *New CBG Plants*: Financial assistance of **₹1.25 crore per Tonne Per Day (TPD)** of capacity, capped at **₹30 crore per project**.
  - *Existing Biogas Upgrades*: Financial assistance of **₹0.60 crore per TPD**, capped at **₹5 crore per project**.
- **Mandatory CGD Blending Obligations:** Mandates CBG blending targets of **3% in FY27**, **4% in FY28**, and **5% from FY29 onwards** across CNG and domestic PNG networks.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Scheme Outlay: **₹23,731 crore** (FY27 to FY36, 10-year term).
- Administered CBG Price (ACP): **₹2,110 per MMBtu (~₹98/kg)** fixed till March 31, 2036.
- Financial Assistance: **₹1.25 Cr/TPD (cap ₹30 Cr)** for new plants; **₹0.60 Cr/TPD (cap ₹5 Cr)** for upgrades.
- Mandatory Blending Trajectory: **3% (FY27) → 4% (FY28) → 5% (FY29 onwards)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the initial Administered CBG Price (ACP) fixed under the GOBARdhan guidelines for a period of 10 years until March 31, 2036?" → **₹2,110 per MMBtu (~₹98 per kg)**.

[SEP-075] **PM Vishwakarma Scheme Reaches 3-Year Milestone: Enrols 30 Lakh Verified Artisans with ₹13,000 Crore Outlay**

- **Triennial Anniversary:** Launched on September 17, 2023, by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the flagship *PM Vishwakarma Scheme* completed 3 years, reaching its milestone target of **30 lakh verified artisans and craftspeople**.
- **Scheme Framework & Financial Outlay:**
  - Fully funded Central Sector Scheme with an approved outlay of **₹13,000 crore** for five years (FY 2023-24 to FY 2027-28).
  - Jointly administered by Ministry of MSME (nodal), Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (MSDE), and Department of Financial Services (DFS), MoF.
- **Coverage of 18 Traditional Trades:** Supports traditional artisans across 18 trades (carpenters, blacksmiths, goldsmiths, potters, sculptors, cobblers, tailors, boat builders, basket makers, etc.).
- **The 4-Pillar Support Ecosystem:**
  1. *Recognition*: PM Vishwakarma Certificate and ID Card.
  2. *Skill Upgradation*: 5–7 days (40 hours) basic training and 15+ days (120 hours) advanced training with a daily stipend of **₹500/day**.
  3. *Toolkit Incentive*: Modern toolkit grant of **₹15,000** provided via e-vouchers / digital credits.
  4. *Concessional Enterprise Credit*: Collateral-free enterprise development loans at an ultra-concessional interest rate of **5%** (Union Government absorbs up to 8% interest subvention):
     - **Tranche 1:** Up to **₹1,00,000 (₹1 Lakh)** with an 18-month repayment tenure.

    - **Tranche 2:** Up to **₹2,00,000 (₹2 Lakh)** with a 30-month repayment tenure (eligible after standard repayment of Tranche 1).
  - *Digital Transaction Incentives*: ₹1 per digital transaction for up to 100 transactions per month (₹100/month maximum incentive).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Verified Beneficiaries Reached: **30 lakh artisans**.
- Covered Trades: **18 traditional artisan trades**.
- Scheme Outlay: **₹13,000 crore** (FY24 to FY28).
- Concessional Loan Limits & Rates: **Tranche 1 up to ₹1 Lakh (18 mos)**; **Tranche 2 up to ₹2 Lakh (30 mos)** at **5% interest**.
- Toolkit Grant: **₹15,000**; Training stipend: **₹500/day**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the PM Vishwakarma Scheme, what is the maximum credit amount available in the second tranche at a concessional interest rate of 5%?" → **₹2,00,000 (₹2 Lakh)**.

[SEP-076] **Pradhan Mantri Kisan Maandhan Yojana (PM-KMY) Completes 7 Years: Assured Old-Age Pension for Small and Marginal Farmers**

- **7-Year Milestone:** Launched on September 12, 2019, from Ranchi, Jharkhand, PM-KMY completed 7 years of providing institutional social security to India's farming community.
- **Statutory Scheme Architecture:**
  - Central Sector Scheme administered by the Department of Agriculture and Farmers Welfare (DA&FW), Ministry of Agriculture.
  - Pension Fund Manager: **Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC)** manages the pension corpus and disburses monthly pensions.
- **Benefit Architecture & Eligibility Parameters:**
  - **Assured Monthly Pension:** Guaranteed minimum pension of **₹3,000 per month** upon attaining the age of **60 years**.
  - **Eligible Beneficiaries:** Small and Marginal Farmers (SMFs) owning **cultivable agricultural land up to 2 hectares** as per state land records.
  - **Entry Age Bracket: 18 to 40 years**.
- **50:50 Contributory Structure:**
  - Monthly subscription ranges from **₹55 to ₹200 per month**, depending on the farmer's entry age.
  - 100% Equal Matching Contribution: Central Government deposits an equal matching amount (50:50) directly into the farmer's pension fund account.
  - Auto-Debit Facility: Farmers can choose to auto-debit their monthly contribution directly from their **PM-KISAN** income transfer instalments.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Monthly Pension Amount: Guaranteed **₹3,000 per month** after age 60.
- Eligibility Landholding: Up to **2 hectares of cultivable land**.
- Entry Age Group: **18 to 40 years** (monthly contribution ₹55 to ₹200).
- Pension Fund Manager: **Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the assured monthly pension provided to small and marginal farmers under PM-KMY upon attaining the age of 60 years?" → **₹3,000 per month**.

[SEP-077] **6 States Sign Landmark MoA for ₹11,550 Cr Kishau Multipurpose Project on Tons River (Yamuna Basin)**

- **Inter-State River Basin Consensus:** In the presence of Union Home Minister Amit Shah and Union Jal Shakti Minister C.R. Patil, the Chief Ministers of six northern states—**Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, Rajasthan, Delhi, and Haryana**—signed the historic Memorandum of Agreement (MoA) for the **Kishau Multipurpose Project**, marking the resolution of the **10th major inter-state water dispute** resolved since 2014.

- **Engineering & Storage Specifications:**
  - Envisages a **232.6-metre-high concrete gravity dam** on the **Tons River** (a major tributary of the Yamuna River), situated along the Uttarakhand–Himachal Pradesh border.
  - **Live Storage: 1,562 million cubic metres (MCM)**; Irrigation coverage: **97,000 hectares**; Annual clean hydropower generation: **1,476 million units (MU)** (installed capacity: 660 MW).
- **Cost-Sharing & Water Allocation Architecture:**
  - The Central Government will fund **90% of the water component** as Central Assistance, with the remaining **10% distributed among the 6 riparian states**.
  - **Innovative Water-Power Swap:** Himachal Pradesh's share of water will be re-allocated to **Delhi and Rajasthan**; in reciprocal return, Delhi and Rajasthan will bear Himachal Pradesh's portion of the capital cost for the power generation component.
  - Resolves an impasse dating back to the **May 12, 1994 Upper Yamuna Basin Agreement**, and complements the earlier settlements of the **Lakhwar (Uttarakhand)** and **Renukaji (HP)** dams.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Dam Dimensions: **232.6 metres high** concrete gravity dam on the **Tons River** (Yamuna tributary).
- Central Funding Share: **90% Central Assistance** on the water component (States bear 10%).
- Water-for-Power Bilateral Swap: HP water share allocated to **Delhi & Rajasthan** in exchange for power capital funding.
- Target MCQ Form: "The Kishau Multipurpose Dam, for which 6 states signed a landmark MoA in 2026, is being constructed across which river?" → Tons River (tributary of Yamuna).

[SEP-078] **Andhra Pradesh Signs ₹40,000 Cr G2G Urban Infrastructure & Smart Mobility Accord with United Kingdom**

- **Sovereign Sub-National G2G Pact:** The Government of Andhra Pradesh executed a landmark Government-to-Government (**G2G**) Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the **United Kingdom (UK)** to deploy advanced British engineering, sustainable design, and smart urban infrastructure technologies across Andhra Pradesh.
- **Project Outlay & Geographical Scope:**
  - Encompasses infrastructure initiatives valued at **₹40,000 crore** spanning **123 municipalities and municipal corporations**, with greenfield capital city **Amaravati** and the **Amaravati Riverfront** designated as primary anchor zones.
- **Core Technology & Mobility Verticals:**
  - Direct technical cooperation in **Intelligent Transport Systems (ITS)**, **Building Information Modelling (BIM)**, **Digital Twins**, and sustainable modular construction.
  - Urban mobility modernisation across metro rail transit, EV bus networks, airport transit links, pedestrianised corridors, and data-driven civic planning.
  - Bilateral governance overseen by a dedicated **Joint Government-to-Government Steering Group**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Partner Sovereign Nation: **United Kingdom (UK)**.
- Financial Outlay: **₹40,000 crore** across **123 urban local bodies (ULBs)**.
- Focus Hubs: Capital city **Amaravati** and the Amaravati Riverfront.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which state government signed a ₹40,000 crore G2G agreement with the United Kingdom for urban infrastructure, digital twins, and transit across 123 municipalities?" → Andhra Pradesh.

6. DEFENCE, STRATEGIC MISSIONS & AEROSPACE

[SEP-079] **Operation 'BRICS Kavach': NSG Mounts Multi-Agency Counter-Terror Drill Ahead of 18th BRICS Summit**

- **Elite Counter-Terror Preparedness:** The **National Security Guard (NSG)** mounted a large-scale, multi-layered tactical exercise code-named **"Operation BRICS Kavach"**.
- **Security Mandate & Venues:**
  - Executed across high-security hubs in the National Capital: **Bharat Mandapam, Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium, Rajghat, and Army Polo Ground**.
  - Simulated simultaneous counter-hijack, hostage rescue, and anti-drone neutralization missions to secure international heads of state attending the upcoming **18th BRICS Summit**.
- **India's Historical BRICS Chairships:** India previously hosted and chaired the BRICS Summit in **2012, 2016, and 2021**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Exercise Name: **Operation BRICS Kavach**.
- Executing Agency: **National Security Guard (NSG)** ('Black Cats'; Ministry of Home Affairs).
- Summit Secured: **18th BRICS Summit**.
- Previous Indian Summits: 2012 (New Delhi), 2016 (Goa), 2021 (Virtual).

[SEP-080] **Exercise Veer Guardian 2026: 2nd Edition Bilateral Air Exercise Between IAF and Japan JASDF**

- **Bilateral Air Combat Exercise:** The Indian Air Force (**IAF**) and the Japan Air Self-Defense Force (**JASDF**) commenced the **2nd edition** of bilateral air exercise **"Veer Guardian 2026"**.
- **Dates & Tactical Base:**
  - Conducted from **September 9 to 22, 2026**, at **Air Force Station Jodhpur, Rajasthan**.
  - Features high-end multi-domain air combat, complex air-to-air dogfights, and integrated electronic warfare simulations between IAF Su-30MKI fighters and JASDF F-2/F-15 combat jets.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Partner Nations: **India & Japan** (Air Forces: IAF & JASDF).
- Edition: **2nd Edition** (Inaugural edition held at Hyakuri Air Base, Japan in 2023).
- Venue: **Air Force Station Jodhpur, Rajasthan**.

[SEP-081] **IAF Hosts 'Dronathon-2026' at Pokhran & Army Establishes AASHVAST Drone Security Lab**

- **IAF Dronathon-2026 at Pokhran:**
  - The Indian Air Force conducted **"Dronathon-2026"** at the **Pokhran Firing Range in Jaisalmer, Rajasthan**.
  - Dedicated live-fire testing symposium evaluating cutting-edge domestic Unmanned Aerial Systems (UAS), swarm drones, and Counter-Unmanned Aerial Systems (CUAS) in high-temperature desert terrain.
- **Indian Army Inmates AASHVAST Lab:**
  - The Indian Army inaugurated the **AASHVAST** software security lab at the Directorate General of Electronics and Mechanical Engineering (**DG EME**) HQ in New Delhi.
  - **Full Form:** *Assessment and Analysis of Electronic Systems Hardware for Vulnerabilities and Security Threats*.
  - Mandated to scan military drones, loitering munitions, and tactical communications systems for malware, backdoor chip vulnerabilities, and unauthorized origin components.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Dronathon-2026 Location: **Pokhran Range, Jaisalmer, Rajasthan**.
- Lab Acronym: **AASHVAST** (DG EME, Indian Army, New Delhi).
- Core Mandate: Hardware/software vulnerability scanning of military drones.

[SEP-082] **AVNL Jabalpur T-72 & T-90 Tank Overhaul Facility (₹472 Cr) & GE Aerospace Delivers 3 F404 Engines to HAL**

- **National Main Battle Tank Overhaul Architecture:**
  - Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and MP Chief Minister Dr. Mohan Yadav laid the foundation stone for the **T-Series Tank Overhaul Facility** at the 57-year-old **Vehicle Factory Jabalpur (VFJ)**, Madhya Pradesh.
  - Project Outlay & Capacity: Executed by **Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited (AVNL)** at a capital outlay of **₹472 Crore**, creating dedicated annual overhaul and life-extension capacity for **80 T-72 'Ajeya' and T-90 'Bhishma' tanks**.
  - Strategic National Requirement: The Indian Army requires roughly **230 T-series tanks overhauled annually**; the existing Heavy Vehicles Factory (**HVF**) at Avadi, Tamil Nadu handles ~150 tanks annually, making VFJ Jabalpur's 80-tank capacity the vital final link for 100% domestic overhaul self-reliance.
- **Tejas LCA Engine Delivery Pipeline Unblocked:**
  - US aviation giant **GE Aerospace** delivered the initial consignment of **3 F404-IN20 turbofan engines** to **Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL)** in Bengaluru, unblocking flight delivery schedules for the 83 Tejas Mk1A fighter jets.
  - *Note*: HAL holds **Maharatna status**, standing as India's **14th Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE)** to achieve the status.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- VFJ Jabalpur Outlay & Annual Capacity: **₹472 Crore**; **80 tanks/year** (T-72 Ajeya & T-90 Bhishma).
- Army Annual Requirement: **~230 tanks per year** (Avadi HVF: ~150/year; VFJ Jabalpur: 80/year).
- PSU Operator: **Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited (AVNL)** (HQ: Avadi, Chennai).
- Jet Engine Delivered: **GE F404-IN20** for Tejas Mk1A.

[SEP-083] **Defence Strategic Milestones: Rajnath Singh Unveils 'RAKSHA' & Indo-US Super Garuda Shield**

- **Rajnath Singh Unveils 'RAKSHA' Diplomacy Framework:**
  - Defence Minister Rajnath Singh released *"RAKSHA"*, the Government's unified Strategic Defence Diplomacy Framework document, articulating India's defence export partnerships, joint military exercises, and naval hydrographic support across the Global South.
- **Multinational Exercise Super Garuda Shield:**
  - United States and Indonesia launched the annual multinational military exercise **"Super Garuda Shield 2026"** across Bandung, Baturaja, and North Kalimantan, joined by 13 partner nations.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Defence Policy Document: **'RAKSHA'** (Defence Diplomacy Framework).
- Super Garuda Shield: Led by **US and Indonesia** (annual exercise since 2006).

[SEP-084] **Indian Navy Commissions DSV 'INS Nipun' & L&T Delivers First Multi-Purpose Vessel 'Samarthak'**

- **Deep Submergence Capability Milestone:** The Indian Navy formally commissioned **'INS Nipun'** (Yard 11191), its second indigenously designed and built **Nistar-class Diving Support Vessel (DSV)**, at the Naval Dockyard in Mumbai, presided over by Chief of the Naval Staff Admiral Krishna Swaminathan.
  - Built by: **Hindustan Shipyard Limited (HSL)**, Visakhapatnam.
  - Specifications: Length 118.4 metres, beam 22.8 metres, displacement **9,350 tonnes**, endurance **60 days**, speed 14 knots. Fitted with advanced saturation diving systems and Deep Submergence Rescue Vehicle (DSRV) mating capabilities (sister vessel *INS Nistar* commissioned July 2025).
- **L&T Delivers 'Samarthak' MPV:** Larsen & Toubro (**L&T**) delivered **'Samarthak'**, the Indian Navy's 1st indigenously designed and built **Multi-Purpose Vessel (MPV)**, from its Kattupalli Shipyard near Chennai.
  - Built under an **₹887 Crore** 'Buy (Indian)' contract for 2 vessels (>75% indigenous content; 3,750 tonnes displacement; sister vessel *Utkarsh*).

- **Coast Guard Fleet Augmentation:** Goa Shipyard Limited (**GSL**) handed over **'ICGS Ajit'** (Yard 1277), the 7th Fast Patrol Vessel (FPV) in the Adamya-class series (51.43m length, 330 tonnes displacement).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- INS Nipun Shipyard: **Hindustan Shipyard Limited (HSL), Visakhapatnam** (displacement: **9,350 tonnes**; class: **Nistar-class DSV**).
- Samarthak Shipyard: **Larsen & Toubro (L&T), Kattupalli Shipyard** (Contract: **₹887 Crore** for 2 MPVs).
- ICGS Ajit Builder: **Goa Shipyard Limited (GSL)** for the Adamya-class FPV.
- Examiner's Trap: Swapping builders—attributing INS Nipun to Mazagon Dock or Cochin Shipyard instead of HSL Visakhapatnam.

[SEP-085] **HAL–Safran Finalise JV Contract for 'Aravalli' Helicopter Engines & India Joins GCAP as Dialogue Partner**

- **The 'Aravalli' Helicopter Engine Contract:** Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (**HAL**) and France's **Safran Helicopter Engines** signed the definitive procurement and development contract through their 50:50 joint venture, **SAFHAL Helicopter Engines Pvt. Ltd.**
  - **Power Envelope & Nomenclature:** The new **"Aravalli" engine** operates in the **3,500–4,000 shaft horsepower (shp)** power bracket, named after India's Aravalli range.
  - **Target Airframes:** Specifically designed to power HAL's upcoming **13-tonne Indian Multi-Role Helicopter (IMRH)** and its 12.5-tonne naval variant, the **Deck-Based Multi-Role Helicopter (DBMRH)**.
  - **Industrial Manufacturing Base:** Dedicated manufacturing facility established at **Tumakuru, Karnataka**.
- **Sixth-Gen Stealth Fighter Diplomacy:** India secured **'Dialogue Partner'** status in the **Global Combat Air Programme (GCAP)**—popularly known as the **Tempest programme**—jointly spearheaded by the **United Kingdom, Japan, and Italy**.
  - The status permits technical observation and strategic capability evaluations without binding financial co-development or access to classified design source code.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Joint Venture Name: **SAFHAL Helicopter Engines Pvt. Ltd.** (50:50 HAL & Safran).
- Engine Designation & Power: **"Aravalli"**, **3,500–4,000 shaft horsepower (shp)**.
- Production Facility Location: **Tumakuru, Karnataka**.
- Target Helicopters: 13-tonne **IMRH** & 12.5-tonne **DBMRH**.
- GCAP Partner Nations: **United Kingdom, Japan, and Italy** (India holds **Dialogue Partner** status).

[SEP-086] **Indian Army Signs $45.7M Javelin Missile LOA with US & Raises First 'Baaz Battalion' Drone Unit**

- **Indo-US Javelin Anti-Tank Deal:** The Indian Army executed a binding Letter of Offer and Acceptance (**LOA**) with the United States under the **Foreign Military Sales (FMS)** mechanism for the **FGM-148 Javelin** anti-tank guided missile system.
  - Transaction Value & Package: **$45.7 Million** outlay covering **100 Javelin missile rounds**, 1 fly-to-buy test round, and **25 Javelin Lightweight Command Launch Units (Block-1 CLUs)**, resolving a 16-year procurement effort since 2010.
- **Raising of First 'Baaz Battalion':**
  - The Indian Army formally raised its inaugural **"Baaz Battalion"**—a specialised, drone-centric combat unit—at **Jalandhar, Punjab**, operating under the **11 Corps** facing the Western border.
  - Complemented by company-level *Ashini drone platoons* for tactical perimeter surveillance and artillery loitering munitions.
- **Indigenous Weapons Trials:**
  - **Khagantak-243 Glide Bomb:** IAF conducted successful drop trials of the indigenously developed *Khagantak-243 Long Range Glide Bomb (LRGB)*, developed by JSR Dynamics with guidance systems by Bharat Electronics Limited

(**BEL**).

- **DRDO MCPS Test:** Successfully air-dropped the indigenous *Military Combat Parachute System (MCPS)* from **22,000 feet** at the Nyoma-Mudh Drop Zone in Eastern Ladakh at -15°C (developed by ADRDE Agra).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Javelin Deal Terms: **$45.7 Million for 100 missiles & 25 Block-1 CLUs** via US FMS route.
- Baaz Battalion Location & Command: **Jalandhar, Punjab (11 Corps)**.
- Khagantak-243 Developers: **JSR Dynamics and Bharat Electronics Ltd (BEL)**.
- MCPS Drop Zone: **Nyoma-Mudh Drop Zone, Eastern Ladakh (22,000 ft altitude)**.

[SEP-087] **SLINEX-26 Maritime Exercise (13th Edition) & Trilateral Naval Security Maneuvers**

- **Bilateral Maritime Engagement:** The Indian Navy and Sri Lanka Navy conducted the **13th edition** of their annual bilateral maritime exercise, **SLINEX-26**, off the coast of **Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh**.
- **Indian Navy Operational Assets:**
  - **INS Kavaratti:** Indigenous *Kamorta-class* Anti-Submarine Warfare (ASW) stealth corvette.
  - **INS Jyoti:** Fleet replenishment tanker.
  - Sri Lanka Navy deployed its Advanced Offshore Patrol Vessel (SLNS Sayurala).
- **Tactical Warfare Phases:**
  - Harbor Phase at Visakhapatnam focusing on cross-deck communications, VBSS (visit, board, search and seizure), and tactical briefings.
  - Sea Phase involving anti-surface warfare firings, ASW maneuvers, and coordinated maritime air patrols with Dornier-228 aircraft.
  - *Institutional Context*: SLINEX was first conceptualised and initiated in **2005**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Exercise Name & Edition: **SLINEX-26 (13th Edition)**.
- Participating Navies: **Indian Navy and Sri Lanka Navy**.
- Venue: **Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh**.
- Key Indian Warship: **INS Kavaratti** (Indigenous ASW Corvette).
- Target MCQ Form: "Where was the 13th edition of the India–Sri Lanka bilateral naval exercise SLINEX-26 conducted in September 2026?" → **Visakhapatnam**.

[SEP-088] **DRDO Successfully Tests Military Combat Parachute System (MCPS) at Nyoma-Mudh Drop Zone (22,000 ft, Ladakh LAC)**

- **Extreme High-Altitude Tactical Insertion:** The Defence Research and Development Organisation (**DRDO**) achieved a historic operational breakthrough by successfully executing high-altitude jumps with its indigenously developed **Military Combat Parachute System (MCPS)** at the **Nyoma-Mudh Drop Zone** in Leh district, Eastern Ladakh, situated in immediate proximity to the Line of Actual Control (LAC).
- **Operational Flight Profile:**
  - Jump executed from an altitude of **22,000 feet above mean sea level** at sub-zero temperatures of **minus 15°C**.
  - Parachutes were successfully deployed at **20,000 feet**, and test jumpers landed precisely at an elevation of **13,700 feet** (matching the adjacent Nyoma IAF Advanced Landing Ground / Airbase).
  - Conducted by ADRDE elite test jumpers led by **Wing Commander Rahul Jha (Chief Test Jumper)**, MWO R.J. Singh, and MWO Vivek Tiwari.
- **Design & Indigenous Architecture:**
  - Developed by DRDO's **Aerial Delivery Research and Development Establishment (ADRDE), Agra**, in technical synergy with the **Defence Bioengineering and Electromedical Laboratory (DEBEL), Bengaluru**.
  - Tailored for high-altitude tactical insertions of Special Forces personnel carrying heavy combat payloads.

- Builds on previous milestone tests including a combat freefall jump from **32,000 feet in October 2025**, solidifying MCPS as the only operational Indian military parachute qualified for jumps above 25,000 feet.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Drop Zone Location: **Nyoma-Mudh Drop Zone, Leh, Eastern Ladakh** (elevation: 13,700 ft).
- Developing Laboratories: **ADRDE (Agra)** and **DEBEL (Bengaluru)** under DRDO.
- Jump Parameters: Exit from **22,000 ft** at **-15°C**; deployed at 20,000 ft; landed at 13,700 ft.
- Target MCQ Form: "The indigenously developed Military Combat Parachute System (MCPS) tested by DRDO at Nyoma-Mudh drop zone was developed by which DRDO laboratory?" → Aerial Delivery Research and Development Establishment (ADRDE), Agra.

[SEP-089] **Munitions India Limited (MIL) & Drogo Aerospace Partner for 'Delta Wing Kamikaze' Loitering Munition UAVs**

- **Public-Private Defence Synthesis:** Munitions India Limited (**MIL**), the largest Defence Public Sector Undertaking (DPSU) formed under the Ministry of Defence, signed a strategic MoU with Hyderabad-based private drone manufacturer **Drogo Aerospace** in Pune to co-develop indigenous loitering munitions and attack UAV systems.
- **Workshare & Technology Division:**
  - **Drogo Aerospace:** Leads airframe aerodynamics, composite structure fabrication, flight control computers, and platform avionics.
  - **Munitions India Limited (MIL):** Provides specialized warhead engineering, explosive composition loading, fuzing mechanisms, and energetic payloads.
- **The "Delta Wing Kamikaze" Platform:**
  - Features a distinctive triangular delta-wing aerodynamic profile engineered for high-speed autonomous strike and loitering endurance.
  - **Operational Range:** Up to **1,000 km**.
  - **Warhead Payload Capacity: 20 kg to 30 kg** high-explosive anti-armour / fragmentation warheads.
  - Successfully concluded initial flight trials in Hyderabad prior to the accord.
- **Entity Context:**
  - Munitions India Limited (MIL; HQ: Pune; CMD: Prakash Agarwala; established in 2021 post OFB corporatisation).
  - Drogo Aerospace (HQ: Hyderabad; Founder & CEO: Yashwanth Bonthu).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Loitering Munition Platform: **Delta Wing Kamikaze** (One-way attack / suicide drone).
- Operational Strike Range: **Up to 1,000 km** with **20–30 kg** warhead payload.
- Partner Entities: **Munitions India Limited (MIL, Pune)** + **Drogo Aerospace (Hyderabad)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Munitions India Limited (MIL) partnered with Drogo Aerospace to co-develop the 'Delta Wing Kamikaze' loitering munition UAV having an operational range of up to:" → 1,000 km.

[SEP-090] **INS Trishul Conducts Maritime PASSEX with Egyptian Navy ENS Bernees in Alexandria, Mediterranean Sea**

- **Strategic Mediterranean Forward Deployment:** The Indian Navy's guided missile stealth frigate **INS Trishul** carried out a Passage Exercise (**PASSEX**) with Egyptian Navy frontline warship **ENS Bernees** off the coast of Alexandria, Egypt, enhancing bilateral interoperability, communications interoperability, and tactical formation maneuvering in the Eastern Mediterranean Sea.
- **Naval Escort & Port Call:**
  - Upon concluding tactical drills, INS Trishul was formally escorted into Alexandria Harbour by Egyptian Naval Ship **ENS Al Qadeer**.
  - Indian Ambassador to Egypt, **Suresh K. Reddy**, inspected the warship and engaged with naval officers.
- **Historical Homage at Chatby War Memorial:**

- The ship's crew and commanding officer paid floral tributes to Indian soldiers of the First and Second World Wars at the **Chatby War Memorial** in Alexandria, which houses **12 burials and memorial tablets commemorating 19 Indian servicemen** whose ships were sunk in Eastern Mediterranean wartime campaigns.

- **Class & Platform Identity:**
  - INS Trishul is a Talwar-class guided missile frigate attached to the Western Fleet (HQ: Mumbai).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Participating Warships: **INS Trishul** (Indian Navy) and **ENS Bernees / ENS Al Qadeer** (Egyptian Navy).
- Location of Exercise: **Alexandria, Egypt (Mediterranean Sea)**.
- Historic War Memorial Visited: **Chatby War Memorial**, Alexandria (commemorating Indian soldiers in WW-I & WW-II).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which Indian Navy guided missile frigate conducted a Passage Exercise (PASSEX) with the Egyptian Navy's ENS Bernees in Alexandria?" → INS Trishul.

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7. SCIENCE, DEEP-TECH, SPACE & ENVIRONMENT

[SEP-091] **ISRO Launches EOS-05 Earth Observation Satellite into Geosynchronous Orbit via GSLV**

- **Advanced Satellite Launch:** The Indian Space Research Organisation (**ISRO**) successfully launched the **Earth Observation Satellite EOS-05** from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre (SDSC) in **Sriharikota**.
- **Mission Specifications & Launch Vehicle:**
  - Lifted off aboard the **Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV)**.
  - Injected EOS-05 into a Geosynchronous Transfer Orbit (GTO) prior to circularization into a **geosynchronous orbit**, establishing India's first continuous optical/infrared observation platform in geosynchronous space.
  - Provides real-time disaster monitoring, cloud tracking, flood mapping, and environmental security assessments across the Indian subcontinent.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Satellite Launched: **EOS-05** (Earth Observation Satellite).
- Launch Vehicle: **GSLV** (Geosynchronous Satellite Launch Vehicle).
- Launch Base: **SDSC SHAR, Sriharikota, Andhra Pradesh**.
- Orbit: **Geosynchronous Orbit** (continuous real-time coverage).

[SEP-092] **DRDO and University of Hyderabad Patent BAM-H24 Next-Gen Rocket Fuel & GalaxEye Wins US Patent**

- **High-Energy BAM-H24 Propellant Patent:**
  - Scientists from **DRDO and the University of Hyderabad (UoH)** secured a joint patent for a next-generation energetic compound designated **BAM-H24**.
  - Synthesised from an advanced boron-nitrogen-hydrogen cluster, BAM-H24 delivers substantially higher specific impulse and thermal stability compared to conventional hydroxyl-terminated polybutadiene (HTPB) solid propellants, revolutionizing domestic missile solid rocket motors.

- **GalaxEye Wins US Patent for Satellite Imaging:**
  - Space-tech startup **GalaxEye Space** (incubated at IIT Madras) became India's **first space startup to win a United States Patent** for its proprietary synchronized SAR (Synthetic Aperture Radar) and optical Earth observation imaging system.

- **Jitendra Singh Launches BIO-NIVESH:**
  - Union Minister Dr. Jitendra Singh launched **BIO-NIVESH** under the Ministry of Science & Technology, mobilizing private venture capital for biotech commercialization backed by the **₹1 lakh crore RDI Fund** with **BIRAC** acting as second-level fund manager.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- High-Energy Compound: **BAM-H24** (DRDO + University of Hyderabad).
- First Indian Space Startup with US Patent: **GalaxEye Space** (SAR + Optical).
- Biotech Venture Engine: **BIO-NIVESH** (BIRAC / ₹1 Lakh Crore RDI Fund).

[SEP-093] **India Joins 24 Nations in Global 6G Initiative & Meta Launches 'Muse' AI Agent**

- **Multilateral 6G Coalition:**
  - India joined a strategic coalition of **24 nations** committing to open, interoperable, and secure **Sixth-Generation (6G) wireless technology** development.
  - Co-hosted by the US Department of Commerce and the White House Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP).
- **Meta Unveils 'Muse' AI Agent:**
  - Mark Zuckerberg's Meta unveiled *"Muse"*, a multimodal AI agentic framework designed to collaborate in real-time gaming, creative arts, and software development.
- **Türkiye Joins NASA Artemis Accords:**
  - **Türkiye** formally acceded to NASA's **Artemis Accords**, becoming the **71st signatory nation** committed to peaceful, transparent lunar and deep-space exploration.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 6G Global Coalition: **India among 24 participating countries**.
- Artemis Accords 71st Signatory: **Türkiye** (71st party to US-led lunar pact).

[SEP-094] **Global Environmental Accords: UNCCD COP17, 4th Indo-German Forum & Coral Reef Decline**

- **UNCCD COP17 Announced for Ulaanbaatar:**
  - The United Nations Convention to Combat Desertification announced that the **17th Session of the Conference of the Parties (COP17)** will be held in **Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia**.
- **4th Indo-German Environmental Forum:**
  - Held in **New Delhi**, co-chaired by Environment Minister Bhupender Yadav and German Minister Carsten Schneider under the theme: *"Together For More Resilience"*.
- **UNEP Global Climate Warning & GCRMN Coral Report:**
  - UNEP released empirical assessments warning that global warming will breach the 1.5°C Paris benchmark under current NDCs, heading toward 2.6°C by 2100.
  - Global Coral Reef Monitoring Network (GCRMN) released the *7th Status of the World's Coral Reefs report*, documenting a catastrophic **9.5% decline in global hard coral cover** since the 1980–2009 baseline.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- UNCCD COP17 Host: **Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia**.
- Indo-German Forum Theme: **"Together For More Resilience"** (New Delhi).
- Global Coral Cover Loss: **9.5% decline** (GCRMN 7th Report).

[SEP-095] **National Critical Minerals Mission Launches Innovation Hackathon & C-DOT Unveils 14 Quantum Products**

- **Critical Minerals R&D Impetus:** Union Minister of Coal and Mines G. Kishan Reddy launched the **Critical Minerals Innovation Hackathon 2026 (CMiH 2026)** to operationalise the **National Critical Minerals Mission (NCMM)**.
  - Problem Statements: Focuses on open-data mineral prospectivity mapping and advanced processing/beneficiation of 30 designated critical minerals, backed by a ₹100 Crore R&D scheme at JNARDDC Nagpur.

- **C-DOT 43rd Foundation Day Breakthroughs:**
  - The Centre for Development of Telematics (**C-DOT**) unveiled **14 indigenous quantum products** across 5 categories: Quantum Key Distribution (**QKD**) hardware, Post-Quantum Cryptography (**PQC**) encryptors, quantum sub-components, endpoints, and access infrastructure.
  - Executed a strategic 5-year agreement with DoT to set up an **End-to-End Optical Network Test Bed** at the C-DOT New Delhi campus.
- **Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS) Silver Hallmarking Expansion:**
  - Expanded mandatory HUID-based silver hallmarking to **341 centres across 102 districts** with 25,000+ registered jewellers under the revised **IS 2112:2025** standard (mandatory 6-digit alphanumeric code).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- NCMM Hackathon: **CMiH 2026** under Ministry of Coal and Mines (G. Kishan Reddy).
- C-DOT Product Battery: **14 quantum products** across QKD and PQC disciplines.
- Silver Hallmarking Standard: **IS 2112:2025** (Mandatory 6-digit **HUID** across 102 districts).
- Examiner's Trap: Stating gold hallmarking standard instead of silver (Gold standard is IS 1417; Silver standard is IS 2112).

[SEP-096] **TRISHNA Mission: Joint ISRO–CNES Thermal Satellite for Natural Resource & Evapotranspiration Mapping**

- **Bilateral Space Collaboration:** The Indian Space Research Organisation (**ISRO**) and the French National Centre for Space Studies (**CNES**) finalized technical deployment protocols for their flagship joint satellite mission, **TRISHNA**.
- **Mission Acronym & Objectives:**
  - *TRISHNA* stands for **Thermal infraRed Imaging Satellite for High-resolution Natural resource Assessment**.
  - Operates in a **Sun-Synchronous Orbit at 761 km altitude** with a designed operational mission life of **5 years**.
- **Scientific Payload & Environmental Impact:**
  - Equipped with dual state-of-the-art optical payloads: a Thermal Infrared (TIR) instrument developed by CNES and a Visible Near-Infrared (VNIR) optical sensor built by ISRO.
  - Delivers high-resolution, high-frequency thermal imaging to measure field-level crop **evapotranspiration**, monitor agricultural drought vulnerabilities, assess urban heat islands, and track glacial retreat across the Himalayas.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Space Agencies: **ISRO (India) and CNES (France)**.
- Satellite Name: **TRISHNA** (Thermal infraRed Imaging Satellite for High-resolution Natural resource Assessment).
- Orbit & Altitude: **Sun-Synchronous Orbit at 761 km**.
- Mission Life: **5 years**.
- Target MCQ Form: "The TRISHNA thermal earth observation satellite is being jointly developed by ISRO in partnership with the space agency of which country?" → **France (CNES)**.

[SEP-097] **Project Cheetah Completes 4 Years: India's Wild Feline Population Expands to 52 across Kuno & Gandhi Sagar**

- **Four-Year Reintroduction Milestone:** India's landmark transcontinental wildlife restoration initiative, **Project Cheetah**, completed **4 full years** on **September 17, 2026** (launched by PM Narendra Modi on September 17, 2022).
- **Wild Population Growth (52 Cheetahs):**
  - From the original batch of 8 wild cheetahs translocated from **Namibia in 2022** and 12 from **South Africa in 2023**, India's total cheetah population expanded to **52 cheetahs**.
  - **32 cheetahs were born on Indian soil**, demonstrating successful reproductive acclimatization.
- **Geographical Distribution:**
  - **49 cheetahs** inhabit **Kuno National Park (Sheopur, Madhya Pradesh)**.

- **3 cheetahs** successfully introduced into the second landscape, **Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary (Mandsaur, Madhya Pradesh)**.
- Genetic diversification bolstered in 2026 through the arrival of **9 cheetahs from Botswana**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Launch Date: **17 September 2022** (Kuno National Park, MP).
- 4th Anniversary Total Population: **52 cheetahs** (32 born in India).
- The Two Habitat Reserves: **Kuno National Park** and **Gandhi Sagar Wildlife Sanctuary** (both in Madhya Pradesh).
- Translocation Partner Nations: **Namibia (2022), South Africa (2023), and Botswana (2026)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "On the completion of four years of Project Cheetah in September 2026, what was the total cheetah count in India including Indian-born cubs?" → **52 cheetahs**.

[SEP-098] **India Joins IAEA ATLAS Initiative: Advancing Small Modular Reactors (SMRs) for Civilian Maritime Fleets**

- **Nuclear Maritime Expansion:** India officially joined the **ATLAS (Atomic Technologies Licensed for Applications at Sea)** project launched by the **International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA)** at its ministerial conference in Washington D.C.
- **Small Modular Reactor (SMR) Focus:**
  - Formulates global safety, regulatory, and non-proliferation protocols for deploying **Small Modular Reactors (SMRs)** in commercial cargo shipping, container carriers, and floating coastal nuclear power barges.
  - Bolsters India's net-zero maritime commitment and maritime decarbonisation under *Harit Nauka* guidelines.
- **IAEA Institutional Profile:**
  - Established: **1957** as the world's "Atoms for Peace" watchdog within the United Nations family.
  - Headquarters: **Vienna, Austria**.
  - Leadership: Director General is **Rafael Mariano Grossi**; membership comprises **182 member states**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Project Acronym: **ATLAS** (Atomic Technologies Licensed for Applications at Sea).
- Lead Agency: **IAEA (International Atomic Energy Agency)**.
- Core Technology: **Small Modular Reactors (SMRs)** for commercial shipping and floating power plants.
- IAEA Headquarters: **Vienna, Austria** (DG: Rafael Mariano Grossi).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which global initiative did India join in September 2026 to support the deployment of Small Modular Reactors (SMRs) in civilian shipping?" → **ATLAS project (IAEA)**.

[SEP-099] **UK Recognises India's Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) for Carbon Border Adjustment Relief**

- **Sovereign Climate Trade Alignment:** The United Kingdom officially recognised India's domestic **Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS)**, providing Indian industrial exporters relief under the UK's upcoming **Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (UK-CBAM)** scheduled for implementation in 2027.
- **Protection for Hard-to-Abate Sectors:**
  - Ensures that carbon fees paid by Indian heavy industrial manufacturers (steel, aluminium, cement, and fertilisers) under the Bureau of Energy Efficiency's (**BEE**) carbon market will be offset against UK-CBAM import taxes.
  - Prevents double carbon taxation and preserves the export competitiveness of Indian engineering goods entering the British and European markets.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Foreign Country Recognizing Indian Carbon Scheme: **United Kingdom (UK)**.
- Indian Scheme: **Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS)** (administered by Bureau of Energy Efficiency, Ministry of Power).
- Import Tax Relieved: **UK-CBAM (Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism)** effective 2027.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which country officially recognized India's Carbon Credit Trading Scheme (CCTS) to provide tax offsets against its upcoming Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism?" → **United Kingdom**.

[SEP-100] **GRSE Launches Ocean Research Vessel 'ORV Sagar Manthan' (Yard 3041) under ₹840 Crore Deep Ocean Mission Vertical-4**

- **Vessel Launch & Construction:** Union Minister Dr. Jitendra Singh launched India's advanced Ocean Research Vessel (ORV) **"Sagar Manthan" (Yard 3041)** at the Rishi Bankim Shipyard of Garden Reach Shipbuilders and Engineers (**GRSE**), Kolkata.
- **Mission Anchor & Outlay:**
  - Constructed under **Vertical-4 (Deep Ocean Survey and Exploration)** of the flagship **Deep Ocean Mission (DOM)** at an approximate cost of **₹840 crore**.
  - Built for the National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (**NCPOR**), Goa, under the Ministry of Earth Sciences (MoES).
- **Operational Specifications & Extreme Capabilities:**
  - Dimensions: Length of **89.5 metres** and width of **18.8 metres**, with an endurance of 45 days and an operational lifespan of **30 years**.
  - Extreme Waters: Designed as an all-weather multidisciplinary vessel capable of polar oceanographic research in the Southern Ocean (Antarctica).
  - Dual-Class Certification: Certified by both the **Indian Register of Shipping (IRS)** and the **American Bureau of Shipping (ABS)**.
  - Scientific Payload: Equipped with multichannel seismic systems, multibeam bathymetry, sub-bottom profilers, drop keels, and deployment bays for Remotely Operated Vehicles (ROVs) and Autonomous Underwater Vehicles (AUVs).
- **Replacement Timeline:** Gradually replaces India's historic 43-year-old research vessel *ORV Sagar Kanya* (procured from Germany in 1983); final delivery and NCPOR commissioning scheduled for 2028.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Vessel Name & Yard: **ORV Sagar Manthan (Yard 3041)** built by **GRSE, Kolkata**.
- Flagship Umbrella: **Deep Ocean Mission (Vertical-4: Deep Ocean Survey)**; Outlay = **₹840 crore**.
- Operating Body: **National Centre for Polar and Ocean Research (NCPOR), MoES**.
- Replaces: 43-year-old **ORV Sagar Kanya** (1983).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which historic ocean research vessel procured in 1983 is set to be replaced by the newly launched ₹840-crore ORV 'Sagar Manthan'?" → **ORV Sagar Kanya**.

[SEP-101] **Akasa Air Operates India's First Commercial Flight Blended with 1% Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) via BPCL**

- **Decarbonisation Milestone:** Akasa Air operated India's first commercial passenger flight powered by conventional Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) blended with **1% Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF)**, supplied by Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (**BPCL**).
- **Flight Route & Fleet Technology:**
  - Flight operated from Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj International Airport (Mumbai) to Manohar International Airport (Mopa, Goa) on a Boeing 737 MAX aircraft powered by CFM LEAP-1B engines.
- **National Decarbonisation Mandate:**
  - Ministry of Civil Aviation and MoPNG set a national mandate of **5% mandatory SAF blending by 2030** for domestic airlines, aligning with the International Air Transport Association's (**IATA**) global commitment of Net-Zero

Carbon Emissions by 2050.

- **Airline Decarbonisation Innovations:** Akasa Air utilizes the OpenAirlines "SkyBreathe" fuel analytics platform and was the first Indian airline to discontinue traditional ceremonial water-cannon salutes during route inaugurations, saving over 5.5 lakh litres of water.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Airline & Fuel Partner: **Akasa Air** and **BPCL** (Mumbai to Goa flight).
- SAF Blending Ratio: **1% Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF)**.
- National Policy Target: **5% mandatory SAF blending by 2030** (IATA Net-Zero 2050).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is India's national policy target for mandatory Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF) blending in aviation turbine fuel by the year 2030?" → **5%**.

[SEP-102] **OIL Green Energy (OGEL) Inks 4 Municipal MoUs in Haryana for 5,000 TPD Waste-to-CBG & 50 MW Power Projects**

- **Circular Bioeconomy Scaling:** OIL Green Energy Limited (**OGEL**), the dedicated renewable energy subsidiary of Maharatna CPSE Oil India Limited (**OIL**), signed four tripartite MoUs with key municipal corporations in Haryana in the presence of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini to set up integrated municipal waste-to-energy and Compressed Biogas (**CBG**) complexes.
- **Processing Scale & City Clusters:**
  - Aggregate municipal solid waste (MSW) processing capacity: **5,000 tonnes per day (TPD)** across four industrial hubs:
    1. **Gurugram:** 2,000 TPD
    2. **Faridabad:** 1,600 TPD
    3. **Ambala:** 900 TPD
    4. **Hisar:** 500 TPD
- **Output Generation & Circular Dynamics:**
  - Yields an estimated **70 to 75 TPD of Compressed Biogas (CBG)** and **50 MW of clean grid-connected green electricity**.
  - Model: High-efficiency optical/mechanical sorting segregates wet biodegradable fractions for anaerobic digestion into CBG, while non-recyclable high-calorific dry refuse-derived fuel (RDF) feeds waste-to-energy power plants.
- **National Policy Anchoring:**
  - Aligned with the **GOBARdhan** (*Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan*) National Circular Bioenergy Scheme 2026 under the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Municipal Locations in Haryana: **Gurugram (2,000 TPD), Faridabad (1,600 TPD), Ambala (900 TPD), Hisar (500 TPD)**.
- Aggregate Capacities: **5,000 TPD waste**, producing **70–75 TPD CBG** and **50 MW green power**.
- Parent Maharatna Firm: **Oil India Limited (OIL)** via subsidiary **OIL Green Energy Limited (OGEL)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "OIL Green Energy Limited (OGEL) signed agreements to process 5,000 TPD of municipal waste into CBG and 50 MW power across four cities of which state?" → Haryana (Gurugram, Faridabad, Ambala, Hisar).

[SEP-103] **BPCL & Centre for Science and Environment (CSE) Ink Strategic MoU for Biofuels & Circular Bioeconomy Value Chains**

- **Decarbonisation & Biomass Value Chains:** Maharatna CPSE Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (**BPCL**) entered into a strategic Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with leading environmental think-tank **Centre for Science and Environment (CSE)** in Mumbai to establish sustainable commercial frameworks across biofuels, waste-to-resource pathways, and circular bioeconomy ecosystems.
- **Scope of Collaborative Verticals:**

- Joint identification and technology evaluation across: **Compressed Biogas (CBG)**, **2G Bioethanol**, **Biodiesel**, and **Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF)**.
- Feedstock supply chain mapping: Agricultural residue, paddy stubble, and municipal organic fractions.
- By-product monetisation: Formulating national standards for **Fermented Organic Manure (FOM)**, liquid digestate, bio-CO_2, and Distillers Dried Grains with Solubles (DDGS).

- **Institutional Profiles:**
  - BPCL (HQ: Mumbai; Chairman & MD: Sanjay Khanna; founded 1952).
  - Centre for Science and Environment (CSE; HQ: New Delhi; Director General: Sunita Narain; founded 1980).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Institutional Partners: **BPCL** + **Centre for Science and Environment (CSE)**.
- Alternative Fuels Covered: **CBG, Bioethanol, Biodiesel, and Sustainable Aviation Fuel (SAF)**.
- By-Product Focus: **Fermented Organic Manure (FOM)** and bio-CO_2 commercial utilization.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which Maharatna oil PSU partnered with the Centre for Science and Environment (CSE) to develop feedstock supply chains and standards for CBG, SAF, and Fermented Organic Manure (FOM)?" → Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited (BPCL).

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8. HONOURS, AWARDS, SUMMITS & INTERNATIONAL DIPLOMACY

[SEP-104] **Ramon Magsaysay Awards 2026: Tommy Koh, Bo Kyi, and Runa Khan Conferred Asia's Nobel Prize**

- **68th Edition of Asia's Highest Honour:** The Ramon Magsaysay Award Foundation announced the laureates for the **2026 Ramon Magsaysay Award** (established in 1958, honoring former Philippine President Ramon Magsaysay):
  1. **Tommy Koh (Singapore):** Veteran international lawyer, diplomat, and law of the sea negotiator; recognized for principled multilateral diplomacy and global environmental advocacy.
  2. **Bo Kyi (Myanmar):** Pro-democracy human rights champion and former political prisoner; honored for documenting abuses and rehabilitating political prisoners.
  3. **Runa Khan (Bangladesh):** Social reformer and founder of Friendship NGO; recognized for establishing floating hospitals and climate-resilient schools across vulnerable riverine island communities (*chars*).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Laureates & Countries: **Tommy Koh (Singapore)**, **Bo Kyi (Myanmar)**, and **Runa Khan (Bangladesh)**.
- Award Heritage: Often hailed as **"Asia's Nobel Prize"** (first instituted in 1958, Manila, Philippines).

[SEP-105] **72nd National Film Awards to be Held at Ekta Nagar, Gujarat: First Time Outside Delhi Since 1970**

- **Historical Shift in Venue:** The Ministry of Information and Broadcasting announced that the **72nd National Film Awards** ceremony will take place on September 22, 2026, at **Ekta Nagar (Kevadia), Narmada district, Gujarat**, near the iconic Statue of Unity.
- **Presided by Head of State:** Awards will be conferred by **President Droupadi Murmu**.
- **Historical Milestone:**
  - Marks the **first time in 56 years** that the National Film Awards ceremony is hosted outside New Delhi.
  - The only previous instance occurred on November 21, 1970, when the 17th National Film Awards were presented at the University Centenary Auditorium in Madras (Chennai).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 72nd National Film Awards Venue: **Ekta Nagar, Gujarat** (near Statue of Unity).
- Historical Precedent: First ceremony outside Delhi since the **17th edition in Madras (1970)**.

[SEP-106] **Global Summits, International Honours & Accords: PM Modi Conferred Uzbekistan's Highest Award & Tenzing Norgay Awards**

- **Prime Minister Conferred Uzbekistan's Highest Honour:**
  - Uzbek President Shavkat Mirziyoyev conferred the **"Oliy Darajali Do'stlik" Order (Order of Highest Friendship)**—Uzbekistan's highest state honour for foreign leaders—on Prime Minister Narendra Modi at Kuksaroy Presidential Palace, Tashkent, recognising his contribution to strengthening the India-Uzbekistan Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (marking PM Modi's 4th state visit to Uzbekistan).
- **27th World Knowledge Forum (Seoul, South Korea):**
  - South Korea hosted the 27th World Knowledge Forum in **Seoul** under the theme: *"The Promethean Moment: Architecting the Co-Intelligence Order"*, exploring macroeconomic decoupling and generative AI governance.
- **Tenzing Norgay National Adventure Awards 2024:**
  - Ministry of Youth Affairs and Sports conferred the prestigious Tenzing Norgay awards (India's highest national adventure honours) across Land, Water, Air, and Life Time Achievement categories.
- **Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam Jan Seva Puraskar 2026:**
  - Presented at the 16th Sansad Ratna Awards in New Delhi to **Kishor Makwana**, Chairman of the National Commission for Scheduled Castes (NCSC), for public advocacy.
- **International Space Accord (Artemis Accords 71st Signatory):**
  - **Türkiye** formally signed the NASA-led **Artemis Accords** as the **71st signatory** (7th West Asian nation after UAE, Saudi Arabia, Bahrain, Oman, Jordan, Israel; India joined June 21, 2023 as 27th signatory).
- **UNGA 'Correct the Map' Resolution:**
  - The United Nations General Assembly adopted the *"Correct the Map"* resolution, officially recommending cartographic agencies transition away from the distorted Mercator projection to accurate equal-area projections reflecting Africa's true landmass (over 30 million sq km).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Uzbekistan Highest Honour: **"Oliy Darajali Do'stlik" Order** conferred on PM Narendra Modi.
- World Knowledge Forum Host: **Seoul, South Korea** (*The Promethean Moment*).
- Artemis Accords 71st Signatory: **Türkiye** (India is 27th signatory, joined June 2023).
- Kalam Jan Seva Puraskar: **Kishor Makwana** (Chairman, NCSC).
- Tenzing Norgay Award: India's highest national adventure prize under MoYA&S.

[SEP-107] **Institutional Accords & Multilateral Development: ADB ₹1,750 Crore Karnataka Loan & NABARD–NaBFID Partnership**

- **ADB ₹1,750 Crore School Transformation Loan:** The Asian Development Bank (**ADB**) and the Government of Karnataka signed a **₹1,750 Crore sovereign loan agreement** to upgrade **500 government schools** into model **Karnataka Public Schools (KPS)** by 2029-30 (each equipped for ≥ 1,200 students).
- **DFI Infrastructure Financing Convergence:**
  - The National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (**NABARD**, Chairman: Shaji K.V.) and the National Bank for Financing Infrastructure and Development (**NaBFID**, Chairman: K.V. Kamath) executed a strategic MoU to co-finance large-scale infrastructure projects bridging rural supply chains, agri-logistics, and irrigation infrastructure.
- **Mission Rangeen Machhli 2031:**
  - Vice President C.P. Radhakrishnan unveiled **"Mission Rangeen Machhli 2031"** at Agatti, Lakshadweep—a Strategic Action Plan under the **Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY)** to standardize ornamental fish breeding, quarantine, and export certification with a dedicated ₹62 Crore allocation for Lakshadweep.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- ADB Karnataka Loan Outlay: **₹1,750 Crore for 500 schools** (KPS model school upgradation).
- DFI Alliance: **NABARD + NaBFID** for rural infrastructure financing.
- Ornamental Fisheries Plan: **Mission Rangeen Machhli 2031** launched in **Agatti, Lakshadweep** under **PMMSY**.
- Examiner's Trap: Distractor claiming the ADB school loan was granted to Andhra Pradesh or Tamil Nadu—it was signed with Karnataka.

[SEP-108] **Dadasaheb Phalke Award 2024: Veteran Actor Anant Nag Conferred India's Highest Cinema Honour**

- **Apex Cinematic Accolade:** The Ministry of Information & Broadcasting announced the prestigious **Dadasaheb Phalke Award for the year 2024** to legendary actor **Anant Nag** in recognition of his illustrious lifetime contribution to Indian and Kannada cinema.
- **Ceremony Venue Milestone:**
  - The formal investiture ceremony took place at **Kevadia (Ekta Nagar), Gujarat**, marking the continuation of hosting apex national cultural awards outside the national capital.
- **Laureate's Legacy:**
  - Over a distinguished career spanning 5 decades across 300+ films, Anant Nag worked extensively in Kannada, Hindi, Marathi, and Telugu cinema, known for landmark collaborations in parallel cinema with Shyam Benegal (*Ankur, Nishant, Manthan, Bhumika*).
  - *Statutory Anchor*: The Dadasaheb Phalke Award was instituted in **1969** (first recipient: Devika Rani); carries a Swarna Kamal medallion, shawl, and cash prize of **₹10 Lakh**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Dadasaheb Phalke Award 2024 Recipient: **Anant Nag**.
- Awarding Authority: **Ministry of Information & Broadcasting**.
- First Recipient (1969): **Devika Rani**.
- Award Components: **Swarna Kamal (Golden Lotus)**, shawl, and **₹10 Lakh cash prize**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who was conferred the prestigious Dadasaheb Phalke Award for 2024 for outstanding lifetime contributions to Indian cinema?" → **Anant Nag**.

[SEP-109] **Arthur M. Bueche Award 2026: Dr. Sethuraman Panchanathan Becomes First Indian-American Honouree**

- **Global Engineering Triumph:** The U.S. **National Academy of Engineering (NAE)** conferred the **2026 Arthur M. Bueche Award** upon distinguished computer scientist and engineer **Dr. Sethuraman Panchanathan**.
- **Historic Distinction:**
  - Dr. Panchanathan became the **first Indian-American** and the first resident of Arizona to receive this apex engineering leadership award.
  - Recognized for seminal contributions to science and technology policy, human-centered computing, and national innovation ecosystems during his tenure as Director of the U.S. National Science Foundation (NSF).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Award: **2026 Arthur M. Bueche Award**.
- Conferred By: **U.S. National Academy of Engineering (NAE)**.
- Recipient: **Dr. Sethuraman Panchanathan**.
- Historic First: First **Indian-American** to win the Bueche Award.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who became the first Indian-American to be honoured with the prestigious Arthur M. Bueche Award by the US National Academy of Engineering?" → **Sethuraman Panchanathan**.

[SEP-110] **26th SCO Summit in Bishkek Designates Lahore as SCO 'Tourism and Cultural Capital for 2026–27'**

- **SCO Cultural Presidency Milestone:** The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (**SCO**), at the 26th meeting of the Council of Heads of State in **Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan**, officially designated **Lahore, Pakistan** as the **"SCO Tourism and Cultural Capital for 2026–27"**.
- **Chairmanship Theme & Timeline:**
  - The title coincides with Pakistan assuming the rotating annual chairmanship of the SCO for 2026–27 under the theme: *"Turning Vision into Action: Connectivity, Innovation and Shared Prosperity"*.
- **Historical Pedigree of the Title (Established 2022):**
  - Initiated in 2022 to showcase the cultural heritage of the member state holding the rotating presidency:
    - **2022–23: Varanasi, India** (Inaugural cultural capital)
    - **2023–24: Almaty, Kazakhstan**
    - **2024–25: Qingdao, China**
    - **2025–26: Cholpon-Ata, Kyrgyzstan**
    - **2026–27: Lahore, Pakistan**
- **SCO Institutional Architecture:**
  - Full members (10): China, India, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, Iran, and Belarus (admitted in 2024).
  - Secretariat: Beijing, China; Secretary-General: Nurlan Yermekbayev; Established: June 15, 2001 (originated from Shanghai Five).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New Cultural Capital: **Lahore, Pakistan (2026–27)**.
- Summit Host City: **Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan** (26th Council of Heads of State).
- Inaugural Titleholder (High-Yield): **Varanasi, India (2022–23)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which city has been designated as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) 'Tourism and Cultural Capital for 2026–27'?" → Lahore, Pakistan.

[SEP-111] **Booker Prize Foundation Unveils 2026 Shortlist: Mary Beard Chairs Panel Featuring 2 Previous Winners**

- **Literary Masterpieces Shortlist:** The Booker Prize Foundation unveiled the definitive shortlist of six novels contending for the prestigious **Booker Prize 2026**, selected from 163 submissions of English-language fiction published across the UK and Ireland.
- **Judging Panel:**
  - Chaired by renowned classicist and historian **Mary Beard**, alongside fellow judges Raymond Antrobus, Jarvis Cocker, Rebecca Liu, and Patricia Lockwood.
- **The 6 Shortlisted Novels & Authors:**
  1. *The End of Everything* by **M. John Harrison** (England)
  2. *The Disappearers* by **Marlon James** (Jamaica) — *Previous winner in 2015 for 'A Brief History of Seven Killings'*
  3. *Black Bag* by **Luke Kennard** (England)
  4. *May We Feed the King* by **Rebecca Perry** (England) — *Sole debut novelist on the list*
  5. *The Things We Never Say* by **Elizabeth Strout** (USA) — *Shortlisted in 2022 for 'Oh William!'*
  6. *John of John* by **Douglas Stuart** (Scotland) — *Previous winner in 2020 for 'Shuggie Bain'*
- **Prize Purse & Ceremony:**
  - Winner receives **£50,000**, with each shortlisted author receiving **£2,500**.
  - Ceremony scheduled for **November 9, 2026**, at **Old Billingsgate, London**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Jury Chair: **Mary Beard** (British classicist).
- 2 Past Winners on Shortlist: **Marlon James** (2015 winner) and **Douglas Stuart** (2020 winner).
- Purse Value: **£50,000** for the winner; **£2,500** for shortlisted finalists.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who chairs the judging panel for the prestigious Booker Prize 2026?" → Mary Beard.

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9. APPOINTMENTS, RESIGNATIONS & SPORTS TRAJECTORIES

[SEP-112] **Global Leadership Shifts: John Ternus Named Apple CEO as Tim Cook Becomes Executive Chairman**

- **Corporate Succession at World's Most Valuable Tech Firm:**
  - **John Ternus** was appointed as the new **Chief Executive Officer (CEO) of Apple Inc.**, effective September 1, 2026.
  - **Tim Cook** stepped down as CEO after a historic 15-year tenure (having taken the helm in August 2011 succeeding Steve Jobs), transitioning into the role of **Executive Chairman of the Board of Apple**.
- **Vinaya Prakash Singh Re-Elected Secretary-General of APPU:**
  - India's **Vinaya Prakash Singh** was re-elected by acclamation as the **Secretary-General of the Asian-Pacific Postal Union (APPU)** for a second consecutive 4-year term (2027–2030).
  - APPU comprises 32 member nations across Asia-Pacific; headquartered in **Bangkok, Thailand**.
- **Domestic & Corporate Key Appointments:**
  - *Dinesh Sharma*: Appointed Lieutenant Governor (LG) of **Andaman and Nicobar Islands**.
  - *Anil Chakravarthy*: Named Chief Executive Officer of **Adobe Inc.**, succeeding long-serving CEO Shantanu Narayen.
  - *Shenu Agarwal* (MD & CEO, Ashok Leyland): Elected President of the **Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM)**.
  - *Air Marshal Jeetendra Mishra (Retd)*: Appointed as the **first Chief Executive Officer of Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust**.
  - *Tatsuya Fujimoto*: Appointed MD & CEO of **IFFCO-TOKIO General Insurance**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New Apple CEO: **John Ternus** (Tim Cook is now Executive Chairman).
- APPU Secretary-General: **Vinaya Prakash Singh** (2nd term; HQ: Bangkok).
- New Adobe CEO: **Anil Chakravarthy**.
- SIAM President: **Shenu Agarwal**.

[SEP-113] **Sports Sagas: Lionel Messi Retires, Smriti Mandhana World Record, Satwik-Chirag China Masters & Pickleball WC**

- **Lionel Messi Retires from International Football:**
  - Argentina's talismanic captain **Lionel Messi** officially announced his retirement from international football after 207 caps and **125 goals** for Argentina.
  - Accolades: FIFA World Cup Winner (2022) & Runner-up (2014, 2026); Olympic Gold (2008); 8-time Ballon d'Or winner; 2-time World Cup Golden Ball winner (2014, 2022).
- **Smriti Mandhana All-Time Run-Scoring Record:**
  - Indian batting star **Smriti Mandhana** became the **highest run-scorer in women's international cricket across all formats combined**, surpassing previous milestones in ODIs, T20Is, and Tests.
- **Satwiksairaj Rankireddy & Chirag Shetty Win Historic China Masters:**
  - India's premier badminton duo **Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty** clinched the Men's Doubles title at the **China Masters 2026 in Shenzhen**, defeating Chinese pair He Ji Ting and Ren Xiang Yu in straight games to secure India's **first-ever China Masters crown**.

- **India's Record Finish at Pickleball World Cup 2026 (Vietnam):**
  - At the Pickleball World Cup in **Da Nang, Vietnam**, the Indian contingent recorded its best-ever international finish, bagging **4th position globally** with an unprecedented haul of **41 medals (7 Gold, 17 Silver, 17 Bronze)**.
- **World Archery Para Series (Ahmedabad):**
  - Indian para-archers won **5 medals (2 Gold, 2 Silver, 1 Bronze)**; Men's Compound Team Gold clinched by Toman Kumar and Shyam Sundar Swami.
- **Maiden WTT Title for Ankur Bhattacharjee:**
  - Ankur Bhattacharjee captured his maiden Men's Singles crown at the **WTT Feeder Olomouc** in Czechia and partnered Akash Pal to win the Men's Doubles title.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- International Football Retirement: **Lionel Messi** (125 goals, 207 matches, 8 Ballon d'Ors).
- Women's Cricket Milestone: **Smriti Mandhana** (highest all-format run-scorer).
- Badminton Milestone: **Satwik-Chirag** won India's first **China Masters title** (Shenzhen).
- Pickleball World Cup: India finished **4th with 41 medals** (Da Nang, Vietnam).

[SEP-114] **Airtel Payments Bank Leadership Transition & World Bank Record $112B Private Capital Milestone**

- **Airtel Payments Bank Board Restructuring:**
  - **Shabnam Sinha** appointed as the new **Non-Executive Chairperson** of Airtel Payments Bank, effective **October 1, 2026**.
  - She succeeds **Sunil Bharti Mittal**, who transitioned off the payments bank board to focus on Bharti Enterprises' global telecom satellite expansions (Eutelsat OneWeb).
  - *Institutional Context*: Airtel Payments Bank was India's first operational payments bank (launched in January 2017); regulated under RBI Payments Bank licensing norms.
- **World Bank Group Historic Private Capital Mobilization:**
  - The World Bank Group reported a landmark record for fiscal year 2026, mobilizing over **$112 Billion in private capital** for developing economies—more than tripling the annual volume mobilized four years prior.
  - Accelerated by the **Private Sector Investment Lab (PSIL)**, focusing on renewable energy transitions, climate resilience, and digital infrastructure across emerging markets.
- **World Circular Economy Forum (WCEF 2026) in South Asia:**
  - Hosted in India from **September 15–18, 2026**, marking the forum's inaugural South Asian edition; focused on resource circularity, critical mineral recycling, and bio-economy frameworks.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Airtel Payments Bank New Chairperson: **Shabnam Sinha** (takes charge October 1, 2026).
- First Payments Bank in India: **Airtel Payments Bank** (launched January 2017).
- World Bank FY26 Private Capital Milestone: **$112 Billion** mobilized.
- Circular Economy Summit: **WCEF 2026** hosted in India (South Asia's first edition).
- Target MCQ Form: "Who was appointed as the Non-Executive Chairperson of Airtel Payments Bank in September 2026, succeeding Sunil Bharti Mittal?" → **Shabnam Sinha**.

[SEP-115] **Savita Punia Becomes India's Most-Capped Women's Hockey Player (321 International Caps)**

- **Historic Hockey Milestone:** Veteran Indian goalkeeper **Savita Punia** became the **most-capped player in the history of Indian women's hockey**, earning her **321st international senior cap**.
- **Record-Breaking Appearance:**
  - Achieved the landmark during India's Pool B clash against Indonesia at the Asian Games 2026.
  - Surpassed the longstanding record of former Indian captain and striker **Vandana Katariya (320 international appearances)**.

- **Accolades & Recognition:**
  - Reared as *"The Wall of India"* for her heroic performances in penalty shoot-outs and the Tokyo 2020 Olympics; awarded a ₹10 Lakh cash reward by Hockey India.
  - Stands alongside Vandana Katariya as the only two Indian women to cross 300 caps, and only the second Indian goalkeeper after legendary **PR Sreejesh** to achieve the 300-cap milestone.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Most-Capped Indian Woman Hockey Player: **Savita Punia (321 caps)**.
- Surpassed: **Vandana Katariya (320 caps)**.
- Nickname: **"The Wall of India"**.
- Only Goalkeeper Precedent: **PR Sreejesh** (men's hockey).
- Target MCQ Form: "Who surpassed Vandana Katariya to become the most-capped player in the history of Indian women's hockey with 321 international appearances?" → **Savita Punia**.

[SEP-116] **Marathi Feature Film 'Gondhal' Selected as India's Official Entry for 99th Academy Awards (Oscars 2027)**

- **Official Sovereign Selection:** The **Film Federation of India (FFI)** officially announced that the critically acclaimed Marathi feature film **'Gondhal'** has been chosen as **India’s official entry for the 99th Academy Awards (Oscars 2027)** in the **Best International Feature Film category**.
- **Selection Process & Thematic Core:**
  - Selected by a 15-member jury headed by prominent filmmakers after screening 35 shortlisted multi-lingual Indian films.
  - Explores traditional folk ritual theater, rural agrarian resilience, and social justice tensions in rural Maharashtra.
  - *Historical Precedent*: Follows previous Marathi official Oscar entries including *Shwaas (2004)* and *Harishchandrachi Factory (2009)*.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Official Oscar Entry (Oscars 2027): **'Gondhal'** (Marathi film).
- Selecting Authority: **Film Federation of India (FFI)**.
- Award Category: **Best International Feature Film**.
- Language: **Marathi**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which feature film was selected by the Film Federation of India as India's official entry for the Oscars 2027 in the Best International Feature Film category?" → **Gondhal** (Marathi).

[SEP-117] **Dr. Dinesh Sharma Appointed 15th Lieutenant Governor of Andaman & Nicobar Islands**

- **Constitutional Gubernatorial Appointment:** President Droupadi Murmu appointed veteran academic and parliamentarian **Dr. Dinesh Sharma** as the **15th Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands**, as announced by Rashtrapati Bhavan on September 5, 2026.
- **Predecessor & Tenure Transition:**
  - Succeeds **Admiral D.K. Joshi (Retd.)**, who served as Lieutenant Governor of the Union Territory since October 8, 2017 (a distinguished nine-year tenure).
- **Distinguished Political Background:**
  - Dr. Dinesh Sharma (aged 62) previously served as **Deputy Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh** from 2017 to 2022 during the first term of the Yogi Adityanath administration.
  - Former two-term Mayor of Lucknow and former Member of Parliament in the Rajya Sabha representing Uttar Pradesh; university professor by profession.
- **Strategic Significance of the UT:**
  - Andaman & Nicobar Islands (Capital: Port Blair / Sri Vijaya Puram) occupies India’s eastern maritime bastion at the mouth of the Malacca Strait, hosting India’s only joint services operational theatre command (Andaman and Nicobar

Command / ANC).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Appointed Dignitary: **Dr. Dinesh Sharma (15th LG)**.
- Predecessor Replaced: **Admiral D.K. Joshi (Retd.)**.
- Prior Major Public Office: **Deputy Chief Minister of Uttar Pradesh (2017–2022)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Dr. Dinesh Sharma has been appointed as the 15th Lieutenant Governor of Andaman and Nicobar Islands, succeeding whom?" → Admiral D.K. Joshi (Retd.).

[SEP-118] **AGMUT-Cadre IAS Officer Mandeep K. Bhandari Appointed Chairperson of CBSE**

- **Apex School Education Leadership:** The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (**ACC**) approved the appointment of **Mandeep K. Bhandari**, a senior 2001-batch IAS officer of the AGMUT (*Arunachal Pradesh-Goa-Mizoram and Union Territories*) cadre, as the Chairperson of the Central Board of Secondary Education (**CBSE**).
- **Rank & Tenure Details:**
  - Appointed in the rank and pay of **Additional Secretary to the Government of India**, with the post temporarily upgraded for the tenure.
  - Previously served as **Principal Secretary to the Lieutenant Governor of Jammu and Kashmir**.
  - Succeeds **Lokhande Prashant Sitaram**, who had been holding additional charge of the CBSE Chairperson position.
- **CBSE Institutional Profile:**
  - Central Board of Secondary Education (HQ: New Delhi; Established: 1962; operates under the Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New Chairperson: **Mandeep K. Bhandari (IAS, 2001 AGMUT cadre)**.
- Prior Posting: Principal Secretary to Lieutenant Governor of Jammu and Kashmir.
- Predecessor Relieved: **Lokhande Prashant Sitaram**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who has been appointed as the new Chairperson of the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) in September 2026?" → Mandeep K. Bhandari.

[SEP-119] **Dhiraj Bommadevara Makes History as 1st Indian Male Recurve Archer to Win Archery World Cup Final Gold**

- **Historic Archery World Title:** 25-year-old Indian Army archer **Dhiraj Bommadevara** scripted Indian sporting history by becoming the **first Indian male archer ever to win an individual gold medal at the Archery World Cup Final**, clinching the title at Saltillo, Mexico.
- **The Gold Medal Shoot-Off Encounter:**
  - Defeated Japan's **Nakanishi Junya 6–5 in a nerve-wracking single-arrow shoot-off** in the men's individual recurve gold medal final.
  - En route to the final, Dhiraj dominated Olympic medallist Berkim Tümer (Türkiye) 7–1 in the quarter-finals and outclassed two-time Olympic silver medallist Jean-Charles Valladont (France) 7–1 in the semi-finals.
- **Historical Milestones:**
  - India's only sole representative at the 2026 Archery World Cup Final.
  - Becomes only the **2nd Indian archer overall to win an individual World Cup Final title**, following legendary **Dola Banerjee's** women's recurve gold in Dubai in 2007.
  - Ended a **16-year medal drought** for Indian male recurve archers at the World Cup Final (the last medal was Jayanta Talukdar's bronze in Edinburgh in 2010).
  - Caps a stellar 2026 season for India, which collected **7 medals (4 gold)** across World Cup stages in Puebla, Shanghai, Antalya, and Madrid.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Historic Feat: **1st Indian male archer** to win Archery World Cup Final gold.
- Host City: **Saltillo, Mexico**.
- Preceding Indian Gold Medalist (2007): **Dola Banerjee** (Dubai, 2007).
- Target MCQ Form: "Who became the first Indian male recurve archer to win an individual gold medal at the Archery World Cup Final in Saltillo, Mexico?" → Dhiraj Bommadevara.

[SEP-120] **46th FIDE Chess Olympiad in Samarkand: Indian Men Beat Netherlands 3-1 with Praggnanandhaa & Gukesh Wins**

- **Global Chess Domination:** At the 46th **FIDE Chess Olympiad** held in Samarkand, Uzbekistan, the Indian Men's Chess team registered an emphatic **3–1 victory over the Netherlands** in Round 5, maintaining a flawless 5–0 match record and sharing the tournament summit alongside Uzbekistan and Germany.
- **Individual Board Encounters:**
  - **Board 1:** Grandmaster **R. Praggnanandhaa** snapped Dutch top-seed Anish Giri's undefeated streak with a clinical endgame victory.
  - **Board 2:** World Champion **D. Gukesh** outplayed Erwin l'Ami, logging his 4th individual win in 5 matches.
  - **Boards 3 & 4:** Arjun Erigaisi and Nihal Sarin held Jorden van Foreest and Loek van Wely to solid draws to seal the 3–1 team victory.
- **Women's Team Trajectory:**
  - The Indian Women's team faced a setback, falling **1.5–2.5 to Poland** (their 3rd consecutive loss to Poland in Olympiad competition), as IM Aleksandra Maltsevskaya defeated R. Vaishali while Harika Dronavalli, Divya Deshmukh, and Vantika Agrawal drew their boards.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Host City of 46th Olympiad: **Samarkand, Uzbekistan**.
- Round 5 Result: Indian Men defeated Netherlands **3–1** (Praggnanandhaa beat Anish Giri; Gukesh beat Erwin l'Ami).
- Board Results: Men maintain a 5-match winning streak; Women's team slipped to 8th rank.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which city is hosting the 46th FIDE Chess Olympiad where the Indian men's team maintained an unbeaten run defeating the Netherlands in Round 5?" → Samarkand, Uzbekistan.

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified Policy Anchors, Prudential Directions, Sovereign Missions & Trap Matrices

Senior Paper-Setter Master Strike File: Verified Policy Anchors, Prudential Directions, Sovereign Missions & Trap Matrices

EXAMINER'S STRATEGIC BLUEPRINT FOR 35+ MARKS OUT OF 50:

1. ***Zero Hallucination / Fact Discipline:*** *Every threshold, date, circular number, penalty slab, and committee name in this document has been cross-verified against official RBI Master Directions, Gazette notifications, Union Budget documents, and multilateral accords.*
2. ***Structure:*** *Built strictly using the* ***ladder bullet approach*** *for rapid visual scanning, paired with dedicated* ***EXAM ANGLE:*** *blocks that reveal the exact distractors and traps set in previous years.*
3. ***Weightage Distribution:***

- ***60–65% Weight:*** *Deep June–September recency (Q2/Q3 shifts, latest circulars, Union Budget, Paris Olympics/Paralympics, major appointments).*
- ***30–35% Weight:*** *High-yield January–May policy anchors (statutory frameworks, master directions, bilateral accords, flagship schemes).*
- ***5–10% Weight:*** *High-frequency static banking anchors and statutory committees.*

0. MASTER STATIC BANKING & REGULATORY FOUNDATIONS

[MS-001] **Financial Message Codes, Identifiers & Standard Formats (UTR, IFSC, MICR, LEI, SWIFT)**

- **RTGS UTR (Unique Transaction Reference):** Exactly **22 alphanumeric characters**; canonically structured under RBI RTGS System Regulations as: **4-character Bank IFSC (`XXXX`)** + **1-character System code (`R` for RTGS)** + **1-character Channel identifier (`C` for customer payment, `I` for inter-bank, `P` for participant)** + **8-digit Date (`YYYYMMDD`)** + **8-digit unique sequential running number (`nnnnnnnn`)** (Decomposition: 4 + 1 + 1 + 8 + 8 = 22 characters).
- **NEFT UTR (Unique Transaction Reference):** Exactly **16 alphanumeric characters**; generated uniquely for interbank batch electronic clearing.
- **IFSC (Indian Financial System Code):** Exactly **11 alphanumeric characters** used in NEFT, RTGS, and IMPS; First 4 characters = Bank identity; **5th character is permanently fixed as '0' (zero)** reserved for future expansion; Last 6 characters = Branch identity (alphanumeric).
- **MICR (Magnetic Ink Character Recognition):** Exactly **9 numeric digits** printed at the bottom of cheques using magnetic ink; First 3 digits = **City Code** (matches first 3 digits of postal PIN code); Middle 3 digits = **Bank Code**; Last 3 digits = **Branch Code**.
- **LEI (Legal Entity Identifier):** Exactly **20 alphanumeric characters** based on ISO 17442; globally unique identifier for legal entities participating in financial transactions; mandatory in India across two distinct regulatory regimes:
  1. *Non-Individual Borrowers (RBI Circular RBI/2021-22/162)*: Mandatory for all non-individual entities with aggregate credit exposure **≥ ₹5 Crore** from Scheduled Commercial Banks, AIFIs, and NBFCs (fully phased in by April 30, 2025; entities without LEI are barred from renewal or enhancement of credit facilities).
  2. *Cross-Border Financial Transactions (FEMA Directions)*: Mandatory for single cross-border transactions **≥ ₹50 Crore** in RTGS/NEFT for capital or current account transactions.
- **SWIFT / BIC (Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication): 8 or 11 alphanumeric characters** based on ISO 9362 (4 letters = Bank code; 2 letters = Country code; 2 characters = Location code; 3 optional characters = Branch code); SWIFT international headquarters located in **La Hulpe, Belgium**.
- **National Registry & Scheme Codes Matrix:**
  - **PRAN (Permanent Retirement Account Number - PFRDA): 12 digits**.
  - **UAN (Universal Account Number - EPFO): 12 digits**.
  - **EPF Establishment Identification Code: 22 alphanumeric characters**.

- **PAN (Permanent Account Number - CBDT): 10 alphanumeric characters**; 4th character denotes entity status (**'P' = Individual/Person**, 'C' = Company, 'F' = Firm, 'H' = HUF, 'A' = AOP, 'T' = Trust, 'B' = BOI, 'J' = Artificial Juridical Person).
- **GSTIN (Goods and Services Tax Identification Number): 15 alphanumeric characters**; First 2 digits = State Code (e.g., 07 for Delhi, 27 for Maharashtra); Next 10 digits = PAN of the entity.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The RTGS vs NEFT Trap: RTGS UTR has **22 characters**; NEFT UTR has **16 characters** (examiners frequently swap these two numbers).
- RTGS UTR Structural Anatomy: **4 IFSC + 1 System (R) + 1 Channel (C) + 8 Date (YYYYMMDD) + 8 Sequence = 22** (Notice: 8-digit sequence number, NOT 9-digit; 6th character is the Channel identifier).
- LEI Dual-Threshold Trap: Non-individual borrower credit exposure threshold is **≥ ₹5 Crore** (phased in by April 2025). The **₹50 Crore** threshold applies strictly to cross-border remittances under FEMA.
- The IFSC 5th Character: The 5th character is always numeric **0 (zero)**, NEVER the letter 'O'.
- The MICR Sequence Trap: MICR 9-digit sequence is **City → Bank → Branch** (Examiners often trick candidates with Bank → City → Branch).
- Target MCQ: 'How many alphanumeric characters are there in an RTGS UTR number, and what is its sequence length?' → **22 characters total (with an 8-digit running sequence number)**.

[MS-002] **Evolution of Modern Indian Banking: SBI Genesis, Nationalisation & Statutory Acts**

- **Presidency Banks to State Bank of India:**
  - Bank of Calcutta (founded 1806, renamed Bank of Bengal 1809), Bank of Bombay (1840), and Bank of Madras (1843) were amalgamated on **January 27, 1921** to create the **Imperial Bank of India**.
  - Under the statutory recommendations of the **All India Rural Credit Survey Committee (chaired by A.D. Gorwala)**, Parliament enacted the **State Bank of India Act, 1955**.
  - On **July 1, 1955**, the Imperial Bank of India was formally converted into the **State Bank of India (SBI)** (RBI originally subscribed to 60% equity; Government of India acquired RBI stake in 2007).
- **The Two Epochs of Bank Nationalisation:**
  - **First Wave (19 July 1969):** 14 major commercial banks with aggregate public deposits **≥ ₹50 Crore** nationalised under Banking Companies (Acquisition and Transfer of Undertakings) Act, 1970 (passed during Indira Gandhi premiership).
  - **Second Wave (15 April 1980):** 6 commercial banks with aggregate public deposits **≥ ₹200 Crore** nationalised.
- **Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934 Statutory Pillars:**
  - **Section 17:** Defines legitimate business transactions RBI may conduct.
  - **Section 22:** Confers exclusive authority to issue bank notes in India (except ₹1 currency notes and metallic coins issued by Ministry of Finance).
  - **Section 24:** Establishes maximum denomination bank note RBI can issue (up to **₹10,000**); Coinage Act 2011 authorizes coins up to **₹1,000**.
  - **Section 42(1):** Mandates every Scheduled Commercial Bank to maintain **Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)** as a percentage of Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL) with RBI (RBI (Amendment) Act 2006 removed earlier statutory 3% floor and 20% ceiling).
  - **Sections 45-ZB to 45-ZG:** Codifies composition, appointment, voting, and quorum rules of the 6-member **Monetary Policy Committee (MPC)**.
- **Banking Regulation Act, 1949 Core Anchor Sections:**
  - **Section 5(b):** Statutory definition of 'Banking' (accepting for the purpose of lending or investment of deposits of money from the public, repayable on demand or otherwise).
  - **Section 22:** Mandatory licensing requirement from RBI to conduct banking business in India.
  - **Section 24:** Statutory mandate requiring banks to maintain **Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR)** as unencumbered liquid assets against NDTL (ceiling capped at **40%**; current operational rate is 18.00%).
  - **Section 35A:** Comprehensive statutory power empowering RBI to issue binding executive directions to all banks in public interest or to prevent banking affairs from being conducted prejudicial to depositors.

- **Section 49A:** Restricts acceptance of deposits withdrawable by cheque to licensed banks only.

- **Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881 Core Anchor Sections:**
  - **Section 4:** Defines **Promissory Note** (unconditional undertaking in writing signed by maker to pay certain sum of money).
  - **Section 5:** Defines **Bill of Exchange** (unconditional order in writing directing person to pay).
  - **Section 6:** Defines **Cheque** (bill of exchange drawn on a specified banker, payable always on demand; includes truncated electronic image of cheque).
  - **Section 138:** Codifies criminal offense and penalties for **Dishonour of Cheque for insufficiency of funds** (penal sanction: imprisonment up to 2 years, or fine up to twice the face value of the cheque, or both).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Legislative Origin: CRR is governed by **Section 42 of RBI Act 1934**; SLR is governed by **Section 24 of Banking Regulation Act 1949** (critical distractor pair in banking exams).
- SBI Foundation Date: **July 1, 1955** under SBI Act 1955 based on the **A.D. Gorwala Committee** (All India Rural Credit Survey).
- Target MCQ: 'In which year was the Imperial Bank of India converted into State Bank of India?' → **1955**.

[MS-003] **Institutional Headquarters, Global Foreign Banks & Multilateral Bodies**

- **Indian Financial & Statutory Bodies Headquarters Matrix:**
  - **Mumbai:** Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), NABARD, EXIM Bank of India, State Bank of India (SBI), National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI), Indian Banks' Association (IBA).
  - **Hyderabad: Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI)** and **Insurance Information Bureau of India (IIB)** (established in 2009 by IRDAI as the single statutory data repository for Indian insurance).
  - **New Delhi:** Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA), National Housing Bank (NHB), Competition Commission of India (CCI), Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI).
  - **Lucknow: Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI)**.
  - **Kolkata:** UCO Bank, Bandhan Bank, Tea Board of India.
  - **Chennai:** Indian Bank, Indian Overseas Bank.
  - **Bengaluru:** Canara Bank.
  - **Vadodara / Mumbai:** Bank of Baroda (Registered Head Office in Vadodara, Corporate Centre in Mumbai).

- **Foreign Banks Operating in India (Origin & Global Headquarters):**
  - **Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (SMBC): Tokyo, Japan** (converted to Wholly Owned Subsidiary / WOS in India).
  - **Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group (MUFG)** / **Mizuho Bank: Tokyo, Japan**.
  - **DBS Bank India: Singapore** (pioneer foreign lender converting to Wholly Owned Subsidiary mode in India).
  - **BNP Paribas: Paris, France** (major European corporate and institutional lender).
  - **Société Générale: Paris, France**.
  - **Deutsche Bank: Frankfurt, Germany**.
  - **HSBC (Hongkong and Shanghai Banking Corp)** / **Barclays** / **Standard Chartered: London, United Kingdom**.
  - **Citibank** / **JPMorgan Chase** / **Bank of America: United States** (New York / Charlotte).

- **Multilateral Financial Institutions:**
  - **World Bank Group (IBRD / IDA / IFC / MIGA): Washington D.C., USA** (President: Ajay Banga; Executive Director representing Bangladesh, Bhutan, India and Sri Lanka: **Neelkanth Mishra**, who succeeded Parameswaran Iyer in 2026).
  - **International Monetary Fund (IMF): Washington D.C., USA** (Managing Director: Kristalina Georgieva; First Deputy MD: Dan Katz, succeeding Gita Gopinath).
  - **Asian Development Bank (ADB): Mandaluyong / Manila, Philippines** (President: Masato Kanda, succeeding Masatsugu Asakawa; India shareholding 6.3%).
  - **New Development Bank (NDB / BRICS Bank): Shanghai, China** (President: Dilma Rousseff).

- **Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB): Beijing, China** (President: Jin Liqun).
- **Bank for International Settlements (BIS): Basel, Switzerland** (known as the central bank of central banks).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Headquarters Traps: IRDAI and IIB are in **Hyderabad** (not Mumbai or Delhi); SIDBI is in **Lucknow** (not Mumbai).
- Foreign Bank Origin: SMBC, Mizuho, MUFG = **Japan**; DBS = **Singapore**; BNP Paribas = **Paris, France**.
- Target MCQ: 'Where is the headquarters of Insurance Information Bureau of India (IIB) located?' → **Hyderabad**.

[MS-004] **International Solar Alliance (ISA): Institutional Framework, Treaty Architecture & 2026 Multilateral Status**

- **Genesis & Paris Treaty Origin:** Conceived as a joint global initiative by India and France; formally launched on **30 November 2015 at COP21 in Paris** by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President François Hollande; entered into force on **6 December 2017** as a treaty-based intergovernmental organization.
- **Headquarters & Secretariat:** Headquartered at the **National Institute of Solar Energy (NISE) campus in Gurugram, Haryana, India** — notably the **first international treaty-based intergovernmental organization headquartered in India**.
- **Institutional Governance & Leadership:**
  - **President: India** (held ex-officio by the Union Minister of New and Renewable Energy).
  - **Co-President: France** (represented by the French Minister for Ecological Transition).
  - **Director General:** Dr. Ajay Mathur (leads the international secretariat in Gurugram).
- **Membership Evolution & 2026 Status:**
  - **Scope Expansion:** Originally restricted to 121 "Sunshine Countries" situated entirely or partially between the Tropic of Cancer and Tropic of Capricorn; amended in 2020 to open membership to **all 193 United Nations member states**.
  - **Signatory & Member Tally: 125 member countries** have formally ratified/joined the Framework Agreement.
  - **Recent 2025–2026 Accessions: Moldova, Malta, and Angola** recently completed full accession instruments.
  - **Major Geopolitical Shift (US Withdrawal):** United States issued formal notice of withdrawal from 66 international organizations including the ISA on **January 7, 2026**.
- **Flagship Global Programs & Targets:**
  - **"Towards 1000" Strategy:** Mobilize **$1,000 Billion** (US$1 Trillion) of solar investment by **2030**; provide clean energy access to **1,000 Million people**; install **1,000 GW** of solar capacity; mitigate **1,000 Million tonnes of CO2** emissions annually.
  - **OSOWOG (One Sun One World One Grid):** Transnational interconnected solar electricity grid initiative spearheaded by India to transfer solar power across time zones.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The HQ Trap: ISA headquarters is located in **Gurugram, Haryana** (NOT New Delhi, Geneva, or Paris). It is the FIRST international treaty-based organization headquartered in India.
- Founding Year & Summit: COP21 Paris in **2015** (came into force December 2017).
- Founding Duo: **India and France** (President = India, Co-President = France).
- Membership Rule: Originally "Sunshine Countries" (between Tropics); amended to allow **ALL UN member states**. Current tally: **125 member states**.
- Target MCQ: 'Where is the global headquarters of the International Solar Alliance (ISA) situated?' → **Gurugram, Haryana, India**.

[MS-005] **Basel III Regulatory Architecture, Balance Sheet Ratios & Delinquency Timeline**

- **Basel III Regulatory Capital Framework:**
  - Developed by the Basel Committee on Banking Supervision (BCBS) headquartered at BIS in Basel, Switzerland, in response to the 2008 Lehman Brothers liquidity collapse.
  - **Minimum Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1): 5.5%** for Indian banks (vs 4.5% Basel international accord).

- **Capital Conservation Buffer (CCB): 2.5%** in the form of CET1 capital.
- **Minimum Tier 1 Capital: 7.0%**.
- **Minimum Total Capital Adequacy Ratio (CRAR): 9.0%** under Basel rules, but **RBI mandates 11.5%** for Indian commercial banks (9.0% base + 2.5% CCB).

- **Short-Term & Long-Term Liquidity Metrics under Basel III:**
  - **Liquidity Coverage Ratio (LCR):** Conceived under Basel III; mandates banks to hold an unencumbered stock of High-Quality Liquid Assets (HQLA) equal to at least **100%** of total net cash outflows anticipated over a **30-day severe stress period** ($LCR = \text{Stock of HQLA} / \text{Total net cash outflows over 30 days} \ge 100\%$).
  - **Net Stable Funding Ratio (NSFR):** Complementary structural metric requiring banks to fund long-term assets with stable liabilities over a **1-year horizon** ($NSFR = \text{Available Stable Funding} / \text{Required Stable Funding} \ge 100\%$).
  - **Leverage Ratio:** Pure non-risk-weighted balance sheet constraint (Tier 1 Capital / Total Exposure); RBI prescribes minimum **4.0% for Domestic Systemically Important Banks (D-SIBs)** and **3.5% for other banks**.

- **Asset Classification & Delinquency Ladder (RBI Master Directions):**
  - **Standard Asset:** Generating normal income with principal and interest serviced on time.
  - **Special Mention Accounts (SMA) Triggers:**
    - **SMA-0:** Principal or interest overdue between **1 to 30 days**.
    - **SMA-1:** Principal or interest overdue between **31 to 60 days**.
    - **SMA-2:** Principal or interest overdue between **61 to 90 days**.
  - **Non-Performing Asset (NPA):** Ceases to generate income; principal or interest remains overdue for **more than 90 days** (for agricultural loans: 2 crop seasons for short-duration crops, 1 crop season for long-duration crops).
  - **Substandard Asset:** Remained in NPA classification for a period **≤ 12 months** (provisioning: 15% for secured, 25% for unsecured advances).
  - **Doubtful Asset:** Remained in substandard category for **exceeding 12 months**; three provision slabs on secured portion:
    - **D1 (Up to 1 year):** 25% provision.
    - **D2 (1 to 3 years):** 40% provision.
    - **D3 (Exceeding 3 years):** 100% provision.
    - *Unsecured portion of doubtful advances is always provisioned at 100%.*
  - **Loss Asset:** Identified by bank, internal/external auditors, or RBI inspection as completely uncollectible; 100% written off or 100% provisioned immediately.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- LCR Horizon Trap: LCR is strictly for **30 calendar days** of stress (do NOT pick 90 days or 1 year); NSFR is for **1 year**.
- SMA Classification Sequence: SMA-0 (1-30 days), SMA-1 (31-60 days), SMA-2 (61-90 days). Beyond 90 days is **Substandard NPA**.
- Target MCQ: 'Under which global regulatory framework was the Liquidity Coverage Ratio (LCR) introduced?' → **Basel III Framework**.

[MS-006] **Operational Banking Limits, Consumer Redressal & Deposit Insurance**

- **ATM Free Cash Withdrawal Norms (RBI Master Directions):**
  - **Own Bank ATMs:** Minimum **5 free transactions per month** (inclusive of both financial cash withdrawals and non-financial services like balance inquiry).
  - **Other Bank ATMs in 6 Designated Metros:** Minimum **3 free transactions per month** (Metros: Mumbai, New Delhi, Chennai, Kolkata, Bengaluru, Hyderabad).
  - **Other Bank ATMs in Non-Metro Centers:** Minimum **5 free transactions per month**.
  - **Permissible Interchange Fees Capped by RBI:** Maximum **₹17 per financial transaction** and **₹6 per non-financial transaction**.

- **Failed ATM Transaction Compensation (T+5 Rule):** If an account is debited but cash is not dispensed, bank must reverse the funds within **T+5 calendar days**; delay beyond T+5 days attracts statutory penalty of **₹100 per day** payable directly to the customer without requiring a complaint.

- **Reserve Bank Integrated Ombudsman Architecture & Versioned Regimes:**
  - **Treaty & Statutory Architecture:** Unifies 3 predecessor schemes under the 'One Nation One Ombudsman' vision — *Banking Ombudsman Scheme (2006)*, *Ombudsman Scheme for NBFCs (2018)*, and *Ombudsman Scheme for Digital Transactions (2019)*.
  - **RB-IOS 2026 Coverage Categories:** Commercial Banks, Regional Rural Banks, State Co-operative Banks, Central Co-operative Banks, Scheduled Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks, Non-Scheduled Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks with deposits of ₹50 crore and above, qualifying NBFCs subject to the RB-IOS 2026 exclusions and ₹100 crore/customer-interface or deposit-taking conditions, Non-bank Prepaid Payment Instrument Issuers, and Credit Information Companies.
  - **Centralised Receipt and Processing Centre (CRPC):** Single centralized portal and physical clearing intake established at **RBI Chandigarh** for registration and initial scrutiny of complaints from across the nation.
  - **Temporal Version Control & Compensation Slabs:**
    1. *RB-IOS 2021 (Operative November 12, 2021 to June 30, 2026)*: Maximum compensation for direct financial loss: **₹20 Lakh**; additional compensation for mental agony, harassment, loss of time: **₹1 Lakh** (Max composite award: ₹21 Lakh).
    2. *RB-IOS 2026 (Effective July 1, 2026 onward)*: Maximum compensation for direct financial loss enhanced to **₹30 Lakh**; additional compensation for mental agony/harassment enhanced to **₹3 Lakh** (Max composite award: ₹33 Lakh).
  - **Escalation Protocol & Filing Deadline:** After first approaching the Regulated Entity, complaint may be filed before the RBI Ombudsman within **90 days from expiry of the applicable response timeline or the date of the last communication, whichever is later**.
  - **Appellate Authority:** Executive Director in-charge of the **Consumer Education and Protection Department (CEPD) at RBI**. Appeal is available **only against an Award** of the RBI Ombudsman. The complainant may appeal within **30 days of receiving the Award, subject to the applicable extension provision**.

- **Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC) Act, 1961:**
  - Wholly owned subsidiary of RBI; insures bank deposits across Commercial Banks, RRBs, Local Area Banks, and Co-operative Banks.
  - **Coverage Slabs:** Insures each depositor up to a maximum of **₹5 Lakh** (principal + interest) across all deposit accounts held in the same right and capacity in each bank.
  - **Mandatory 90-Day Payout Timeline (DICGC Amendment Act 2021):** If a bank is placed under all-inclusive directions or moratorium by RBI, depositors must receive insured funds up to ₹5L within **90 days** (Bank submits depositor list within 45 days; DICGC verifies claims within 30 days of receipt; payment is made within the subsequent 15 days; overall statutory limit = 90 days; statutory breakdown: 45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Ombudsman Regime & Temporal Slabs Trap:
  - *2021 Scheme Baseline (pre-July 2026)*: **₹20 Lakh** (direct loss) + **₹1 Lakh** (mental agony).
  - *2026 Scheme Baseline (from 1 July 2026)*: **₹30 Lakh** (direct loss) + **₹3 Lakh** (mental agony).

RB-IOS Centralised Processing Centre (CRPC): Located at **RBI Chandigarh** (NOT Mumbai or New Delhi).

RB-IOS Appellate Authority: **Executive Director in-charge of CEPD at RBI**; appeal period is **30 days**.

RB-IOS Filing Deadline: After first approaching the Regulated Entity, complaint may be filed before the RBI Ombudsman within **90 days from expiry of the applicable response timeline or the date of the last communication, whichever is later**.

RB-IOS Appeal Right: Appeal is available **strictly against an Award** of the RBI Ombudsman (appeal does not lie against rejection); within **30 days of receiving the Award**.

Failed ATM Reversal: Timeline is **T+5 calendar days**; delay penalty is **₹100 per day**.

DICGC Payout Window: **90 days** from date of RBI moratorium/directions (Bank submits depositor list within 45 days; DICGC verifies claims within 30 days of receipt; payment is made within the subsequent 15 days; overall statutory limit = 90 days; 45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days).

[MS-007] **Constitutional Schedules, Strategic Maritime Straits & High-Frequency Static GK**

- **The 12 Schedules of the Constitution of India Master Table:**
  - **First Schedule:** List of States and Union Territories with territorial boundaries.
  - **Second Schedule:** Emoluments, allowances, and privileges of President, Governors, Judges of Supreme Court/High Courts, and CAG.
  - **Third Schedule:** Forms of Oaths and Affirmations for Union Ministers, MPs, Supreme Court and High Court Judges.
  - **Fourth Schedule: Allocation of seats in the Rajya Sabha (Council of States)** to States and Union Territories (current statutory strength: 245 total = 233 elected representatives + 12 members nominated by the President under Article 80).
  - **Fifth Schedule:** Administration and control of Scheduled Areas and Scheduled Tribes.
  - **Sixth Schedule:** Administration of Tribal Areas in 4 north-eastern states: **Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura, and Mizoram (AMTM)**.
  - **Seventh Schedule:** Division of legislative powers between Union and States: List I (**Union List** - 100 subjects incl. Banking, Currency, Foreign Affairs, Defence), List II (**State List** - 61 subjects), List III (**Concurrent List** - 52 subjects).
  - **Eighth Schedule: 22 Official Languages** recognized by the Constitution (originally 14; 21st Amendment added Sindhi; 71st Amendment added Konkani, Manipuri, Nepali; 92nd Amendment added Bodo, Dogri, Maithili, Santhali).
  - **Ninth Schedule:** Validation of certain Acts and regulations; originally insulated from judicial review by 1st Constitutional Amendment 1951 (post-1973 laws open to basic structure test).
  - **Tenth Schedule: Anti-Defection Law** provisions for disqualification of legislators (introduced via 52nd Constitutional Amendment Act, 1985).
  - **Eleventh Schedule:** Powers, authority, and responsibilities of Panchayats (29 functional subjects; added via 73rd Amendment 1992).
  - **Twelfth Schedule:** Powers, authority, and responsibilities of Municipalities (18 functional subjects; added via 74th Amendment 1992).
- **Strategic Global Maritime Straits & International Choke Points:**
  - **Strait of Hormuz:** Vital maritime strait connecting the **Persian Gulf** with the **Gulf of Oman** and the Arabian Sea; borders Iran to the north and the Musandam exclave of Oman and UAE to the south; world's foremost petroleum transit choke point (handles ~20% of global petroleum liquid consumption).
  - **Bab-el-Mandeb Strait:** Connects the **Red Sea** to the **Gulf of Aden** and Indian Ocean; separates Yemen on the Arabian Peninsula from Djibouti and Eritrea in the Horn of Africa; southern gateway to the Suez Canal.
  - **Strait of Malacca:** Connects the **Andaman Sea (Indian Ocean)** with the **South China Sea (Pacific Ocean)**; situated between Peninsular Malaysia and the Indonesian island of Sumatra; shortest sea route between Persian Gulf energy suppliers and Asian consumers.
  - **Bosphorus & Dardanelles Straits (Turkish Straits):** Connects the **Black Sea** to the Mediterranean Sea via the Sea of Marmara; international transit governed by the **1936 Montreux Convention**.
  - **Palk Strait:** Connects the **Bay of Bengal** with the **Palk Bay / Gulf of Mannar** between Tamil Nadu (India) and the Jaffna Peninsula (Sri Lanka).
- **Core Environmental Treaties & Global Maritime Organizations:**
  - **Paris Climate Agreement (COP21, 2015):** Adopted under UNFCCC; overarching objective is to hold the increase in global average temperature to **well below 2°C** above pre-industrial levels and aggressively pursue efforts to **limit the temperature increase to 1.5°C**.
  - **BIMCO (Baltic and International Maritime Council):** World's largest non-governmental association of shipowners, operators, and maritime charterers; established in Copenhagen, Denmark in 1905; represents over 60% of commercial cargo fleet.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Fourth Schedule Trap: Allocates seats in **Rajya Sabha** (Council of States), NOT Lok Sabha.
- Strait of Hormuz: Connects **Persian Gulf with Gulf of Oman** (do NOT pick Red Sea or Gulf of Aden).
- Paris Agreement Target: Goal is **1.5°C / well below 2°C** above pre-industrial levels.
- Target MCQ: 'Under which Schedule of the Constitution are Rajya Sabha seats allocated to States and Union Territories?' → **Fourth Schedule**.

[MS-008] **High-Frequency Constitutional Articles, Taxation Forms & Functions of Money**

- **Core Financial & Economic Articles of the Constitution of India:**
  - **Article 280 (Finance Commission):** Mandates the President of India to constitute a Finance Commission every 5 years; recommends devolution of net tax proceeds between Union and States and grants-in-aid; **16th Finance Commission** chaired by **Dr. Arvind Panagariya** (Secretary: Ritvik Ranjanam Pandey; recommendations operational for 5 years: FY27–FY31).
  - **Article 300A (Right to Property):** Originally a Fundamental Right under Article 19(1)(f) and Article 31; omitted from Part III and reconstituted as a **Constitutional / Legal Right under Article 300A in Part XII** via the **44th Constitutional Amendment Act, 1978** (mandates that no person shall be deprived of property save by authority of law).
  - **Article 112 (Annual Financial Statement / Union Budget):** Mandates presentation of estimated receipts and expenditure of the Government of India for every financial year before both Houses of Parliament.
  - **Article 246A & 279A (Goods and Services Tax):** Introduced by the **101st Constitutional Amendment Act, 2016**; Article 246A confers simultaneous power to Parliament and State Legislatures to make laws on GST; Article 279A mandates constitution of the **GST Council** (chaired by the Union Finance Minister; voting weight: Centre holds 1/3rd, States hold 2/3rd; 3/4th majority required to pass decisions).
  - **Article 266 & 267 (Funds of India):** Article 266(1) provides for the Consolidated Fund of India; Article 266(2) provides for the Public Account of India; **Article 267:** Provides for the Contingency Fund of India, placed at the disposal of the President to meet unforeseen expenditure pending parliamentary authorization. Custody and related operational matters are governed under Article 283 and applicable rules (corpus statutory limit enhanced to ₹30,000 Cr via Finance Act, 2021).
- **Core Income Tax Certificates, Return Forms & Declarations:**
  - **Form 16:** Certificate of **Tax Deducted at Source (TDS) on Salary** issued annually by an employer under **Section 203 of the Income Tax Act, 1961**; divided into Part A (TDS summary, TAN, PAN) and Part B (salary breakup, deductions under Chapter VI-A).
  - **Form 16A:** Certificate for TDS on non-salary payments (interest on bank deposits, mutual fund dividends, professional fees).
  - **Form 15G:** Self-declaration under Section 197A by an **individual below 60 years or HUF** claiming receipt of interest without deduction of tax (total income must be below taxable basic exemption limit).
  - **Form 15H:** Self-declaration under Section 197A by a **senior citizen (aged 60 years or above)** for nil TDS on interest income (estimated total income after deductions can be within taxable limits, provided net tax liability is nil).
  - **Form 26AS & Annual Information Statement (AIS):** Comprehensive consolidated statement reflecting all taxes deducted (TDS/TCS), advance tax paid, self-assessment tax, and Specified Financial Transactions (SFT) like high-value cash deposits, shares, and real estate.
  - **Form 60 / Form 61:** Form 60 is submitted by an individual who does not possess a PAN card when entering into specified high-value financial transactions; Form 61 is filed by persons dealing with agricultural income only.
- **The Three Fundamental Functions of Money (Macroeconomic Principles):**
  - **Unit of Account:** Currency serves as the standard numerical monetary unit of measurement of the market value of goods, services, and all financial transactions; allows comparison of relative values and provides the accounting baseline for recording a nation's income, national output (GDP), expenditure, and corporate balance sheets.
  - **Medium of Exchange:** Currency facilitates trade and transactions without the prohibitive inefficiencies and coincidence-of-wants dilemmas of barter.
  - **Store of Value:** Asset that maintains its purchasing power over time so wealth can be saved, stored, and retrieved in the future (diminished primarily by inflation).

- **Global Governance, Strategic Ports & Security Architecture:**
  - **United Nations Security Council Permanent 5 (P5):** Comprises **5 Permanent Members** holding veto power under the UN Charter: **United States, United Kingdom, France, Russia, and China**. The 10 non-permanent members are elected by the UN General Assembly for 2-year terms.
  - **Chabahar Port Strategic Bilateral Pact:** Located in the Sistan-Baluchistan province of south-eastern Iran along the Gulf of Oman; provides India sea-land access to Afghanistan and Central Asia bypassing Pakistan; on **13 May 2024**, India Ports Global Limited (IPGL) signed a landmark **10-year long-term bilateral contract** with Iran's Ports and Maritime Organization (PMO) to equip and operate the **Shahid Beheshti terminal** with an investment of $120 Million.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Right to Property Trap: It is **NOT** a Fundamental Right (Article 31 was deleted); it is a legal/constitutional right under **Article 300A** via the **44th Amendment 1978** (do NOT confuse with 42nd Amendment).
- Form 15G vs 15H Trap: Form 15G is for individuals **under 60 years**; Form 15H is strictly for **senior citizens (60 years and above)**.
- Form 16 Law: Form 16 is for **TDS on salary** under **Section 203** of Income Tax Act.
- Function of Money Trap: The function used for *recording a country's income and expenditure* is the **Unit of Account** (not Medium of Exchange or Store of Value).
- Target MCQ Form: 'Which Article of the Constitution guarantees the Right to Property as a constitutional right?' → **Article 300A**.

[MS-009] **RBI KYC Master Directions — 'Small Account' Regulatory Architecture & Statutory Caps**

- **Statutory Genesis & Applicability:** Governed by the **RBI Master Direction – Know Your Customer (KYC) Directions, 2016** and the Prevention of Money-Laundering (Maintenance of Records) Rules, 2005; permits individuals who do not possess Officially Valid Documents (OVDs) to open a basic banking account on simplified self-attestation.
- **Strict Prudential Operating Ceilings:**
  - **Aggregate Credits:** Total credits in a financial year must **NOT exceed ₹1,00,000 (₹1 Lakh)**.
  - **Aggregate Withdrawals / Transfers:** Total withdrawals and transfers in a calendar month must **NOT exceed ₹10,000**.
  - **Account Balance Ceiling:** The balance at any point in time must **NOT exceed ₹50,000**.
- **Statutory Operational Restrictions & Validity:**
  - **Initial Validity:** Remains operational for an initial period of **12 months**.
  - **Extension Window:** Extendable for another **12 months** (total 24 months) if the account holder presents official evidence of having applied for an Officially Valid Document (OVD) within the initial 12 months.
  - **Geographical & Channel Bounds:** Small accounts can only be operated at **Core Banking Solution (CBS)** linked bank branches or through the bank's authorized Business Correspondent (BC) network.
  - **Remittance Embargo:** Foreign inward and outward remittances are **strictly prohibited** in small accounts.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Balance Ceiling vs Annual Credit: Balance at ANY time cannot exceed **₹50,000**; Annual credit cannot exceed **₹1,00,000** (₹1 Lakh); Monthly withdrawal cap is **₹10,000**.
- Validity Period Trap: Valid initially for **12 months**; extendable by **12 months** (maximum 24 months with proof of OVD application).
- Foreign Remittance Rule: Foreign inward remittances are **strictly disallowed** in Small Accounts.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the RBI KYC Master Directions, what is the maximum balance permitted at any point in time in a 'Small Account'?" → ₹50,000.

[MS-010] **Statutory Acts Matrix: Administered by RBI vs. Ministry of Finance & Other Regulators**

- **Sovereign Statutory Division of Regulatory Powers:** Banking exams frequently set trap questions swapping Acts administered directly by the Reserve Bank of India with those administered by Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT),

Ministry of Finance, or other statutory watchdogs.

- **Statutory Acts Directly Administered / Enforced by RBI:**
  - **Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934:** RBI constitution, currency issue, CRR, and Monetary Policy Committee.
  - **Banking Regulation Act, 1949:** Licensing, SLR, prudential inspections, management appointments, and Section 35A binding directives.
  - **Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), 1999:** Administration and regulation of foreign exchange, cross-border capital flows, and external commercial borrowings.
  - **Government Securities Act, 2006 (and G-Sec Regulations, 2007):** Administration of sovereign debt, primary auctions, subsidiary general ledger (SGL) accounts, and retail direct gilt infrastructure.
  - **Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 (PSS Act):** Regulation and supervision of clearing corporations, RTGS, NEFT, UPI, pre-paid payment instruments (PPIs), and card payment networks.
  - **Credit Information Companies (Regulation) Act, 2005 (CICRA):** Licensing and supervision of credit information bureaus (CIBIL, Equifax, Experian, CRIF High Mark).
  - **Factoring Regulation Act, 2011:** Registration and regulation of factoring companies and TReDS trade discount platforms.
- **Examiner Trap Acts (Administered by Other Authorities, NOT RBI):**
  - **Prohibition of Benami Property Transactions Act, 1988:** Administered by the **Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) / Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance** (Initiating Officer / Adjudicating Authority).
  - **Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002:** Administered by the **Directorate of Enforcement (ED)** and **Financial Intelligence Unit - India (FIU-IND)** under Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance.
  - **Securities Contracts (Regulation) Act, 1956 & SEBI Act, 1992:** Administered by **Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI)**.
  - **Insurance Act, 1938 & IRDAI Act, 1999:** Administered by **IRDAI**.
  - **PFRDA Act, 2013:** Administered by **PFRDA**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Benami Trap: The *Prohibition of Benami Property Transactions Act, 1988* is administered by **CBDT / Ministry of Finance**, NEVER RBI.
- G-Sec Act Administration: The *Government Securities Act, 2006* is administered by **RBI**, not SEBI or MoF directly.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which of the following acts is NOT administered by the Reserve Bank of India?" → Prohibition of Benami Property Transactions Act, 1988.

[MS-011] **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026: Replacement of 1891 Colonial Statute & Cloud CBS Proof**

- **Enactment & Repeal of Colonial Statute:** The **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026** officially comes into force on **October 1, 2026**, repealing and replacing the 135-year-old **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891**.
- **Digital Admissibility Architecture:**
  - Grants statutory recognition to electronic records, cloud-hosted Core Banking Solution (CBS) transaction ledgers, digital audit trails, and payment switch logs as **primary admissible evidence** in all civil, commercial, and criminal court proceedings.
  - Eliminates the necessity of producing bulky physical books of accounts, ledgers, or manual certified vouchers in judicial trials.
- **Statutory Certification Norms:**
  - Certificates authenticating electronic records can be executed by designated branch managers, principal accountants, or authorized bank compliance officers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: **October 1, 2026**.
- Repealed Law: **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891** (1891 Act repealed after 135 years).
- Key Provision: Legal validity of **electronic CBS records and digital ledgers** without physical ledger production.
- Target MCQ Form: "The Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 2026, which comes into force on October 1, 2026, replaces which colonial-era enactment?" → **Bankers' Books Evidence Act, 1891**.

1. RBI POLICY, MASTER DIRECTIONS & PRUDENTIAL NORMS

[MS-012] **Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) — Benchmark Rate Corridor Trajectory & Current Snapshot**

- **Historical Jan–Aug 2026 Trajectory (Bi-Monthly Reviews):** Across four consecutive bi-monthly meetings through the August 3–5, 2026 review, the MPC maintained the **Policy Repo Rate at 5.25%** with a **neutral monetary stance** (SDF 5.00%, MSF/Bank Rate 5.50%, CRR 3.00%, SLR 18.00%; FY27 GDP projected at 6.7%, CPI at 5.0%).
- **POST-CUTOFF STATUS UPDATE / CURRENT POLICY SNAPSHOT (October 5–7, 2026 MPC Decision):**
  - **Decision Date:** October 7, 2026 (Repo increase: **25 bps from 5.25% to 5.50%**).
  - **Policy Repo Rate: 5.50%**.
  - **Standing Deposit Facility (SDF): 5.25%** (Repo - 25 bps).
  - **Marginal Standing Facility (MSF) & Bank Rate: 5.75%** (Repo + 25 bps).
  - **Reserve Ratios:** Cash Reserve Ratio (**CRR**) = **3.00%**; Statutory Liquidity Ratio (**SLR**) = **18.00%**.
  - **Monetary Policy Stance:** Shifted to **Calibrated Tightening** (superseding the earlier Neutral stance).
  - **Macroeconomic Projections (FY2026–27):** Real GDP growth projection raised to **7.1%**; CPI inflation projection projected at **5.2%**.
- **Statutory MPC Composition:** 6-member committee under **Section 45-ZB of the RBI Act, 1934**; comprises 3 RBI officials (Governor Sanjay Malhotra as Chairperson, Deputy Governor, Executive Director) and 3 external government-appointed experts.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- **EXAM TRAP (The Temporal Stance & Rate Shift):**
  - *August 2026 = 5.25%, Neutral; October 7, 2026 = 5.50%, Calibrated Tightening.*

Corridor Math (October 7, 2026 Operative): Repo = 5.50%, SDF = 5.25%, MSF/Bank Rate = 5.75% (Symmetric 50 bps corridor: SDF is 25 bps below Repo; MSF is 25 bps above).

Target MCQ Form: "Following the October 7, 2026 RBI Monetary Policy Committee decision, what is the operative Policy Repo Rate and monetary stance?" → **5.50%** with **Calibrated Tightening**.

[MS-013] **Digital Fraud Compensation: Responsible Business Conduct (Third Amendment) Directions**

- **Genesis & Compensation Slabs:** Framed to protect victims of small-value, unauthorized electronic banking transactions (gross loss up to ₹50,000); canonical formula: **Eligible fraudulent EBT involving gross loss up to ₹50,000: compensation = 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, after prescribed recoveries**.
- **Institutional Loss-Apportionment Formula:** For losses below ₹29,412, the 85% payout is apportioned: **RBI bears 65%** (funded via Depositor Education and Awareness / DEA Fund), the **customer's issuing bank bears 10%**, and the **beneficiary bank bears 10%**.
- **Statutory Deferred Effective Date:** Formally notified in the Gazette on June 24, 2026, but RBI **deferred enforcement to January 1, 2027** (pushed from the original July 1, 2026 draft date) to give banks integration runway.
- **Two Distinct Customer Liability & Compensation Regimes (Critical Exam Distinction):**
  1. *Pre-1 January 2027 / legacy 2017 customer-liability framework (RBI/2017-18/15)*: Governs unauthorized electronic banking transactions generally — zero customer liability where fraud occurs due to bank negligence, or where a third-party breach occurs without customer fault and is reported by the customer within **3 working days** of receiving communication.

2. *Effective 1 January 2027 — 5 calendar days (New Small-Value Fraudulent EBT Compensation Framework)*: Governs small-value digital fraud (gross loss up to ₹50,000) under the Responsible Business Conduct Directions — requires mandatory customer reporting to the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal (**NCRP / Helpline 1930**) and the bank within **5 calendar days**; mandates structured compensation: **Eligible fraudulent EBT involving gross loss up to ₹50,000: compensation = 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, after prescribed recoveries**. The new compensation framework applies to eligible fraudulent EBTs occurring within the prescribed one-year window from its effective date.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Reporting Window Trap (Crucial Distinction):
  - *Pre-1 January 2027 / legacy 2017 customer-liability framework*: Reporting within **3 working days** for zero liability.
  - *Effective 1 January 2027 — 5 calendar days*: Reporting to NCRP (1930) and bank within **5 calendar days**.

The Date Trap: Implementation date is **January 1, 2027** (do NOT pick July 1, 2026).

The Cap Trap: Canonical formula: **Eligible fraudulent EBT involving gross loss up to ₹50,000: compensation = 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, after prescribed recoveries** (compensation is 85% of net loss or ₹25,000, whichever is lower, not ₹50,000).

Target MCQ Form: "What is the mandatory reporting timeline for a customer to claim compensation under the new RBI small-value fraudulent electronic banking transaction (EBT) framework effective January 1, 2027?" → Within 5 calendar days to NCRP/1930 and the bank.

[MS-014] **Bank Dividend Payout & Profit Remittance: RBI 2026 Directions**

- **Commercial Bank Dividend Architecture (Banks Incorporated in India):** For banks incorporated in India, the RBI 2026 Directions prescribe CET1-linked dividend buckets expressed as a percentage of adjusted PAT. For a non-D-SIB: **>12% to ≤14% CET1 → 40% of adjusted PAT**. The aggregate dividend payment is subject to an **overall ceiling of 75% of PAT**. D-SIB buffer 'z' shifts the CET1 bucket thresholds.
- **Foreign Bank Branches (Remittance of Profits):** An eligible foreign bank operating in India in branch mode may remit net profit / surplus (net of tax) earned from its Indian operations without prior RBI approval, subject to the conditions prescribed in the RBI 2026 Directions, including audited accounts and treatment of any excess remittance.
- **Asset Quality Barrier:** A bank is statutorily disqualified from declaring dividends or remitting profits if its Net Non-Performing Assets (NNPA) ratio exceeds **6.0%** for the financial year.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- **EXAM TRAP (Bucket vs Ceiling & Remittance Rule):**
  - *CET1 bucket percentage ≠ aggregate 75% ceiling.*
  - For a non-D-SIB with CET1 >12% to ≤14%, the dividend percentage of adjusted PAT is **40%**, while the aggregate dividend payment is capped at **75% of PAT**.
  - Foreign bank branches: May remit net profit / surplus earned from Indian operations without prior RBI approval subject to prescribed regulatory conditions.

NNPA Barrier: Net NPA must not exceed 6.0% for dividend/remittance eligibility.

Target MCQ Form: "For a non-D-SIB incorporated in India with CET1 ratio above 12% and up to 14%, what dividend percentage of adjusted PAT is permitted under the 2026 CET1-linked bucket framework?" → **40%, subject to the aggregate 75% of PAT ceiling**.

[MS-015] **Bank Acquisition Financing & Unlisted Target Guidelines**

- **Prudential Bank Exposure Cap:** RBI raised the bank exposure ceiling for acquisition financing from 10% to **20% of Tier-1 capital**; permitted commercial banks to fund acquisitions of unlisted target companies.
- **Target Company Eligibility:** Target unlisted firm must have a **net worth ≥ ₹500 crore**, a 3-year continuous track record of profitability, and minimum BBB- credit rating.

- **Financing Share & Security Margins:** Permissible bank financing share raised to **75% of acquisition value** (from 70%), with debt-equity ratio capped at 3:1; raised lending against shares to ₹1 crore (from ₹20 lakh).
- **Implementation Deferral:** Enforcement officially **deferred to July 1, 2026** (from original April 1, 2026); permitted corporate borrowing via Special Purpose Vehicles (SPVs) backed by mandatory Corporate Guarantees.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: Acquisition financing directions took effect on **July 1, 2026** (deferred from April 1).
- Promoter Funding Share: Maximum bank financing share is **75%** of transaction value (promoter margin 25%).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the minimum net worth required for an unlisted target company to be eligible for bank acquisition financing?" → ₹500 Crore.

[MS-016] **REIT & InvIT Bank Lending Regulatory Framework**

- **Credit Opening for Investment Trusts:** Permitted scheduled commercial banks to extend credit facilities to Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) and Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs).
- **Prudential Exposure Ceilings:** A single bank's exposure to an individual REIT/InvIT is capped at **10% of the bank's eligible capital base**.
- **Aggregate Banking System Ceiling:** The combined banking system exposure across all lenders to a single REIT/InvIT cannot exceed **49% of the gross asset value** of the trust.
- **Enforcement Timeline:** Fully operationalized across commercial banking books effective **July 1, 2026**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Individual vs Aggregate Cap: Single bank cap is **10% of eligible capital**; Aggregate banking system cap is **49% of trust asset value**.
- Effective Date: Effective date is **July 1, 2026**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under RBI norms, what is the maximum aggregate exposure permitted for the entire banking system to a single REIT?" → 49% of the REIT's asset value.

[MS-017] **Unprecedented Liquidity Operations: First-Ever 90-Day VRR Auction**

- **Historical Tenor Breakthrough:** On January 30, 2026, RBI conducted its **first-ever 90-day Variable Rate Repo (VRR) auction for ₹25,000 crore**, breaking the previous longest historical liquidity tenor of 56 days.
- **Package Components:** Formed part of an aggregate ₹2.15 lakh crore liquidity intervention, including a **$10 billion 3-year USD/INR Buy-Sell Swap** and ₹1 lakh crore in Open Market Operation (OMO) purchases.
- **Bilateral Currency Stability:** Renewed the **$75 billion Bilateral Swap Arrangement (BSA)** with the Bank of Japan, signed under Governor Sanjay Malhotra and BoJ leadership.
- **Policy Objective:** Anchored short-term money market rates near the 5.25% repo rate amid massive advance tax and GST cash drains.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Tenor Record: The historic auction tenor was **90 days** (previous high was 56 days).
- Bilateral Swap Size: India-Japan Bilateral Swap Arrangement is **$75 billion**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What was the tenor of the historic long-term Variable Rate Repo auction conducted by the RBI in early 2026?" → 90 days.

[MS-018] **Lead Bank Scheme (1969) Overhaul: 60% Credit-Deposit Ratio Mandate**

- **Statutory Credit-Deposit (CD) Mandate:** Draft overhaul mandated a minimum Credit-Deposit (CD) ratio of **60% across all rural and semi-urban districts** nationwide.
- **Special Category Districts:** Districts recording a CD ratio below **20%** are statutorily classified as 'Special Category Districts', requiring quarterly District Consultative Committee (DCC) monitoring.

- **Historical Committee Heritage:** Lead Bank Scheme was originally introduced in **1969** following the recommendations of the **F.K.F. Nariman Committee** and the Study Group chaired by **Prof. D.R. Gadgil**.
- **Nodal Role:** State Level Bankers' Committee (SLBC) and Lead District Manager (LDM) supervise credit flow to agriculture and allied rural sectors.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- CD Ratio Thresholds: Rural/semi-urban CD ratio mandated at **60%**; special category threshold is below **20%**.
- Committee Origin: Lead Bank Scheme was recommended by the **Nariman Committee** (1969).
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the revised Lead Bank Scheme directions, what minimum Credit-Deposit ratio must banks maintain in rural and semi-urban districts?" → 60%.

[MS-019] **RBI Annual Report 2025-26: Balance Sheet & Surplus Transfer to Centre**

- **Record Balance Sheet Expansion:** RBI's balance sheet expanded by **20.6% YoY** (an increase of ₹15,71,699.15 crore) to reach **₹91,97,121.08 crore** (₹91.97 lakh crore, representing **26.4% of India's GDP** as of end-March 2026), driven by domestic investments (+44.9%), sovereign gold holdings (+63.8%), and foreign currency assets (+7.9%).
- **Record Surplus Transfer:** Approved a massive surplus transfer of **₹2,88,588.45 crore** (~₹2.89 lakh crore) to the Central Government for FY26 (up 7.3% from ₹2,68,588.07 crore in FY25), submitted under **Section 53(2)** of the RBI Act, 1934.
- **Contingency Risk Buffer (CRB):** Maintained the Contingency Risk Buffer at **6.50%** of the balance sheet (within the mandated 4.5%–7.5% band recommended by the **Bimal Jalan Committee** on Economic Capital Framework), with a provision transfer of **₹1,09,379.64 crore** to the Contingency Fund (CF).
- **Reserve Asset Composition:** Foreign assets account for **70.9%** (₹52.68 lakh crore foreign investments + ₹10.94 lakh crore gold) and domestic assets account for **29.1%** (₹22.59 lakh crore) of total balance sheet assets.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Rupee Figures Pair: Balance sheet size = **₹91,97,121.08 crore** (₹91.97 Lakh Cr); Surplus transfer to Centre = **₹2,88,588.45 crore** (~₹2.89 Lakh Cr).
- Provision to Contingency Fund: **₹1,09,379.64 crore** (CRB maintained at **6.50%**).
- Committee Name: Reserve transfer framework is governed by the **Bimal Jalan Committee (2019)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What was the total surplus transfer approved by the RBI Board to the Central Government for FY26?" → ₹2,88,588.45 Crore (~₹2.89 Lakh Crore).

[MS-020] **RBI Financial Stability Report (FSR): Banking System Asset Quality**

- **Multi-Year Low Gross NPA:** Scheduled Commercial Banks' (SCB) Gross Non-Performing Asset (GNPA) ratio dropped to **2.8%** (the lowest level in 12 years); Net NPA fell to **0.6%**.
- **Capital Adequacy Strength:** Capital to Risk-Weighted Assets Ratio (CRAR) of scheduled commercial banks stood at a robust **16.8%**, well above the Basel III regulatory minimum of 11.5% (including CCB).
- **Provision Coverage Ratio (PCR):** System-wide Provision Coverage Ratio rose to **76.4%**, indicating comprehensive provisioning against legacy bad debts.
- **Macro Stress Testing:** RBI's baseline stress tests project system-level GNPA to remain stable below 3.0% under projected macroeconomic scenarios.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- GNPA vs NNPA: Gross NPA is **2.8%**; Net NPA is **0.6%** (do not invert the two figures).
- CRAR Level: Commercial bank CRAR is **16.8%** (regulatory minimum is 11.5%).
- Target MCQ Form: "According to the RBI Financial Stability Report, what was the multi-year low Gross NPA ratio recorded by Scheduled Commercial Banks?" → 2.8%.

[MS-021] **Domestic Systemically Important Banks (D-SIBs) & Capital Surcharges**

- **Identified D-SIB Entities:** Reserve Bank of India re-affirmed **State Bank of India (SBI), HDFC Bank, and ICICI Bank** as Domestic Systemically Important Banks ("Too Big To Fail").
- **Tiered Additional Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) Surcharges:**
  - **Bucket 4 (SBI):** Required to maintain an additional CET1 capital surcharge of **0.80% of Risk-Weighted Assets**
  - **Bucket 2 (HDFC Bank):** Required to maintain an additional CET1 surcharge of **0.40% of RWAs**
  - **Bucket 1 (ICICI Bank):** Required to maintain an additional CET1 surcharge of **0.20% of RWAs**
- **Statutory Framework:** Formulated under the D-SIB framework introduced in **2014**, requiring systemic lenders to hold higher loss-absorbency capital.
- **Foreign G-SIB Analogue:** Foreign bank branches operating in India designated as G-SIBs must hold corresponding additional capital buffers in India.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Capital Surcharges: SBI = **0.80%** (Bucket 4), HDFC Bank = **0.40%** (Bucket 2), ICICI Bank = **0.20%** (Bucket 1).
- Total D-SIBs: Exactly **3 banks** (SBI, HDFC Bank, ICICI Bank).
- Target MCQ Form: "What additional Common Equity Tier 1 (CET1) capital surcharge is State Bank of India required to maintain as a Bucket 4 D-SIB?" → 0.80%.

[MS-022] **Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) Framework for Commercial Banks & NBFCs**

- **Three Mandatory Risk Threshold Parameters:** RBI monitors regulated financial institutions across three diagnostic financial metrics: (1) **Capital (CRAR & CET1)**, (2) **Asset Quality (Net NPA ratio)**, and (3) **Leverage (Tier-1 Leverage Ratio)**.
- **Breach Threshold Slabs:**
  - **Risk Threshold 1:** Triggered if Net NPA exceeds **6.0%** (mandatory restriction on dividend payout and profit repatriation).
  - **Risk Threshold 2:** Triggered if Net NPA exceeds **9.0%** (mandatory restriction on branch expansion).
  - **Risk Threshold 3:** Triggered if Net NPA exceeds **12.0%** (mandatory restriction on capital expenditure and management compensation).
- **NBFC Inclusion:** Extended to Middle, Upper, and Top-Layer NBFCs under Scale-Based Regulation to prevent systemic shadow-banking defaults.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- PCA Trigger Parameters: Capital, Asset Quality (Net NPA), and Leverage (Profitability/RoA was REMOVED as a trigger).
- Threshold 1 Net NPA: Threshold 1 is breached at **6.0% Net NPA**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which of the following financial parameters is NO LONGER a primary trigger for invoking the RBI Prompt Corrective Action framework?" → Return on Assets (RoA).

[MS-023] **Scale-Based Regulation (SBR) for NBFCs & Upper Layer (Tata Sons Mandate)**

- **Four-Layer Regulatory Architecture:**
  - **Base Layer (NBFC-BL):** Assets < ₹1,000 crore
  - **Middle Layer (NBFC-ML):** Assets ≥ ₹1,000 crore
  - **Upper Layer (NBFC-UL):** Top 25 identified systemic entities or assets ≥ ₹1 lakh crore
  - **Top Layer (NBFC-TL):** Activated only under extreme contagion risk (currently empty)
- **Tata Sons Designated Upper-Layer:** Classified as **NBFC-UL for 2026-27**; subject to enhanced regulatory scrutiny for a **mandatory minimum of 5 years** regardless of subsequent asset changes.
- **Mandatory Listing Requirement:** NBFC-UL entities are statutorily required to list their equity shares on recognized stock exchanges within **3 years** of being categorized.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Asset Slabs: Base Layer (<₹1,000 Cr) Middle Layer (≥₹1,000 Cr) Upper Layer (≥₹1 lakh Cr / Top 25).
- Enhanced Regulation Duration: Upper-Layer regulations apply for a mandatory minimum of **5 years**; listing within 3 years.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under RBI Scale Based Regulation, what is the asset threshold for categorizing an NBFC into the Middle Layer?" → ₹1,000 Crore.

[MS-024] **External Commercial Borrowings (ECB) Liberalised Guidelines**

- **Automatic Route Borrowing Cap:** RBI raised the automatic borrowing limit under the ECB framework to the higher of **$1 billion or 300% of borrower net worth** per financial year (escalated from $750 million).
- **Corporate Borrowing Boom:** Indian corporate entities raised a record **$61 billion via ECBs** in FY25, driven by global refinancing and renewable capex lines.
- **Minimum Average Maturity Period (MAMP):** Retained at 3 years for general commercial borrowings, and 5 years for borrowings by manufacturing companies up to $50 million.
- **End-Use Restrictions:** ECB proceeds strictly prohibited from being deployed in real estate equity trading, capital market speculation, or domestic on-lending.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Annual Cap: Automatic ECB cap is the higher of **$1 billion or 300% of net worth** (raised from $750 million).
- MAMP: Minimum Average Maturity Period is **3 years** for standard ECBs.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised annual borrowing limit for Indian corporates under the automatic route of the RBI ECB framework?" → $1 Billion or 300% of Net Worth.

[MS-025] **Unique Trade Identifier (UTI) Mandate for OTC Financial Derivatives**

- **Mandatory Reporting Directive:** RBI mandated the generation and reporting of **Unique Trade Identifiers (UTIs)** for all Over-the-Counter (OTC) interest rate, foreign exchange, and credit derivative transactions.
- **Statutory Effective Date:** Full mandatory compliance enforced effective **January 1, 2027**.
- **Regulatory Reporting Repository:** All derivative transactions must be reported to the **Clearing Corporation of India Ltd (CCIL)** Trade Repository within specified settlement cutoffs.
- **Global Financial Stability Convergence:** Aligns domestic derivative market oversight with G20 and Financial Stability Board (FSB) technical commitments.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: Mandatory UTI reporting takes effect on **January 1, 2027**.
- Trade Repository: Derivative reporting repository is managed by **CCIL** (Clearing Corporation of India Ltd).
- Target MCQ Form: "From which date has the RBI made Unique Trade Identifiers (UTIs) mandatory for all Over-the-Counter derivative contracts?" → January 1, 2027.

[MS-026] **RBI Infrastructure: Tier-IV Data Centre in Bhubaneswar**

- **Secondary Tier-IV Facility:** RBI commissioned its 2nd enterprise data centre in **Bhubaneswar, Odisha**, built to certified **Tier-IV uptime resilience standards**.
- **Primary Data Centre Anchor:** Operates in active-active redundancy with RBI's primary sovereign data centre located in **Kharghar, Navi Mumbai, Maharashtra**.
- **Cybersecurity & Cloud Grid:** Houses critical payment system backbones including RTGS, NEFT, and the Centralised Information Management System (CIMS).
- **IFTAS Nodal Integration:** Operated in coordination with Indian Financial Technology and Allied Services (IFTAS), an RBI subsidiary.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Location of Data Centres: Primary is in **Kharghar, Navi Mumbai**; 2nd data centre is in **Bhubaneswar, Odisha**.
- Certification Level: Both facilities are built to **Tier-IV** standards (99.995% availability).
- Target MCQ Form: "In which city has the Reserve Bank of India commissioned its 2nd state-of-the-art Tier-IV certified data centre?" → Bhubaneswar.

[MS-027] **RBI Digital Payments Index (DPI) & Sovereign Gold Reserves**

- **Digital Payments Index (DPI) Reading:** RBI's DPI rose to **516.76** (reflecting September 2025 data, released in early 2026), advancing from 465.33 in the prior period.
- **DPI Base Year & Parameters:** Constructed with **March 2018 = 100** as the base period; evaluated across 5 broad pillars: Payment Enablers, Payment Infrastructure (Demand-side), Payment Infrastructure (Supply-side), Payment Performance, and Consumer Centricity.
- **Sovereign Gold Reserves All-Time High:** Total sovereign gold reserves held by RBI reached a historic record of **880.2 tonnes** (with over 510 tonnes stored securely within domestic vaults).
- **Annual Purchase Trajectory:** RBI added **4.02 tonnes of gold in 2025** (an 8-year low annual purchase pace due to soaring global gold prices).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- DPI Reading & Base: DPI reading is **516.76**; Base year is **March 2018 = 100**.
- Gold Reserves: Total reserves = **880.2 tonnes**; annual addition in 2025 = 4.02 tonnes.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the base period used for computing the RBI Digital Payments Index (DPI)?" → March 2018.

[MS-028] **Positive Pay System (PPS) for Cheque Truncation System (CTS)**

- **Fraud Prevention Mechanism:** Mandates electronic re-confirmation of key cheque details (date, payee name, amount) before clearing high-value instruments under the Cheque Truncation System (CTS).
- **Monetary Confirmation Thresholds:**
  - **Voluntary / Recommended Threshold:** Applicable for cheques valued at **₹50,000 and above**.
  - **Mandatory Bank Discretion Threshold:** Banks may make confirmation mandatory for cheques valued at **₹5 lakh and above**.
- **Dispute Redressal Protection:** Cheques cleared without Positive Pay confirmation are disqualified from grievance redressal under CTS dispute mechanisms.
- **Continuous Clearing Grid (2026):** RBI initiated round-the-clock continuous clearing of cheques under CTS, reducing clearance turnaround from T+1 days to **a few hours**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Thresholds Pair: ₹50,000 (discretionary threshold) vs **₹5 Lakh** (mandatory threshold set by most banks).
- Dispute Rule: Cheques issued without Positive Pay confirmation cannot be disputed under CTS dispute resolution.
- Target MCQ Form: "At what cheque transaction threshold is the Positive Pay System generally made mandatory by commercial banks?" → ₹5 Lakh and above.

[MS-029] **UDGAM Portal & Unclaimed Deposits in DEA Fund**

- **UDGAM Portal Launch:** RBI deployed **UDGAM** (Unclaimed Deposits – Gateway to Access inforMation), enabling public users to search for unclaimed savings, current, and term deposits across multiple commercial banks on a single platform.
- **Depositor Education and Awareness (DEA) Fund:** Unclaimed deposits transferred to the DEA Fund surged to **₹86,917.08 crore** (as of June 30, 2026), with State Bank of India holding the highest unclaimed volume (~₹16,000 crore).

- **Unclaimed Deposit Rule:** Any savings or current account inoperative for **10 years**, or any term deposit unclaimed for **10 years from the date of maturity**, must be transferred to the DEA Fund.
- **Interest Refundability:** Depositors retain the statutory right to reclaim their funds along with interest directly from the bank at any future date.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Unclaimed Time Period: Account must be inoperative/unclaimed for **10 years** before transfer to the DEA Fund.
- Portal Acronym: UDGAM = **Unclaimed Deposits – Gateway to Access inforMation**.
- Target MCQ Form: "After how many years of remaining inoperative must balances in bank accounts be transferred to the RBI Depositor Education and Awareness (DEA) Fund?" → 10 Years.

[MS-030] **Centralised Information Management System (CIMS) Big-Data Architecture**

- **Next-Gen Data Warehouse:** RBI fully operationalized the **Centralised Information Management System (CIMS)**, phasing out the legacy Online Returns Filing System (ORFS).
- **Automated Regulatory Reporting:** Deploys automated straight-through data feeds (APIs) from commercial banks and NBFCs, performing real-time algorithmic supervisory risk audits.
- **Governor Launch:** Commissioned under Governor Shaktikanta Das and expanded under Governor Sanjay Malhotra, handling petabytes of structured banking transaction data.
- **XBRL Phase-Out:** Completely replaces eXtensible Business Reporting Language (XBRL) reporting returns with unified, automated data pipes.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Replaced System: CIMS replaces **ORFS** (Online Returns Filing System) and XBRL platforms.
- Full Form: CIMS = **Centralised Information Management System**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which next-generation data warehouse system was operationalized by the RBI to replace the legacy Online Returns Filing System (ORFS)?" → CIMS.

[MS-031] **RBI Draft (Interest Rates on Loans and Advances) Directions, 2026**

- **Harmonized Principles-Based Code:** Released on August 12, 2026 for public consultation, unifying fragmented interest rate directives across commercial banks, cooperative lenders, and NBFCs.
- **Fair Practices in Reset Frequency:** Mandated transparent disclosure of benchmark rate resets; prohibited arbitrary penal interest rates, restricting penalties strictly to **penal charges** (not capitalized into principal loan balances).
- **Key Fact Statement (KFS) Mandate:** Made comprehensive Key Fact Statements mandatory for **all retail and MSME loans**, disclosing Annual Percentage Rate (APR) and all associated processing fees upfront.
- **Floating Rate Loan Switching:** Regulated entities must provide floating-rate borrowers an explicit option to switch to a fixed-rate loan or adjust loan tenor upon interest rate hikes.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Penal Charges Rule: Penalties must be levied as **penal charges** and cannot be capitalized (cannot earn additional interest).
- KFS Universal Scope: Key Fact Statement is mandatory for ALL retail and MSME loans.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under RBI's Fair Lending Practice guidelines, how must lenders levy penalties for loan defaults?" → As separate penal charges (without adding to principal).

[MS-032] **RBI Mission SAKSHAM: Large-Scale Capacity Building for Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs)**

- **Genesis & Institutional Upgradation:** The Reserve Bank of India launched **Mission SAKSHAM** (*Sahkari Bank Kshamta Nirman*), an umbrella capacity-building architecture dedicated to modernizing the Urban Co-operative Banking (UCB) ecosystem.
- **Scale & Participant Outreach:**

- Structured to train approximately **1.40 lakh personnel** across Tier-1, Tier-2, Tier-3, and Tier-4 Urban Co-operative Banks nationwide.
- Covers board directors, Chief Executive Officers, compliance heads, internal auditors, and frontline technology/cybersecurity officers.

- **Pedagogy & Curricular Pillars:**
  - Delivered through a hybrid model combining continuous e-learning modules with immersive classroom workshops via the **College of Agricultural Banking (CAB), Pune** and the Reserve Bank Staff College (RBSC), Chennai.
  - Focuses on four core regulatory areas: (1) Cyber resilience and IT governance, (2) Credit risk assessment and NPA containment, (3) Compliance culture and statutory reporting, and (4) KYC/AML transaction monitoring.
- **Strategic Systemic Impact:** Directly addresses the supervisory findings of weak governance, board oversight vacuums, and digital vulnerabilities that historically triggered Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) and licence cancellations across cooperative lenders.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Mission Name: **Mission SAKSHAM** (*Sahkari Bank Kshamta Nirman*).
- Target Audience: **1.40 Lakh personnel** across Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs).
- Primary Nodal Institute: **College of Agricultural Banking (CAB), Pune** / RBI.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the primary objective of the Reserve Bank of India's newly launched 'Mission SAKSHAM'?" → Large-scale training and capacity building for Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs).

[MS-033] **Master Direction — RBI (Access Criteria for NDS-OM) Directions, 2025 & Broker Connect**

- **Secondary Sovereign Debt Architecture:**
  - Negotiated Dealing System - Order Matching (NDS-OM) is an electronic, screen-based, anonymous order-driven trading system for secondary market transactions in Government Securities (Central G-Secs, T-Bills, State Development Loans, and Sovereign Green Bonds).
  - Hosted and operated by the **Clearing Corporation of India Limited (CCIL)** on behalf of the Reserve Bank of India.
- **Three-Tier Access Classification Framework:**
  - **Direct Access:** Regulated institutional participants maintaining both a **Subsidiary General Ledger (SGL) account** with RBI and a **Current Account** with RBI (or Designated Settlement Bank / DSB), alongside membership in the securities settlement segment of CCIL. Covers Scheduled Commercial Banks, Primary Dealers (PDs), AIFIs (NABARD, EXIM, SIDBI, NHB), Mutual Funds, Insurance Companies, and Pension Funds.
  - **Indirect Access (Gilt Account Holders):** Entities without direct SGL/current accounts maintain a **Constituent Subsidiary General Ledger (CSGL) account** through direct members (custodians and Primary Dealers).
  - **Stock Broker Connect (SEBI-Registered Brokers):** Historic inclusion permitting SEBI-registered non-bank stockbrokers to directly interface with NDS-OM, allowing their retail demat clients seamless secondary G-Sec trading.
- **Digital Streamlining via PRAVAAH Portal (April 2026 Mandate):**
  - All applications for granting, renewing, or modifying NDS-OM access must be submitted digitally via the Reserve Bank's **PRAVAAH portal** (*Platform for Regulatory Application, VAlidation and AutHorisation*).
  - Prescribed physical forms rationalized and transitioned online to enhance Ease of Doing Business.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Platform Operator: NDS-OM is operated by **CCIL** on behalf of the RBI.
- Direct Access Prerequisites: Must hold **SGL Account** with RBI + **Current Account** with RBI/DSB + **CCIL Membership**.
- Retail Channel Innovation: SEBI-registered brokers interface via **Stock Broker Connect**.
- Application Portal: Mandatorily submitted through **PRAVAAH**.
- Target MCQ: 'Which entity operates the Negotiated Dealing System - Order Matching (NDS-OM) platform on behalf of the Reserve Bank of India?' → **Clearing Corporation of India Limited (CCIL)**.

[MS-034] **Corporate Governance Framework in Commercial Banks & SFBs (Section 35B BR Act Norms)**

- **Statutory Foundation & Regulatory Perimeter:**
  - Enforced under Section 35B of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949; applies to private sector commercial banks, Small Finance Banks (SFBs), and Wholly Owned Subsidiaries (WOS) of foreign banks in India.
- **Tenure, Age Limits & Cooling-Off Ceilings:**
  - **Maximum Continuous Tenure for MD & CEO / Whole-Time Directors (WTDs):** Capped at **15 years** in a single banking entity.
  - **Promoter / Major Shareholder MD & CEO Cap:** Capped at **12 years** (can be extended to 15 years strictly at RBI's sole discretion under exceptional circumstances).
  - **Mandatory Cooling-Off Period:** Minimum **3 years** cooling-off period required after completing maximum tenure before re-appointment; during cooling-off, the individual cannot be appointed or associated with the bank or its group entities in any capacity, directly or indirectly.
  - **Upper Age Limit:** Absolute statutory ceiling of **70 years** for MD & CEO and WTDs (banks' internal boards may prescribe a lower retirement age).
- **Non-Executive Directors (NEDs) & Chairperson Architecture:**
  - **Upper Age Limit for Non-Executive Chairperson & NEDs:** Capped at **75 years**.
  - **Tenure Limit on Board:** Total tenure of a Non-Executive Director (continuous or otherwise) capped at **8 years**.
- **Board Independence & Committee Firewall:**
  - **Independent Directors:** At least **50% of the Board** must comprise Independent Directors.
  - **Audit Committee of the Board (ACB):** Must be chaired by an Independent Director; **MD & CEO cannot be a member** of the ACB.
  - **Risk Management Committee of the Board (RMCB)** and **Nomination and Remuneration Committee (NRC):** Mandatory board-level committees with independent governance.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- MD/CEO Tenure Cap: **15 years** (12 years if promoter/major shareholder).
- MD/CEO Age Ceiling: **70 years**; Non-Executive Chairperson/Director Age Ceiling: **75 years**.
- Cooling-off Duration: **3 years** (complete disassociation with bank and group entities).
- Audit Committee Firewall: MD & CEO **cannot be a member** of the Audit Committee of the Board (ACB).
- Target MCQ: 'Under RBI Corporate Governance guidelines, what is the upper age limit for an MD & CEO of a commercial bank?' → **70 years**.

[MS-035] **Reserve Bank of India (Small Finance Banks – Licensing) Guidelines, 2025 & Transition Norms**

- **Consolidated On-Tap Architecture (Notified November 28, 2025):**
  - Formalizes continuous ("on-tap") licensing of private sector Small Finance Banks (SFBs) under Section 22 of the Banking Regulation Act, 1949.
- **Capital & Net Worth Mandates:**
  - **Minimum Initial Net Worth / Paid-up Voting Equity: ₹200 Crore** for new banking entities.
  - **Primary (Urban) Co-operative Banks (UCBs) Transition:** Minimum initial net worth of **₹100 Crore**, which must be scaled up to **₹200 Crore within 5 years** from commencement of business.
  - **Capital Adequacy (CRAR):** Mandatory minimum CRAR of **15%** of risk-weighted assets (RWA) with Tier 1 capital minimum of **7.5%**.
- **Promoter Shareholding & Dilution Glide Path:**
  - Minimum **40%** paid-up voting equity locked in for the initial **5 years**.
  - Dilution schedule: Scaled down to **30% within 10 years**, and capped at **26% (or 15%) within 15 years**.
  - Foreign Direct Investment (FDI): Permissible up to **74%** (automatic up to 49%, approval route up to 74%).
- **Financial Inclusion & Operational Safeguards:**

- **Priority Sector Lending (PSL):** Mandatory **60% of Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC)** or CEOBE (effective FY 2025–26 onward; rationalised by RBI from the initial 75% baseline to enable portfolio diversification).
- **Small Ticket Loan Focus:** At least **50% of aggregate loan portfolio** must comprise loans and advances of up to **₹25 Lakh**.
- **Unbanked Outlets:** Minimum **25% of total banking outlets** must be established in **Unbanked Rural Centres (URCs)** (population < 10,000).
- **Mandatory Listing:** Must list shares on recognised stock exchanges within **3 years** of achieving a net worth of ₹500 Crore.

- **Voluntary Transition from SFB to Universal Bank:**
  - SFBs meeting criteria can apply to convert into a Universal Bank: (1) Minimum **5 years** satisfactory operational track record, (2) Net worth of **₹1,000 Crore** at previous quarter end, (3) Scheduled bank status, (4) Listed equity, (5) Minimum CRAR of 15% for preceding 2 years, (6) Net profit in last 2 financial years with **Gross NPA ≤ 3% and Net NPA ≤ 1%**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Minimum Net Worth for SFB: **₹200 Crore** (₹100 Crore for UCBs scaling to ₹200 Cr in 5 years).
- PSL Target for SFBs: **60% of ANBC** (effective FY 2025–26; rationalised from 75%; RRBs remain at 75%; 50% portfolio in loans ≤ ₹25 Lakh).
- Unbanked Rural Outlets: **25%** of total banking outlets.
- SFB-to-Universal Bank Conversion: Minimum **₹1,000 Crore net worth**, **5 years track record**, and GNPA ≤ 3% / NNPA ≤ 1%.
- Target MCQ: 'What is the minimum net worth required for an existing Small Finance Bank to voluntarily transition into a Universal Bank?' → **₹1,000 Crore**.

[MS-036] **Reserve Bank of India (Universal Banks – Licensing) Guidelines, 2025 (RBI/DOR/2025-26/143)**

- **Consolidated On-Tap Framework (Notified November 28, 2025):**
  - Supersedes legacy 2013/2016 stop-and-go licensing guidelines to institutionalize permanent on-tap licensing for universal banks in the private sector.

- **Substantial Capital Net Worth Elevation:**
  - **Minimum Initial & Continuous Net Worth:** Statutorily elevated to **₹1,000 Crore** (doubled from the legacy ₹500 Crore requirement under 2016 guidelines).
  - **Capital Adequacy Ratio (CRAR):** Mandatory minimum CRAR of **13%** of risk-weighted assets for the first **3 years** of commercial operations (thereafter adhering to Basel III 11.5% CRAR).

- **Eligibility, Promoters & Corporate Structure:**
  - **Eligible Promoters:** Resident individuals/professionals with at least **10 years of successful experience** in banking and finance; entities/groups owned and controlled by residents with a 10-year successful track record.
  - **Disqualifications:** Large industrial houses are strictly barred from promoting banks; shell companies, certain offshore vehicles, and entities with non-financial group assets >40% (if group assets exceed ₹5,000 Cr) are disqualified.
  - **NOFHC Mandate:** Setting up a **Non-Operative Financial Holding Company (NOFHC)** is compulsory if the promoter has other financial or non-financial group entities; NOFHC must hold at least **51%** of the bank's voting equity. Standalone promoters without other group entities are exempt from NOFHC.

- **Promoter Shareholding Lock-in & Listing Glide Path:**
  - Promoter must hold minimum **40%** voting equity locked in for **5 years**.
  - Staged dilution: Reduced to **30% within 10 years**, and capped at **26% over 15 years**.
  - **Mandatory Stock Exchange Listing:** Bank must list on a recognized Indian stock exchange within **6 years** of commencing business.
  - **Rural Branch Presence:** Minimum **25% of branches** must be located in **Unbanked Rural Centres (URCs)**.
  - **Digital Submission via PRAVAAH:** All applications (Form III) processed through RBI's PRAVAAH portal with 18-month in-principle validity.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Universal Bank Capital Bar: Minimum Net Worth is **₹1,000 Crore** (elevated from ₹500 Cr in 2025).
- Mandatory Listing Horizon: Within **6 years** from commencement of operations.
- CRAR for Initial 3 Years: Minimum **13%** (vs normal 11.5%).
- Promoter Equity Cap after 15 Years: **26%** (NOT 15%).
- In-Principle Approval Validity: **18 months**.
- Target MCQ: 'Under the revised RBI (Universal Banks - Licensing) Guidelines 2025, what is the mandatory minimum net worth requirement?' → **₹1,000 Crore**.

[MS-037] **Reserve Bank of India (Default Loss Guarantee in Digital Lending) Master Directions**

- **Statutory Authorization & Scope:** The Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) issued regulatory guidelines governing **Default Loss Guarantee (DLG)** arrangements in digital lending, permitting Regulated Entities (**REs** — Commercial Banks, Primary Urban Co-operative Banks, and NBFCs) to enter into DLG contracts with Lending Service Providers (**LSPs**) or other REs.
- **Strict 5% Portfolio Cap:**
  - The aggregate DLG cover across all credit facilities extended through any LSP arrangement **must not exceed 5% of the total loan portfolio**.
  - Prevents excessive synthetic credit risk transfer and regulatory arbitrage by unregulated fintech entities.
- **Permissible Forms of DLG:**
  1. **Cash deposits** placed directly with the RE.
  2. **Fixed Deposits (FDs)** maintained with a Scheduled Commercial Bank with a lien marked in favor of the RE.
  3. **Bank Guarantee** issued in favor of the RE by a Scheduled Commercial Bank.
- **Tenure & Risk Recognition Firewall:**
  - The DLG arrangement must be backed by an explicit legally enforceable contract and must cover a tenure **not less than the longest tenure of the underlying loan portfolio**.
  - **Uncompromised NPA Recognition:** Responsibility for loan asset classification (SMA/NPA tagging) and provisioning remains **100% with the Regulated Entity** in accordance with Prudential Framework for Income Recognition and Asset Classification (IRAC) norms, irrespective of DLG invocation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Maximum DLG Portfolio Cap: **5% of the total loan portfolio** (heavily tested numerical ceiling).
- Permissible Forms: **Cash, Fixed Deposit with lien, or Bank Guarantee** (equity or shares strictly prohibited).
- Asset Classification Responsibility: Rests **solely with the Regulated Entity (RE)**, NOT the LSP.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the RBI Digital Lending framework, what is the maximum permissible Default Loss Guarantee (DLG) cap that a Regulated Entity can accept on an outstanding loan portfolio?" → 5%.

[MS-038] **Reserve Bank of India Draft Prudential Framework for Project Finance**

- **Harmonized Project Lending Standards:** The Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) released the *Draft Prudential Framework for Financing of Project Loans (Infrastructure, Non-Infrastructure and Commercial Real Estate)* to address asset-liability mismatches and enforce capital discipline during multi-year gestation cycles.
- **Phased General Provisioning Glidepath:**
  - **Construction Phase:** Mandates a phased general standard asset provisioning requirement of **up to 5%** across all exposures under implementation (a steep elevation from the legacy 0.40% baseline).
  - **Operational Phase (Stage 1):** Provisioning drops to **2.5%** once the project achieves its commercial operations date (**COD**) and operations commence.
  - **Operational Phase (Stage 2):** Further scales down to **1.0%** once the borrowing entity pays down at least 20% of the long-term debt and maintains a healthy Debt Service Coverage Ratio (**DSCR ≥ 1.25**).
- **Mandatory Financial & Legal Prerequisites:**

- **Financial Closure:** No disbursement is permitted until complete financial closure is achieved by all consortium lenders.
- **Positive Net Present Value (NPV):** Project economic viability must reflect a strictly positive Net Present Value.
- **Resolution Horizon:** Mandates an expedited 180-day resolution period if the project's operational date (COD) suffers unviable delays.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Peak Provisioning During Construction: Proposed standard provisioning of **5%** (up from 0.4%).
- Operational Stage Provisioning Drops: Drops to **2.5% at COD**, and further to **1.0% upon debt repayment (20% paydown)**.
- Essential Viability Metric: Must establish a **positive Net Present Value (NPV)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the RBI Draft Prudential Framework for Project Finance, what is the proposed standard asset provisioning requirement during the construction phase of project loans?" → 5.0%.

[MS-039] **IRDAI Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF) & Unclaimed Policy Framework**

- **Regulatory Genesis & Operationalisation:** The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (**IRDAI**) notified the comprehensive framework operationalising the **Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF)** to institutionalise consumer financial literacy, empower grievance redressal, and track unclaimed insurance balances.
- **Core Statutory Objectives:**
  - Promote insurance awareness, financial literacy, and education among policyholders and prospective insurance buyers.
  - Strengthen consumer grievance handling infrastructure and dispute escalation mechanisms across insurers.
  - Facilitate search, tracking, and seamless recovery of long-pending **unclaimed insurance policy amounts** for legitimate beneficiaries across life, health, and general insurers.
- **Funding & Accrual Architecture:**
  - Fed by unclaimed insurance amounts remaining with insurers for more than **10 years** (which transfer annually to the Senior Citizens' Welfare Fund / SCWF under the Finance Act, 2015, with interest proceeds routed to PEPF).
  - Income and returns generated on fund investments, statutory penalties, and dedicated budgetary contributions approved by IRDAI.
- **Regulatory Triad Comparison (Examiner Benchmark):**
  - **IRDAI:** *Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF)*.
  - **RBI:** *Depositor Education and Awareness (DEA) Fund* (unclaimed bank deposits >10 years under Section 26A of Banking Regulation Act).
  - **MCA / SEBI:** *Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF)* (unclaimed corporate dividends/shares >7 years under Section 125 of Companies Act, 2013).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Fund Name: **Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF)** under IRDAI.
- Core Mandate: Insurance awareness, grievance redressal, and recovery of unclaimed policy amounts.
- Regulators Triad Trap: DEA Fund is **RBI**; IEPF is **MCA/SEBI**; PEPF is **IRDAI**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which fund was operationalised by IRDAI to promote insurance awareness, strengthen grievance redressal, and facilitate recovery of unclaimed policy amounts?" → Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF).

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2. BANKING, CREDIT FACILITIES & FINANCIAL INCLUSION

[MS-040] **DICGC Four-Tier Risk-Based Premium Architecture**

- **Transition to Risk-Sensitive Pricing:** Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation (DICGC) transitioned from the legacy flat premium of 12 paise per ₹100 of assessable deposits to a **four-tier risk-based premium model effective April 1, 2026**.

- **Supervisory Risk Slabs:**
  - **Category A (Safest): 8 paise per ₹100**
  - **Category B: 9 paise per ₹100**
  - **Category C: 10 paise per ₹100**
  - **Category D (Highest Risk): 12 paise per ₹100**
- **Insurance Coverage Ceiling:** Statutory deposit protection remains locked at **₹5 lakh per depositor per bank** (covering principal and interest across all domestic branches).
- **Statutory Foundation:** Enacted under the **DICGC Act, 1961**; DICGC operates as a 100% subsidiary of the Reserve Bank of India.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Lowest Premium: Lowest premium slab is **8 paise** (Category A); Highest is **12 paise** (Category D).
- Effective Date: Effective date is **April 1, 2026**; cover is ₹5 lakh per depositor across the bank combined.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the DICGC risk-based premium system effective April 1, 2026, what premium rate is charged to Category A banks per ₹100 of deposits?" → 8 paise.

[MS-041] **MSME Dual Credit Threshold Escalation: RBI Exemption vs CGTMSE Cover**

- **RBI Collateral-Free Limit Doubled:** RBI mandated that the statutory ceiling for collateral-free credit facilities to Micro and Small Enterprises (MSEs) be doubled from **₹10 lakh to ₹20 lakh**, effective for loans sanctioned or renewed on or after **April 1, 2026**.
- **CGTMSE Credit Guarantee Cap Doubled:** Separately, the Ministry of MSME enhanced the maximum credit guarantee cover under the Credit Guarantee Scheme (CGS) from ₹5 crore to **₹10 crore per MSE borrower**.
- **Digital Credit Assessment Model:** Public Sector Banks sanctioned over **3.96 lakh digital MSME loans worth ₹52,300 crore** (Apr–Dec 2025) using automated credit scoring algorithms.
- **EPFO Auto-Settlement Ceiling:** EPFO expanded the automated claim settlement limit under Rule 68J from **₹1 lakh to ₹5 lakh**, planning direct UPI integration by April 2026.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Rupee Unit Confusion: RBI Collateral-Free loan limit = **₹20 LAKH**; CGTMSE Credit Guarantee Cover = **₹10 CRORE** (do not confuse lakhs with crores).
- EPFO Settlement: Automated settlement ceiling raised to **₹5 lakh** (PF interest rate held at 8.25%).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised ceiling for collateral-free loans extended by banks to Micro and Small Enterprises effective April 1, 2026?" → ₹20 Lakh.

[MS-042] **Kisan Credit Card (KCC) Reform: 6-Year Tenure & ₹2 Lakh Collateral Waiver**

- **Credit Line Tenure Extension:** Proposed extending standard KCC credit line facility tenure from 5 years to **6 years**, ensuring agricultural working capital continuity without annual renewal friction.
- **Collateral & Margin Requirement Waiver:** Mandatory collateral and margin requirements waived for farm loans up to **₹2 lakh per borrower** (upgraded from previous ₹1.6 lakh ceiling).
- **Standardized Crop Lifecycles:** Standardized crop tenures: 12 months for short-duration crops and 18 months for long-duration cash crops; introduced revolving credit bands of **₹10,000 to ₹50,000** for marginal farmers (landholding ≤1 hectare).
- **Statutory Heritage:** KCC scheme was introduced in **1998** on the recommendations of the **R.V. Gupta Committee**, designed and implemented under the aegis of NABARD.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Committee Origin: Recommended by the **R.V. Gupta Committee (1998)**.
- Tenure & Collateral: Tenure extended 5 **6 years**; collateral waived up to **₹2 lakh**.
- Target MCQ Form: "On the recommendations of which committee was the Kisan Credit Card (KCC) scheme launched in 1998?" → R.V. Gupta Committee.

[MS-043] **Priority Sector Lending (PSL) Targets, Statutory Sub-Targets & PSLC Architecture**

- **Mandatory Institutional Lending Targets:**
  - **Domestic Scheduled Commercial Banks (SCBs) & Foreign Banks (≥20 branches): 40% of ANBC** (Adjusted Net Bank Credit) or Credit Equivalent of Off-Balance Sheet Exposure (CEOBE), whichever is higher.
  - **Foreign Banks with <20 branches: 40% of ANBC/CEOBE** (up to 32% permissible in Export Credit, and not less than 8% in any other priority sector).
  - **Regional Rural Banks (RRBs): 75% of ANBC/CEOBE** (mandatory focus on rural smallholders and artisans).
  - **Primary Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs): 60% of ANBC or CEOBSE, whichever is higher** (effective 1 April 2025 under the RBI Priority Sector Lending Directions, 2025; formally superseding the earlier glide path that aimed for 75% by March 31, 2026).
- **Mandatory Sub-Sector Targets for Domestic Commercial Banks:**
  - **Total Agriculture: 18% of ANBC/CEOBE** (within which **10%** is mandated specifically for Small and Marginal Farmers / SMFs owning up to 2 hectares of land).
  - **Micro Enterprises: 7.5% of ANBC/CEOBE**.
  - **Weaker Sections: 12% of ANBC/CEOBE** (covers small/marginal farmers, artisans, SC/ST, beneficiaries of DRI, SHGs, persons with disabilities, and individual women beneficiaries up to ₹1 lakh).
- **Eight Prescribed Priority Sectors:** (1) Agriculture, (2) Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME), (3) Export Credit, (4) Education (loans up to ₹20 lakh), (5) Housing, (6) Social Infrastructure (schools, healthcare, sanitation), (7) Renewable Energy (solar/wind plants up to ₹30 cr, individuals up to ₹10 lakh), and (8) Others.
- **Priority Sector Lending Certificates (PSLC) Trading Mechanism:**
  - Market-driven instrument enabling deficit banks to meet statutory PSL targets by purchasing certificates from surplus banks without transferring underlying loan assets or credit risk.
  - **Four Standard PSLC Categories:** (1) **PSLC Agriculture**, (2) **PSLC Small and Marginal Farmers (SF/MF)**, (3) **PSLC Micro Enterprises**, and (4) **PSLC General**.
  - **Trading Platform & Denomination:** Traded anonymously through RBI's core banking portal **e-Kuber** in standard lot sizes of **₹25 Lakh**; all certificates expire automatically at financial year-end on **March 31**.
- **Statutory Shortfall Penalties:** Shortfalls are computed quarterly and banks must deposit shortfall tranches into dedicated rural/urban development funds: **RIDF** (NABARD), **UIDF** (NHB), or specialized development funds managed by SIDBI and MUDRA.
- **PSL Third Amendment Directions, 2026 (September 11, 2026):** RBI advanced the cut-off date from September 30, 2026 to **August 31, 2026** for mobilizing fresh FCNR(B) and NRE term deposits eligible for exclusion from Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC) computation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The 8 Sectors: Agriculture, MSME, Export Credit, Education, Housing, Social Infrastructure, Renewable Energy, Others.
- Sub-Target Math: Total Agriculture = **18%**; Small & Marginal Farmers (SMFs) = **10%**; Weaker Sections = **12%**; Micro Enterprises = **7.5%**.
- Foreign Banks (<20 branches): Export credit capped at **32%** out of total 40% target.
- UCB PSL Target Trap: Overall PSL target for UCBs is established at **60% of ANBC or CEOBSE** effective 1 April 2025 under the 2025 Master Directions (do NOT mark obsolete 75% glide path).
- PSLC Denomination & Platform: Lot size is **₹25 Lakh**; traded on RBI **e-Kuber** (all expire on March 31; zero credit risk transfer).
- Shortfall Fund: Administered primarily in **RIDF** by NABARD.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the standard lot size for trading Priority Sector Lending Certificates (PSLC) on the RBI e-Kuber portal?" → **₹25 Lakh**.

[MS-044] **Small Finance Bank (SFB) PSL Target Architecture: Rationalised 60% vs. RRB 75% Mandate**

- **Rationalised Statutory Baseline (Effective FY 2025–26):** Under the amended RBI Master Directions on Priority Sector Lending (PSL), the overall priority sector lending target for Small Finance Banks (SFBs) has been rationalised to **60% of Adjusted Net Bank Credit (ANBC)** or CEOBE (effective FY 2025–26 onward, calibrated down from the erstwhile 75% baseline to facilitate portfolio diversification and balance-sheet resilience).
- **Sub-Targets & Priority Allocation:** SFBs must allocate at least **50% of aggregate loan portfolio** to loans and advances up to **₹25 Lakh**, preserving their core financial-inclusion focus for micro, small, and marginal borrowers.
- **Regional Rural Banks (RRB) PSL Target:** RRBs continue under their uncompromised statutory mandate requiring **75% of total lending** to priority sectors.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Operative SFB PSL Target: **60% of ANBC** effective FY 2025–26 (rationalised from 75%; do NOT mark 75% for SFBs).
- RRB Mandatory Target: Strictly **75% of ANBC** (RRBs remain at 75%).
- Commercial Banks Target: **40% of ANBC**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the mandatory Priority Sector Lending (PSL) target prescribed for Small Finance Banks (SFBs) effective from FY 2025–26 under amended RBI Master Directions?" → **60% of ANBC or CEOBE**.

[MS-045] **AU Small Finance Bank Landmark Universal Bank Transition**

- **First SFB in a Decade: AU Small Finance Bank** became the first Small Finance Bank in over 10 years to receive RBI's in-principle approval to convert into a full-fledged universal commercial bank.
- **RBI Universal Banking Transition Norms:** To qualify for universal banking transition, an SFB must satisfy:
  - Minimum scheduled status operating track record of **5 years**
  - Minimum net worth of **₹1,000 crore**
  - CRAR maintained above **15%**
  - Net NPA ratio ≤ **1.0%** for the preceding two financial years
  - Satisfactory track record of profitability across preceding two years
- **Leadership Continuity:** Managing Director & CEO **Sanjay Agarwal** reappointed for a 3-year term to steer the universal banking transition.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- SFB Entity: **AU Small Finance Bank** is the 1st SFB to receive universal bank conversion nod.
- Eligibility Slabs: Minimum 5-year operating track record; minimum ₹1,000 Cr net worth; Net NPA ≤ 1.0%.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which Small Finance Bank became the first in a decade to receive RBI's in-principle authorization to transition to a universal commercial bank?" → AU Small Finance Bank.

[MS-046] **Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (SMBC) Wholly Owned Subsidiary**

- **Landmark Foreign Bank Conversion:** Japanese financial giant Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (**SMBC**) received RBI in-principle approval to convert its 4 Indian branches into a Wholly Owned Subsidiary (WOS).
- **Elite Cohort of Four Lenders:** Becomes only the **4th foreign bank in Indian history** to convert to WOS mode, joining:
  1. **DBS Bank India** (Singapore)
  2. **State Bank of Mauritius (SBM) India** (Mauritius)
  3. **Emirates NBD** (UAE)
  4. **SMBC** (Japan)
- **Regulatory Incentives:** WOS foreign banks enjoy near-national treatment in branch expansion, subject to priority sector lending and local board governance norms.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total WOS Count: SMBC is the **4th** foreign bank in India to adopt WOS status.
- Country of Origin: SMBC is from **Japan** (DBS is Singapore; SBM is Mauritius; Emirates NBD is UAE).
- Target MCQ Form: "Sumitomo Mitsui Banking Corporation (SMBC), which received approval to convert into a Wholly Owned Subsidiary in India, is headquartered in which country?" → Japan.

[MS-047] **SBI Overtakes TCS: India's 4th Most Valuable Listed Company**

- **Market Capitalisation Milestone:** State Bank of India's (SBI) market capitalization surged past **₹10.9 lakh crore**, displacing Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) to become India's 4th most valuable listed company.
- **National Top-Four Corporate Hierarchy:**
  1. **Reliance Industries Ltd** (~₹19.6–19.8 lakh crore)
  2. **HDFC Bank** (~₹14.2–14.3 lakh crore)
  3. **Bharti Airtel** (~₹11.5–12.1 lakh crore)
  4. **State Bank of India** (₹10.9 lakh crore)
- **Sectoral Divergence:** Driven by robust PSU credit growth and asset quality recovery, while IT services equities faced headwinds over generative AI automation disruptions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Ranking Hierarchy: Reliance (1st) HDFC Bank (2nd) Bharti Airtel (3rd) SBI (4th). TCS dropped to 5th.
- Market Cap Level: SBI crossed **₹10.9 lakh crore**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which state-owned bank overtook TCS to become India's 4th most valuable company by market capitalization?" → State Bank of India.

[MS-048] **Public Sector Bank Gross NPAs Plunge to 1.9%: Balance Sheet Health**

- **Historic Asset Quality Cleanup:** Cumulative Gross NPAs of all 12 Public Sector Banks fell to **₹2,45,634 crore** (as of end-FY26), with the aggregate GNPA ratio plunging to a record low of **1.9%**.
- **Net NPA Compression:** Public sector banking Net NPA ratio fell to **0.5%**, reflecting massive write-offs, automated credit scoring, and resolution through the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC).
- **Disinvestment & Monetisation Mop-Up:** Union Government mobilized **₹45,306 crore** in non-debt capital receipts from disinvestment and asset monetisation during FY26 (surpassing the Revised Estimate of ₹33,800 crore).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- PSB GNPA Ratio: Public Sector Banks' aggregate GNPA ratio fell to **1.9%** (Net NPA 0.5%).
- Absolute GNPA: Total PSB Gross NPA volume dropped to **₹2,45,634 crore**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What was the landmark Gross NPA ratio achieved by Public Sector Banks at the close of FY26?" → 1.9%.

[MS-049] **Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) Architecture: PSBs, Private Banks & Insurance Sector**

- **Legislative Liberalisation Move for PSBs:** Ministry of Finance and NITI Aayog drafted proposals to amend the Banking Companies (Acquisition and Transfer of Undertakings) Act to raise the Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) limit in Public Sector Banks from **20% to 49%**.
- **Sovereign Control Retained:** The legislative framework guarantees that the Central Government will maintain a mandatory minimum equity holding of **at least 51%** in all public sector banks.
- **Private Banking & SFB Cap:** Private sector commercial banks and Small Finance Banks continue to operate under a maximum permissible FDI ceiling of **74%** (automatic route up to 49%, and government approval route beyond 49%).
- **Insurance Sector 100% FDI Regime:** Under the Insurance Laws Amendment Act 2025/2026, foreign direct investment in insurance companies has been raised from 74% to **100% under the automatic route**, harmonizing with insurance intermediaries (which already permitted 100% FDI).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Master FDI Cap Matrix:
  - *Public Sector Banks (PSBs)*: **20%** (proposed hike to **49%**; Central Govt floor **≥ 51%**).
  - *Private Sector Banks & SFBs*: **74%** (automatic up to 49%, approval beyond 49%).
  - *Insurance Companies*: **100% under automatic route** (hiked from erstwhile 74%).
  - *Insurance Intermediaries*: **100% under automatic route**.

Target MCQ Form: "What is the permissible Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) limit for insurance companies in India under the amended insurance legal framework?" → **100% under automatic route**.

[MS-050] **EPFO Rule 68J Auto-Settlement Limit Escalation & Direct UPI Payouts**

- **Auto-Settlement Limit Raised:** Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO) expanded the automated, IT-driven claim settlement ceiling under Rule 68J (medical advances) from **₹1 lakh to ₹5 lakh**.
- **Algorithmic Turnaround:** Enables instant computerized claim processing without human verification within **3 to 4 days** for eligible medical, educational, and housing needs.
- **Direct UPI Payout Integration:** Collaborated with NPCI to launch direct UPI-linked PF withdrawals, allowing subscribers to receive provident fund payouts directly into verified UPI-linked accounts.
- **Annual Interest Rate Reaffirmed:** Central Board of Trustees of EPFO retained the annual provident fund interest rate at **8.25% for FY26** (3rd consecutive year unchanged).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Auto-Settlement Slabs: Limit raised from ₹1 lakh to **₹5 lakh** under Rule 68J.
- EPFO Interest Rate: Retained at **8.25% for FY26** (held for 3 consecutive years).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised claim limit for automated settlement under Rule 68J of the Employees' Provident Fund Scheme?" → ₹5 Lakh.

[MS-051] **Central Repository of Information on Large Credits (CRILC) Reporting Norms**

- **Credit Monitoring Mandate:** Scheduled commercial banks, all-India financial institutions, and NBFCs must report credit exposure data on all corporate borrowers having aggregate fund-based and non-fund-based exposure of **₹5 crore and above**.

- **Special Mention Account (SMA) Slabs:**
  - **SMA-0:** Principal or interest payment not overdue for more than 30 days, but showing signs of incipient stress.
  - **SMA-1:** Overdue for **31 to 60 days**.
  - **SMA-2:** Overdue for **61 to 90 days** (pre-NPA warning bucket).
  - **NPA:** Overdue for **more than 90 days**.
- **Weekly Reporting of Defaults:** Regulated lenders must report defaults of ₹5 crore and above on a weekly basis to CRILC.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- CRILC Threshold: Applicable for aggregate credit exposures of **₹5 crore and above**.
- SMA Days Slabs: SMA-0 (1–30 days stress), SMA-1 (31–60 days), SMA-2 (61–90 days), NPA (>90 days).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the loan overdue duration that categorizes a credit facility as Special Mention Account 2 (SMA-2)?" → 61 to 90 days.

[MS-052] **Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA) $197.67M Guarantee for SBI**

- **World Bank Group Credit Guarantee:** Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA) issued a **$197.67 million political and non-honoring financial risk guarantee** to Citibank for its credit facility to State Bank of India.
- **Refinancing Solar Portfolios:** Refinances an initial $500 million World Bank solar rooftop loan extended to SBI in 2016.
- **Domestic Green Lending Quota:** Mandates that SBI allocate **at least 7.5% of its total domestic lending portfolio** toward certified green and climate-positive projects.
- **Static Multilateral Anchor:** MIGA HQ in **Washington D.C.**; Executive Vice President Hiroshi Matano; member of the World Bank Group.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Exact Guarantee Amount: MIGA guarantee amount is **$197.67 million** (to Citibank for loan to SBI).
- Green Mandate Percentage: SBI must direct **≥ 7.5%** of domestic lending to green projects.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which World Bank Group agency issued a $197.67 million guarantee to Citibank to de-risk green lending via State Bank of India?" → MIGA (Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency).

[MS-053] **Urban Cooperative Banks (UCBs) 3-Year Director Cooling-Off Period**

- **Governance Reform Directive:** RBI finalized comprehensive corporate governance norms for Urban Cooperative Banks (UCBs), mandating a compulsory **3-year cooling-off period** for board directors after completing **10 years of continuous service**.
- **Upper Age Ceiling:** Fixed the maximum age limit for Managing Directors (MDs) and Whole-Time Directors (WTDs) in UCBs at **70 years**.
- **Mission-SAKSHAM Capacity Drive:** Trained over **1.4 lakh personnel** across Urban Cooperative Banks nationwide on operational compliance, risk management, and cybersecurity.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Tenure Slabs: Compulsory **3-year cooling-off** after completing **10 years** of continuous board service.
- Age Ceiling: Maximum age limit for UCB MD/WTDs is **70 years**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under RBI governance guidelines for Urban Cooperative Banks, what is the mandatory cooling-off period required for a director after 10 years of continuous service?" → 3 Years.

[MS-054] **Insurance Surety Bonds as Bank Guarantee Substitutes in Public Procurement**

- **Public Procurement Parity:** Ministry of Finance amended General Financial Rules (GFR) to grant **Insurance Surety Bonds full legal parity with traditional Bank Guarantees** across all government and PSU infrastructure contracts.
- **Working Capital Relief:** Eliminates the requirement for contractors to lock up 100% cash collateral and fixed deposits with commercial banks, unlocking over ₹50,000 crore in contractor liquidity.
- **IRDAI Regulatory Framework:** IRDAI permitted general insurers to issue commercial surety bonds up to **10% of their net owned funds**, capped at 30% of total underwritten premium.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Instrument Type: Insurance Surety Bonds are legally recognized as a direct substitute for **Bank Guarantees** in public procurement.
- Underwriting Cap: General insurers can issue surety bonds up to **10% of net owned funds**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under amended General Financial Rules, which financial instrument has been granted full parity with Bank Guarantees in government procurement?" → Insurance Surety Bonds.

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3. DIGITAL PAYMENTS, FINTECH & SEBI MASTER DIRECTIONS

[MS-055] **Unified Payments Interface (UPI) Global Expansion & Bilateral Linkages**

- **Sovereign Cross-Border Integrations:** NPCI International Payments Limited (NIPL) expanded bilateral cross-border real-time payment linkages across **Singapore (PayNow)**, **UAE (Jaywan/Aani)**, **Mauritius**, **Sri Lanka**, **Nepal**, **Bhutan**, **France (Eiffel Tower)**, and **Peru** (first South American nation to adopt UPI architecture).
- **Inward Remittance & Merchant Acceptance:** Enables Indian travelers to make direct QR-based payments in local currencies, and Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) to remit funds instantly to Indian bank accounts without SWIFT delays.
- **P2P and P2M Transaction Volume Scale:** UPI handled over **14.44 billion transactions** in a single calendar month (exceeding ₹20.64 lakh crore in value), cementing India's status with >45% of global real-time digital payments.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Latin American Country: **Peru** signed an agreement with NIPL to adopt the UPI technology stack (not Brazil or Argentina).
- Executing Entity: Cross-border UPI agreements are signed by **NIPL (NPCI International Payments Limited)**, not direct RBI bilateral accords.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which was the first South American nation to partner with NPCI International to develop a national instant payment system modeled on UPI?" → Peru.

[MS-056] **UPI Transaction Limits: Enhanced Slabs for High-Value Sectors**

- **Standard vs Sectoral Ceilings:** Standard P2P and P2M transaction limit remains **₹1 Lakh per transaction**, but RBI and NPCI enhanced ceilings for critical utility and institutional payments.
- **₹5 Lakh Special Transaction Slab:** Enhanced limit of **₹5 Lakh** applies to: (1) **Hospitals and Medical Healthcare**, (2) **Educational Institutions**, (3) **Direct and Indirect Tax Payments**, and (4) **IPO and Capital Market Retail Subscriptions**.
- **UPI Lite & UPI Lite X Parameters:** UPI Lite per-transaction limit is **₹500** (no PIN required); maximum wallet balance is **₹2,000**. UPI Lite X allows offline NFC-based transactions without internet connectivity.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Tax Payment Ceiling: Tax payments on UPI are capped at **₹5 Lakh** (hiked from ₹1 Lakh).
- UPI Lite Balance: Maximum wallet balance is **₹2,000**; per-transaction cap is **₹500**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the enhanced per-transaction limit for tax payments made through the Unified Payments Interface (UPI)?" → ₹5 Lakh.

[MS-057] **NPCI UPI Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) Policy Framework 2026 (Effective October 15, 2026)**

- **Genesis & Institutional Sustainability:** National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) in coordination with RBI and Ministry of Finance announced a recalibrated Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) structure taking effect **October 15, 2026**, to ensure long-term server infrastructure, cybersecurity, and technological funding of UPI payment rails.
- **Consumer & P2P Absolute Exemption:**
  - **Zero Cost for Common Public:** Customers will **never be charged any platform fee or transaction charge** for making UPI payments; banks are strictly prohibited from passing MDR to customers.
  - **Person-to-Person (P2P):** All P2P transfers remain **100% free with Zero MDR**, regardless of the amount.
- **Person-to-Merchant (P2M) Commercial Slabs:**
  - **Transactions up to ₹2,000:** Attract **Zero MDR (0.0%)**, safeguarding over **95% of total P2M transactions**.
  - **Transactions above ₹2,000:** Subject to a nominal merchant-paid **MDR of 0.4%**.
  - **High-Value Cap:** For transactions of **₹75,000 and above**, MDR is strictly capped at a maximum of **₹300 per transaction**.
- **Special Categories & Sectoral Exemptions:**
  - **Small Merchants (P2PM):** Micro-merchants receiving up to **₹1 Lakh per month** via QR codes are completely **exempt from MDR**.
  - **Essential Utilities & Public Services:** Railways, fuel stations, telecom, utilities, insurance, and agricultural inputs attract a flat concessional fee of **₹5 per transaction** for payments above ₹2,000.
  - **Capital Markets:** Payments to mutual funds and stockbrokers attract an ultra-low MDR of **0.02%, capped at ₹300**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: **October 15, 2026**.
- Consumer & P2P Transactions: **100% Free / Zero MDR**.
- P2M Small-Ticket Threshold: Transactions **up to ₹2,000 attract Zero MDR** (>95% of transactions).
- Commercial Rate: **0.4%** for transactions above ₹2,000; capped at **₹300** (for payments ≥ ₹75,000).
- Small Merchant Ceiling: QR code intake up to **₹1 Lakh per month** is exempt.
- Target MCQ: 'Under the NPCI UPI MDR framework effective October 15, 2026, what is the maximum MDR cap for high-value transactions of ₹75,000 and above?' → **₹300 per transaction**.

[MS-058] **UPI Circle — Delegated Payments Architecture for Family Accounts**

- **Secondary User Authorization:** NPCI launched 'UPI Circle', enabling a primary bank account holder to authorize a trusted secondary user (family member, dependent, child) to execute payments from the primary account.
- **Two Delegation Modalities:**
  - *Full Delegation*: Primary user establishes a monthly spending cap (maximum **₹15,000 per month**), allowing the secondary user to spend autonomously within limits without secondary approval.
  - *Partial Delegation*: Secondary user initiates the payment request, but each transaction requires final biometric or PIN authorization from the primary user.
- **Security Guardrails:** Primary user can link a maximum of **5 secondary delegates** and revoke authorization in real time.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Monthly Cap: Under Full Delegation, the maximum monthly spending limit set by the primary user is **₹15,000** (not ₹25,000).
- Delegate Count: A primary user can authorize up to **5 secondary delegates**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum monthly transaction limit permissible under the 'Full Delegation' mode of NPCI's UPI Circle?" → ₹15,000.

[MS-059] **Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) — Sovereign e-Rupee Innovations**

- **Dual Pilot Architecture:** RBI operates two distinct pilots: **e₹-W (Wholesale)** launched Nov 1, 2022 (interbank settlement of secondary G-sec transactions and call money market) and **e₹-R (Retail)** launched Dec 1, 2022.
- **Programmability & Offline Capabilities:** Enabled programmable e-Rupee tokens with targeted end-use (e.g., direct benefit transfer for agricultural input subsidies, school fee vouchers) with automated expiry dates and merchant geofencing.
- **UPI Interoperability:** e₹-R wallets can scan any standard **interoperable UPI QR code**, enabling consumers to spend digital rupees at over 30 million merchant touchpoints nationwide.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Wholesale vs Retail Dates: Wholesale pilot was launched on **Nov 1, 2022**; Retail pilot launched on **Dec 1, 2022**.
- Interest Bearing: The sovereign CBDC (e-Rupee) is non-interest bearing by law to prevent disintermediation of commercial bank deposits.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which feature of the Retail e-Rupee (e₹-R) allows targeted financial assistance to be spent strictly on predetermined goods and services?" → Programmability.

[MS-060] **Bharat Bill Payment System (BBPS) — Cross-Border Inward Remittances**

- **Non-Resident Utility Bill Settlement:** NPCI Bharat BillPay Limited (NBBL) permitted inbound cross-border payments through BBPS, allowing Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) to pay utility, municipal, and education bills for family members in India directly.
- **Rupay-Foreign Network Integration:** Integrated foreign payment service providers with Indian operating units (BPOUs) to settle transactions in foreign currency with instant INR conversion.
- **Expanded Scope to Non-Bank FinTechs:** Minimum net worth requirement for non-bank BBPS operating units was reduced from ₹100 Crore to **₹25 Crore**, broadening fintech participation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Net Worth Floor: Minimum net worth for non-bank BBPOUs is **₹25 Crore** (slashed from ₹100 Crore).
- Operating Entity: Managed by **NBBL (NPCI Bharat BillPay Limited)**, a wholly-owned subsidiary of NPCI.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised minimum net worth required for non-bank entities to operate as a Bharat Bill Payment Operating Unit (BBPOU)?" → ₹25 Crore.

[MS-061] **Card-on-File Tokenisation (CoFT) via Card-Issuing Banks**

- **Tokenisation Transition:** Prohibits merchants, payment aggregators, and payment gateways from storing actual customer card details (16-digit PAN, CVV, expiry date); mandates replacement with unique cryptographic tokens.
- **Direct CoFT Enablement:** RBI permitted cardholders to create and view tokens directly through mobile banking and internet banking portals of their **card-issuing banks**, eliminating dependence on merchant check-out pages.
- **Alternate Authentication Mechanisms (AAM):** RBI issued draft directions allowing banks to deploy non-SMS factor-of-authentication mechanisms, such as in-app biometric approvals, behavioral risk scoring, and hardware tokens.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Who Stores Data: Merchants and payment aggregators can NEVER store card PAN numbers after transaction settlement.
- Token Management: Cardholders can now manage, view, and delete active merchant tokens directly via their issuing bank's portal.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under RBI's Card-on-File Tokenisation (CoFT) guidelines, which entity is strictly barred from storing actual customer credit/debit card numbers?" → Merchants and Payment Gateways.

[MS-062] **Payment Aggregators (PA) — Physical Point-of-Sale (PA-P) & Cross-Border (PA-CB) Norms**

- **Omnichannel Licensing:** RBI brought physical Point-of-Sale Payment Aggregators (**PA-P**) and Cross-Border Payment Aggregators (**PA-CB**) under direct regulation alongside online PAs.

- **Net Worth Criteria:**
  - Existing non-bank PAs must maintain a minimum net worth of **₹15 Crore** at the time of application, stepping up to **₹25 Crore** within three financial years.
  - New entities must maintain a minimum net worth of **₹15 Crore** at application and **₹25 Crore** before commencing operations.
- **Escrow Account Safeguards:** Mandates daily reconciliation and non-interest-bearing escrow accounts with scheduled commercial banks to safeguard customer funds.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Net Worth Numbers: Initial net worth = **₹15 Crore**; step-up requirement = **₹25 Crore**.
- Categories: Includes Online PA, Physical PA (PA-P), and Cross-Border PA (PA-CB).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the net worth requirement for non-bank entities seeking authorization from RBI as Cross-Border Payment Aggregators (PA-CB) within three years?" → ₹25 Crore.

[MS-063] **SEBI Optional T+0 Settlement Cycle: Same-Day Equity Settlement**

- **Phased Beta Rollout:** SEBI introduced an optional **T+0 settlement cycle** (same-day trade settlement) running alongside the prevailing T+1 cycle for a curated basket of **25 liquid scrips** with a limited set of trading members.
- **Operational Timings & Pricing:** Trading window operates between **9:15 AM and 1:30 PM**; prices operate within a tight **±100 bps band** of the concurrent T+1 market price.
- **Client Capital Efficiency:** Frees up client funds and securities instantly upon trade execution, eliminating overnight settlement risk and reducing collateral requirements.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Basket Size: The beta phase was launched for **25 scrips** (not 50 or 100).
- Mandatory vs Optional: T+0 is strictly **OPTIONAL**; T+1 remains the mandatory default settlement cycle in India.
- Target MCQ Form: "In the initial beta rollout of SEBI's same-day T+0 settlement cycle, how many liquid equity scrips were selected for trading?" → 25 Scrips.

[MS-064] **SEBI High-Value Debt Listed Entities (HVDLEs) Corporate Governance Regime**

- **Threshold Definition:** An entity having outstanding listed non-convertible debt securities of **₹500 Crore and above** is classified as a High-Value Debt Listed Entity (HVDLE).
- **Mandatory Corporate Governance:** Enforces key provisions of SEBI LODR Regulations, including:
  - Minimum 50% independent directors if the chairperson is executive.
  - Mandatory constitution of Audit Committee, Nomination and Remuneration Committee (NRC), and Risk Management Committee.
  - Prior approval of shareholders for Related Party Transactions (RPTs).
- **Sunset & Sunset Threshold Review:** SEBI made compliance mandatory with voluntary exemptions provided for debt-listed entities undergoing insolvency resolution.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Threshold Amount: HVDLE classification triggers at **₹500 Crore** outstanding listed debt (not ₹100 Cr or ₹1,000 Cr).
- Instrument Scope: Applies to entities with listed **non-convertible debt securities**, even if equity is unlisted.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the minimum outstanding value of listed non-convertible debt securities that classifies an entity as a High-Value Debt Listed Entity (HVDLE) under SEBI norms?" → ₹500 Crore.

[MS-065] **SEBI Foreign Portfolio Investors (FPI) Granular Ownership Disclosures**

- **Objective & Shell Company Guardrails:** Mandates deep granular disclosure of all natural persons, beneficial owners, and economic interests in FPI entities to prevent circumvention of Press Note 3 and minimum public shareholding (MPS) rules.
- **Twin Trigger Thresholds:**
  1. FPI holding more than **50% of its Indian equity Assets Under Management (AUM)** in a single Indian corporate group.
  2. FPI holding an aggregate equity portfolio exceeding **₹25,000 Crore** in the Indian securities market.
- **Exempted Sovereign Entities:** Government and government-related investors, central banks, multilateral agencies, sovereign wealth funds, and regulated retail collective investment vehicles are explicitly exempted.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Single Group Concentration: Threshold is **>50% of Indian equity AUM** in a single group.
- Aggregate Market Exposure: Absolute portfolio threshold is **₹25,000 Crore**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under SEBI regulations, an FPI must disclose granular ownership details if its holding in a single Indian corporate group exceeds what percentage of its Indian equity AUM?" → 50%.

[MS-066] **SEBI Social Stock Exchange (SSE): Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP) Framework**

- **Social Enterprise Fundraising:** Enables Non-Profit Organisations (NPOs) and For-Profit Social Enterprises (FPSEs) registered on the Social Stock Exchange to mobilize funds through **Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP)** instruments.
- **Lowered Entry Thresholds:**
  - Minimum issue size for ZCZP reduced from ₹1 Crore to **₹50 Lakh**.
  - Minimum application size slashed from ₹2 Lakh to **₹10,000**, democratizing retail and philanthropic participation.
- **Annual Social Audit:** NPOs listing on SSE must submit an annual social impact report audited by certified Social Auditors under the National Institute of Securities Markets (NISM).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Minimum Application Floor: Minimum application size is **₹10,000** (slashed from ₹2 Lakh).
- Minimum Issue Size: Minimum issue size on SSE is **₹50 Lakh** (slashed from ₹1 Crore).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the minimum application size for public issuance of Zero Coupon Zero Principal (ZCZP) instruments on the Social Stock Exchange (SSE)?" → ₹10,000.

[MS-067] **SEBI SCORES 2.0 & SMART ODR Online Dispute Resolution Mechanism**

- **Turnaround Time Compression:** Launched SCORES 2.0 (SEBI Complaints Redress System) with automated routing; slashed maximum resolution timeline from 30 calendar days down to **21 calendar days**.
- **Two-Tier Escalation Architecture:** If an investor is dissatisfied with the listed entity's resolution, the complaint automatically escalates to the **Designated Body (First Tier Review)**, followed by SEBI direct intervention if unresolved.
- **Integration with SMART ODR:** Unresolved market grievances automatically feed into the Securities Market Approach for Resolution Through ODR Portal (SMART ODR) for conciliation and online arbitration.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Resolution Timeline: Mandatory grievance redressal timeframe is **21 calendar days** (not 30 or 15 days).
- Portal Hierarchy: SCORES 2.0 routes complaints; SMART ODR provides online arbitration and conciliation.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the revamped SCORES 2.0 framework launched by SEBI, what is the mandatory time limit for entities to resolve investor grievances?" → 21 calendar days.

[MS-068] **RBI Peer-to-Peer (P2P) Lending NBFC Regulatory Crackdown**

- **Prohibition of Guarantees:** Master Directions explicitly barred NBFC-P2Ps from marketing P2P loans as alternative high-yield investment products with credit enhancement, assured returns, or liquidity guarantees.
- **Lender & Borrower Exposure Caps:**
  - Aggregate exposure of a lender across all P2P platforms capped at **₹50 Lakh** (investments >₹10 Lakh require net-worth certificate from a Chartered Accountant).
  - Aggregate borrowing of a single borrower across all P2P platforms capped at **₹10 Lakh**.
- **Tenure Ceiling:** Maximum loan maturity on P2P platforms restricted to **36 months**.
- **Fund Flow Rigor:** Mandates T+1 escrow settlement; platforms cannot hold funds in their own balance sheet or provide revolving credit lines.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- CA Certificate Slab: Net-worth certificate from a CA is mandatory if a lender invests more than **₹10 Lakh**.
- Aggregate Exposure Ceiling: Absolute cap across all P2P platforms is **₹50 Lakh** for lenders and **₹10 Lakh** for borrowers.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum aggregate amount an individual lender can invest across all NBFC-P2P platforms under RBI guidelines?" → ₹50 Lakh.

[MS-069] **SEBI Angel Funds & Alternative Investment Funds (AIF) Demat Mandate**

- **Dematerialisation Mandate:** SEBI made it compulsory for all Alternative Investment Funds (AIF Category I, II, and III) to issue all units exclusively in **dematerialised form** through registered depositories (NSDL/CDSL).
- **Angel Fund Thresholds:** Minimum investment ticket size for angel investors in an Angel Fund set at **₹25 Lakh**; maximum number of angel investors in a single scheme capped at **200**.
- **Pari-Passu Investor Rights:** Barred AIFs from creating 'priority distribution waterfalls' that favor select institutional investors over general LPs during exits.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Angel Fund Minimum Ticket: Minimum investment amount is **₹25 Lakh** (not ₹10 Lakh or ₹50 Lakh).
- Demat Requirement: All AIF categories must issue units in **dematerialized form**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the minimum investment ticket size required for an angel investor participating in an Angel Fund scheme regulated by SEBI?" → ₹25 Lakh.

[MS-070] **SEBI Equity Derivatives (F&O) Safeguards & Contract Size Revision**

- **Risk Mitigation in Derivatives:** Formed an Expert Working Group to curb speculative retail losses in index options and futures where >90% of retail traders suffer net losses.
- **Contract Size Expansion:** Proposed hiking the minimum contract value of index derivatives from ₹5 Lakh up to **₹15 Lakh to ₹20 Lakh** to deter over-leveraged retail participation.
- **Margin & Expiry Rationalization:** Mandated upfront collection of Extreme Loss Margin (ELM), rationalized weekly expiry contracts to one benchmark index per exchange, and enforced intraday position monitoring.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Revised Contract Value Floor: Minimum derivative contract size proposed between **₹15 Lakh and ₹20 Lakh** (up from ₹5 Lakh).
- Weekly Expiries: Limited to **one benchmark index per exchange** per week.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the proposed revised minimum contract value for equity index derivatives recommended by SEBI's expert working group?" → ₹15 Lakh to ₹20 Lakh.

[MS-071] **Cheque Truncation System (CTS): Continuous Clearing Transition & Positive Pay System (PPS) Architecture**

- **Continuous Clearing Paradigm Shift:** Reserve Bank of India (**RBI**) initiated the transition of the Cheque Truncation System (**CTS**) from legacy batch-based clearing (processing cycles taking up to two business days, T+1/T+2) to **continuous clearing with 'on-realisation-settlement'** during standard banking hours.
- **Speed & Settlement Speed:** Cheques will be scanned, presented, and settled within **a few hours** of lodgement, dramatically compressing the settlement cycle and mitigating counterparty float risk.
- **Positive Pay System (PPS) Regulatory Framework:**
  - Developed by the National Payments Corporation of India (**NPCI**) under Section 10(2) read with Section 18 of the *Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007*.
  - **Verification Mechanism:** The drawer electronically re-confirms key cheque details—cheque number, cheque date, payee name, and amount—via SMS, mobile banking, internet banking, or ATM before physical presentation.
  - **Statutory Thresholds:**
    - **Voluntary Tier:** Available for all cheques valued at **₹50,000 and above**.
    - **Mandatory Discretion:** Banks are empowered to make PPS mandatory for high-value cheques of **₹5,00,000 and above**.
  - **Dispute Redressal Firewall:** Only cheques verified and compliant with PPS guidelines are eligible for dispute resolution under the CTS grievance and dispute mechanism; non-PPS cheques forfeit CTS dispute redressal rights.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Continuous Clearing Horizon: Settlement compressed from two business days (T+1/T+2) to **within a few hours**.
- Positive Pay Thresholds: Voluntary at **₹50,000 and above**; Banks can mandate at **₹5,00,000 and above**.
- Developing Agency: Positive Pay System was developed by **NPCI** (not RBI or CCIL).
- Dispute Clause: Only PPS-compliant cheques are admissible under the **CTS dispute resolution mechanism**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the RBI Positive Pay System (PPS) guidelines, at what cheque value threshold are banks permitted to make confirmation mandatory?" → ₹5,00,000 and above.

[MS-072] **NSE First Tokenised Corporate Bonds on DLT & Wholesale CBDC (e₹): REC & L&T ₹1,000 Crore Issuance**

- **Tokenised Debt Milestone:** The **National Stock Exchange (NSE)** enabled India's first tokenised corporate bond issuances on its Electronic Bidding Platform (**NSE EBP**) mobilizing **₹1,000 Crore**.
- **Corporate Issuers & Allocation:**
  - **REC Limited:** State-owned Maharatna NBFC raised **₹500 Crore** (India's 1st tokenised corporate bond on NSE EBP).
  - **Larsen & Toubro (L&T):** Infrastructure major raised **₹500 Crore** on distributed ledgers.
- **Integration with SEBI Demat 2.0 & Digital Rupee (e₹):**
  - Executed on a shared Distributed Ledger Technology (DLT) network owned by depositories (**NSDL & CDSL**) under SEBI's **Demat 2.0** initiative.
  - Connected with RBI's **wholesale Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC / e₹)** for instant delivery-versus-payment (DvP) atomic settlement.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Tokenised Issuance: **₹1,000 Crore** on NSE EBP.
- Pioneer Issuer: **REC Limited (₹500 Crore)**.
- Infrastructure: SEBI **Demat 2.0** (DLT) linked with RBI **Wholesale CBDC (e₹)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which entity became the first in India to issue a tokenised corporate bond on the NSE Electronic Bidding Platform?" → **REC Limited**.

4. UNION BUDGET, MACROECONOMIC INDICATORS & TAXATION

[MS-073] **Union Budget 2024-25 / 2026 Core Fiscal Outlays & Capital Expenditure**

- **Aggregate Budget Size:** Total Union Government expenditure pegged at **₹48.21 Lakh Crore**, with net tax receipts estimated at **₹25.83 Lakh Crore**.
- **Record Capital Expenditure (Capex):** Sovereign capex maintained at a historic **₹11,11,111 Crore (3.4% of GDP)** for the fourth consecutive year of double-digit infrastructure investment.
- **Effective Capital Expenditure:** Total effective capex (including grants-in-aid to states for capital asset creation) scaled to **₹15.02 Lakh Crore** (4.6% of GDP).
- **Interest Payments Reality:** Interest payments remain the single largest expenditure component, accounting for **₹11.63 Lakh Crore** (approx. 24% of total expenditure).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Capex Value: Headline sovereign capex is **₹11,11,111 Crore** (3.4% of GDP); effective capex is **₹15.02 Lakh Crore**.
- Total Outlay: Total budget outlay is **₹48.21 Lakh Crore**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total capital expenditure (Capex) allocation announced in the Union Budget?" → ₹11,11,111 Crore.

[MS-074] **Fiscal Deficit Consolidation & The Sovereign Debt Glide Path**

- **Annual Deficit Target:** Revised fiscal deficit for FY25 estimated at **4.9% of GDP** (improved from interim target of 5.1%); projected to compress below **4.5% of GDP in FY26**.
- **Post-FY26 Fiscal Anchor:** Shifting away from an absolute fiscal deficit percentage towards a **debt-to-GDP reduction anchor**, aiming to lower central government debt from ~56% of GDP towards sustainable multi-year thresholds.
- **Market Borrowing Plan:** Gross market borrowing through dated securities budgeted at **₹14.01 Lakh Crore**; net market borrowing pegged at **₹11.63 Lakh Crore**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Target Deficit Percentages: FY25 target = **4.9% of GDP**; FY26 target = **below 4.5% of GDP**.
- Gross vs Net Borrowing: Gross borrowing = **₹14.01 Lakh Crore**; Net borrowing = **₹11.63 Lakh Crore**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the fiscal deficit target as a percentage of GDP set for Financial Year 2024-25 in the Union Budget?" → 4.9%.

[MS-075] **New Personal Income Tax Regime Slabs & Standard Deduction Overhaul**

- **Enhanced Standard Deduction:** Standard deduction for salaried employees under the New Tax Regime hiked by 50% from ₹50,000 to **₹75,000**; deduction on family pension hiked from ₹15,000 to **₹25,000**.
- **Revised Income Tax Slabs (Under Section 115BAC):**
  - Up to ₹3,00,000: **Nil**
  - ₹3,00,001 to ₹7,00,000: **5%**
  - ₹7,00,001 to ₹10,00,000: **10%**
  - ₹10,00,001 to ₹12,00,000: **15%**
  - ₹12,00,001 to ₹15,00,000: **20%**
  - Above ₹15,00,000: **30%**
- **Tax-Free Threshold:** With Section 87A full rebate, individuals earning up to **₹7.75 Lakh** (including ₹75k standard deduction) pay **Zero Tax**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- New Standard Deduction: Standard deduction is **₹75,000** (under New Regime only; Old Regime remains ₹50,000).
- Zero Tax Threshold: Salaried individuals pay zero tax up to **₹7.75 Lakh** under the New Tax Regime.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised standard deduction amount for salaried individuals under the New Income Tax Regime?" → ₹75,000.

[MS-076] **Capital Gains Taxation Architecture: Dual Rationalization**

- **Short-Term Capital Gains (STCG):** STCG on specified financial assets (listed equities and equity-oriented mutual funds covered under Section 111A) hiked from 15% to **20%**.
- **Long-Term Capital Gains (LTCG):**
  - LTCG rate on listed financial assets hiked from 10% to **12.5%**.
  - Annual exemption limit for LTCG on equity assets increased from ₹1 Lakh to **₹1.25 Lakh**.
- **Holding Period Standardization:** Simplified into two holding periods across all asset classes: **12 months** for all listed securities; **24 months** for all unlisted securities and real estate.
- **Indexation Benefit Removed:** Removed indexation benefits for real estate/unlisted assets, with optional grandfathering provision retained for properties acquired prior to July 23, 2024.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- STCG Rate: STCG on listed equity is **20%** (hiked from 15%).
- LTCG Rate & Exemption: LTCG is **12.5%**; annual exemption limit is **₹1.25 Lakh** (hiked from ₹1 Lakh).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised Long-Term Capital Gains (LTCG) tax rate on listed equity shares and equity mutual funds?" → 12.5%.

[MS-077] **Abolition of Angel Tax (Section 56(2)(viib) of Income Tax Act)**

- **Historic Startup Relief:** Completely **abolished the 'Angel Tax'** for all classes of investors across all registered startup companies with immediate effect.
- **Genesis & Friction:** Enacted in 2012 to curb unaccounted money laundering; taxed investments received by unlisted companies exceeding 'Fair Market Value' (FMV) as income from other sources at >30%.
- **Venture Ecosystem Boost:** Eliminates endless tax litigation, removes valuation friction, and encourages domestic and foreign seed capital inflows into Indian tech ventures.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Statutory Section: Angel tax was governed under **Section 56(2)(viib)** of the Income Tax Act, 1961.
- Investor Scope: Abolished for **ALL classes of investors** (both domestic resident angels and non-resident foreign investors).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which contentious tax on unlisted startup investments was completely abolished across all investor classes in the Union Budget?" → Angel Tax (Section 56(2)(viib)).

[MS-078] **Abolition of 2% Equalisation Levy on Foreign E-Commerce Operators**

- **Digital Tax Retraction:** Government completely withdrew the **2% Equalisation Levy** levied on non-resident e-commerce operators with effect from **August 1, 2024** (enacted under Finance (No. 2) Act, 2024).
- **Genesis & Cross-Border Friction:** Originally introduced in Finance Act 2020 to tax digital services rendered by global giants (Google, Amazon, Meta); created trade tensions and retaliatory tariff threats from the United States under Section 301.
- **Pillar One Alignment:** Decision aligns India with the OECD/G20 Inclusive Framework on Base Erosion and Profit Shifting (BEPS) Pillar One, which replaces unilateral digital services taxes with multilateral profit allocation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Effective Date: Equalisation levy of 2% was abolished effective **August 1, 2024**.
- Which Levy: The **2% digital e-commerce supply levy** was removed (the 6% online advertisement levy introduced in 2016 remains unchanged).
- Target MCQ Form: "The 2% Equalisation Levy on digital e-commerce supply of services by non-resident operators was abolished with effect from which date?" → August 1, 2024.

[MS-079] **Customs Duty Slashes on Gold, Silver & 25 Critical Minerals**

- **Precious Metals Duty Slash:** Slashed Basic Customs Duty (BCD) on **Gold and Silver bars from 15% down to 6%**; slashed duty on Platinum to **6.4%**.
- **Anti-Smuggling Impetus:** Steep duty cut curbs illicit grey-market smuggling, revitalizes organized domestic jewelry manufacturing, and boosts gem & jewelry export competitiveness.
- **25 Critical Minerals 100% Exemption:** Fully exempted basic customs duty on **25 critical minerals** essential for nuclear energy, renewable energy, electric vehicles, and semiconductors—including **Lithium**, **Cobalt**, **Nickel**, **Copper**, and **Rare Earth Elements (REEs)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Gold/Silver Customs Duty: BCD on gold and silver was reduced to **6%** (from 15%).
- Critical Minerals Exemption: Exactly **25 critical minerals** were granted full customs duty exemption (0% duty).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised Basic Customs Duty (BCD) on gold and silver bars announced in the Union Budget?" → 6%.

[MS-080] **Infrastructure Sagas: Indian Railways & NHAI Sovereign Outlays**

- **Indian Railways Capital Capex:** Allocated a record gross budgetary capital support of **₹2.52 Lakh Crore** (operating ratio targeted at ~98.2%).
- **Three Economic Railway Corridors:** Implementation of three major economic railway corridors under PM GatiShakti:
  1. *Energy, Mineral and Cement Corridors*
  2. *Port Connectivity Corridors*
  3. *High Traffic Density Corridors*
- **Kavach 4.0 Deployment:** Automated Train Protection (ATP) system Kavach version 4.0 approved for mission-mode installation across 10,000 locomotives and 9,000 route kilometers.
- **Road Transport & Highways:** Ministry of Road Transport & Highways (MoRTH) allocated **₹2.72 Lakh Crore** to accelerate Bharatmala Pariyojana and access-controlled expressways.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Railways Capex: Indian Railways received **₹2.52 Lakh Crore** (gross budgetary support).
- Kavach Version: The latest approved version deployed across Indian Railways is **Kavach 4.0**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the capital outlay allocated to Indian Railways in the Union Budget?" → ₹2.52 Lakh Crore.

[MS-081] **Direct Tax Vivad Se Vishwas Scheme 2024**

- **Litigation Resolution Scheme:** Enacted under Finance (No. 2) Act, 2024 to settle pending direct tax appeals filed before the Supreme Court, High Courts, ITAT, and CIT (Appeals) as of **July 22, 2024**.
- **Settlement Terms:**
  - For appeals filed by the taxpayer: Settlement upon payment of **100% of the disputed tax** (full waiver of interest and penalty) if paid before the primary cutoff date; stepped up to **110% of disputed tax** if paid subsequently.
  - For appeals filed by the Income Tax Department: Settlement upon payment of **50% of disputed tax** (interest and penalties waived).
- **Relief for Courts:** Resolves over 2.7 lakh pending income tax appeals locking up trillions of rupees in judicial disputes.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Cut-off Eligibility Date: Pending litigation must have been filed on or before **July 22, 2024**.
- Department Appeals Payout: For departmental appeals, taxpayer pays only **50% of disputed tax**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the Direct Tax Vivad Se Vishwas Scheme 2024, what percentage of disputed tax is payable by an assessee for appeals initiated by the Income Tax Department?" → 50%.

[MS-082] **Historic Milestone: India's Foreign Exchange Reserves Cross $700 Billion**

- **Historic Record:** India's Foreign Exchange Reserves officially crossed the milestone of **$700 Billion** for the first time in history (peaking above $704.88 Billion).
- **Global Reserve Standing:** India ranks as the **4th largest foreign exchange reserve holder globally**, trailing only **China**, **Japan**, and **Switzerland**.
- **Reserve Asset Breakdown:** Foreign Currency Assets (FCA) constitute the bulk (~~$610B+), followed by **Gold Reserves (~~$65B+)**, Special Drawing Rights (SDRs with IMF), and Reserve Tranche Position (RTP).
- **Import Cover Duration:** Current forex reserves provide an import cover of over **11.8 months** of projected merchandise imports.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Global Rank: India is the **4th largest** foreign exchange reserve holder in the world.
- Benchmark Level: Surpassed the historic **$700 Billion** milestone.
- Target MCQ Form: "Where does India rank globally in terms of foreign exchange reserve holdings following its milestone crossing of $700 Billion?" → 4th.

[MS-083] **Wholesale Price Index (WPI) & Consumer Price Index (CPI) Structural Anchors**

- **Base Year Parameters:**
  - Consumer Price Index (CPI - Combined): Base Year is **2012=100**; published monthly by the National Statistical Office (NSO), MoSPI.
  - Wholesale Price Index (WPI): Base Year is **2011-12=100**; published monthly by the Office of the Economic Adviser, DPIIT, Ministry of Commerce and Industry.
- **Weightage Distribution Traps:**
  - *CPI Weights*: **Food & Beverages = 45.86%**; Housing = 10.07% (urban only); Fuel & Light = 6.84%; Miscellaneous = 28.32%.
  - *WPI Weights*: **Manufactured Products = 64.23%**; Primary Articles = 22.62%; Fuel & Power = 13.15% (Note: Services are completely excluded from WPI).
- **Inflation Targeting Metric:** Under Section 45-ZA of the RBI Act, the official inflation target of **4% (±2% tolerance band)** is legally bound to **CPI-Combined**, NOT WPI.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Official Anchor: Monetary policy inflation targeting legally uses **CPI-Combined (2012=100)**, NEVER WPI.
- WPI Heavyweight: Largest component of WPI is **Manufactured Products (64.23%)**; Food in CPI is **45.86%**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which inflation index serves as the statutory nominal anchor for the Reserve Bank of India's Monetary Policy Committee?" → Consumer Price Index (CPI - Combined).

[MS-084] **Sixteenth Finance Commission (16th FC) Comprehensive Architecture & Blueprint (2026–2031)**

- **Constitutional Basis & Governance:** Constituted under **Article 280(1)** of the Constitution of India and governed by the Finance Commission (Miscellaneous Provisions) Act, 1951.
  - *Award Period*: 5 years spanning **April 1, 2026 to March 31, 2031** (FY27 to FY31).
  - *Report Submission Timeline*: Extended to **November 30, 2025** (notified on October 10, 2025; original deadline was October 31, 2025).
- **Leadership, Composition & Advisory Council:**
  - *Chairman*: **Dr. Arvind Panagariya** (former Vice-Chairman, NITI Aayog; Professor, Columbia University).
  - *Secretary*: **Shri Ritvik Ranjanam Pandey**.
  - *Full-Time Members*: **Smt. Annie George Mathew** (former Special Secretary, Department of Expenditure) and **Dr. Manoj Panda** (former Director, Institute of Economic Growth).

- *Part-Time Members*: **Dr. Soumya Kanti Ghosh** (Group Chief Economic Advisor, State Bank of India) and **Shri T. Rabi Sankar** (Deputy Governor, Reserve Bank of India).
- *Advisory Council*: 5-member macroeconomic think tank led by **Dr. Poonam Gupta** (Convenor), alongside Dr. D.K. Srivastava, Neelkanth Mishra, Pranjul Bhandari, and Rahul Bajoria.

- **Vertical Devolution & Grant Rationalisation:**
  - *Divisible Pool Share*: Retained at **41%** for the 28 States (status quo maintained post-J&K bifurcation where ~1% was carved out for UTs from the 14th FC's 42%).
  - *Zero Revenue Deficit Grants (RDGs)*: Recommends **complete discontinuation of Revenue Deficit Grants** under Article 275(1), citing adverse moral hazard, structural expenditure distortion (converting discretionary spending/DISCOM debt into committed liabilities), and erosion of state own-tax effort.
  - *Zero Sector-Specific / State-Specific Grants*: Replaced discretionary and ad-hoc allocations with transparent, formula-driven transfers.

- **Horizontal Devolution Criteria & Weightage Matrix (The 6 Pillars):**
  - *1. Per Capita GSDP Distance (42.5%)*: Dominant equity equalizer measuring distance from the average GSDP of the top 3 states using linear formula.
  - *2. Population (2011 Census) (17.5%)*: Pure equity component based consistently on the 2011 Census.
  - *3. Area (10.0%)*: Compensates for geographical cost disabilities in service delivery; **minimum floor area reduced from 2% to 1.5%**.
  - *4. Forest Cover & Ecology (10.0%)*: Incentivizes ecological preservation across very dense, moderately dense, and open forests; **rewards net forest expansion between 2015 and 2023**.
  - *5. Demographic Performance (10.0%)*: **Major Paradigm Shift** — phases out inverse Total Fertility Rate (TFR) and replaces it with the **inverse of population growth rate (1971–2011)** to reward long-term population stabilization without penalizing transition states.
  - *6. Contribution to GDP (10.0%)*: **Brand New Efficiency Criterion** replacing the erstwhile 'Tax Effort'; rewards growth-oriented states based on the share of State GSDP in aggregate States' GSDP, modulated via square root to prevent excessive disparity.

- **Inter-Se Devolution Ranking of Top States:**
  - *Highest Allocations*: **Uttar Pradesh (17.619%)**, **Bihar (9.948%)**, **Madhya Pradesh (7.347%)**, **West Bengal (7.215%)**, **Maharashtra (6.441%)**, **Rajasthan (5.926%)**, **Odisha (4.420%)**, **Andhra Pradesh (4.217%)**, **Karnataka (4.131%)**, **Tamil Nadu (4.097%)**.
  - *Lowest Allocations*: Sikkim (0.335%), Goa (0.365%), Nagaland (0.481%), Mizoram (0.564%).

- **Local Body Grants Architecture (Total Outlay: ₹7,91,493 Crore):**
  - *Macro Split*: **60% Rural Local Bodies (RLBs)** : **40% Urban Local Bodies (ULBs)**.
  - *Component Division*: **80% Basic Component** : **20% Performance Component** across both RLBs and ULBs.
  - *Basic Component (80%)*: Earmarked as **50% Tied** (strictly for Drinking Water supply and Sanitation / Solid Waste Management) and **50% Untied** (roads capped at max 20%; strictly prohibited for salaries or establishment expenses).
  - *Performance Component (20%)*: **100% Untied**, split equally into Local Body Performance (10%) and State Performance (10%). Disbursed based on Own Source Revenue (OSR) thresholds (Gram Panchayats must achieve 2.5% p.a. growth or ₹1,200/household/yr; ULBs must achieve 5% p.a. growth).
  - *Urbanisation Premium (₹10,000 Cr)*: One-time grant of **₹2,000 per person** (2011 Census) to incentivize peri-urban village mergers into ULBs with population $\ge$ 1 lakh, subject to a state rural-to-urban transition policy.
  - *Special Infrastructure Component (₹56,100 Cr)*: Targeted wastewater and drainage overhaul in cities with population **10 lakh to 40 lakh** (max 2 cities per state; funded **60% Centre : 40% State/ULB**; project ceilings ₹5,000 Cr for pop $\ge$ 15L and ₹3,500 Cr for pop < 15L).
  - *State Transfer Mandate*: States must pass on grants to local bodies within **10 working days** of receipt from the Centre; delays attract penalty interest at the State's previous year SDL / market borrowing rate.

- **Financing of Disaster Management (Total Corpus: ₹2,04,401 Crore):**
  - *State Level (SDRF + SDMF)*: **₹2,04,401 crore** (Centre: ₹1,55,915.85 Cr; States: ₹48,485.15 Cr) covering FY27–FY31.
  - *Funding Ratio*: **75:25** for Non-NEH States; **90:10** for Northeastern and Hilly (NEH) States.

- *Allocation Split*: **80% State Disaster Response Fund (SDRF: ₹1,63,521 Cr)** : **20% State Disaster Mitigation Fund (SDMF: ₹40,880 Cr)**.
- *Prudence Safeguard*: If unspent SDRF balances exceed the sum of the past 3 years' annual allocations, central releases are temporarily withheld.
- *National Level Funds (NDRF + NDMF)*: **₹79,406 crore** with graded state matching contributions (10% to 25% for Non-NEH).
- *Compliance Gate*: Mandatory data validation on the **NDMIS (National Disaster Management Information System)** portal by May 31 of each succeeding year (operational from FY28).

- **Macro-Fiscal Discipline & Debt Sustainability:**
  - *State Fiscal Deficit Ceiling*: Anchored at **3.0% of GSDP** strictly enforced under **Article 293(3)** of the Constitution (excluding Special Assistance for Capital Investment loans).
  - *Union Fiscal Deficit Target*: Glidepath to **3.5% of GDP** by FY31 (end of the award period).
  - *Off-Budget Liabilities*: Recommends a complete ban on off-budget borrowings, mandating all state liabilities to be transparently brought onto the formal budget.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Constitutional Article: Finance Commission is constituted under **Article 280(1)**; Grants-in-Aid under **Article 275(1)**; Discretionary transfers (CSS) under **Article 282**; State borrowing limits under **Article 293(3)**.
- Commission Personnel: Chairman is **Dr. Arvind Panagariya**; Secretary is **Ritvik Ranjanam Pandey**; RBI Deputy Governor member is **T. Rabi Sankar**; SBI Chief Economic Advisor member is **Dr. Soumya Kanti Ghosh**; Advisory Council Convenor is **Dr. Poonam Gupta**.
- Devolution Numbers: Vertical tax devolution retained at **41%**; Revenue Deficit Grants = **₹0 (discontinued)**.
- Horizontal Weights: Income Distance (**42.5%**), Population 2011 (**17.5%**), Area (**10.0%**), Forest Cover (**10.0%**), Demographic Performance (**10.0%**), Contribution to GDP (**10.0%**).
- Local Body Grants: Total ₹7,91,493 Cr; RLB:ULB = **60:40**; Basic:Performance = **80:20**; Tied:Untied = **50:50**; Urbanisation Premium = **₹10,000 Cr** (₹2,000/person); State transfer window = **10 working days**.
- Disaster Financing: Total State corpus ₹2,04,401 Cr; SDRF:SDMF = **80:20**; Union:State = **75:25** (General) and **90:10** (NEH).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which new criterion was introduced by the 16th Finance Commission in horizontal devolution with a 10% weightage, replacing Tax Effort?" → Contribution to GDP (using square root of GSDP).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the mandatory timeline within which State Governments must transfer Finance Commission local body grants to Panchayats and Municipalities?" → Within 10 working days of receipt.

[MS-085] **Macroeconomic Modernization & Base-Year Architecture: 2026 Active Series & Historical Baselines**

- **Synchronized National Accounts & Price Indices Modernization:**
  - Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (**MoSPI**) and DPIIT operationalized a synchronized overhaul of India's foundational macroeconomic statistical indicators to eliminate structural obsolescence.

- **Master Base-Year Matrix (2026 Operative Series vs Predecessor Baselines):**
  - **Gross Domestic Product (GDP / GVA):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2022–23** (officially released by MoSPI / NSO on **27 February 2026**, incorporating updated Supply-Use Tables and GST electronic filings).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12** (operational from 2015 to early 2026).
  - **Consumer Price Index (CPI - Combined):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2024 = 100** (officially released by MoSPI / NSO in **February 2026**; anchored in the Household Consumption Expenditure Survey / HCES 2022–23 & 2023–24; rationalises Food & Beverages weight down to **36.75%** across 12 divisions and 358 items).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2012 = 100** (compiled monthly by NSO).
  - **Index of Industrial Production (IIP):**
    - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2022–23 = 100** (released by MoSPI in **June 2026**, expanding electronics manufacturing, semiconductors, and solar PV modules).
    - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12 = 100**.

- **Index of Core Industries (ICI - 9 Core Sectors):**
  - **Operative 2026 Series: Base Year 2022–23** (released August 2026; expanded to **9 core industries** with the addition of **Iron Ore**).
  - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12** (8 core industries).
- **Wholesale Price Index (WPI):**
  - **Operative 2026 Series:** Revised to **Base Year 2022–23** (compiled by Office of Economic Adviser, DPIIT, expanding items from 697 to 957 based on Gross Value of Output / GVO weighting).
  - *Historical Predecessor Series*: **2011–12 = 100**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- The Base-Year Exam Trap (High Risk):
  - *GDP Active Base Year*: **2022–23** (released Feb 2026; do NOT mark 2011–12).
  - *CPI-Combined Active Base Year*: **2024 = 100** (released Feb 2026; do NOT mark 2012).
  - *IIP Active Base Year*: **2022–23 = 100** (released June 2026; do NOT mark 2011–12).
  - *Core Industries (ICI)*: **Base Year 2022–23** with **9 core industries** (Iron Ore added as 9th).

Monetary Policy Inflation Anchor: RBI legally targets **CPI-Combined**, NEVER WPI.

Services Coverage: CPI includes services; WPI **does NOT include services**.

Target MCQ Form: "What is the active base year for the revised Gross Domestic Product (GDP) series released by MoSPI in 2026?" → **2022–23** (replaces 2011–12).

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5. FLAGSHIP CENTRAL GOVERNMENT SCHEMES & MISSIONS

[MS-086] **PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana — Rooftop Solar Transformation**

- **Financial Outlay & Household Target:** Total financial outlay of **₹75,021 Crore** to install rooftop solar power systems across **1 Crore households** nationwide.
- **Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) Subsidy Architecture:**
  - 1 kW capacity: **₹30,000** subsidy (covers residential electricity load up to 150 units/month).
  - 2 kW capacity: **₹60,000** subsidy (covers load between 150–300 units/month).
  - 3 kW capacity and above: Capped at **₹78,000** maximum subsidy.
- **National Nodal Agency & Concessional Lending: REC Limited** designated as the national project implementation agency; scheduled commercial banks provide collateral-free loans at ~7% interest (Repo + 0.5%) up to ₹2 Lakh.
- **Free Power Guarantee:** Yields up to **300 units of free electricity per month** per household, with surplus power sold back to local DISCOMs via net-metering.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Maximum Subsidy Cap: Maximum subsidy for residential systems (3 kW+) is **₹78,000** (not ₹1,00,000).
- Nodal Implementation Agency: **REC Limited** (a Maharatna CPSE under Ministry of Power), NOT IREDA.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which Maharatna public sector undertaking has been appointed as the National Nodal Agency for implementing PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana?" → REC Limited.

[MS-087] **PM-KISAN (Pradhan Mantri Kisan Samman Nidhi) — Direct Income Support**

- **Annual Benefit & Installment Schedule:** Provides **₹6,000 per year** in three equal 4-monthly installments of **₹2,000 each** directly into Aadhaar-seeded bank accounts of landholding farmer families.
- **Scheme Nature & Funding:** 100% Central Sector Scheme fully funded by the Government of India, operational since **December 1, 2018**.
- **Mandatory Compliance Triggers:** Disbursement strictly conditioned on:
  1. *e-KYC* authentication via biometric or facial recognition on PM-KISAN mobile app.

2. *Land Seeding* (verification of landholding records in state revenue portals).
3. *Aadhaar-seeded NPCI Bank Account Mapping*.

- **Cumulative Financial Footprint:** Disbursed over **₹3.24 Lakh Crore** across 17 consecutive tranches to more than 11 crore beneficiary farmers.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Scheme Type: PM-KISAN is a **100% Central Sector Scheme** (not Centrally Sponsored; Centre bears 100% cost).
- Exclusions: Institutional landholders, income taxpayers, and individuals receiving monthly pensions of ₹10,000+ are strictly excluded.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the annual financial assistance provided to eligible farmer families under the PM-KISAN scheme?" → ₹6,000 in three installments.

[MS-088] **PM Vishwakarma Scheme — Artisans & Traditional Craftsmen Ecosystem**

- **Sovereign Outlay & Duration:** Central Sector Scheme with a total outlay of **₹13,000 Crore** for a 5-year period covering **FY24 to FY28**.
- **Coverage of Traditional Trades:** Covers **18 traditional artisan and craft trades** (carpenters, blacksmiths, goldsmiths, potters, sculptors, cobblers, tailors, boat builders, etc.).
- **Two-Tranche Collateral-Free Enterprise Loans:**
  - *First Tranche*: Collateral-free loan up to **₹1,00,000** at a concessional interest rate of **5%** (repayable in 18 months).
  - *Second Tranche*: Subsequent loan up to **₹2,00,000** at **5% interest** (repayable in 30 months) upon successful repayment of the first tranche.
  - *Interest Subvention*: Ministry of MSME provides an interest subvention of **8%** to participating lending banks.
- **Skill Training & Toolkit Incentives:** 5–7 days basic training with **₹500 daily stipend**; **₹15,000 modern toolkit grant**; ₹1 per digital transaction incentive (up to 100 transactions/month).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Loan Tranche Math: Tranche 1 = **₹1 Lakh** (18 months); Tranche 2 = **₹2 Lakh** (30 months); Borrower interest = **5%**.
- Toolkit Grant: One-time modern toolkit incentive is **₹15,000** (not ₹10,000 or ₹20,000).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum loan amount available under the second tranche of the PM Vishwakarma Scheme?" → ₹2,00,000.

[MS-089] **Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana 2.0 (PMAY Urban & Gramin Expansion)**

- **Cabinet Approval of 3 Crore Additional Houses:** Union Cabinet approved the construction of **3 Crore additional rural and urban houses** (2 Crore under PMAY-Gramin and 1 Crore under PMAY-Urban).
- **PMAY-Urban 2.0 Financial Structure:** Total investment of **₹10 Lakh Crore** over 5 years with Central Financial Assistance of **₹2.2 Lakh Crore**.
- **Interest Subsidy Scheme (ISS) for Urban Poor:**
  - Beneficiary criteria: Economically Weaker Section (EWS - income up to ₹3L) and Low Income Group (LIG - income up to ₹6L).
  - Loan threshold: Housing loans up to **₹25 Lakh** for houses valued up to **₹35 Lakh**.
  - Subsidy parameter: **4% interest subsidy** on loan principal up to **₹8 Lakh** for a tenure of up to 12 years (maximum upfront subsidy ₹1.80 Lakh).
- **PMAY-Gramin Unit Assistance:** Unit cost assistance remains **₹1.20 Lakh in plain areas** and **₹1.30 Lakh in hilly/North-Eastern/difficult areas**, integrated with 90–95 days of unskilled wage labor under MGNREGS.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Additional Houses Breakdown: Total = **3 Crore** (2 Crore Gramin + 1 Crore Urban).
- PMAY-U 2.0 Interest Subsidy: 4% interest subsidy applies to loans up to **₹8 Lakh** (total loan allowed up to ₹25 Lakh).
- Target MCQ Form: "How many additional houses have been sanctioned under the expanded Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana across urban and rural segments?" → 3 Crore Houses.

[MS-090] **Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY) — 5-Year Sovereign Extension**

- **Five-Year Horizon & Outlay:** Extended for **5 years from January 1, 2024 to December 31, 2028** with a massive estimated budgetary outlay of **₹11.80 Lakh Crore**.
- **Entitlement Norms under NFSA:**
  - *Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) Families*: Entitled to **35 kg of free foodgrains per family per month**.
  - *Priority Households (PHH)*: Entitled to **5 kg of free foodgrains per person per month**.
- **100% Sovereign Subsidy:** Central Government fully absorbs the cost of procurement, storage, and distribution through Fair Price Shops; zero cost borne by beneficiaries or state governments.
- **Beneficiary Coverage:** Covers approximately **81.35 Crore beneficiaries** across all 36 States and Union Territories via the One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC) technology stack.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Extension Period: Extended for **5 years** until **December 31, 2028**.
- Allocation Slabs: AAY = **35 kg per family/month**; PHH = **5 kg per person/month**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Until which year has the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana (PMGKAY) free foodgrain scheme been extended by the Union Cabinet?" → December 31, 2028.

[MS-091] **Lakhpati Didi Initiative — Economic Graduation of Women SHGs**

- **Expanded Mission Target:** Union Budget officially elevated the national target from 2 Crore to **3 Crore Lakhpati Didis**.
- **Lakhpati Didi Definition:** A woman member of a Self-Help Group (SHG) mobilized under Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana - National Rural Livelihoods Mission (DAY-NRLM) whose household earns a **sustainable annual income of at least ₹1,00,000** (calculated with an average monthly income of >₹8,333).
- **Convergence Ecosystem:** Integrates multi-skilling, financial literacy, value-chain linkages, agriculture-drone services (Namo Drone Didi), animal husbandry, and direct bank linkage.
- **National Reach:** Over 1 Crore women have already achieved verified Lakhpati Didi status across rural India.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Target Number: Enhanced national target is **3 Crore women** (hiked from 2 Crore).
- Income Threshold: Minimum sustainable annual household income is **₹1,00,000**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the enhanced target set by the Government of India for creating 'Lakhpati Didis' through women Self-Help Groups?" → 3 Crore.

[MS-092] **Namo Drone Didi Scheme — Modernizing Agriculture via Women SHGs**

- **Central Sector Outlay:** Approved with a financial outlay of **₹1,261 Crore** for a period of two years (FY24-25 to FY25-26).
- **Physical Allocation Target:** Supplies advanced agricultural drones to **15,000 selected women Self-Help Groups (SHGs)** under DAY-NRLM to provide rental spraying services (nano-urea, DAP, pesticides) to local farmers.
- **Central Financial Assistance (CFA):**
  - Central Government provides **80% of drone cost (up to a maximum of ₹8 Lakh)** as direct financial grant.

- Remaining balance amount can be mobilized as a loan under the Agriculture Infrastructure Fund (AIF) with **3% interest subvention**.

- **Skill Certification:** 15-day certified training module (5 days mandatory DGCA drone pilot training + 10 days agricultural nutrient application training).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Drone Fleet Target: Exactly **15,000 women SHGs** will receive drones.
- Financial Grant Cap: Government subsidizes **80% of drone cost up to ₹8 Lakh**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum subsidy amount provided by the Central Government to a women SHG under the Namo Drone Didi Scheme?" → ₹8 Lakh (80% of cost).

[MS-093] **Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY) & PMMKSSY Sub-Scheme**

- **Parent Mission Outlay:** PMMSY operates with an investment of **₹20,050 Crore** (FY21 to FY25) aiming to expand fish production to **22 million metric tons** and fishery exports to ₹1 Lakh Crore.
- **New Sub-Scheme (PMMKSSY):** Cabinet approved the **Pradhan Mantri Matsya Kisan Samridhi Sah-Yojana (PMMKSSY)** with an outlay of **₹6,000 Crore** (50% public financing including World Bank/AFD loans, 50% private investment).
- **Formalisation & Insurance Drive:** Creates the National Fisheries Digital Platform (NFDP) to issue institutional identity cards, formalise micro-fisheries, and offer aquaculture insurance premium subsidies up to **50% of the premium cost**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Sub-Scheme Outlay: PMMKSSY sub-scheme has an outlay of **₹6,000 Crore**.
- Insurance Subsidy: Insurance premium incentive covers up to **50% of cost**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total financial outlay approved for the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Kisan Samridhi Sah-Yojana (PMMKSSY) sub-scheme under PMMSY?" → ₹6,000 Crore.

[MS-094] **PM-PRANAM Scheme — Chemical Fertilizer Rationalization**

- **Full Nomenclature:** *PM Programme for Restoration, Awareness, Nourishment and Amelioration of Mother Earth*.
- **Innovative Financing Mechanism:** Does not have an independent separate budget; financed entirely through **savings generated in the central fertilizer subsidy** bill.
- **50% Subsidy Sharing Formula:**
  - **50% of the total fertilizer subsidy saved** by a State/UT by reducing chemical fertilizer consumption (Urea, DAP, MOP) is provided back to that State as a direct grant.
  - Of this grant received by the state, **70% must be deployed for capital asset creation** (alternate fertilizer production plants, organic input bio-resource centers).
  - Remaining **30% is allocated for incentivizing panchayats, farmers, and farmer producer organizations (FPOs)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Budget Allocation Trap: PM-PRANAM has **NO separate budgetary outlay**; funded 100% via fertilizer subsidy savings.
- Incentive Ratio: **50% of subsidy saved** is transferred to the State (70% capital assets, 30% incentive).
- Target MCQ Form: "How is the PM-PRANAM scheme for promoting alternate fertilizers funded by the Central Government?" → Through savings generated from chemical fertilizer subsidy reductions.

[MS-095] **PM SVANidhi — Street Vendor Micro-Credit Architecture**

- **Ministry & Implementing Agency:** Launched by **Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (MoHUA)**; implementation managed by **SIDBI**.

- **Three-Tier Escalating Loan Tranches:**
  - *1st Tranche*: Collateral-free working capital loan up to **₹10,000** (tenure 1 year).
  - *2nd Tranche*: Enhanced loan up to **₹20,000** (tenure 1.5 years) upon timely repayment of the 1st loan.
  - *3rd Tranche*: Enhanced loan up to **₹50,000** (tenure 3 years) upon timely repayment of the 2nd loan.
- **Financial Incentives: 7% interest subvention** credited quarterly via DBT; monthly digital cashback up to **₹100 (₹1,200 annually)** for conducting digital transactions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Loan Tranches: Tranche 1 = **₹10,000**; Tranche 2 = **₹20,000**; Tranche 3 = **₹50,000**.
- Interest Subvention: Concessional interest subvention is **7% per annum**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum loan amount admissible under the third tranche of the PM SVANidhi micro-credit scheme?" → ₹50,000.

[MS-096] **Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY) — 10th Anniversary Milestone**

- **Decade of Financial Inclusion:** Completed **10 years of national implementation** on **August 28, 2024 / 2026** (originally launched Aug 28, 2014 under the National Mission for Financial Inclusion).
- **Core Parameters & Milestones:**
  - Cumulative beneficiaries exceed **53 Crore bank accounts** with aggregate deposit balances crossing **₹2.30 Lakh Crore**.
  - Over 67% of PMJDY accounts are opened in rural and semi-urban bank branches; women account for >55% of account holders.
- **Inbuilt RuPay Insurance Slabs:** Free inbuilt RuPay debit card accidental insurance cover of **₹2 Lakh** (for accounts opened after Aug 28, 2018; ₹1 Lakh for older accounts).
- **Overdraft (OD) Facility Parameters:**
  - Overdraft limit up to **₹10,000** (no conditions or collateral required up to **₹2,000**).
  - Eligibility age bracket expanded from 18–60 years to **18–65 years**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Overdraft Limits & Age: OD limit is **₹10,000** (hassle-free up to ₹2,000); age bracket is **18 to 65 years**.
- RuPay Accidental Cover: Accidental insurance is **₹2 Lakh** (for accounts opened post-August 2018).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum Overdraft (OD) limit available to eligible account holders under the Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana?" → ₹10,000.

[MS-097] **Atal Pension Yojana (APY) — Sovereign Pension Architecture**

- **Administering Body & Enrollment:** Administered by **PFRDA (Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority)** through NPS architecture; total subscribers crossed **6.8 Crore**.
- **Eligibility & Age Bracket:** Open to all Indian citizens aged between **18 and 40 years** having a savings bank account.
- **Guaranteed Monthly Pension Slabs:** Provides government-guaranteed monthly pension of **₹1,000, ₹2,000, ₹3,000, ₹4,000, or ₹5,000** from the age of **60 years**, depending on the subscriber's contribution.
- **Income Taxpayer Restriction:** With effect from **October 1, 2022**, any citizen who is or has been an income taxpayer is strictly barred from joining APY.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Entry Age vs Pension Age: Entry age is **18 to 40 years**; pension commences strictly at **60 years**.
- Taxpayer Bar: Income taxpayers cannot join APY (rule enforced since **October 1, 2022**).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum entry age for an Indian citizen to subscribe to the Atal Pension Yojana (APY)?" → 40 Years.

[MS-098] **Pradhan Mantri Social Security Insurance Dual Sagas: PMJJBY & PMSBY**

- **Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana (PMJJBY):**
  - Life insurance cover: **₹2,00,000** for death due to any reason.
  - Annual premium: **₹436 per annum** (auto-debited from bank account).
  - Age eligibility: **18 to 50 years** (life cover continues up to 55 years subject to continuous premium payment).
- **Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY):**
  - Accidental death and full disability cover: **₹2,00,000**; partial permanent disability: **₹1,00,000**.
  - Annual premium: **₹20 per annum**.
  - Age eligibility: **18 to 70 years**.
- **Administering Architecture:** Offered by LIC and other public/private life and general insurers in tie-up with commercial and regional rural banks.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Premium Slabs: PMJJBY premium = **₹436/year**; PMSBY premium = **₹20/year**.
- Age Brackets: PMJJBY entry age = **18–50 years**; PMSBY entry age = **18–70 years**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the annual premium payable by an eligible subscriber for the Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY)?" → ₹20.

[MS-099] **Mission Shakti (Sambal & Samarthya) & Mission Vatsalya**

- **Ministry of Women & Child Development Umbrella:** Umbrella mission structured into two distinct sub-schemes:
  - *Sambal (Safety & Security)*: 100% Centrally sponsored; includes **One Stop Centres (OSC)**, **Women Helpline (181)**, **Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP)**, and **Nari Adalats** (women-led dispute resolution).
  - *Samarthya (Empowerment)*: Includes **Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY)** providing ₹5,000 in two installments for first child and ₹6,000 for second child (if girl), **Palna** (day-care crèches), and **Shakti Niwas** (working women hostels).
- **Mission Vatsalya (Child Protection):** Dedicated central framework for juvenile justice, foster care, adoption (CARA), and child-in-need rehabilitation.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- PMMVY Girl Child Benefit: PMMVY provides **₹6,000** incentive if the second child born is a girl child.
- Sambal vs Samarthya: Sambal covers **Safety/Protection** (OSC, BBBP); Samarthya covers **Empowerment** (PMMVY, Crèches).
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the revamped Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana, what is the cash incentive provided for the birth of a second child if the infant is a girl?" → ₹6,000.

[MS-100] **Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) — Har Ghar Jal Milestones**

- **Mission Goal & Per Capita Metric:** Targets providing functional household tap connections (FHTC) delivering **55 litres per capita per day (lpcd)** of potable water to every rural home.
- **National Budgetary Outlay:** Massive sovereign outlay of **₹3.60 Lakh Crore**, operational under the Ministry of Jal Shakti.
- **Milestone States & UTs:**
  - First certified 'Har Ghar Jal' State: **Goa**.
  - First certified 'Har Ghar Jal' Union Territory: **Dadra & Nagar Haveli and Daman & Diu**.
  - First certified 'Har Ghar Jal' District: **Burhanpur (Madhya Pradesh)**.
- **National Penetration:** Rural household coverage expanded from 17% in 2019 to over **77% nationwide**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Water Supply Norm: Mandatory quantity is **55 litres per capita per day (lpcd)** (not 40 or 70 lpcd).
- First Certified District: **Burhanpur (Madhya Pradesh)** was the first certified Har Ghar Jal district.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the prescribed benchmark water supply per person per day under the Jal Jeevan Mission?" → 55 litres per capita per day (lpcd).

[MS-101] **PM RAHAT Scheme: Cashless Emergency Medical Care for Road Accident Victims**

- **Genesis & Statutory Backing:** Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (**MoRTH**) operationalized **PM RAHAT** (*Relief and Assistance for Highway Accident Trauma*), providing emergency golden-hour trauma care under Section 162 of the *Motor Vehicles Act, 1988*.
- **Cashless Treatment Limits & Duration:**
  - Entitles any road accident victim (regardless of nationality or financial status) to **cashless medical treatment up to ₹1.50 lakh per victim**.
  - Covers stabilization and in-hospital trauma treatment for a maximum duration of **up to 7 days from the date of the accident**.
- **Institutional Funding Architecture:**
  - Financed directly through the **Motor Vehicle Accident Fund (MVAF)**, funded via contributions from general insurance motor third-party premiums.
  - Seamlessly integrated with the National Emergency Response Support System (**ERSS 112**) and the National Health Authority (NHA) IT portal.
  - Mandates electronic police authentication of the accident incident within **24 to 48 hours**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Cashless Financial Ceiling: **₹1.50 Lakh per victim**.
- Treatment Window: **Up to 7 days** from the date of the accident.
- Statutory Fund: **Motor Vehicle Accident Fund (MVAF)** under Motor Vehicles Act, 1988.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the PM RAHAT scheme, what is the maximum cashless treatment assistance provided per road accident victim?" → ₹1.50 Lakh (up to 7 days).

[MS-102] **Urban Challenge Fund (UCF): ₹1 Lakh Crore Infrastructure Transformation Architecture**

- **Flagship Urban Infrastructure Pool:** Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs (**MoHUA**) unveiled the **Urban Challenge Fund (UCF)** with an aggregate financial outlay of **₹1,00,000 crore (₹1 Lakh Crore)** operational over a 5-year execution horizon (**FY26 to FY31**).
- **Financing & Contribution Structure:**
  - **Central Government Share:** Contributes **25% (₹25,000 crore)** as viability gap funding and credit-enhancement grants.
  - **Commercial Market Sources:** Minimum **50% of total project cost** must be mobilized via market-driven debt, municipal bonds, and private public-private partnerships (PPP).
  - **State / Urban Local Body (ULB) Share:** Remainder funded through municipal internal revenues and state budget allocations.
- **Municipal Creditworthiness Corpus:** Creates a dedicated **₹5,000 crore revolving credit-enhancement corpus** covering **4,223 statutory cities and towns** to improve municipal bond credit ratings and bankability.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Outlay: **₹1,00,000 Crore (₹1 Lakh Crore)** across FY26–FY31.
- Central Contribution Share: **25%** (Minimum **50%** must come from market/PPP sources).
- Creditworthiness Corpus: **₹5,000 Crore** covering 4,223 cities.
- Target MCQ Form: "What proportion of total project funding must be mobilized from market sources under the ₹1 Lakh Crore Urban Challenge Fund?" → Minimum 50%.

[MS-103] **GOBARdhan Scheme Overhaul: ₹23,731 Crore Outlay & Statutory CBG Blending Targets**

- **Cabinet Approval & Decade-Long Horizon:** Union Cabinet approved the revamped **GOBARdhan** (*Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan*) – National Circular Bioenergy Scheme with an outlay of **₹23,731 crore** operational over a 10-year period (**FY 2026–27 to FY 2035–36**).
- **Mandatory CBG Blending Mandate for City Gas Distribution (CGD):**
  - **FY 2026–27 (FY27):** Mandatory **3% blending of Compressed Biogas (CBG)** in City Gas Distribution (CGD) networks.
  - **FY 2027–28 (FY28):** Mandatory blending elevated to **4%**.
  - **FY 2028–29 (FY29) Onwards:** Mandatory blending locked at **5% continuously**.
- **Financial Support Slabs:**
  - Provides capital subsidy of **up to ₹2 crore per Tonne per Day (TPD)** of installed CBG production capacity.
  - Launches specialized **Credit Guarantee Scheme for MSMEs** setting up bio-gas plants and biomass aggregation value chains.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Outlay: **₹23,731 Crore** (10-year validity: FY27 to FY36).
- Statutory CGD Blending Glidepath: **3% in FY27 4% in FY28 5% from FY29 onwards**.
- Capital Subsidy: **Up to ₹2 Crore per TPD** of installed capacity.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the mandatory Compressed Biogas (CBG) blending target for City Gas Distribution networks in FY 2026-27 under the GOBARdhan framework?" → 3%.

[MS-104] **PM-SETU Programme: ₹60,000 Crore Modernisation of 1,000 ITIs**

- **Vocational Upgradation Mission:** Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship (**MSDE**) approved the **PM-SETU** (*Skill Enhancement and Technical Upgradation*) Programme.
- **Outlay & Institutional Target:**
  - Total financial outlay of **₹60,000 crore** to comprehensively upgrade and modernize **1,000 Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs)** across India into state-of-the-art Centers of Excellence (CoEs).
- **Core Curricular Focus:** Industry 4.0 integration, semiconductor packaging, advanced robotics, drone maintenance, renewable green energy systems, and AI-driven predictive manufacturing.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Programme Name: **PM-SETU**.
- Total Financial Outlay: **₹60,000 Crore**.
- Target ITIs: **1,000 ITIs** modernized into Centers of Excellence.
- Target MCQ Form: "How many Industrial Training Institutes (ITIs) will be upgraded under the ₹60,000 Crore PM-SETU programme?" → 1,000 ITIs.

[MS-105] **EPFO Mandatory Wage Ceiling Raised to ₹25,000/Month: Landmark Social Security Expansion**

- **First Revision in 12 Years:** The Union Cabinet chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved a historic hike in the statutory wage ceiling for mandatory coverage under the Employees' Provident Fund Organisation (**EPFO**) from

₹15,000 to ₹25,000 per month (effective **September 17, 2026**).

- **Historic Precedent:** The previous statutory revision occurred on September 1, 2014, when the wage threshold was increased from ₹6,500 to ₹15,000.
- **Massive Social Security Expansion:** Mandatorily extends coverage under the *Employees' Provident Funds and Miscellaneous Provisions Act, 1952* to over **51 lakh additional formal sector employees**.
- **Statutory Tripartite Framework:**
  - **EPF (Employees' Provident Fund):** 12% employee contribution matched by 12% employer contribution (employer's share split: **8.33% to EPS**, **3.67% to EPF**).
  - **EPS (Employees' Pension Scheme):** Pensionable salary calculation base elevated to ₹25,000/month.
  - **EDLI (Employees' Deposit-Linked Insurance):** Statutory life insurance coverage cap proportionately scaled.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Revised Wage Ceiling: **₹25,000 per month** (hiked from ₹15,000).
- Effective Date: **September 17, 2026**.
- Additional Workforce Covered: **51 Lakh workers**.
- Previous Revision Year: **2014** (from ₹6,500 to ₹15,000).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the revised statutory wage ceiling approved by the Union Cabinet for mandatory coverage under EPFO in September 2026?" → ₹25,000 per month.

[MS-106] **Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana (PMMY) & The New 'Tarun Plus' ₹20 Lakh Tier**

- **Genesis & Institutional Architecture:** Launched on **April 8, 2015**, under the Ministry of Finance to provide formal institutional credit to non-corporate, non-farm micro and small enterprises.
- **The 4 Statutory Loan Categories:**
  - **Shishu:** Covering loans up to **₹50,000** (initial seed capital for micro-vendors and solo entrepreneurs).
  - **Kishore:** Covering loans above **₹50,000 and up to ₹5,00,000** (equipment purchase and working capital).
  - **Tarun:** Covering loans above **₹5,00,000 and up to ₹10,00,000** (business expansion and modernization).
  - **NEW — Tarun Plus:** Union Budget introduced an enhanced tier elevating the credit ceiling to **₹20,00,000 (₹20 Lakh)** specifically for entrepreneurs who have successfully availed and repaid previous loans under the Tarun category.
- **Collateral-Free Guarantee Mechanism:**
  - No collateral security or third-party guarantee is required for loans under PMMY.
  - Credit guarantee coverage provided through the **Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Units (CGFMU)** managed by the National Credit Guarantee Trustee Company (**NCGTC**).
  - Processing charges and upfront fees are completely waived for Shishu category loans.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Launch Date: **April 8, 2015**.
- Original Maximum Cap: **₹10 Lakh** (Tarun).
- New 'Tarun Plus' Ceiling: **₹20 Lakh** for repeat borrowers with disciplined repayment history.
- The 4 Slabs: Shishu (≤₹50k), Kishore (₹50k–₹5L), Tarun (₹5L–₹10L), Tarun Plus (₹10L–₹20L).
- Guarantee Agency: **NCGTC / CGFMU** (not DICGC or CGTMSE).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the enhanced loan limit approved under the new 'Tarun Plus' category of Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana (PMMY) for repeat borrowers?" → ₹20 Lakh.

[MS-107] **Stand-Up India Scheme (SUI): Credit Guarantee & Greenfield Entrepreneurship Architecture**

- **Statutory Mandate & Vision:** Launched on **April 5, 2016** (extended through **2025/2026**), administered by the Department of Financial Services (**DFS**), Ministry of Finance, to promote entrepreneurship at the grassroots level.

- **Mandatory Bank Branch Target:** Mandates **every scheduled commercial bank branch** in India to facilitate at least **two loans:**
  1. At least **one Scheduled Caste (SC) or Scheduled Tribe (ST) borrower**.
  2. At least **one Woman borrower**.
- **Credit Quantum & Enterprise Nature:**
  - Offers composite loans (including term loan and working capital) between **₹10 Lakh and up to ₹100 Lakh (₹1 Crore)**.
  - Exclusively for setting up **greenfield enterprises** (first-time venture) in manufacturing, services, agri-allied activities, or the trading sector.
  - In non-individual enterprises, at least **51% of shareholding and controlling stake** must be held by either an SC/ST or woman entrepreneur.
- **Margin Money & Repayment Horizon:**
  - Margin money requirement rationalized to **up to 15%** (which can be converged with eligible central/state subsidies; borrower must provide minimum 10% own contribution).
  - Repayable over a period of **7 years** with a maximum moratorium period of **18 months**.
  - Credit guarantee backed by the **Credit Guarantee Fund for Stand Up India (CGFSI)** operated by NCGTC.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Target Borrowers: Strictly **SC, ST, and Women entrepreneurs**.
- Branch Mandate: At least **one SC/ST and one woman borrower per bank branch**.
- Loan Range: **₹10 Lakh to ₹100 Lakh (₹1 Crore)**.
- Margin Money Cap: **Up to 15%** (minimum 10% borrower contribution).
- Enterprise Condition: Strictly **greenfield** (new) enterprises only.
- Repayment Term: **7 years** with up to **18 months moratorium**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the loan quantum eligible under the Stand-Up India Scheme for SC/ST and Women entrepreneurs?" → ₹10 Lakh to ₹1 Crore.

[MS-108] **PM-eBus Sewa Payment Security Mechanism (PSM) Scheme: ₹3,435 Crore E-Mobility Guarantee**

- **Cabinet Sanction & Financial Outlay:** The Union Cabinet approved the *Scheme for Payment Security Mechanism (PSM) for procurement and operation of electric buses by Public Transport Authorities (PTAs)* with a dedicated budgetary allocation of **₹3,435 Crore**.
- **Massive Fleet Transformation:**
  - Facilitates the procurement, deployment, and operation of more than **38,000 electric buses (e-buses)** nationwide across Indian cities from **FY 2024-25 to FY 2028-29**.
  - Operates on a Public-Private Partnership (**PPP**) Gross Cost Contract (**GCC**) framework where original equipment manufacturers (OEMs) and private bus operators supply and operate buses.
- **Sovereign Payment Guarantee Architecture:**
  - Cash-strapped state road transport corporations and municipal transport undertakings historically suffered credit unviability and payment defaults.
  - The PSM acts as a credit enhancement mechanism: if a public transport authority defaults on daily/monthly operational payments, the dedicated fund under PSM immediately fulfills payments to bus operators.
- **National Nodal Implementing Agency: Convergence Energy Services Limited (CESL)**, a subsidiary of Energy Efficiency Services Limited (EESL) under the Ministry of Power, manages the central guarantee fund.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Budgetary Outlay: **₹3,435 Crore**.
- Target Electric Bus Deployment: **38,000+ electric buses** (FY25 to FY29).
- Implementing Agency: **CESL (Convergence Energy Services Limited)**.
- Operating Model: **Gross Cost Contract (GCC)** under Public-Private Partnership (PPP).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the financial outlay approved by the Union Cabinet for the PM-eBus Sewa Payment Security Mechanism (PSM) Scheme to support 38,000+ electric buses?" → ₹3,435 Crore.

[MS-109] **PM Vidyalaxmi Scheme: Central Sector Collateral-Free Higher Education Loan Architecture**

- **Cabinet Approval & Mission Scope:** The Union Cabinet approved the **PM Vidyalaxmi Scheme** on **November 6, 2024** as a central sector scheme under the Ministry of Education to ensure no meritorious student is denied higher education due to financial constraints.
- **Institutional Eligibility (Top 860 QHEIs):**
  - Applicable to all students admitted to the **Top 860 Quality Higher Education Institutions (QHEIs)** in the country.
  - Includes all institutions ranked in the **Top 100 overall, category-specific, and domain-specific NIRF rankings**, plus government higher education institutions.
- **Prudential Financing & Guarantee Architecture:**
  - **Collateral & Guarantor Free:** Financial institutions provide **100% collateral-free and guarantor-free education loans** covering tuition fees and course-related expenses.
  - **75% Credit Guarantee:** Government of India provides a **75% credit guarantee** on outstanding default balances for loan amounts **up to ₹7.5 Lakh**, encouraging commercial banks to lend aggressively.
  - **3% Interest Subvention:** Students with annual gross family income **up to ₹8 Lakh** (and not availing other scholarships) receive a **3% interest subvention** during the moratorium period on loan amounts **up to ₹10 Lakh** (benefiting ~1 lakh students annually).
  - **Full Interest Subvention:** Students with family income **up to ₹4.5 Lakh** continue to receive full interest subvention under the Central Sector Interest Subsidy (CSIS / PM-USP).
- **Scale Milestone:** Crossed **1,12,817 sanctioned collateral-free education loans** within months of nationwide unified portal rollout.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Cabinet Approval Date: **November 6, 2024**.
- Institutional Scope: Top **860 Quality Higher Education Institutions (QHEIs)** as per NIRF.
- Credit Guarantee Floor: Government provides **75% credit guarantee** for loans up to **₹7.5 Lakh**.
- Income Slab for 3% Subvention: Family income **up to ₹8 Lakh** per annum.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the PM Vidyalaxmi Scheme, what percentage of credit guarantee is provided by the Central Government for loans up to ₹7.5 Lakh?" → 75%.

[MS-110] **Atal Beemit Vyakti Kalyan Yojana (ABVKY) & ESIC Social Security Net**

- **Institutional Governance:** Administered by the **Employees' State Insurance Corporation (ESIC)** under the Ministry of Labour and Employment, enacted under Section 2(9) and Section 46 of the ESI Act, 1948.
- **Core Unemployment Relief Architecture:**
  - Provides cash relief directly to the bank accounts of Insured Persons (IPs) who face involuntary unemployment or job loss.
  - **Relief Quantum:** Payout of **50% of the average daily earnings** for a maximum duration of **up to 90 days** in a lifetime.
- **Relaxed Eligibility Conditions:**
  - The insured person must have been in insurable employment for a minimum period of **two years** prior to unemployment.

- Must have contributed for not less than **78 days** in each of the four contribution periods immediately preceding unemployment.
- Claim payable within **30 days** of filing (reduced from earlier 90-day waiting period).

- **Statutory Scheme Extension:** ESIC officially approved successive extensions of the scheme through **June 30, 2026** (and ongoing regulatory review) to protect formal-sector workers against cyclical job shocks.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Implementing Agency: **Employees' State Insurance Corporation (ESIC)**, Ministry of Labour and Employment.
- Payout Rate: Cash relief of **50% of average daily earnings** for up to **90 days**.
- Incurred Contribution Requirement: Minimum **78 days of contribution** in preceding periods.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum duration for which unemployment relief is payable to an insured worker under the Atal Beemit Vyakti Kalyan Yojana (ABVKY)?" → 90 days.

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6. SOVEREIGN INDUSTRIAL MISSIONS, DEEP-TECH & GREEN ENERGY

[MS-111] **India Semiconductor Mission (ISM) & Sovereign Fab Sanctions**

- **Incentive Framework:** Union Cabinet approved the ISM with an outlay of **₹76,000 Crore**, offering **50% fiscal support on a pari-passu basis** for setting up silicon fabs, display fabs, compound semiconductors, and ATMP/OSAT facilities.
- **Approved Mega-Projects:**
  - *Commercial Silicon Fab*: **Tata Electronics Pvt Ltd (TEPL)** partnering with **Powerchip Semiconductor Manufacturing Corp (PSMC, Taiwan)** to build India's 1st commercial semiconductor fabrication facility in **Dholera, Gujarat** (Investment: **₹91,000 Crore**; capacity: 50,000 wafer starts/month).
  - *OSAT Facility in Assam*: Tata Semiconductor Assembly and Test facility in **Morigaon, Assam** (Investment: **₹27,000 Crore**; 48 million chips/day).
  - *OSAT in Gujarat*: CG Power partnering with **Renesas Electronics (Japan)** and Stars Microelectronics in **Sanand, Gujarat** (Investment: **₹7,600 Crore**).
  - *Kaynes SemiCon Facility*: Advanced packaging facility approved in **Sanand, Gujarat** (Investment: **₹3,307 Crore**).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Commercial Fab Location: Dholera, Gujarat (Tata + PSMC Taiwan).
- Assam Facility Location: Morigaon, Assam (Tata Semiconductor OSAT).
- Target MCQ Form: "Where is India's first commercial semiconductor fabrication facility being established by Tata Electronics in partnership with PSMC?" → Dholera, Gujarat.

[MS-112] **National Quantum Mission (NQM) — Deep-Tech Quantum Frontier**

- **Financial Outlay & Execution Horizon:** Approved with a total budget of **₹6,003.65 Crore** spanning an 8-year period from **FY24 to FY31**, spearheaded by the Department of Science and Technology (DST).
- **Primary Technology Benchmarks:**
  - Develop intermediate-scale quantum computers with **50 to 1000 physical qubits** within 8 years.
  - Establish satellite-based secure quantum communications over a ground distance of **2,000 kilometers** within India and inter-city quantum key distribution (QKD).
- **Four Thematic Hubs (T-Hubs):** Set up across premier academic institutes in four domains:
  1. *Quantum Computing*
  2. *Quantum Communication*
  3. *Quantum Sensing & Metrology*
  4. *Quantum Materials & Devices*

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Financial Outlay: Approved outlay is **₹6,003.65 Crore** (covers 8 years).
- Qubit Target: Intermediate-scale quantum computer targets **50 to 1000 physical qubits**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total financial outlay approved for the National Quantum Mission (NQM) over its 8-year tenure?" → ₹6,003.65 Crore.

[MS-113] **National Green Hydrogen Mission (NGHM) & SIGHT Programme**

- **National Targets by 2030:**
  - Green hydrogen production capacity of **5 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT) per annum**.
  - Addition of **125 GW of associated renewable energy capacity**.
  - Abatement of nearly 50 MMT of annual greenhouse gas emissions.
- **Financial Outlay:** Total mission outlay of **₹19,744 Crore** under the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE).
- **SIGHT Sub-Programme:** *Strategic Interventions for Green Hydrogen Transition (SIGHT)* allocated **₹17,490 Crore** structured into two financial incentive mechanisms:
  1. *Component I*: Domestic manufacturing of Electrolysers (**₹4,440 Crore**).
  2. *Component II*: Production of Green Hydrogen (**₹13,050 Crore**).
- **Implementing Entity: Solar Energy Corporation of India (SECI)** conducts competitive bidding.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 2030 Target: Target is **5 MMT per annum** green hydrogen production by 2030.
- SIGHT Implementing Agency: **SECI (Solar Energy Corporation of India)** manages auctioning and subsidy disbursements.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is India's annual green hydrogen production target by 2030 under the National Green Hydrogen Mission?" → 5 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT).

[MS-114] **PM Electric Drive Revolution in Innovative Vehicle Enhancement (PM E-DRIVE)**

- **Successor to FAME-II:** Officially approved by Union Cabinet to replace FAME-II, with a total financial outlay of **₹10,900 Crore** over a two-year tenure (2024 to 2026).
- **Subsidized Vehicle Targets:**
  - Subsidizes **24.79 Lakh electric two-wheelers (e-2W)**.
  - Subsidizes **3.16 Lakh electric three-wheelers (e-3W)**.
  - Procures **14,028 electric buses (e-buses)** through Convergence Energy Services Limited (CESL) with an allocation of **₹4,391 Crore**.
- **EV Public Charging Infrastructure:** Allocates **₹2,000 Crore** to install 22,100 fast chargers for e-4Ws, 1,800 for e-buses, and 48,400 for e-2W/3Ws.
- **e-Vouchers via Aadhar Integration:** Introduces Aadhaar-authenticated digital e-vouchers for EV buyers generated at the time of purchase to claim upfront consumer subsidies.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Outlay: Approved outlay is **₹10,900 Crore** (not ₹10,000 Cr).
- Electric Cars Excluded: PM E-DRIVE **does NOT subsidize private electric cars** (subsidies are reserved for e-2W, e-3W, e-buses, and e-ambulances).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the total financial outlay approved for the PM E-DRIVE scheme succeeding FAME-II?" → ₹10,900 Crore.

[MS-115] **National Critical Minerals Mission & Offshore Mineral Auctions**

- **Union Budget Sovereign Mission:** Mandates securing domestic exploration, refining, overseas mine acquisitions, and recycling of 24 strategic and critical minerals.
- **Offshore Areas Mineral (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act:** Formulated rules for auctioning **offshore mineral blocks** in India's Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ) for polymetallic nodules, cobalt crusts, and mineral sands.
- **KABIL Sovereign Acquisitions:** *Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL)* (joint venture of NALCO, HCL, and MECL) secured exploration and mining rights over **5 lithium brine blocks in Catamarca Province, Argentina** (covering 15,703 hectares).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Argentine Province: KABIL acquired 5 lithium blocks in **Catamarca Province, Argentina**.
- KABIL Constituents: JV of three PSUs: **NALCO (40%), HCL (30%), and MECL (30%)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "In which Argentine province has Khanij Bidesh India Limited (KABIL) secured exploration and mining rights for five lithium brine blocks?" → Catamarca.

[MS-116] **Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Schemes Overhaul & Disbursement Status**

- **Macro Outlay & Sectors:** Total sovereign commitment of **₹1.97 Lakh Crore** across **14 strategic manufacturing sectors** to build national champions and integrate into Global Value Chains (GVCs).
- **Outperforming Sectors: Large-Scale Electronics (Mobile Phones)**, **Pharmaceuticals**, **Medical Devices**, and **Food Processing** led in capex realization and incentive payouts.
- **Value Addition & Export Boom:** Mobile phone production in India crossed ₹4.1 Lakh Crore with exports surpassing **₹1.2 Lakh Crore** (driven by Apple and Samsung ecosystem suppliers).
- **Design-Led PLI Integration:** 1% additional incentive window introduced under Telecom PLI for design-led manufacturing domestic patents.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Total Sectors: PLI covers **14 key manufacturing sectors**.
- Total Outlay: Aggregate financial commitment is **₹1.97 Lakh Crore**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Across how many strategic manufacturing sectors is the Government of India's Production Linked Incentive (PLI) scheme operational?" → 14 Sectors.

[MS-117] **BioE3 Policy — High-Performance Biomanufacturing Blueprint**

- **Full Nomenclature:** *Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment*.
- **Department & Ministry:** Formulated and driven by the **Department of Biotechnology (DBT)** under the Ministry of Science & Technology.
- **Six Thematic Strategic Pillars:**
  1. *Bio-based chemicals and enzymes*
  2. *Functional foods and smart proteins*
  3. *Precision biotherapeutics*
  4. *Climate resilient agriculture*
  5. *Carbon capture and utilization through biological agents*
  6. *Futuristic marine and space biofoundries*
- **Bio-Enablers Hubs:** Establishes world-class Biomanufacturing & Bio-AI Hubs to commercialize pilot fermentation technologies and synthetic biology.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Department: BioE3 Policy is spearheaded by the **Department of Biotechnology (DBT)**.
- Thematic Pillars: Focuses on **six priority thematic areas** of biomanufacturing.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which department has formulated the landmark BioE3 (Biotechnology for Economy, Environment and Employment) Policy approved by the Union Cabinet?" → Department of Biotechnology.

[MS-118] **Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) — Sovereign R&D Engine**

- **Statutory Genesis:** Established under the **Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) Act, 2023**, superseding the Science and Engineering Research Board (SERB).
- **Financial Architecture:** Massive planned outlay of **₹50,000 Crore** over five years (FY24 to FY28):
  - Central Government budgetary support: **₹14,000 Crore**.
  - Mobilization from non-government private industry and philanthropy: **₹36,000 Crore (72% of total)**.
- **Apex Governance:**
  - **Prime Minister of India** serves as the ex-officio **President of the Governing Board**.
  - Union Minister of Science & Technology and Union Minister of Education serve as Vice-Presidents.
  - Principal Scientific Adviser (PSA) heads the Executive Council.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Private Funding Share: **₹36,000 Crore (72%)** of the ₹50,000 Crore outlay must come from private philanthropic/industry sources.
- Apex President: The **Prime Minister of India** is the ex-officio President of ANRF's Governing Board.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who acts as the ex-officio President of the Governing Board of the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF)?" → Prime Minister of India.

[MS-119] **Ultra-Mega Solar Power Parks & Renewable Energy Landscape**

- **500 GW Non-Fossil Fuel Target:** India is committed to installing **500 GW of non-fossil electricity capacity by 2030** under its COP26/COP28 NDC commitments.
- **World's Largest Operational Solar Parks:**
  - **Bhadla Solar Park (Rajasthan):** World's largest operational solar park with a capacity of **2,245 MW**.
  - **Pavagada Solar Park (Karnataka - 'Shakti Sthala'):** Second largest domestic solar installation with **2,050 MW**.
- **Ultra Mega Renewable Energy Power Parks (UMREPPs):** Developing 30 GW hybrid renewable park in **Khavda, Kutch (Gujarat)**, set to become the world's largest single renewable energy installation upon completion.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Largest Operational Solar Park: **Bhadla Solar Park, Rajasthan** (2,245 MW).
- 2030 NDC Renewable Target: **500 GW** of non-fossil power capacity by 2030.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which operational solar park in Rajasthan is currently recognized as the largest single-location solar power plant in the world by capacity?" → Bhadla Solar Park (2,245 MW).

[MS-120] **Nuclear Power Expansion: Small Modular Reactors (SMRs) & PFBR Core Loading**

- **Nuclear Private-Public Partnerships:** Union Budget announced sovereign collaboration with private enterprise to develop **Bharat Small Reactors (BSR)** (220 MWe) and research into **Small Modular Reactors (SMRs)**.
- **Commercial Commissioning at Kakrapar:** Nuclear Power Corporation of India Limited (NPCIL) fully commenced commercial operations of **Kakrapar Atomic Power Project (KAPP) Unit-4 (700 MWe PHWR)** in Gujarat (following Unit-3 commissioning).
- **Core Loading of Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR):** Commenced core loading of India's indigenous **500 MWe Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor at Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu**, marking entry into the second stage of India's three-

stage nuclear power programme.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- PFBR Location & Capacity: **500 MWe** at **Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu**.
- KAPP Reactor Capacity: Kakrapar Units 3 and 4 are **700 MWe indigenous Pressurised Heavy Water Reactors (PHWRs)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "At which location did the historic core loading of India's indigenous 500 MWe Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) take place?" → Kalpakkam, Tamil Nadu.

[MS-121] **Maritime India Vision 2030: India Becomes World's Largest Ship Recycling Nation Ahead of Target**

- **Vision Realisation Milestone:** India officially surpassed global competitors to become the **world's largest ship recycling nation by gross tonnage**, achieving the benchmark set under **Maritime India Vision 2030 five full years ahead of the target schedule**.
- **Hub of Operations:** Concentrated at **Alang-Sosiya Ship Recycling Yard in Bhavnagar district, Gujarat**, which accounts for over 98% of domestic ship-breaking activity.
- **Hong Kong Convention (HKC) Compliance:** Over **100+ recycling plots at Alang** have secured Statements of Compliance (SoC) under the IMO's *Hong Kong International Convention for the Safe and Environmentally Sound Recycling of Ships*.
- **Economic & Steel Recovery Contribution:** Supplies nearly **10%–15% of India's secondary re-rolled steel feedstock**, conserving iron ore resources and substantially cutting industrial carbon emissions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Global Ranking: India is officially the **No. 1 ship recycling nation globally**.
- Core Operational Hub: **Alang Ship Breaking Yard (Bhavnagar, Gujarat)**.
- International Safety Accord: **Hong Kong Convention (HKC)** of the International Maritime Organization (IMO).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which global milestone did India achieve 5 years ahead of schedule under the Maritime India Vision 2030?" → Becoming the World's Largest Ship Recycling Nation.

[MS-122] **DRDO Long-Range Hypersonic Maritime Missile (LR-AShM / Mach 10)**

- **Strategic Flight Test Milestone:** Defence Research and Development Organisation (**DRDO**) successfully conducted the flight test of its indigenous **Long-Range Anti-Ship Missile (LR-AShM)** / Hypersonic Glide demonstrator off the coast of Odisha from **Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam Island**.
- **Extreme Kinetic & Flight Parameters:**
  - **Operational Strike Range:** Exceeds **1,500 kilometers**, providing unprecedented anti-access/area-denial (A2/AD) capabilities across the Indian Ocean Region.
  - **Velocity Ceiling:** Capable of sustaining flight speeds of **up to Mach 10** (extreme hypersonic regime, substantially exceeding Mach 5).
  - **Manoeuvring Flight Path:** Powered by solid-propellant rocket booster stages and high-altitude hypersonic glide avionics capable of evasive mid-course manoeuvres to defeat modern shipborne anti-missile air defence shields.
- **Operational Integration:** Developed to equip front-line Indian Navy destroyers and coastal missile batteries, positioning India among an elite group of nations (USA, Russia, China) possessing verified long-range hypersonic maritime strike technology.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Strike Range: Exceeding **1,500 km**.
- Velocity: Speeds of **up to Mach 10** (hypersonic domain).
- Test Location: **Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam Island (Wheeler Island), Odisha coast**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the strike range and maximum speed capability of the DRDO-developed hypersonic maritime missile tested off the Odisha coast?" → Strike range > 1,500 km, Speed up to Mach 10.

[MS-123] **Pioneering State AI Cabinet Portfolios & Sovereign Tech Governance**

- **Historic Institutional First:** The State Government of **Andhra Pradesh** issued a landmark State Gazette order formally creating India's first dedicated Cabinet-level **Department of Artificial Intelligence, Cloud Infrastructure & Emerging Technologies**.
- **Governance Mandate:**
  - Formulates sovereign AI governance guidelines, responsible AI deployment, and data centre regulatory frameworks.
  - Established a dedicated ministerial portfolio to attract global deep-tech hyperscale data centres, GPU clusters, and autonomous systems manufacturing.
  - Integrates AI-driven public service delivery, precision agriculture analytics, and administrative grievance processing.
- **National Benchmark:** Precedent followed by ministerial-level AI and digital task forces across Telangana and Karnataka, signaling the decentralization of deep-tech economic policy to state administrative structures.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First State with AI Cabinet Portfolio: **Andhra Pradesh** (issued via state Gazette order).
- Focus: Artificial Intelligence, GPU clusters, and emerging technology governance.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which Indian state became the first in the country to create a dedicated Artificial Intelligence portfolio at the cabinet level through an official Gazette order?" → Andhra Pradesh.

7. MULTILATERAL LOANS, BILATERAL ACCORDS & GIFT CITY

[MS-124] **World Bank $1.5 Billion Second Low-Carbon Energy Development Policy Operation**

- **Financial Commitment:** World Bank approved a massive **$1.5 Billion financing package** (Second Low-Carbon Energy Programmatic DPO) to accelerate India's green hydrogen and renewable energy ecosystems.
- **Strategic Policy Targets:**
  - Scale domestic production of **Green Hydrogen** and electrolyser manufacturing capacity.
  - Mobilize private climate finance through green bonds and renewable energy grid integration.
  - Facilitate trade in green hydrogen and low-carbon derivatives.
- **IBRD & IDA Lending Structure:** Structured via the International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (IBRD) with a sovereign maturity period of 19 years, including a 5-year grace period.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Loan Quantum: Exactly **$1.5 Billion** (Second Low-Carbon DPO).
- Multilateral Agency: **World Bank (IBRD)**, not Asian Development Bank or IMF.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which multilateral financial institution approved a $1.5 billion loan to support India's Low-Carbon Energy transition and green hydrogen development?" → World Bank.

[MS-125] **Asian Development Bank (ADB) Sovereign Country Partnership & Strategic Loans**

- **Largest Sovereign Borrower:** India continues as the **largest sovereign borrower of ADB**, holding over $16 billion in active sovereign loan commitments.
- **Key Sectoral Sanctions:**
  - *$500 Million*: Approved to modernize and expand **tertiary healthcare and medical education facilities in Maharashtra**.
  - *$250 Million*: Industrial Corridor Development Programme to strengthen logistics nodes along the Vizag-Chennai and Delhi-Mumbai corridors.
  - *$200 Million*: Climate-resilient urban water supply and sanitation projects in **Uttarakhand**.
  - *$181 Million*: Urban mobility and livability infrastructure in **Ahmedabad peri-urban areas (Gujarat)**.

- **Headquarters & Governance:** ADB Headquarters located in **Mandaluyong, Metro Manila, Philippines**; President is **Masato Kanda** (assumed office 24 February 2025, succeeding Masatsugu Asakawa; unanimously re-elected in September 2026).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- ADB Headquarters: **Mandaluyong, Metro Manila, Philippines** (not Tokyo or Jakarta).
- ADB Leadership: President is **Masato Kanda** (succeeded Masatsugu Asakawa in February 2025).
- Largest Borrower: **India** is the largest sovereign portfolio borrower of ADB.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who is the President of the Asian Development Bank (ADB)?" → **Masato Kanda**.

[MS-126] **Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) India Engagements**

- **India's Apex Shareholding:** India is the **second-largest shareholder** in AIIB with an **8.36% shareholding (7.6% voting power)**, trailing only China (26.6% voting power).
- **Flagship Project Sanctions:**
  - Co-financing **Chennai Metro Rail Project Phase 2** ($356.67 Million).
  - Financing private sector renewable energy through Tata Cleantech Capital and green transmission corridors.
- **Governance Anchor:** Headquartered in **Beijing, China**; President is **Jin Liqun**; operational since January 2016.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Voting Power & Shareholding: India is the **2nd largest shareholder** in AIIB (behind China).
- Headquarters: **Beijing, China** (do NOT confuse with NDB which is in Shanghai).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is India's position among the largest shareholders in the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB)?" → Second largest.

[MS-127] **New Development Bank (NDB) — GIFT City Regional Office & BRICS Funding**

- **Equitable Sovereign Ownership:** Established by BRICS nations (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa) with equal initial subscribed capital; headquartered in **Shanghai, China**; President is **Dilma Rousseff** (former President of Brazil).
- **Indian Regional Office (IRO):** NDB operationalized its **Indian Regional Office at GIFT City, Gandhinagar (Gujarat)** to accelerate sovereign and non-sovereign project preparation.
- **New Admitted Members:** NDB admitted **Bangladesh, Egypt, UAE**, and **Uruguay** as new member countries expanding beyond original BRICS founders.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- NDB Headquarters vs AIIB: NDB is headquartered in **Shanghai, China** (AIIB is in Beijing).
- Regional Office Location: NDB's India Regional Office is in **GIFT City, Gandhinagar**.
- Target MCQ Form: "In which financial hub has the New Development Bank (NDB) established its Indian Regional Office (IRO)?" → GIFT City, Gandhinagar.

[MS-128] **IFSCA: Statutory Foundation, Unified Regulatory Architecture & IFSC Banking Units (IBUs)**

- **Genesis & Statutory Super-Regulator Status:**
  - Established under the **International Financial Services Centres Authority Act, 2019** passed by Parliament; formally constituted on **April 27, 2020** and operationalized in October 2020.
  - Headquartered permanently at **GIFT City, Gandhinagar, Gujarat**.
  - **Unified Regulatory Authority:** Functions as India's single unified statutory regulator exercising the consolidated powers of **four apex domestic regulators** — Reserve Bank of India (RBI), Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI), Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI), and Pension Fund Regulatory and Development Authority (PFRDA) — within IFSC jurisdictions.

- **Institutional Composition & Board Governance:**
  - Apex leadership headed by a **Chairperson** (appointed by Central Government; tenure up to 3 years or age 65; K. Rajaraman).
  - **Governing Board Structure (9 Members):** Chairperson + 4 nominated members (1 each from RBI, SEBI, IRDAI, and PFRDA) + 2 members from the Ministry of Finance + 2 whole-time or part-time members appointed by Central Government.
- **IFSC Banking Units (IBUs) Regulatory Architecture:**
  - **Legal Status under FEMA:** An IBU is a branch of an Indian or foreign bank set up in GIFT IFSC; treated statutorily as a **person resident outside India** under the Foreign Exchange Management Act (FEMA), 1999.
  - **Minimum Regulatory Capital:** The parent bank must provide minimum capital of **$20 Million** (US Dollars) or equivalent in freely convertible currency.
  - **Statutory Reserve Exemption:** IBUs are **100% exempt from domestic Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) and Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR)** mandates of the RBI.
  - **Currency of Operation:** Transacts strictly in freely convertible foreign currencies (USD, EUR, GBP, JPY), not Indian Rupees (INR allowed only for local administrative expenses).
  - **Asset & Liability Powers:** Authorized to accept foreign currency deposits from non-residents and eligible residents (under LRS), arrange External Commercial Borrowings (ECBs), and underwrite global syndicated loans.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Unified Regulator Powers: Replaces **RBI, SEBI, IRDAI, and PFRDA** inside IFSCs (consolidating 4 regulators into 1).
- Governing Law & HQ: **IFSCA Act, 2019**; HQ at **GIFT City, Gandhinagar, Gujarat**.
- Board Composition: **Chairperson + 9 members** (includes 1 nominee each from RBI, SEBI, IRDAI, PFRDA).
- IBU Capital & Reserve Exemption: Parent bank minimum capital = **$20 Million**; IBUs are **completely exempt from CRR and SLR**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which statutory authority acts as the single unified regulator replacing RBI, SEBI, IRDAI, and PFRDA in GIFT City?" → **International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA)**.

[MS-129] **GIFT City IFSC Regulatory Milestones: Single Window SWITS & Direct Listing**

- **IFSCA Unified Portal (SWITS):** International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA) launched the **Single Window IT System (SWITS)** for seamless registration, licensing, and compliance for global financial institutions.
- **Direct Listing of Indian Companies:** Ministry of Finance and IFSCA operationalized the framework permitting **unlisted and listed Indian public companies to issue and list their equity shares directly on GIFT-IFSC stock exchanges** (India INX and NSE IX).
- **Global In-House Centres (GICs):** Over 120 global banking, insurance, and fintech back-offices and treasury centers established operations in GIFT City enjoying a 10-year 100% tax holiday under Section 80LA.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Stock Exchanges in IFSC: **India INX** (BSE subsidiary) and **NSE IX** (NSE subsidiary).
- Tax Holiday: GIFT IFSC units receive a **100% tax exemption for 10 consecutive years** out of 15 years.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which unified portal was launched by the IFSCA to streamline registration and regulatory approvals in GIFT City?" → SWITS (Single Window IT System).

[MS-130] **Foreign Universities Establishing Autonomous Campuses in GIFT City**

- **First Foreign University in India: Deakin University (Australia)** became the **world's first foreign university** to establish an operational international branch campus in India at GIFT City, Gandhinagar.
- **Second Australian Entrant: University of Wollongong (Australia)** followed Deakin, launching specialized postgraduate programs in Computing, Finance, and FinTech.
- **Regulatory Autonomy:** Regulated directly by IFSCA (exempt from UGC/AICTE domestic curriculum restrictions); allowed to repatriate earnings abroad without foreign exchange friction.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- First Foreign University: **Deakin University, Australia** (NOT Wollongong, Harvard, or Oxford).
- Regulatory Authority: Regulated by **IFSCA**, not UGC (University Grants Commission).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which foreign university became the first in the world to open an international branch campus in India at GIFT City?" → Deakin University (Australia).

[MS-131] **India International Bullion Exchange (IIBX) & Direct Gold Imports**

- **Sovereign Bullion Gateway:** Located in GIFT City; established as India's sole gateway for institutional bullion trading and physical delivery vaults.
- **Direct Import by Qualified Jewellers (QJs):** RBI and DGFT permitted eligible domestic jewellery manufacturers (Qualified Jewellers) to **import gold directly through IIBX**, bypassing intermediary nominated banks and reducing procurement premiums.
- **India-UAE CEPA Bullion Integration:** Enabled import of gold under the Tariff Rate Quota (TRQ) of 140 tonnes through IIBX with a **1% concessional customs duty duty-benefit** under the India-UAE CEPA.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Duty Concession under CEPA: **1% duty concession** on gold imported through IIBX under TRQ.
- Direct Importers: Regulated entities authorized to trade directly are called **Qualified Jewellers (QJs)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which entity serves as the statutory sole international exchange for physical bullion trading and direct gold imports into India?" → IIBX (India International Bullion Exchange).

[MS-132] **India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC)**

- **Historic Multilateral Genesis:** Signed on the sidelines of the **G20 New Delhi Summit** via an MoU between India, USA, UAE, Saudi Arabia, France, Germany, Italy, and the European Union.
- **Dual Corridor Architecture:**
  - *Eastern Corridor*: Connecting Indian maritime ports (Mundra, Kandla, JNPT) to Arabian Gulf ports (Jebel Ali, Fujairah).
  - *Northern Corridor*: Connecting Arabian Gulf ports via high-speed railway networks through UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Jordan to Israeli port of Haifa, and onward to European ports (Piraeus, Greece).
- **Strategic Triad Infrastructure:** Beyond freight rail and shipping lanes, IMEC integrates an electricity cable grid, a high-capacity clean hydrogen export pipeline, and high-speed digital fiber-optic cables.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Founding Forum: Launched during the **G20 New Delhi Leaders' Summit** (September 2023).
- Non-Signatories: Neither China nor Turkey are signatories to the IMEC pact.
- Target MCQ Form: "On the sidelines of which international summit was the historic India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) MoU signed?" → G20 New Delhi Summit.

[MS-133] **India-EFTA Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA)**

- **Historic European Free Trade Accord:** Signed between India and the 4-nation **European Free Trade Association (EFTA)** comprising **Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, and Liechtenstein**.
- **First-of-its-Kind $100 Billion Investment Commitment:** EFTA nations committed legally to invest **$100 Billion in India over 15 years** (generating over 1 million direct jobs) as a reciprocal condition for tariff concessions.
- **Tariff Phase-Out Scope:** India provided tariff concessions on 82.7% of its tariff lines covering Swiss watches, machinery, precision instruments, and chocolates (excluding domestic agriculture and dairy sectors).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- EFTA Member Nations: **Switzerland, Norway, Iceland, Liechtenstein** (EFTA is separate from the European Union).
- Investment Commitment: **$100 Billion over 15 years** (not $50B or $200B).
- Target MCQ Form: "How much foreign direct investment has the European Free Trade Association (EFTA) legally committed to inject into India over 15 years under the TEPA pact?" → $100 Billion.

[MS-134] **India-UAE Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA) & LCS**

- **Local Currency Settlement (LCS) System:** Operationalized direct bilateral trade settlement in **Indian Rupee (INR) and UAE Dirham (AED)**, bypassing USD intermediation.
- **Payment Linkages:** Integrated India's UPI with UAE's **Aani/Jaywan** instant payment system and linked national card switches (RuPay and Jaywan).
- **Bilateral Investment Treaty (BIT):** Formally signed the India-UAE Bilateral Investment Treaty in Abu Dhabi, replacing the older Bilateral Investment Promotion and Protection Agreement (BIPPA).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- UAE Domestic Card System: UAE's sovereign domestic card switch linked with RuPay is **Jaywan**.
- Currencies: Bilateral trade settled directly in **INR and AED**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which domestic payment card network of the UAE has been integrated with India's RuPay network?" → Jaywan.

[MS-135] **BRICS Historic Expansion — Five New Sovereign Entrants**

- **Expansion Milestone:** On **January 1, 2024**, BRICS officially inducted **five new full members: Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, Saudi Arabia**, and the **United Arab Emirates (UAE)**.
- **Argentina's Sovereign Rejection:** Argentina was formally invited during the 15th Johannesburg Summit but newly elected President Javier Milei formally declined membership.
- **16th BRICS Summit Host:** The 16th BRICS Annual Summit hosted in **Kazan, Russia** under the 2024 Russian Presidency with the theme of strengthening multilateralism and sovereign currency settlement.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Declined Country: **Argentina** declined the official invitation to join BRICS.
- Summit City: 16th BRICS Summit held in **Kazan, Russia**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which country officially withdrew from joining the expanded BRICS bloc on January 1, 2024 despite receiving an official invitation?" → Argentina.

[MS-136] **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Summit: Belarus Admitted as 10th Member**

- **Astana Summit 2024:** Held in **Astana, Kazakhstan** under Kazakh presidency with the theme *'Strengthening Multilateral Dialogue — Striving Towards Sustainable Peace and Prosperity'*.
- **Tenth Full Member State: Belarus** was formally admitted as the **10th full member state** of the SCO (joining India, China, Russia, Pakistan, Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan, and Iran).
- **Astana Declaration:** Emphasized non-interference in internal affairs, multi-currency trade settlements, and opposition to unilateral economic sanctions.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- 10th Member: **Belarus** is the 10th full member of SCO (Iran was the 9th member inducted in 2023).
- Summit Venue: 2024 SCO Summit was held in **Astana, Kazakhstan**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which nation was formally inducted as the 10th full member state of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) at the 2024 Astana Summit?" → Belarus.

[MS-137] **India–New Zealand Free Trade Agreement (FTA): 100% Duty-Free Access & US$20B Investment**

- **Operational Date:** Formally takes effect on **October 20, 2026** (signed April 27, 2026).
- **Tariff-Free Access:** Grants **100% duty-free access** for Indian exports entering New Zealand, eliminating peak 10% tariffs on autos, auto components, ceramics, textiles, and carpets.
- **Investment Pillar:** New Zealand committed to invest **US$20 Billion in India over 15 years** in agri-tech, cold-chains, and green energy.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Enforcement: **October 20, 2026**.
- Tariffs: **100% duty-free entry** for Indian goods.
- Investment: **US$20 Billion over 15 years**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the India–New Zealand FTA, what is New Zealand's 15-year investment commitment in India?" → **US$20 Billion**.

[MS-138] **Maldives US$150 Million SBI T-Bill Full Repayment: India's US$45 Million Sovereign Interest Support**

- **Debt Clearance:** Maldives cleared the final **US$50 Million tranche** on September 17, 2026, completing full repayment of the **US$150 Million T-bill facility** subscribed by State Bank of India (SBI) in 2019.
- **India's Grant Assistance:** Government of India absorbed nearly **US$45 Million in interest payments** over 5 years as direct sovereign support to Male.
- **Currency Swap & Bonds:** India maintains a **₹3,000 Crore currency swap line** and holds **$350 Million in Maldivian T-Bonds** valid till 2029–2030.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Repaid Facility: **US$150 Million** (SBI subscribed 2019; final $50M cleared Sept 2026).
- India's Interest Relief: **Nearly US$45 Million** absorbed by Government of India.
- Target MCQ Form: "How much interest assistance did the Government of India absorb on the US$150M SBI T-bill facility extended to the Maldives?" → **Nearly US$45 Million**.

8. REGULATORY BODIES, ACTS, COMMITTEES & APPOINTMENTS

[MS-139] **Telecommunications Act, 2023 Enacted into Law**

- **Century-Old Law Repeal:** Formally repealed archaic colonial legislations: the **Indian Telegraph Act, 1885**, the **Indian Wireless Telegraphy Act, 1933**, and the Telegraph Wires (Unlawful Possession) Act, 1950.
- **Administrative Allocation of Satellite Spectrum:** Mandated the **administrative allocation** of satellite communication spectrum (satcom) without competitive auctioning, aligning India with global ITU standards for Starlink, Eutelsat OneWeb, and Jio Satellite.
- **Digital Bharat Nidhi:** Renamed and restructured the Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF) into **'Digital Bharat Nidhi'** to support R&D, pilot deployment, and rural broadband expansion.
- **Biometric SIM Guardrails:** Enforces mandatory biometric verification for SIM acquisition, prescribing penalties up to **₹50 Lakh and 3 years imprisonment** for fraudulent acquisition using forged identities.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Satellite Spectrum Allocation: Allocated **ADMINISTRATIVELY**, not through public auction.
- Renamed USOF: USOF was renamed to **Digital Bharat Nidhi**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under the Telecommunications Act 2023, the Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF) was renamed as which entity?" → Digital Bharat Nidhi.

[MS-140] **Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023 Regulatory Framework**

- **Statutory Genesis & DPBI:** Establishes the **Data Protection Board of India (DPBI)** as an autonomous digital adjudicatory authority to investigate breaches and impose statutory penalties.
- **Penalties Slabs:**
  - Failure to prevent significant personal data breach: Penalties up to **₹250 Crore**.
  - Failure to fulfill duties of Data Fiduciary towards children: Up to **₹200 Crore**.
  - General non-compliance penalties: Up to **₹50 Crore**.
- **Consent Architecture:** Introduces the legal concept of **'Consent Managers'** registered with the DPBI, interoperable consent withdrawal, and mandatory notice in all 22 Eighth Schedule languages.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Maximum Penalty: Maximum penalty for failing to prevent a significant data breach is **₹250 Crore** per instance.
- Adjudicating Body: Governed by the **Data Protection Board of India (DPBI)**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is the maximum financial penalty that can be imposed under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 for failure to prevent a personal data breach?" → ₹250 Crore.

[MS-141] **Criminal Justice Overhaul: BNS, BNSS & BSA Operationalization**

- **Enforcement Date:** Came into full legal effect across India on **July 1, 2024**, completely replacing the British-era penal codes.
- **Three Replaced Statutes:**
  1. **Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), 2023** replaced the Indian Penal Code (IPC), 1860.
  2. **Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS), 2023** replaced the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), 1973.
  3. **Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam (BSA), 2023** replaced the Indian Evidence Act, 1872.
- **Pioneering Legal Reforms:**
  - Introduction of **Zero FIR** (can be registered at any police station regardless of jurisdiction).
  - Mandatory **audio-video recording of search and seizure operations**.
  - Introduction of **Community Service** as a recognized punishment for petty offenses.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Enforcement Date: Enacted into law on **July 1, 2024** (not Jan 1 or April 1).
- Law Mapping: BNS = IPC; BNSS = CrPC; BSA = Evidence Act.
- Target MCQ Form: "On which date did the three new criminal laws (BNS, BNSS, and BSA) come into legal force across India?" → July 1, 2024.

[MS-142] **Sovereign Appointments: Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Leadership**

- **26th Governor of RBI: Sanjay Malhotra** (Senior IAS officer and former Revenue Secretary) appointed as the **26th Governor of the Reserve Bank of India** with effect from **December 11, 2024**, succeeding Shaktikanta Das upon completion of his extended tenure.
- **Statutory Terms:** Appointed for a period of **3 years** under Section 8(1)(a) of the RBI Act, 1934.

- **Four Deputy Governors:** RBI governance maintained with four statutory Deputy Governors: **Michael Debabrata Patra, M. Rajeshwar Rao, T. Rabi Sankar, and Swaminathan J.**

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Governor Succession: **Sanjay Malhotra** appointed as the **26th Governor** succeeding Shaktikanta Das (who was the 25th Governor).
- Effective Date: Tenure commences **December 11, 2024**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who was appointed as the 26th Governor of the Reserve Bank of India succeeding Shaktikanta Das?" → Sanjay Malhotra.

[MS-143] **State Bank of India (SBI) Leadership: Chairman C.S. Setty**

- **Apex Commercial Banking Transition:** Government appointed **Challa Sreenivasulu Setty (C.S. Setty)** as the **Chairman of State Bank of India** for a tenure of three years, succeeding **Dinesh Kumar Khara** upon his superannuation.
- **FSIB Recommendation:** Nominated by the **Financial Services Institutions Bureau (FSIB)**, the autonomous statutory body recommending board-level appointments in Public Sector Banks and financial institutions (chaired by Bhanu Pratap Sharma).
- **Career Path:** Setty previously served as Senior Managing Director of SBI overseeing Global Markets and Retail Banking.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Chairman Name: **Challa Sreenivasulu Setty (C.S. Setty)** (succeeded Dinesh Kumar Khara).
- Recommending Body: **FSIB (Financial Services Institutions Bureau)**, which replaced the Banks Board Bureau (BBB).
- Target MCQ Form: "Who succeeded Dinesh Kumar Khara as the Chairman of the State Bank of India (SBI)?" → Challa Sreenivasulu Setty.

[MS-144] **Constitutional Watchdog: Comptroller & Auditor General of India (CAG)**

- **Constitutional Appointment: K. Sanjay Murthy** (former Higher Education Secretary) appointed as the **Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG)**, succeeding Girish Chandra Murmu.
- **Constitutional Anchors:** Appointed by the President of India under **Article 148** of the Constitution of India; holds office for a term of **6 years or until attaining 65 years of age**, whichever is earlier.
- **Apex Accountability:** Serves as the guardian of the public purse and auditing authority for Consolidated Funds of the Union and States.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Constitutional Article: CAG is appointed under **Article 148** of the Constitution.
- Tenure Ceiling: Term is **6 years or up to 65 years of age**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who has been appointed as the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG) under Article 148 of the Constitution?" → K. Sanjay Murthy.

[MS-145] **High-Level Committee on 'One Nation, One Election'**

- **Committee Leadership:** Chaired by former President of India **Ram Nath Kovind**; submitted a landmark 18,626-page unanimous report to President Droupadi Murmu.
- **Two-Phase Simultaneous Election Roadmap:**
  - *Phase 1*: Synchronize elections to the **Lok Sabha and all State Legislative Assemblies** simultaneously.
  - *Phase 2*: Hold synchronized elections to local bodies (**Municipalities and Panchayats**) within **100 days** of the Lok Sabha and Assembly elections.

- **Single Electoral Roll:** Recommended amendment of Article 325 to create a single electoral roll and single voter photo identity card across all three tiers of government.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Committee Chairman: Chaired by former President **Ram Nath Kovind**.
- Local Body Window: Local body elections must be conducted within **100 days** of state/national elections.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who headed the High-Level Committee that submitted its report on the 'One Nation, One Election' simultaneous polls roadmap?" → Ram Nath Kovind.

[MS-146] **Election Commission of India (ECI) Appointments under New Act**

- **Statutory Selection Panel:** Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023 operationalized.
- **New Appointments: Gyanesh Kumar** and **Sukhbir Singh Sandhu** appointed as Election Commissioners by a selection committee comprising the Prime Minister, a Union Cabinet Minister, and the Leader of the Opposition/single largest party in Lok Sabha.
- **Apex Bench Composition:** Chief Election Commissioner **Rajiv Kumar** flanked by ECs Gyanesh Kumar and Sukhbir Singh Sandhu under **Article 324**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Newly Appointed ECs: **Gyanesh Kumar** and **Sukhbir Singh Sandhu**.
- Selection Panel Structure: Selection committee comprises PM, Cabinet Minister, and Leader of Opposition (CJI is not on the selection committee under the 2023 Act).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which two former IAS officers were appointed as Election Commissioners under the new 2023 Election Commissioners Act?" → Gyanesh Kumar and Sukhbir Singh Sandhu.

[MS-147] **Competition Commission of India (CCI) — Leniency Plus Regime**

- **Statutory Notification:** CCI notified the Competition Commission of India (Leniency Plus) Regulations, 2024 under the Competition (Amendment) Act, 2023.
- **Mechanism of Leniency Plus:** An enterprise undergoing an inquiry for an existing cartel can disclose the existence of a **second, undisclosed cartel** in an unrelated market.
- **Financial Benefit:**
  - Up to **100% penalty reduction** for the newly disclosed second cartel.
  - An additional **up to 30% reduction** in penalty for the first cartel under active investigation.
- **Leadership:** Chairperson of CCI is **Ravneet Kaur** (first woman full-time chairperson).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Leniency Plus Penalty Discounts: Additional reduction of **up to 30%** in the first cartel, up to **100%** in the second cartel.
- CCI Chairperson: **Ravneet Kaur**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Under CCI's Leniency Plus regulations, what is the maximum additional penalty reduction granted in the first cartel for disclosing a second cartel?" → Up to 30%.

[MS-148] **Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (IBBI) — Real Estate Reforms**

- **Project-Wise Insolvency Resolution:** IBBI amended Corporate Insolvency Resolution Process (CIRP) regulations to mandate **project-specific insolvency** for real estate developers, preventing un-defaulted housing projects of the same company from being dragged into bankruptcy.
- **Allotment Possession Safeguards:** Insolvency Resolution Professionals (RPs) permitted to hand over possession of completed flats/units to genuine homebuyers with CoC approval before overall resolution.

- **Regulatory Leadership:** Headquartered in New Delhi; IBBI Chairperson is **Ravi Mital**; statutory body under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC), 2016.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Key Reform: Introduced **Project-Wise Resolution** in real estate insolvency.
- IBBI Chairperson: **Ravi Mital**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which significant structural reform was introduced by IBBI to prevent stalled real estate projects from impacting unaffected solvent projects?" → Project-Wise Insolvency Resolution.

[MS-149] **NABARD Institutional Milestones & Rural Infrastructure Development Fund (RIDF)**

- **43rd Foundation Day:** Celebrated on **July 12, 2024 / 2026** (established July 12, 1982 on the recommendations of the **B. Sivaraman Committee** under Act 61 of 1981).
- **RIDF Allocation Tranche:** Rural Infrastructure Development Fund (RIDF) managed by NABARD allocated **₹40,000 Crore** annually funded out of priority sector lending shortfalls of scheduled commercial banks.
- **Apex Leadership:** NABARD Chairman is **Shaji K.V.**; 100% owned by the Government of India (after RBI divested its stake).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Founding Committee: Established on the recommendations of the **B. Sivaraman Committee** (1982).
- Ownership: NABARD is **100% owned by the Government of India** (zero RBI ownership today).
- Target MCQ Form: "On the recommendations of which committee was the National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD) established in 1982?" → B. Sivaraman Committee.

[MS-150] **Small Industries Development Bank of India (SIDBI) & Urban Infrastructure Fund (UIDF)**

- **SIDBI Mandate & SHe MAVEN Initiative:** Established on **April 2, 1990** under an Act of Parliament; Chairman and Managing Director is **Manoj Mittal**; launched 'SHe MAVEN' and direct micro-credit windows for first-generation women entrepreneurs.
- **Urban Infrastructure Development Fund (UIDF):**
  - Managed by the **National Housing Bank (NHB)** with an annual corpus of **₹10,000 Crore** from priority sector lending shortfalls.
  - Used by public agencies to create urban infrastructure in **Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities**.
  - Managing Director of NHB is **Sanjay Shukla**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- UIDF Managing Agency: UIDF is managed by **National Housing Bank (NHB)**, NOT SIDBI or HUDCO.
- UIDF City Focus: Targeted exclusively at **Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which financial institution is responsible for managing the Urban Infrastructure Development Fund (UIDF) established with an annual corpus of ₹10,000 Crore?" → National Housing Bank (NHB).

[MS-151] **Financial Action Task Force (FATF) — India's Historic Vice-Presidency Leadership**

- **Historic Leadership Breakthrough:** In June 2026, the **Financial Action Task Force (FATF)** elected and appointed India to its executive leadership as **Vice-President of FATF for a one-year term from July 2026 to June 2027**.
- **First-Ever Indian Entry:** Marks India's **first-ever accession to the FATF Vice-Presidency / Presidency hierarchy** since joining the 40-member intergovernmental body as a full member in **2010**.
- **Institutional Context & Mutual Evaluation Backing:**
  - Follows the unanimous adoption of India's **Mutual Evaluation Report (MER)** at the FATF Plenary in Singapore (June 2024), where India was placed in the highest rating tier ('Regular Follow-up' / High Compliance alongside only a handful of G20 nations).

- India plays an active role in shaping global standards on countering terrorist financing (CFT), anti-money laundering (AML), and regulating virtual digital asset (crypto) transactions.

- **FATF Institutional Profile:**
  - Established: **1989 at G7 Summit in Paris**.
  - Headquarters: **Paris, France** (at OECD headquarters).
  - Membership: 40 members (38 countries + 2 regional organizations: European Commission and GCC).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Term of Leadership: **July 2026 to June 2027** (one-year Vice-Presidency).
- Historic Context: **First-ever Indian entry** into FATF executive leadership since joining in 2010.
- Headquarters: **Paris, France** (established 1989 at G7 summit).
- Target MCQ Form: "Who was appointed to the Vice-Presidency of the Financial Action Task Force (FATF) for the term July 2026 to June 2027, marking the country's first-ever entry into the body's leadership?" → India.

9. GLOBAL INDICES, BENCHMARK REPORTS & HONOURS

[MS-152] **Global Innovation Index (GII) 2024 — WIPO Rankings**

- **India's Global Ascent:** India climbed to the **39th rank** among 133 economies in the Global Innovation Index 2024, published annually by the **World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO)** in Geneva.
- **Regional & Income Leadership:** Ranked **1st among 10 economies in Central and Southern Asia** and **1st among lower-middle-income economies** globally.
- **Top 3 Economies: Switzerland** ranked 1st (for the 14th consecutive year), followed by **Sweden (2nd)** and the **United States (3rd)**.
- **Pillar Outperformance:** India retained world-leading ranks in ICT services exports (1st globally), venture capital received, and domestic market scale.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Publishing Body: Published by **WIPO (World Intellectual Property Organization)**, NOT World Bank or WEF.
- India's Rank: India is ranked **39th** (up from 40th in 2023).
- Target MCQ Form: "What is India's rank in the Global Innovation Index (GII) 2024 published by WIPO?" → 39th.

[MS-153] **Global Gender Gap Report 2024 — World Economic Forum (WEF)**

- **India's Rank Position:** India ranked **129th out of 146 countries** with an overall gender parity score of 64.1%, published by the **World Economic Forum (WEF)** in Geneva.
- **Sub-Index Disparities:** Scored highest in Educational Attainment and Political Empowerment, but lagged severely in Economic Participation and Opportunity (142nd) and Health and Survival.
- **Global Leader: Iceland** ranked 1st as the most gender-equal country for the 15th consecutive year (closing >93% of its gender gap), followed by Finland (2nd) and Norway (3rd).
- **South Asian Neighbors:** Bangladesh ranked highest in South Asia at 99th, while Pakistan (145th) and Sudan (146th) anchored the bottom.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Rank: Ranked **129th out of 146 countries**.
- Global No. 1: **Iceland** retained 1st rank for the 15th consecutive year.
- Target MCQ Form: "According to the World Economic Forum's Global Gender Gap Report 2024, what is India's rank among 146 evaluated nations?" → 129th.

[MS-154] **Human Development Index (HDI) — UNDP Human Development Report**

- **India's Standing:** India ranked **134th out of 193 countries** with an HDI score of **0.644**, placing it firmly in the **Medium Human Development** category.
- **Three Dimensions & Four Indicators:**
  1. *Long and Healthy Life*: Life expectancy at birth in India improved to **67.7 years**.
  2. *Knowledge*: Expected years of schooling reached **12.6 years**; Mean years of schooling stood at **6.57 years**.
  3. *Decent Standard of Living*: Gross National Income (GNI) per capita (2017 PPP $) stood at **$6,951**.
- **Global Benchmark: Switzerland** ranked 1st globally (HDI 0.967), followed by Norway (2nd) and Iceland (3rd).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's HDI Value & Rank: Rank is **134th**; HDI value is **0.644** (Medium category).
- Life Expectancy Figure: Life expectancy at birth in India is **67.7 years**.
- Target MCQ Form: "What is India's rank in the Human Development Index (HDI) report published by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)?" → 134th.

[MS-155] **World Press Freedom Index 2024 — Reporters Without Borders (RSF)**

- **India's Ranking:** India ranked **159th out of 180 countries** (score 31.28) in the annual index published by Paris-based **Reporters Without Borders (Reporters Sans Frontières - RSF)**.
- **Global Podium: Norway** ranked 1st for the 8th consecutive year, followed by Denmark (2nd) and Sweden (3rd).
- **Worst Ranked Nation: Eritrea (180th)** ranked at the absolute bottom, replacing North Korea (179th).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Rank: Ranked **159th out of 180** (improved marginally from 161st in 2023).
- Publisher: Published by **Reporters Without Borders (RSF)**, headquartered in Paris.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which country topped the World Press Freedom Index 2024 published by Reporters Without Borders for the eighth consecutive year?" → Norway.

[MS-156] **World Happiness Report 2024 — UN SDSN Assessment**

- **India's Ranking:** India ranked **126th out of 143 evaluated countries** with an average life evaluation score of 4.054.
- **Publishing Agency:** Released by the **UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network (SDSN)** in partnership with Gallup and the Oxford Wellbeing Research Centre.
- **Happiest Nation: Finland** crowned the world's happiest country for the **7th consecutive year**, followed by Denmark (2nd), Iceland (3rd), and Sweden (4th).
- **Least Happy Nation: Afghanistan** remained at the bottom (143rd rank).

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- India's Rank: Ranked **126th out of 143** countries.
- Happiest Nation Consecutive Streak: **Finland** has won for **7 consecutive years**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which nation was ranked as the world's happiest country for the seventh consecutive year in the World Happiness Report 2024?" → Finland.

[MS-157] **SIPRI Global Military Expenditure Report 2024**

- **India's Global Standing:** India was ranked as the **4th largest military spender in the world** in 2023–24, with total defence outlays reaching **$83.6 Billion** (up 4.2% year-on-year), published by Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI).
- **Top 5 Military Spenders:**

1. **United States:** $916 Billion (accounts for 37% of global total).
2. **China:** $296 Billion.
3. **Russia:** $109 Billion.
4. **India:** $83.6 Billion.
5. **Saudi Arabia:** $75.8 Billion.

- **Global Military Outlay:** Surpassed an all-time record of **$2.44 Trillion**, driven by geopolitical conflicts in Eastern Europe and the Middle East.

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> - India's Rank & Amount: India is **4th largest spender** ($83.6 Billion).
> - Top 3 Order: 1st USA, 2nd China, 3rd Russia, 4th India.
> - Target MCQ Form: "According to the latest SIPRI report, what is India's global rank in terms of military expenditure?" → 4th.

[MS-158] **LSEG Global Green Economy Report: India Generates US$110 Billion in Green Revenues**

- **Global Sustainable Leadership:** According to the benchmark *Global Green Revenues* study released by the **London Stock Exchange Group (LSEG)**, Indian enterprises generated approximately **US$110 billion (approx. ₹9.24 lakh crore) in green revenues** during 2025.
- **Leading Contributing Verticals:**
  - Utility-scale renewable solar and wind energy generation.
  - Electric mobility (EV manufacturing and charging network infrastructure).
  - Energy-efficient industrial machinery, green hydrogen tech, and smart grid components.
- **Global Standing:** Positions India among the world's leading emerging-market green economy powerhouses, accelerating corporate decarbonization ahead of national COP commitments.

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> - Publishing Entity: **London Stock Exchange Group (LSEG)**.
> - Quantum of Green Revenues: Approximately **US$110 Billion**.
> - Target MCQ Form: "According to a study by the London Stock Exchange Group (LSEG), what was the approximate volume of green revenues generated by Indian firms?" → US$110 Billion.

[MS-159] **NITI Aayog Releases 8th Trade Watch Quarterly: India's Export Pivot Towards Asia & Africa**

- **Institutional Trade Diagnostics:** NITI Aayog released the **8th edition of its Trade Watch Quarterly**, evaluating India's post-pandemic trade trajectory and geopolitical tariff realignments.
- **Geographical Pivot:**
  - Highlights a structural shift in India's merchandise export footprint towards **Asia, Africa, and Latin America**, reducing historical over-reliance on traditional EU and North American markets.
  - Driven by the operationalization of CEPA/ECTA trade agreements and strong outbound shipments of engineering goods, electronics, and specialty active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs).

> **EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS**
>
> - Publishing Body: **NITI Aayog** (8th edition of Trade Watch Quarterly).
> - Core Finding: Structural trade diversification toward **Asia and Africa**.

[MS-160] **70th National Film Awards 2024 — Apex Cultural Honours**

- **54th Dadasaheb Phalke Award:** Conferred upon legendary cinema icon **Mithun Chakraborty** for his iconic lifetime contribution to Indian cinema.

- **Feature Film Honors:**
  - *Best Feature Film*: **Aattam** (The Play) — Malayalam drama directed by Anand Ekarshi.
  - *Best Actor*: **Rishab Shetty** for his performance in *Kantara* (Kannada).
  - *Best Actress (Shared)*: **Nithya Menen** for *Thiruchitrambalam* (Tamil) and **Manasi Parekh** for *Kutch Express* (Gujarati).
  - *Best Director*: **Sooraj R. Barjatya** for *Uunchai* (Hindi).
  - *Best Film in Wholesome Entertainment*: **Kantara**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Dadasaheb Phalke Awardee: **Mithun Chakraborty** (54th recipient; Waheeda Rehman was 53rd).
- Best Feature Film: **Aattam** (Malayalam), NOT Kantara or RRR.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who was conferred the prestigious 54th Dadasaheb Phalke Award at the 70th National Film Awards?" → Mithun Chakraborty.

[MS-161] **Ramon Magsaysay Awards 2024 ('Nobel Prize of Asia')**

- **66th Edition Laureates:** Presented annually by the Ramon Magsaysay Award Foundation in Manila, Philippines; five distinguished laureates honored:
  1. **Karma Phuntsho (Bhutan):** Former monk and scholar honored for preserving Bhutanese cultural heritage through the Loden Foundation.
  2. **Hayao Miyazaki (Japan):** Legendary animator and Studio Ghibli co-founder honored for environmental and pacifist storytelling through animation.
  3. **Farwiza Farhan (Indonesia):** Forest activist leading community protection of Sumatra's Leuser Ecosystem.
  4. **Rural Doctors Movement (Thailand):** Network of physicians advocating universal healthcare access in impoverished rural provinces.
  5. **Dr. Nguyen Thi Ngoc Phuong (Vietnam):** Physician honored for caring for victims of chemical Agent Orange defoliant.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Japanese Animator: **Hayao Miyazaki** (Studio Ghibli) received the 2024 Ramon Magsaysay Award.
- Bhutanese Laureate: **Karma Phuntsho** (Loden Foundation).
- Target MCQ Form: "Which world-renowned Japanese animator and co-founder of Studio Ghibli was conferred the Ramon Magsaysay Award 2024?" → Hayao Miyazaki.

[MS-162] **Abel Prize 2024 — Mathematics Apex Honor**

- **Laureate:** Awarded to French mathematician **Michel Talagrand** by the Norwegian Academy of Science and Letters.
- **Citation:** Honored *"for his groundbreaking contributions to probability theory and stochastic processes, with outstanding applications in mathematical physics and statistics"*.
- **Administering Body:** Established in honor of Niels Henrik Abel; carries a cash prize of **7.5 Million Norwegian Kroner (NOK)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Prize Discipline: Abel Prize is universally regarded as the **"Nobel Prize of Mathematics"** (since Nobel does not award Mathematics).
- Laureate: French mathematician **Michel Talagrand**.
- Target MCQ Form: "Who was awarded the prestigious Abel Prize 2024 for groundbreaking contributions to probability theory?" → Michel Talagrand.

[MS-163] **International Booker Prize 2024 — Literary Triumph**

- **Winning Novel:** Awarded to German author **Jenny Erpenbeck** and translator **Michael Hofmann** for the novel ***Kairos***.
- **Historic Literary Milestones:**
  - Jenny Erpenbeck became the **first German writer** to win the International Booker Prize.
  - Michael Hofmann became the **first male translator** to win the prize.
- **Narrative Context:** Chronicles the destructive romantic entanglement between an older writer and an architecture student in East Berlin before and after the collapse of the Berlin Wall in 1989.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Book Title: ***Kairos*** by Jenny Erpenbeck (translated by Michael Hofmann).
- Nationality Milestone: Jenny Erpenbeck is the **first German writer** to win the International Booker Prize.
- Target MCQ Form: "Which novel won the International Booker Prize 2024, making its author Jenny Erpenbeck the first German writer to achieve this honour?" → Kairos.

[MS-164] **Environmental Performance Index (EPI) 2026 — Yale/Columbia Component Framework**

- **Institutional Architecture & Methodology:** Published biennially by the **Yale Center for Environmental Law & Policy** and **Columbia University's Center for International Earth Science Information Network (CIESIN)**; evaluates **180 countries** across 58 performance indicators.
- **The Three Core Policy Objectives & India's Ranks:**
  - **1. Environmental Health:** Measures protection of human health from environmental hazards (air quality, sanitation & drinking water, heavy metals, waste management). India ranked **174th out of 180 countries**.
  - **2. Ecosystem Vitality:** Measures ecosystem health, conservation of natural resources, biodiversity & habitat protection, forests, fisheries, and agricultural sustainability. India ranked **171st out of 180 countries**.
  - **3. Climate Change Mitigation:** Evaluates greenhouse gas emissions trajectories, net-zero commitment pace, and carbon intensity of economic growth. India ranked **130th out of 180 countries**.
- **India's Overall Placement:** India was placed **176th overall** with an aggregate score of 27.6, reflecting severe pressures in urban air quality and biodiversity loss, while outperforming its aggregate score on renewable capacity ramp-up.
- **Global Leaders: Estonia** ranked 1st globally, followed by **Denmark (2nd)** and the **United Kingdom (3rd)**.

EXAM ANGLE & MULTI-STATEMENT PITFALLS

- Publishers: **Yale University & Columbia University**.
- The 3 Sub-Objective Ranks for India:
  - Environmental Health: **174th**.
  - Ecosystem Vitality: **171st**.
  - Climate Change: **130th**.

Overall Rank: **176th / 180**.

Target MCQ Form: "Under the Environmental Performance Index (EPI), what was India's rank under the Environmental Health and Ecosystem Vitality objectives?" → 174th and 171st respectively.

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10. CURATED HIGH-YIELD STRIKE GRIDS: SCHEMES, SPORTS, DAYS & STATIC ANCHORS

Strike Grid 1: Apex Sports Championships 2024

Championship / Tournament	Champion / Winner	Runner-Up	Venue / Host Country	Critical High-Yield Detail
ICC Men's T20 World Cup 2024	**India** (won by 7 runs)	South Africa	Kensington Oval, Bridgetown, Barbados	• India won 2nd T20 World Cup title (first in 2007 under MS Dhoni) • Player of the Tournament: **Jasprit Bumrah** (15 wickets, 4.17 econ) • Player of the Match (Final): **Virat Kohli** (76 runs off 59 balls) • Rohit Sharma & Virat Kohli announced retirement from T20Is
Paris Olympic Games 2024	**United States** (40 Gold, 126 Total)	China (40 Gold, 91 Total)	Paris, France (Motto: *Games Wide Open*)	• India finished **71st with 6 medals (1 Silver, 5 Bronze)** • **Neeraj Chopra:** Silver (Men's Javelin, 89.45m; Arshad Nadeem won Gold with 92.97m Olympic record) • **Manu Bhaker:** Two Bronze medals (10m Air Pistol & 10m Air Pistol Mixed with Sarabjot Singh) — 1st athlete in independent India to win 2 medals at a single Olympics • **Swapnil Kusale:** Bronze (Men's 50m Rifle 3 Positions) • **Aman Sehrawat:** Bronze (Men's Freestyle 57kg Wrestling) — youngest Indian individual Olympic medalist (21y 24d) • **Indian Men's Hockey Team:** Bronze (defeated Spain 2-1; PR Sreejesh retirement)
Paris Paralympic Games 2024	**China** (94 Gold, 220 Total)	Great Britain	Paris, France	• India achieved historic best: **18th rank with 29 medals (7 Gold, 9 Silver, 13 Bronze)** • Flagbearers: Sumit Antil and Bhagyashree Jadhav (Opening); Harvinder Singh and Preethi Pal (Closing) • **Harvinder Singh:** Gold in Men's Individual Recurve Archery (1st archery Gold for India) • **Avani Lekhara:** Gold in Women's 10m Air Rifle Standing SH1 (retained Tokyo Gold) • **Sumit Antil:** Gold in Men's Javelin F64 (retained Tokyo Gold, 70.59m record) • **Sheetal Devi & Rakesh Kumar:** Bronze in Mixed Team Compound Archery (Sheetal became youngest Paralympic medalist at 17 years)
FIDE Candidates Tournament 2024	**D. Gukesh** (India)	Hikaru Nakamura / Ian Nepomniachtchi	Toronto, Canada	• At **17 years old**, Gukesh became the **youngest ever challenger** in world chess history to qualify for the World Chess Championship match against Ding Liren • Second Indian after Viswanathan Anand to win Candidates
Wimbledon Championships 2024	**Carlos Alcaraz** (Men's Singles, Spain) **Barbora Krejčíková** (Women's, Czech Rep)	Novak Djokovic (Serbia) Jasmine Paolini (Italy)	All England Club, London	• Alcaraz won back-to-back Wimbledon titles (def. Djokovic 6-2, 6-2, 7-6) • Krejcikova won 2nd Grand Slam singles title
UEFA Euro 2024	**Spain** (won 2-1)	England	Olympiastadion, Berlin, Germany	• Spain won record **4th European Championship** title • Player of Tournament: Rodri; Young Player of Tournament: Lamine Yamal

Strike Grid 2: Must-Know International Days & Statutory Themes (Jan–Sept)

Date	Observance / Event	Sovereign Theme / Core Examiner Detail
January 24	**National Girl Child Day** & **International Day of Education**	Theme: *"Learning for Lasting Peace"*; instituted by MoWCD in 2008 to celebrate Beti Bachao Beti Padhao milestones.
January 25	**National Voters' Day (NVD)**	Theme: *"Nothing Like Voting, I Vote for Sure"*; marks the foundation day of Election Commission of India (established Jan 25, 1950).
February 2	**World Wetlands Day**	Theme: *"Wetlands and Human Wellbeing"*; marks signing of Ramsar Convention in Ramsar, Iran on Feb 2, 1971.
February 28	**National Science Day**	Theme: *"Indigenous Technologies for Viksit Bharat"*; commemorates discovery of the **Raman Effect** by Sir C.V. Raman (Feb 28, 1928, Nobel Prize 1930).
March 8	**International Women's Day**	UN Theme: *"Invest in Women: Accelerate Progress"*; campaign theme: #InspireInclusion.
March 15	**World Consumer Rights Day**	Theme: *"Fair and Responsible AI for Consumers"*; National Consumer Day in India is celebrated on December 24 (Consumer Protection Act 1986).
April 7	**World Health Day**	Theme: *"My Health, My Right"*; marks the founding of the World Health Organization (WHO) on April 7, 1948 in Geneva.
April 22	**Earth Day**	Theme: *"Planet vs. Plastics"*; advocates 60% reduction in production of all plastics by 2040.
May 31	**World No Tobacco Day**	Theme: *"Protecting Children from Tobacco Industry Interference"*; WHO award winner: Meghalaya.
June 5	**World Environment Day**	Theme: *"Land Restoration, Desertification and Drought Resilience"*; Global Host Nation: **Kingdom of Saudi Arabia**.
June 21	**International Day of Yoga (IDY)**	Theme: *"Yoga for Self and Society"*; **10th Edition** of IDY; Prime Minister led national celebrations at SKICC, Srinagar (Jammu & Kashmir).
July 11	**World Population Day**	Theme: *"Leave No One Behind, Count Everyone"*; established by UNDP Governing Council in 1989.
July 12	**NABARD Foundation Day**	43rd Foundation Day; established July 12, 1982 on recommendations of B. Sivaraman Committee.
July 29	**International Tiger Day**	Global Tiger Day; India houses **3,682 tigers** (75% of global wild tiger population); Project Tiger launched April 1, 1973.
August 12	**International Youth Day**	Theme: *"From Clicks to Progress: Youth Digital Pathways for Sustainable Development"*; National Youth Day is Jan 12 (Swami Vivekananda birth).
August 23	**National Space Day (1st Celebration)**	Theme: *"Touching Lives while Touching the Moon: India's Space Saga"*; commemorates historic soft-landing of **Chandrayaan-3 Vikram lander on Shiv Shakti Point** at Moon's South Pole (August 23, 2023).
August 29	**National Sports Day (Rashtriya Khel Divas)**	Celebrates birth anniversary of hockey wizard **Major Dhyan Chand** (born August 29, 1905 in Prayagraj).
September 8	**International Literacy Day**	Theme: *"Promoting Multilingual Education: Literacy for Mutual Understanding and Peace"*.
September 16	**World Ozone Day**	Theme: *"Montreal Protocol: Advancing Climate Action"*; commemorates Montreal Protocol signing (1987).
September 27	**World Tourism Day**	Theme: *"Tourism and Peace"*; Global Host Country: **Georgia**; UN Tourism headquarters located in Madrid, Spain.

Strike Grid 3: Sovereign UNESCO Sites & Ramsar Wetland Additions

Category	Newly Designated Asset / Site	Location (State)	Critical Fact Discipline & Examiner Traps
43rd UNESCO World Heritage Site	**Moidams — The Mound-Burial System of the Ahom Dynasty**	Charaideo, **Assam**	• Inscribed at the 46th World Heritage Committee session in New Delhi (India hosted for the 1st time) • **First cultural World Heritage site from North-East India** (Kaziranga and Manas are natural sites) • India now houses **43 UNESCO World Heritage Sites** (35 Cultural, 7 Natural, 1 Mixed - Khangchendzonga)
85 Ramsar Sites Tally (Expanded)	• **Nanjarayan Bird Sanctuary** • **Kazhuveli Bird Sanctuary**	**Tamil Nadu**	• India expanded its total tally of Ramsar Wetlands of International Importance to **85 Sites** • **Tamil Nadu holds the highest number of Ramsar sites (16 sites)**, followed by **Uttar Pradesh (10 sites)**
Ramsar Additions (Karnataka)	• **Magadi Kere Conservation Reserve** • **Ankasamudra Bird Conservation Reserve** • **Aghanashini Estuary**	**Karnataka**	• Karnataka added 3 Ramsar sites simultaneously; takes state total to 4 sites.
Ramsar Additions (Madhya Pradesh)	• **Tawa Reservoir**	**Madhya Pradesh** (Narmadapuram)	• Located inside Satpura Tiger Reserve; created by damming Tawa and Denwa rivers.

Strike Grid 4: Bilateral Defence Exercises & Indigenous Strategic Platforms

Exercise / Asset	Partner Nations / Armed Force	Location / Base	Strategic Significance & Examiner Angle
Exercise Tarang Shakti 2024	**Multinational Air Exercise** (hosted by Indian Air Force)	Phase 1: **Sulur, Tamil Nadu** Phase 2: **Jodhpur, Rajasthan**	• **Largest multinational air exercise ever hosted by India** • Joined by air forces from Germany, France, Spain, UK (Phase 1) and USA, Australia, Japan, UAE, Singapore (Phase 2) • Deployed indigenous Tejas LCA, Prachand LCH, and Sukhoi Su-30MKI
Exercise MILAN 2024	**Multilateral Naval Exercise** (50+ navies)	**Visakhapatnam, Andhra Pradesh** ('City of Destiny')	• 12th edition; theme: *"Camaraderie, Cohesion, Collaboration"* • Conducted dual-carrier operations featuring INS Vikramaditya and INS Vikrant
Exercise Malabar 2024	**Quad Navies** (India, USA, Japan, Australia)	Bay of Bengal / Visakhapatnam	• Trilateral/Quad high-end anti-submarine warfare and air defence exercises.
Exercise Nomadic Elephant 2024	**India & Mongolia**	Umroi, Meghalaya	• 16th edition of bilateral military exercise focusing on counter-insurgency operations.
Exercise Dharma Guardian 2024	**India & Japan**	Mahajan Field Firing Ranges, Rajasthan	• 5th edition between Indian Army and Japan Ground Self-Defense Force (JGSDF).
Exercise Maitree 2024	**India & Thailand**	Fort Wachiraprakan, Tak Province, Thailand	• Bilateral army exercise enhancing tactical interoperability in jungle warfare.
INS Arighaat (SSBN 81)	**Indian Navy** (Commissioned August 29, 2024)	Visakhapatnam	• India's **second indigenous nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarine (SSBN)** after INS Arihant • Bolsters India's survivable nuclear triad second-strike capability under Strategic Forces Command
Zorawar Light Tank	**DRDO & Larsen & Toubro (L&T)**	High-altitude desert trials	• 25-tonne light tank designed specifically for mountain warfare in Eastern Ladakh against PLA Type 15 tanks.

Strike Grid 5: Static Banking & Financial Regulatory Anchors

Statutory / Prudential Metric	Statutory Basis / Governing Framework	Mandatory Regulatory Benchmark	Examiner Trap & Distractor Matrix
RBI Nationalisation	RBI (Transfer to Public Ownership) Act, 1948	**January 1, 1949**	• Established on **April 1, 1935** under RBI Act 1934 based on **Hilton Young Commission** (Royal Commission on Indian Currency and Finance). • Trap: Do not confuse establishment date (1935) with nationalisation date (1949).
Bank Nationalisation Waves	Banking Companies (Acquisition & Transfer of Undertakings) Acts	• **1st Wave: July 19, 1969** (14 banks, deposit floor ₹50 Crore) • **2nd Wave: April 15, 1980** (6 banks, deposit floor ₹200 Crore)	• Trap: 14 banks in 1969; 6 banks in 1980. • Deposit floor was ₹50 Cr in 1969 and ₹200 Cr in 1980.
Basel III Capital Adequacy (CRAR)	RBI Master Circular on Basel III Capital Regulations	• **Minimum CET1:** 5.5% • **Minimum Tier 1 Capital:** 7.0% • **Minimum Total CRAR:** 9.0% (PSBs maintain 12%) • **Capital Conservation Buffer (CCB):** 2.5% (all CET1) • **Minimum Total Capital + CCB: 11.5%**	• Minimum CRAR alone is 9.0%, but Total Capital + CCB is **11.5%**. • Global Basel III baseline CRAR is 8.0%, but RBI mandates **9.0%** for Indian banks.
Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) Framework	RBI Master Direction on PCA for Scheduled Commercial Banks	**Three Trigger Parameters:** 1. **Capital (CRAR / CET1)**, 2. **Asset Quality (Net NPA Ratio >6.0%)**, 3. **Leverage (Tier 1 Leverage Ratio)**	• Return on Assets (RoA) was removed as a PCA trigger. • NBFCs are also covered under a dedicated PCA framework (effective Oct 2022).
Money Market Tenures	RBI Master Direction — Money Market Instruments	• **Call Money:** Overnight (1 Day) • **Notice Money: 2 Days to 14 Days** • **Term Money: 15 Days to 1 Year**	• Trap: Notice Money is 2 to 14 days (examiners frequently test notice money upper limit = 14 days).
Lead Bank Scheme	Gadgil Study Group (1969) & Nariman Committee (1969)	• District Credit Plans (DCP) • **Target Credit-Deposit (CD) Ratio: 60%**	• Recommended by Nariman Committee. • Monitored at district level by Lead District Manager (LDM) and DLCC.
DICGC Deposit Insurance	Deposit Insurance and Credit Guarantee Corporation Act, 1961	• **Statutory Coverage: ₹5,00,000 (₹5 Lakh)** per depositor per bank (Principal + Interest combined across all branches) • **Premium: 12 paise per ₹100** deposit per annum (borne 100% by the bank) • **Section 18A Payout:** 90-day interim payout rule (Bank submits depositor list within 45 days; DICGC verifies claims within 30 days of receipt; payment made within subsequent 15 days; statutory breakdown: 45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days)	• Covers Commercial, RRB, Local Area, and Cooperative Banks. • Excludes foreign government deposits, central/state government deposits, and inter-bank deposits. • Trap: ₹5 Lakh limit applies per bank, not per branch or account.
Payment Systems Windows & Limits	Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 (PSS Act)	• **RTGS:** Minimum **₹2,00,000 (₹2 Lakh)**; No maximum limit; 24x7x365 • **NEFT:** Minimum **₹1**; No maximum limit; 24x7x365 (half-hourly batches) • **IMPS:** Capped at **₹5,00,000 (₹5 Lakh)** per day • **UPI:** Standard **₹1,00,000**; **₹5,00,000** for Hospital/Educational/Tax/IPO/RBI Retail Direct	• RTGS minimum floor is ₹2 Lakh (NEFT has no minimum floor). • IMPS daily cap is ₹5 Lakh. • Tax payments via UPI elevated to ₹5 Lakh in 2024.
Priority Sector Lending (PSL) Targets	RBI Master Directions — Priority Sector Lending (PSL)	• **Commercial Banks (Domestic & Foreign ≥20 branches): 40% of ANBC** (or CEOBSE) • **Regional Rural Banks (RRBs): 75% of ANBC** • **Small Finance Banks (SFBs): 60% of ANBC** (effective FY 2025–26; rationalised from 75%) • **Urban Co-operative Banks (UCBs): 60% of ANBC or CEOBSE** (effective 1 April 2025 under PSL Directions 2025) • **Sub-Targets:** Agriculture = **18%** (Small & Marginal Farmers = **10%**); Micro Enterprises = **7.5%**; Weaker Sections = **12%**	• Foreign banks with <20 branches have 40% PSL target (up to 32% in exports). • Shortfalls allocated to RIDF (NABARD), UIDF (NHB), or SIDBI/MUDRA funds. • UCB target established at 60% of ANBC/CEOBSE from 1 April 2025 (superseding earlier 75% glide path).

Statutory / Prudential Metric	Statutory Basis / Governing Framework	Mandatory Regulatory Benchmark	Examiner Trap & Distractor Matrix
Cheque Truncation & Positive Pay (PPS)	Negotiable Instruments Act, 1881 & PSS Act, 2007	• **CTS Clearing:** Transition to continuous clearing within a few hours • **PPS Thresholds:** Voluntary at **₹50,000+**; Mandatory at banks' discretion at **₹5,00,000+**	• Developed by NPCI. • Only PPS-compliant cheques are admissible under CTS dispute mechanism.

Strike Grid 6: Master 10-Bucket Government Welfare Schemes & Exam Trap Matrix

Core Classification Rule:

- ***Central Sector Schemes (CS):*** *100% funded and executed directly by Central Government apparatus or designated central PSUs/NBFCs (e.g., PM-KISAN, PMMY, PM Vishwakarma, AIF).*
- ***Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS):*** *Jointly funded by Centre and States (standard ratio **60:40** for general states; **90:10** for 8 NE states + Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh, J&K; **100:0** for UTs without legislature). Implemented via State machinery.*

Bucket 1: Master Governance & Financial Inclusion

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Type & Funding	Eligibility Criteria	Core Provisions, Ceilings & Financial Architecture
Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY)	**August 28, 2014** MoF (DFS)	Central Sector	Any Indian citizen aged 10+	• Universal banking access: Zero balance BSBDA account with no minimum balance penalty. • Free RuPay debit card with **₹2 Lakh accidental death cover** (for accounts opened after 28.08.2018; ₹1 Lakh earlier). • Overdraft (OD) facility up to **₹10,000** (age 18–65; OD up to ₹2,000 without condition).
Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana (PMJJBY)	**May 9, 2015** MoF (DFS)	Central Sector	Bank/Post Office account holders aged **18 to 50 years**	• Renewable one-year term life insurance; risk cover: **₹2,00,000** for death due to ANY cause. • Annual premium: **₹436** (auto-debited; life risk coverage terminates at age 55).
Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY)	**May 9, 2015** MoF (DFS)	Central Sector	Bank/Post Office account holders aged **18 to 70 years**	• Renewable one-year accidental death/disability cover. • Risk cover: **₹2,00,000** for accidental death or permanent total disability; **₹1,00,000** for permanent partial disability. • Annual premium: **₹20** (auto-debited in May).
Atal Pension Yojana (APY)	**May 9, 2015** PFRDA / MoF	Central Sector	All citizens aged **18 to 40 years** (*Income taxpayers excluded since Oct 1, 2022*)	• Unorganized sector pension scheme; minimum 20 years contribution. • Guaranteed monthly pension: **₹1,000, ₹2,000, ₹3,000, ₹4,000, or ₹5,000** from age 60. • Pension continues to spouse upon death; corpus returned to nominee.
Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana (PMMY)	**April 8, 2015** MoF (DFS) / SIDBI	Central Sector Refinance	Non-corporate, non-farm micro/small enterprises	• Collateral-free institutional micro-credit. • **Shishu:** Loans up to **₹50,000**. • **Kishore:** Loans **> ₹50,000 up to ₹5 Lakh**. • **Tarun:** Loans **> ₹5 Lakh up to ₹10 Lakh**. • **Tarun Plus (Budget 2024–25):** Ceiling enhanced to **₹20 Lakh** for past repayers who repaid Tarun loans.
Stand-Up India Scheme	**April 5, 2016** MoF (DFS) / SIDBI	Central Sector	SC/ST and Women entrepreneurs (age 18+)	• Bank loans between **₹10 Lakh and ₹1 Crore** for greenfield enterprises (manufacturing, services, agri-allied, trading). • At least one SC/ST and one Woman borrower per bank branch; margin money reduced to **up to 15%**; extended up to 2025.

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Type & Funding	Eligibility Criteria	Core Provisions, Ceilings & Financial Architecture
PM-SYM (Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maan-dhan)	**Feb 2019** Ministry of Labour	Central Sector (50:50 matching)	Unorganized workers aged **18 to 40** with monthly income ≤ ₹15,000	• Guaranteed monthly pension of **₹3,000** after attaining age 60. • Matching 50:50 monthly contribution (₹55 to ₹200/month by beneficiary, matched by Centre). Managed by LIC.

Bucket 1 Exam Traps:

- *MUDRA Direct Lending Trap*: MUDRA does NOT lend directly to citizens; it is a statutory refinance agency under SIDBI. Commercial banks, RRBs, and MFIs disburse the loans.
- *APY Taxpayer Disqualification Trap*: Effective October 1, 2022, any individual who is or has been an **income tax payer is disqualified** from joining APY.
- *PMJJBY vs PMSBY Age Limits*: PMJJBY entry age is **18–50 years** (coverage ceases at 55); PMSBY entry age is **18–70 years**.

Bucket 2: Agriculture, Allied Sectors & Farmer Income Security

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Type & Funding	Core Financial Architecture & Implementation Benchmarks
PM-KISAN (PM Kisan Samman Nidhi)	**Feb 24, 2019** (retroactive from Dec 1, 2018) MoA&FW	**Central Sector (100% Centre)**	• Direct income support of **₹6,000 per year** in 3 equal installments of **₹2,000** every 4 months via DBT. • Universal coverage for all landholding farmer families (subject to institutional/taxpayer exclusion criteria).
PMFBY (PM Fasal Bima Yojana)	**Kharif 2016** MoA&FW	Centrally Sponsored (50:50 normal; 90:10 NE)	• Actuarial crop insurance: Farmer premium capped at **2.0% for Kharif**, **1.5% for Rabi foodgrains/oilseeds**, and **5.0% for Annual Commercial/Horticultural crops**. • Balance premium subsidized equally by Centre and States.
PM-KUSUM (Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Utthaan Mahabhiyan)	**March 2019 Ministry of New & Renewable Energy (MNRE)**	Central Scheme	• **Component A:** 10,000 MW decentralized ground-mounted grid-connected solar power plants (up to 2 MW each). • **Component B:** Installation of 14 Lakh standalone solar agriculture pumps. • **Component C:** Solarization of 35 Lakh grid-connected agricultural pumps (feeder level). Subsidy: 30% Centre, 30% State, 40% farmer (bank loan up to 30%).
Agriculture Infrastructure Fund (AIF)	**July 2020** MoA&FW	Central Sector Financing	• Medium-long term debt financing facility of **₹1,00,000 Crore (₹1 Lakh Crore)**. • Interest subvention of **3.0% per annum** up to a loan limit of **₹2 Crore** for a maximum period of **7 years**. • CGTMSE credit guarantee fee paid by Government.
Kisan Credit Card (KCC)	**1998** (expanded 2019 to Animal Husbandry & Fisheries) MoA&FW / RBI	Credit Instrument	• Short-term crop loans up to **₹3 Lakh** at concessional benchmark rate of **7%**. • Prompt Repayment Incentive (PRI) of **3%**, making effective borrowing cost **4% per annum**. • Sub-limit for Animal Husbandry & Fisheries: up to **₹2 Lakh** within overall ₹3 Lakh ceiling.
Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY)	**May 2020** Ministry of Fisheries, AH & Dairying	Umbrella Scheme (CS + CSS)	• Total estimated outlay: **₹20,050 Crore** over 5 years. • Target: Fish production to **22 million metric tons**; export earnings to **₹1,00,000 Crore**.

Bucket 2 Exam Traps:

- *PM-KISAN Funding Split Trap*: PM-KISAN is **100% Central Sector**, NOT Centrally Sponsored. States do not pay any share of the ₹6,000.
- *PM-KUSUM Ministry Trap*: Administered by the **Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE)**, NOT the Ministry of Agriculture.
- *KCC Concessional Rate*: Baseline rate is 7%; with the 3% Prompt Repayment Incentive, the effective borrowing cost is **4%**.

Bucket 3: Rural Transformation, Employment & Panchayati Raj

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Type & Funding	Core Financial Architecture & Targets
MGNREGA	**Act 2005** (launched Feb 2, 2006) Ministry of Rural Development	Centrally Sponsored (100% unskilled wage by Centre; 75% material by Centre)	• Statutory guarantee of **at least 100 days of wage employment** per financial year to every rural household whose adult members volunteer for unskilled manual work. • Unemployment allowance mandated if work is not provided within **15 days** of application. • Social audit mandatory by Gram Sabha.
Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana - Gramin (PMAY-G)	**Nov 20, 2016** Ministry of Rural Development	CSS (60:40 general; 90:10 NE/Himalayan)	• Unit assistance: **₹1,20,000** in plains and **₹1,30,000** in hilly/NE/difficult areas. • Plus 90/95 days of unskilled labour under MGNREGS (~₹25,000) + ₹12,000 for toilet under SBM-G. • Minimum house size: **25 sq. metres**. Union Cabinet approved constructing additional **2 Crore rural houses** over next 5 years (FY 2024–2029).
Pradhan Mantri Gram Sadak Yojana (PMGSY)	**Dec 25, 2000** Ministry of Rural Development	CSS (60:40 general; 90:10 NE)	• All-weather road connectivity to unconnected rural habitations (population 500+ in plains; 250+ in hill/desert/tribal areas). • **PMGSY-IV** approved in 2024 to provide 62,500 km all-weather roads to 25,000 unconnected habitations with outlay of **₹70,125 Crore**.
DAY-NRLM (Deendayal Antyodaya Yojana - NRLM)	**June 2011** Ministry of Rural Development	CSS (60:40 general; 90:10 NE)	• Institutional mobilization into Women SHGs. • Interest subvention reduces loan interest to **7%** for loans up to ₹3 Lakh (further 3% PRI drops rate to **4%**). Indian Bank is Central Nodal Bank. • **Lakhpati Didi Initiative:** Target to enable **3 Crore rural SHG women** to earn an annual income of ≥ **₹1,00,000 (₹1 Lakh)**.

Bucket 3 Exam Traps:

- *Lakhpati Didi Target Trap*: The enhanced target is **3 Crore women** (raised from 2 Crore in Interim Budget 2024).
- *PMAY-G Minimum Size*: Exactly **25 sq. metres** (including dedicated hygienic cooking area).
- *MGNREGA Wage Funding*: Central Government bears **100% of unskilled manual labour wages** (States bear unemployment allowance if work is not given).

Bucket 4: Urban Renewal, Affordable Housing & Municipal Infrastructure

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Core Operational Mandate & Thresholds
PMAY-Urban (PMAY-U 2.0)	**August 2024** (PMAY-U launched June 2015) MoHUA	• Investment of **₹10 Lakh Crore**; Central assistance of **₹2.2 Lakh Crore** over 5 years. • Target: 1 Crore urban poor and middle-class families. • 4 Verticals: ISSR (In-situ Slum Redevelopment), BLC (Beneficiary-Led Construction), AHP (Affordable Housing in Partnership), and ISS (Interest Subsidy Scheme - 4% subvention on home loans up to ₹25 Lakh for EWS/LIG).
PM SVANidhi	**June 1, 2020** MoHUA / SIDBI	• Collateral-free micro-credit for urban street vendors. • **Tranche 1:** Up to **₹10,000** (1-year tenor). • **Tranche 2:** Up to **₹20,000** (upon timely repayment of Tranche 1). • **Tranche 3:** Up to **₹50,000** (upon repayment of Tranche 2). • Interest subvention of **7.0% per annum** credited quarterly via DBT; digital transaction cashback up to **₹1,200/year** (₹100/month).
AMRUT 2.0	**Oct 1, 2021** MoHUA	• Target: 100% universal piped water supply coverage across all **4,800+ Statutory Towns**; universal sewage/septage management in 500 AMRUT cities; total indicative outlay: **₹2,77,000 Crore**.
Smart Cities Mission	**June 25, 2015** MoHUA	• Selection of **100 Smart Cities** via competitive challenge; establishment of Integrated Command and Control Centres (ICCC) across all 100 cities.

Bucket 4 Exam Traps:

- *PM SVANidhi Interest Subvention*: Interest subsidy is **7.00%**, NOT 3%.
- *PM SVANidhi Implementing Agency*: Administered by **SIDBI** under MoHUA.

- *PMAY-U 2.0 Outlay*: Total investment is **₹10 Lakh Crore** (with ₹2.2 Lakh Crore central assistance).

Bucket 5: Universal Healthcare, Nutrition & Disease Elimination

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Type & Funding	Key Invariants & Entitlements
Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY	**Sept 23, 2018** (Ranchi, Jharkhand) MoHFW / National Health Authority (NHA)	CSS (60:40 general; 90:10 NE)	• World's largest government-funded health assurance scheme. • Health cover of **₹5,00,000 (₹5 Lakh) per family per year** for secondary and tertiary care hospitalization. • Fully cashless and paperless access; no restriction on family size or age. • **September 2024 Landmark Expansion:** Approved health coverage of **₹5 Lakh per year to ALL senior citizens aged 70 years and above**, regardless of socio-economic status or family income. Seniors in existing PM-JAY families receive an exclusive top-up of ₹5 Lakh distinct from the family pool.
PM-ABHIM (PM Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission)	**Oct 25, 2021** MoHFW	Centrally Sponsored (Outlay: ₹64,180 Cr)	• Pan-India health infrastructure strengthening over 5 years; establishing 11,024 Urban Health and Wellness Centres and 730 Integrated Public Health Labs across all districts.
PMMVY (Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana)	**Jan 1, 2017** (revamped under Mission Shakti - Samarthya) MoWCD	CSS (60:40 general; 90:10 NE)	• Direct Benefit Transfer (DBT) maternity benefit scheme. • **First Child: ₹5,000** in 2 installments (₹3,000 at early ANC registration; ₹2,000 at child birth and primary vaccination). • **Second Child (strictly if girl child):** Single installment of **₹6,000** to incentivize girl child births.

Bucket 5 Exam Traps:

- *PM-JAY Family Size Limit*: Zero cap. There is **NO limit on family size, gender, or age**.
- *PM-JAY 70+ Senior Citizen Expansion*: Open to **ALL citizens aged 70+ irrespective of income**.
- *PMMVY Second Child Incentive*: The ₹6,000 second-child grant is payable **ONLY if the second child born is a girl**.

Bucket 6: Foundational Literacy, Education & Skilling

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Financial Outlay & Implementation Mandates
PM-SHRI Schools (PM Schools for Rising India)	**Sept 7, 2022** Ministry of Education	• Total project cost: **₹27,360 Crore** (Central share: ₹18,128 Crore). • Upgrading over **14,500 existing schools** managed by Central/State/UT governments into exemplar institutions showcasing the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.
PM-POSHAN (Pradhan Mantri Poshan Shakti Nirman)	**Sept 2021** (formerly Mid-Day Meal Scheme, 1995) Ministry of Education	• Hot cooked meal provided to children studying in **Classes I to VIII** in Government and Government-aided schools. • **Downward Extension Landmark:** Expanded to include pre-primary children studying in **Balvatikas / pre-schools** attached to primary schools. • Caloric norms: 450 calories & 12g protein for Primary (Class I–V); 700 calories & 20g protein for Upper Primary (Class VI–VIII).
Samagra Shiksha Scheme	**2018** (extended to 2026) Ministry of Education	• Integrated scheme for school education from **Pre-School to Class XII** subsuming Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA), Rashtriya Madhyamik Shiksha Abhiyan (RMSA), and Teacher Education (TE).
PMKVY 4.0 (PM Kaushal Vikas Yojana)	**2023** Ministry of Skill Development & Entrepreneurship (MSDE)	• Implemented by National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC). • Emphasizes on-the-job training, industry 4.0 courses (AI, Robotics, Mechatronics, IoT, 3D Printing, Drones), and setting up 30 Skill India International Centres.

Bucket 6 Exam Traps:

- *PM-POSHAN Pre-Primary Expansion*: Pre-primary (*Balvatika*) children are now formally covered.
- *PM-SHRI Scale*: Upgrading **14,500+ existing schools** (not building new schools from scratch).

Bucket 7: Women Empowerment, Child Welfare & Social Justice

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Sub-Schemes, Allocations & Statutory Mandates
Mission Shakti	**15th Finance Commission cycle** (2021–2026) MoWCD	• Unified umbrella scheme for safety, security, and empowerment of women. • **Sambal Sub-Scheme (Safety & Security - 100% Central):** One Stop Centres (OSC / Sakhi), Women Helpline (181), Beti Bachao Beti Padhao (BBBP), Nari Adalat. • **Samarthya Sub-Scheme (Empowerment - 60:40 CSS):** Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana (PMMVY), Palna (National Creche Scheme), Shakti Sadan (Swadhar Greh), Working Women Hostels (Sakhi Niwas).
Mission Vatsalya	**2021–22** MoWCD	• Dedicated child protection services scheme; statutory implementation of Juvenile Justice (Care and Protection of Children) Act, 2015. • Child Helpline integrated with national emergency response number **112**.
PM Vishwakarma Scheme	**Sept 17, 2023** MoMSME / MoF / MSDE	• **Central Sector Scheme (100% Central, Outlay: ₹13,000 Crore)**. • Holistic end-to-end support for traditional artisans and craftspeople across **18 traditional trades**. • PM Vishwakarma Certificate & ID Card; Skill upgradation (5–7 days basic training + ₹500/day stipend; 15 days advanced training); Toolkit incentive of **₹15,000** via e-vouchers. • **Collateral-Free Credit:** Enterprise Development Loan up to **₹3 Lakh** in two tranches (Tranche 1: up to **₹1 Lakh** with 18-month repayment; Tranche 2: up to **₹2 Lakh** with 30-month repayment). Concessional interest rate of **5.00%** (Ministry provides 8% interest subvention cap).

Bucket 7 Exam Traps:

- *PM Vishwakarma Interest Rate*: Beneficiary pays **5% interest**; Central Government provides up to **8% interest subvention**.
- *PM Vishwakarma Outlay & Trades*: Outlay is **₹13,000 Crore** across **18 traditional trades**.
- *Sambal vs Samarthya Funding Split*: Sambal is **100% Central Sector**; Samarthya is **60:40 Centrally Sponsored**.

Bucket 8: MSME Ecosystem, Industrial Manufacturing & Commerce

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Core Provisions, Ceilings & Financial Architecture
MSME Classification & Udyam Portal	**July 1, 2020** MoMSME	• Composite criteria of Investment in Plant/Machinery and Annual Turnover: • **Micro:** Investment ≤ **₹1 Crore** AND Turnover ≤ **₹5 Crore**. • **Small:** Investment ≤ **₹10 Crore** AND Turnover ≤ **₹50 Crore**. • **Medium:** Investment ≤ **₹50 Crore** AND Turnover ≤ **₹250 Crore**. • Mandatory registration on **Udyam Registration Portal** based on self-declaration linked to PAN & GSTIN.
Credit Guarantee Fund Trust for Micro and Small Enterprises (CGTMSE)	**Aug 2000** MoMSME & SIDBI (80:20 ratio)	• Collateral-free credit guarantee coverage for MSE loans. • Guarantee ceiling enhanced to **₹5 Crore** per borrower. • Guarantee coverage up to **85%** for micro-enterprises (loans up to ₹5 Lakh) and women/SC/ST/aspirational districts; 75% for general category. Annual guarantee fee reduced to 0.37%.
PM-MITRA (PM Mega Integrated Textile Region and Apparel)	**Oct 2021** Ministry of Textiles	• Total outlay: **₹4,445 Crore**; Development of **7 Mega Textile Parks** located in: Tamil Nadu (Virudhunagar), Telangana (Warangal), Gujarat (Navsari), Karnataka (Kalaburagi), Madhya Pradesh (Dhar), Uttar Pradesh (Lucknow), and Maharashtra (Amravati). • Plug-and-play world-class industrial infrastructure.
Production Linked Incentive (PLI) Schemes	**2020** (expanded under Atmanirbhar Bharat) Nodal: Respective Ministries / NITI Aayog	• Total allocated financial incentive outlay: **₹1.97 Lakh Crore** across **14 strategic manufacturing sectors** (Automobiles, Telecom, Pharmaceuticals, Solar PV Modules, Advanced Chemistry Cell Batteries, Electronic/Tech Products, White Goods, Textiles, etc.).

Bucket 8 Exam Traps:

- *MSME Definition Trap*: The criteria is **Investment AND Turnover** (both conditions must be satisfied; exports turnover is excluded from the calculation).
- *CGTMSE Guarantee Ceiling*: Enhanced to **₹5 Crore** (formerly ₹2 Crore).
- *PM-MITRA Park Locations*: Exactly **7 parks** approved in 7 states.

Bucket 9: Digital India, Telecom Infrastructure & Frontier Technologies

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Core Mandates & Implementation Architecture
BharatNet Project	**Oct 2011** (formerly NOFN; revamped Aug 2023) DoT (Ministry of Communications)	• Funded by the **Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF)** (renamed Digital Bharat Nidhi under Telecommunications Act 2023). • Target: Optical Fibre Cable (OFC) broadband connectivity to all **2,50,000 (2.5 Lakh) Gram Panchayats** and 6.4 Lakh villages. • Modified BharatNet outlay: **₹1,39,579 Crore** executed by Bharat Broadband Network Ltd (BBNL) merged into BSNL.
PM-WANI (PM Wi-Fi Access Network Interface)	**Dec 2020** DoT	• Proliferation of public broadband through Public Data Offices (PDOs) with **zero license fee and zero registration charge**. • Architecture: PDO (retail shop/kiosk), PDOA (Public Data Office Aggregator), App Provider, and Central Registry maintained by C-DOT.
India Semiconductor Mission (ISM)	**Dec 2021** MeitY	• Comprehensive incentive package with total financial outlay of **₹76,000 Crore**. • Fiscal support of **50% of Project Cost on pari-passu basis** for setting up Silicon Semiconductor Fabs, Display Fabs, Compound Semiconductors, Silicon Photonics, and Assembly, Testing, Marking and Packaging (ATMP) / OSAT facilities.

Bucket 9 Exam Traps:

- *BharatNet Funding Mechanism*: Funded exclusively via **Universal Service Obligation Fund (USOF) / Digital Bharat Nidhi**, NOT general budgetary support.
- *PM-WANI License Fee*: Exactly **₹0 (Zero license fee, zero registration requirement)** for PDOs.
- *Semiconductor Incentive*: **50% of project cost** on equal pari-passu basis across all technology nodes.

Bucket 10: Energy Transition, Climate Action & Water Security

Scheme Name	Launch Date & Nodal Ministry	Type & Financial Architecture
PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana	**Feb 13, 2024** Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE)	• Total outlay: **₹75,021 Crore**; Target: Providing up to **300 units of free electricity** per month to **1 Crore households** via rooftop solar installations. • **Central Financial Assistance (CFA) Subsidy Slab:** • 1 kW system: **₹30,000**. • 2 kW system: **₹60,000**. • 3 kW system or higher: **₹78,000** (maximum subsidy cap). • Low-interest collateral-free bank loans at benchmark repo + 0.5% (around 7%) for systems up to 3 kW.
Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM) - Har Ghar Jal	**August 15, 2019** Ministry of Jal Shakti	• Total outlay: **₹3,60,000 Crore**; CSS (50:50 general states; 90:10 NE/Himalayan; 100:0 UTs). • Mandate: Assured potable tap water supply with Functional Household Tap Connections (FHTC) to every rural household at the service level of **55 litres per capita per day (lpcd)** by 2024–2025.
PM-PRANAM (PM Programme for Restoration, Awareness, Nourishment & Amelioration of Mother Earth)	**Budget 2023–24** (approved June 2023) Ministry of Chemicals & Fertilizers	• Incentive scheme to promote balanced use of chemical fertilizers and alternative fertilizers. • **Zero separate budgetary outlay:** 50% of the subsidy savings achieved by a State/UT in chemical fertilizers is transferred as an incentive grant to that State/UT.
National Green Hydrogen Mission	**Jan 4, 2023** MNRE	• Initial financial outlay: **₹19,744 Crore**. • Target: Green hydrogen production capacity of at least **5 Million Metric Tonnes (MMT) per annum** with associated renewable energy capacity addition of ~125 GW by **2030**. • Strategic Interventions for Green Hydrogen Transition (SIGHT) programme: ₹17,490 Cr incentive for electrolyser manufacturing and green hydrogen production.

Bucket 10 Exam Traps:

- *PM Surya Ghar Subsidy Maximum Cap*: Capped at **₹78,000** for ≥ 3 kW systems (₹30,000 for 1 kW, ₹60,000 for 2 kW).
- *Jal Jeevan Mission Water Metric*: Exactly **55 litres per capita per day (lpcd)**.
- *PM-PRANAM Budget Allocation*: It has **NO separate budgetary outlay**; funded strictly by recycling 50% of chemical fertilizer subsidy savings!

Strike Grid 7: Landmark Banking Reform Committees & Statutory Genesis Matrix

Committee Name & Year	Chairperson & Mandate	Key Landmark Recommendations & Impact	High-Yield Examiner Trap / Distractor
Narasimham Committee I (1991)	**M. Narasimham** Committee on the Financial System	• Phased reduction in **CRR (down to 3-5%)** and **SLR (down to 25%)** • Introduction of **Prudential Norms (IRAC):** 90-day NPA classification • 4-tier banking structure (3-4 international banks, 8-10 national banks, local/rural banks) • Deregulation of interest rates and establishment of **Debt Recovery Tribunals (DRTs)**	• Trap: Narasimham I was 1991 (Financial System); Narasimham II was 1998 (Banking Reforms). • IRAC norms and DRTs were recommended by Narasimham I.
Narasimham Committee II (1998)	**M. Narasimham** Committee on Banking Sector Reforms	• Capital Adequacy (**CRAR**) enhancement to **9%** (aligned with Basel norms) • Creation of **Asset Reconstruction Companies (ARCs)** to take over bad loans • Autonomy to PSB Boards and revision of Banking Regulation Act Section 35A guidelines • Concept of **Universal Banking** (merging DFIs with commercial banks)	• Trap: Capital adequacy hike to 9% and ARCs were recommended by **Narasimham-II (1998)**. • Led to the enactment of the SARFAESI Act, 2002.
R.V. Gupta Committee (1998)	**R.V. Gupta** (Deputy Governor, RBI) Committee on Agricultural Credit	• Conceptualisation and launch of the **Kisan Credit Card (KCC)** scheme • Simplification of agricultural loan appraisal, sanction procedures, and collateral norms	• Trap: Recommended the Kisan Credit Card (KCC) framework (introduced in 1998 by NABARD/RBI).
Khan Committee (1998)	**S.H. Khan** (Chairman, IDBI) Working Group on DFIs and Banks	• Structural transition to **Universal Banking** in India • Removal of operational boundaries between Development Financial Institutions (DFIs) and Commercial Banks • Paved the way for ICICI and IDBI transforming into commercial banks	• Recommended Universal Banking framework in India (ICICI Bank reverse merger, IDBI Bank transformation).
Raghuram Rajan Committee (2008)	**Raghuram Rajan** Committee on Financial Sector Reforms	• Report titled: *"A Hundred Small Steps"* • Recommended entry of **Small Finance Banks**, liberalized branch licensing, and electronic trade receivables discount system (TReDS) • Conceptualized shift toward formal inflation targeting	• Known as the *"A Hundred Small Steps"* report. • Laid conceptual foundation for differentiated banking licences.
Nachiket Mor Committee (2014)	**Nachiket Mor** Committee on Comprehensive Financial Services for Small Businesses and Low-Income Households	• Recommended two new categories of **Differentiated Banks: Payments Banks** and **Small Finance Banks (SFBs)** • Mandatory Universal Electronic Bank Account (UEBA) for all adult citizens • Priority Sector Lending (PSL) obligation reforms	• Trap: Recommended **Payments Banks & SFBs** (NOT universal banks). • Recommended priority sector lending guidelines recalibration.
Urjit Patel Committee (2014)	**Dr. Urjit Patel** Committee to Revise and Strengthen the Monetary Policy Framework	• Adoption of **Flexible Inflation Targeting (FIT)** with headline **Consumer Price Index (CPI)** as the primary anchor • Target inflation rate of **4% with a tolerance band of ±2% (2% to 6%)** • Recommended creation of the statutory 6-member **Monetary Policy Committee (MPC)** under RBI Act	• Shifted India's policy anchor from Wholesale Price Index (WPI) to **CPI Combined**. • Statutory 6-member MPC under Section 45-ZB.
B. Sivaraman Committee (1981)	**B. Sivaraman** Committee to Review Arrangements for Institutional Credit for Agriculture and Rural Development (CRAFICARD)	• Statutory establishment of **National Bank for Agriculture and Rural Development (NABARD)** • Transferred agricultural credit functions of RBI and ACD to NABARD under NABARD Act, 1981 (inaugurated **12 July 1982**)	• CRAFICARD report led to the formation of **NABARD** on **12 July 1982**.
Hilton Young Commission (1926)	**Edward Hilton Young** Royal Commission on Indian Currency and Finance	• Recommended creation of a central bank for India • Led to the enactment of the **Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934** and RBI commencing operations on **April 1, 1935**	• Led to the creation of **RBI** in 1935.

Committee Name & Year	Chairperson & Mandate	Key Landmark Recommendations & Impact	High-Yield Examiner Trap / Distractor
A.D. Gorwala Committee (1951)	**A.D. Gorwala** All India Rural Credit Survey Committee	• Recommended amalgamation and conversion of the Imperial Bank of India into a state-partnered national institution • Led to the enactment of **State Bank of India Act, 1955** and formation of **SBI on July 1, 1955**	• Led to the creation of **State Bank of India (SBI)** in 1955.

Strike Grid 8: Comprehensive Global Indices, Rankings & Multi-Dimensional Benchmark Reports Matrix 2025–2026

Index / Report Name & Edition	Publishing Body / Organization	Top Ranked Nation (#1)	India's Rank & Score	Bottom Ranked Nation	Core Indicator & Examiner Traps
Global Innovation Index (GII 2025/26)	**WIPO** (World Intellectual Property Organization, Geneva)	**Switzerland** (14th consecutive year)	**39th** / 133 economies (Score: 38.3)	Angola / Niger (133rd)	Tops Central & Southern Asia; tops lower-middle income economies alongside Vietnam. *Trap: Not published by WEF or World Bank.*
Human Development Index (HDI 2025/26)	**UNDP** (UN Development Programme)	**Switzerland** (0.967), #2 Norway	**134th** / 193 nations (Score: 0.644)	Somalia (0.361) / South Sudan	Medium Human Development tier. Life expectancy at birth: **67.7 years**; Expected schooling: **12.6 years**; GNI per capita: **$6,951**.
World Happiness Report 2026	**UN SDSN** (Sustainable Development Solutions Network) + Gallup	**Finland** (7th consecutive year), #2 Denmark	**126th** / 143 nations	Afghanistan (143rd)	Based on 6 variables: GDP per capita, social support, healthy life expectancy, freedom, generosity, perceptions of corruption.
Global Gender Gap Index 2026	**WEF** (World Economic Forum, Cologny)	**Iceland** (15th consecutive year, 93.5% closed)	**131st** / 145 nations (Score: 64.5% closed)	Sudan (145th)	4 Sub-indices: Economic (39.8%), Educational (97.2%), Health (95.1%), Political (25.1%). *Trap: India ranks highest in Educational Attainment.*
Global Peace Index (GPI 2026)	**IEP** (Institute for Economics & Peace, Sydney)	**Iceland** (most peaceful since 2008), #2 Ireland	**127th** / 163 nations (Score: 2.319)	Yemen (163rd), #162 Sudan	Measured on 23 qualitative & quantitative indicators across societal safety, ongoing domestic/international conflict, and militarisation.
Global Terrorism Index (GTI 2026)	**IEP** (Institute for Economics & Peace, Sydney)	**Burkina Faso** (most impacted), #2 Israel	**14th** most impacted globally	Multiple nations (0 impact)	Measures direct and indirect impact of terrorism (deaths, incidents, injuries, hostages).
Global Hunger Index (GHI 2025/26)	**Concern Worldwide** (Ireland) & **Welthungerhilfe** (Germany)	Belarus, Bosnia, Chile (Grouped 1–22 with score <5)	**105th** / 127 nations (Score: 27.3 - "Serious")	Yemen (127th), Somalia	4 Indicators: Undernourishment, Child Wasting, Child Stunting, Child Mortality. *Trap: India's child wasting rate is highest in world at 18.7%.*
World Press Freedom Index 2026	**Reporters Without Borders** (RSF, Paris)	**Norway** (8th consecutive year), #2 Denmark	**159th** / 180 nations (Score: 31.28)	Eritrea (180th), #179 Syria	Evaluates 5 contextual indicators: political context, legal framework, economic context, sociocultural context, and security. Classified as "Very Serious".
Corruption Perceptions Index (CPI 2025/26)	**Transparency International** (Berlin)	**Denmark** (score 90), #2 Finland (87)	**93rd** / 180 nations (Score: 39 / 100)	Somalia (score 11), Venezuela	Ranks 180 countries on perceived public sector corruption; 0 = highly corrupt, 100 = very clean. *Trap: Score dropped 1 point from 40 to 39.*
Climate Change Performance Index (CCPI 2026)	**Germanwatch**, NewClimate Institute & CAN	**Ranks 1, 2, 3 left BLANK**; #4 Denmark	**7th** globally (among top-performing G20)	Saudi Arabia (67th), Iran	First 3 ranks vacant because no country is on 1.5°C Paris trajectory. Evaluates GHG emissions, renewable energy, energy use, and climate policy.
Environmental Performance Index (EPI 2026)	**Yale Center for Environmental Law** & Columbia University	**Estonia** (score 75.3), #2 Luxembourg	**176th** / 180 nations (Score: 27.6)	Vietnam (180th), Pakistan	Assesses climate change mitigation, environmental health, and ecosystem vitality.

Index / Report Name & Edition	Publishing Body / Organization	Top Ranked Nation (#1)	India's Rank & Score	Bottom Ranked Nation	Core Indicator & Examiner Traps
IMD World Competitiveness Ranking 2026	**IMD** (International Institute for Management Development, Lausanne)	**Singapore** (#1), #2 Switzerland, #3 Denmark	**39th** / 67 economies	Venezuela (67th), Argentina	4 Pillars: Economic Performance, Government Efficiency, Business Efficiency, and Infrastructure.
Global Soft Power Index 2026	**Brand Finance** (London, UK)	**United States** (#1), #2 UK, #3 China	**27th** / 193 nations	Multiple small island nations	Measures Familiarity, Reputation, and Influence across 8 Soft Power Pillars.
Global Firepower Index 2026	**Global Firepower** (GFP)	**United States** (#1), #2 Russia, #3 China	**4th** most powerful military globally	Bhutan (145th)	Evaluates over 60 individual factors (troop strength, logistics, geography, financial capability). Top 4: US, Russia, China, India.

Strike Grid 9: RBI Master Directions, Statutory Timeframes & Prudential Penalties Matrix

Regulatory Mechanism	Governing Act & Section	Statutory Timeframe / Threshold Value	Operational Rule & High-Yield Examiner Trap
DICGC Moratorium Claim Settlement	**Section 18A**, DICGC Act, 1961 (Amended 2021)	**90 Days Total** (45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days)	When RBI places a bank under all-inclusive Directions/Moratorium, depositors receive up to **₹5 Lakh** within 90 days. *Trap: Bank submits depositor list within 45 days; DICGC verifies claims within 30 days of receipt; payment is made within subsequent 15 days; overall statutory limit = 90 days (45 + 30 + 15 = 90 days).* Authorized capital: **₹50 Crore**.
Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) Minutes	**Section 45ZL**, RBI Act, 1934	**14th Day** post meeting	Resolution is published on the day of the meeting; detailed minutes (voting record and member statements) published on the **14th day**. MPC has **6 members**, quorum is **4 members**; Governor holds casting vote.
Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR)	**Section 42(1)**, RBI Act, 1934	No statutory floor or ceiling	Maintained with RBI in cash. Maintained on Net Demand and Time Liabilities (NDTL). RBI pays **0% interest** on CRR. *Trap: 2006 amendment removed the historical 3% floor and 20% ceiling.*
Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR)	**Section 24**, Banking Regulation Act, 1949	Maximum ceiling: **40%** (No floor)	Maintained by banks with themselves in gold, unencumbered approved securities, or cash. *Trap: 2007 amendment removed the 25% floor; ceiling remains 40%.*
Priority Sector Lending (PSL) Targets	RBI Master Directions - Priority Sector Lending	• Commercial Banks: **40%** of ANBC • SFBs: **60%** of ANBC (effective FY 2025–26) • RRBs: **75%** of ANBC • UCBs: **60%** of ANBC or CEOBSE (effective 1 April 2025)	Sub-targets for domestic commercial banks: **Agriculture 18%** (with **10%** for Small & Marginal Farmers / SMF); **Micro Enterprises 7.5%**; **Weaker Sections 12%**. Shortfall funds go to **RIDF (NABARD)**.
Urban Co-operative Banks (UCB) 4-Tier Framework	RBI Master Directions based on N.S. Vishwanathan Committee	• **Tier 1:** Deposits ≤ ₹100 Cr (CRAR **9%**) • **Tier 2:** Deposits > ₹100 Cr to ₹1,000 Cr (CRAR **12%**) • **Tier 3:** Deposits > ₹1,000 Cr to ₹10,000 Cr (CRAR **12%**) • **Tier 4:** Deposits > ₹10,000 Cr (CRAR **12%**)	Minimum net worth: ₹2 Crore for unit UCBs (single district); ₹5 Crore for all other UCBs. Tiers 2 to 4 must maintain **12% CRAR**; Tier 1 UCBs maintain **9% CRAR**.

Regulatory Mechanism	Governing Act & Section	Statutory Timeframe / Threshold Value	Operational Rule & High-Yield Examiner Trap
Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS)	FEMA, 1999 & RBI Master Directions	**$250,000** per financial year	Available to resident individuals including minors. Tax Collected at Source (TCS): **0% up to ₹7 Lakh**; **20% above ₹7 Lakh** for overseas tours/general remittance (**5%** if loan for overseas education under Sec 80E).
Statutory Currency & Coin Denomination Limits	**Section 24**, RBI Act, 1934 & **Section 6**, Coinage Act, 2011	• Banknotes: Up to **₹10,000** • Coins: Up to **₹1,000**	RBI can issue banknotes up to denomination of ₹10,000. Under Coinage Act 2011, coins can be minted up to ₹1,000 denomination. *Trap: ₹1 notes and coins are issued by Ministry of Finance, not RBI.*
Ways and Means Advances (WMA)	**Section 17(5)**, RBI Act, 1934	Repayable within **3 Months (90 Days)**	Clean advances extended by RBI to Central and State Governments to bridge temporary cash flow mismatches between revenue and expenditure. Interest rate: Repo rate for normal WMA.
Treasury Bills (T-Bills) & CMBs	RBI Public Debt Operations	• 91-day, 182-day, 364-day tenors • Minimum: **₹10,000** and multiples thereof	Zero-coupon promissory notes auctioned on Wednesdays. Cash Management Bills (CMBs) have maturity **< 91 days** to meet temporary cash mismatches.
Turnaround Time for Grievances (Ombudsman / CPGRAMS / Bima Bharosa)	Statutory Citizen Charters	• RB-IOS (RBI): **30 days** • CPGRAMS: **21 days** • Bima Bharosa (IRDAI): **14 days**	Reserve Bank - Integrated Ombudsman Scheme covers complaints resolved within 30 days (RB-IOS 2021: up to ₹20L loss + ₹1L mental agony; enhanced under RB-IOS 2026 from 1 July 2026: up to ₹30L loss + ₹3L mental agony). CPGRAMS tightened to **21 days** in 2024. Bima Bharosa mandates **14 days** resolution.

Strike Grid 10: 2025–2026 Sovereign Industrial Missions, Cabinet Outlays & Digital Governance Portals

Scheme / Mission Name	Nodal Ministry & Implementing Body	Financial Outlay & Budgetary Allocation	Target Beneficiaries & Core Parameters	Key Distractor / Numerical Exam Trap
PM Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana (PM-VBRY)	Ministry of Labour & Employment (EPFO)	Budgetary employment package	Operational from **1 August 2025 to 31 July 2027**. Supports first-time formal employees with wage up to ₹1 Lakh/month (receives 1-month wage up to **₹15,000** in 3 installments).	*Trap: Nodal body is Ministry of Labour & Employment, NOT Ministry of Skill Development or Finance.*
PM Surya Ghar: Muft Bijli Yojana	Ministry of New & Renewable Energy (MNRE)	**₹75,021 Crore**	**1 Crore households** receive up to 300 units free power/month. Subsidy: **₹30,000** for 1 kW, **₹60,000** for 2 kW, **₹78,000** for 3 kW or higher.	*Trap: Maximum subsidy is ₹78,000 (not ₹1 Lakh); target is 1 Crore households.*
PM-E DRIVE Scheme	Ministry of Heavy Industries	**₹10,900 Crore** (over 2 years)	Replaces legacy FAME-II. Subsidies for electric 2-wheelers, 3-wheelers, ambulances, and **14,028 electric buses** (₹4,391 Cr). ₹2,000 Cr allocated for public EV fast-chargers.	*Trap: Administered by Ministry of Heavy Industries, NOT Road Transport & Highways.*
Ayushman Bharat PM-JAY Universal 70+ Senior Cover	Ministry of Health & Family Welfare (NHA)	Central Sector top-up package	Comprehensive free health cover of **₹5 Lakh per year** on family basis to all senior citizens aged **70 years and above**, regardless of income. Distinct **Ayushman Vaya Vandana Card** issued.	*Trap: Age threshold is exactly 70 years and above (not 60 or 65); zero income bar.*
Prime Minister's Internship Scheme (PMIS)	Ministry of Corporate Affairs (MCA)	Comprehensive CSR model	Target: **1 Crore youth** over 5 years in top **500 CSR companies**. Age: **21 to 24 years**. Monthly stipend: **₹5,000** (₹4,500 Govt + ₹500 CSR) + **₹6,000** one-time grant.	*Trap: Age bracket is 21–24 years (not 18–25). Stipend is ₹5,000/month (not ₹10,000).*
PAIMANA Monitoring Framework	Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI)	Central Infrastructure Portfolio	Online digital monitoring system specifically tracking all Central Sector Infrastructure Projects costing **₹150 Crore and above**.	*Trap: Threshold is projects costing ₹150 Crore and above.*

Scheme / Mission Name	Nodal Ministry & Implementing Body	Financial Outlay & Budgetary Allocation	Target Beneficiaries & Core Parameters	Key Distractor / Numerical Exam Trap
Semicon India Programme (Semicon 2.0)	Ministry of Electronics & IT (India Semiconductor Mission / ISM)	Expanded beyond initial **₹76,000 Crore**	Comprehensive fiscal support (50% project cost) for silicon fabs, display fabs, compound semiconductors, silicon photonics, ATMP/OSAT, and Design Linked Incentive (DLI).	*Trap: Fiscal support is 50% of project cost on pari-passu basis across all technology nodes.*
GOBARdhan (National Circular Bioenergy Scheme 2026)	Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas / Jal Shakti	Circular Bioeconomy Outlay	Galvanizing Organic Bio-Agro Resources Dhan; mandates CBG blending in CNG/PNG (1% in FY26, 3% in FY27, 4% in FY28, 5% in FY29); 500 new waste-to-wealth CBG plants under SATAT.	*Trap: Mandatory blending target reaches 5% by FY 2028-29.*

COMPUTER APTITUDE, DIGITAL BANKING SYSTEMS & CYBERSECURITY

Canonical Examination Study Dossier for IBPS PO/Clerk Mains, SBI PO Mains, RRB Scale-I & Regulatory Bodies (Units COMP-001 to COMP-018)

Canonical Examination Study Dossier for IBPS PO/Clerk Mains, SBI PO Mains, RRB Officer Scale-I & Regulatory Bodies

Target Exam Section: Section I — Reasoning & Computer Aptitude (45 Questions, 60 Marks) **Standard Coverage:** Units [COMP-001] to [COMP-018] (Flowcharts, Binary Logic, CBS, OSI, DBMS, Networking, Hardware, Security)

MASTER INDEX & QUICK JUMP MATRIX

ID	Unit Title	Core High-Yield Invariants
[COMP-001]	Evolution of Computing & Pioneers	Abacus, Napier, Pascaline, Babbage, Von Neumann Stored-Program Architecture
[COMP-002]	Generations & Structural Classification	Vacuum Tubes, Transistors, ICs, Microprocessors, AI; Supercomputers, Mainframes
[COMP-003]	Hardware Architecture & System Bus	Von Neumann CPU, ALU, CU, Registers (PC, MAR, MDR, IR, AC), System Bus (Data/Addr/Ctrl)
[COMP-004]	Firmware, Booting & Diagnostics	BIOS, UEFI, CMOS battery, POST Sequence, Cold Boot vs Warm Boot
[COMP-005]	Input Devices & Automated Capture	QWERTY, Optical Mouse, MICR, OCR, OMR, Barcode, QR Code, Biometric Scanners
[COMP-006]	Output Devices & Display/Printing	CRT, LCD, OLED; Impact (Dot Matrix) vs Non-Impact (Laser, Inkjet); DPI, PPM
[COMP-007]	Memory Hierarchy & Cache	Register > Cache (L1/L2/L3) > RAM > SSD/HDD; SRAM vs DRAM; Cache Hit/Miss
[COMP-008]	Secondary & Auxiliary Storage	Magnetic Disk (Tracks/Sectors), Optical (CD/DVD/Blu-ray), Solid-State (NAND Flash)
[COMP-009]	Operating Systems & Process Scheduling	Kernel vs Shell, Multitasking, FCFS, Round Robin, Deadlock (Mutual Exclusion)
[COMP-010]	Logic Design, Number Systems & Base Conversion	Binary, Octal, Hexadecimal conversions, 1's/2's Complement, Logic Gates (AND, OR, NOT, NAND, NOR, XOR)
[COMP-011]	Computer Networks & Hardware Devices	LAN, MAN, WAN, PAN; Star, Mesh, Ring, Bus; Hub, Switch, Router, Bridge, Gateway
[COMP-012]	OSI 7-Layer Reference Model & TCP/IP	Physical, Data Link, Network, Transport, Session, Presentation, Application; IP/Port rails
[COMP-013]	Microsoft Office Master Suite	Word, Excel Formulas (VLOOKUP, INDEX-MATCH, SUMIF), PPT, Access; Universal Shortcuts
[COMP-014]	Information Security & Malware Taxonomy	Viruses, Worms, Trojans, Ransomware, Phishing, Vishing, Smishing, Zero-Day, CSOC
[COMP-015]	Banking Technology, CBS & Statutory Cyber	Finacle, BaNCS, Flexcube; Tier-4 Data Centers; ISO 8583 switch; CERT-In 6-Hour Rule
[COMP-016]	Database Management Systems (DBMS) & SQL	Relational model, Keys (Primary, Foreign, Candidate), ACID, 1NF-3NF, DDL/DML/DCL/TCL
[COMP-017]	Web Architecture & HTTP Status Codes	DNS, URL syntax, HTTP vs HTTPS, Status Codes (200, 301, 400, 403, 404, 500, 503)

ID	Unit Title	Core High-Yield Invariants
[COMP-018]	PO Mains Algorithmic Flowcharts & Binary Logic	ISO symbols, Decision Diamonds, Variable Tracing, Loop counters, Binary Cipher Puzzles

[COMP-001] EVOLUTION OF COMPUTING, PIONEERS & HISTORICAL MILESTONES (ABACUS TO MICROPROCESSORS)

Key Concept — The Evolution from Mechanical Calculating to Stored-Program Computing Mechanical calculating machines operated on fixed gear ratios where program instructions and data were physically bound to mechanical levers. The true digital revolution emerged when John von Neumann (1945) conceptualized the Stored-Program Architecture, treating program instructions and calculation data as interchangeable binary bits stored within the exact same electronic memory medium. The Master Chronology of Computing Pioneers COMPUTING DEVICE / MACHINE YEAR INVENTOR / PIONEER COUNTRY OPERATIONAL TECHNOLOGY / MECHANISM HISTORICAL & TECHNICAL SIGNIFICANCE Abacus (Soroban / Suanpan) ~2500– 3000 BCE Ancient Babylon / China Babylon / China Wooden frame with beads strung on parallel wires (Heaven & Earth beads) First known mechanical aid for arithmetic calculation (addition and subtraction). Still utilized for mental arithmetic training. Napier's Bones (Rods) 1617 John Napier Scotland Carved ivory/bone rods inscribed with multiplication tables (Rabdology) Introduced manual calculation of products and quotients using logarithms; mechanized multiplication. Slide Rule (Calculating Rule) 1620– 1622 William Oughtred & Edmund Gunter England Sliding logarithmic scales Earliest analog computing device; remained the primary calculating tool of engineers until electronic pocket calculators emerged in the 1970s. Pascaline (Adding Machine) 1642 Blaise Pascal France Toothed wheels, gears, and internal carry-transfer mechanisms First mechanical automatic calculator; could perform addition and subtraction directly via rotating dials. Stepped Reckoner (Leibniz Wheel) 1673 Gottfried Wilhelm Leibniz Germany Fluted stepped cylinder drum gears Extended mechanical calculation to direct multiplication, division, and square roots. Leibniz also formalized the binary number system. Jacquard Loom 1801– 1804 Joseph Marie Jacquard France Interchangeable punched paper cards controlling textile warp/weft First practical application of punch cards to automate complex sequences; precursor to stored computer programming. Difference Engine 1822 Charles Babbage England Steam-powered mechanical gear train executing polynomial differences Designed to calculate and print navigational and astronomical mathematical tables without human typesetting error. Analytical Engine 1834– 1842 Charles Babbage England General-purpose mechanical computer: Store (Memory), Mill (CPU), and punch-card Reader The architectural ancestor of modern digital computers. Conceived conditional branching, looping, and memory separation. First Computer Algorithm 1843 Lady Ada Augusta Lovelace England Punched card sequence designed to compute Bernoulli numbers on Analytical Engine The world's first computer programmer. Recognized that machines could manipulate symbols beyond mere arithmetic numbers. Census Tabulator 1890 Herman Hollerith USA Electromechanical tabulating machine using punched cards and mercury pools Processed the 1890 US Census in 2.5 years (vs 8 years prior). Hollerith founded the Tabulating Machine Company (later merged into IBM in 1924).

COMPUTING DEVICE / MACHINE YEAR INVENTOR / PIONEER COUNTRY OPERATIONAL TECHNOLOGY / MECHANISM HISTORICAL & TECHNICAL SIGNIFICANCE Harvard Mark-I (ASCC) 1937– 1944 Howard Aiken & IBM USA Electromechanical relays and rotating shafts (51 feet long, 5 tons) First fully automatic, general-purpose electromechanical calculator. Programmed via paper tape. Atanasoff-Berry Computer (ABC) 1939– 1942 John Atanasoff & Clifford Berry USA Vacuum tubes (300+ valves), regenerative capacitor drum memory, binary arithmetic The first electronic digital computer (special purpose: solved systems of linear algebraic equations). ENIAC 1946 J. Presper Eckert & John Mauchly USA 18,000 vacuum tubes, 70,000 resistors, 1,500 relays; 30 tons; programmed via plugboards The world's first general-purpose, fully electronic digital computer. Built for US Army artillery firing tables. EDVAC 1945– 1949 John von Neumann, Eckert & Mauchly USA Binary electronic computer utilizing mercury delay-line memory First computer designed around the Von Neumann Stored-Program Architecture (instructions and data share the same memory). EDSAC 1949 Maurice Wilkes England Mercury delay lines; cathode ray tube displays; binary stored program The first practical, fully operational stored-program electronic computer in history (Cambridge University). UNIVAC-I 1951 J. Presper Eckert & John Mauchly USA Magnetic tape storage; vacuum- tube logic; commercial general- purpose machine The world's first commercially available mass-produced computer. Purchased by US Census Bureau; predicted 1952 US Presidential Election. Intel 4004 1971 Ted Hoff, Federico Faggin, Stan Mazor USA Silicon-gate PMOS technology; 2,300 transistors on a single chip; 4-bit CPU The world's first single-chip commercial microprocessor. Ignited the personal computing revolution.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Father of Computers vs Father of Modern Computer Science: Charles Babbage is the "Father of Computers" (for the Analytical Engine). Alan Turing is the "Father of Modern Computer Science / AI" (for the Turing Machine, Universal Computation, and Breaking Enigma).
2. First Programmer: Lady Ada Lovelace is universally recognized as the first computer programmer; the Ada programming language (developed by US DoD) is named in her honor.
3. First Electronic vs First General-Purpose Electronic: The ABC (Atanasoff-Berry Computer) was the first electronic digital computer (special purpose). ENIAC was the first general-purpose fully electronic digital computer.
4. Stored-Program Pioneer: Though EDVAC was conceptualized first in Von Neumann's draft, EDSAC (built by Maurice Wilkes at Cambridge in 1949) was the first operational stored-program computer to run an actual user program.
5. Origin of IBM: Herman Hollerith's Tabulating Machine Company (1896) merged into Computing-Tabulating-Recording Company (C-T-R) in 1911, which was renamed International Business Machines (IBM) in 1924 under Thomas J. Watson.

[COMP-002] GENERATIONS OF COMPUTERS & STRUCTURAL CLASSIFICATION

Classification by Scale & Processing Throughput

1. Supercomputers: The most powerful, expensive, and fastest computing systems on Earth, designed to execute trillions of floating-point operations per second (FLOPS: PetaFLOPS, ExaFLOPS). Utilize thousands of interconnected CPUs/GPUs working in massive parallel processing (MPP). Global Benchmarks: Frontier (USA - Exascale $>$ 1.1 EFLOPS), Aurora (USA), Fugaku (Japan), Summit (USA). Indian Benchmarks: PARAM 8000 (India's first indigenous supercomputer developed in 1991 by C-DAC Pune under Dr. Vijay Bhatkar), PARAM Shivay, PARAM Siddhi-AI, AIRAWAT (AI supercomputer ranked globally in Top 100), Pratyush and Mihir (Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology for weather forecasting).
2. Mainframe Computers: Enterprise-scale multi-user computers engineered not for raw scientific mathematical calculations, but for massive I/O throughput, high reliability, and concurrent transaction processing. Capable of supporting thousands of simultaneous online users and executing millions of database queries concurrently with zero downtime. Applications: Core Banking Systems (CBS) handling millions of debit/credit transactions, airline reservation systems (SABRE), insurance claims databases, railway reservation networks (CRIS). Examples: IBM zSeries (z16), IBM System/390.
3. Minicomputers (Mid-Range Systems): Intermediate systems smaller than mainframes but significantly more capable than microcomputers. Developed in the 1960s to serve small businesses, university departments, and manufacturing plants. Support 4 to 200 simultaneous users via terminal time-sharing. Examples: Digital Equipment Corporation (DEC) PDP-11, VAX-11, IBM AS/400.
4. Microcomputers (Personal Computers - PCs): Built around a single Microprocessor chip containing the entire CPU logic (ALU, CU, Registers). Single-user design intended for general-purpose productivity, communication, and education.

Form Factors: Desktop PCs, Laptops / Notebooks, Netbooks, Palmtops / Personal Digital Assistants (PDAs), Tablets, Smartphones, Workstations (high-end graphics/engineering PCs), and Embedded Systems (microcontrollers embedded in washing machines, cars, microwave ovens).

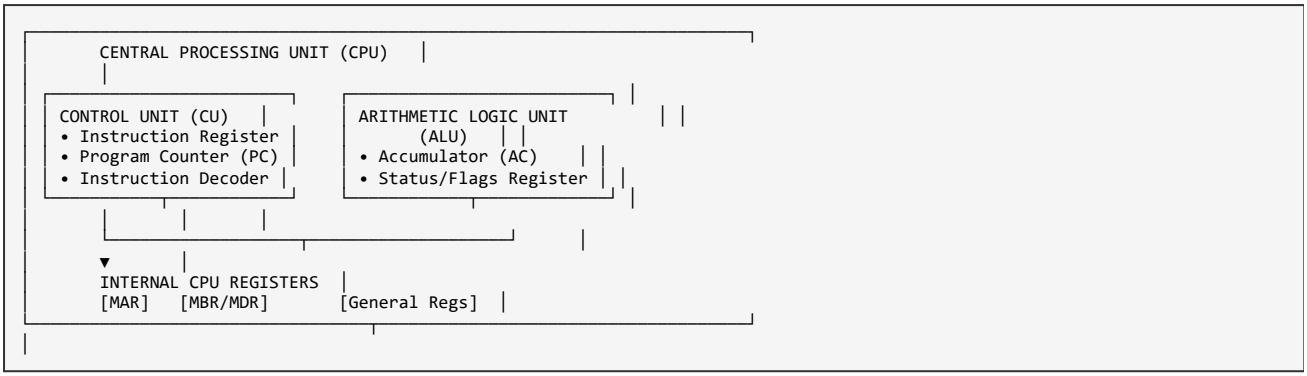
EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. First Indian Supercomputer: PARAM 8000, developed in 1991 by the Center for Development of Advanced Computing (C-DAC) at Pune, led by Dr. Vijay Bhatkar.
2. Supercomputer Speed Unit: Supercomputer processing throughput is measured in FLOPS (Floating Point Operations Per Second), NOT MIPS (Million Instructions Per Second, which measures standard CPU instructions).
3. Analog vs Digital Precision: Analog computers have lower precision and limited storage compared to digital computers, but calculate instantaneous physical differential equations faster without sampling delays.
4. Microcomputer vs Microprocessor: A microprocessor is merely the single-chip CPU (e.g. Intel Core i7). A microcomputer is the complete operational machine (including microprocessor, motherboard, RAM, storage, and I/O).

[COMP-003] COMPUTER HARDWARE ARCHITECTURE, CPU MECHANICS & THE SYSTEM BUS

The Von Neumann Machine Architecture



SYSTEM BUS (Address, Data, Control)



PRIMARY MEMORY (RAM/ROM) INPUT DEVICES (Keyboard, etc.) OUTPUT DEVICES The Three Functional Organs of the CPU

1. Arithmetic Logic Unit (ALU): The digital computational workhorse of the CPU. Executes two distinct classes of operations: Arithmetic Operations: Fundamental numeric additions, subtractions, multiplications, divisions, and bitwise binary shifts. Logical Operations: Boolean comparisons evaluating conditions to binary True (1) or False (0), including AND , OR , NOT , XOR , and relational evaluations (=, ≠, <, >, ≤, ≥).
2. Control Unit (CU): The operational supervisor / "nerve center" of the computer system. Does NOT process or store data itself; instead, it coordinates and directs the entire system by issuing sequential synchronization pulses (timing signals) via the system clock. Fetches instructions from primary RAM, routes them into the Instruction Register, decodes the opcode (operational code), and activates the specific functional units (ALU, registers, I/O interfaces) required to fulfill the command.
3. Internal High-Speed Registers: The absolute fastest storage locations in the entire computer hierarchy, located directly on the CPU silicon die with zero-cycle latency. REGISTER ABBREVIATION FULL NAME WIDTH (TYPICAL) DEDICATED OPERATIONAL FUNCTION PC Program Counter 32 / 64 bits Holds the memory address of the next sequential instruction waiting to be

fetched and executed. Automatically increments after each fetch. IR Instruction Register 32 / 64 bits Holds the current instruction being decoded and executed by the Control Unit. MAR Memory Address Register 32 / 64 bits Holds the memory address in RAM that is currently being accessed for a Read or Write operation.

REGISTER ABBREVIATION FULL NAME WIDTH (TYPICAL) DEDICATED OPERATIONAL FUNCTION MBR / MDR Memory Buffer / Data Register 32 / 64 bits Acts as an immediate holding buffer for the actual data word fetched from RAM or waiting to be written into RAM. AC Accumulator 32 / 64 bits Directly stores the immediate operands and the intermediate / final mathematical result of calculations performed by the ALU. SP Stack Pointer 32 / 64 bits Stores the memory address of the current top of the execution stack (used for subroutine calls, interrupts, and local variables). Flags / PSW Program Status Word 8 to 64 bits Individual single-bit indicator flip-flops reflecting execution status (Zero Flag Z , Carry Flag C , Sign Flag S , Overflow Flag O , Parity Flag P). The Instruction Execution Cycle (Machine Cycle) Every CPU instruction executes across four synchronized micro-phases:

1. Fetch: The Control Unit reads the memory address stored in the Program Counter (PC), loads that address into the MAR, signals a memory Read command across the Control Bus, and transfers the instruction word from RAM into the MBR/MDR, which routes it into the Instruction Register (IR). The PC is simultaneously incremented by the instruction word size.
2. Decode: The Control Unit's instruction decoder interprets the binary operation code (opcode) inside the IR and identifies any required operands/memory addresses.
3. Execute: The Control Unit directs the ALU to perform the specified arithmetic or logical transformation on the data operands.

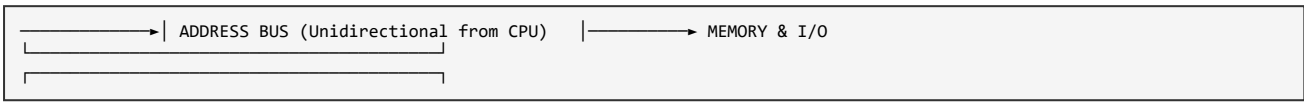
4. Store (Write-back): The final output of the operation (from the Accumulator or ALU output register) is written back to an internal CPU register or routed across the Data Bus into main memory.

$$\text{Instruction Time (I-Time)} = \text{Fetch} + \text{Decode} \quad \Big| \quad \text{Execution Time (E-Time)} = \text{Execute} + \text{Store}$$

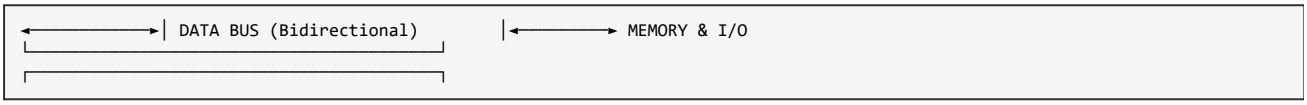
The System Bus Architecture A "Bus" is a collection of parallel conductive wires connecting two or more internal components. The System Bus is divided into three functional channels:



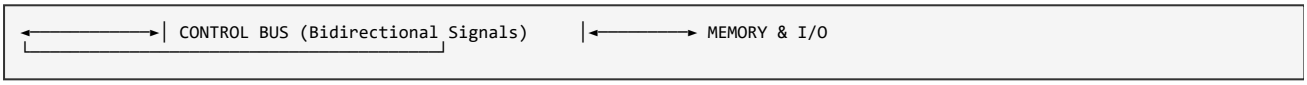
CPU



CPU



CPU



1. Address Bus (Unidirectional): Carries the memory address generated solely by the CPU to designate the source/target memory cell or I/O device. Bus Width Rule: The width of the address bus determines the Maximum Physical Memory Addressing Capacity of the computer:

$$\text{Max Addressable Memory} = \mathbf{2^N} \text{ Bytes} \quad (N = \text{number of address lines})$$

A 32-bit Address Bus can address . A 64-bit Address Bus can address . 2. Data Bus (Bidirectional): 2 bytes = 32 4, 294, 967, 296 bytes = 4 GB RAM 2 bytes ≈ 64 16 Exabytes (EB) RAM

Transmits the actual data bits between the CPU, RAM, and peripheral controllers. It is bidirectional because the CPU must both read data from memory and write data to memory. Bus Width Rule: The width of the data bus determines the CPU's word size and memory throughput per clock cycle (e.g., a 64-bit data bus moves 8 bytes simultaneously). 3. Control Bus (Bidirectional): Transmits synchronization, command, and status signals across system components. Key signals include: Memory Read , Memory Write , I/O Read , I/O Write , Bus Request , Bus Grant , Clock Pulse , Reset , and Interrupt Request (IRQ) . Physical Connectors, Ports & Motherboard Chipsets Northbridge (Host Bridge): Traditionally connected the CPU directly to high-speed system components (Main DRAM memory and PCIe x16 graphics card). In modern processors, the Northbridge is completely integrated into the CPU die itself. Southbridge (I/O Controller Hub - ICH): Manages communication with slower peripheral components, including SATA ports, USB controllers, BIOS/UEFI chip, audio card, Ethernet, and legacy PCI slots. Port Standards: USB (Universal Serial Bus): Hot-swappable, serial bus supporting up to 127 daisy-chained devices per controller. USB 2.0 (480 Mbps), USB 3.0 (5 Gbps, blue connector), USB 3.1 Gen 2 (10 Gbps), USB4 / Thunderbolt 4 (up to 40 Gbps via Type-C reversible interface). Serial Port (COM / RS-232): Transmits data 1 bit at a time over a single wire. Typically 9-pin or 25-pin D-sub connector (legacy modems and mice). Parallel Port (LPT / IEEE 1284): Transmits 8 bits (1 byte) simultaneously across 8 parallel wires. 25-pin D-sub connector (legacy printers). Display Interfaces: VGA (15-pin analog video output), DVI (Digital Visual Interface), HDMI (High-Definition Multimedia Interface - transmits uncompressed digital video and multi-channel audio simultaneously), DisplayPort (packetized digital audio/video). RJ-45 (Registered Jack 45): 8-pin / 8-conductor modular connector utilized for Ethernet twisted-pair computer networking (LAN). (Distinguished from RJ-11, the 4/6-pin connector utilized for landline telephone wiring). PS/2 Port: 6-pin mini-DIN connector utilized for legacy input devices (standardized color-coding: Purple for Keyboard, Green for Mouse).

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Address Bus Directionality: The Address Bus is strictly UNIDIRECTIONAL (signals flow ONLY outward from the CPU to memory/devices). The Data Bus and Control Bus are BIDIRECTIONAL.
2. 32-Bit Memory Barrier: A 32-bit processor cannot natively utilize more than 4 GB of physical RAM because .
3. Program Counter Function: The PC does NOT store the current instruction; it stores the address of the NEXT instruction to be executed. The current instruction resides in the Instruction Register (IR).
4. Accumulator Location: The Accumulator is located inside the CPU (specifically the ALU), NOT in primary RAM or the Hard Disk. 2 = 32 4 GB

[COMP-004] FIRMWARE, BOOTING PROTOCOLS & HARDWARE DIAGNOSTICS (BIOS, UEFI & POST)

POST) Firmware Foundations: BIOS vs UEFI Firmware is permanent, low-level software programmed directly into non-volatile hardware memory (ROM, EEPROM, or SPI Flash memory) on the motherboard. ARCHITECTURAL PARAMETER LEGACY BIOS (BASIC INPUT/OUTPUT SYSTEM) MODERN UEFI (UNIFIED EXTENSIBLE FIRMWARE INTERFACE) Origin & Era Developed by Gary Kildall & IBM (1975–1981) Developed by Intel (EFI) & Unified EFI Forum (2005+) Processor Operating Mode 16-bit Real Mode (addresses maximum 1 MB RAM) 32-bit or 64-bit Mode (addresses gigabytes of RAM) Boot Drive Partition Standard Master Boot Record (MBR) GUID Partition Table (GPT) Maximum Disk Volume Size 2.2 Terabytes (TB) 9.4 Zettabytes (ZB) (2^{64} sectors) Maximum Primary Partitions Strictly 4 Primary Partitions (or 3 Primary + 1 Extended) Up to 128 Primary Partitions natively in Windows User Interface & Control Pure text-based CLI (blue screen, keyboard navigation only) Rich Graphical User Interface (GUI), mouse support, network diagnostics Security Architecture Zero pre-boot authentication; vulnerable to bootkits Secure Boot (cryptographically verifies OS loader signatures) Boot Speed Slow sequential hardware probing Rapid parallel hardware initialization The Master Booting Sequence & The POST Routine [POWER ON]

```
──► [POWER GOOD SIGNAL] ──► [CPU Resets to 0xFFFF0] ──► [EXECUTE POST]
│
└──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
▼
```

[DETECT HARDWARE: RAM, CPU, GPU, Keyboard]

```
├── Error Detected? ──► Emit Audio BEEP Codes / Display POST Code & HALT
└── Hardware OK? ──► [READ CMOS SETUP SETTINGS (Boot Device Order)]
│
└──────────────────────────┘
▼
```

[READ MASTER BOOT RECORD (MBR Sector 0) / EFI SYSTEM PARTITION]

```
│
▼
```

[BOOTSTRAP LOADER]

```
──► Loads OS Bootloader (Windows Boot Manager / GRUB)
│
▼
```

[OS KERNEL INITIALIZATION]

```
──► Loads Device Drivers ──► [USER LOGIN SCREEN]
```

1. Power Application & CPU Reset: When power stabilizes, the Power Supply Unit (PSU) sends a Power Good (+5V) signal to the motherboard. The CPU initializes and automatically jumps its Program Counter to a hardwired memory address in firmware ROM (typically 0xFFFF0).
2. Power-On Self-Test (POST): A diagnostic testing routine executed by the firmware before loading any software: Verifies the integrity of the CPU registers. Tests and verifies the primary memory (RAM) capacity and read/write capability.

Detects system buses, system timer chips, display adapters (GPU), and keyboard/input devices. Audio Beep Codes: If a fatal error occurs before the display adapter is initialized, the motherboard speaker emits audio beep codes (e.g., 1 continuous beep = RAM failure, 1 long + 2 short beeps = Video card failure). 3. CMOS RAM & The Real-Time Clock: BIOS/UEFI settings (boot priority order, hardware clock, CPU frequency ratios, passwords) are stored in a small complementary metal-oxide-semiconductor memory block (CMOS RAM). CMOS RAM is volatile; it is kept continuously powered when the AC power cord is unplugged by a small coin-cell lithium battery on the motherboard (CR2032 battery, 3 Volts). If the CMOS battery dies, the system clock resets to factory default (e.g., 01-01-2000) and prompts CMOS Checksum Error - Defaults Loaded . 4. Bootstrap Loader Execution: Once POST succeeds, firmware searches storage devices in the sequence defined by the user in the BIOS Boot Priority menu (e.g., NVMe SSD → USB Drive → Network PXE). Firmware reads the very first physical sector of the bootable drive: the Master Boot Record (MBR) (Sector 0: 512 bytes, containing 446 bytes of Bootstrap code, a 64-byte Partition Table, and a 2-byte signature 0x55AA). The bootstrap loader program executes, loads the primary Operating System bootloader into RAM (e.g. bootmgr in Windows or GRUB in Linux), and transfers control to the OS kernel. Cold Boot vs Warm Boot Cold Boot (Hard Boot): Powering ON a computer from a state of total electrical shutdown. Involves a full hardware power cycle, power surge stabilization, complete POST hardware diagnostics, and full bootstrap loading. (Initiated via physical power button). Warm Boot (Soft Boot): Restarting an operating computer without disconnecting electrical power from the motherboard. Clears volatile RAM and re-initializes the OS kernel, but skips certain hardware diagnostic routines (POST), making it substantially faster. (Initiated via Ctrl + Alt + Delete or OS Restart menu).

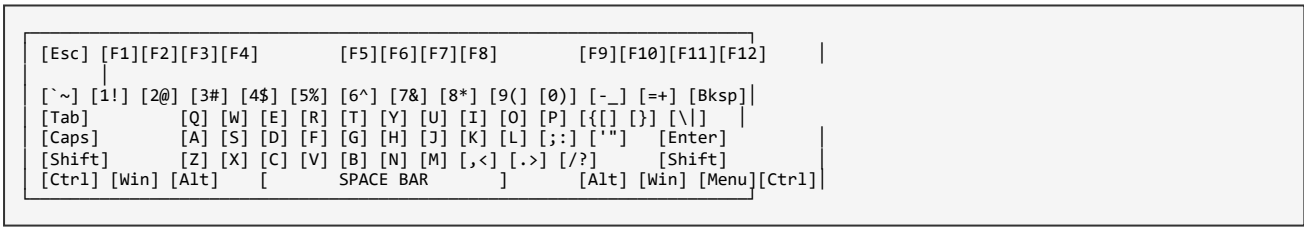
EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. BIOS vs CMOS Distinction: BIOS is firmware (software code) stored permanently in non-volatile ROM/Flash. CMOS is hardware memory that stores user settings and real-time clock data, powered by the CR2032 battery.
2. MBR Size Limit: MBR cannot natively address drives larger than 2.2 TB because its partition table uses 32-bit sector addressing ($2^{32} \times 512$ bytes = 2.19 TB). Large drives require GPT.
3. Key to Enter BIOS: Standard keys pressed immediately during POST include Del, F2, F10, or Esc (depending on manufacturer).
4. Bootstrap Loader Location: The bootstrap loader is stored in ROM (firmware), while the OS bootloader it retrieves is stored on the boot sector of secondary storage (HDD/SSD).

[COMP-005] INPUT DEVICES & BIOMETRIC / AUTOMATED DATA CAPTURE SYSTEMS

⌨ Computer Keyboard Architecture & Functional Key Mappings Keyboards utilize the standard QWERTY layout, engineered in 1873 by Christopher Latham Sholes for the Sholes and Glidden typewriter.



1. Classification of Keys: Alphanumeric Keys: Letters (A–Z) and Numbers (0–9). Modifier Keys: Keys that perform no action on their own, but modify the action of another key when pressed simultaneously: Ctrl , Alt , and Shift . Toggle Keys: Keys that switch between two operational states (on/off) and are typically accompanied by an LED indicator on the keyboard: Caps Lock , Num Lock , and Scroll Lock . Navigation / Cursor Keys: Arrow Keys (←, →, ↑, ↓), Home (jumps to beginning of line), End (jumps to end of line), Page Up , Page Down . Special / System Keys: Esc (Escape - cancels current operation/dialogue), Print Screen (captures screen buffer to clipboard), Insert (toggles insert/overwrite mode), Delete (erases character to the right of cursor), Backspace (erases character to the left of cursor). The Universal Function Keys Master Matrix (F1–F12) FUNCTION KEY UNIVERSAL WINDOWS / BROWSER ACTION MICROSOFT WORD SPECIFIC ACTION MICROSOFT EXCEL SPECIFIC ACTION F1 Help: Opens the Help and Support center

window. Opens MS Word Help pane. Opens MS Excel Help pane. F2 Rename: Renames selected file, folder, or desktop icon. Moves text or graphic. Edit Active Cell: Enters cell edit mode. F3 Search: Opens search box in File Explorer/browser. Shift + F3 : Toggles case (UPPERCASE, lowercase, Title Case). Opens the "Paste Name" dialogue. F4 Alt + F4 : Closes

active application window; shuts down PC. Repeat: Repeats the last formatting/typing action. Toggle Reference: Toggles Absolute/Relative ($A1$). F5 Refresh: Reloads active webpage or File Explorer window. Opens "Find and Replace" Go To tab. Opens "Go To" dialogue box. F6 Cycles through screen elements / highlights address bar. Cycles between document, panes, and status bar. Moves to next pane in split worksheet. F7 Spell Check: Launches Spelling and Grammar verification. Launches Spelling and Grammar check tool. Launches Spelling and Grammar check tool. F8 Windows Safe Mode boot menu (legacy); toggles selection. Turns on extend selection mode. Toggles extend selection mode.

FUNCTION KEY UNIVERSAL WINDOWS / BROWSER ACTION MICROSOFT WORD SPECIFIC ACTION MICROSOFT EXCEL SPECIFIC ACTION F9 Refreshes document fields. Updates selected document fields. Calculates all formulas in open workbooks. F10 Activates the Menu bar; Shift + F10 = Right-click menu. Displays shortcut KeyTips on Ribbon. Displays KeyTips on Ribbon. F11 Full Screen: Toggles full-screen display mode. Jumps to next field code. Create Chart: Generates instant chart sheet. F12 Opens Developer Tools in web browsers. Save As: Opens the "Save As" dialogue box. Save As: Opens the "Save As" dialogue box. Pointing, Scanning & Automated Data Capture (ADC)

1. Pointing Devices: Mouse: Invented by Douglas Engelbart in 1964 (wooden shell with two metal wheels). Modern mice are Optical (utilize an LED and optoelectronic sensor) or Laser (utilize an infrared laser diode for high-precision tracking across reflective glass). Trackball: An inverted mouse where the ball is on top; the user rolls the ball directly while the housing remains stationary (ideal for confined spaces and radar/air-traffic consoles). Touchpad: Capacitive touch surface utilizing human skin capacitance to detect finger position on laptops. Light Pen: Photosensitive pen containing a photodiode; detects CRT raster scanning beams to select screen coordinates directly. Digitizing Graphics Tablet: Electromagnetic stylus pad utilized by CAD engineers and digital artists to capture hand- drawn vectors.
2. Optical & Magnetic Document Readers: DEVICE / TECHNOLOGY FULL NAME OPERATIONAL PHYSICS / MEDIUM PRIMARY BANKING & COMMERCIAL APPLICATION MICR Magnetic Ink Character Recognition Reads characters printed in magnetic iron-oxide ink using E-13B or CMC-7 font. Characters are magnetized and read via magnetic flux induction. Bank Cheque Processing (CTS): 9-digit MICR code on bottom of cheque leaf (Digits 1–3 = City Code, 4–6 = Bank Code, 7–9 = Branch Code). Highly fraud- resistant. OCR Optical Character

Recognition Optical photo sensors scan printed or handwritten text and convert raster pixel images into editable ASCII/Unicode digital text. Automated digitizing of passport identity pages, KYC identity documents, and scanned legal books. OMR Optical Mark Recognition Senses the presence or absence of a dark pencil/ink mark on pre-printed paper forms by measuring reflected light differential. Objective competitive exam answer sheets, national census forms, and survey questionnaires. Barcode Reader Linear / 1D Barcode Scanner Emits a laser beam to read alternating dark parallel lines and light spaces representing binary codes (UPC, EAN). Retail Point of Sale (POS) inventory tracking, library book catalogs, warehouse courier parcels. QR Code Reader Quick Response Code (2D Barcode) 2D matrix barcode invented in 1994 by Denso Wave (Japan). Identified by three square position-detection patterns in corners. Digital Payments (UPI / BharatQR): Stores up to 7,089 numeric or 4,296 alphanumeric characters; readable from angles with Reed-Solomon error correction. 3. Biometric Input Systems: Capture physiological characteristics: Fingerprint scanners (optical, capacitive, or ultrasonic), Iris scanners (high- security biometric matching of eye trabecular meshwork), Retina scanners, Facial recognition cameras. 360∘

Core Application in India: Aadhaar Enabled Payment System (AePS) and biometric branch authentication for Micro- ATMs / Bank Mitras.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Backspace vs Delete: Backspace deletes the character to the LEFT of the cursor. Delete deletes the character to the RIGHT of the cursor.
2. MICR 9-Digit Code Structure: In Indian banking cheques, the 9-digit MICR code contains exactly:

Digits 1–3: City Code (matches PIN Code) | Digits 4–6: Bank Code | Digits 7–9: Branch Code

3. Thesaurus Shortcut: The shortcut key to launch the Thesaurus (Synonyms dictionary) in Microsoft Word is Shift + F7 , while F7 alone launches standard Spelling & Grammar.
4. QR Code Dimension: A barcode is 1-Dimensional (linear lines). A QR code is 2-Dimensional (matrix grid).

[COMP-006] OUTPUT DEVICES, DISPLAY TECHNOLOGIES & PRINTING ENGINEERING

Visual Display Units (VDU) & Monitor Metrics Soft Copy vs Hard Copy: Output displayed temporarily on a monitor screen or emitted through audio speakers is a Soft Copy (intangible, editable, volatile). Output physically printed onto paper or engraved by a plotter is a Hard Copy (permanent, tangible). Display Technologies:

1. CRT (Cathode Ray Tube): Legacy monitors utilizing an electron gun firing directed streams of electrons at a phosphor-coated glass screen inside a vacuum tube. Bulky, heavy, high power consumption.
2. LCD (Liquid Crystal Display): Contains liquid crystals sandwiched between polarizing glass filters. Liquid crystals do not emit light themselves; they modulate light passing through from a cold cathode fluorescent lamp (CCFL) backlight.
3. LED (Light Emitting Diode): An advanced LCD monitor that utilizes an array of efficient semiconductor LEDs as the backlighting source instead of CCFL tubes. Provides superior contrast, thinner profiles, and lower power consumption.
4. OLED (Organic LED): Uses organic carbon-based molecular films that emit their own light when electrified (emissive display; requires zero backlighting). Enables true absolute blacks (pixels turn completely off) and flexible/curved displays. Key Quality Parameters: Resolution: The total number of individual horizontal and vertical picture elements (Pixels) on screen (e.g. Full HD =

$1920 \times 1080 = 2,073,600$ pixels; 4K UHD = 3840×2160). Pixel (Picture Element): The smallest resolvable physical point of a raster display image. Dot Pitch (Pixel Pitch): The physical distance between the centers of two adjacent pixels of the same color (measured in millimeters, e.g. 0.24 mm). Smaller dot pitch = sharper, clearer image. Refresh Rate: The number of times per second the display hardware redraws the screen image, measured in Hertz (Hz) (e.g. 60 Hz, 120 Hz, 144 Hz). High refresh rates eliminate motion blur. Aspect Ratio: The proportional ratio of screen width to height (Standard traditional = $4:3$; Modern widescreen = $16:9$; Ultra-wide = $21:9$). Printer Taxonomy: Impact vs Non-Impact Engineering PRINTERS



IMPACT PRINTERS (Physical Contact) NON-IMPACT PRINTERS (No Contact)

- Character: Dot Matrix, Daisy Wheel • Thermal (ATM/POS heat paper)
- Line: Drum, Chain, Band • Inkjet (Liquid ink droplets)
- Laser (Electrostatic toner drum) PARAMETER IMPACT PRINTERS NON-IMPACT PRINTERS Operating Mechanism Pins or hammers physically strike an inked ribbon against paper. Sprays liquid ink, applies dry electrostatic toner powder, or uses thermal heat. Physical Contact Direct mechanical striking contact with paper. Zero mechanical contact with paper surface. Noise Level Extremely loud and noisy during operation. Virtually silent operation.

PARAMETER IMPACT PRINTERS NON-IMPACT PRINTERS Print Speed Measurement CPS (Characters Per Second) or LPM (Lines Per Minute). PPM (Pages Per Minute). Carbon Copies Capability Yes. Can produce multipart carbon copies via physical impact force. No. Cannot produce multipart carbon copies in a single pass. Print Quality & Resolution Low resolution; noticeable dot pixelation. High to ultra-high photographic resolution (up to \$4800\text{ DPI}\$). Representative Types Dot Matrix Printer (DMP), Daisy Wheel, Drum, Chain, Band. Laser Printer, Inkjet Printer, Thermal Printer. Dissection of Core Printer Types

1. Dot Matrix Printer (DMP - Impact): Uses a print head containing a vertical matrix of 9 or 24 stiff metal pins (wires) driven by electromagnets. As the head moves horizontally across the carriage, pins strike an inked fabric ribbon to form characters out of dots. Speed: 100 to 600 CPS (Characters Per Second). Core Use: Bank passbook printing, railway passenger ticket printing, continuous stationery invoices where carbon duplicates are legally required.
2. Inkjet Printer (Non-Impact): Sprays microscopic droplets of liquid ink from tiny nozzles directly onto paper. Uses four ink cartridges (CMYK: Cyan, Magenta, Yellow, Key/Black). Technologies: Thermal Bubble (heat expands vapor bubble pushing ink) or Piezoelectric (electric charge flexes crystal pushing ink). Speed & Quality: Measured in PPM; resolution measured in DPI (Dots Per Inch: e.g. 1200–2400 DPI).
3. Laser Printer (Non-Impact): High-speed, high-resolution page printer operating on the principle of electrophotography (xerography). Operating Lifecycle:
4. Primary Corona wire charges an Organic Photoconductor (OPC) drum with negative electrostatic voltage.

5. A rotating polygon mirror directs a Laser beam onto the drum, discharging the drum wherever text/images belong to create an invisible electrostatic latent image.
6. Negatively charged dry powdered Toner (carbon black and plastic polymer particles) clings to the laser- discharged areas.
7. Paper passes under the drum; toner transfers to paper via positive electrical attraction.
8. Paper passes through heated Fuser Rollers (heat and pressure melt plastic toner permanently into the paper fibers). Speed: 20 to 100+ PPM; highest text clarity and lowest cost-per-page for enterprise volume.
9. Thermal Printer (Non-Impact): Uses a thermal print head with microscopic heating elements pressed against chemically treated heat-sensitive thermal paper. Heat turns the paper black at contact points. Requires zero ink, toner, or ribbons. Core Use: ATM withdrawal receipts, POS card transaction slips, airline boarding passes. (Disadvantage: prints fade when exposed to sunlight or heat).
10. Plotters (Specialized Vector Graphics Output): Unlike raster printers that print in lines of dots, a Plotter draws continuous, high-precision vector lines using automated mechanical ink pens or knives. Used by architects, civil engineers, and cartographers for CAD blueprints, circuit schematics, and GIS topographic maps. (Types: Drum Plotter vs Flatbed Plotter).

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Speed Metric Trap: Dot Matrix speed = CPS (Characters Per Second). Line printer speed = LPM (Lines Per Minute). Laser / Inkjet speed = PPM (Pages Per Minute).
2. Resolution Metric: Printer output clarity and resolution is universally measured in DPI (Dots Per Inch).
3. The Carbon Copy Rule: If an exam question asks which printer can produce carbon duplicate copies, the answer is ALWAYS an Impact Printer (Dot Matrix) because non-impact printers apply zero physical mechanical striking pressure.
4. ATM Receipt Printing: ATM receipts are printed using Thermal Printers on thermal paper, NOT dot matrix or inkjet.

[COMP-007] MEMORY HIERARCHY, PRIMARY STORAGE & CACHE OPTIMIZATION

Units of Digital Storage Measurement Data in computers is structured around the Bit (Binary Digit: 0 or 1). STORAGE UNIT ABBREVIATION EXACT MATHEMATICAL EQUIVALENCY POWER OF 2 Bit b Single binary digit: 0 or 1 Nibble - 4 Bits (half a byte) - Byte B 8 Bits = 2 Nibbles (stores 1 ASCII character) bits Kilobyte KB 1,024 Bytes Megabyte MB 1,024 KB = 1,048,576 Bytes Gigabyte GB 1,024 MB = 1,073,741,824 Bytes Terabyte TB 1,024 GB Petabyte PB 1,024 TB Exabyte EB 1,024 PB Zettabyte ZB 1,024 EB Yottabyte YB 1,024 ZB Brontobyte BB 1,024 YB Geopbyte - 1,024 Brontobytes Primary Memory: SRAM vs DRAM Primary memory (Main Memory) communicates directly with the CPU via the memory bus. It is predominantly Volatile (loses contents instantaneously upon power disconnection). ENGINEERING PARAMETER SRAM (STATIC RANDOM ACCESS MEMORY) DRAM (DYNAMIC RANDOM ACCESS MEMORY) Storage Cell Physics Composed of Flip-Flops (4 to 6 Transistors) per bit. Composed of 1 Transistor + 1 Tiny Capacitor per bit. Electric Charge Decay Charge remains static as long as power is supplied. Capacitor leaks electrical charge continuously over milliseconds. 20 23 2 Bytes 10 2 Bytes 20 2 Bytes 30 2 Bytes 40 2 Bytes 50 2 Bytes 60 2 Bytes 70 2 Bytes 80 2 Bytes 90 2 Bytes 100

ENGINEERING PARAMETER SRAM (STATIC RANDOM ACCESS MEMORY) DRAM (DYNAMIC RANDOM ACCESS MEMORY) Periodic Refresh Cycles No Refreshing Required. Requires Continuous Periodic Refreshing (thousands of times/sec). Access Speed Extremely fast (1 to 5 nanoseconds). Moderate speed (10 to 50 nanoseconds). Silicon Density Low density (requires 6 transistors per memory bit). High density (1 transistor allows billions of cells on one chip). Cost & Power Expensive; high power consumption. Inexpensive; lower power consumption. Primary System Use CPU Cache Memory (L1, L2, L3). System Primary RAM (DDR3, DDR4, DDR5). DDR SDRAM (Double Data Rate Synchronous DRAM): System RAM synchronized with the CPU system clock. While traditional SDRAM transfers data only on the rising edge of each clock cycle, DDR transfers data on BOTH the rising and falling edges of each clock cycle, effectively doubling memory throughput without doubling clock speed. Non-Volatile Primary Memory: ROM Evolution Read-Only Memory (ROM) is non-volatile; it retains critical bootloader programs and firmware permanently without requiring electrical power.

1. Masked ROM (MROM): Hardwired at the semiconductor foundry during physical fabrication; cannot be modified or rewritten under any circumstances.
2. PROM (Programmable ROM): Ships blank from the factory. Programmed once by a user using a high-voltage PROM Programmer (ROM Burner) that physically blows microscopic internal electrical fuses. Once written, it can never be altered.
3. EPROM (Erasable Programmable ROM): Can be erased and reused. Features a transparent quartz crystal window on top of the ceramic chip packaging. Erasing requires exposing the quartz window to intense Ultraviolet (UV) light for 20 to 30 minutes. All memory cells are erased simultaneously.
4. EEPROM (Electrically Erasable Programmable ROM): Can be erased and reprogrammed byte-by-byte electrically using standard circuit voltages without removing the chip from the motherboard.
5. Flash Memory: An advanced, highly optimized form of EEPROM that erases and writes data in multi-kilobyte blocks rather than individual bytes. Forms the basis of modern USB flash drives, memory cards, and Solid-State Drives (SSDs). Cache Memory & The Principle of Locality Function: A small, ultra-fast block of SRAM placed directly between the lightning-fast CPU core and the comparatively sluggish DRAM main memory to prevent CPU execution bottlenecks. The Principle of Locality of Reference:
6. Temporal Locality: If a specific memory location is referenced right now, it is highly probable that the exact same location will be accessed again in the immediate future (e.g. loops, counters).
7. Spatial Locality: If a specific memory location is accessed, memory locations immediately adjacent to it are likely to be accessed soon (e.g. array traversals, sequential code execution). Cache Architecture Levels: L1 Cache: Located directly inside the CPU core silicon die; split into L1 Instruction Cache (L1i) and L1 Data Cache (L1d). Smallest (32–128 KB per core), fastest (sub-nanosecond). L2 Cache: Dedicated to each CPU core; larger than L1 (512 KB to 2 MB per core). L3 Cache: Massive shared cache shared across all CPU cores on the processor die (16 MB to 96+ MB).

Metrics: Cache Hit: CPU finds requested data in cache memory. Cache Miss: Requested data is not in cache; CPU must stall while fetching it from slow DRAM. Hit Ratio: Percentage of total memory accesses satisfied by the cache:

$$\text{Hit Ratio} = \frac{\text{Cache Hits}}{\text{Cache Hits} + \text{Cache Misses}} \times \mathbf{100\%}$$

Virtual Memory & OS Paging Definition: A memory management capability of the Operating System that uses secondary storage (HDD or NVMe SSD) to simulate additional physical RAM when physical RAM runs out. Mechanism (Paging): The OS divides logical memory into fixed-size blocks called Pages (typically 4 KB) and physical RAM into blocks of identical size called Frames. A Page Table maps virtual page addresses to physical frame addresses. Page Fault: Occurs when the CPU requests a page that is not currently loaded in physical RAM. The OS interrupts execution, suspends the thread, loads the missing page from the secondary storage Swap File (pagefile.sys) into an available RAM frame, and resumes execution. Thrashing: A catastrophic operating system condition occurring when physical memory is severely overcommitted. The OS spends virtually 100% of its CPU time continuously swapping pages back and forth between RAM and secondary storage rather than executing actual application code.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. DRAM Periodic Refresh: DRAM must be refreshed continuously because its storage mechanism uses capacitors that leak charge. SRAM uses flip-flops and requires NO refreshing.
2. Cache Memory Technology: Cache memory is constructed from SRAM, NOT DRAM.
3. EPROM Erasure Method: EPROM is erased by Ultraviolet (UV) light, while EEPROM is erased electrically.
4. Nibble Definition: 1 Nibble is exactly 4 Bits (or half a Byte). 2 Nibbles = 1 Byte.
5. Virtual Memory Location: Virtual memory is NOT a separate physical memory chip; it is a space allocated on the Secondary Storage (Hard Disk / SSD) managed by the Operating System.

[COMP-008] SECONDARY & AUXILIARY STORAGE TECHNOLOGIES (MAGNETIC, OPTICAL & SOLID-STATE)

Solid-State) Magnetic Storage: Hard Disk Drive (HDD) Geometry A Hard Disk Drive stores binary data magnetically on rapidly spinning rigid circular platters coated with a microscopic ferromagnetic layer. TOP-DOWN VIEW OF PLATTER



Physical Components: Platters: Circular aluminum, glass, or ceramic disks stacked vertically on a central spindle. Spindle Motor: Rotates platters at constant speeds, measured in RPM (Revolutions Per Minute): standard 5,400 RPM (laptops), 7,200 RPM (desktops), or 10,000–15,000 RPM (enterprise servers). Read/Write Heads: Aerodynamic electromagnetic coils attached to an actuator arm. Heads fly on a microscopic cushion of air (air bearing) nanometers above the spinning platter without touching it. Head Crash: Catastrophic mechanical failure occurring when a read/write head touches the spinning platter surface due to shock or contamination, physically gouging the magnetic coating and causing permanent data loss. Logical Organization: Tracks: Concentric circular recording rings on each platter surface. Sectors: Pie-shaped subdivisions of a track. The smallest physically addressable unit of storage on an HDD: traditional standard was 512 Bytes per sector; modern drives use Advanced Format (4,096 Bytes / 4 KB). Cylinder: The vertical set of all tracks across all platter surfaces located at the exact same radial distance from the spindle. Clusters (Allocation Units): An OS logical abstraction grouping multiple contiguous sectors (e.g. 4 KB to 64 KB). The minimum disk space allocated for any file. HDD Performance Latency Metrics:

1. Seek Time: The time required for the mechanical actuator arm to position the read/write head over the target track. (Typically 3 to 10 milliseconds; the largest component of disk latency).
2. Rotational Latency: The time required for the target sector on the spinning platter to rotate under the read/write head. (Average latency is the time for half a revolution: at 7,200 RPM, average latency is ≈ 4.16 ms).
3. Transfer Rate: The rate at which data bits are read from the surface and transmitted to system RAM.

$$\text{Total Access Time} = \text{Seek Time} + \text{Rotational Latency} + \text{Transfer Time}$$

Optical Storage: Lasers, Pits & Lands Optical media store digital bits as microscopic indentations (Pits) and flat reflective surfaces (Lands) stamped along a continuous spiral track on a polycarbonate plastic disc. A focused laser diode shines on the track: lands reflect light back into a photodiode detector (interpreted as binary 1), while pits scatter light (interpreted as binary 0). OPTICAL MEDIA DIAMETER STANDARD STORAGE CAPACITY LASER TYPE & WAVELENGTH PHYSICAL TRACK PITCH CD (Compact Disc) 120 mm 700 Megabytes (MB) (approx. 80 mins audio) Infrared Laser (780 nm) DVD (Digital Versatile Disc) 120 mm 4.7 GB (Single Layer) / 8.5 GB (Dual Layer) Red Laser (650 nm) Blu-ray Disc (BD) 120 mm 25 GB (Single Layer) / 50 GB (Dual Layer) / 100 GB (XL) Blue-Violet Laser (405 nm) Optical Media Suffixes: -ROM (Read-Only Memory): Factory stamped; data is permanent and cannot be written or erased (e.g. CD-ROM, DVD-ROM). -R (Recordable / WORM): Write Once, Read Many. A user can write data to the disc once using an optical laser burner (burns dye layer); once written, data cannot be erased. -RW (ReWritable): Uses phase-change material (chalcogenide alloy); laser can switch material between crystalline (reflective) and amorphous (absorbing) states up to 1,000 times. Solid-State Drives (SSD) & Flash Storage SSDs contain zero mechanical moving parts. Data is stored entirely in non-volatile NAND Flash memory chips consisting of floating-gate or charge-trap transistors. NAND Cell Density Architectures:

1. SLC (Single-Level Cell): 1 bit per cell. Blindingly fast, maximum endurance (100,000 write cycles), highly expensive; used in mission-critical enterprise servers.
2. MLC (Multi-Level Cell): 2 bits per cell. Balanced consumer/commercial performance.
3. TLC (Triple-Level Cell): 3 bits per cell. The mainstream standard for consumer laptops and desktops.
4. QLC (Quad-Level Cell): 4 bits per cell. Highest storage capacity, lower endurance. SSD Interface Standards: SATA III SSD: Limited by legacy SATA bus throughput (maximum theoretical bandwidth $\approx \mathbf{600\text{ MB/s}}$). NVMe (Non-Volatile Memory Express) PCIe SSD: Connects directly across the high-speed PCI Express bus via M.2 slots, bypassing legacy disk controllers. Operates with 64,000 parallel queues, delivering speeds from 3,500 MB/s (PCIe

3.0) to over 14,000 MB/s (PCIe 5.0). TRIM Command: An OS command that informs the SSD which data blocks are no longer considered in use and can be wiped internally. Crucial for maintaining SSD write performance and longevity.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Seek Time vs Latency: Seek Time is moving the head to the track. Rotational Latency is waiting for the platter to rotate the sector under the head. Seek Time is the slowest mechanical operation. 1.6 µm 0.74 µm 0.32 µm
2. Blu-ray Laser Color: Blu-ray uses a Blue-Violet laser (405 nm), NOT an infrared or standard red laser. Shorter wavelength allows significantly tighter track spacing and much higher data density.
3. WORM Definition: WORM stands for Write Once, Read Many (describes CD-R, DVD-R, and write-once archival media).
4. Smallest Physical Unit on HDD: The Sector (traditionally 512 Bytes) is the smallest physically addressable unit on a hard disk platter.

[COMP-009] COMPUTER SOFTWARE, OPERATING SYSTEMS & PROCESS SCHEDULING

Operating System Architecture: Kernel & Shell The Operating System (OS) is the master system software that manages hardware resources, memory, storage devices, and provides an abstraction layer for application programs. Source Code Compiler Object Modules (.obj) Linker Executable File (.exe) Loader Execution in RAM

The Kernel: The core, innermost heart of the OS. Resides permanently in physical RAM from boot to shutdown. Directly manages CPU scheduling, hardware device drivers, memory paging, and system calls. Monolithic Kernel: All OS services (file system, memory manager, driver stack) run inside kernel space (e.g. Linux). Microkernel: Only essential primitives run in privileged kernel space; drivers and file systems run in user space (e.g. QNX, MINIX). The Shell: The outer user-interface layer that wraps around the kernel. Interprets user commands and passes them to the kernel. CLI (Command Line Interface): Text-based command prompt where users type specific commands (e.g. MS-DOS, Linux Bash terminal). GUI (Graphical User Interface): Visual environment utilizing WIMP (Windows, Icons, Menus, Pointer) navigation (e.g. Windows 11, macOS). ⏱ Process Management & CPU Scheduling Algorithms A Process is a program currently in active execution. When multiple processes compete for CPU attention, the OS scheduler determines execution sequence:

1. First-Come, First-Served (FCFS): Non-preemptive. Processes are executed strictly in the order they arrive in the ready queue. Suffers from the Convoy Effect (a massive CPU-bound process makes dozens of tiny I/O processes wait for long durations).
2. Shortest Job First (SJF): Selects the process with the shortest execution burst time. Mathematically optimal in minimizing average waiting time, but can cause Starvation for long processes.
3. Round Robin (RR): Preemptive scheduling designed specifically for time-sharing systems. Each process is allocated a fixed slice of CPU time called a Time Quantum (e.g. 10 ms). When the time quantum expires, the CPU is preempted and allocated to the next process in a cyclic queue.
4. Priority Scheduling: Each process is assigned a priority integer; the CPU is allocated to the highest-priority process. Lower-priority processes may suffer starvation unless Aging (gradually increasing the priority of waiting processes over time) is implemented. File Systems: FAT32 vs NTFS FEATURE / METRIC FAT32 (FILE ALLOCATION TABLE 32) NTFS (NEW TECHNOLOGY FILE SYSTEM) Developer & Era Microsoft (Windows 95 OSR2, 1996) Microsoft (Windows NT, 1993; modern Windows standard) Maximum Single File Size Strictly 4 Gigabytes (GB) ($2^{32} - 1$ bytes) 16 Terabytes (TB) Maximum Volume Size 2 TB (up to 8 TB theoretically) Up to 8 Petabytes File Security & Permissions None (no native file encryption or ACL access controls) Comprehensive ACLs (Access Control Lists) & EFS Encryption Fault Tolerance & Recovery Poor; prone to corruption during sudden power losses Journaling File System (logs metadata changes before writing) Compression & Quotas No native support Native file compression and user disk space quotas Cross-Platform Compatibility Universal (works on Windows, macOS, Linux, TVs, Car audio) Native read/write on Windows; read-only on macOS without tools

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Compiler vs Interpreter Error Handling: A Compiler scans the entire document and displays all errors together. An Interpreter stops execution immediately at the first error encountered.
2. FAT32 4 GB Limit: You cannot copy a single file larger than 4 GB (such as a 4K movie) onto a USB drive formatted in FAT32, even if the drive has 128 GB of free space. The drive must be formatted as NTFS or exFAT.
3. Round Robin Time Slice: The execution time slice allocated to each process in Round Robin scheduling is formally known as a Time Quantum (or Time Slice).
4. Java Hybrid Translation: Java code is compiled by the Java Compiler into platform-independent Bytecode (.class), which is then interpreted or Just-In-Time (JIT) compiled into native machine code by the Java Virtual Machine (JVM).

[COMP-010] LOGIC DESIGN, FLOWCHARTS, NUMBER SYSTEMS & COMPUTER LANGUAGES

Positional Number Systems & Base Conversions A number system is defined by its Base (Radix), which dictates the number of unique symbols utilized: Binary (Base 2): Digits 0, 1 . Octal (Base 8): Digits 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7 . (Each octal digit maps to exactly 3 binary bits: $2^3 = 8$). Decimal (Base 10): Digits 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9 . Hexadecimal (Base 16): Digits 0, 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, A, B, C, D, E, F (where $A=10, B=11, C=12, D=13, E=14, F=15).($Each hexdigit maps to exactly 4 binary bits :2^4 = 16$). RADIX CONVERSION REFERENCE TABLE Decimal: 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 Binary: 0000 0001 0010 0011 0100 0101 0110 0111 1000 1001 1010 1011 1100 1101 1110 1111 Octal: 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 Hex: 0 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 A B C D E F Conversion Algorithms:

1. Decimal to Binary / Octal / Hex: Continuously divide the integer decimal number by the target base $(2, 8, 16)$ and record remainders from bottom to top (Double-Dabble Method).
2. Binary to Hexadecimal: Group binary bits in sets of 4 bits starting from the right (least significant bit). Replace each 4-bit nibble with its hexadecimal equivalent:

$$\mathbf{11010110_2} \implies (1101)_2\,(0110)2 \implies \mathbf{D616}$$

3. Binary to Octal: Group binary bits in sets of 3 bits starting from the right:

$$\mathbf{11010110_2} \implies (011)_2\,(010)_2\,(110)_2 \implies \mathbf{326_8}$$

Negative Binary Representation: 1's & 2's Complement 1's Complement: Invert all bits (change all 0 s to 1 s and all 1 s to 0 s). Example: 1's complement of . 2's Complement: Add binary 1 to the 1's complement result.

$$2\text{'s Complement} = 1\text{'s Complement} + \mathbf{1}$$

Example: 2's complement of :

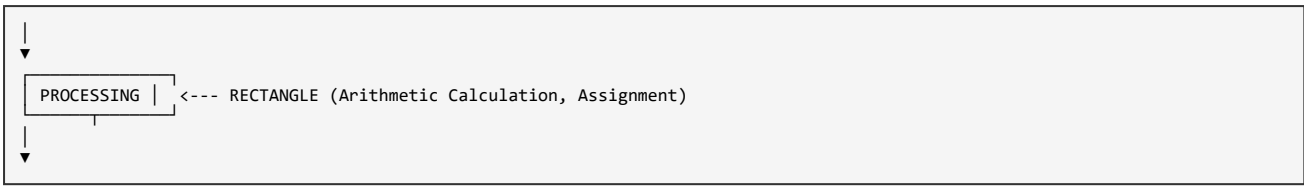
$$1\text{'s complement} = 01001101 \implies 01001101 + 1 = \mathbf{01001110_2}$$

Significance: Modern computer ALUs perform subtraction entirely using 2's Complement Addition, eliminating the need for separate subtraction circuits and resolving the ambiguity of positive and negative zero. Fundamental & Universal Logic Gates LOGIC GATE LOGIC SYMBOL BOOLEAN ALGEBRAIC EXPRESSION OPERATIONAL TRUTH CONDITION AND D -shaped gate Output is 1 ONLY IF ALL inputs are 1. OR Curved shield gate Output is 1 IF ANY input is 1. Output is 0 only if all inputs are 0 . NOT (Inverter) Triangle with bubble Inverts input: Output is 1 if input is 0 ; Output is 0 if input is 1 . 10110010 = 2 010011012 101100102 Y = A · B Y = A + B Y = A

LOGIC GATE LOGIC SYMBOL BOOLEAN ALGEBRAIC EXPRESSION OPERATIONAL TRUTH CONDITION NAND AND gate with bubble Universal Gate. Inverted AND: Output is 0 only if all inputs are 1 . NOR OR gate with bubble Universal Gate. Inverted OR: Output is 1 only if all inputs are 0 . XOR (Exclusive OR) Curved double input line Output is 1 if inputs are DIFFERENT. Output is 0 if inputs are identical. XNOR (Equivalence) XOR with bubble Output is 1 if inputs are IDENTICAL. Universal Gates: NAND and NOR gates are designated "Universal Gates" because any conceivable Boolean circuit, memory latch, or processor can be constructed using exclusively NAND or NOR gates alone. ANSI / ISO Flowchart Standard Symbols A flowchart is a standardized visual representation of an algorithm detailing the sequence of operations: [START / STOP] <--- OVAL / ROUNDED RECTANGLE (Terminator)



/ INPUT / OUTPUT / <--- PARALLELOGRAM (Data Read / Write)



／＼ < DECISION > <--- DIAMOND (Conditional Branching: Yes/No, True/False) ＼／



(O) <--- CIRCLE (On-Page Connector)

1. Oval / Rounded Rectangle (Terminator): Indicates the absolute Start, End, or Pause of a program flow.
2. Parallelogram (Input / Output): Denotes manual or automated data entry or output generation (e.g. Read A, B or Print Total).
3. Rectangle (Process): Represents calculation, internal arithmetic manipulation, or variable data assignment (e.g. Total = A + B).
4. Diamond (Decision): Represents conditional evaluation resulting in binary branching (e.g. Is X > 0? with branching paths for True/False).
5. Circle (Connector): Links intersecting flow lines on the same page.
6. Pentagon (Off-Page Connector): Connects flowchart sequences across multiple separate printed pages.
7. Arrows (Flowlines): Indicate the precise directional path of execution. The Five Generations of Computer Languages 1GL (First Generation - Machine Language): Direct native binary codes (0 and 1). Directly executed by CPU circuitry; zero translation delay; extreme machine dependency; nearly impossible for humans to debug. 2GL (Second Generation - Assembly Language): Replaces binary opcodes with readable alphanumeric Mnemonics (e.g. MOV AX, BX , ADD AX, 5 , JMP 0x1000). Architecture-specific; requires an Assembler. $Y = A \cdot B$ $Y = A + B$ $Y = A \oplus B = B + A AB$ $Y = = A \oplus B AB + A B$

3GL (Third Generation - High-Level Procedural): English-like, mathematically intuitive, and machine-independent languages. Emphasizes step-by-step algorithms: FORTRAN (1957 - Formula Translation, John Backus for scientific math), COBOL (1959 - Common Business Oriented Language, Grace Hopper for corporate ledger finance), BASIC (1964 - Beginner's All-purpose Symbolic Instruction Code, Kemeny & Kurtz), Pascal (1970 - Niklaus Wirth), C (1972 - Dennis Ritchie at Bell Labs). 4GL (Fourth Generation - Declarative / Non-Procedural): Human-like syntax specifying WHAT data to retrieve rather than HOW to retrieve it step-by-step. Includes SQL (Structured Query Language), report generators, and rapid development tools. 5GL (Fifth Generation - Logic & Constraint AI): Solves problems using declarative constraints and rules rather than programmer-written algorithms. Includes Prolog (Programming in Logic) and LISP (List Processing), foundational to artificial intelligence and expert systems.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Universal Logic Gates: The only two universal gates are NAND and NOR.
2. Flowchart Decision Symbol: The decision/branching block is ALWAYS a Diamond. Input/Output is ALWAYS a Parallelogram. Process is a Rectangle.
3. Hexadecimal Character Values: Remember that in Hex: .
4. Mother of COBOL: Dr. Grace Hopper pioneered the compiler concept and was instrumental in developing COBOL (Common Business Oriented Language).
5. Origin of C: The C language was developed in 1972 by Dennis Ritchie at AT&T Bell Laboratories specifically to write the UNIX Operating System. A = 10, B = 11, C = 12, D = 13, E = 14, F = 15

[COMP-011] COMPUTER NETWORKS, TOPOLOGIES & NETWORK HARDWARE DEVICES

Network Classification by Geographic Scale

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┌──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┐
│       NETWORK GEOGRAPHIC HIERARCHY    │
│       │
│ PAN (Personal Area Network: ~10 m, Bluetooth/NFC)     │
│       └── LAN (Local Area Network: Single office/building, Ethernet/Wi-Fi) │
│       └── CAN (Campus Area Network: University/Military Base)         │
│       └── MAN (Metropolitan Area Network: City-wide, Cable TV) │
│       └── WAN (Wide Area Network: Country/Globe, Internet) │
└──────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────────┘
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1. PAN (Personal Area Network): Covers personal operating workspace within a radius of under 10 meters. Typically wireless (WPAN). Includes Bluetooth (IEEE 802.15.1), Infrared, Zigbee, and NFC (Near Field Communication) (used for contactless credit card tap-and-pay transactions up to 4 cm).
2. LAN (Local Area Network): Spans a localized physical area: a room, office floor, banking branch, or school computer lab (typically < 1 km). High data transfer rates (100 Mbps to 10 Gbps) with low propagation delays and low error rates. Dominated by Ethernet (IEEE 802.3) and Wi-Fi (IEEE 802.11).
3. MAN (Metropolitan Area Network): Spans an entire municipality or urban city (typically 5 to 50 km). Interconnects multiple LANs across a metropolis. Common examples include municipal cable television networks and regional smart-city surveillance camera backbones.
4. WAN (Wide Area Network): Spans vast geographic distances across states, countries, or entire continents. Operates over public telecommunication backbones, transoceanic fiber-optic submarine cables, and geostationary satellites. The Internet is the world's largest public WAN.
5. SAN (Storage Area Network): A dedicated, high-speed, private network interconnecting block-level storage arrays (RAID, tape libraries) directly to enterprise banking servers via Fibre Channel or iSCSI, bypassing the standard LAN to avoid bandwidth saturation. Master Matrix of Network Topologies Network topology defines the physical layout or logical arrangement of connected nodes (computers/printers) and communication links. TOPOLOGY GEOMETRIC ARCHITECTURE TOTAL CABLE LINKS REQUIRED (N NODES) FAULT TOLERANCE & RESILIENCE PRIMARY STRENGTHS FATAL VULNERABILITY Star All nodes connect directly to a central Hub or Switch. Links High for nodes; Zero for central hub. Simple installation; node failure does not affect others; easy troubleshooting. If the central Hub/Switch fails, the entire network collapses. Bus All nodes connect via

drop lines to a single shared Backbone cable terminated at ends. 1 Backbone Cable (N drop lines) Low. Inexpensive; minimal cabling; well-suited for small temporary setups. Backbone break paralyzes whole network; packet collisions surge as nodes increase. Ring Nodes connected in a closed circle; data circulates sequentially via token. Links Low (unless dual counter- rotating ring). Zero packet collisions; deterministic token access. Break in single ring disables entire network; adding/removing nodes disrupts loop. N N

TOPOLOGY GEOMETRIC ARCHITECTURE TOTAL CABLE LINKS REQUIRED (N NODES) FAULT TOLERANCE & RESILIENCE PRIMARY STRENGTHS FATAL VULNERABILITY Mesh (Full) Every node connects directly to every other node in the network. Absolute Maximum Resilience. Dedicated links prevent congestion; multiple redundant backup paths; robust privacy. Extremely expensive; astronomical cabling density; complex routing setup. Tree Hierarchical parent-child branching structure (combination of Star and Bus). Links Moderate. Scalable expansion for corporate divisional departments. Root node failure isolates subordinate network branches. Hybrid Combination of two or more distinct topologies (e.g. Star-Bus, Star-Ring). Variable High. Customized for large enterprise campuses. Complex architectural maintenance and troubleshooting. Mesh Cable Calculation Formula: For a fully connected mesh network of devices:

$$\text{Number of Physical Duplex Links} = \frac{\mathbf{N(N-1)}}{\mathbf{2}} \quad \Big| \quad \text{Ports per Device} = \mathbf{N-1}$$

Example: A banking network connecting 8 regional servers in a full mesh requires:

$$\frac{8 \times (8-1)}{2} = \frac{8 \times 7}{2} = \mathbf{28} \text{ Physical Cable Links}$$

Physical Networking Devices & Operating OSI Layers APPLICATION LAYER

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┌──┐
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PRESENTATION LAYER

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| ──► GATEWAYS (Protocol Converters)
```

SESSION LAYER

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└──────┘
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TRANSPORT LAYER

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──────────► L4 FIREWALLS
```

NETWORK LAYER

```
──────────► ROUTERS (IP Addressing & Routing)
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DATA LINK LAYER

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──────────► SWITCHES & BRIDGES (MAC Addressing & Filtering)
```

PHYSICAL LAYER

```
──────────► HUBS & REPEATERS (Signal Amplification & Regeneration)
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1. Repeater (Physical Layer - Layer 1): An analog/digital amplifier that receives attenuated electrical, optical, or radio signals weakened by transmission distance, cleans and regenerates them to full signal strength, and retransmits them. Extends maximum cable length.
2. Hub (Physical Layer - Layer 1): A multi-port repeater. A "dumb" broadcasting device. When a data packet arrives at one port, the Hub blindly broadcasts the packet to ALL other connected ports, regardless of intended recipient. All connected devices share a single collision domain and operate in half-duplex (high packet collision probability).
3. Bridge (Data Link Layer - Layer 2): Connects two distinct physical LAN segments and filters traffic based on hardware MAC Addresses. Inspects incoming frames: if sender and receiver are on the same segment, the frame is blocked; if on different segments, the frame is forwarded. Divides one large collision domain into two smaller collision domains.
4. Switch (Data Link Layer - Layer 2 / Layer 3): An intelligent multi-port bridge. The universal foundation of modern wired LANs. Maintains an internal hardware MAC Address Table (CAM Table - Content Addressable Memory) mapping physical MAC addresses to specific switch ports. Instead of broadcasting, a switch inspects the destination MAC address of incoming frames and unicasts the frame directly and exclusively to the destination port. Links 2 N(N−1) N − 1 N

Microsegmentation: Every single switch port represents an independent, isolated collision domain operating in full- duplex (simultaneous send and receive with zero packet collisions). 5. Router (Network Layer - Layer 3): An intelligent internetworking device that connects two or more completely distinct logical networks (e.g. connecting a private bank branch LAN to the public Internet WAN). Operates using logical IP Addresses (IPv4 / IPv6). Maintains dynamic Routing Tables and executes routing algorithms (OSPF, BGP, RIP) to determine the mathematically optimal path for packets across networks. Breaks Broadcast Domains: While switches propagate broadcasts across all ports, routers terminate and block broadcast frames by default. 6. Gateway (Application / All Layers - Layers 4 to 7): An advanced protocol converter that connects networks operating on completely incompatible network architectures, transport mechanisms, or communication protocols (e.g. connecting an IBM SNA mainframe network to a standard TCP/IP network). 7. Modem (Modulator-Demodulator): Converts digital binary pulses from a computer into analog audio frequencies for transmission across analog telephone/cable lines (Modulation), and converts received analog signals back into digital bits (Demodulation). 8. Network Interface Card (NIC): A hardware expansion card or onboard chip providing physical connection to the network medium. Contains a globally unique 48-bit (6-Byte) MAC Address hardcoded into its ROM at the manufacturing plant. Transmission Media: Guided (Wired) vs Unguided (Wireless) Twisted Pair Cable: Consists of color-coded copper wires twisted in pairs to cancel out electromagnetic interference (EMI) and crosstalk. Terminated with RJ-45 connectors. UTP (Unshielded Twisted Pair): Standard office LAN cabling (e.g. Cat5e supports 1 Gbps up to 100 m; Cat6/Cat6a supports 10 Gbps). STP (Shielded Twisted Pair): Encased in protective metal foil shielding for noisy industrial factory environments. Coaxial Cable: Central copper conductor surrounded by dielectric insulation, woven copper braiding shield, and outer jacket. Terminated with BNC connectors. Resistant to interference; historically utilized in Bus topologies and cable TV networks. Fiber Optic Cable: Transmits digital data as pulses of light through ultra-pure silica glass or plastic cores utilizing the physics of Total Internal

Reflection (TIR). Immune to Electromagnetic Interference (EMI). Completely tap-proof and secure against electromagnetic eavesdropping. Single-Mode Fiber (SMF): Narrow core ($\sim 9\ \mu$m); uses laser diodes; transmits over tens of kilometers with minimal modal dispersion (backbone WAN/transoceanic cables). Multi-Mode Fiber (MMF): Wider core (50–62.5 μm); uses LEDs; transmits over shorter distances within data centers (< 500 m).

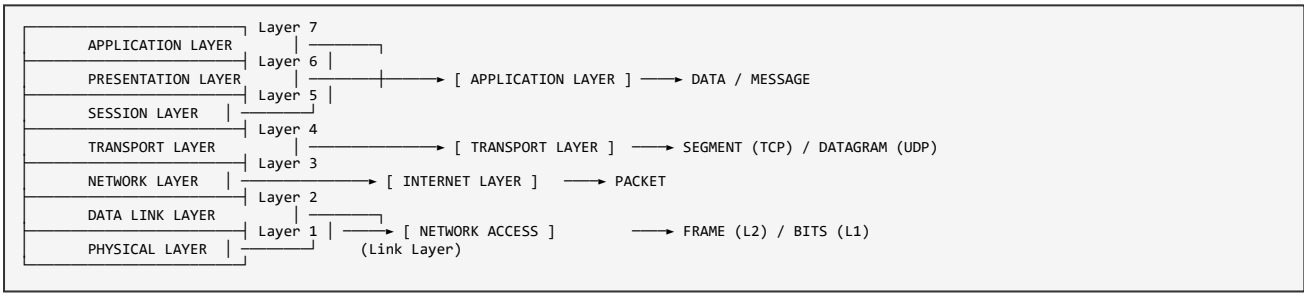
EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Hub vs Switch Broadcast: A Hub broadcasts incoming data to EVERY connected port. A Switch unicasts data specifically to the destination port using its MAC table.
2. Collision Domains: A Hub has ONE single collision domain across all ports. A Switch provides an independent collision domain for EVERY individual port.
3. Mesh Topology Formula: Memorize the formula . If asked how many cables are needed to connect 10 computers in a full mesh: .
4. Optical Transmission Principle: Fiber optic data transmission operates strictly on the physical phenomenon of Total Internal Reflection (TIR).
5. MAC vs IP Operating Layer: MAC Addresses operate at Layer 2 (Data Link Layer). IP Addresses operate at Layer 3 (Network Layer). N(N − 1)/2 10 × 9/2 = 45 cables

[COMP-012] NETWORK ARCHITECTURE, OSI 7-LAYER MODEL, TCP/IP & INTERNET PROTOCOLS

The OSI 7-Layer Reference Model vs TCP/IP Suite Formulated by the International Organization for Standardization (ISO) in 1984, the Open Systems Interconnection (OSI) model standardizes network communication into seven discrete layers. OSI 7-LAYER MODEL TCP/IP 4-LAYER MODEL PROTOCOL DATA UNIT (PDU)



Deep-Dive Matrix of the OSI 7 Layers LAYER

LAYER

NAME PROTOCOL DATA UNIT (PDU) CORE FUNCTIONAL MANDATE HARDWARE / PROTOCOLS Layer 7 Application Data / Message Direct interface between end-user applications and network services. Initiates communication requests. HTTP, HTTPS, FTP, SMTP, DNS, Telnet, SSH, SNMP, DHCP Layer 6 Presentation Data Data translation, encryption/decryption, and compression. Converts network formats (ASCII, Unicode, EBCDIC; JPEG, MP3; SSL/TLS). SSL, TLS, JPEG, MPEG, GIF, ASCII Layer 5 Session Data Establishes, maintains, synchronizes, and terminates dialogues (sessions) between applications. Inserts recovery checkpoints into data streams. NetBIOS, RPC, PPTP, SOCKS, SIP Layer 4 Transport Segment (TCP) / Datagram (UDP) End-to-end process-to-process delivery, flow control (sliding window), error checking, and port addressing. TCP, UDP; Port numbers (0–65535) Layer 3 Network Packet Logical addressing (IP) and routing. Determines optimal physical path across interconnected networks. IPv4, IPv6, ICMP, ARP, RARP, OSPF, BGP; Routers Layer 2 Data Link Frame Node-to-node hop delivery, physical MAC addressing, framing, and error detection via CRC (Cyclic Redundancy Check). Divided into LLC (802.2) and MAC (802.3). Ethernet, PPP, HDLC, Frame Relay; Switches & Bridges Layer 1 Physical Bits Transmission of raw unstructured bitstreams across physical transmission media (voltages, light pulses, radio frequencies). Cables, Fiber optics, Connectors, Hubs & Repeaters Data Encapsulation Lifecycle: As data descends the stack on the sender's machine, each layer wraps the incoming data unit with its own protocol header (and trailer at Layer 2):

$$\text{Data} \xrightarrow{L4} \text{Segment} \xrightarrow{L3} \text{Packet} \xrightarrow{L2} \text{Frame} \xrightarrow{L1} \text{Bits}$$

Upon arrival at the destination, the reverse process (Decapsulation) strips headers sequentially as data ascends the stack.

Transport Layer Protocols: TCP vs UDP FEATURE / PROPERTY TCP (TRANSMISSION CONTROL PROTOCOL) UDP (USER DATAGRAM PROTOCOL) Connection Orientation Connection-Oriented: Establishes connection via Three-Way Handshake (SYN → SYN-ACK → ACK) before sending data. Connectionless: Transmits packets immediately without verifying receiver readiness. Reliability Guaranteed Delivery: Acknowledges received segments; automatically retransmits lost packets. Unreliable / Best-Effort: No acknowledgments; zero automatic retransmission of lost packets. Packet Ordering Sequenced: Segments carry sequence numbers and are reassembled in exact original order. Unordered: Datagrams may arrive out of order or be dropped entirely. Flow & Congestion Control Comprehensive flow control (Sliding Window) and congestion control algorithms. None. Transmits as fast as application supplies data. Protocol Overhead Heavy header (20 to 60 Bytes). Slower throughput. Lightweight header (8 Bytes). Ultra-fast transmission. Core Applications Web browsing (HTTP/HTTPS), Secure Shell (SSH), Email (SMTP/IMAP), File Transfer (FTP), Banking Transactions. Real-time voice/video calls (VoIP), Video streaming, Online gaming, DNS queries, DHCP. IP Addressing Architecture: IPv4 vs IPv6 IPv4 (Internet Protocol Version 4): 32-bit binary address, written in Dotted-Decimal Notation as four 8-bit octets separated by dots (e.g. 192.168.1.1). Total theoretical address space: (≈ 4.3 Billion). Address Classes: Class A: 1.0.0.0 to 126.255.255.255 (Subnet Mask 255.0.0.0 ; massive multinational networks). Loopback / Diagnostic Address: 127.0.0.1 (127.0.0.0/8 reserved exclusively for software loopback self- testing). Class B: 128.0.0.0 to 191.255.255.255 (Subnet Mask 255.255.0.0 ; medium enterprise networks). Class C: 192.0.0.0 to 223.255.255.255 (Subnet Mask 255.255.255.0 ; small local area networks). Class D: 224.0.0.0 to 239.255.255.255 (Reserved for Multicasting). Class E: 240.0.0.0 to 255.255.255.255 (Reserved for Experimental / R&D purposes). Private IP Address Ranges (RFC 1918 - Non-routable on public Internet; translated via NAT): Class A: 10.0.0.0 to 10.255.255.255 Class B: 172.16.0.0 to 172.31.255.255 Class C: 192.168.0.0 to 192.168.255.255 APIPA (Automatic Private IP Addressing): 169.254.0.1 to 169.254.255.254 (assigned automatically by Windows when a DHCP server is unreachable). IPv6 (Internet Protocol Version 6): Developed to completely eliminate IPv4 address exhaustion. 128-bit binary address, written in Hexadecimal Notation as eight groups of four hex digits separated by colons (e.g. 2001:0db8:85a3:0000:0000:8a2e:0370:7334). Total theoretical address space: (virtually inexhaustible). 2 = 32 4, 294, 967, 296 addresses 2 ≈ 128 3.4 × 10 addresses 38

Well-Known Ports & Application Layer Protocols Master Inventory Network port numbers are 16-bit integers (0 to $65,535$) identifying specific application processes: PORT # PROTOCOL FULL NAME PRIMARY NETWORK FUNCTION 20 & 21 FTP File Transfer Protocol Port 20 transfers actual data; Port 21 manages commands and control connections. 22 SSH Secure Shell Encrypted remote terminal access and secure file transmission (replaces Telnet). 23 Telnet Telecommunication Network Unencrypted, plaintext remote terminal protocol (highly insecure). 25 SMTP Simple Mail Transfer Protocol Sending / routing outgoing email messages between mail transfer agents (MTAs). 53 DNS Domain Name System Translates human domain names (rbi.org.in) to machine IP addresses (142.250.x.x). 67 & 68 DHCP Dynamic Host Configuration Protocol Automatically assigns IP addresses, subnet masks, and default gateways to client devices. 80 HTTP Hypertext Transfer Protocol Unencrypted transmission of World Wide Web hypertext documents. 110 POP3 Post Office Protocol Version 3 Retrieving incoming email from mail server to client; downloads and deletes from server. 143 IMAP4 Internet Message Access Protocol Retrieving incoming email with two-way folder synchronization across multiple devices. 161 SNMP Simple Network Management Protocol Monitoring and managing network devices (routers, switches, printers). 443 HTTPS Hypertext Transfer Protocol Secure Web browsing encrypted over SSL / TLS (foundational for secure online banking).

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. OSI Layer of Encryption: Encryption and Decryption (SSL/TLS) occur at the Presentation Layer (Layer 6).
2. PDU Terminology: Layer 4 PDU = Segment (TCP) or Datagram (UDP). Layer 3 PDU = Packet. Layer 2 PDU = Frame. Layer 1 PDU = Bits.
3. SMTP vs POP3/IMAP: SMTP is for SENDING email. POP3 and IMAP are for RECEIVING / RETRIEVING email.
4. POP3 vs IMAP: POP3 downloads email and typically removes it from the server. IMAP synchronizes email across multiple client devices, keeping mail safely archived on the server.
5. Loopback Address: 127.0.0.1 is universally reserved as the Loopback Address (localhost) to verify that the local TCP/IP protocol stack is functioning correctly on the computer.

[COMP-013] MICROSOFT OFFICE MASTER SUITE (WORD, EXCEL, POWERPOINT & ACCESS)

⌨ Universal Microsoft Office Keyboard Shortcuts Master Reference KEYBOARD SHORTCUT UNIVERSAL ACTION ACROSS MS OFFICE Ctrl + A Select All text, objects, or all cells in worksheet. Ctrl + B Toggles Bold text formatting. Ctrl + C Copy selected text, object, or cells to clipboard. Ctrl + D Word: Opens Font dialog box; Excel: Fill Down command. Ctrl + E Center Align text / paragraph. Ctrl + F Opens Find search pane. Ctrl + G Opens Go To navigation window. Ctrl + H Opens Find and Replace window. Ctrl + I Toggles Italics text formatting. Ctrl + J Justify Align text (spreads text evenly between margins). Ctrl + K Insert Hyperlink dialog box. Ctrl + L Left Align text. Ctrl + M Word: Indents paragraph; PowerPoint: Inserts New Slide (Ctrl + M). Ctrl + N Opens a New blank document, workbook, or presentation. Ctrl + O Opens an existing document or file (Open). Ctrl + P Opens the Print dialog window. Ctrl + R Right Align text. Ctrl + S Save active file. Ctrl + U Toggles Underline text formatting. Ctrl + V Paste contents from clipboard. Ctrl + W Close current document / window. Ctrl + X Cut selected text or object to clipboard. Ctrl + Y Redo last undone action. Ctrl + Z Undo last action.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. New Slide vs New Presentation: To create a New Presentation / File, press Ctrl + N . To insert a New Slide inside an existing presentation, press Ctrl + M .
2. Slide Show Shortcuts: F5 starts from the First Slide. Shift + F5 starts from the Current Slide.
3. Excel Total Grid Capacity: Modern Excel (2007+) has exactly 1,048,576 Rows and 16,384 Columns (ending at column header XFD).
4. Count vs CountA: =COUNT() counts cells containing numbers only. =COUNTA() counts cells containing any data (numbers, text, symbols).
5. Word Alignment Shortcuts: Left = Ctrl + L , Right = Ctrl + R , Center = Ctrl + E (NOT Ctrl+C), Justify = Ctrl + J .

[COMP-014] INFORMATION SECURITY, MALWARE CLASSIFICATION & CYBER THREATS

Defensive Architecture & Cryptography Controls The CIA Triad:

1. Confidentiality: Ensuring information is shielded from unauthorized access (achieved via Encryption, Access Control Lists, Multi-Factor Authentication).
2. Integrity: Guaranteeing data has not been altered, tampered with, or forged in transit (achieved via Cryptographic Hashing: SHA-256, MD5, and Digital Signatures).
3. Availability: Ensuring computing systems, networks, and banking portals remain accessible to authorized users when needed (achieved via Hardware Redundancy, RAID, Disaster Recovery Sites, DDoS scrubbing). Firewalls: Hardware or software security barriers that monitor and filter incoming and outgoing network traffic based on strict predefined security rules. Packet Filtering Firewall (L3/L4): Inspects source/destination IP and port numbers. Stateful Inspection Firewall: Tracks the active state of network connections. Next-Generation Application Firewall (WAF - L7): Inspects application-layer HTTP payloads to block SQL injection and cross-site scripting. Cryptography Essentials: Symmetric Key Cryptography (Secret-Key): The exact same secret key is utilized to both encrypt and decrypt data. Fast, but key distribution is vulnerable. (Examples: AES - Advanced Encryption Standard, DES, 3DES, Blowfish). Asymmetric Key Cryptography (Public-Key): Utilizes a mathematically linked pair of keys: a Public Key (shared openly with the world for encryption) and a Private Key (kept strictly secret by the owner for decryption). (Examples: RSA,

ECC - Elliptic Curve Cryptography, Diffie-Hellman). Digital Signatures: Provides Authentication, Integrity, and Non-Repudiation (the sender cannot deny having sent the message). Created by encrypting a document's cryptographic hash using the sender's Private Key; verified by anyone using the sender's Public Key. Indian Cyber Law: Key Penal Provisions of the Information Technology Act, 2000 SECTION (IT ACT 2000) OFFENCE / SUBJECT MATTER PRESCRIBED STATUTORY PENALTY / PUNISHMENT Section 43 Unauthorized access, data theft, virus introduction, damaging computer systems, or extracting data without permission Civil Compensation up to ₹1 Crore to the affected person/bank. Section 66 Computer-related offences / Hacking committed dishonestly or fraudulently Imprisonment up to 3 Years OR fine up to ₹5 Lakhs, or both. Section 66B Dishonestly receiving stolen computer resource or communication device Imprisonment up to 3 Years OR fine up to ₹1 Lakh, or both. Section 66C Identity Theft: Fraudulent use of electronic signature, password, or biometric PIN Imprisonment up to 3 Years AND fine up to ₹1 Lakh. Section 66D Cheating by

Personation using computer resource / mobile device (Phishing) Imprisonment up to 3 Years AND fine up to ₹1 Lakh. Section 66E Violation of privacy (capturing/publishing private images without consent) Imprisonment up to 3 Years OR fine up to ₹2 Lakhs, or both. Section 66F Cyber Terrorism: Acts threatening the unity, integrity, security, or sovereignty of India Imprisonment for LIFE. Section 70 Unauthorized access to a declared Protected System (Critical Information Infrastructure) Imprisonment up to 10 Years and fine.

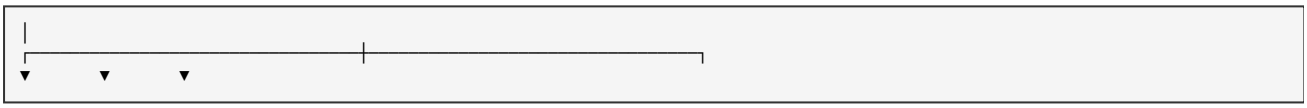
EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Virus vs Worm Host Dependency: A Virus REQUIRES a host program to replicate. A Worm is completely autonomous and does NOT require a host file.
2. Digital Signature Key Pair: A digital signature is created using the sender's PRIVATE KEY and verified by the recipient using the sender's PUBLIC KEY.
3. Non-Repudiation Definition: Non-repudiation means the sender cannot deny having sent the message or performed the digital transaction.
4. Cyber Terrorism Punishment: Under Section 66F of the IT Act, 2000, cyber terrorism carries a mandatory sentence of up to Life Imprisonment.
5. First PC Virus: The first IBM PC compatible computer virus was Brain (1986), developed by two Pakistani brothers (Amjad and Basit Farooq Alvi).

[COMP-015] BANKING TECHNOLOGY, CORE BANKING SOLUTIONS (CBS) & STATUTORY CYBER FRAMEWORKS

Core Banking Solutions (CBS) Architecture Historically, bank accounts were tied strictly to a specific physical branch where paper account ledgers resided (Branch Banking). Today, banking operates under Core Banking Solutions (CBS). CENTRAL BANK CBS DATA CENTER (Active Primary Data Center)



BRANCH TERMINALS INTERNET BANKING ATM SWITCH & POS (Any Branch Banking) & MOBILE APPS (UPI) (NFS Connectivity) Core Concept: "CORE" stands for Centralized Online Real-time Exchange. Operational Mechanics: All customer accounts, balance ledgers, transaction records, and loan files reside on a central master database housed in a Tier-4 secure Primary Data Center (PDC) with synchronous replication to a geographically separated Disaster Recovery (DR) Site. Branches operate simply as front-end thin client terminals accessing the central database. Any-Branch Banking: A customer is an account holder of the bank as a whole, rather than an account holder of a specific geographic branch. Cash deposits, withdrawals, fund transfers, and passbook updates can be executed seamlessly from any branch nationwide. Prominent Commercial CBS Software Platforms: Finacle: Developed by Infosys (utilized by State Bank of India, Punjab National Bank, Canara Bank, Bank of Baroda). BaNCS: Developed by Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) (utilized by Central Bank of India, Indian Bank, and global financial institutions). Flexcube: Developed by Oracle Financial Services Software (utilized by HDFC Bank, Citibank, Kotak Mahindra Bank). Electronic Fund Transfer & Settlement Rails The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) operate several domestic electronic payment systems: PAYMENT SYSTEM ADMINISTERING ENTITY SETTLEMENT METHODOLOGY MINIMUM / MAXIMUM TRANSACTION LIMITS OPERATING HOURS TIMELINES & BATCH CADENCE RTGS Reserve Bank of India (RBI) Real-Time Gross Settlement: Individual transactions settled continuously on a one-to-one gross basis without netting. Minimum: ₹2,00,000 (₹2 Lakhs) for customer transactions; No maximum ceiling. 24x7x365 Immediate, irrevocable final settlement in central bank money within seconds. NEFT Reserve Bank of India (RBI) National Electronic Funds Transfer: Net settlement in discrete half-hourly batches (Deferred Net Settlement - DNS). No minimum limit (starts from ₹1); No maximum ceiling (except cash deposit walk-in: max ₹50,000). 24x7x365 48 half-hourly batches daily (settles every half hour around the clock).

PAYMENT SYSTEM ADMINISTERING ENTITY SETTLEMENT METHODOLOGY MINIMUM / MAXIMUM TRANSACTION LIMITS OPERATING HOURS TIMELINES & BATCH CADENCE IMPS NPCI Instant retail payment rail routing funds across mobile numbers and account numbers. Minimum: ₹1; Maximum: ₹5,00,000 (₹5 Lakhs) per transaction. 24x7x365 Real-time settlement within seconds across bank accounts. NACH NPCI National Automated

Clearing House: High-volume, interbank bulk recurring debits/credits. Designed for bulk transactions (subsidies, dividends, loan EMIs, utility bills). Standard operational banking windows Replaces legacy ECS (Electronic Clearing Service) with centralized web mandates. CTS RBI / NPCI Cheque Truncation System (CTS-2010): Physical paper cheques are stopped at collecting branch. Governed by drawer's cheque amount. Clearing House Grid schedules High-resolution greyscale and UV digital images transmitted electronically to drawee bank. The National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) Ecosystem Incorporated in 2008 under the provisions of the Payment and Settlement Systems Act, 2007 (PSSA) as a "Not-for-Profit" company under Section 25 of the Companies Act 1956 (Section 8 of Companies Act 2013), NPCI serves as the umbrella retail payment infrastructure provider in India.

1. UPI (Unified Payments Interface): Instant real-time interbank payment architecture built on top of the IMPS rail. Eliminates the need to disclose bank account numbers and IFSC codes by utilizing a unique Virtual Payment Address (VPA) (e.g. username@okhdfcbank or mobile numbers). Features Single-Click Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) using a secure MPIN.
2. NFS (National Financial Switch): The interconnected domestic network of shared Automated Teller Machines (ATMs) in India. Enables an ATM card issued by any Indian bank to withdraw cash and check balances at any other bank's ATM machine nationwide.
3. AePS (Aadhaar Enabled Payment System): A financial inclusion platform allowing bank customers to access their Aadhaar-linked bank accounts using biometric authentication (fingerprint/iris) at Point of Sale (Micro-ATMs) operated by Business Correspondents (Bank Mitras). Basic services: Cash Withdrawal, Cash Deposit, Balance Enquiry, Aadhaar-to-Aadhaar Fund Transfer.
4. RuPay: India's domestic card payment scheme, providing an indigenous alternative to international card networks (Visa, Mastercard). Features lower transaction processing costs and domestic data sovereignty.
5. BBPS (Bharat Bill Payment System): Centralized interoperable bill payment ecosystem covering electricity, water, gas, telecom, and municipal fees.
6. NETC (National Electronic Toll Collection - FASTag): Interoperable electronic toll payment platform utilizing RFID (Radio Frequency Identification) technology affixed to motor vehicle windscreens. Financial Messaging Architecture: SWIFT vs SFMS SWIFT (Society for Worldwide Interbank Financial Telecommunication): A secure international financial messaging network headquartered in La Hulpe, Belgium.

Does NOT transfer funds directly; it transmits standardized, cryptographically secure financial transaction messages (instructions) between banks worldwide. BIC Code (Business Identifier Code / SWIFT Code): An 8 or 11-character alphanumeric code identifying a financial institution globally:

AAAA (Bank Code) BB (Country Code) CC (Location Code) DDD (Branch Code, Optional)

Standard banking messages include MT700 (Letter of Credit issuance) and MT103 (Single customer credit transfer). SFMS (Structured Financial Messaging System): The domestic Indian counterpart to SWIFT, developed by the Institute for Development and Research in Banking Technology (IDRBT) in Hyderabad. Transmits standardized interbank financial messages within India securely across the INFINET (Indian Financial Network) closed satellite/terrestrial communications network. Forms the secure messaging backbone for domestic RTGS and NEFT transactions. RBI Cyber Security Framework & Regulatory Mandates In response to surging digital fraud risks, the Reserve Bank of India issued its comprehensive Cyber Security Framework in Banks (2016):

1. Board-Level Cyber Security Oversight: Every bank must establish a specialized Board-level IT Strategy Committee and an executive Information Security Committee headed by a designated Chief Information Security Officer (CISO).
2. Cyber Security Operations Center (C-SOC): Banks must maintain a Security Operations Center that continuously monitors network traffic, detects intrusions, and analyzes real-time SIEM (Security Information and Event Management) logs.
3. Cyber Crisis Management Plan (CCMP): A formally audited disaster response protocol detailing containment, eradication, data restoration, and legal disclosure steps in the event of ransomware infections or core banking breaches.
4. Mandatory 6-Hour Incident Reporting Mandate: Under statutory directives issued by CERT-In (Indian Computer Emergency Response Team) and the RBI, all regulated banking entities must report any cybersecurity breach, unauthorized data access, ransomware attack, or critical system outage to CERT-In and the RBI within 6 hours of detection.
5. SWIFT-CBS Integration Mandate: Following the 2018 Punjab National Bank (PNB) fraud, the RBI issued an absolute statutory directive mandating that all SWIFT outbound messaging operations must be automated and tightly integrated

with the bank's Core Banking Solution (CBS). No bank officer can transmit a SWIFT payment guarantee (LoU/LoC) without an automatic pre-sanctioned credit limit and ledger entry in the CBS.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. RTGS Minimum Limit: The minimum transaction limit for customer transactions under RTGS is ₹2,00,000 (₹2 Lakhs). There is NO minimum limit for NEFT (can send ₹1).
2. NEFT Batch Timings: NEFT operates 24x7x365 in 48 half-hourly batches (settling every 30 minutes).
3. SWIFT Does NOT Transfer Money: SWIFT does not hold funds or settle cash; it is strictly a secure financial messaging system.
4. ATM Network Backbone: The National Financial Switch (NFS), developed by IDRBT and operated by NPCI, is the network interconnecting all bank ATMs in India.
5. Statutory Incident Reporting Window: Regulated financial institutions must report cybersecurity incidents to CERT-In within 6 HOURS of detection. 24 × 7 × 365

[COMP-016] DATABASE MANAGEMENT SYSTEMS (DBMS), RELATIONAL ARCHITECTURE & SQL TAXONOMY

Key Concept — Relational Data Model vs Flat File Systems Pioneered by Dr. Edgar F. Codd (E.F. Codd) at IBM in 1970, the Relational Model organizes data into two-dimensional tables termed Relations. Unlike flat file systems—which suffer from severe data redundancy, data inconsistency, lack of concurrency control, and tight hardware dependence—an RDBMS enforces logical and physical data independence, declarative querying via SQL, and strict mathematical constraints through relational keys. Relational Database Terminology & Anatomy A relational database table is formally modeled as a mathematical relation. Banking examinations routinely test the precise technical terminology distinguishing table components: Table: BANK_CUSTOMERS (Relation)

```
┌─────────────┬─────────────────┬─────────────┬─────────────────┐
│ Customer_ID │ Customer_Name   │ Branch_Code │ Account_Balance │ <-- Attributes (Columns / Fields)
├─────────────┼─────────────────┼─────────────┼─────────────────┤    Degree = 4 (Total Columns)
│ 1001        │ Rajesh Sharma   │ BR-DEL-01   │ 85400.00        │ <-- Tuple 1 (Row / Record)
│ 1002        │ Ananya Iyer     │ BR-MUM-04   │ 124500.50       │ <-- Tuple 2 (Row / Record)
│ 1003        │ Vikram Rathore  │ BR-JAI-02   │ 42000.00        │ <-- Tuple 3 (Row / Record)
└─────────────┴─────────────────┴─────────────┴─────────────────┘
```

Cardinality = 3 (Total Rows) RELATIONAL TERM COMMON / PHYSICAL TERM TECHNICAL DEFINITION & INVARIANT Relation Table A two-dimensional grid of named columns and unstructured rows containing data elements of identical entity types. Tuple Row / Record A single horizontal entry representing a unique, complete instance of an entity (e.g., one single customer record). Attribute Column / Field A single vertical property or characteristic defining an entity (e.g., Customer_Name). Domain Data Type / Permitted Set The pool of atomic, valid values from which an attribute draws its values (e.g., Age domain is integers $18 \leq x \leq 120$). Cardinality Row Count The total number of tuples (rows) currently stored in a relation. Cardinality changes dynamically as records are inserted or deleted. Degree Column Count The total number of attributes (columns) defining the relation schema. Degree remains fixed unless an administrative schema alteration occurs. Schema Blueprint / Design The overall structural design and data type definitions of the database (rarely changes). Instance Database State / Snapshot The actual collection of data residing in the database at any specific given moment in time. Relational Database Keys Taxonomy Relational keys uniquely identify tuples within a table and establish referential relationships across multiple tables:

1. Super Key: Any single attribute or set of attributes that can uniquely identify every tuple within a relation. A table can have many super keys. Example: {Customer_ID} , {Customer_ID, Customer_Name} , {PAN_Number, Branch_Code} .
2. Candidate Key: A minimal Super Key containing no redundant attributes. If any attribute is removed from a candidate key, its uniqueness guarantee is broken. Example: If {Customer_ID} uniquely identifies a customer, then {Customer_ID, Customer_Name} is a super key, but not a candidate key because Customer_Name is redundant.
3. Primary Key (PK): The specific candidate key chosen by the database designer to uniquely identify tuples in the table. Absolute Constraints: Unique: No two tuples can have the identical primary key value. NOT NULL: A primary key value can never be NULL (Entity Integrity Constraint). Single Primary Key per Relation: A relation can possess only one primary key (though it may be composed of multiple columns).

4. Alternate Key (Secondary Key): All candidate keys that were not chosen as the Primary Key. Example: If a relation has candidate keys {Account_Number} and {Aadhaar_Number} , and {Account_Number} is designated as the Primary Key, then {Aadhaar_Number} functions as the Alternate Key.

5. Foreign Key (FK): An attribute (or set of attributes) in one table whose values must match the Primary Key in another table (or the same table in self-referencing relationships). Referential Integrity Constraint: Ensures that a record in a child table cannot reference a non-existent record in the parent table. Unlike Primary Keys, a Foreign Key can contain NULL values (unless explicitly defined as NOT NULL) and can contain duplicate values.

6. Composite Key (Compound Key): A primary or candidate key constructed from two or more attributes combined together when no single individual attribute can guarantee uniqueness. Example: In an interbank transaction log, {Transaction_Date, Account_Number, Sequence_Number} forms a composite key.

7. Surrogate Key: An artificial, system-generated numerical identifier (e.g., auto-incrementing integer ID: 1, 2, 3...) introduced solely for database operations when real-world attributes (natural keys) are unwieldy or mutable. Database Normalization & Anomaly Elimination Normalization is the systematic algorithmic process of decomposing complex, redundant tables into smaller, well-structured relations to eliminate data anomalies and ensure data integrity. The Three Destructive Data Anomalies:

8. Insertion Anomaly: Inability to record certain facts without artificially inserting unrelated data (e.g., cannot record a new banking branch without first having an account holder enrolled at that branch).

9. Update / Modification Anomaly: When identical data is replicated across multiple rows, modifying it in one row while missing another causes conflicting, corrupt records (e.g., updating a customer address in one branch ledger leaves

another branch ledger displaying the old address). 3. Deletion Anomaly: Deleting one fact inadvertently destroys completely unrelated, valuable information (e.g., deleting a customer's only account unintentionally deletes the branch's operational details from the database). Normal Forms Progression: Unnormalized Table ↓ (Eliminate multi-valued attributes & repeating groups) 1st Normal Form (1NF) ↓ (Eliminate Partial Dependencies on Composite Keys) 2nd Normal Form (2NF) ↓ (Eliminate Transitive Dependencies) 3rd Normal Form (3NF) ↓ (Every determinant must be a Super Key) Boyce-Codd Normal Form (BCNF / 3.5NF)

1. First Normal Form (1NF): Requirement: Every attribute value must be atomic (single, indivisible value). Prohibitions: No repeating groups, no arrays, no comma-separated values in a single cell (e.g., a customer phone number column cannot contain "98111XXXXX, 98222XXXXX").
2. Second Normal Form (2NF): Requirement: The table must be in 1NF, AND no non-prime attribute may be partially dependent on any candidate key. Full Functional Dependency: Every non-prime attribute (column not part of any candidate key) must depend on the entire composite key, not merely a subset of it. Note: If a table's primary key consists of a single column (non-composite), and it is already in 1NF, it automatically satisfies 2NF.
3. Third Normal Form (3NF): Requirement: The table must be in 2NF, AND no non-prime attribute may be transitively dependent on the primary key. Transitive Dependency: If Attribute (A determines B) and (B determines C), then is a transitive dependency. 3NF dictates that non-key columns cannot determine other non-key columns. Formal Condition: For every functional dependency , either: is a Super Key, OR is a Prime Attribute (member of a candidate key).
4. Boyce-Codd Normal Form (BCNF / 3.5NF): A stricter, advanced variant of 3NF developed by Raymond F. Boyce and Edgar F. Codd. Strict Requirement: For every functional dependency , MUST be a Super Key (eliminating even dependencies where is a prime attribute). SQL (Structured Query Language) Command Taxonomy SQL is the universal declarative language used to manage relational databases. Banking exams classify SQL commands into five distinct functional categories: $A \rightarrow B$ $B \rightarrow C$ $A \rightarrow C$ $X \rightarrow Y$ $X Y$ $X \rightarrow Y$ $X Y$

```
┌─ DDL (Data Definition Language)
├─ DML (Data Manipulation Language)
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SQL Taxonomy

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─┼─ DQL (Data Query Language)
 ├─ DCL (Data Control Language)
 └─ TCL (Transaction Control Language)
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CATEGORY FULL FORM PURPOSE & SCOPE KEY COMMANDS TRANSACTIONAL BEHAVIOR DDL Data Definition Language Defines, alters, or destroys physical database schema, tables, and indexes. CREATE , ALTER , DROP , TRUNCATE , RENAME Auto-committed immediately. Changes cannot be rolled back via standard undo commands. DML Data Manipulation Language Inserts, modifies, or removes records (rows) stored within existing tables. INSERT , UPDATE

, DELETE , MERGE Manual commit required. Changes reside in transaction buffers and can be rolled back before committing. DQL Data Query Language Retrieves and filters data rows from one or more tables without altering stored data. SELECT Read-only operations. (Frequently grouped under DML in general syllabus overviews). DCL Data Control Language Manages security privileges, user roles, and access control rights on database objects. GRANT (give privileges), REVOKE (take back privileges) Administered by Database Administrators (DBA). TCL Transaction Control Language Manages the transactional integrity and permanence of DML executions. COMMIT (save permanent), ROLLBACK (revert changes), SAVEPOINT (checkpoint) Controls database consistency during multi-step financial transfers. The Classic Exam Distinction: DROP vs TRUNCATE vs DELETE Examiners repeatedly target the structural, performance, and transactional differences between these three deletion commands: FEATURE / METRIC DROP TRUNCATE DELETE SQL Category DDL (Data Definition Language) DDL (Data Definition Language) DML (Data Manipulation Language) Operational Impact Destroys the entire table structure, all data rows, indexes, constraints, and privileges. Deletes all data rows inside the table, but preserves the table structure/schema. Deletes specified rows matching a WHERE condition (or all rows if WHERE omitted). WHERE Clause Allowed? No No (all rows purged indiscriminately) Yes (supports conditional filtering: WHERE ID = 5) Transaction Rollback? No (Auto-committed) No (Auto-committed in standard SQL) Yes (Can be reverted via ROLLBACK) Execution Speed Fastest (drops object pointer) Extremely fast (deallocates entire data storage pages; minimal logging) Slower (deletes row-by-row, recording each deletion in transaction logs) Identity / Auto- Increment Table no longer exists Resets identity counter back to initial seed value (e.g., resets to 1) Retains identity counter sequence (next insert continues from last index) Database Triggers Does not fire DML triggers Does NOT fire ON DELETE triggers Fires ON DELETE triggers for each deleted tuple

Transaction Processing & The ACID Properties In a banking Core Banking Solution (CBS), a financial transaction represents an indivisible logical unit of work (e.g., transferring ₹10,000 from Customer A to Customer B). Every transaction must satisfy the four ACID Properties to prevent monetary corruption:

1. Atomicity ("All-or-Nothing Principle"): A transaction cannot be partially executed. Either all operations succeed and become permanent, or the transaction fails and the system rolls back completely to its original state. Banking Example: If ₹10,000 is debited from Account A, but a server crash occurs before crediting Account B, Atomicity mandates that the debit on Account A is immediately rolled back.
2. Consistency ("Preservation of Invariants"): The database must transition from one valid legal state to another valid legal state, adhering to all integrity rules, primary/foreign key constraints, and business domain rules. Banking Example: The total sum of money across Account A and Account B before the transfer must equal the total sum after the transfer. An account balance cannot violate a CHECK (Balance >= 0) constraint.
3. Isolation ("Concurrency Independence"): Multiple transactions executing simultaneously must execute without interfering with one another. The intermediate state of a transaction remains invisible to all other concurrent transactions until committed. Mechanism: Managed through Concurrency Control Protocols (e.g., Two-Phase Locking - 2PL, Timestamp Ordering). Anomalies Prevented: Dirty Reads (reading uncommitted data), Non-repeatable Reads, and Phantom Reads.
4. Durability ("Permanence After Commit"): Once a transaction has been successfully committed, its changes survive permanently in the database, even in the event of an catastrophic system power failure or operating system crash. Mechanism: Implemented via Write-Ahead Logging (WAL) and non-volatile storage flushing (RAID arrays and battery-backed write caches). Relational Databases (RDBMS) vs NoSQL Databases METRIC / DIMENSION RELATIONAL DBMS (RDBMS) NOSQL DATABASES Pioneering Model Relational Model (E.F. Codd, 1970) Distributed Non-Relational Model (Web 2.0 / Big Data era) Data Schema Rigid, predefined structured schema (tables, columns, types) Dynamic, schema-less (Document, Key-Value, Column-family, Graph) Scaling Mechanism Vertical Scaling (Scale-Up: adding faster CPU, more RAM to one server) Horizontal Scaling (Scale-Out: partitioning across clusters of cheap nodes) Query Standard Standardized SQL (Structured Query Language) Unstandardized APIs, JSON queries, GraphQL Guarantees Strict ACID (Atomicity, Consistency, Isolation, Durability) BASE (Basically Available, Soft-state, Eventual consistency) Primary Use Cases Core Banking Solutions (CBS), financial ledgers, ERP, airline ticketing Social media feeds, IoT telemetry, real-time analytics, caching (Redis) Leading Software Oracle Database, MySQL, PostgreSQL, Microsoft SQL Server, SQLite MongoDB, Apache Cassandra, Redis, Couchbase, Neo4j A (Atomicity) ⟶ C (Consistency) ⟶ I (Isolation) ⟶ D (Durability)

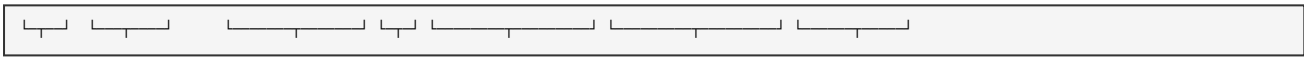
EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Cardinality vs Degree: Cardinality = Number of Rows (Tuples). Degree = Number of Columns (Attributes). (Mnemonic: Degree has columns of education; Cardinality counts the card entries/rows).
2. Candidate Key Minimality: Every candidate key is a super key, but not every super key is a candidate key. A candidate key is strictly a minimal super key.
3. Primary Key Nullability: A primary key can NEVER be NULL (Entity Integrity). A foreign key CAN be NULL unless an explicit NOT NULL constraint is attached.
4. TRUNCATE vs DELETE Category: DELETE is DML (can be rolled back, accepts WHERE). TRUNCATE is DDL (auto-committed, no WHERE, resets identity seed, executes instantly).
5. ACID "All or Nothing": Atomicity is the specific ACID property defining the "All or Nothing" execution guarantee. Durability ensures persistence post-crash.

[COMP-017] WEB ARCHITECTURE, HTTP STATUS CODES & MASTER FILE FORMATS COMPENDIUM

Key Concept — Stateless Request-Response Model of the Web The World Wide Web operates primarily on the Client-Server Architecture utilizing HTTP (Hypertext Transfer Protocol). By design, HTTP is Stateless: the web server treats every incoming HTTP request as completely independent, retaining no built-in memory of prior requests from the same user. To maintain stateful interactions—such as keeping a banking customer logged in across multiple account balance pages—web systems utilize Cookies and Server-Side Sessions. The Anatomy of a Uniform Resource Locator (URL) Every resource on the web is located via a standardized address known as a URL (Uniform Resource Locator), which is a specific form of URI (Uniform Resource Identifier): https:// netbanking. bankofindia.co.in :443 /portal/transfer.php ?acc=98721&mode=neft #confirmation



Scheme Subdomain Domain Name Port Path Query String Fragment

1. Scheme / Protocol (https://): Specifies the communication protocol used to retrieve the resource (e.g., http , https , ftp , sftp).
2. Subdomain (netbanking.): A child domain segregating specific organizational services from the apex domain.
3. Second-Level Domain (bankofindia): The registered proprietary organization name.
4. Top-Level Domain - TLD (.co.in or .com , .org , .edu , .gov): The final segment indicating geographical jurisdiction or institutional classification.
5. Port Number (:443): The network socket channel on the host server. (Default port for HTTP is 80; default port for HTTPS is 443). Omitted in standard user URLs.
6. Path (/portal/transfer.php): The exact hierarchical file or resource route on the host web server.
7. Query String (?acc=98721&mode=neft): Key-value parameter pairs preceded by ? and separated by & , used to transmit form inputs or filters to dynamic server scripts.
8. Fragment / Anchor (#confirmation): Preceded by # , references a specific internal bookmark or element ID within the retrieved HTML document (processed client-side, never transmitted to server). The Hierarchical DNS Resolution Pipeline When a user types a human-readable domain name (e.g., rbi.org.in) into a web browser, the Domain Name System (DNS) resolves it into a machine-routable numerical IP address through a 4-tier query hierarchy:

User Web Browser



Recursive DNS Resolver (ISP / 8.8.8.8)

```
│
├── 1. Queries Root DNS Servers (13 logical root clusters: a.root-servers.net to m.root-servers.net)
│       └── Returns IP for TLD Servers (.in)
│
├── 2. Queries TLD DNS Servers (Manages all .in domains)
│       └── Returns IP for Authoritative DNS Server of rbi.org.in
│
├── 3. Queries Authoritative DNS Server (Houses authoritative DNS Zone File)
│       └── Returns definitive IP address: 52.140.115.14
│
▼
```

Browser connects directly to Web Server IP via TCP Handshake (SYN -> SYN-ACK -> ACK) HTTP vs HTTPS & The SSL/TLS Handshake DIMENSION HTTP (HYPERTEXT TRANSFER PROTOCOL) HTTPS (HTTP SECURE) Default Port Port 80 Port 443 Security Layer Plaintext transmission; zero encryption Encrypted via TLS (Transport Layer Security) / SSL Vulnerability Vulnerable to Packet Sniffing & Man-In-The-Middle (MITM) attacks Authenticated host; eavesdropping prevented via cryptography Handshake Mechanics Simple 3-Way TCP Handshake 3-Way TCP Handshake + Multi-step TLS Cryptographic Handshake Digital Certificate Not required Requires digital SSL/TLS Certificate issued by trusted Certificate Authority (CA) The TLS Hybrid Cryptographic Handshake: To balance speed and military-grade security, HTTPS uses Hybrid Encryption:

1. Asymmetric Key Exchange (Slow, Highly Secure): The client (browser) and server use asymmetric public-key cryptography (RSA or Diffie-Hellman) along with the server's Digital Certificate to authenticate the server's identity and negotiate a temporary, shared secret Symmetric Session Key.
2. Symmetric Bulk Stream Encryption (Fast, Lightweight): Once the session key is established, all ongoing web traffic (banking data, passwords, page content) is encrypted using high-speed symmetric algorithms (e.g., AES-256). The Master HTTP Status Codes Matrix HTTP status codes are 3-digit numerical responses returned by a web server indicating the exact result of the client's request. Banking examinations test the major categories and specific status codes: 1xx

```
— Informational (Request received, continuing process)
```

2xx

```
— Success (Action successfully received, understood, and accepted)
```

3xx

```
— Redirection (Further action required to complete request)
```

4xx

```
— Client Error (Request contains bad syntax or cannot be fulfilled)
```

5xx

```
— Server Error (Server failed to fulfill an apparently valid request)
```

STATUS CODE STATUS NAME TECHNICAL MEANING & BANKING CONTEXT 100 Continue Server has received request headers and client should proceed to send the request body.

STATUS CODE STATUS NAME TECHNICAL MEANING & BANKING CONTEXT 101 Switching Protocols Client requested protocol switch (e.g., upgrading from HTTP to WebSocket). 200 OK Standard successful request. Web page, account ledger, or media payload delivered successfully. 201 Created Request succeeded and resulted in the creation of a new resource (e.g., new bank account record registered via API). 202 Accepted Request accepted for processing, but processing has not yet completed (batch financial transaction queued). 204 No Content Server successfully processed request, but returns no body content (e.g., save preferences action). 301 Moved Permanently Target resource assigned a permanent new URI. Web browsers and search engines update bookmarks and transfer SEO equity. 302 Found (Temporary Redirect) Target resource temporarily resides under a different URI; clients should continue using original URI for future calls. 304 Not Modified Client-side cache validation. Server informs browser that cached copy is still fresh and does not re-transmit data (saves bandwidth). 400 Bad Request Malformed request syntax, invalid query parameter, or deceptive request routing. Server refuses to process. 401 Unauthorized Authentication required or failed. User has not supplied valid login credentials (e.g., invalid NetBanking password). 403 Forbidden Authenticated, but lacking authorization. Server recognizes identity, but user permissions prohibit accessing resource (e.g., a cashier trying to access the Branch Manager approval module). 404 Not Found Server cannot find the requested URL path. Most common client-facing error on the web. 405

Method Not Allowed Request HTTP method (e.g., POST) is not supported for the requested resource (which may only accept GET). 408 Request Timeout Server waited for client request transmission, but client connection timed out. 429 Too Many Requests Client exceeded rate-limiting thresholds (anti-scraping and brute-force password mitigation). 500 Internal Server Error Generic catch-all error: server encountered an unexpected exception preventing it from fulfilling request. 502 Bad Gateway Edge proxy or reverse proxy server (e.g., Cloudflare, Nginx) received an invalid response from upstream backend server. 503 Service Unavailable Server temporarily offline or overloaded. Often observed during month-end banking batch runs or server maintenance. 504 Gateway Timeout Reverse proxy or gateway server did not receive a timely response from upstream database or application server. State Persistence: Cookies vs Sessions Because HTTP is a stateless protocol, state persistence is maintained using two distinct mechanisms: FEATURE / METRIC HTTP COOKIES WEB SESSIONS Physical Storage Location Stored on the Client Device (inside browser profile on user hard drive/RAM). Stored securely on the Web Server (in server RAM, database, or Redis cache). Data Capacity Maximum 4 KB (4096 bytes) per cookie. Virtually unlimited (constrained only by server hardware resources).

FEATURE / METRIC HTTP COOKIES WEB SESSIONS Security Risk Vulnerable to client-side inspection, Cross-Site Scripting (XSS), and tampering. High security; sensitive data remains on server. Client holds only an encrypted Session ID. Classification - Session Cookie: Temporary; deleted immediately when browser closes.

- Persistent Cookie: Retained until an explicit expiration date.
- Third-Party Cookie: Placed by external ad networks for cross-site tracking. Active until session timeout (e.g., banking portals terminate session after 5 minutes of user inactivity). Web Crawlers (Spiders) & robots.txt : Automated scripts operated by search engines (e.g., Googlebot) that traverse hyperlinks across the web to build search indexes. Webmasters place a standardized plaintext file named robots.txt in the root directory (e.g., bank.com/robots.txt) specifying the Robots Exclusion Standard to disallow crawlers from indexing private portals or admin directories. Master File Formats, Encodings & Codecs Compendium Banking and regulatory exams frequently test the classification, compression mechanisms, and technical extensions of digital files:

1. Image Formats: Raster (Pixel-Based) vs Vector (Math-Based)

```
┌── Raster Graphics (Bitmaps: Pixel grids, loss of quality on zoom)
```

Digital Images

```
────┤
└── Vector Graphics (Mathematical vectors: Infinite scaling without loss)
```

FORMAT FULL NAME COMPRESSION TYPE COLOR DEPTH / FEATURES TYPICAL REAL-WORLD USE CASE JPEG / JPG Joint Photographic Experts Group Lossy 24-bit True Color (16.7M colors). Discards psycho-visually imperceptible data. Digital camera photographs; web banner imagery. Does not support transparency. PNG Portable Network Graphics Lossless 24-bit True Color + 8-bit Alpha Channel for true variable transparency. Logos, web interface icons, infographics, text screenshots. Replaced GIF. GIF Graphics Interchange Format Lossless Limited to 8-bit color palette (maximum 256 colors). Supports frame-based animation. Short animated clips, simple reaction memes, legacy web graphics. BMP Bitmap Image File Uncompressed Raw, uncompressed pixel map. Generates enormous file sizes. Native Microsoft Windows internal graphics; device-level raw image processing. TIFF / TIF Tagged Image File Format Lossless / Uncompressed Ultra-high bit depth, supports CMYK print color spaces. Commercial offset printing, medical scanning (X-rays, MRI), archiving. SVG Scalable Vector Graphics Vector (XML- based) Mathematically described paths, polygons, curves. Scales infinitely with zero pixelation. Responsive website logos, UI icons, interactive dynamic charts. WebP Web Picture Format (Google) Lossy & Lossless Advanced modern compression; 30% smaller than JPEG/PNG while supporting transparency and animation. High-performance modern web publishing.

2. Audio Formats: Lossy vs Lossless vs Synthesized FORMAT FULL NAME TYPE TECHNICAL MECHANICS & OPERATIONAL FEATURES MP3 MPEG-1 Audio Layer

III Lossy Utilizes psychoacoustic modeling to permanently strip out sound frequencies beyond human hearing range ($>$ 20 kHz) or masked by louder tones. Default bitrate: 128–320 kbps. WAV Waveform Audio File Format Uncompressed Lossless Developed by Microsoft & IBM. Stores raw Pulse Code Modulation (PCM) audio wave samples. Pristine studio recording quality; massive file sizes (~10 MB per minute). AAC Advanced Audio Coding Lossy Designed as the architectural successor to MP3. Achieves superior audio fidelity at lower bitrates. Default standard for YouTube, Apple Music, and Bluetooth streaming. FLAC Free Lossless Audio Codec Compressed Lossless Compresses audio files by 50–60% without discarding a single acoustic bit. Open- source audiophile archival standard. MIDI Musical Instrument Digital Interface Synthesized Control Commands Does NOT record actual sound waves or human vocals. Encodes performance

instructions: note pitch, timing, duration, instrument channel, and key velocity. Tiny file sizes (kilobytes). 3. Video Containers vs Compression Codecs Examiners heavily test the distinction between a Container (the file format housing video, audio, and subtitles) and a Codec (the compression algorithm encoding raw video data): Video Containers (File Extensions): MP4 (.mp4): MPEG-4 Part 14. Universal web and mobile playback container. MKV (.mkv): Matroska Multimedia Container. Open-standard container capable of holding unlimited video, audio, and subtitle streams in a single file. AVI (.avi): Audio Video Interleave (Microsoft). Legacy container with minimal compression. MOV (.mov): Apple QuickTime format. Standard capture format for iOS and macOS video. Video Codecs (Compression Algorithms): H.264 / AVC: Most widely deployed video compression standard on earth. H.265 / HEVC: High Efficiency Video Coding. Delivers 50% better data compression than H.264 at identical visual quality; standard for 4K/8K broadcasting. AV1: Open-source, royalty-free next-generation video codec developed by the Alliance for Open Media (Google, Netflix, Amazon, Apple). 4. Document & Archival Standards PDF (Portable Document Format - ISO 32000): Developed by Adobe (John Warnock). Preserves exact document typography, vectors, raster images, and page geometry across all operating systems and hardware architectures independently of native fonts or software. RTF (Rich Text Format): Developed by Microsoft for cross-platform formatted text exchange between word processors. CSV (Comma-Separated Values): Plaintext tabular format where each line represents a data record and fields are delimited by commas. Universal format for bulk banking database exports. Compression Archives: ZIP / RAR / 7z: Lossless data compression archive formats bundling multiple files into a single condensed file using algorithms like DEFLATE or LZMA. TAR (.tar): Tape Archive (Unix). Packages multiple files into a single archive without compression (frequently paired with Gzip to create .tar.gz).

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Default Network Ports: HTTP is Port 80; HTTPS is Port 443. DNS is Port 53.
2. Authentication vs Authorization Status Codes: 401 Unauthorized = Authentication failure (identity unknown). 403 Forbidden = Authorization failure (identity known, but access denied).
3. 301 vs 302 Redirects: 301 is Permanent (browser caches new URL, search engine passes SEO rank); 302 is Temporary (future requests must still query original URI).
4. Raster vs Vector Scaling: Raster images (JPEG, PNG, GIF) pixelate when enlarged. Vector images (SVG) can be scaled infinitely to any dimension without loss of clarity because they are rendered from mathematical formulas.
5. MIDI Does Not Store Sound: A .mid (MIDI) file contains no audio samples or recorded voices; it stores only synthetic instrument control instructions (note, duration, tempo).

[COMP-018] PO MAINS ALGORITHMIC FLOWCHARTS & BINARY LOGIC PUZZLE PATTERNS

Key Concept — Algorithmic Machine Simulation In banking PO Mains, the computer aptitude component tests your ability to function as an infallible human central processing unit (CPU). You are presented with an abstract flowchart, machine algorithm, or binary cipher and required to trace the exact state changes of memory variables through sequential decisions and iterative loops without making single-step off- by-one errors. Standard ISO / ANSI Flowchart Symbols Flowcharts represent sequential logical algorithms visually. The International Organization for Standardization (ISO 5807) and ANSI standardize their structural symbols: Terminal (Start / Stop) Input / Output (Data)



Process Box Decision Diamond



On-Page Connector /

- A



FLOWCHART GEOMETRIC SHAPE STANDARD SYMBOL NAME COMPUTATIONAL FUNCTION & SEMANTIC MEANING Oval / Rounded Rectangle (Capsule) Terminal Denotes the absolute Start, Stop, Halt, or Exit boundary of an algorithm. Parallelogram Input / Output (I/O) Represents raw data entering the system (Input A, B , Read File) or processed output emitted (Print Total , Display Error). Rectangle Process Represents an internal arithmetic computation, data manipulation, or variable assignment (Set Counter = 1 , Tax = Gross * 0.10). Diamond (Rhombus) Decision Box Evaluates a conditional Boolean expression (Is X > Y? , Balance >= Minimum?). Has one entry path and at least two exit paths (True/False or Yes/No). Circle (Small) On-Page Connector Connects disjointed flow lines on the same page, identified by an alphanumeric label (e.g., A , 1), preventing tangled crossover lines. Pentagon (Home Plate) Off-Page Connector Links a flowchart extending across multiple physical pages or screens. Arrow Line Flowline Indicates the absolute directional sequence of instruction execution. Pattern 1: Multi-Step Algorithmic Flowchart Variable Tracing In PO Mains, candidates are given a complex flowchart with conditional loops and required to answer 3 to 5 multi-step questions based on varying inputs. (A, B, C, N , Sum)

Fully Worked SBI PO Mains Benchmark Problem: Algorithm Specification: A banking payroll server calculates an employee's Annual Bonus and Tax Liability according to the following flowchart logic: [START]



/ INPUT: Salary (S), Rating (R), Years (Y) /



[Set Bonus = 0]



/ Is Rating >= 4 ?
/
Yes No



[Bonus = S * 0.20] [Bonus = S * 0.10]



/ Is Years > 5 ?
/
Yes No



[Bonus = Bonus + 15000]



[Set Net = S + Bonus]



/ Is Net > 80000 ?

/

Yes No



[Tax = (Net - 80000) * 0.10] [Tax = 0]



[Set FinalPay = Net - Tax]



/ OUTPUT: Bonus, FinalPay /



[STOP] Systematic Trace Table Execution: To solve questions with 100% accuracy without mental fatigue, construct a Trace Table: Question 1: If Employee 1 has , , and , what is their FinalPay ? STEP EXECUTION SEQUENCE VARIABLE VARIABLE VARIABLE VARIABLE BONUS VARIABLE NET VARIABLE TAX OUTPUT FINALPAY

1. Input 60,000 5 8 0 - - - Salary (S) = ₹60, 000 Rating (R) = 5 Years (Y) = 8 S R Y

STEP EXECUTION SEQUENCE VARIABLE VARIABLE VARIABLE VARIABLE BONUS VARIABLE NET VARIABLE TAX OUTPUT FINALPAY 2. Condition: ?

- ◦ ▪ Yes - - -

3. Condition: ?

- ◦ ▪ Yes - - -

4. Process: Net

- ◦ ▪ 27,000 - -

5. Condition: Net ?

- ◦ ▪ ▪ 87,000 Yes -

6. Final Process & Output

- ◦ ▪ 27,000 - 700 87,000 - 700 = ₹86,300 Question 2: If Employee 2 has , , and , what is their FinalPay ? Step 1: is False . Step 2: is False remains ₹5,000. Step 3: . Step 4: is False . Step 5: . Pattern 2: Binary-Coded Logic & Machine Translation Tables In IBPS/SBI PO Mains, examiners frequently encrypt numerical distances, directions, or arithmetic operators into binary code representations using special typographical symbols. The PO Mains Symbol Decoding Model: Suppose the exam defines: Symbol @ represents binary digit 0 . Symbol # represents binary digit 1 . Any number is written as a sequence of these two symbols starting with # from the left. Rapid Binary Conversion Key: To instantly decode symbol sequences, assign weights of ascending powers of 2 from right to left: BINARY WEIGHT Code: ### - - - - Code: #@#@ - - - Code: ##@@# - - Fully Worked PO Mains Direction & Binary Distance Puzzle: Given Directional Code Rules: S R Y R ≥ 4 → 60000 × 0.20 = 12000 Y > 5 → 12000 + 15000 = 27000 60000 + 27000 = 87000

> *80000 → (87000 −*

00. × 0.10 = 700 Salary (S) = ₹50, 000 Rating (R) = 3 Years (Y) = 4 R ≥ 4 → Bonus = 50000 × 0.10 = ₹5, 000 Y > 5 → Bonus Net = 50000 + 5000 = ₹55, 000 Net > 80000 → Tax = 0 FinalPay = 55000 − 0 = ₹55, 000 2 = 6 64 2 = 5 32 2 = 4 16 2 = 3 8 2 = 2 4 2 = 1 2 2 = 0 1 1 × 4 1 × 2 1 × 1 1 × 8 0 × 4 1 × 2 0 × 1 1 × 16 1 × 8 0 × 4 0 × 2 1 × 1

means: is to the North of at a distance of meters. means: is to the South of at a distance of meters. means: is to the East of at a distance of meters. means: is to the West of at a distance of meters. Here, is given in the binary symbols where @ = 0 and # = 1 . Given Statement: 1. 2. 3. Decoding Step 1: Decode the numerical distances from binary: Distance 1: . Distance 2: . Distance 3: . Decoding Step 2: Translate the statements into Cartesian spatial directions:

1. is 6 meters East of .
2. is 8 meters South of .
3. is 6 meters West of . A



D



Examination Questions Solved: Question 1: What is the shortest distance between Point A and Point D? Because is 6m East of , and is 6m West of (which is directly South of B),A, B, C, D forms a perfect rectangle. Therefore, is directly South of , and the distance between and is equal to the distance between and : . Question 2: In which direction is Point B with respect to Point D? Point is to the North-East of Point . Shortest Euclidean distance between and :

$$\text{Distance} = \sqrt{6^2 + 8^2} = \sqrt{36 + 64} = \sqrt{100} = \mathbf{10} \text{ meters.}$$

Encoded in binary symbols: . Pattern 3: Operating System Paging & Cache Replacement Simulations Tested in Regulatory Body examinations (RBI Assistant / Grade B, NABARD Grade A, Bank IT Specialist Officers), candidates are evaluated on calculating Page Faults when a CPU processes memory requests through finite cache page frames. Page Replacement Algorithms:

1. FIFO (First-In, First-Out): Replaces the page that was brought into memory earliest in time. P & Q (X) P Q X P % Q (X) P Q X P $ Q (X) P Q X P ∗ Q (X) P Q X X B $ A (##@) C % B (#@@@) D ∗ C (##@)

##@ = 110 = 2 (1 × 4) + (1 × 2) + (0 × 1) = 6 meters #@@@ = 1000 = 2 (1 × 8) + (0 × 4) + (0 × 2) + (0 × 1) = 8 meters ##@ = 110 = 2 6 meters B $ A (6) ⟹ B A C % B (8) ⟹ C B D ∗ C (6) ⟹ D C B A D C D A A D B C 8 meters B D D B 10 = 1010 = 2 #@#@

2. LRU (Least Recently Used): Replaces the page in memory that has not been referenced for the longest period of historical time.
3. Optimal Page Replacement: Replaces the page that will not be used for the longest period of future time (theoretical benchmark). Worked Benchmark Simulation (LRU vs FIFO): Reference String: 1, 2, 3, 4, 1, 2, 5 with 3 physical page frames (initially empty). LRU (Least Recently Used) Execution: Reference: 1 2 3 4 1 2 5



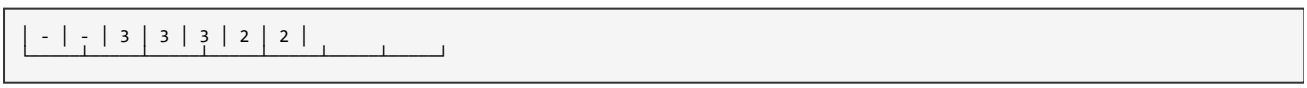
Frame 1:



Frame 2:



Frame 3:



Fault?: M M M M M M M (M = Miss / Page Fault, H = Hit)

1. Request 1 : Frame [1, -, -] Fault (Miss)
2. Request 2 : Frame [1, 2, -] Fault (Miss)
3. Request 3 : Frame [1, 2, 3] Fault (Miss)

4. Request 4 : All frames full. LRU page is 1 (used least recently). Replace 1 with 4 Frame [4, 2, 3] Fault (Miss)
5. Request 1 : LRU page is 2 . Replace 2 with 1 Frame [4, 1, 3] Fault (Miss)
6. Request 2 : LRU page is 3 . Replace 3 with 2 Frame [4, 1, 2] Fault (Miss)
7. Request 5 : LRU page is 4 . Replace 4 with 5 Frame [5, 1, 2] Fault (Miss) Total Page Faults under LRU: 7 Faults.

EXAM ANGLE & TRAP MATRIX

Exam Anchor & High-Yield Traps:

1. Flowchart Decision Exits: A decision diamond must have at least two exit paths (typically True/False). It can never have only one exit path.
2. Loop Reassignment vs Accumulation Trap: In flowchart tracing, pay extreme attention to Sum = A (overwrites variable) versus Sum = Sum + A (accumulates variable). Overlooking this distinction is the #1 cause of lost marks in PO Mains.
3. Binary Power Progression: Always remember binary position values from right to left: . For binary bits, the maximum decimal value represented is .
4. Pythagorean Triples in Machine Coded Direction Puzzles: PO Mains binary coordinate puzzles almost always resolve into standard Pythagorean triples: , , , , and . Recognizing these allows instant calculation without calculating square roots. → → → → → → → → → → 1, 2, 4, 8, 16, 32, 64, 128 n 2 − n 1

(3, 4, 5) (6, 8, 10) (5, 12, 13) (8, 15, 17) (7, 24, 25)